ROUTLEDGE HANDBOOKS



The Routledge Handbook of Employee Communication and Organizational Processes

Edited by Soojin Kim, Patrice M. Buzzanell, Alessandra Mazzei and Jeong-Nam Kim

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THE ROUTLEDGE HANDBOOK OF EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION AND ORGANIZATIONAL PROCESSES

This Routledge Handbook takes a truly global and multidisciplinary approach to exploring all facets of employee communication.

Beginning with two key disciplinary approaches—organizational communication and public relations—scholars capture and define employee communication from both perspectives, addressing commonalities and bridging disciplinary differences. This volume places importance on the everyday communicative behaviors by internal members such as leaders, managers, inter/generational cohorts, employees, and those working on behalf of organizations, such as social media influencers, and on expansive conceptualizations of employee communication such as chatbots, environment, and global supply chain members involved in organizing. With a focus on employees in situ, the authors respond to these key questions: in what ways is employee communication relevant today? What does employee communication entail? How, why, and to what extent does employee communication influence or become influenced by organizational processes?

Investigating antecedents, organizational contexts and processes, and consequences of employee communication, and offering key theoretical information and empirically driven recommendations for practice, this handbook will be an essential resource for students, researchers, and industry practitioners in employee communication, organizational communication, business and management, leadership communication, and public relations more generally.

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This handbook is dedicated to my human child, Hansoo, and my fur child, Daisy—who I believe are God's gifts for me. I also acknowledge my parents and parents-in-law for their unwavering support and encouragement throughout my academic journey. Finally, I thank the late Leo for believing in my potential.
–Soojin Kim

I dedicate this handbook, as always, to my family—my parents (Frances and Marie Buzzanell), my siblings (Charles and Doreen Buzzanell, and William D. Wheeler), and my children in birth order: #1 Brendan Sheahan (Fawzia Rahman, Zereen Ali and Zuhair Ali), #2&3 Sheridan and Ashlee Sheahan, #4 Lisette Sheahan Johns (Jeremy Johns, Xander and Winston), #5 Annie Sheahan McAnespie (Seth, Eliza Marie), and #6 Robyn Wilson Wieten (David, Grace Marilyn). Steven Robert Wilson, I am so grateful for all you do and are.
–Patrice M. Buzzanell

To Antonio and to all the people that inspired and motivated me in my fantastic journey across communication knowledge and disciplines. First of all, my parents Iolanda ed Ettore, as they instilled in me the passion for studying and enlarge my knowledge. Furthermore, to my students, my academic colleagues, my professional partners, and my advisors.
–Alessandra Mazzei

To my family members and our team.
–Jeong-Nam Kim

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FOREWORD

With their fantastic handbook, Soojin Kim and her colleagues accomplished a real tour de force by creating the conditions of an improbable dialogue between organizational communication (OC) and public relations (PR) scholars. Although these two sub-fields of communication are both interested in how organizations function and sometimes dysfunction, more often than not, they ignore each other, which is a real pity for our comprehension of these processes. While PR scholars tend to focus on how an organization, taken as a whole, communicates with its environment, OC researchers have historically been interested in how employees communicate with each other in the context of the organization they work for. A long time ago, George Cheney and Lars Christensen (2001) showed how this division of academic labor could be called into question, but 25 years later, their call obviously still needs to be heard, which is what this volume obviously does.

By using a constitutive lens, that is, a lens that conceives of communication as *constitutive* of organizational processes, the contributors to this volume focus on employee communication and organization processes to investigate phenomena as diverse as boundary-spanning behaviors, misinformation, leadership, listening, creativity, conflict, romance, corporate social responsibility, or whistleblowing. Employee communication is therefore envisaged as a complex phenomenon where questions of identity, agency, and boundary are called into question and reinvestigated as dynamic processes. In a world where social media, hybrid workplaces, and artificial intelligence play an increasing role in the way organizations work, this handbook offers an important stepping stone toward our comprehension of the ethical, practical, and theoretical dimensions associated with the constitutive aspects of employee communication, both at the internal and external levels.

PR and OC scholars of the world, unite!

François Cooren, PhD
Université de Montréal

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INTRODUCTION TO THE ROUTLEDGE HANDBOOK OF EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION AND ORGANIZATIONAL PROCESSES

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Today's world is marked by unprecedented changes that challenge the ways managers and employees in every organizational and institutional sector do their work and assess its effectiveness. For instance, for many people, the novel coronavirus global pandemic shifted tasks, collaborations, workspaces, and other routine activities and procedures to remote work and organizing, often without full preparation and work-life balance considerations. In our post-pandemic world, researchers and organizational members are trying to sort out what changes should remain while others revert to previous standard operating procedures. Today, there still are pandemic repercussions and further disruptions. There are: unreliable global supply chains; assaults on bodily integrity and on people of different races/ethnicities, genders, and nationalities; and wars in the Ukraine, Gaza, and other parts of the globe altering political, environmental, and commercial alliances. These changes continue to shape (and be shaped by) employee communication and organizational processes at multiple levels.

In addition to communication and organizing changes incurred by COVID-19, there are also challenges related to other contemporary issues. These considerations include: climate change, roll backs in and reinstatements of environmental protections, aging populations and lower birth rates, decreased (then reinstated) funding for entities such as the World Health Organization (WHO), and ongoing needs to organize for accountable practices in equity, inclusion, and social justice, particularly for indigenous people and those who face discriminatory treatment, even death, based on their visible and invisible social identity group memberships. In light of today's crises, it seems imperative to understand employees as communicative actors who can shape a new normal while they themselves confront and make sense of organizing and organizations at present.

As researchers and organizational members, we recognize that people communicate to understand and influence their surroundings or environment and to solve the problems they face. In organizations, employees and leaders construct and adapt to the structures, policies, and challenges via communicative behaviors. Of importance in this handbook are the everyday communicative behaviors of internal members, such as leaders, managers, intergenerational cohorts, and employees, who constitute organizational processes (for fresh insights on leadership, see Jian & Fairhurst, 2025). To these personnel and roles, we add other workers who labor on behalf of organizations, such as social media influencers, and who are informal sector members and chatbots. Our book aims to develop greater understanding of and explanations for these agents' actions while expanding the notion of employees beyond the confines of organization structures. As we focus on employee communication, we ask: in what ways is employee communication relevant today? This question centers on employee communication but also brings in leadership, managerial communication, difference, technology, work-life considerations, and a host of other interests. To address this question, we discuss (a) what employee communication entails, (b) how communication is conceptualized, and (c) where our handbook chapter structure attends to specific aspects of employee communication.

What Employee Communication Entails

We take the stance that tensions in employees' communication can constitute constantly changing and dynamic working relationships and

structures. Here we acknowledge that boundaries between employees and leaders often are fluid and shift contextually; both engage in dialectic tensions of organizing in which their communicative behaviors are functional and dysfunctional depending on what is happening in and around their organizations and industries. Moreover, our chapters challenge the language and identities of "employee" per se by broadening this concept to include various non-human agents such as chatbots and the environment.

Besides expanding and enriching "employee", we relatedly delve into how organizational roles within and beyond traditional boundaries enhance communicative interactions and organizational processes that involve and affect leaders, managers, informal sector and gig workers, and local-global environments. For these issues, communication can be conceptualized in many ways. We utilize a constitutive lens as an umbrella approach offering metatheoretical and pragmatic means of unifying seemingly disparate ideas about and approaches to communication. In other words, as we communicate, we construct our world that then affects us. In this sense, the distinctive qualities of communication as constitutive offer bases from which employee, leadership, and related areas of communication can be analyzed from varied metaphorical schemas (Putnam et al., 1996; see also Putnam & Boys, 2006) and traditions (Craig, 1999) that offer not only understanding, direction, and tools for use in communication behaviors and organizational processes but also critique given such behaviors embeddedness in particular contexts.

How Communication Is Conceptualized

Accordingly, we define *communication* in various ways. Mumby (2007) noted that,

> In simple terms, organizational communication scholars study the dynamic relationships between communication processes and human organizing. Communication is conceived as foundational to, and constitutive of, organizations, while organizations are viewed as relatively enduring structures that are both medium and outcome of communication processes.
>
> *(p. 3290)*

This definition is useful for those oriented toward organizational communication. However, for many other authors, communication is conceptualized as the process in which verbal (spoken or written form) and/or non-verbal symbols (non-linguistic representations) are being used to convey and exchange information, as well as to create or share meanings (attuned to constitutive perspectives, particularly sensemaking and sensegiving) among entities within broader societal and global discourses and material conditions. Within this conceptualization, *communicative actions* often are defined as purposeful communication that a person, a group, or an organization use to adapt, relate, or influence to its surroundings (Kim & Grunig, 2011). Meanwhile, c*ommunication management* typically is used to indicate organizations' planned and purposive communicative actions such as public relations (PR), employee communication, Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR), and/or human resources (HR) communication with specific intentions and reflection of given organizational contexts (e.g., culture, mission) and members' values (e.g., dominant coalition, ethical stances). Communication management is both a process and the result of the planned efforts constructed for and operating toward certain directions. While communication management is seen as purposeful by nature, organizational communication also at times takes a message-oriented approach and one that is strategic in attaining members' goals. In these cases, communication can be broadly defined as "the collective and interactive process of generating and interpreting messages" among organizations and their actors (Stohl, 1995, p. 4). Miller and Poole (2024) combine these different orientations when they conceptualize communication as exchanging messages, coordinating activities, negotiating meanings, and coordinating understandings, values, perspectives, and so on. Furthermore, in other organizational communication approaches, the ways in which communicative and linguistic turns affect structures, processes, and products of managerial communication, and their converse, are offered to explain activities, forms, and contexts of managerial communication, such as that offered in the *Handbook of Management Communication* (Cooren & Stücheli-Herlach, 2021). What sets our work apart is the emphasis on primarily intentional communicative behavior and our comparisons of behaviors studied from organizational and/or managerial communication and PR and/or strategic communication.

Yet both communication management and organizational communication reflect, constitute, and shape their spatio-temporal,

cultural, political-economic, and technological contexts. How employees, leaders, and related organizational constituencies interact, coordinate, disrupt and contest, and relate among themselves through their communication are unique and joint products. These interactions are not always as purposeful and planned as our definitions indicate. Indeed, employee communication is constituted in ways for which aims, everyday discourses, and material entanglements are ironically appropriated and relatively invisible without critique. Moreover, communication management and organizational communication have expanded from earlier interests in the Global North and White spaces to greater concerns about equity and inclusion in the Global South to incorporate marginalized members and indigenous perspectives in the informal section and more liquid and fluid organizing (Cruz & Sodeke, 2020; Pal et al., 2023; Wilhoit Larson et al., 2022), thus encouraging scholars to question the very notions of employee, organization, and communication management throughout the chapters but most especially in the conclusion of this book.

Where Our Structure Attends to Specific Aspects of Employee Communication

The *Routledge Handbook of Employee Communication and Organizational Processes* takes two different disciplinary approaches: organizational communication and public relations. Scholars in these two disciplines capture and define different types of employee communication, often using similar language. The commonalities in language choices enable these scholars to bridge disciplinary interests but can cause confusion when the specific academic terminology has not been fully explicated. For instance, phenomena such as conflict, whistleblowing, dissent, gossip, leaks, rumors, and disagreements about relationships and/or resources might be approached differently in the two disciplines. Whereas organizational communication has a long tradition of investigating organizational members' actions using terminology such as silence, threat, voice, gossip, dissent, and exit (e.g., Buzzanell, 1994; Christensen & Christensen, 2022; Clair, 1998; Garner, 2022; Rice & Searle, 2022; Xie et al., 2022), public relations has focused employees' communicative actions in these areas as problem-solving behaviors (e.g., Kim & Rhee, 2011; Lee & Kim, 2017; Li et al., 2021). In some cases, scholars from the two disciplines actually investigate similar phenomena. Regardless of the disciplinary approaches and terms, these practices and

processes affect or are affected by organizational performance both positively and negatively, with such consequences determined by interactants in varied ways. Yet, the commonalities and differences among the research programs in these different disciplines have not been fully explored to understand the dynamics of employee communication and offer strategies transferable to different organizing contexts.

Therefore, authors revisit public relations and organizational communication in topical areas and processes by presenting literature reviews and key findings. Next, they present pragmatic applications and/or unanswered questions that can be generative for scholarship. Finally, many conclude with tools for practitioners or questions to consider. By placing chapters in public relations and organizational communication side by side, our handbook encourages meaningful conversations between researchers focusing in similar areas but from different approaches. These conversations can bring new insights and practices that take into consideration today's world. These conversations are couched within consideration of the contemporary global political-economic climate, increasingly diverse membership, online organizing enabled by technological affordances, growth of gig and sharing economies, calls for greater environmental and other social responsibility platforms, and other factors.

Toward these ends, our handbook is organized into four parts: (a) presenting diverse theoretical approaches to employee communication and organizational process, from two disciplines, public relations and organizational communication; (b) exploring employee communication as complex phenomena; (c) looking at the dynamic processes inherent in employee communication and organizational processes; and (d) discussing emerging trends in employee communication.

Part I: Theoretical Frameworks

The chapters in this section respond to questions regarding the theoretical frameworks/conceptual links that explain employee communication.

Chapter 2 by Lisa Tam and Jeong-Nam Kim entitled "Public Relations Research on Employee Communication" provides an overview of employee communication research in public relations scholarship. Tam and Kim explain how organization–public relationship gave rise to the concept of employee–organization relationships (EORs) in PR scholarship. It also introduces key antecedents, consequences, and

contexts of employee communication. Finally, this chapter identifies key concepts in EORs, including employee engagement, employee communicative behavior (ECB), and allegiant communicative behaviors.

In contrast, **Chapter 3**, "Organizational Communication Research on Employee Communication" by Patrice M. Buzzanell, Willow Craine, Sidney Murray, and Maggie Vail, provides an overview of organizational communication's interdisciplinary roots to discuss employee communication. They describe three key issues and discuss their importance in employee communication research: identity/identification, organizational community, and agency and boundaries.

Part II: Employee Communication as Complex Phenomena

Part II introduces and discusses diverse types of employee communication as complex phenomena by explaining pertinent behaviors and processes while also presenting their implications. These chapters present numerous topics and approaches.

For instance, **Chapter 4**, "Boundary-Spanning Behavior and Its Implications for Employee Communication" by Loarre Andreu Perez and Kyougmin Lee, overviews traditional boundary-spanner behaviors, employees' boundary spanner behaviors, boundary-spanners communicative behaviors, and then presents the consequences of those behaviors.

In **Chapter 5**, Young Kim explores employees' social media literacy in countering crisis misinformation. Given existing internal crisis communication research conceptualizing employee communication behavior for sensemaking and sensegiving as a process of creating and transmitting meaning, he promotes valuable information through voluntary communication behaviors. The role of attitude toward verifying information is proposed as a mediator between employee social media literacy and employee communication behavior for sensemaking and sensegiving.

Chapter 6, "Employee Voice" by Johny T. Garner, traces the early roots of employee voice such as scientific management and HR perspectives and Hirschman's exit-voice-loyalty model before delving into behavioral, structural, and political approaches. He concludes with contemporary nuances to employee voice and nontraditional organizational arrangements.

In **Chapter 7**, entitled "Creativity and Creative Processes in Organizations: A Network Perspective", Seungyoon Lee and Ajay Shah

illustrate how network perspectives can provide valuable insights into collaborative aspects and network dimensions pertinent in creative processes. They also recommend four broad areas in employee and organizational communication that inform the network processes of creativity.

Chapter 8 by Myoung-Gi Chon and Soo Park, "Scouting and Vocalizing in Workplace: A Theoretical Approach to Address Quiet Quitting While Promoting Scouting Behavior", introduces a theoretical framework that evaluates employees' quiet quitting, while concurrently promoting scouting behavior. They introduce crucial variables from strategic communication studies, such as transformational leadership, organizational culture, EOR, and allegiant communication behavior.

Given that studies of employee silence are less common than studies of employee voice Ryan S. Bisel and Egbe B. Okpaireh suggest that employee silence is worthy of sophisticated conceptualization and inquiry. In **Chapter 9**, entitled "Employee Silence", they examine motives, costs/benefits, and common antecedents to employee silence. They suggest strategies for combating problematic forms of employee silence.

Chapter 10 by Minjeong Kang, "Understanding Employee Dissent in Relations to Organizational Process", explores dissent as a necessity and moral imperative for organizational democracy and organizational efficiency. She covers diverse perspectives then concludes that PR scholarship can view dissent as a type of employee communication that can benefit organizations by enhancing employee empowerment and engagement.

In **Chapter 11**, Sean M. Horan and Rebecca M. Chory synthesize research on organizational communication about workplace romance, particularly gossip, and interrogate approaches to managing these relationships. They offer recommendations for practice and future research.

Workplace romance often links with the complex dynamics of organizational secrecy with its ethical, legal, and practical considerations as does Anna W. Wolfe's **Chapter 12** "Organizational Secrecy" that summarizes and explains the conditions and consequences of organizational secrecy. She pursues four constitutive claims of organizational secrecy. She directs attention to areas of ethical communication, power dynamics, and technological innovation and artificial intelligence (AI) for future studies.

Whereas Wolfe's Chapter 13 on organizational secrecy could be interpreted as organizations' strategic image management by balancing selective openness and closedness, Eric Karikari's **Chapter 13**, "Employee Communication and Secrecy Breaches", views secrecy as a human communication process that produces both concealment and revelation of organizational knowledge and information. He explores the tensions among secrecy, transparency, concertive control, and their implications for employee communication. He suggests that there are functional and ideological/cultural reasons for keeping secrets.

Extending secrecy and disclosure further, **Chapter 14** by Cary A. Greenwood, entitled "Employee Whistleblowing", offers the "Golden Handcuffs" as the reason public relations executives and practitioners are reluctant to address a topic of whistleblowing. Drawing from evolutionary theory, she suggests future research and offers guidance for addressing whistleblowing and whistleblowers.

***Part III*: Employee Communication and Organizational Processes**

The contributing chapters in Part III are related to organizational processes that encompass contexts, environments, and approaches that affect and shift understandings of employee communication. Especially in cultivating positive communication environments and outcomes, several contributors propose theoretical and empirical extensions in relation to ethical culture, leadership communication, coworkership, organizational listening, and co-creational employee engagement.

Chapter 15, by Soojin Kim, Alessandra Mazzei, and Jarim Kim, provides a conceptual review of **"**Causes, Contexts, and Consequences of Employee Communication". They revisit several chapters in our handbook to discuss key concepts in employee communication. They present employee communication as an interconnected phenomenon with positive and negative potential outcomes. They then summarize concepts significant in cultivating positive results for both employees and organizations.

Ethics is crucial in attaining positive organizational outcomes. Shannon A. Bowen, in **Chapter 16,** "Enacting Ethics Beyond Institutionalization: Creating Ethical Culture, Leadership, and Employee Communication", recommends institutionalizing ethics into organizational culture using internal communication. She integrates

servant and authentic leadership, intentional ethical culture, engagement, and ECBs to embed ethics within organizational structures.

Chapter 17, entitled "Corporate Heritage for Employee Communication: Investing in History to Share the Future", by Valentina Martino and Alessandro Lovari, portrays how corporate heritage management strategies play a strategic role as valuable platforms for cultivating corporate culture and identity, fostering quality relationships among employees and external stakeholders such as customers, visitors, business partners, educational institutions, government bodies, and local communities.

Not-for-profit contexts traditionally have received less attention than businesses or government organizations, even though volunteers constitute a significant workforce. **Chapter 18**, entitled "Employee Communication and Organizing in Not-for-Profits", by Kristie McAllum, Laura Ginoux, and Félix Bourget Careau, discusses trends and tensions in nonprofit contexts that affect employee communication. This chapter sets out a research-informed agenda for future scholarship on and engagement in nonprofit organizing and employee communication.

Chapter 19, entitled "Employee Communication: Resources, Behavior, and Enablement", by Alessandra Mazzei, abandons systems perspectives to revise employee communication from a resource perspective. She introduces the Enabling Model of Employee Communication that defines employee communication as a set of interactive processes generating knowledge and suggests that knowledge and employee engagement are catalysts to fuel organizational processes and mutually reinforce each other.

Chapter 20, "Coworkership and Engagement: Toward a Communication-Centered Pespective" by Rickard Andersson, Mats Heide, and Charlotte Simonsson, reviews how employee engagement has been investigated in organizational communication and PRs literature and suggests a communication-centered approach to employee engagement. From a social constructionist perspective, these authors propose using the term "coworker" rather than the more common "employee". "Coworker" entails that organizational members are active agents who produce and reproduce social reality by communicating.

Chapter 21, "Leadership Communication: A Multidisciplinary Review of Theoretical Approaches, Applications, and Emerging Opportunities"**,** by Cen April Yue, Linjuan Rita Men, and Weiting Tao, provides a multidisciplinary review of theoretical approaches, applications, and emerging opportunities to leadership communication.

They highlight emerging types of leadership communication behaviors, such as diversity-oriented leadership, family supportive leadership, as well as the implication of AI on leadership communication.

Communication scholars have long studied the power of metaphors to shape how we engage in organizational action. In **Chapter 22** entitled "Employee Communication and Organizational Environment", Jennifer Mease discusses what scholars and practitioners can see, analyze, and engage when using environment as an organizational metaphor. By exploring organizational environment as metaphor, she draws parallels between the ways organizations and ecological environment exist and function before presenting four assumptions as Environmental Principles. These assumptions respond to calls and urge attention to indigenous ontologies and epistemologies, not only as significant for analyses of organizational environment but also as they might inform Communicative Constitution of Organization scholarship more broadly.

Four chapters cluster around appreciation, care and resilience, affective well-being, and listening. **Chapter 23**, entitled as "Employee Appreciation—A Communication Perspective" by Julia Stranzl, Sabine A. Einwiller, and Christopher Ruppel, presents the findings of a systematic literature review on appreciation in the workplace. They encourage greater attention to this area, especially during crises, and to the co-creation process of an appreciative working climate. Second, **Chapter 24**, "Care, Justice, and Resilience: Designing Positive Employee Communication from Organizational Communication Perspectives", written by Ziyu Long and Lauren L. Buisker, reviews relevant literature in the field of organizational communication to foreground four processes essential for positive employee communication: cultivating a dissent-welcoming culture; enacting care and justice leadership; building mentoring relationships; and fostering employee and group resilience. This chapter synthesizes key findings from existing literature to generate theoretical and practical insights for intervention and invention that can (re)build, cultivate, and elevate positive employee communication. Third, **Chapter 25** by Enzhu Dong and Yeonjae Lee, "Employee Communication and Well-Being", explores how transparent communication, as a strategic employee communication, affects employees' affective well-being while working from home during the pandemic turbulence/crisis. Fourth, organizational listening has been overlooked in most public relations and organizational communication scholarship. Jim Macnamara's **Chapter 26**, "Organizational Listening by Employers and Employees: The Communication 'Glue' for

Organizational Success" argues that listening needs to be made explicit and suggests embedding listening in organizational processes, as reciprocal relationships.

Finally, Laura L. Lemon conclude Part III with **Chapter 27**, "Employees' Lived Experiences and Co-Creational Employee Engagement Approach". She advocate adoption of a co-creational approach to employee engagement in which all internal publics are treated as intrinsically valuable meaning-making partners who then act as conduits for organizational success. They suggest that co-creational employee engagement be a top priority for organizations, not simply because it impacts the bottom line but also because it is the right thing to do.

Part IV: Emerging Trends in Research on Employee Communication and Organizational Processes

Our last section of this handbook covers emerging trends in research on employee communication and organizational processes. These trends include: the impact of technologies and the COVID-19 pandemic on employee communication and organizational processes; diversity, equity, inclusion, and belongingness (DEIB) initiatives in the workplace; and inclusion of communicative dilemmas in labor and supply chains in the Global South. We divide these emerging trends into "big picture" or overarching issues and then focus on specific strategies and insights about employee communication in the workplace before providing our own final thoughts in our last chapter.

With regard to overarching issues in emerging trends, Timothy Betts and Logan E. Gibbs examine how employees' use of social media affects organizing in **Chapter 28**, "Connection, or Communicating the Place and Purpose of Work on Social Media". They look at how social media have reshaped employees' sensemaking about work and the world through discursive connection—specifically digital labor and online antiwork advocacy—in the contexts of the economic and political conversations.

Sean M. Eddington, Caitlyn M. Jarvis, Cale Morrow, Mara McGee, and Chanse R. Jordan also present theorizing on online organizing but in their **Chapter 29**, "Navigating Employee Communication during Times of Backlash: An Affordable Perspective on Online Organizing", they examine recurring online issues for workplaces, such as antifeminism, antiworkness, and anti-DEIB attitudes. They highlight specific

affordances—anonymity, community and connection and the role of emotion—and conclude with implications for employee communication, including policies for harassment and trolling, leadership considerations, and bridging differences.

Besides social media and online organizing, three chapters address communication competence as an emerging trend. Kaisa Pekkala, Chiara Valentini, and Vilma Luoma-aho take a different view on emerging trends insofar as their **Chapter 30**, "Tracing the History of Organizational Representatives' Communication Competence", pursues the need for greater understanding of organizational representatives' communication competence. They conduct a broad sweep of the conceptualizations and manifestations of competence from ancient orators to modern employee advocates to show how organizations have depended on members' communication competence to interact with diverse stakeholders. Ana Ana Tkalac Verčič also explores culture in terms of essential competencies for our global intercultural/multicultural and technological world in their **Chapter 31**, "Challenges for Global and International Employee Communication". The third chapter on competence, **Chapter 32** by Luca Quaratino, traces the historical development of hybrid workplaces then describes key competences required for effective leadership in "Hybrid Work Context and Leadership Communication".

Besides online communication and competence, another emerging trend is identified by Chun-Ju Flora Hung-Baesecke and Kate Delmo who propose employee activism as a means of navigating growing social expectations toward organizations' corporate citizenship in **Chapter 33**, "Employee Activism for Social Impacts: The Strategic Management and Relational Approach". They recommend that organizations both integrate employee activism with strategic planning, and consider employees as partners in addressing social issues.

Activism also is inherent in worker voice and workplace participation that has a vital element of critical organizational communication inquiry. Shiv Ganesh, Bhoopali Nandurkar, and Samantha Rae Shorey critically assess organizational communication research on participation and voice in the context of employee engagement. In **Chapter 34**, "From Employee Engagement to Worker Voice: Communicative Dilemmas in Labor and Supply Chains in the Global South", they argue for the need to utilize terminology more conducive to critical analyses that center workers and labor. They model how to do so by presenting two cases on global labor hierarchies, focusing on global commodity and supply

chains. They address whether and how issues of voice might be centered in contemporary discussions about circularity and sustainability, and in questions about scale, vulnerability, and risk that inevitably accompany discussions about solutions and remedies to the ravages of global capitalism on work, life, and the planet.

From broader concerns regarding activism, other chapters engage with these processes in workplaces. With regard to specific strategies and insights about internal employee communication and workplace configurations in emerging trends—such as DEIB, internal CSR, the current permacrisis and paradoxical world, and the role of AI and chatbots.

A sense of belonging occurs when people feel like they are an integral part of a system or environment. Attention to belonging has extended to the workplace, identifying collegial acceptance as an important relational dynamic for employees. **Chapter 35** by Brenda J. Allen on Belonging at Work explores why and how to cultivate workplaces where all members feel a strong sense of belonging. This area of study is especially relevant in the wake of the global pandemic, social unrest, economic disruption, and the great workplace attrition. As organizations navigate these and other challenges, cultivating a strong sense of belonging among employees is essential for loyalty, retention, and justice.

Taking a different slant on DEIB, Sunha Yeo and Norliana Hashim focus on multinational companies (MNCs)' communication strategies, including two-way communication, symmetrical communication and cross-cultural communication in **Chapter 36**. In "A Multinational Company with Foreign Employees", they explore how these communication strategies can address the challenges MNCs face, such as integration, differentiation, and communication with employees from diverse cultural backgrounds. They identify outcomes of communication strategies, such as ethical communication, inclusion, and conflict resolution.

Similarly, Katharine E. Miller suggests that key CSR issues—workplace harassment, inequality, and diversity initiatives—should be addressed internally in her **Chapter 37**, "Internal Corporate Social Responsibility: A Communication Perspective on CSR for Employees". She contends that aligning internal CSR initiatives with core business strategies engage employees. She concludes with current discourse in the media and popular press to argue that this is the most important CSR trend now and in the foreseeable future.

Looking at the present with an eye toward the future, Ganga Dhanesh and Gaellle Picherit-Duthler delve into the ways organizations navigate a world in a state of paradox and permacrisis, with continuing wars and conflicts, geopolitical uncertainties, and agitations for social and environmental causes. Their **Chapter 38**, "The Role of Internal Communication in Predicting Remote Employee Engagement in a Crisis: An Expanded Framework of Remote Internal Crisis Communication (RICC)", offers a comprehensive theoretical and practical lens to understand drivers of employee engagement in remote work contexts during crisis situations. Meanwhile, Yunna Rhee and Bitt Moon's **Chapter 39,** "When Employee Communication Behavior Triggers Organizational Crisis: Strategic Thinking about Internal Crisis Communication (ICC) in Public Relations", emphasizes how anonymous online ECBs can act as triggers for organizational crises. They propose potential avenues for future ICC and ECB research and tools for effectively managing crises. Taking a different, paradoxical route, Silvia Ravazzani reflects on how (pandemic) employee communication of the future might benefit from adopting a processual, paradoxical perspective on crises and communication that could better prepare organizations for any "unimaginable" critical event in **Chapter 40**, "Pandemic and Employee Communication: Unprecedented Changes in Employee Communication and Organizational Processes".

Although not unimaginable, Kerk F. Kee, Shan Xu, and Kulsawasd Jitkajornwanich bridge internal and external communication for the present and into the future by discussing the challenges and opportunities of AI in the workplace. **Chapter 41**, "AI, Chatbots, and Employee Communication", explores AI's affordances at the workplace, including automation, personalization, and self-learning. Challenges include the ethical considerations of biases in AI systems, the threats of AI at the workplace, as well as fairness, transparency, and privacy. By provides an overview of theoretical frameworks for understanding AI adoption and implementation in organizations, these authors develop some implications and future directions that link AI concerns with other emerging trends in this Part IV.

Our final essay, **Chapter 42: Conclusion** by Patrice M. Buzzanell, Soojin Kim, Alessandra Mazzei, and Jeong-Nam Kim collapses the context of our chapters into four main themes centered around who employees are, how aspects of employee communication and organizing become more or less (in)visible and to what ends, when and where tensions emerge during organizing employee communication, and why

employee communication needs to be challenged at this point in time for ethical and responsible futures. We also discuss what topics are not covered in our handbook. It is our hope that our work provides theoretical and pragmatic insights for practitioners, PR and organizational scholars, and students.

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PART I

Theoretical Frameworks

2

PUBLIC RELATIONS RESEARCH ON EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION

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Between 2010 and 2020, the research cluster of employee communication makes up 7.16% of public relations scholarship (Zhou et al., 2023). In fact, perspectives of public relations have been applied to research on employee communication since the 1970s, and such research has evolved as the focus of public relations has shifted from impression management to relationship management. Since the concept of organization–public relationships (OPRs) was introduced in public relations research in 2000s, the concept of employee–organization relationships (EORs) has been extensively examined in relation to different antecedents (e.g., leadership styles, symmetrical communication) and different outcomes (e.g., communicative behaviors, turnover intentions) and in a variety of situations (e.g., crises, CSR). Employee communication remains a research cluster with minimal intersections with other research areas within public relations (Zhou et al., 2023). There has been a surge in empirical research on employees' behaviors, including employee engagement, employee voice and silence, employee communicative behaviors (ECBs), and allegiant communication behavior (ACB). This chapter provides an overview of how public relations has been applied to employee communication, discusses the antecedents, outcomes, and situations examined, and summarizes the new concepts arising from research on EORs.

From Impression Management Strategies to EORs

Employee communication, also known as internal communication, is a subdiscipline within communication that examines organizational members' communication within organizations. According to Frank and Browell (1989), it is defined as "the communication transactions between individuals and/or groups at various levels and in different areas of specialization that are intended to design and redesign organizations, to implement designs and to coordinate day-to-day activities" (pp. 5–6). Employee communication is a multidimensional construct, and two of its components, including how the information is communicated within their organizations and employees' satisfaction with the information being communicated, are critical determinants of employees' identification with their organizations (Smidts et al., 2001). When employee communication is applied to the context of public relations, it adopts a focus on stakeholders' perspectives and is defined as "communication between an organization's strategic managers and its internal stakeholders, designed to promote commitment to the organisation, a sense of belonging to it, awareness of its changing environment and understanding of its evolving aims" (Welch & Jackson, 2007, p. 193). Its purpose is to build favorable relationships between management and employees (Men & Stacks, 2014).

Since the 1990s, the development of employee communication research has evolved with the development of public relations research. Some of the earliest work that applied the perspective of public relations to the context of employee communication associated public relations with image or impression management. Image refers to the mental symbols or ideas that a communicator creates to give to receivers to change their cognitions, attitudes, and behaviors (Grunig, 1993). Caillouet and Allen (1996) explored the impression management strategies employees used when discussing their organizations' situations with outsiders. Wright (1995) noted that the roles of public relations executives in employee communication had been limited to the dissemination of messages such as producing publications and videos. Despite the research findings from the Excellence Study that demonstrated the significance of two-way communication to facilitate mutual understanding, the concept of relationship was not prevalent in research on employee communication in or prior to the 1990s (Grunig et al., 1992; Wright, 1995).

During the 2000s, there was a surge of research on OPRs, giving rise to the concept of EORs. Ledingham and Bruning (1998) defined OPRs as "the state that exists between an organization and its key publics that

provides economic, social, political, and/or cultural benefits to all parties involved, and is characterized by mutual positive regard" (p. 62). The quality of OPRs was measured with four indicators including trust, control mutuality, commitment, and satisfaction (Huang, 2001). OPRs were empirically tested in the context of employee communication when H. S. Kim (2007) confirmed the finding of the Excellence Study, noting the significance of symmetrical communication in developing positive employee relationships. EORs are defined as "the degree to which an organization and its employees trust one another, agree on who has the rightful power to influence, experience satisfaction with each other, and commit oneself to the other" (Men & Stacks, 2014, p. 307) and emphasize mutual obligations and expectations and continuous interactions between an organization and its employees (Lee, Kang, et al., 2022). While individual employees often perceive a power imbalance in their relationships with their employers, relational attributes, especially control mutuality, are critical to alleviating perceptions of power difference and improving employee outcomes such as turnover intention (Lee, Kang, et al., 2022). Furthermore, organizations that are perceived to be making efforts to pursue mutual understanding with employees are also more likely to generate supportive behaviors from consumer publics (Kim et al., 2024).

Two studies have analyzed the past and current states of research that applied public relations to employee communication research (Lee & Yue, 2020; Zhou et al., 2023). Y. Lee and Yue (2020) conducted a systematic review of 223 articles published in three major journals from 1970 to 2019. They found: (a) exponential growth of publications since 2012, (b) a surge in research on employee behaviors such as employee voice and dissent, and (c) coverage of diverse topics, ranging from job satisfaction to work engagement. As previously noted, the development of employee communication research has gone hand-in-hand with public relations research. The rise of social media as two-way communication channels has turned employees into strategic brand ambassadors who are not just recipients of messages but active communicators of information related to the organizations with external publics (Lee & Yue, 2020). Zhou et al. (2023) used computer modeling to analyze 1,293 articles published in two major public relations journals in 2010–2020 and found that the research cluster of internal communication made up 7.16% of all publications and had used business and management literature as basis. The growth of the cluster concentrates around the use of the strategic behavioral paradigm (i.e., EORs) (Zhou et al., 2023). Despite this, the

cluster mostly used frameworks from employee communication and developed new ones that were only applicable to further research on employee communication, failing to harness collaboration with other specialties within public relations such as crisis communication (Zhou et al., 2023).

Antecedents of EORs

Symmetrical Communication

Because EORs are described as "the major outcome generated by internal public relations" (Men & Stacks, 2014, p. 306), a large volume of literature has sought to identify the antecedents of EORs. One of the most frequently examined antecedents is symmetrical communication (e.g., Kim, 2007; Kim & Rhee, 2011; Lee, 2022a; Men & Sung, 2022). H. S. Kim (2007) characterized symmetrical communication as taking place "through dialogue, negotiation, listening, and conflict management rather than through persuasion, manipulation, and the giving of others" (p. 171). Symmetrical communication could be facilitated through the use of communication channels by CEOs, managers, and peers (Lee, 2022a). Men and Sung (2022) found that corporate character mediates the relationship between symmetrical communication and EORs as "symmetrical internal communication nurtures an agreeable, competent, and enterprising corporate character in the eyes of employees" (p. 443). Symmetrical communication is measured in terms of an organization's commitment to maintain two-way communication and to encourage expression of different opinions. Its significance can be explained by the organization's demonstrated commitment to foster a participative organizational culture where employees are empowered to participate in decision-making, reducing the asymmetry of power between management and employees (Men, 2014).

Leadership

Leadership has been identified as another determinant of EORs. Leadership refers to the process of influencing followers at various organizational levels, and leadership communication shapes perceptions of the followers (Men, 2014). There are leaders at various levels of organizations, ranging from front-line supervisors and executive leaders (Men & Jiang, 2016). Leadership affects EORs because it determines an

organization's communication styles which ultimately influence employees' perceptions of organizational culture and power distribution (Men & Jiang, 2016). Transformational leadership and authentic leadership have positive effects on EORs. Transformational leaders are relationship-oriented and motivate employees by inducing them to prioritize organizational interests over self-interests (Men, 2014). By instilling a sense of purpose and collective mission in employees, transformational leaders also create an emotional bond between leaders and employees, fostering a trusting organizational climate in which employees feel empowered to influence decision-making. Employees are found to have a strong preference for transformational leadership over transaction leadership; the latter is characterized as viewing the leader–follower relationship as instrumental economic transactions (Men, 2014). In addition to transformational leadership, authentic leadership also significantly influences EORs. Men and Stacks (2014) characterized authentic leaders as those who demonstrate consistency in what they believe, say, and do, and authentic leadership communication as "openness, consistency, transparency, truthfulness, and accountability" (p. 307). Authentic and transformational leaders are able to build positive EORs because of their efforts to put in place an organizational communication system that promotes openness, fairness, and balance in their communication with employees.

Communication Styles and Channels

In addition to symmetrical communication and leadership styles, public relations research has also identified other factors that determine EORs. Corporate character, defined as how individuals distinguish one organization from another, reflects the human attributes that individuals associate with an organization (Men & Sung, 2022). Men and Sung (2022) found that the attribute of ruthlessness (i.e., controlling, authoritarian, arrogant, selfish) negatively affected EORs. Men (2015) also argued that CEOs had an "internal communication role" and that when they demonstrated a responsive communication style, EORs are improved. A responsive communication style is characterized by "good listening, being responsive, empathetic, compassionate, understanding, friendly, warm, sincere and interested" (Men, 2015, p. 464). Employees' perceptions of such a communication style are partially determined by channels CEOs used. Their use of two-way communication channels, such as social media and interpersonal communication, fosters two-way

communication and power symmetry (Men, 2015). Y. Lee (2022a) also found that CEOs' use of diverse communication channels shape perceptions of symmetrical communication and enhance EORs.

Consequences of EORs

Turnover Intention

Numerous empirical studies have established significant relationships between EORs and positive employee outcomes. Positive relationships with employees help to engage them in the organizational decision-making and to get them to support the implementation process (Men & Hung, 2012). Within public relations research, one of the most frequently examined outcome variable is turnover intention. Turnover intention refers to employee' intention to quit their jobs, which is detrimental and expensive for an organization (e.g., Kim et al., 2017). The presence of a turnover culture within organizations is especially problematic, high turnover rates indicate shared cognitions of job movements among employees. Suh and Lee (2016) described employee turnover as a withdrawal behavior and measured it as intention to quit one's job and look for a new job. Internal communication efforts that foster employees' identification with their organizations and inclusion are mostly likely to reduce employee turnover intention (Kim & Kim, 2023; Lee, Zhang, et al., 2022).

Organizational Citizenship Behaviors

Organizational citizenship behaviors (OCBs) refer to individuals' discretionary behaviors that promote the effective functioning of an organization and consist of seven behaviors: helping behavior, sportsmanship, organizational loyalty, organizational compliance, individual initiative, civic virtue, and self-development (Podsakoff et al., 2000). In the context of startups in China, Men (2021) found a significant relationship between EORs and OCBs. Because startups are constrained with limited financial resources, employees' voluntary acts within organizations helped to free up their limited resources and divert them to attain important strategic goals (Men, 2021). Positive EORs lead employees to be "more likely to walk extra miles and even sacrifice their self-interests for the benefits of the startup" (Men, 2021, p. 4). Although many studies measure OCBs with multiple indicators testing the different

behaviors within OCBs, Men (2021) measured it as a formative construct with four items that examined employees' willingness to walk the extra miles to improve the startups they worked for. The finding demonstrates EORs' contribution to organizational effectiveness as employees are willing to take up extra roles and responsibilities to benefit their organizations.

Perceived Organization-Employee Dialogic Communication

An organization's efforts to engage in two-way communication with employees also help to positively contribute to consumer publics' supportive behaviors toward the organization. Perceived organization–employee dialogic communication refers to individuals' perceptions of organizations' engagement in a dialogue with employees to promote mutual understanding (Kim et al., 2024). It consists of two dimensions: the dimension of perceived mutual dimension refers to an organization's efforts to listen to employees' diverse perspectives in a mutually respectful manner, whereas the dimension of perceived climate of openness refers to an organization's efforts to open up access of information and communication channels for open and honest communication with employees (Kim et al., 2024). From the perspectives of CSR communication, this shows the importance of promoting to external publics how an organization has involved its employees in its decision-making processes.

Situations Examined in Research on EORs

Issues and Crises

Y. Lee and Yue (2020) found that issue and crisis management were the most researched topic within internal communication research after 2011. Even if employees are not the direct victims of organizational crises, they may still suffer from problematic consequences of crises involving their organizations. During COVID-19, employees experienced job-related uncertainty, negative emotions, and job disengagement (Ruppel et al., 2022). These negative consequences may also affect employees' communicative behaviors and engage in collective actions against their companies (Lee, 2021). Due to the dire consequences, internal crisis communication plays a crucial role in reducing employees' feelings of uncertainty. Effective internal crisis communication should strive to

increase employees' willingness to support their organizations during and after a crisis (Kim et al., 2019). To do this, organizations are advised to provide employees with access to important and updated information about the crisis (Adamu & Mohamad, 2019) and reduce misalignment of misinterpretations between managers and employees (Mazzei & Ravazzani, 2011). Despite this, pre-crisis EORs and employees' problem perceptions about the crisis itself also determine employee outcomes of the crises (Kim et al., 2019; Lee, 2019).

Corporate Social Responsibility

Because employees' communicative behaviors are critical determinants of organizational reputation, they are considered ambassadors of their organizations who create and distribute information about their workplaces. In the context of corporate social responsibility (CSR), they are known as "information influencers of organization's CSR practices" (Lee & Tao, 2020, p. 1). Their favorable or unfavorable messages about their organizations' CSR activities influence external publics' attitudes and behavioral intentions (Lee & Tao, 2020). To ensure that employees see the fit between their organizations' CSR activities and organizational culture, organizations are advised to incorporate discretionary, ethical, legal, and economic CSR into their relationship building and cultivation efforts with employees (Chen et al., 2019). CSR-culture fit is found to increase perceptions of fairness in organizational actions and reduce skepticism toward an organization's CSR efforts (Chen et al., 2019). Employees' participation in decision-making in CSR also improves prosocial behavioral outcome among employees and EORs (Tao et al., 2018).

Organizational Change

Organizations ought to engage in planned changes to adapt to changing external environments, but employees tend to display employee cynicism toward constant changes in organizations (Qian & Daniels, 2008). Qian and Daniels (2008) examined change-specific cynicism as a negative attitude toward the organizations they work for and found that it led to a resistance to change. Since employees are active participants of their organizations, organizations should seek to foster trust among them to facilitate change implementation through strategies such as transformational leadership (Yue et al., 2019). According to Shah et al. (2017), organizations' change programs should be developed based on

multiple data points that reflect employees' internal and external motivations to involve in the change process. Before and during the process, there should also be an emphasis on employee voice, including providing anonymous communication platforms that encourage employee voice and discourage silence (Kim & Leach, 2020).

Key Concepts in Research on EORs

Employee Engagement

Engagement has been a buzzword in public relations research; its application to the employee context examines the extent to which employees are cognitively, affectively, and behaviorally present and dedicated to their roles in order to contribute to organizational outcomes (Dhanesh, 2017). The presence of employee engagement reflects employees' well-being and employees' motivations to accomplish positive job performance. Internal communication is an antecedent to employee engagement. When organizations are engaged in two-way bi-lateral flows of communication with employees and publish content that foster employees' trust in and identification with the organizations, employees feel more socially connected with their colleagues and develop a better sense of control over their work and time (Dhanesh & Picherit-Duthler, 2021). Verčič and Men (2023) also found that employees' satisfaction with internal communication contributed to employee engagement through perceived organizational support and perceived employer attractiveness. Kang and Sung (2017) found that the relationship between internal communication and employee engagement was mediated by EOR quality.

Employee Voice and Dissent

Research on employee engagement has consistently found the positive benefits of two-way and inclusive internal communication environments on employee and organizational outcomes (Dhanesh & Picherit-Duthler, 2021; Kang & Sung, 2017; Verčič & Men, 2023), highlighting the significance of employee voice. Ruck et al. (2017) juxtaposed employee voice and employee silence, defining the former as the intention to express work-related ideas and the latter as the intention to withhold work-related ideas. When there are opportunities for employees to express their ideas "upward" to senior management and for senior

management to respond to their suggestions, employees become more emotionally engaged (Ruck et al., 2017). On the other hand, Kang (2021) identified the negative effects of employees' dissenting testimonials on organizational reputation as assessed by external publics. Notably, there are three types of dissenting voices: articulated dissent (i.e., openly and clearly expressing ideas through upward organizational voice channels), latent dissent (i.e., voicing dissent to internal audiences amidst limited official organizational channels), and displaced dissent (i.e., voicing dissent to external audiences other than media and political sources) (Kang, 2021). Displaced dissent is different from whistleblowing, which is defined as an act of communication to disclose organizational wrongdoing either internally or externally (Greenwood, 2015).

Employee Communicative Behaviors

Shifting the focus of employees as recipients of organizational messages to their being producers and messengers of messages related to their organizations, research on ECBs considers employees as micro-boundary spanners between their organizations and external publics (Kim & Rhee, 2011). ECB consists of two aspects: megaphoning and scouting. Megaphoning is a broader term than word-of-mouth and includes both active and passive voluntary behaviors (Lee, 2022b). It is defined as "the likelihood of employees' voluntary information forwarding or information sharing about organizational strengths (accomplishments) or weaknesses (problems)" (Kim & Rhee, 2011, p. 246). Scouting is defined as employees' voluntary information attending or seeking during formal and informal interactions with organizational strategic constituencies and sharing and forward of the information with the organizations (Kim & Rhee, 2011). Positive EORs would foster micro-boundary spanning, as employees engage in voluntary communicative behaviors to disperse positive information about their organizations, search and obtain valuable organization-related information, and disseminate the acquired information with management (Kim & Rhee, 2011).

Allegiant Communicative Behaviors

ACB refers to "employees' loyal and faithful communicative actions for their organizations" (Chon et al., 2021, p. 1). ACB further conceptualizes employee voice and silence and breaks them down into three categories. Allgiant Voice refers to "employees' proactive communication to care for

organizational betterment by speaking up" (Chon et al., 2021, p. 3). Allegiant amity is defined as "employees' shyness and quietness to benefit one's belonging to a group or organization by speaking down" (Chon et al., 2021, p. 5). Allegiant reticence refers to the withholding of work-related ideas or information with the goal of benefiting an organization (Chon et al., 2021). Chon et al. (2021) argues that it is important to examine and differentiate these to provide a more holistic view of employees' actions and inactions.

Practical Implications

Public relations research has highlighted the importance of communication *to*, *with*, and *by* employees to pursue mutually beneficial EORs. In consideration of organizational hierarchy, organizations should strive to acknowledge the significant impact of organizational leaders' leadership and communication styles, and practice two-way communication to reduce power imbalances between management and employees. Because employees actively engage in communicative behaviors about their organizations within and outside of their organizations, organizations should also ensure that multiple channels are put in place to foster effective upward, downward, and horizontal communication between employees and management. They should also regularly monitor and track whether and how employees' feedback is integrated into organizational decision-making.

Conclusion

From the perspectives of public relations, internal communication is an antecedent that builds and cultivates mutually beneficial relationships between an organization and its employees. Present research has identified factors that create positive internal communication environments such as symmetrical internal communication and leadership. Consequently, positive EORs will also lead to positive organizational outcomes including lower staff turnover and positive ECBs and ACB. Despite its lack of collaboration with other research clusters, employee communication within the public relations domain has made significant contributions to the conceptualization and operationalization of a series of communicative behaviors, including megaphoning, scouting, allegiant amity, allegiant voice, and allegiant reticence. These communicative behaviors extend beyond the

passiveness and activeness of word-of-mouth communication (Lee, 2022b) and highlight the significance of different communicative behaviors to organizational outcomes in various situations.

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3

ORGANIZATIONAL COMMUNICATION RESEARCH ON EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION

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Over 70 years ago, organizational communication had its interdisciplinary roots in industrial psychology, management and administrative science, and rhetoric with a focus on improving business practices and developing a positive organizational climate for bottom-line results and employee satisfaction (Buzzanell & Stohl, 1999). This pragmatic orientation focused on Western business enterprises and sought to uncover strategies that would explain and predict how workers and managers in bricks-and-mortar companies exchanged messages so that expectations, directives, and goals were clearly transmitted, accurately received, and instrumental in creating culture in which workers were motivated to perform tasks without a second thought (Barnard, 1938/1968; Stohl & Redding, 1987). Employee communication topics related primarily to internal organizational functions and workplace interactions, including superior-subordinate communication, feedback, listening, intergroup conflict, training effects, decision-making, and managerial and/or organizational communication climate. For instance, researchers investigated ways of utilizing participation and organizational clarity to increase employees' organizational commitments (Guzley, 1992).

In the 1980s–1990s, organizational communication began shifting from its (post)positive and functionalist positioning to explore different

types of members and forms as well as organizing as a politicized process through interpretive, critical, postmodern, and feminist analyses and critiques (Mumby, 2007). Since then, organizational communication has retained its roots while also embracing the ambiguities, contradictions, and the boundaryless, technologically-mediated, and local-global nature of organizing. By taking linguistic, discursive, material, and affective turns, scholars attend to the constitutive processes through which organizing and organization are (re)structured on micro, meso, and macrolevels. Mumby and Stohl (1996) contended that organizational communication differentiated itself as a discipline from business, corporate, and managerial communication by promoting expansive problematics. These problematics were: voice ("contest[ing] the monolithic managerial voice that tends to dominate other areas of organizational studies", p. 55); rationality (infusing "pluralistic understandings…[that shape] knowledge claims" to undermine a singular focus on effectiveness, p. 59); organization ("calling into question what is meant by organization", p. 62); and the organization–society relationship (attending "to the ways in which society, culture, organizations, and communication are inextricably and reciprocally bound", p. 65). These, too, were challenged as Broadfoot and Munshi (2007) provoked reconsiderations of these problematics and of organizational communication from postcolonial positionalities of marginalized Others. They continue this work with current advocacy to de-center, de-colonize, and revolutionize organizational communication by pulling in non-Western, particularly marginalized and indigenous, ways of knowing and being (Pal et al., 2022), and broaden those whom researchers study from intersectional lenses (Crenshaw, 1989; Linabary et al., 2021).

This overview of organizational communication sets the stage for discussions about employee communication. At first employee communication—particularly that involving white, male, heterosexual workers and managers in businesses operating and/or headquartered in Western countries—centered on the ways in which standard operating procedures, upward–downward–horizontal communication, and workplace and organizational structures could be designed and implemented for seemingly similar employees (i.e., ideal workers) who had no encumbrances, such as family lives, to divert them from work. The design of employee communication sought to orient hierarchy, meritocracy, selection, and competitiveness with organizational goals (see traditional-alternative themes in Buzzanell, 1994). This approach to

effectiveness, while still applicable for economic sustainability, has been enriched and complicated by polyvocality and the emergent, constitutive approach to organizing that attends to how realities are co-created or jointly produced by embodied people engaged in interaction situated in time and place (Ashcraft et al., 2009).

At present, organizational communication has branched out into the messy, complicated contradictions at the basis of employee communication in diverse organizational forms, sectors, and memberships. Researchers still study ways of increasing productivity, effectiveness, and commitment, and also address work-life policies and practices, initiatives to foster belongingness (often called diversity, equity, and inclusion or DEI), virtual distributed teams, and leadership for mundane and crisis/post-crisis situations. For instance, Cruz (2017) used an Afrocentric feminist organizing lens to explore how market women in post-conflict Liberia engage in grassroots organizing. Furthermore, contingent, independent contracting, and temporary help agency workers have become prominent in scholarship (Buzzanell & Medved, 2024), as have non-human AI employees such as chatbots (West, 2018) and workers in the informal economy (Villanueva & Lin, 2020). Although not "employees" in a traditional sense, enlarged and enriched understandings of workers are central to contemporary employee communication (Khan et al., 2024). Communicating and organizing among workers are theorized as more fluid and context-dependent in values and logics and embedded in economies of the Global South and other areas of the world (Buzzanell & Medved, 2024; Cruz & Sodeke, 2021). As a result, employee communication from an organizational communication perspective considers varied processes but often those that can be grouped in three areas: (a) identity/identification, (b) organizational community, and (c) agency and boundaries.

Identity/Identification

Work identity is the central characteristic that informs what and how employees choose their occupations (Albert & Whetten, 1985). Work identification describes the cognitive process of assessing identity to obtain status enhancement (Dutton et al., 1994; Liu et al., 2011), but organizational communication scholars have theorized communicative identity and identification regions formed through social interactions (Scott et al., 1998). For example, they investigate group conversations for organizational change from a constitutive approach (Chaput &

Basque, 2022), ways identification affects workers' willingness to share their organizational affiliations via social media (Piercy & Carr, 2023), and how immigrant women entrepreneurs from 30 different countries (dis)connect from various identities for business success (Haseki et al., 2021).

The importance of identity/identification in employee communication is embedded in the assumption that when individuals strongly identify with their organization or work, they adopt their occupation into their self-concept (Dutton et al., 1994; Lam, 2012), but when they disidentify, they disassociate their identity from their organizations and perceive "negative relational categorization[s] of [them/]oneself and the organization" (Elsbach & Bhattacharya 2001, p. 397). Further, in cases of disidentification, individuals "eschew managerial definitions of organization, identity, and practice in favor of alternative designations….the subject positions embedded in an alternative discourse determine the individual's (explicit) interpretations of the organization and her/his relation to it" (Holmer-Nadesan, 1996, p. 58).

Recent research has studied organizational disidentification examining various sites or phenomenon where disidentification could be found. Organizational disidentification influences organizational citizenship behavior by limiting employees' motivation to improve organizational practices—unless employees want to make good impressions, are benevolent toward others, perceive that their organizations encourage these behaviors, or are highly involved with their occupation (De Clercq, 2021). For example, disidentification among soldiers can begin with betrayal, manifested in a detachment from various factors like leadership, mission, and values of organizations (i.e., the military), and produce suffering like loneliness among the soldiers (Kalkman, 2023). When organizational decisions are perceived as self-serving, there is an increased probability that employees who disidentify with their organization will attempt to cause harm to their co-workers due to the embarrassment of being associated with the organization (De Clercq & Pereira, 2023).

Organizational disidentification impacts employees' and employers' day-to-day lives through issues such as employee turnover (Bentein et al., 2017; Lai et al., 2013). For example, when National Rifle Association employees experienced disidentification, they voiced their opinions and values (Elsbach & Bhattacharya, 2001). When employees become aware of organizational injustice, they disconnect from their organization (Jahanzeb et al., 2021); and when organizational disidentification is left

unchecked, unethical employee behavior, such as embarrassing co-workers, can occur (De Clercq & Pereira, 2023). However, if employees perceive their occupation to have high status or their organization to be caring and supportive, they are less likely to consider leaving even when they have high levels of disidentification (Lai et al., 2013). Some organizations have higher worker disidentification, such as those whose members perform "dirty work" or stigmatized occupations (Hughes, 1951). Since work dirtiness is a perceived construct (Ashforth & Kreiner, 1999), organizations can enact programs that instill importance and dignity in the occupation while demonstrating their organizational support. In addition, human service agencies can foster resilience communication to stem turnover by supporting employees' and volunteers' strategies for overcoming occupational challenges, such as the stressors and family disruptions incurred by disaster-relief work and care for clients living in poverty. For example, disaster-relief workers talk about and invoke familial, ideological, and destruction-renewal identify/identification networks to find support for and to continue their work (Agarwal & Buzzanell, 2015).

Organizational Community

Organizational communication scholars have long valued positive communication cultures and community, as seen in the Redding tradition's message-centered and relational approach (managerial climate, Buzzanell & Stohl, 1999) and continuing through investigations of place-based and not-for-profit affiliations in disadvantaged rural areas (Okamoto, 2020), men's rights and anti-feminist online groups (Eddington, 2020), political advocacy by women's networks (Pauly, 2022), queer spaces and gay bars (Branton & Compton, 2021), and single-mother family communities and nonprofit organizing (Williams et al., 2023). In each of these studies, research participants are in different kinds of communities but all work for their organizations' missions whether paid employees, unpaid volunteers, clients, and/or co-workers. Across organizations, prominent issues tie members together through identification, creating and sustaining belongingness and inclusion for recruitment, retention, quality of life, ethical responsibilities, and innovation.

Belongingness is the degree to which employees feel a part of organizational missions and processes (Mor-Barak & Cherin 1998) and is considered a fundamental human need (Baumeister & Leary, 2017).

Currently, scholars examine belongingness through DEI initiatives that are considered to be vehicles for achieving cultures of belonging or attachments, participation, dignity, and respect (Doerfel & Gibbs, 2020). Organizational communication scholars explore inclusion in their research as diversity or differences among groups. The politics that surround difference have become ever more salient in U.S. workplaces and around the globe (Doerfel & Gibbs, 2020) and are embedded in organizational communication's roots.

The study of difference in organizational communication initially emphasized managerial control (Tompkins & Wanca-Thibault, 2001) and the "reification of the status quo", before moving into more complex studies of identities, meanings, and cultures from different metatheoretical perspectives (Parker & McDonald, 2019). Difference is conceptualized as a social construction through which power disseminates via communicative processes (Allen, 2011; McDonald, 2015; Parker & McDonald, 2019). Today, organizational communication scholars have taken an "inclusive turn" in their research (Larson et al., 2022) as part of broad D/discourses of difference or diversity that shape inclusive ideals and practices, identify disadvantaged groups, examine how they have been historically and systemically excluded from participation, and focus on inclusion barriers such as normativity, stereotypes, and tokenism (Larson et al., 2022), as well as language, class, and racial differences in all aspects of organizing and socializing (e.g., Gist-Mackey & Kingsford, 2020; Walker & Muñoz Rojas, 2021; Williams et al., 2023). Furthermore, engaged organizational communication scholars address exclusion-related dilemmas, research and analyze the problems, and develop recommendations and diversity programs (Dempsey & Barge, 2014; Mease, 2012). DEI initiatives can positively influence feelings of inclusion and belonging (Jelks et al., 2021). They can foster coworker connections (DiFrancesco et al., 2023), employee engagement and motivation (Murrell et al., 2021), creativity and innovation (Murrell et al., 2021), and organizational commitment (DiFrancesco et al., 2023), among other outcomes and processes.

However, these efforts can also lead to downsides or unintended consequences that might reinforce existing power structures or further marginalize certain groups (Sulistyawati et al., 2019) as members work within tensions of tradition and innovation (Gailliard et al., 2020). Organizational communication scholars recognize that if actions are not coupled with sites of power and potential, they cannot have the desired effects for employees, communication, and society (Ballard et al., 2020).

While employees often feel they are being treated unfairly when their voices and ideas are not heard (Wagstaff et al., 2015), there also are examples of programs developed for particular members and organizations that produce satisfaction and employee identification by relying on discussion, role playing, and feedback (Allen, 2011; Kossek et al., 2022).

Many organizational communication scholars address inclusion through deliberative inquiry and dialogue that builds genuine relationships (Carcasson & Sprain, 2016; Larson et al., 2022). Even so, inclusion may be hampered by challenges regarding representation (who participates), definition (how voice or diversity is constituted and valued), and existing power relations (potential privileging of dominant voices) (Dutta & Pal, 2010; Larson et al., 2022; Na'puti & Cruz, 2022). Such dynamics are so deeply intertwined with multiple sources of exclusion as to be considered wicked problems and inequality regimes (Acker, 2006; Buzzanell, 2020). In terms of employee communication, organizational communication scholars seek to address inclusion as critical to contemporary organizing.

Agency and Boundaries

Much of what organizational communication scholars contribute to employee communication discusses agency and boundaries implicitly and/or explicitly. Agency typically is defined as the ability to take action but individuals' and collectivities' abilities to act may be constrained, contested, and complicit for discursive, relational, symbolic, and structural and/or material reasons that are embedded in situational power dynamics. Notions about agency and boundaries have shifted with technologies, social media policies, and professional-personal boundary-making. Interdisciplinary scholars often examine agency from human decision-making capacity, free-will, intent, and theories of rational choice toward "temporally variable social manifestations…informed by the past, but also oriented toward the future and toward the present" (Emirbayer & Mische, 1998, pp. 962–963); thus, situating human agency as a temporally, contextually, and structurally bound concept in continuous flux. Within organizational communication, agency is further complicated as sites of control, where systems of affordances discursively and fluidly shift agency between human and non-human actors (Barad, 2007; Leonardi, 2011). Agency can reproduce structures

and enhance and/or constrain capacities for organizational change (Harris et al., 2020).

In these change processes, affordances traditionally describe actions or constraints made possible through use of technology or apparatuses (Faraj & Azad, 2012; Gibson, 1979; Withagen et al., 2017). However, they also decenter human agency in acknowledging the discursive-material entanglements that make up sustainable organizational operations (Babri et al., 2022). Therefore, agency is not assumed. Rather, it is distributed or afforded through the technological and discursive infrastructures of organizations, thus structuring boundaries and shaping agency and accountability (Borowski, 2023).

Affordances of agency have been studied in varying ways within employee-centered communication scholarship. For example, internal social media platforms have been shown to afford dialogical strategies such as ambiguity, inquiry, and anonymity (Mao & DeAndrea, 2019) in enhancing uncertainty management for employees (Gode, 2019). Through their study of tourism industries, Sigala (2020) demonstrated how macro-level events like the COVID-19 pandemic can afford organizations and their stakeholders possibilities for both beneficial and detrimental change—such as discourses of essentiality that afford some employees increased worthiness of risk and danger, or work-from-home policies that can elicit greater organizational control over employees.

Shifts of agency can be tracked through diffractive cuts—referring to overlapping affordances amplifying or reducing perceptions of organizational control—that appear through organizationally situated metaphors (Tipler & Ruscher, 2014), narrative structures (Bucher, 2014), and systems of governance. For example, in their study of sexual violence discourse, Harris et al. (2020) demonstrated how organizations strategically constrain their accountability and need for change by simplifying violence as individual action. In sum, organizational communication shifts agency from the individual to an entanglement of affordances that manufacturing individuality—the linkage between employees and organizational control.

Despite the complicated nature of defining and tracking agency within organizations, systems of discursive affordances can be used to understand how control and boundaries are internally and strategically implemented into the lives of their employees. For example, social media offers a site for organizational control and the negotiation of boundaries between work and life. Within their study of social media affordances during the socialization stage of organizational assimilation, Lee et al.

(2019) found that while social media enabled new employees to establish networks with co-workers and superiors—granting the exposure necessary for socialization and advancement—these same tools proved a dialectical tension between employees' desired visibility within organizations and their separation of work and life. However, being afforded editability granted some participants the ability to selectively conceal their recreational use of social media from other organizational members and afforded agency in the conceptualizing and enacting of boundaries (Lee et al., 2019).

Similarly, in their content analysis of social media policies for the world's largest corporations, Banghart et al. (2018) revealed how boundaries of control are enacted within social media policies and structured employee behavior in different ways. Banghart et al. (2018) found ambiguity facilitated a broader regulation of behaviors not explicated in their policy, "maintaining deniability and encouraging employee interpretations that privilege corporate interests over individual ones", as in the case of professional and personal life boundaries (p. 362). Even so, legal and career issues regarding boundaries, surveillance, and organizational control remain ambiguous, contested, and ever-changing (Ghoshray, 2013; Monahan, forthcoming).

Conclusion

Organizational communication has expanded beyond notions of the traditional employee in businesses to center different kinds of workers and work itself. It does so by focusing on some key issues—identity/identification, organizational community, and agency and boundaries—while also bringing in interdisciplinary insights and findings from other communication contexts. This varied approach benefits a changing world and builds toward richer understandings of how people engage in labor—both paid and unpaid—across their lifespans and within different kinds of organizations.

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PART II

Employee Communication as Complex Phenomena

4

BOUNDARY-SPANNING BEHAVIOR AND ITS IMPLICATIONS FOR EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION

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Exploring Boundary-Spanning

This chapter focuses on defining boundary-spanning behaviors, learning from its past tradition in the management field, and its current application nested in the areas of organizational communication and public relations. This chapter aims not only to gather definitions and characteristics of boundary-spanning in different fields, but also to depict its implications for employee communication. With the growing number of approaches to boundary-spanning, as it has been used in different fields and areas of knowledge, the present work attempts to explore boundary-spanning as a whole, concentrating on the role and impact of employee boundary-spanners, alongside their communication-specific behaviors.

Boundary-spanners are in general defined as organization members who interact with both internal and external stakeholders, collecting information for these stakeholders, and bridging the gaps between them (Aldrich & Herker, 1977; Tushman & Scanlan, 1981; Springston & Leichty, 1994). This definition focuses on the relational processes and the management of information rather than in the creation of information (Ankney & Curtin, 2002), which highlights the relational mediator capability of boundary-spanners. Having to deal with individuals with

different professional backgrounds and organizational units, boundary-spanners get involved in information translating, so that complex concepts can be understood across areas (Pülzl & Rametsteiner, 2009). As mediators, they deal with conflicts, different stakeholders' expectations and interests (Ankney & Curtin, 2002).

Boundary-spanning behaviors, particularly in the context of modern organizational dynamics, have seen a considerable shift in focus, reflecting an expanded understanding of their critical role in enhancing organizational adaptability, innovation, and resilience. This trend has led to an interdisciplinary approach, integrating insights from management, organizational communication, and public relations. These diverse perspectives provide a comprehensive understanding of how organizations navigate complex environments. Additionally, there has been a shift from considering boundary-spanning as merely a group-level phenomenon to acknowledging the profound impact of individual-level actions, known as microboundary-spanning.

In today's rapidly evolving digital landscape, the role of technology and new media platforms has become important in boundary-spanning research. As organizations undergo digital transformation, the integration of advanced technologies has reshaped how they interact with their external environment. For instance, social media platforms are now widely used to extend organizational boundaries, allowing for real-time engagement with a diverse range of stakeholders (Altman & Tushman, 2017). This democratization of information dissemination has revolutionized the speed and scope of organizational communication, making it more inclusive and broad-reaching. Platforms like X, previously known as Twitter, and LinkedIn provide avenues for organizations to share updates, gather stakeholder feedback, and engage in dialogues that were previously constrained by geographical and temporal boundaries (Mao & Menchen-Trevino, 2019).

The advent of digital technologies and social media platforms has significantly transformed the landscape of boundary-spanning behaviors, necessitating a deeper understanding of digital boundary-spanning. The digital realm offers unprecedented opportunities for organizations to transcend traditional boundaries, enabling real-time communication and collaboration across geographic and temporal barriers. Studies by Leonardi and Treem (2012) have highlighted how digital tools and platforms such as enterprise social networks facilitate boundary-spanning by providing spaces for interaction that cut across organizational silos, thus promoting the sharing of knowledge and fostering innovation.

Moreover, the work of Aaltonen and Seiler (2016) on crowdsourcing as a form of digital boundary-spanning illustrates the potential of leveraging external knowledge through online communities, further extending the organization's capability to innovate and solve complex problems. These digital dynamics underscore the evolving nature of boundary-spanning behaviors, as organizations increasingly rely on technology to navigate the complexities of the modern business ecosystem (Leonardi & Treem, 2012; Aaltonen & Seiler, 2016).

Boundary-spanning is increasingly recognized not just for its role in information exchange but also as a vital driver of innovation, reputation management, and stakeholder engagement. Organizations are now strategically leveraging boundary-spanning to gain competitive advantages, such as tapping into external collaborations for new ideas or proactively managing their reputation in anticipation of market shifts (Ancona & Caldwell, 1992; Gnyawali & Madhavan, 2001). This expanded view acknowledges the strategic importance of boundary-spanning in navigating the complexities of modern business ecosystems.

The ability of an organization to anticipate, respond to, and recover from disruptions is increasingly linked to effective boundary-spanning behaviors. Research suggests that adaptive and flexible organizational structures, supported by proactive boundary-spanning, can significantly enhance an organization's resilience in the face of uncertainty (Levina & Vaast, 2005). This perspective positions boundary-spanning as a critical capability for organizations aiming to thrive in volatile environments.

Cross-Disciplinary Perspectives and Research Diversification

Understanding boundary-spanning behaviors requires, as explained before, cross-disciplinary lenses, incorporating insights from management and organizational theory, communication studies, and public relations. This approach recognizes that boundary-spanning is not a one-dimensional construct but is influenced by a myriad of factors, including organizational culture, the personality traits of individuals, and broader socio-economic factors (Williams & O'Reilly, 1998; Levina & Vaast, 2005). For example, an organization's culture of openness and collaboration can significantly enhance boundary-spanning activities by fostering an environment where employees feel empowered to share and innovate.

The study of boundary-spanning has benefitted from a diversification of research methods, ranging from in-depth case studies and

ethnographies to comprehensive quantitative analyses. This methodological pluralism has enriched our understanding by providing deep insights into the varied ways in which boundary-spanning manifests across different industries and organizational contexts (Cross & Cummings, 2004; Tsai, 2001). Employing diverse research methods allows for a more nuanced exploration of boundary-spanning activities, capturing the complexity and multifaceted nature of these behaviors.

Since its development, research regarding boundary-spanning grounded in communication and public relations has taken different approaches, expanding the application of the term further beyond. Among the current trends, boundary-spanning has been explored from the health communication perspective, in studies that combine science and communication, and in work that merges public relations, social media, and journalism (Hoffmann-Longtin et al., 2022; Wallace et al., 2021). Some other interesting work includes Han and Yang's (2017) research, which studied boundary-spanners in the context of public diplomacy in connection with public relations, focusing on the functional convergence of diplomats and public relations scholars.

Boundary-Spanner Behaviors

Traditional Boundary-Spanner Behaviors

Traditional boundary-spanner behaviors traditionally referred to roles explicitly designated for interacting with both internal and external stakeholders. However, as organizational structures and communication needs have evolved, there has been a shift toward recognizing the importance of non-designated boundary-spanners. Employees now also perform boundary-spanning roles that involve building relationships and disseminating information both within and outside the organization. This shift has occurred because modern organizations require more dynamic and flexible communication channels to adapt to rapidly changing environments. Boundary spanning behavior can be seen as a catalyst, bridging internal constituents and creating connections between the organization and external stakeholders.

In the case of internal constituents, it is worth highlighting the behavior known as task coordinator activities. Employees concentrate on managing interdependencies within organizational fragments, ensuring the judicious sharing of resources, and adeptly resolving any brewing conflicts (Ancona & Caldwell, 1992). Employees proficient in these

tasks play an instrumental role in bridging communication chasms between departments or teams, consequently quelling uncertainties related to internal workflows, project timelines, and the strategic allocation of resources (Marrone, 2010). Such efforts invariably culminate in bolstered organizational efficiency, enhanced decision-making, fortified collaboration, and an amplified overall performance (Levina & Vaast, 2005; Marrone, 2010; Williams & O'Reilly, 1998).

Ambassadorial activities are a good example for employee behaviors that depict the connection with external publics. These imply that employees represent the organization to external entities, fostering relationships with pivotal stakeholders, and spearheading negotiations (Ancona & Caldwell, 1992). By cultivating robust external liaisons, employees can tap into a treasure trove of resources and information, mitigating uncertainties tied to market dynamics, industrial shifts, and the maneuvers of competitors (Gnyawali & Madhavan, 2001).

Employees' Boundary-Spanner Behaviors

While traditional views of boundary-spanning focused on organizational roles, there's a growing recognition of the power of individual agency. Employees, in their daily interactions, often voluntarily cross organizational boundaries to share knowledge, foster innovation, and contribute to organizational learning. This microboundary-spanning behavior highlights the significant impact that individual actions can have on an organization's ability to navigate complex environments (Kim & Rhee, 2011). Employees who take initiative, leveraging their personal networks and understanding of cross-departmental dynamics, become invaluable assets in bridging gaps and ensuring a seamless flow of information both internally and externally.

Microboundary-spanning is an intricate aspect of how organizations operate, focusing on the pivotal role individuals play in connecting different parts of an organization and beyond. This concept emphasizes the power and impact of employees' actions in enhancing organizational capabilities, such as innovation, adaptability, and overall performance, through their unique positions, networks, and abilities.

Kim and Rhee (2011) introduced the term microboundary-spanners to refer to non-designated boundary-spanners who engage in communication behaviors voluntarily, both obtaining and disseminating information from and to internal and external constituencies. Because employees' microboundary-spanning is not a designated role, it is a

relational component that makes employees voluntarily engage in such activities (Kim & Rhee, 2011). As indicated in Kim and Rhee (2011), there are two kinds of boundary-spanners: formally designated and practice spanners. Formally designated boundary-spanners are agents assigned to perform such roles, whereas practice boundary-spanners engage in spanning the boundaries in diverse fields without being assigned such role (Kim & Rhee, 2011). In the case of employees, they become practice boundary-spanners, as they engage in spanning with no official assignment of the role (Levina & Vaast, 2005).

Several research pieces regarding organizational communication have indicated that the tool to bridge publics and originate relationships between organizations and publics is two-way communication (Andreu Perez et al., 2022; Briones et al., 2011; Kim & Rhee, 2011; Springston & Leichty, 1994), which provides and makes the information flow between intra-organizational and out-of-the-organization constituents (Springston & Leichty, 1994). This type of communication strategy can be initiated by organizations to increase the quality of the relationship with employees (Andreu Perez et al., 2022; Kim & Rhee, 2011), and because of the higher quality of the relationship, being more prone to engaging into microboundary-spanning (Kim & Rhee, 2011).

The type of relationship (Grant & Mayer, 2009; Lee, 2017) is determinant to produce employee behaviors, although other factors (like existence of previous crisis in the organization, employees' self-monitoring, etc.) intermingled with the relational component could also have an effect on employees' behavior (Bolino, 1999; Kim, 2018). Research has shown that personal characteristics, like self-belief in one's abilities (self-efficacy), the alignment with one's professional role (role identity), and the extent and diversity of one's personal connections (personal networks), significantly affect how likely someone is to engage in microboundary-spanning activities (Bandura, 1997; Levina & Vaast, 2005). For instance, an employee who is confident in their capabilities is more inclined to go beyond their job description, seeking and sharing valuable information that could benefit their organization. Similarly, someone who sees their role as integral to their identity might be more proactive in activities that extend their influence, effectively crossing organizational boundaries to create new opportunities for collaboration and knowledge exchange.

The strength and diversity of an individual's network—often referred to as social capital—play a crucial role in facilitating microboundary-spanning (Levina & Vaast, 2005). Being part of varied networks allows

employees to access a broader range of information and resources. They can leverage these networks to link different organizational areas or connect the organization with external entities. This aspect underscores the significance of informal networks in driving innovation and learning within organizations, surpassing the limitations of formal structures.

Boundary-Spanners Communicative Behaviors

While boundary-spanner behaviors can be classified based on the internality or externality of the publics employees bridge, there are more distinct behaviors explained in the organizational communication and public relations work regarding employee behaviors. In the fields of public relations, Kim and Rhee (2011) researched how employee communicative behaviors can affect public relations outcomes, and introduced the concept of megaphoning, which includes both "positive and negative external communicative behaviors" (p. 246) of employees about their organizations. Employees could voluntarily forward and share information about their organization's accomplishments and problems.

The megaphoning concept may initially look similar to word-of-mouth (WOM), but there are two main differences: first, the type of public disseminating the information, and second, the unit of analysis for each concept. WOM is a concept used in marketing, an area that focuses solely on consumers'. The main differences between WOM and megaphoning are that megaphoning is not limited to consumer behavior, nor is it limited to positive and negative experience with products, as it also includes communicative actions toward the organization itself (Chon, 2019).

Similar to what happens with extra-role behaviors, which are composed of different constructs, in public relations, megaphoning employee communication behavior (ECB) contains constructs such as megaphoning (Lee, Mazzei & Kim, 2018), advocative, and adversarial communicative behaviors on the employees' side (Kim & Rhee, 2011). The relationship that employees have with their organizations predicts megaphoning effects: if the relationship is positive, employees are more likely to engage in positive megaphoning, and if the relationship is negative, employees are more likely to engage in negative megaphoning (Kim & Rhee, 2011).

Scouting is another ECB, which interlinks with megaphoning because of the proactivity of employees and their volition to look for information

and forward information to other publics, but scouting implies a more internal end of the communication. While megaphoning focuses on the forwarding and sharing of information to external publics, scouting focuses on the forwarding and sharing of the information with internal publics, although the information comes from the outside of the organization (Kim & Rhee, 2011). The term scouting comes, in fact, from the environmental scanning literature. Scout activities revolve around vigilantly monitoring external trends, pinpointing potential prospects or threats, and astutely gathering competitive intelligence (Ancona & Caldwell, 1992). Engaging in these activities equips organizations with external insights vital for informed decision-making and strategy sculpting (Tushman & Scanlan, 1981). By weaving these external cues into the very fabric of organizational strategies and decision-making frameworks, enterprises can truncate uncertainty, leading to more calculated and efficacious choices (Cross et al., 2001). Scouting is particularly relevant to boundary spanning, as it involves connecting the organization with external environments and integrating external information into internal processes. The importance of scouting has been further amplified by the advancement of digital media technologies, which have made it easier for employees to gather and disseminate information quickly and efficiently.

Boundary-Spanners Behaviors Implications

Communication Behavior Implications

Like this, there are several flagship behaviors of boundary-spanner, which are reflective of their function as bridge-builders among publics, as well as their role as disseminators of information. In most of the literature, boundary-spanner behaviors are taken into account as outcomes or consequences of relational factors (Kim & Rhee, 2011; Tam et al., 2018), individual factors such as skepticism and cynicism (Chon & Kim, 2021), situational factors (Chon & Kim, 2021; Chon et al., 2021), or organization level factors, including conflict history (Chon et al., 2021) and perceived organizational injustice (Lee, 2022).

Yet, there are implications that can be drawn from these behaviors that go beyond the description of the behavior per se. Boundary-spanner behaviors can lead to both positive and negative consequences. In the case of communicative behaviors, on a positive light, when employees engage in positive megaphoning and scouting, the organization can

extremely benefit from it, achieving a greater dissemination of positive information to external publics (Kim & Rhee, 2011; Peng & Sutanto, 2012), and integrating information brought by boundary-spanner in organizational decision-making (Cross et al., 2001; Gnyawali & Madhavan, 2001). Conversely, negative communicative behaviors can include megaphoning (Kim & Rhee, 2011), which could involve the dissemination of harmful information about the organization, potentially causing backlash, stirring up turmoil, damaging the organization's reputation, increasing customer turnover, and ultimately affecting relationships with other organizational publics. Negative consequences could include heightened employee turnover intentions (Chon et al., 2021).

An organization is not able to manage the individual characteristics of its employees—such as their levels of skepticism, self-efficacy, or other personal characteristics—that could impact employees' behaviors as boundary-spanners (Bandura, 1997; Chon & Kim, 2021). However, the organization is in power of choosing a communication style, and is able to build a relationship with employees; relational factors being crucial in determining employee boundary-spanner behaviors (Kim & Rhee, 2011; Tam et al., 2018; Song & Tao, 2022). Employees with stronger relational ties, which show more trust to their organization, will be more prone to engaging in positive behaviors, following the logic laid out in Chon (2019). The building of exchange and communal relationships was another indicator of positive megaphoning (Song & Tao, 2022).

By investing in symmetrical communication, listening, and being able to adapt organizational goals to the needs of their employees, a stronger relationship can be built. Because of this relationship, employees will be prone to carrying out the positive behaviors characteristic of boundary-spanning, helping the organization to achieve positive outcomes. The maintenance of relationships and the retention of employee boundary-spanners have been linked to the avoidance of customer turnover, as the connections between boundary-spanners and external publics yield positive outcomes, including organizational benefits (Lovett et al., 1997).

In addition, technological advancements and shifts in societal dynamics have increased the importance of boundary-spanning behaviors, making the development of relationships with employees even more vital. Notably, the integration of artificial intelligence, the adoption of remote work during and post-pandemic, and the increasing trend toward gig economy have provided crucial impetuses for employee boundary-spanning behaviors. These dynamics have added layers of

complexity and ambiguity within organizations, highlighting the need for fluid communication and collaboration across boundaries (Altman & Tushman, 2017).

For this, positive boundary-spanning behaviors are not merely beneficial but imperative for surging organizational performance. They pave the way for communication, collaboration, and information dissemination across internal and external boundaries. Existing literature is rife with examples that underscore the role of boundary-spanning in championing organizational learning and innovation (Levina & Vaast, 2005). By stimulating the cross-pollination of ideas and fostering collaboration amongst diverse teams, boundary-spanning behaviors catalyze the genesis, dissemination, and assimilation of novel organizational knowledge (Cross & Cummings, 2004), ultimately fueling innovation and elevating organizational performance (Tsai, 2001).

Employee Behaviors' Impact on Organizational Learning and Performance

The actions taken by individuals in microboundary-spanning are vital for fostering organizational learning and promoting innovation (Cross & Cummings, 2004; Tsai, 2001). Through these activities, employees act as bridges, enabling the flow of ideas and resources across organizational boundaries. This grassroots approach to innovation complements top-down strategies and significantly boosts an organization's ability to adapt and respond to external pressures and changes.

Studies have found a positive link between microboundary-spanning behaviors and the performance of an organization (Tsai, 2001). When employees engage in these behaviors, they help create more cohesive and collaborative environments across different organizational segments and with external stakeholders. This collaborative effort ensures a more efficient use of knowledge, prevents the creation of information silos, and positions the organization to capitalize on market opportunities more effectively.

While the advantages of microboundary-spanning are evident, organizations face challenges in nurturing and supporting these behaviors. There is a delicate balance to be struck in giving employees the freedom to engage in microboundary-spanning while aligning their activities with the organization's goals and strategies (Levina & Vaast, 2005). Recognizing and rewarding these often-voluntary efforts is essential for cultivating a culture that values and promotes

microboundary-spanning, thereby enabling organizations to fully harness the potential of their employees in contributing to success and innovation.

Microboundary-spanning presents a crucial perspective on the dynamics of organizational behavior, emphasizing the significant role individual employees play in bridging gaps within and outside their organizations. By understanding and fostering these behaviors, organizations can unlock new opportunities for growth, learning, and performance in an increasingly complex and interconnected business landscape. This detailed exploration aims to provide readers with a clearer understanding of microboundary-spanning and its importance in contemporary organizational success.

To further underscore the critical nature of microboundary-spanning in organizational ecosystems, it's imperative to consider the mechanisms through which these behaviors enhance organizational agility and competitive positioning. Cross and Cummings (2004) delineate the importance of network structures within organizations, where microboundary-spanning behaviors catalyze the formation of dynamic linkages that are essential for rapid information flow and adaptive learning. Similarly, Tsai (2001) elucidates on the concept of social capital within organizations, positing that the relationships and networks fostered through microboundary-spanning activities are instrumental in accessing diverse resources and knowledge bases. These interconnections are crucial for innovation as they facilitate the synthesis of disparate ideas into novel solutions, thereby enhancing the organization's problem-solving capabilities and its ability to innovate proactively. Furthermore, the process of engaging in microboundary-spanning can itself be seen as a form of experiential learning, where employees, by navigating through and connecting different organizational realms, acquire valuable insights and understanding that contribute to their personal and professional growth (Levina & Vaast, 2005). This personal development aspect underscores the bidirectional benefit of microboundary-spanning, enriching both the individual and the organization at large.

Implications and Future Endeavors

The globalization of markets and the rapid advancement of technologies have accentuated the need for effective boundary-spanning behaviors within organizations. As businesses operate in an increasingly global

context, the ability to navigate cross-cultural differences and leverage global networks becomes paramount (Stahl et al., 2010; Reiche et al., 2016).

This global perspective necessitates a deeper understanding of how boundary-spanning practices can facilitate international collaboration and innovation. Additionally, the digital transformation of workplaces introduces new platforms and tools for boundary-spanning, enabling more dynamic interactions across geographical and organizational boundaries (Orlikowski, 2002; Yoo et al., 2012). These developments suggest that the future of boundary-spanning will increasingly rely on the ability to integrate technological capabilities with cross-cultural competencies, underscoring the importance of a holistic approach to studying and implementing boundary-spanning strategies (Stahl et al., 2010; Yoo et al., 2012).

As boundary-spanning seems to be an only increasing behavior, it makes sense that its theoretical study will likely increase. Cross-disciplinary research and application is prevalent today, with the inclusion of boundary-spanning in communication (Briones et al., 2011), public relations (Powell & Pieczka, 2016), management, organizational theory, media (Wallace et al., 2021), political communication (Kim & Krishna, 2018), public diplomacy (Tam et al., 2018), and even health industries (Hoffmann-Longtin et al., 2022). It would not be surprising to see how employees from different fields take action and engage in boundary-spanning activities, this providing a promising ground from research, although explored from different field perspectives. Furthermore, the evolution of technologies also fosters room for new research, as the use of technologies can reinforce employees' boundary-spanning behaviors, change the channels from which they engage in communicative behaviors, and even increase the impact of their boundary-spanning activities.

Professional-wise is clear that, no matter the field or organization employees belong to, boundary-spanning withholds great impact for the organization they belong to. With an impact only expected to increase, it is essential for organizations to communicate with employees, as relationship quality (Hon & Grunig, 1999) and two-way communication are pivotal to achieve the positive outcomes of boundary-spanning, and avoid backlash and negative effects (Andreu Perez et al., 2022; Briones et al., 2011).

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5

EMPLOYEE SOCIAL MEDIA LITERACY TO PROMOTE EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION BEHAVIORS FOR SENSEMAKING AND SENSEGIVING COUNTERING CRISIS MISINFORMATION

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As an unexpected event, an organizational crisis involves high levels of ambiguity, uncertainty, and surprise for every organizational member (Ulmer et al., 2015). In particular, employees confronted with a surprising or uncertain situation actively seek out and share crisis-related information to answer the questions: "how does something come to be an event for organizational members?" and "what does an event mean?"—that is, during a crisis they engage in *a sensemaking process* (Weick et al., 2005, p. 410). Previous research on internal crisis communication has conceptualized *employee communication behaviors for sensemaking* (CBSM) *and sensegiving* (CBSG) as a process of creating and transmitting meaning and has demonstrated the importance of employees' communication behaviors (ECBs) around seeking and sharing valuable crisis-related information to their organizations (Kim, 2018, 2020). The sensemaking and sensegiving process seen in ECBs during a crisis can be crucial for organizations, because it has both positive (e.g., organizational resilience and decision-making process) and negative (e.g., reputational damage) impacts on effective crisis communication (Heide & Simonsson, 2014; Kim & Lim, 2020).

At the same time, misinformation in a crisis—especially in the social media context—hinders the effectiveness of organizations' communication strategies for the publics during the crisis (Jin et al., 2020). Moreover, empirical evidence on how an organization can effectively fight crisis misinformation in terms of their internal crisis communication is sorely needed (Kim & Lim, 2023). Recently, researchers have suggested improving publics' media literacy as a potential solution to combat misinformation on social media (Tully et al., 2020). However, it is yet to be determined how employees' social media literacy (SML) can be leveraged to prevent the spread of crisis-related misinformation and to promote valuable information through their voluntary CBSM and CBSG.

Therefore, this chapter suggests the potential applications of the concepts to the context of misinformation, thereby offering theoretical and practical insights into effective internal crisis communication combating misinformation. Specifically, this chapter aims to enhance our understanding of how to create and organize successful internal communication initiatives that promote active and voluntary communication behaviors by employees, in order to counter the spread of misleading crisis-related information on social media. Furthermore, the chapter provides directions for future research that brings much-needed empirical evidence on the enhancement of employees' SML as a prescriptive measure against misinformation: this leads to voluntary ECBs that create a shared understanding of crisis-related information and that influence others' sensemaking of such information, thereby mitigating the spread of misinformation on social media.

Concept Explications: Employee CBSM and CBSG

Sensemaking refers to "a process, prompted by violated expectations, that involves attending to and bracketing cues in the environment, creating intersubjective meaning through cycles of interpretation and action, and thereby enacting a more ordered environment from which further cues can be drawn" (Maitlis & Christianson, 2014, p. 67). In the organizational crisis context, sensemaking can be understood as the process of meaning creation through organizational members' (employees') communication behaviors in a crisis (Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010; Stieglitz et al., 2018). In the crisis, employees who face ambiguity or uncertainty situations seek to clarify what is going on by extracting and interpreting cues from their environment (crisis), using these as the basis for a plausible account that make sense of what has occurred (i.e., development of plausible interpretations), and

through which they continue to enact the environment (Heide & Simonsson, 2021; Sørensen et al., 2022).

In the context of an organizational crisis, sensemaking has been frequently studied as intertwined with ECBs that help to construct meaning of crises, as sensemaking is the interplay between situational interpretation and actions (Kim, 2020; Maitlis & Christianson, 2014). As an unexpected event, a crisis violates employees' expectations and triggers their sensemaking, resulting in employees constructing meaning through direct or subtle behavioral cues (Stieglitz et al., 2018; van Zoonen et al., 2022). Specifically, scholars have emphasized employees' CBSM through enactment concept, meaning "employees generate the environment through actions and through their attempts to makes sense of these actions" (Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010, p. 553). Weick (1988) also underscores that employees' comprehension of a crisis situation is enhanced by action, as "action that is instrumental to understanding the crisis often intensifies the crisis" (p. 305). In the sensemaking process, employees strive to create their own environments, based on plausible interpretations of the crisis, by selectively taking in information through communication behaviors that seek out, attend to, and save information (Heide & Simonsson, 2021; Weick, 1988).

Understanding ECBs for sensemaking is crucial for effective crisis communication, as an inadequate sensemaking process is likely to make crisis situations more difficult (Maitlis & Sonenshein, 2010; Strandberg & Vigsø, 2016; Weick, 1988). Researchers have emphasized sensemaking among employees in a crisis as a socially constructed process in which employees engage in active communication behaviors that interact with their environment (organizational crisis) and with others to create meaning and to enable their purpose-oriented behaviors (Christianson & Barton, 2021). To this end, Kim (2018) proposed *employee CBSM*, defined as "employees' active and voluntary communicative behaviors to create a shared understanding of information by searching for and obtaining valuable and positive organization-related information from internal and external constituencies" (p. 454).

Furthermore, the term sensemaking was originated by scholars who study how meaning is constructed and transmitted (Polanyi, 1967). In the workplace, especially, the employee sensemaking process affects "perceptions of the meaning of work and ultimately responses to those altered meaning" (van Zoonen et al., 2022, p. 320; Wrzesniewski et al., 2003). In a crisis, employee sensemaking processes can be influenced by others' communication behaviors sharing crisis information with relevant personnel and groups, as organizational members at any level of an

organization can engage in attempting to influence other's sensemaking (Heide & Simonsson, 2021; Maitlis & Lawrence, 2007). Thus, employees' need for sensemaking can be met by interacting with other employees through communication behaviors; such interaction creates meaning and understanding based on others' interpretations (Strandberg & Vigsø, 2016).

The interpretive process in which co-workers influence each other through communication is termed "sensegiving"[1] (Gioia & Chittipeddi, 1991; Maitlis & Lawrence, 2007). This process involves the process of attempting to influence the sensemaking and meaning construction of others, resulting in them toward a preferred redefinition of organizational reality (Adamu et al., 2023; Wyant & Kramer, 2022). In this regard, Kim (2018) conceptualized *employee CBSG*, which involves "employees' active and voluntary communicative behaviors to influence others' sense by forwarding valuable and positive organization-related information to internal and external constituencies" (p. 455).

Researchers have emphasized the importance of CBSM and CBSG to effective crisis communication, because employees can exacerbate or attenuate the impact of a crisis through their communication behaviors (Kim & Rhee, 2011; Lee, 2020). Employees who encounter inaccurate and untimely information about a crisis tend to misinterpret or reject the organization's communication (Heide & Simonsson, 2014). Such employees can become organizational adversaries through their ECBs, generating and spreading negative information or rumors as well as engaging in collective actions with other employees against their company during a crisis (Lee, 2021). In contrast, employees can function as organizational ambassadors in a crisis by actively and positively disseminating their perceptions and understandings with colleagues and customers (Kim & Rhee, 2011). In addition, employees who engage in voluntary communication behaviors for seeking and sharing valuable crisis information (i.e., sensemaking and sensegiving) are likely to enhance organizational resilience through their willingness to learn and adaptation ability (Adamu et al., 2023) as well as increase their work-role performance after a crisis (Kim, 2020).

Other researchers have identified antecedents, including strategic internal communication (Kim, 2018), internal reputation (Kim & Lim, 2020), situational perception (Lee, 2019), and quality of employee–organization relationships (Kim & Rhee, 2011), that determine how employees act for their organization positively or negatively through their communication behaviors in a crisis. Recently, Wyant and Kramer (2022) applied sensemaking process to how local employees acquire information and then interpret the roles and responsibilities of their organizational

members, particularly corporate expatriates. Furthermore, they demonstrated the important role of sensegiving in facilitating the sensemaking process that potential prevent negative consequences during uncertain or ambiguous situations (e.g., organizational changes). Nevertheless, research on how CBSM and CBSG can be facilitated in the context of crisis misinformation is lacking, despite a growing concern about the spread of misinformation in a crisis (Kim & Lim, 2023; Sirlin et al., 2021).

Application of CBSG and CBSM to the Context of Crisis Misinformation

Employee Social Media Literacy for CBSG and CBSM to Counter Crisis Misinformation

Misinformation, as harmful or inaccurate information, is a wide-ranging concern in a crisis as it involves detrimental impacts on crisis communication outcomes such as reputational damage, relationships destruction, and undesired behaviors (Barua et al., 2020; Lewandowsky et al., 2012). *Crisis misinformation* is defined as "false information about a crisis, initially assumed to be valid but can be later corrected or retracted, that can lead to factual misperception held by people" (van der Meer & Jin, 2020, p. 561). Crisis misinformation can be widely spread by employees who have misperceptions of the crisis, establishing the incorrect information about the organization in other employees' minds as well as damaging organization–employee relationships (Coombs et al., 2021). The impact of misinformation can be intensified in the social media context, which entails more reputational threats than other media and which facilitates the sharing of misinformation without checks on accuracy (Singh & Banga, 2022).

In fact, social media have been found to play an important role in the dissemination of misinformation because social media facilitate sharing misinformation without being check for accuracy (Singh & Banga, 2022). Despite social media platforms' functional efforts to filter misleading contents (e.g., algorithms and flags), the removal of the misinformation is challenging, due to its nuanced and variable nature in terms of contexts, demographics, and cultures (Ali & Qazi, 2023; Wei et al., 2023). Against this backdrop, scholars have increasingly demonstrated the importance of communication professionals' media literacy efforts as an effective remedy that provides social media users with the knowledge and skills to counter misinformation in the new media environments (Lewandowsky et al., 2017;

Tully et al., 2020). Such efforts are considered to be an internal motivator that can "buffer and mitigate the effects of misinformation" (Su et al., 2022, p. 1365). The assumption underpinning this approach is that individuals with higher levels of media literacy are more likely to consume content critically and skeptically, resulting in a greater ability to discern misinformation, thereby mitigating its spread (Xiao et al., 2021). Media literacy is "a process or set of skills based on critical thinking", promoting critical engagement with media contents (Bulger & Davison, 2018, p. 3). In this regard, SML refers to "not only the practical and cognitive competencies possessed by users of social media but also the motivation to employ these media effectively and appropriately for social interaction and communication on the web" (Vanwynsberghe et al., 2015, p. 284).

Researchers have consistently recommended implementing media literacy programs to help media users gain the necessary skills for combating misinformation online by promoting critical content consumption and decision-making, which leads to positive behaviors online (Tully et al., 2020; Xiao et al., 2021). Sirlin et al. (2021) found that social media users who cannot competently navigate digital spaces (i.e., who lack SML) are likely to share misinformation online. Sundar et al. (2021) suggested an expansion of literacy programs to not only increase social media users' awareness of misinformation but also help them gain the skills needed to evaluate content and detect misinformation. Ali and Qazi (2023) demonstrated that educational interventions for populations with low digital literacy significantly improved their ability to identify misinformation on social media.

However, there is a lack of empirical evidence on how employees' SML can be leveraged to prevent the spread of crisis-related misinformation and promote accurate information through their voluntary CBSM and CBSG.

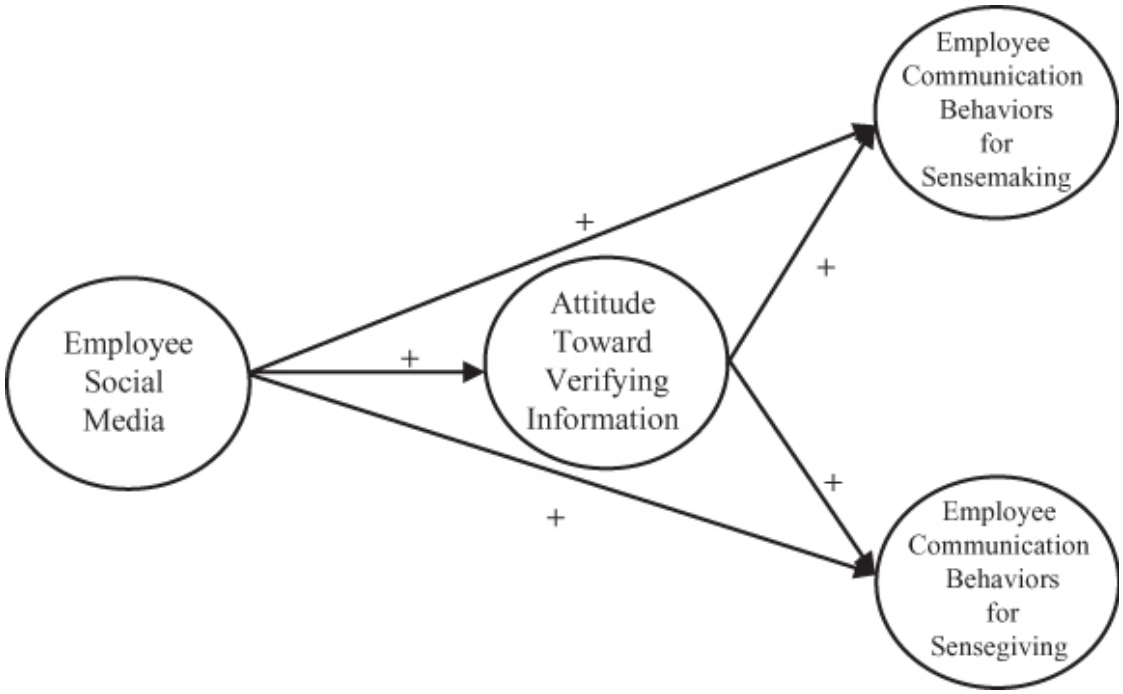
Some researchers have indicated how SML can be linked with ECBs to avoid the spread of misinformation. Stieglitz et al. (2018) revealed that uncertainty communicated via social media during crisis situations is very important to understanding the dynamics of collective sensemaking, and Perez et al. (2022) demonstrated that employees can perform voluntary gatekeeping behaviors that control the flow of misinformation related to their organization.

Mediating Role of Attitude toward Verifying Information

Previous research on misinformation has demonstrated that attitude—an individual's evaluation of the behavior being considered—is essential to predicting the performance of literacy behaviors, such as identifying misinformation or verifying sources (Vraga et al., 2020). Zerback et al.

(2021) also argued that attitude certainty meaning the extent to which one is confident in it influences their behavioral impact in the context of online misinformation. More specifically, Khan and Idris (2019) found that skeptical attitudes toward misinformation can reduce susceptibility to misinformation and, in turn, prevent its spread. Lu et al. (2022) suggested that individuals' attitudes toward information vetting (a judgmental process on the accuracy of information) can influence their enactment of information-sharing. Previous research has also found that such attitudes can be influenced by literacy interventions, as the news literacy helps media users critically and skeptically detect misinformation online (Tully et al., 2020; Vraga & Tully, 2016). Su et al. (2022) also concurred that social media users with high level of media literacy are less likely to believe misinformation related to a crisis than those who have low level of media literacy.

Xiao et al. (2021) indicated a mediating role of attitude between media literacy and behaviors, suggesting that implementing a media literacy program can be beneficial in decreasing misperceptions and in increasing critical behaviors for acquiring more accurate information. Kim and Lim (2023) also stressed that employees' attitudes toward misinformation (e.g., counterarguing against the misinformation) are important, as they are strongly associated ECBs in the context of internal communication. Therefore, this chapter proposes an application model of employee CBSM and CBSG, aiming to counter crisis misinformation (see Figure 5.1).



▶ Long Description for Figure 5.1

Figure 5.1 A proposed structural model.

Conclusion

This chapter discussed the important application of employee CBSM and CBSG to the context of crisis misinformation. To this end, this chapter suggests a strong impact of employee social media literacy (ESML) on CBSM and CBSG. Employees who have high SML are likely to engage in (pro)active communication behaviors for their organization, seeking out and disseminating valuable positive organization-related information to both internal and external publics when they encounter misinformation related to an organizational crisis. In other words, employees with high SML skills and knowledge are less likely to consume and share misinformation in a crisis, because their high SML encourages them to engage in responsible communication behaviors online in light of the technical, relational, and informational knowledge and skills related to social media that they possess. In line with previous research on misinformation correction, this chapter underscores the importance of media literacy as a potential solution in the fight against the spread of misinformation within the context of internal crisis communication. Furthermore, this chapter articulates how employee's SML functions as an internal motivator that can mitigate the spread of crisis-related misinformation and promote valuable information through their voluntary CBSM and CBSG.

As an additional factor for the application of CBSM and CBSM to the crisis misinformation, this chapter emphasizes the mediating role of attitude toward verifying information (ATVI) for the effect of ESML on CBSM and SBSG. In other words, employees who hold high SML are better able to validate information before sharing it and know that sharing misinformation can endanger their organization (Wei et al., 2023). To this end, employees with high SML are likely to recognize and be critical of crisis misinformation when they encounter it on the social media; this influences how they respond to misinformation, in that they engage in more active sensemaking and sensegiving processes for their organization during a crisis. This result indicates that employees who are social media-literate can be expected to engage in critical and skeptical consumption of media contents, thereby functioning as *a protective shield* that helps employees to navigate through and discern misinformation in a crisis (Su et al., 2022).

Theoretical and Practical Implications

This chapter makes a theoretical contribution to employee sensemaking research by expanding the current literature to crisis misinformation within the context of social media crisis communication. By utilizing social media, employees can easily engage in sensemaking and sensegiving processes

through their networks during a crisis, as they are empowered to be in control of creating and distributing crisis information (Coombs et al., 2021). In addition, crisis communication on social media is increasingly faced with misinformation in various forms, with its negative impacts on misperceptions and detrimental behavioral reactions (Singh & Banga, 2022). To this end, CBSM and CBSG do not always benefit an organization in a crisis, because employees may search for, obtain, and disseminate explanatory cues for the crisis that are based on flawed information, misunderstandings, and less-valid materials (Sørensen et al., 2022). Consequently, this chapter provides directions for future sensemaking research on internal crisis communication, especially on how ECBs can be instrumental to understanding the crisis in light of misinformation among employees and other publics (e.g., consumers) on social media; in this way, this study advances a theoretical framework of sensemaking.

Additionally, this chapter highlights the importance of employees' attitudes toward verifying information as both a direct antecedent to and an effective mediator of SML's effect on employees' sensemaking and sensegiving processes in a crisis. This idea suggests that employees with ATVI strengthened by media literacy can perceive and interpret crisis information. Khan and Idris (2019) argued that an ATVI, or "a healthy sense of skepticism", can be beneficial in dealing with the spread of misinformation, as it contributes to recognizing misinformation and reducing its negative effects (p. 1208). In other words, a healthy sense of skepticism works as the basis for plausible interpretations of crisis misinformation, which helps employees make sense of what has occurred and that encourages them to continue to counter the crisis by searching for and sharing more valuable information for their organization (Sørensen et al., 2022). In this regard, this chapter proposes a theoretical extension of internal crisis communication integrating employee literacy, suggesting that an organization can effectively combat crisis misinformation through employees' CBSM and CBSG, facilitated by employees' SML and their ATVI. Furthermore, this study suggests that internal crisis communication research dealing with crisis misinformation considers employee media literacy, as it can improve employees' discernment in their sensemaking and sensegiving processes, ultimately leading to effective internal crisis communication.

In terms of practical implications, the proposed model can help crisis communication managers promote employees' engagement in sensemaking and sensegiving processes in the face of crisis misinformation. Its practical application enhances our understanding of how to develop effective internal communication to manage crisis misinformation through voluntary ECBs

on social media. This chapter recommends that organizations support employees in engaging in valuable voluntary communication behaviors by improving their SML through an internal communication program, which educates them on various internet and social media–related terms and policies, as well as improves their ability to discern accurate information online. Shen et al. (2019) also proposed that the most effective way to mitigate the harm caused by misinformation online is to invest in educational efforts that improve users' digital media literacy. To this end, this chapter provides valuable insights into how to develop internal crisis communication programs as a prescriptive measure against crisis misinformation, which involves implementing a media-literacy approach to ECBs when faced with crisis misinformation.

Directions for Future Research

Further studies could empirically explore how employee SML can interact with internal communication practices (e.g., leadership and transparent communication) and the effectiveness thereof in various contexts of misinformation. Furthermore, an experimental approach is suggested for future research, to examine how the design and delivery of a communication program for SML matter; for instance, personalized messages with feedback and guidance can be effective in helping social media users learn how to identify misinformation (Ali & Qazi, 2023).

In addition, future research could investigate how CBSM and CBSG differ in terms of the temporal dimensions of crisis stages; previous research has found that collective sense-making primarily takes place during the first stages of social media crisis communication (Stieglitz et al., 2018). Christianson (2019) emphasized that *updating*—"the process of revising provisional sensemaking to incorporate new cues"—is critically important for ongoing sensemaking of an unexpected event (p. 45). In this regard, future research could reveal how crisis communication team can effectively monitor cues, facilitating employees' sense-making changes over time, which involves employees' investigation and interpretation of cues to develop plausible explanations according to the different stage of social media crisis communication.

Note

1. Gioia and Chittipeddi (1991) coined the term "sensegiving" as "process of attempting to influence the sensemaking and meaning

construction of others toward a preferred redefinition of organizational reality" (p. 442).

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6

EMPLOYEE VOICE

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Organizations are inherently hierarchical, which implies that most communication may come from the top of the organization toward the bottom. However, scholars have known for close to a century that upward communication is critical to organizational success. Employee voice is an important type of organizational communication where employees share ideas and feedback about how their organization can be better. Gorden (1988) defined voice as "suggesting improvements, discussing problems in the work setting, seeking outside help, whistleblowing, and some forms of union activity" (p. 284; see also Morrison, 2014; Van Dyne et al., 1995). Van Dyne et al. (1995) classified most voice as extra-role behavior, something beyond employees' required job duties. They defined voice as suggestions for changing standard policies and procedures and noted that conflict was a possible but not necessary part of such suggestions. Morrison (2014) added that voice was expressed by employees upward to supervisors. Others have also argued that voice should be defined to include organizational structures and mechanism that facilitate employee participation in decision-making (Kaufman, 2015; Wilkinson et al., 2014). Research has consistently demonstrated the value of employee voice for organizations, as well as the headwinds employees voice as they try to express their ideas. This chapter examines that scholarship in its historical context before proposing three trends that shape employee voice in contemporary organizations and that require further examination.

Early Roots of Employee Voice

Scientific Management and Human Resources

Early 20th century research in organizations sought to maximize efficiency, as exemplified by the research of Fredrick Taylor (1911). Taylor saw a distinction between the work of employees and managers, such that employees implemented the decisions made by management. Due to this separation where managers did the intellectual tasks of the organization and workers did the labor of the organization, Taylor believed that downward communication was sufficient to communicate decisions and that any other communication was superfluous. Thus, Taylor and his contemporaries saw what we call employee voice as inefficient since scholars and practitioners alike did not see employees as having anything useful to contribute. Rather, employee voice was a distraction, keeping workers from completing their tasks as quickly as possible.

That view began to change in the middle part of the 20th century with the development of what is now called the human resources perspective. Rensis Likert (1961) contrasted an exploitative-authoritative approach to management with an employee-centered approach that focused on supportive relationships between supervisors and subordinates. In contrast to Taylor and earlier theorists, Likert found that, when employees participated in organizational goal-setting and decision-making, those employees took responsibility for the overall health of the organization. Based on that research, Likert argued that employee voice in decision-making was critical. Contemporarily, Blake and Mouton (1964) proposed a model of leadership that emphasized seeing managers and employees as a team rather than in the strictly hierarchical ways that had been popular prior to that time. Like Likert, Blake and Mouton saw employees as talented and motivated to participate in decision-making and emphasized the role of employee voice in effective organizational practices.

Exit-Voice-Loyalty

Perhaps the most influential treatment of voice emerging from the human resources movement was Hirschman's (1970) exit-voice-loyalty model. Hirschman assumed that organizational members would find ways in which their organizations could improve. Hirschman's original model focused on customers' responses to dissatisfaction, but others extended the model to focus on employees who were frustrated with the status quo in their organizations (e.g., Boroff & Lewin, 1997; Freeman & Medoff,

1984). These employees faced a choice—to leave the organization for other opportunities or to voice their ideas on how the organization could do better. Importantly, Hirschman argued that the hinge of that choice was employees' organizational loyalty. Loyal employees would stay and improve the organization through voice while disloyal employees would leave as the organization continued in suboptimal conditions. This conceptualization positioned employee voice as something organizations should desire rather than an inefficient distraction.

A number of researchers have tested and extended this model to better understand employee voice. For example, Farrell (1983) suggested a fourth dimension labeled neglect be added alongside exit, voice, and loyalty. Farrell's neglect dimension captured situations where an employee chose to suffer in silence when faced with a frustrating circumstance, waiting for others to address the problem. Farrell also reconceptualized loyalty. Rather than seeing loyalty as an antecedent characteristic of an employee that could determine whether the employee voiced frustrations or left the organization, Farrell used loyalty to label optimistically waiting for the organization to fix the problem itself. Thus, in contrast to neglect where the employee saw the situation cynically but did not voice frustrations or leave the organization, loyalty described employees who patiently waited on the organization to improve the situation with a positive attitude. Hagedoorn et al. (1999) further extended Hirschman's model to include both considerate voice and aggressive voice. In their extension, considerate voice focuses on pro-social motives and outcomes aligned with organizational goals, and aggressive voice is associated with anti-social motives and outcomes at odds with organizational goals. Hagedoorn et al. found that job satisfaction increased the likelihood of considerate voice while decreasing the likelihood of aggressive voice. Similarly, Zhou and George (2001) found that dissatisfied workers who were committed to the organization did in fact voice their dissatisfaction so long as they felt supported by coworkers or the organization more broadly. Employees' sense of personal control or overall satisfaction apart from a specific dissatisfying event may moderate this relationship (Tangirala & Ramanujam, 2012; Withey & Cooper, 1989). Lee and Varon (2020) found that the relationship between the employee and supervisor may play an important role in the voice decision. Employees with high quality relationships with their supervisors were more likely to stay in the organization, while those with lower quality relationships were more likely to exit or neglect their jobs. Interestingly, Lee and Varon found no

relationship between relationship with supervisor and voice behaviors. They suggested that this could be due to the complexity of employee voice and the likelihood of multiple people to whom an employee could voice dissatisfaction.

Hirschman's (1970) work and the subsequent follow-up studies were important as they codified an association between voice and "good" employees. Rather than seeing voice as something that detracted from efficiency, this line of research emphasized that engaged employees would voice frustrations in their organization. That position was a particularly important foundation for subsequent scholarship that explored the ways in which voice functioned to improve organizations and the mechanisms by which organizations could be capitalize on employee voice. The next section of this chapter unpacks that scholarship in further detail.

Approaches to Employees Voice

Voice research following the human resources movement and Hirschman (1970) seems to have developed in three distinctive streams—a behavioral approach that focuses on the types of behaviors employees used to voice ideas, a structural approach that focuses on the mechanisms organizations might use to involve employees in decision-making, and a political approach that highlights the silencing of employees as organizations favor efficiency over participation. Each of those is described below.

Behavioral Approaches to Employee Voice

Given human resources research that emphasized the need for employee voice in healthy organizations, scholars in the 1980s and 1990s began to explore the ways in which voice benefits organizations and employees as well as scope conditions on those benefits. A central component of that research was to identify the nature of employee voice. Scholars wanted to define what counts as voice and when that voice benefits the organization. Gorden (1988) was influential in this movement toward a behavioral view of employee voice, differentiating types of voice along dimensions of active/passive and constructive/destructive. Gorden identified specific dissent strategies such as "principled dissent" and "making suggestions" as active constructive voice, strategies such as "antagonistic exit" and "complaining to coworkers" as active destructive

voice, strategies such as “quiet nonverbal support” and “unobtrusive compliance” as passive constructive voice, and strategies such as “calculative silence” and “psychic withdrawal” as passive destructive voice.

Functionally, employee voice brings a number of benefits for employees and organizations. Organizational receptivity to employee voice increases employee satisfaction (Gorden et al., 1988) and decreases turnover (Spencer, 1986). McFarlin and Sweeney (1996) examined connections between employee voice and satisfaction with decision-making. They distinguished between employees’ influence on decision-making itself and employees’ influence on the decision-making process separate from the actual decision made. One might expect workers to be satisfied when their ideas affected decision-making outcomes, but McFarlin and Sweeney found that workers were also satisfied when they knew organizational decision-makers took their ideas into account. McFarlin and Sweeney concluded that these workers appreciated being heard regardless of whether the decision was in their favor. Cosier et al. (1991) noted that organizational conflict might lead to both better organizational decision-making and decreased satisfaction in organizations. They explained that employee voice might lead to increased conflict in organizations because voice inherently challenges the status quo.

Some research indicated that voicing ideas might be risky for employees in spite of the organizational benefits. Thacker and Wayne (1995) found that employee voice was negatively related to supervisors’ assessments of promotability when that employee expressed feedback using anything other than rational reasoning, and Klaas and DeNisi (1989) argued that dissenters were likely to be sanctioned for their disagreement with the status quo. Others have noted that fear of supervisor reprisal could motivate employees to stay silent rather than voice suggestions (Bisel et al., 2012; Detert & Burris, 2007). However, Van Dyne and LePine (1998) found that employees who voiced feedback with the goal of promoting organizational interests were perceived positively by their supervisors, so the motivation for dissenting may be an important variable influencing effectiveness. Burris et al. (2017) found that, as managers evaluated employee voice, those managers weighed the issue importance, the idea complexity, and the resources required by the employee’s idea in determining their response. Ideas that those managers perceived as more important, simpler, and requiring fewer resources were more likely to be positively received.

Structural Approaches to Employee Voice

The preceding scholarship focused on behaviors that might be called employee voice and the value of such behaviors for organizations. Such research has been criticized for neglecting the institutional context in which voice takes place (Kaufman, 2015). A different stream of research activity looking at voice focuses on the mechanisms through which employees participate in decision-making rather than the specific messages that those employees convey (Wilkinson et al., 2014). Wilkinson et al. (2020) argued that formal mechanisms were necessary for ensuring that employees had the space to challenge the status quo. Voice mechanisms can be direct or indirect (Marchington, 2007). Direct mechanisms allow for individual, often face-to-face expression to supervisors and might include self-managing teams, quality circles, and grievance processes. Indirect mechanisms are typically collective and representative and might include unions. Research in the structural approach has often suggested unions as a more effective voice instrument than direct voice (Freeman & Medoff, 1984), but recent declines in union memberships may decrease employees' perceptions of the effectiveness of unions in representing members' voices (Benson & Brown, 2010).

Structural approaches emphasize the external context of voice at the societal, institutional, and organizational level as much as the behavior of individual employees (Budd et al., 2023). Kaufman (2015) theorized an integrated model, overlaying ideas about the external environment, organizational governance, and various voice systems with behavioral research that examines individual voice behaviors in order to both critique scholarship focused on microlevel expressions of voice (what this chapter labeled behavioral approaches) and show the value in a more integrative approach. Wilkinson et al. (2020) also critiqued what they called silos around behavioral and structural approaches as each perspective rarely used ideas developed in the other perspective. However, few scholars seem to be interested in breaking down those silos to integrate ideas from both of these perspectives.

Political Approaches to Employee Voice

At approximately the same time as research examining behavioral and structural approaches to voice developed, other scholars began critically examining the ways in which organizations marginalize employees' goals and the way in which employee voice might often be silenced in organizations. Political approaches do not typically show up when one

searches for “voice” in most journals, but the lines of research included here are very concerned with the role of employees’ voices in organizations. These researchers typically trace their roots to both Marx and the linguistic turn of the 1980s (Mumby, 2014). Contemporary scholars differ in the degree to which they draw on Marxist ideas, but Marx (1967) was perhaps the first philosopher to challenge how power is embedded in organizations in ways that privilege those at the top of organizations while marginalizing workers. His analyses highlighted how conflict between managers and workers is fundamental to organizing in capitalistic societies. Marx’s ideas gained increased acceptance in communication studies and in organizational communication specifically during the linguistic turn, a series of philosophical expositions that positioned communication as central to organizing and thus central to that fundamental conflict (Mumby, 2014; Putnam & Pacanowsky, 1983).

Voice is at the heart of political approaches. Power is distributed unevenly in organization with those at the top having a greater say in organizational decision-making. The natural state of organizations is to systemically distort communication in such a way as to silence workers’ voices, so political scholarship is concerned with revealing and removing the underlying structures that block workers’ voices (Deetz, 1982). Deetz (1992) noted that organizations use standards of efficiency and rationality as measures of which voices to acknowledge and that such standards privilege managerial voices over others. Because a separate class of organizational members known as managers seems to have all of the relevant knowledge necessary to help the organization succeed, employee voice seems to be an unnecessary and inefficient distraction. Instead, Deetz advocated that workers should be able to participate in organizational governance and voice their ideas without the barriers or closures that often restrict whose ideas are valued in organizations. Cheney (1995) similarly critiqued the current state of employee voice in the face of a variety of trends that put efficiency ahead of participation, asking for whom are workplaces designed. Cheney held up a co-operative organization as a model for employee voice and advocated for democratic practices in organizations that valued both individual goals and organizational goals, where workers could fully participate in decision-making.

Whereas behavioral approaches to employee voice emphasize antecedents and outcomes related to voice behaviors, structural approaches examine the mechanisms by which employees share ideas. Political approaches are much more interested in the systemic barriers

that silence organizational voice. Different metatheoretical assumptions tend to separate political approaches from the other two, and scholars from each approach gravitate toward different journals. Because of these reasons, the research in one rarely references the others. Behavioral and structural approaches to voice generally remain post-positive while political approaches are interpretive and increasingly post-modern/post-structural (e.g., Buzzanell et al., 2015; Trethewey, 1997). Nevertheless, all three approaches remain tied by a focus on the ways in which employees can participate in decision-making.

Organizational Dissent

In the late 1990s and into the 2000s, a related track of research began exploring organizational dissent. While a different chapter examines organizational dissent in more detail, it is important here to understand its roots in employee voice as well as the convergence and divergence in dissent and voice research. Kassing (1997, 2011) used Hirschman's (1970) Exit-Voice-Loyalty dimensions to develop his model of organizational dissent, where employees experience a disconnect with organizational practices or policies and express disagreement with those practices or policies. Whereas Hirschman conceptualized exit and voice as two distinct options for responding to dissatisfaction, Kassing argued that dissent overlapped with both. He explained that dissent was a subset of employee voice in that both stemmed from ideas of participating in organizational decision-making, but organizational dissent also overlapped with exit as employees might use threats of resignation as a dissent strategy. Kassing differentiated dissent from voice more broadly by noting that voice could include employees advocating for new ideas which might not necessarily be dissent if there was not disagreement inherent in those ideas. Nevertheless, much of organizational dissent scholarship draws from the broader research on employee voice.

Contemporary Nuances to Employee Voice

Research on employee voice has grown dramatically since Hirschman (1970) built on human resources ideas to first explore how stakeholders might voice ideas for improving organizations rather than leaving the organization altogether. I have grouped that research under the headings of behavioral, political, and structural approaches as a heuristic device to better understand some of the ways in which scholars have defined and

studied voice. This chapter has only scratched the surface of the scholarship exploring voice. Of course, organizations have changed dramatically since the 1970s and 1980s. More than a quarter of U.S. employees work remotely for part of their job (Walsh, 2023); more than 20% of workers are independent contractors rather than employees, and that number is expected to only increase (Noguchi, 2018). Distinctions between what is work and what is not work have blurred (Fleming, 2014). Given these changes, it is only natural to expect that employee voice has changed and continues to do so. Those changes require additional research. Before closing, I lay out three areas where changing organizational dynamics necessitate research exploring contemporary nuances in organizational voice. Those areas include technology-mediated voice, nontraditional work arrangements, and the increasingly blurry line between work and home life.

Technology-Mediated Voice

One area in which employee voice scholarship has seemed to lag behind contemporary organizations is the role of technology in mediating employee voice. Twenty-first century organizations are reviving Taylor's ideas of efficiency using technology to monitor employees' productivity (e.g., Yeginsu, 2018), but employees can use technology to voice concerns as well. Kim and Leach (2020) contrasted traditional, face-to-face employee voice with mediated voice expressed anonymously through social media. They found that the organization's climate regarding voice influenced employees' voice behavior in person and via social media. In turn, voice positively predicted employees' perceptions that their voice activity led to positive changes in their organizations, as well as their commitment to those organizations. Others have likewise examined voice expressed anonymously through mediated channels and found that anonymity increases employees' perceptions of safety as they share their ideas (Mao & DeAndrea, 2019). However, Knoll et al. (2022) noted that voice has typically been studied from social and psychological perspectives, which may neglect the materiality of mediated voice. In this context, materiality refers to elements of technology that are constant regardless of the social context around the technology (Leonardi, 2012). Knoll et al. also argued that the few studies that have examined technology and voice miss the complexity of technology on communication by reducing their examination to simplistic, direct effects and privileging only materiality. By contrast, Knoll et al. advocated for a

process perspective using a sociomateriality perspective. They start with the affordances of digital technology, the social and material aspects of technologies that enable certain actions and also constrain other actions. Those affordances interact with employees' goals for work arrangements to shape the factors that lead to employees voicing their ideas and to others' responses to those ideas. The pandemic and the subsequent movement toward remote work have amplified the role of technology-mediated voice even more than the decades prior, and further research is needed as many contemporary organizations rely more heavily on mediated communication than ever before.

Nontraditional Organizational Arrangements

Just as voice literature has largely focused on face-to-face contexts, it has also assumed an organizational setting where those expressing voice are employees reporting to a supervisor and working for the same organization. However, the rise of Gig economy jobs, contract work, and other nontraditional work arrangements emphasizes the need to re-examine how voice might look in contexts beyond traditional organizational settings. Oyetunde et al. (2022) reviewed the rare studies that have examined voice in these increasingly common arrangements. They found that nontraditional employees in multi-party employment (e.g., temporary workers) may be silenced by confusion over the party to whom they should voice their ideas. Workers bound to organizations via digital platforms (e.g., rideshare drivers) may be afforded more voice opportunities in that such platforms are increasingly incorporating voice mechanisms into the worker interface. Oyetunde et al. also found that nontraditional workers had little influence in organizational decision-making. Given the remarkable increase in the number and the type of arrangements outside of what is typically conceptualized in organizational research, scholars need to further explore voice in these jobs, unpacking the nuances of voice when organizational membership is fluid. Questions about the voice audience when the worker is not an employee are important as well as questions about the motivation of organizations to solicit feedback from workers who are not employees.

Voice When Work Is Life

Relatedly, it is also important to think about voice in the contemporary environment where the lines between employees' work and home life are blurred. Fleming (2014) noted that, whereas many 20th century

organizations allowed workers to maintain a separation between their work and home life, that separation has increasingly become irrelevant to workers today. Instead, employees' entire life experiences have become commodities that they sell to their employers. The employee's hobbies, social media, and relationships become part of organizational life. However, as extra-work aspects of identity progressively fall under organizational influence, those areas begin to derive their meaning from work (Grey, 1994). Hobbies become side hustles or new skills that can improve job performance. Social media are important for marketing (either the organization or the worker) and enhancing the employee's personal brand. Relationships are contacts that can promote career opportunities. In this environment where employees' identities are increasingly connected to their professions and their workplaces, one has to wonder about the nature and role of employee voice. Perhaps employees are less able to voice ideas that challenge the status quo because there is less of themselves that is unconnected to that status quo. Research is needed to explore the ways in which the blurring lines between work and home life shape employee voice as employees may find less and less of their lives are disconnected from work.

Conclusion

Although early organizational research conceptualized employees as little more than cogs in a machine, scholars now generally recognize the value of employee participation in organizational decision-making. Employees who work on the organization's front lines may see more effective ways of delivering products or services to customers. When employees are frustrated at work, they may leave the organization, but it is often in the organization's best interest if those employees express their frustrations and work toward solving problems in their workplaces. Research on employee voice often falls into one of three approaches. A behavioral approach identifies the behaviors employees use to share their ideas and the ways in which organizations respond to those ideas. A structural approach categorizes the mechanisms through which organizations solicit employee voice. A political approach examines the ways in which organizations are contested sites that often silence employee voice and participation. Finally, this chapter suggested three nuances in contemporary organizations that might challenge existing voice scholarship. First, workplace communication is often mediated, and voice research needs to explore the implications of technology.

Second, organizations are increasingly using nontraditional work arrangements, and disagreement over the definition of "employee" is certainly likely to influence how and whether employees participate in decision-making. Third, the line between work and home life has blurred or even collapsed, and the synthesis of work and home identities may influence the ways in which employees voice their ideas at work.

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7

CREATIVITY AND CREATIVE PROCESSES IN ORGANIZATIONS

A Network Perspective

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Creativity has become an increasingly vital component for an organization's survival and growth. Organizations are embedded in uncertainties stemming from institutional and broader socio-natural environments such as the rise of remote work, extensive uptake of social media, cultural shifts, and public health and environmental crises. Customers' and stakeholders' need changes rapidly, and organizational processes need creative approaches to cater to progressively important values such as sustainability, diversity, and inclusion. Additionally, a creative work environment enables employees to freely express ideas and stimulates stronger engagement and motivation.

This chapter illustrates how network perspectives can provide valuable insights into the processes of creativity embedded in communication among organizational members. We draw from literature on creativity in organizational settings from multiple fields including communication, public relations (PR), management, and psychology. We first discuss the collaborative aspects of creative processes, followed by an overview of network dimensions —tie strength, brokerage, tie content, and multiplexity—that are relevant to the ways in which organizational members engage in communication about new ideas. We then discuss four broad areas in employee and organizational communication that can inform the network processes of creativity: (a) information behaviors and leadership; (b) technology and artificial intelligence (AI); (c) culture and climate; and (d) unconventional organizational forms. We propose a future research agenda across these four areas.

Creativity as a Relational Organizing Process

While the debate regarding the definition of creativity is extensive, scholars have formed a consensus that creativity can be conceptualized as the production of novel and useful ideas (e.g., Amabile, 1983; Oldham & Cummings, 1996). Novelty refers to uncommonness or rarity of the invention, and usefulness involves the invention's appropriateness and its ability to adapt to reality.

As Amabile (1983) summarizes, there are also debates regarding whether creativity should pertain to the person (i.e., creativity as a trait, ability, or personality characteristics), to the product (i.e., creativity as an observable outcome which can be assessed by an observer), or to the process (i.e., creativity as the thought process or problem-solving approaches individuals take). Creativity is often conceptualized and measured as an outcome (e.g., Chen et al., 2020), while some studies empirically examine the process aspect, emphasizing interactions that trigger the generation of creative ideas (Lee & Lee, 2015). Sosa (2011) calls this process creative interaction, and Harrison et al. (2022) use the term creative work to describe the process of ideas being "generated, elaborated, evaluated, stored, discarded, or implemented into a product by individuals or groups" (p. 1). When focusing on these processes of idea generation involving interpersonal interaction, considering the relationships weaving organizational members—the patterns of network structure—can yield valuable insights.

Creativity in Collaborative Settings

Fans of the NBC series, *The Office*, may recall the protagonist's proclivity for dreaming up new ideas to make his work more exciting. In the first seven seasons of the show, Michael Scott oversees the sales and business operations of the Scranton, Pennsylvania branch of Dunder Mifflin—a New York-based firm that sells paper. In the fifth season, Michael dresses up as the Willy Wonka character and announces to his employees that he has concocted an idea to distribute five "golden tickets" (good for a 10% discount for one year) in boxes that have been prepared for shipment to customers. Unwittingly, all five of those boxes are delivered to the same customer, who just so happens to be one of the company's largest clients. Neglecting to specify the promotion is limited to "one per customer", the customer scores a whopping 50% discount for one year, infuriating the firm's Chief Financial Officer who notes the discount will put a dent in the company's finances.

While Michael's idea may not have been all that bad in itself, he would have benefited from seeking input from others as opposed to hatching his scheme in isolation. For instance, if Michael shared his idea with the warehouse team, they likely would have suggested the five tickets be distributed in boxes located in different parts of the warehouse or on different days to help ensure no one customer received multiple golden tickets. If he

shared his ideas with others in his workplace, he may have also been advised to limit the promotion to one per customer. Michael's example illustrates the importance of leveraging one's social network to ensure the success of a creative idea.

Broadly speaking, a social network is defined as the set of relationships an actor, such as an individual or organization, has with others. Contrary to popular conceptions of the "lone creative genius", studies have overwhelmingly discovered that organizational members' interaction, often in team settings, is important for creativity (e.g., Singh & Fleming, 2010). In many contexts, the ability to come up with novel ideas and to make them usable is, in part, influenced by one's ability to leverage their social network. Singh and Fleming (2010) suggest that working as a part of a team or an organization is likely to increase the chance of satisfying both dimensions of creativity: breakthrough inventions and socially judged usefulness. People in collaboration with each other, compared to a lone inventor, will be more likely to produce breakthrough inventions because of the larger potential of radically novel combinations that can be made based on the different sets of perspectives team members hold. The chance of avoiding poor outcomes and failures is simultaneously higher, as the generated ideas go through a more rigorous selection processes in a team setting because of the diversity of experiences present among team members.

As research evolves, there is exploration into contingency factors that add complexity to the widely held belief that collaborative teams outperform individual inventors. Utilizing utility and design patent data, Chan et al. (2021) show that whether teams outperform sole inventors depends on the decomposability of the invention. Inventions that are integral (i.e., not separable into small chunks) rather than modular require coordination costs among members and benefit less from knowledge diversity, favoring lone inventors. Yet, their findings show that even individual inventors benefit from past collaboration experiences, suggesting the long-term advantages of working in teams.

Network Dimensions Influencing Creative Processes

Individual and team creativity is influenced by the network of social relationships as well as resources such as information and support exchanged among members through those relationships. Thus, network theories and methodologies have been frequently adopted for examining how members' interactions in organizations spur creative processes. Several dimensions of both network structure and network content have been given consideration in literature.

Tie Strength

Tie strength is a dimension of network relationships at the dyadic level, conceptualized based on factors such as the time, intensity, and reciprocity associated with dyadic interactions. Contrasting findings exist regarding tie strength and organizational creativity. Sosa (2011) challenges the idea that distant relationships, or weak ties, foster creativity and suggests that considering the substance of exchanges is important. In particular, strong dyadic ties that can act as a conduit of a wide set of knowledge domains positively predicted creative interaction. Mannucci and Yong (2018) suggest that the effect of the depth and breadth of knowledge exchanged between individuals depends on career age. An early-career individual lacks deep and complex knowledge, and thus benefits more from knowledge depth to acquire the building blocks that can lead to recombination possibilities for creativity. In contrast, as individuals' career age increases, they establish rigid knowledge structures and schemas, benefitting more from knowledge breadth that can add flexibility and new linkages among existing combinations.

Network Position

At the broader network level, Burt (2004) argues that structural holes are generally beneficial for creativity. Structural holes refer to the network position of a broker, who connects otherwise unconnected nodes. Since brokers are more likely to receive nonredundant information from bridging ties, they have a larger potential to generate creative ideas. Soda et al. (2019), expanding on these findings, suggest that whether individuals can realize the benefits of their brokerage position depends on the collaborative attitudes of the members in the network. Specifically, brokers were better able to be creative when the level of collaboration in the network was low. The importance of network position applies not only to those generating new ideas but also to those who are supporting their colleagues' inventions, referred to as catalysts of innovation (Tortoriello et al., 2015).

Tie Content

Mannucci and Perry-Smith (2022) found that interacting with weak ties was beneficial for the generation creative ideas. The authors note such contacts provide access to new and diverse sources of information that "foster the recombinatory process that is at the heart of idea generation" (p. 1195). On the other hand, strong ties were better for elaborating and refining those ideas because they were more likely to build upon rather than dismiss or redirect a creator's idea. The authors suggest strong ties often provide developmental feedback that helps further contribute to the potential of early-stage ideas (also see Perry-Smith & Mannucci, 2017).

Baer (2010) found that a larger network size up to an optimal level and weak ties contributed to the production of creative ideas. Yet, these effects

existed only when the ties were diverse in terms of organizational affiliation and when individuals had the personality characteristics of openness to experience.

Multiplexity

Some early research emphasized the benefits of strong personal ties as well as multiplex ties, which tend to involve trust and certainty. For example, Albrecht and Hall (1991) show that both relationship multiplexity (i.e., two or more types of relations existing between nodes) and content multiplexity (i.e., the number of diverse topics discussed between nodes) were associated with communication about new ideas. There is risk associated with new ideas as they often involve departures from existing norms, perspectives, and routines, and they go through assessments from other members (Albrecht & Hall, 1991). Therefore, "face" is an important consideration in communication about new ideas, and strong, multiplex relationships provide the sense of safety to reduce the risk involved in new, possibly face-threatening ideas.

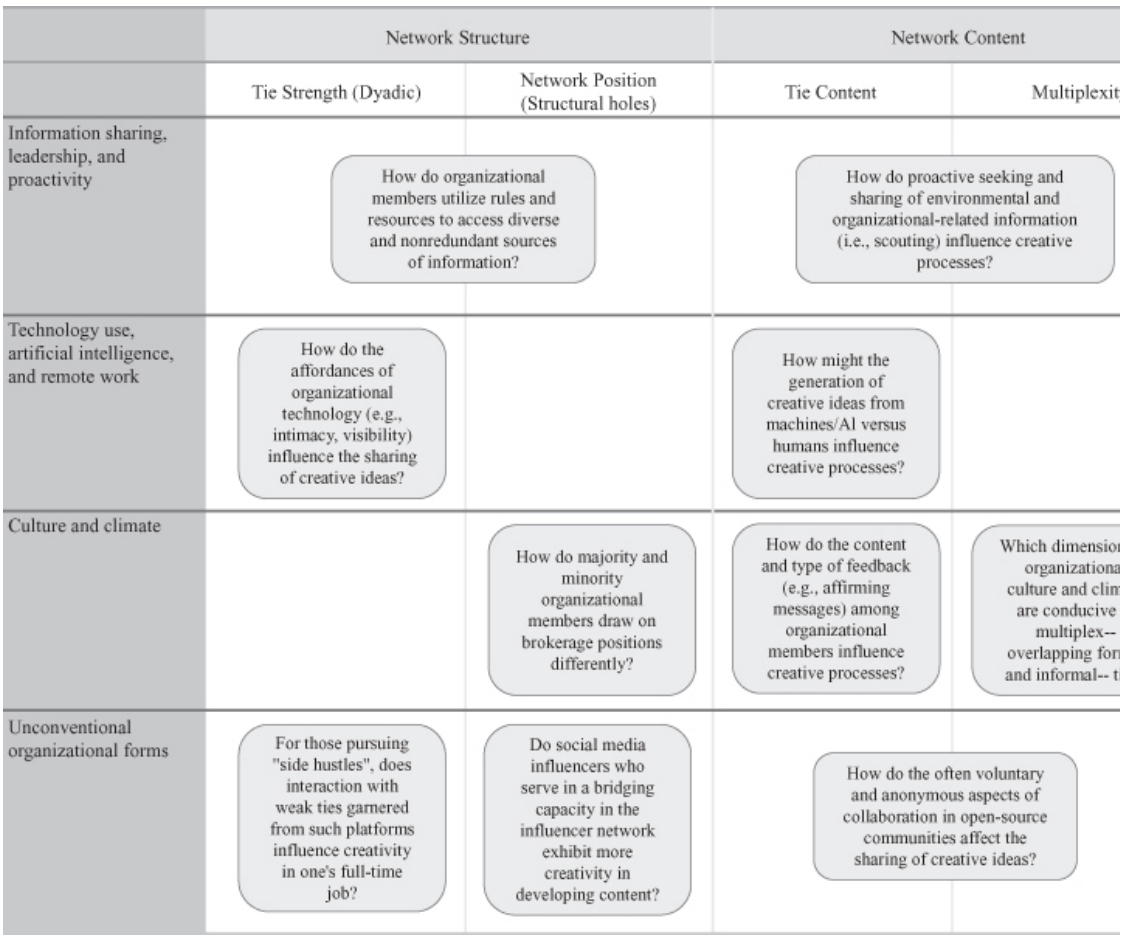
Communicative Approaches to Network Processes of Creativity

Theoretical developments in the field of communication can help highlight the importance of social interaction for creative processes. Structuration theory (ST) can offer a particularly illuminating avenue for examining how both organizational initiatives and employees' interactions mutually influence each other to produce creative processes. ST is based on the idea that social structures are brought about through rules and resources that constrain and enable individual action (Giddens, 1984; McPhee et al., 2014). Rules may be formal policies or social conventions that guide behavior, whereas resources refer to capabilities that can be activated to bring about desired change. While rules and resources work to produce social structures and shape behavior, actors have agency to behave autonomously and in doing so may help bring about change in that social structure. Taking a network approach to ST, Whitbred et al. (2011) note structural rules such as workflow assignments and spatial proximity influence the emergence of communication networks. Additionally, rules that specifically pertain to network structure (i.e., serving in a brokerage capacity) influence the emergence of the communication network. Actors, however, have agency to choose how they go about interacting with others on a daily basis, which may in turn reshape the social structure.

Lee and Lee's (2015) study of an advertising agency helps illustrate how ST can be applied when examining workplace creativity. Examining dyads with focus on multiplexity, the authors explored the relational attributes associated with the sharing of work-related creative ideas between employees. Informal relations, such as friendship, advice, and knowledge-sharing relations, were associated with creative interaction. To the extent creative

interaction between parties affects workflow patterns (e.g., by collaborating to introduce novel ideas into the work process), such informal relations may in turn reshape the mechanisms by which work gets executed and contribute to a reshaping of the organizational social structure.

With ST as an orienting mechanism, we discuss four broad areas in employee and organizational communication that can inform the network processes of creativity. ST prompts the consideration of how formal workflow patterns or managerial actions and organizational members' ties surrounding creative action can mutually influence one another. Together, these properties can contribute to the development of novel and useful solutions to pressing organizational needs. Framing the following sections from a structuration and networks perspective, Figure 7.1 proposes examples of future research topics. The rows represent each of the four domains and the columns represent whether the proposed research question is broadly focused on network structure (e.g., the types of relationships actors have and the positions they occupy in the network) or network content (e.g., the substance of communication that takes place between network actors).



▶ Long Description for Figure 7.1

Figure 7.1 Examples of potential research questions regarding the network dimensions of creative processes from communicative

perspectives.

Information Sharing, Leadership, and Proactivity

Employees who are motivated to be creative are more likely to voluntarily seek internal and external sources of information related to organizational phenomena (i.e., scouting). Thus, scouting as a form of voluntary information behavior becomes relevant (Kim & Rhee, 2011; Lee et al., 2018; Park et al., 2014). In this regard, studies examining organizational members' creativity can be extended by examining how creative interaction is associated with information sharing processes that undergird scouting. Lee et al. (2018) find that an individual's motivation to be creative is associated with having a high-quality relationship with the organization, which in turn contributes to scouting behaviors. Park et al. (2014) suggest daily interactions that occur through scouting often represent a bottom-up process shaped not just by managers, but interactions that occur at all levels of the organization.

Considering the social aspects of creativity, scholars have paid particular attention to the importance of mutual interaction between leaders and members. Various aspects of leadership styles have been examined as predictors of creativity. Hu et al. (2018) show that leader humility, referring to the willingness to acknowledge one's shortcomings and appreciate others' strengths, was positively associated with information exchange within teams and subsequently with team creativity. This relationship existed in teams with low power distance but not in those with high power distance. In other words, humble leaders appeared to encourage information sharing as they are attentive to different viewpoints and willing to welcome diverse ideas, which can contribute to creativity. Chen et al. (2020) show that employees' perception of participative leadership, where leaders engage in decision-making with employees, was predictive of their level of creativity. This relationship was explained based on both cognitive and behavioral processes —if participative leaders build cultures of respect and trust, employees were more likely to perceive psychological safety (Edmondson, 1999). The feeling that they can engage in risky behaviors without facing negative consequences helped them engage in creative processes. In remote work settings, Lee and Kim (2023) find that leaders' support for employees' family and work-home balance was positively associated with employee's perception of positive emotions, and subsequently with creativity.

Based on these findings, managers should recognize that there can be a reciprocal influence between harnessing employees' creative energies and proactive information sharing behaviors. In many cases, this can also be a bottom-up process. Managers can, therefore, consider pairing more direct strategies for increasing the creative motivation of employees with opportunities for employees to informally develop networks to share diverse

sources of information. For instance, managers may schedule cross-functional brainstorming sessions with the additional goal of strengthening social connections, which can serve as future conduits of information exchange and creative interaction.

Technology Use, Artificial Intelligence, and Remote Work

Adaptive structuration theory (AST) is concerned with the ways in which properties of advanced technology and modes of social interaction work together to influence how technological processes contribute to change in an organization's social structure (Desanctis & Poole, 1994; also see McPhee et al., 2014). AST distinguishes between technological features (i.e., the rules and resources embodied in the technology) and spirit (i.e., the general intent for how such features ought to be used). These two elements work to structure work practices, by affecting the ways in which groups collaborate to make decisions, for instance. AST also accounts for the fact that technologies are appropriated as members decide how to coordinate and interpret work tasks. AST can be applied to a wide array of domains. Keeping in mind the context of creativity, Desanctis and Poole (1994) suggest the process of idea generation can be affected by the ways in which the features and spirit of technology are appropriated by members.

AI represents one area where technology can affect creative interaction. Jia et al. (2024) suggest that the use of AI to complete routine tasks can free up cognitive resources for employees to pursue more creative activities at work. In a field experiment of telemarketers, the authors found those who used AI to complete routine tasks were more creative when interacting with potential customers. This effect was more pronounced for higher-skilled workers who were better able to capitalize on the benefits of AI.

Areas for future work include examining how creative processes will be affected by getting new ideas from machines (Amabile, 2020). Already, generative AI is producing creative work that is remarkably similar to human-developed content and there will be continued technological advances. Thus, it is worth considering how the technological properties of AI being adopted and used in organizational settings influence employees' creative interaction with others in the workplace. Given the capacity of generative AI tools to quickly combine concepts to produce a large number of novel ideas or products, as well as to evaluate them, managers are encouraged to examine how each stage of creative processes could be augmented by such tools (Eapen et al., 2023).

Additionally, the rise of remote and hybrid forms of work-related interaction has made it important to consider how computer-mediated communication can influence creative exchanges between individuals. In a study examining the impact of teleconferencing tools on collaborative idea generation, Brucks and Levav (2022) find videoconferencing narrows an

individual's cognitive focus toward a screen and away from visual stimuli that exist around the space. This can hinder one's ability to engage in associative thinking, which helps fuel creative idea generation. On the other hand, the study finds that the selection of creative ideas to pursue, which often requires cognitive focus and analytical reasoning, was not affected by the use of teleconferencing technology.

Remote and hybrid forms of work represent major technological shifts for managers who aim to foster a creative work environment. While many employees enjoy the flexibility of virtual work, remote work can come at the expense of performance (Bloom et al., 2023). For example, the shift to remote work after the COVID-19 pandemic resulted in the emergence of densely connected silos that are less connected with each other across formal business units (Yang et al., 2022). Brucks and Levav (2022) suggest the negative effects of remote work can be tempered through scheduling meetings in a strategic manner. For instance, managers should consider planning meetings where brainstorming is needed on days when their team is in the office. On days when ideas are being evaluated, remote versus in-person distinctions would matter less.

Culture and Climate

Organizational culture and climate shape creative processes, and at the same time, creative interaction in organizations is manifested in organizational structure and practices, therefore shaping the culture and climate in turn (Tesluk et al., 1997). Studies have examined the effects of organizational culture and climate on creativity. In a qualitative study of UK-based PRs professionals, Daymon (2001) found that while PR firms often strive to generate unconventional ideas, they must walk a fine line to not pursue ideas that alienate clients by being so far outside the box. The author suggests that finding personnel to strike this delicate balance often requires firms to recruit employees who are a "right fit" with the organization's culture. Tesluk et al. (1997) note cultural values are important for ensuring that individual creativity leads to effective organizational outcomes.

In general, diversity is theorized as a factor stimulating the exchange of different viewpoints, thus nurturing seeds for creative ideas (e.g., Burt, 2004). To unpack this overarching assumption, a meta-analysis of 44 studies presents several moderating variables (Wang et al., 2019). These include surface-versus deep-level diversity, team virtuality, task interdependence, task complexity, and task intellectiveness. Utilizing race and ethnicity data in combination with network data from ten organizations, Cross et al. (2021) show that employees from different demographic groups tend to develop different types of network structure within and across teams. For example, some subgroups including Black men and Asian women were more likely to develop cohesive ties within

their subgroup. Black women and Latinx men developed fewer ties across functional and spatial units. These differing network patterns can have important implications for employees' creativity.

Scholars have suggested that organizational culture plays an important role in facilitating effective creative outcomes. Organizations often hire members based on perceived cultural fit with the group, which could be based on attributes such as background, personal interests, and hobbies. However, managers should be mindful that such practices can have the unintended consequence of hindering diversity (Ingram, 2021). Personal biases can be reduced in the hiring process by clearly delineating the competencies required for a particular position. For instance, companies may identify the factors that distinguish them from other organizations, identify related competencies, and assess cultural fit based on those factors. Additionally, managers should recognize that the integration of diverse perspectives can provide opportunities to challenge cultural norms in the organization in productive ways. As such the emphasis should not only be to invite diverse groups but also to tap into the unique perspectives and ideas these groups have to further strengthen and improve the culture itself.

Creativity Outside Conventional Organizational Boundaries

Thus far, we have considered the ways in which an individual may engage in creative interaction within the "four walls" of their organization. The rise of computational methods and data generated from open-source online communities (e.g., Github, Firefox), however, provide a robust context to study the emergence and maintenance of organizations through interaction (Foote, 2022). The extent to which creative interaction is influenced by the often voluntary and anonymous nature of open-source participation presents exciting opportunities for future research. Moving to the topic of social media, Himelboim and Golan (2023) made progress in applying network theories to the domain of influencer marketing. The authors suggest when influencers post similar content to those across different subgroups, they serve in a bridging capacity and are thus particularly well-suited to appeal to audiences with heterogeneous interests. Extending this work to the creativity domain, communication scholars may wish to explore how engaging and posting content across diverse subgroups may be associated with the generation of more creative forms of content.

Additionally, the rise of digital platforms to execute work has provided creative professionals more opportunities to pursue freelance work assignments outside a full-time job. Dailey et al. (2024) find in-house graphic designers were often confined to narrowly prescribed task sets in their regular working hours. Those who took on freelance work assignments outside their normal hours, however, had greater autonomy and discretion in completing

those projects. This provided opportunities for greater creative exploration and the ability to collaborate with individuals more directly in the creative process.

Despite some of the positive effects of full-time employees taking on freelance work assignments, employers often consider such "side hustles" as a potential distraction from an employee's full-time work (Sessions et al., 2021). Though, in some cases, side hustles may lead to negative effects, managers should consider cultivating an environment where such experiences can be discussed openly. Freelancing experiences can expose employees to new contacts and ideas, which can empower them to generate new ideas for their full-time related work. Consequently, new opportunities for constructive changes to be implemented within the existing workflow can be created.

Conclusion

In today's organizational environments, the emphasis on creativity extends beyond conventional creative sectors such as arts, design, media, advertising, and PR. Understanding how creativity is nurtured in organizations has wide-reaching implications. Focusing on the unique perspective on the duality between structure and interaction offered by ST, this chapter proposed several ways in which studies of employee and organizational communication can inform our understanding of the network processes surrounding creativity. In doing so, we also emphasize how employee's voluntary actions (e.g., informal interaction, scouting, freelancing) can influence formal workflow patterns in the domain of creativity.

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8

SCOUTING AND VOCALIZING IN WORKPLACE

A Theoretical Approach to Address Quiet Quitting While Promoting Scouting Behavior

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It has been reported that approximately 50% of the American workforce is made up of employees who leave their jobs without providing prior notice (Formica & Sfodera, 2022). Furthermore, Gallup's longitudinal data has shown a rise in the number of quiet quitters in the U.S. workforce (Harter, 2022). Quiet quitting is defined as reduced psychological dedication to work coupled with a deficiency in personal engagement (Anand et al., 2023, p. 5). This trend has been identified as having a negative impact on both organizational sustainability and innovation. It may be challenging for employers to find substitutes for employees who depart without prior notification, leading to disruption to organizational operations. Additionally, when employees show less enthusiasm toward their job, it is less likely that organizational innovation will be fostered within the workplace. To build an innovative organization, employers should be vigilant in monitoring employee engagement through communication behaviors and addressing any signs of burnout or dissatisfaction. In this study, we propose that scouting behavior, defined as employees' voluntary communication efforts, serves as a form of organizational innovation (Chon & Park, 2019). Thus, this

chapter aims to introduce a theoretical framework that evaluates employees' quiet quitting, while concurrently promoting scouting behavior, defined as employees' voluntary efforts to gather and disseminate strategic information (Kim & Rhee, 2011). Particularly, we will explore the following topics. In this chapter, initially, concepts of quiet quitting and scouting are introduced via a review of prior research. Next, we propose crucial variables from strategic communication studies to construct a theoretical framework to predict quiet quitting and scouting behavior of employees.

Employees' Quiet Quitting

Quiet quitting is a behavior of employees with limited commitment to fulfilling their assigned responsibilities, abstaining from taking on extra tasks that are not explicitly specified in their job description (Formica & Sfodera, 2022). Several scholars contend that quiet quitting resembles low job engagement and a lack of job satisfaction (Hamouche et al., 2023).

Although many job descriptions incorporate the standard phrase "other duties as assigned", to quiet quitters, this often conveys a sense of passive task completion rather than voluntary, proactive involvement. When an individual engaging in quiet quitting stays on the job but avoids volunteering for additional responsibilities or participating in job-committed activities, it leads to reduced overall productivity, the onset of a negative work environment, and can impact the organization's long-term success (Harter, 2022; Klotz & Bolino, 2022). Thus, it is crucial for organizations to tackle employees' quiet quitting in order to sustain a healthy workplace.

There are various factors that can explain what drives employees to engage in quiet quitting behaviors (e.g., Clifton, 2002; Klotz & Bolino, 2022; Mahand & Caldwell, 2023).

The primary reasons for quiet quitting have been recently summarized —lacking commitment to career development, organizational failure to value employees, lacking sense of belonging, increasing emphasis in employee autonomy, and declining trust toward their organization (Mahand & Caldwell, 2023). Additionally, when employees perceive that their jobs lack significance or purpose, they are inclined to experience diminished interest and commitment to their organizations (Masterson, 2022).

Amidst the COVID-19 pandemic, researchers have identified that remote workers may exhibit a higher tendency toward quiet quitting, possibly due to a sense of disconnection from the organization compared to those working in physical offices (Zenger & Folkman, 2022). That is, quiet quitting emerges when remote workers feel disconnected from both their tasks and the organization.

Scouting as Employees' Innovative Behaviors

Innovation refers to new ideas, methods, products, or services that bring about a substantial enhancement or transformation within a specific field or industry (Rogers, 2003). The definition of innovation presents innovation as both a process (involving new ideas, methods, or devices) and an outcome (the introduction of something novel) (Kahn, 2018). Numerous organizations incorporate the term "innovation" into their vision or mission statements (Kahn, 2018). This is due to the widespread recognition that innovation capacity is a crucial factor in gaining a competitive advantage in today's rapidly changing business environment (Crossan & Apaydin, 2010; Dess & Picken, 2000; Rubera & Droge, 2013). Management scholars assert that a company's performance is primarily influenced by its ability to innovate (Mone et al., 1998). This significant impact has led to a widespread enthusiasm for innovation across all industries, including public relations. As a discipline, employee communication or international communication in public relations has witnessed substantial growth in recent decades (Men, 2021).

Scouting is one of the innovative behaviors of employees. Scouting refers to employees' voluntary communication efforts to acquire relevant information on management tasks and other related issues, without personal gain and subsequently sharing this information with the organization and fellow members (Kim & Rhee, 2011). Innovation arises not only from systematic investments in research and development but also from informal, serendipitous instances when employees critically analyze and question routine procedures, services, and products (Sauermann & Cohen, 2010; Zhang & Bartol, 2010). Innovation often originates from employees who identify issues associated with current procedures, services, and products, and employees may generate innovative ideas for organizational processes, which is commonly referred to as intrapreneurship (Park et al., 2014). The extensive body of literature on intrapreneurship aims to harness the entrepreneurial and innovative drive within larger organizations (Parker, 2011; Park et al.,

2014). Employee individual innovative behavior serves as a fundamental element (Felin et al., 2015) for fostering organizational innovation and intrapreneurship. In this chapter, we define "employee innovation" as the actions that employees undertake to generate or embrace new ideas and subsequently make efforts to implement them.

Critical Factors to Predict Quiet Quitting and Scouting

Transformational Leadership

As one of factors to predict quiet quitting and scouting behavior of employees, we introduce transformational leadership. Transformational leadership is defined as "the leader moving the follower beyond immediate self-interests through idealized influence, inspiration, intellectual simulation, or individualized consideration" (Bass, 1999, p. 11). The concept of transformational leadership has attracted significant scholarly interest, and it remains among the most extensively studied leadership models even today (Northouse, 2016). Scholars have found that transformational leadership has a positive impact on organizational outcomes (Siangchokyoo et al., 2020).

Transformational leadership influences employees' communication behaviors and organizational outcomes. Previous research indicates that organizational leadership can significantly impact positive internal communications (Grunig et al., 2002; Men, 2014). Bass (1999) states that a leader motivates followers to go beyond their immediate self-interests by employing idealized influence, charisma, inspiration, intellectual stimulation, or individualized consideration (p. 11). Employees who are inspired by this form of leadership are more likely to perform well, align with organizational objectives, and engage in empowering communication behaviors (Hackman & Johnson, 2004). Scholars have particularly observed that transformational leadership yields positive outcomes for organizations (Kavanagh & Ashkanasy, 2006). For instance, it fosters organizational innovation (Jung et al., 2003) and promotes symmetrical communication within the organization (Men, 2014). Previous studies have also highlighted the positive impact of transformational leadership on employees' willingness to express their opinions to their supervisors (Yuanyi & Guiyao, 2011; Duan et al., 2017).

Organizational Cultures

Next, organizational culture can be another important factor to predict quiet quitting and scouting behavior of employees. Generally, culture refers to "the beliefs, values, attitudes, behaviors, and practices that are characteristics of a group of people" (Warrick, 2015, p. 4). Schein (1992) defines the term "group" as social units of all sizes pertaining to any gathering of people. Warrick (2017) pointed out that groups of individuals are prone to developing distinct cultures. Additionally, the term "organizational culture" encompasses the culture of an entire organization or any unit of people working together within the organization in a broad sense. According to Deshpande and Webster (1989), organizational culture can be described as the collective set of values and beliefs that aid individuals in understanding how the organization operates, thereby establishing behavioral norms within the organization. In a practical sense, organizational culture refers to the workplace environment and its impact on individuals' thoughts, actions, and overall work experience (Warrick, 2016).

The significance of organizational cultures lies in their influence on organizational growth. Hartley (2003) stressed that organizations need to promote their employees to become committed members of a purposeful organization rather than contractual employees of an economic entity by creating organizational culture that is mutually shaped and accepted by their employees. Kezar and Eckel (2002) found that organizational change strategies are successful if they are culturally coherent or aligned with the organizational culture, because it is the employees in the culture who will be an agent of implementing change strategies. The resource-based view of strategic management emphasizes the internal capabilities in achieving a sustainable competitive advantage for organizations (Wang et al., 2009). Internal factors are those that are rooted in and thus likely to be controlled by an organization, such as reporting structure, hiring authority, and communication culture. Therefore, fostering continuous growth necessitates organizations to cultivate quality relationships with their agents.

Organizational culture is widely recognized as a valuable strategic resource for the organization, exerting significant influence on employee engagement, loyalty, attitudes, motivation, and commitment to the organization (Denison, 1990; Rollins & Roberts, 1998; Warrick, 2017). Numerous researchers have asserted that organizational culture plays a crucial role in the long-term success of an organization (Ajmal & Helo, 2010). Particularly, the study by John Kotter and James Heskett (1992), which evaluated company cultures over an 11-year period, revealed that

companies with strong and healthy cultures not only experienced a substantial increase in sales but also witnessed a significant rise in stock prices when compared to companies lacking positive cultures. Moreover, organizational culture has been a significant focal point in shaping public relations practices (Sriramesh, 2007). Previous studies have examined its impact on various aspects, including employee satisfaction, turnover, and communication strategies (Sriramesh et al., 1992; Rhee & Moon, 2009).

The competing value model (CVM) has been widely utilized to capture the diverse aspects of organizational culture (Cameron & Quinn, 2005, 2011). According to CVM, organizational culture is characterized by two primary dimensions: control structure versus flexibility structure, and internal focus versus external focus (Cameron & Quinn, 2011). The control structure emphasizes stability, predictability, and efficiency, while the flexible structure emphasizes empowerment, discretion, and dynamism. On the other hand, an internal focus values the harmonious development of people and systems within the organization, whereas an external focus values interaction and competition with the outside environment (Cameron & Quinn, 2011). Based on the typology that employs the intersecting quadrants of these axes, an organization's culture in the CVM can be categorized into four culture types: Clan (Collaborate), Adhocracy (Create), Hierarchy (Control), and Marketing (Compete). Among the four organizational cultures, previous research has found that marketing culture was positively associated with allegiant communication behavior (ACB) of employees in South Korea and the United States (Chon et al., 2021). The term "market" refers not to marketing activities or interactions with consumers in the marketplace, but rather to an organizational type that functions through economic market mechanisms (Cameron & Quinn, 2011). This form of organizational culture, known for its competitiveness, drives employees to prioritize success, emphasizing efficiency and accomplishments (Quinn & Spreitzer, 1991).

Employee–Organization Relationship

Third, we propose employee–organization relationship (EOR) as another variable to predict both quiet quitting and scouting behavior. EOR originated from organization–public relationship (OPR) is defined as "the degree to which an organization and its employees trust one another, agree on who has the rightful power to influence, experience satisfaction with each other, and commit oneself to the other" (Men & Stacks, 2014,

p. 307). EOR has been suggested as a crucial result of effective-internal communication and positive outcomes of public relations activities (Men & Bowen, 2016). Like OPR, EOR consists of four primary elements that characterize the quality of a relationship between an organization and its key publics. The subdimensions of EOR include (1) control mutuality, indicating agreement on rightful power dynamics; (2) satisfaction, representing a positive state where expectations are met between relational parties; (3) trust, reflecting confidence and openness; and (4) commitment, denoting belief and emotional investment. Park and her colleagues (2014) found that decentralized power and symmetrical communication are key factors in developing quality EOR. In other words, employees who are empowered in their organizations and whose organizations foster open, participative communication are more likely to trust and commit to their organizations and be satisfied with their organizations.

Employees in quality EOR have higher loyalty to their organizations and higher desire to maintain the relationship than employees in poor EOR (Omar et al., 2010; Park et al., 2014). e Cunha (2002) defined employee loyalty as the employee's commitment to the success of their organization. Guillon and Cezanne (2014) discussed that increasing performance quality for organizational success includes not only increasing profits and organizational reputation but also reducing employee turnover. Indeed, employees with a high level of loyalty are more likely to stay with their organizations (Suliman & Al-Junaibi, 2010). Therefore, employees in quality EOR are motivated to perform better, because they want their organizations to do well in order to sustain their long-term, enjoyable, quality relationships. Studies (Hashim et al., 2008; Park et al., 2014) also found that employees in a good OER are willing to engage in favorable internal and external communicative behaviors for their organization, such as motivating coworkers to perform better and advocating their organization to others.

Allegiant Communication Behavior

Lastly, we suggest that employees' communication behaviors are essential to predict quiet quitting and scouting behavior of employees in the organization. The ACB is a concept to measure three employees' communication behaviors such as voice, silence, and listening. Chon and his colleagues (2021) conceptualized ACB model and tested it by comparing two groups of employees in South Korea and the United

States. Just like a group of musicians in an orchestra builds musical harmony by using listening, silence, and sound, employees in an organization can enhance organizational performance by choosing when to remain silent, actively listening to others, and speaking up when necessary (Chon et al., 2021). What if, just as the goal of an orchestra is to create musical harmony among musicians, the mission of an organization is to achieve its mission through employees' loyal and effective communication efforts. The ACB places an emphasis on goal-oriented aspects of organizations, work dynamics, and relationships among both organizations and their employees, aiming to enhance performance and efficiency.

ACB has three sub-dimensions such as allegiant reticence (AR; Silence), allegiant voice (AV; Construction), and allegiant amity (AA; Harmony/Listening) and provided operational definitions by providing measurement. Adapting existing two concepts of prosocial voice and prosocial silence (Van Dyne et al., 2003), Chon and his colleagues (2021) suggested AR and AV. The two concepts in ACB are slightly different in that original meanings are extended by overarching proactive communication of employees to make their organizations better and by providing measurements. When considering the value of silence is differently perceived between Eastern countries and Western countries, it is meaning to suggest positive sides of silence to product an organizational security. Importantly, AA in ACB is unique and valuable because it suggests "employees' quietness and the act of listening to others' voices to benefit one's group or organization" (Chon et al., 2021, p. 3). Employees' listening behavior brings out authentic conversation by leading to fewer misunderstandings and improved relationships (Worthington & Fitch-Hauser, 2018). Thus, AR, AV, and AA, as sub-dimensions of ACB, conceptualize employees' loyal and faithful communication behaviors that lead to organizational performance.

Implications and Future Research

This chapter has suggested critical factors to predict quiet quitting and scouting behavior of employees from the view of employee communication research. There are several important theoretical and practical implications of this chapter.

From the perspective of employee communication research, we suggested factors of transformational leadership, organizational culture, EOR, ACB that can be used to mitigate quit quitting. In fact, previous

research of quiet quitting has investigated lacking commitment to career development, organizational failure to value employees, lacking sense of belonging, increasing emphasis in employee autonomy, and declining trust toward their organizations to explain quiet quitting of employees. However, this study newly suggest organizations can predict and reduce employees' quiet quitting through transformational leadership, organizational culture (i.e., marketing culture), quality of relationship (i.e., EOR), and allegiant communication behavior (i.e., ACB). Furthermore, while quiet quitting is a negative outcome for organizations, scouting is a positive factor to bring organizational innovation from employees. Thus, we argue transformational leadership, organizational culture, EOR, and ACB can increase scouting behavior of employees as organizational innovation.

Using proposed factors, it is possible to suggest a theoretical model to predict quiet quitting and scouting of employees. When contemplating the interconnectedness of transformational leadership, organizational culture, and EOR with ACB (Chon et al., 2021; Chon & Park, 2019), our proposition is that ACB serves as a mediating factor, establishing a link between key elements like transformational leadership, organizational culture, and EOR and outcome variables such as quiet quitting and employee scouting. Accordingly, we extend the previous ACB model, which only tested transformational leadership and organizational culture with ACB, by incorporating EOR and two outcome variables such as quiet quitting and scouting. Originally, the ACB model, which captured employees' loyalty and commitment-based communication efforts for their organizations, was developed to evaluate internal communication quality (Chon et al., 2021). However, this chapter expands the application of the ACB model to predict quiet quitting and scouting by adding EOR in the proposed model. Through an exploration of transformational leadership, marketing culture, EOR, and ACB, we have gained profound insights into the intricate interplay of these variables within the context of innovative organizations. This contribution serves to enrich the existing reservoir of knowledge in the field of organizational communication.

While this chapter has undoubtedly offered invaluable insights, it also opens the door to several promising avenues for future research. To initiate the exploration, forthcoming research should assess the proposed model through the collection of employee data. It is with eager anticipation that we envision the validation of this model through

rigorous testing, a process that holds the promise of bolstering both organizational communication and innovation research.

Furthermore, we recommend more variables for testing the model. While the factors influencing employees' inclination toward quiet quitting were not extensively examined in this chapter, it is pivotal to address such factors. For instance, factors such as waning commitment to career development, a diminished sense of belonging, and eroding trust in the organization may hold considerable predictive power over employees' tendencies toward quiet quitting. Moreover, delving into organizational culture necessitates the scrutiny of more granular cultural aspects associated with the work environment, such as a dearth of motivation for advancement within the organization, a sense of detachment from the organization, and the burden of excessive tasks. A comprehensive approach involves comparative assessments, possibly against past or other employees.

Turning to the exploration of innovative behaviors, while this chapter centralizes scouting as one facet of employee innovation, it's important to acknowledge the presence of numerous variables that contribute to such behaviors. Scouting behavior, encompassing the voluntary pursuit of information and its sharing, represents merely one dimension. Given our conceptualization of employee innovation as actions undertaken to generate, embrace, and implement novel ideas, the potential to examine these behaviors in forthcoming research remains plausible. Additionally, this chapter didn't explain how demographic information of employees such as years of working, salary, and different working industry can affect their quiet quitting behavior and innovative behaviors in organizations. Accordingly, future study should control those factors in the model.

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9

EMPLOYEE SILENCE

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Defining Employee Silence

Employee silence is the intentional withholding of opinions, ideas, and information by employees, which could improve teams and organizations (Van Dyne et al., 2003). Studies of employee silence are less common than studies of employee voice behaviors in communication, public relations, and management. Since the late 20th century, scholarship on employee dissent (i.e., expressing disagreements to management; Kassing, 2011) has outpaced publications on employee silence. The divergence may be due to the comparative challenge posed by investigating employee silence as it involves less observable communication behaviors than employee dissent. Another hindrance to the growth and spread of scholarship on employee silence in organizational communication and public relations involves the common misunderstanding that the topic is the mere opposite of employee dissent. To the contrary, Van Dyne et al. (2003) argued convincingly that employee silence is multifaceted and worthy of sophisticated conceptualization and inquiry.

To demonstrate their claim, Van Dyne et al. (2003) set important boundary conditions around the construct and explained divergent motives for withholding opinions, ideas, and information. Boundary conditions are important parameters that include key focal phenomena while also excluding adjacent topics that can distract from rigorous programs of research (Busse et al., 2017). Van Dyne et al. explained employee silence is focused on (a) purposeful, deliberate, or intentional withholding, while excluding inattentive, distracted, forgetful, or

mindless withholding. Also, the authors argued that employee silence should attend to ideas, opinions, and information related (b) to potential improvements—be they remediating concerns or advocating for aspirations—about (c) the work, the team, or the organization. Such a move rules out a focus on employees' withholding of information about many related but work-irrelevant topics (e.g., family, hobbies, sports). The scholars also recommended that employee silence be studied exclusively in face-to-face interactions in organizations. They argued that observer inferences and (mis)attributions of nonverbals would be especially prominent under these communication conditions. We agree face-to-face interaction is a fruitful place to start employee silence investigations but advocate that a broader spectrum of interactional occasions and media be included, where rigorous empirical investigation is possible.

Beyond these boundary conditions, employee silence is multifaceted. Employee silence can be differentiated by *motive*. For example, Van Dyne et al. (2003) proposed that silence can be acquiescent, defensive, or prosocial. *Acquiescent silence* is passive such that withholding occurs due to a sense of resignation or feelings of low efficacy. Alternatively, employee silence can be the result of two kinds of active motives: *Defensive silence* is an active withholding due to self-protection or fear-based motives (e.g., avoiding termination or relational fallout with powerholders). Likewise, *prosocial silence* is an active withholding due to cooperative and social harmony motives (e.g., avoiding embarrassing another) as well as organizationally benefiting motives (e.g., keeping corporate secrets).

While Van Dyne et al.'s (2003) categorical scheme is insightful, other scholars offered competing strategies for dividing the construct. For example, Brinsfield (2012) proposed that employee silence could be subdivided into six types, based on an amalgamation of motives and projected outcomes. In this typology, employee silence can entail *deviant silence* (i.e., withholding crucial information to create harm to the team or organization), *relational silence* (i.e., fear of damaging a relationship), *defensive silence* (i.e., fear of retribution), *diffident silence* (i.e., passivity produced by insecurities, self-doubt, and uncertainties), *ineffectual silence* (i.e., assuming speaking up is not worthwhile and will result in no effective change), and *disengaged silence* (i.e., lacking interest in job responsibilities and organizational values). Notably, Chou and Chang (2020) divided the construct by whether silence was the response to antecedent solicitation of feedback or dialogue. Their categorization

includes *unsolicited predetermined employee silence*, *unsolicited issue-based employee silence*, and *solicited target-based employee silence*. Furthermore, Bisel and Arterburn identified *poor timing employee silence*, which involved a temporary withholding of ideas, opinions, and information—suggesting that employee silence can also be categorized across time and process.

Also, Bisel and colleagues produced a body of scholarship focused on employee silence about private ethical concerns, which they term the *moral mum effect* (for a review, see Bisel, 2018). Experimental studies demonstrated consistently that working adults deny an unethical business request by expressing explicitly ethical reasons for their denial only about 10% of the time, meaning that ethical silence or moral muteness is common in organizations (e.g., Bisel & Adame, 2019). Instead, expressed denials of unethical business requests tend to involve off-record questioning, euphemisms, humor, and economic or policy justifications (Bisel, 2018; Bisel & Kramer, 2014). Here, the content of employee silence about private ethical concerns is often substituted with alternative or adjacent matters in their dissent and expressions. Clearly, employee silence is a multifaceted concept that can be analyzed in several ways.

Costs of Employee Silence

Employee silence has significant costs for organizational members, stakeholders, and organizational reputation. Most critically, employee silence is a major mechanism behind the absence of functional feedback loops. Feedback loops help members, teams, and organizations make needed improvements. Ideally, when upstream decisions and actions are wrong, inappropriate, unethical, suboptimal, or a poor fit for problems and challenges, then corrective feedback signals to the powerholders or the social system that remediation is needed (Crossan et al., 1999; Daft & Weick, 1984). Scholars noted that highly reliable teams and organizations enact sensitivity to operations, such that ongoing monitoring occurs at the frontline—where the real work gets done (for a review see, Scott et al., 2023). Weick and Sutcliffe (2015) explained that sensitivity to operations generally occurs where trusting relationships among organizational members allows for the free flow of candid feedback, especially up the chain of command.

In contrast, rampant employee silence within a team or organization means that operations cannot be monitored well. When employee silence

is endemic in a social system, small and resolvable operational or ethical problems can be left to persist and grow because valued feedback loops are missing. When small problems are allowed to fester without remediation, they can link and amplify becoming large and intractable crises for organizational reputation and survival. Similarly, widespread employee silence can hamper organizational moral learning (i.e., the adaptation of work according to members' moral intuitions; Bisel, 2018). Where organizational members cannot or do not talk about private moral concerns and aspirations aloud together, they remain unable to think about ethics *together* as a team or organizations. In other words, ethics-based deliberation about work will remain impossible while employee silence persists. Furthermore and relatedly, pervasive employee silence will tend to result in poor management of organizational reputation and image. Why? Weak signals or feedback from stakeholders could indicate that aspects of an organization's image is—or could be—losing favorability among key publics. Yet, if those weak signals are not discussed candidly, then needed adjustments to organizational branding and messages will be unlikely. The costs of poor organizational moral learning and poor reputation management are outcomes of the limited requisite variety and poor decision-making that result from pervasive employee silence.

There are other costs of employee silence as well. For example, employee silence can create stress and feelings of burnout for members who feel unable to raise concerns that are important to them (Dong & Chung, 2021). In this sense, employees' expressions of ideas, opinions, and information are a kind of pressure-relief valve, which can help soothe some emotional tensions that build up in work settings. Furthermore, studies have indicated various forms of employee silence are associated with low job satisfaction and high turnover (Hao et al., 2022; Morrison, 2014). Likewise, a meta-analysis revealed that employee silence was associated with poor self and other-reported task performance (Hao et al., 2022). Such findings suggest that employee silence has costs for both members, and ultimately, for whole organizations.

Benefits of Employee Silence

Comprehensive explorations must consider the positive and negative outcomes of social phenomena, whether intended or unintended. While the costs of employee silence are substantial, there may be some benefits,

which partially accounts for why employee silence is such a common and pervasive problem. First, employee silence may reduce information overload for supervisors and managers, especially in organizations marked by large spans of control (e.g., >1 manager to 9 direct report employees). Second, prosocial silence may facilitate social and relational harmony, which can be helpful in the coordination of actions and the ultimate achievement of goals. If every opinion or idea were voiced and deliberated upon thoroughly, teams and organizations could suffer from an inability to act efficiently together—a rare but problematic form of faulty decision-making known as paralysis by analysis (Fraher et al., 2017). Thus, a good sense of *what* opinions, ideas, and information require expressing and *when* to do so are important judgment calls of constructive team and organizational members. Third, highly competent employees' may strategically withhold opinions, ideas, and information in order to avoid job creep and being assigned more and more responsibilities (Kossek, 2016). Indeed, there may be benefits to employee silence, but more research is needed to explore the boundary conditions and contexts under which employee silence is advantageous for members, teams, and organizations.

Common Antecedents of Employee Silence

While employee silence is understudied, some scholarship and theorizing provides clues into the root causes of pervasive employee silence. Those causes range from individual differences, interpersonal contexts, socialization forces, as well as material and cultural causes. In terms of *individual differences*, scholarship by Zanin and Bisel (2023) focused attention on the role played by lay or implicit theories and the selection of defensive silence (i.e., withholding expressions for self-protection and avoiding retribution). Lay or implicit theories refer to those systems of meaning that individuals take-for-granted about how the world works. The scholars measured participants' lay theories around followership. Specifically, they investigated whether participants held strong co-production beliefs (i.e., assumption that followers should ideally have active partnerships with leaders to achieve organizational goals), active role orientations (i.e., believing followers should not be passive and are co-responsible with leaders for organizational outcomes), and romance of leadership (i.e., having a tendency to attribute organizational successes to leadership exclusively). Results indicated that when participants held

an active role orientation, they were less likely to select defensive silence when deciding whether to speak up about organizational issues.

In terms of *interpersonal contexts*, common sense and scholarship suggest that abusive supervision, poor leader–member relationship quality, and distrust between employees and managers can create or exacerbate employee silence. According to Xu et al. (2015), when an employee experiences an abusive behavior from a supervisor, it causes psychological distress; in turn, employees react by developing strategies to avoid future relational stress, resulting in their selection of silence. The authors state that silence is an "important passive reaction due to its widespread detrimental impact on organizations at all levels" (p. 764). Unsurprisingly, trust in supervisors reduces defensive and acquiescent employee silence (Hao et al., 2022) as well as reduces silence regarding private ethical concerns (Zanin et al., 2016).

In terms of *socialization forces*, employee silence is likely the consequence of politeness and group harmony norms learned throughout the lifespan. For example, Detert and Edmondson (2011) investigated self-censorship as a product of lay or implicit theories (see above) of communication learned from childhood socialization with authority figures. Across a series of studies, the scholars demonstrated that employees have strong normative beliefs that dissuade them from expressing contrary views to powerholders, especially if expressions risk embarrassment for the self or powerful others. Similarly, employees raised in the context of high power distance national cultures may also be especially prone to pervasive employee silence.

Some self-protective forms of employee silence (e.g., defensive silence, diffident silence) are likely exacerbated in situations where *material resources* are scarce and employee populations are vulnerable. Over the past decade, organizational communication scholars advocated the need to avoid explanations that are excessive in assuming the socially constructed nature of reality. Such explanations can ignore material realities in accounting for human behavior (Ashcraft et al., 2009; Bruscella & Bisel, 2018). Here, material resource scarcity can exacerbate employees' fear of retribution, which is a key motivator of some forms of employee silence. Imagine for example the potential fear experienced by an undocumented immigrant who is a single mother as she decides whether to speak up about an issue involving workplace safety. That employee may have a lot to fear materially (e.g., deportation, separation from children, financial hardship), and, as a result, experience strong motivation to select silence (Segarra & Prasad, 2022). To date, little or no

research has specifically focused on material resource scarcity or vulnerable employee populations in terms of employee silence.

In terms of *organizational culture causes*, Zanin and Bisel (2023) studied more than 300 working adults, based in the United States. The scholars investigated whether perception of structurational divergence was associated with dissent strategy selection (e.g., circumvention, threatening resignation) or defensive silence. Structurational divergence occurs in organizational cultures where employees' experience competing and contradictory demands levied on them by management, clients, or stakeholders. Colloquially, structurational divergence feels like being stuck between a rock and a hard place, or being damned if I do, damned if I don't. Structurational divergence is a problematic social dynamic that creates immobilization, negative conflict, and a lack of productive growth and improvement of the situation. Thus, it is not surprising that structurational divergence is statistically associated with employees' defensive silence (Zanin & Bisel, 2023). Additionally, a meta-analysis revealed perceptions of workplace fairness in terms of decision-making and resource distribution (i.e., organizational justice) is negatively associated with defensive and acquiescent silence (Hao et al., 2022).

Strategies for Combating Problematic Forms of Employee Silence

Work remains to be done in identifying effective remediation strategies to reduce problematic forms of employee silence (e.g., defensive silence). However, it seems reasonable that strategies which bolster psychological safety, as well as related forms of trust- and relationship-building, are a good starting point for discouraging problematic silence in the workplace. Psychological safety is a team-level construct and refers to the degree to which team members believe they can take interpersonal risks with one another without the likelihood of retribution or relational fallout (Edmondson, 2018). Interpersonal risks can entail providing corrective feedback and communicating opinions and information that might be embarrassing to coworkers and supervisors. Furthermore, while direct investigations of employee silence and psychological safety are limited, studies reveal consistently that psychological safety bolsters team and organizational learning and innovativeness by stimulating quality communication, even potentially hurtful communication among team members (Edmondson & Lei, 2014).

Thus, bolstering psychological safety is a reasonable candidate for combating problematic forms of employee silence. Similarly, strategies to bolster trust in supervisor or leader-member relational quality via relational bids (i.e., minor opportunities for relationship deepening) are likely helpful as well (Zanin et al., 2016).

Supervisor communication competence and encouraging perceptions of organizational fairness will likely help to manage many of the fears that drive problematic forms of employee silence. Communication competence refers to social skillfulness in balancing task and relational demands through socially-preferred language adjustments. Unsurprisingly, supervisor communication competence has been associated with employee job satisfaction, motivation, and organizational commitment (Mikkelson et al., 2015). Similarly, positive communication practices, such as warm greetings, authentic complimenting, reciprocal disclosure, and empathic listening (Mirivel & Lyon, 2023) are hallmarks of skillful and likable communicators and relationship partners. To date, no direct investigations of employee silence and competent or positive communication practices by leaders are yet available. However, and conversely, studies revealed that abusive supervision is strongly associated with defensive and acquiescent silence (Hao et al., 2022). Thus, it stands to reason that positive and competent supervisor communication practices should suppress problematic forms of employee silence.

Some research has documented two strategies for combating the moral mum effect in the workplace. Recall that the moral mum effect involves employee silence about ethics such that individuals show an unwillingness to express private ethical concerns explicitly. Zanin et al. (2016) conducted an experiment with working adults. The experiment compared participants' responses to an unethical business request from participants who were assigned to a condition in which they had (a) a supervisor who used explicitly-moralized vocabulary regularly (i.e., using words, such as "ethics", "morals", "integrity") and asked others about work situations in those terms, (b) a supervisor who used economic vocabulary regularly (i.e., using words, such as "profit", "revenue", "expenses") and asked others about work situations in those terms, or (c) a baseline control condition. Analysis revealed a pattern of *moral talk contagion*, such that explicit supervisor ethics talk resulted in participants using statistically more ethics-based denials of the unethical business request than either competing condition. Thus, the moral mum effect appears to be eased by supervisor moral talk contagion. In another

experiment, Bisel and Adame (2019) assigned working adults to respond to an unethical business request from their supervisor. Before responding, participants were randomly assigned to a condition in which they had (a) a supervisor who talked regularly about bodily signals (e.g., "follow your heart", "going with your gut feelings") and asked others about work situations in those terms, (b) a supervisor who talked regularly about intellectual reasoning (e.g., "follow your intellect", "going with your logical reasoning") and asked others about work situations in those terms, or (c) a baseline control condition. Analysis revealed that supervisor talk about *embodied moral knowing* resulted in participants using statistically more ethics-based denials than either competing condition. Furthermore, participants also reported significantly less communication anxiety in that same condition, suggesting that embodied moral knowing talk from supervisors can ease fears. Taken together, these studies suggest that at least some forms of problematic employee silence (i.e., the moral mum effect) can be counteracted by strategic supervisor communication practices.

Theoretical and Empirical Implications

This review of the organizational communication and public relations literature on employee silence suggests the following theoretical and empirical implications. First, employee silence is a multifaceted communication phenomenon that should be of interest to scholars and practitioners. The construct is multifaceted in the sense that employees have many motivations to remain silent. Likewise, silence can be the result of several antecedents and can involve many relevant topics (e.g., ethical concerns). Furthermore, scholarship and theorizing make it clear that employee silence is not reducible to the mere absence of employee voice or dissent. The construct is a *communication* topic. Communication is meaning-making (Berger & Luckmann, 1967). As such, employee silence is a communication topic because it involves meaning-making about meaning-making (e.g., whether and how to express opinion, ideas, and information).

Additionally, this review illustrates that employee silence can be productively (a) theorized, (b) measured quantitatively, and (c) investigated qualitatively. Sophisticated theoretical treatises explained above suggest that the construct is complex and different enough from adjacent concepts (e.g., employee voice) to deserve its own elaboration. We encourage scholars to continue the work of theorizing employee

silence and its implications for employees, stakeholders, organizations, organizational reputations, and society. The foregoing review also indicates that facets of employee silence can be measured quantitatively (e.g., defensive silence; Zanin & Bisel, 2023) and manipulated experimentally (e.g., moral mum effect; Bisel & Adame, 2019). We call for studies that measure other types of employee silence quantitatively, such as acquiescence, prosocial, and deviant silence. Measurement innovations should help stimulate future research into the topic.

Finally, employee silence studies can be investigated fruitfully with multiple established theories. For example, Weick et al.'s (2005) *sensemaking theory* was used to explain the reasons employees' use to rationalize times when they withheld critiques from their supervisors (Bisel & Arterburn, 2012). Sensemaking theory explains how individuals, teams, and organizations attribute meaning to events and act upon those attributions (Weick et al., 2005). Also, *structurational divergence theory* (Nicotera et al., 2010)—an adaptation of Giddens's (1984) structuration theory—was used successfully to predict employees' selection of defensive silence (Zanin & Bisel, 2023). Structurational divergence theory explains how employees experience workplace structures that place them between competing and contradictory demands, which saps self-efficacy and generates self-perpetuating negative conflict communication cycles. In yet another example, *conservation of resources* (COR) theory was used to explain how emotional exhaustion mediated the relationship between abusive supervision and subordinates' generalized silence (Xu et al., 2015). COR theory explains that individuals are motivated to retain, protect, and grow (emotional) resources in order to generate a surplus of resources, in this case, against psychological stressors. Thus, employees find abusive supervision to be emotionally taxing. In turn, they will withhold more from management as a means of retaining emotional resources—the implication being that employees predict speaking up can generate more abusive supervision directed at them, which results in a subsequent expenditure of emotional resources. These three examples demonstrate that employee silence can be studied and explained from several theories.

Directions for Future Research

This review of the employee silence literature suggests three directions for future scholarship. First, greater integration is needed between the employee silence and the organizational dissent and voice behavior

literature. Early debates about the uniqueness of the employee silence construct are settled both theoretically and empirically. Employee silence is worthy of its own investigation and it cannot be reduced to the mere absence of dissent or voice. However, studying the constructs together more often may yield fascinating results, such as when unexpected interplays can be identified between employee silence and voice. We encourage researchers to use qualitative, quantitative, field, and experimental methods to identify these unexpected interplays. Second, scholarship is needed to explore leader and manager silence and its implications. Along these lines, Chang et al. (2018) provided a fascinating example of this kind of research. The scholars theorized that leaders engage in downward silence for a variety reasons (e.g., relational protection, sabotage, disengagement). We call on scholars to study leaders' downward silence empirically and work to compare its relationship to employee silence generally. Third, prescriptive communication theories are needed for reducing silence and managing the complex and often hidden conflict that may result from upward dissent. The scholarship described above makes it apparent that employee silence is widespread and can be very damaging to members, stakeholders, organizations, and their reputations. As such, interventions are needed to reduce employee silence. Rigorous interventions must be grounded in prescriptive theorizing, which itself is based in valid descriptive theory. Scholars may begin with the descriptive theories listed above (i.e., sensemaking theory, structurational divergence theory, COR theory) and extend those theories into logical prescriptions for reducing employee silence. Of course, prescriptive interventions must also be subject to rigorous testing. However, the promise of reducing employee silence is worth this applied pursuit.

Conclusion

Employee silence is a socially significant topic, which communication and public relations scholars are well positioned to investigate. The state of literature reveals that employee silence is complex and not reducible to the absence of employee dissent. The phenomenon has known antecedents, costs, and even potential benefits. This chapter reviewed major empirical and theoretical contributions to date. Taken together, this review suggests that work on employee silence is just beginning and will be the focus of sustained scholarly attention for years to come.

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10

UNDERSTANDING EMPLOYEE DISSENT IN RELATIONS TO ORGANIZATIONAL PROCESSES

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Dissent originates from the Latin word *dissentire*, which means "feeling apart" (Kassing, 1997). "Dissent" in English refers to "differ in opinion" (Merriam-Webster Dictionary). Dissent in the workplace refers to employees expressing disagreement, opposing viewpoints, or objections regarding various aspects of their work environment, including policies, practices, decisions, or actions taken by their organization or superiors (de Ruiter et al., 2016). It involves employees voicing their concerns, criticisms, or alternative perspectives in a manner that challenges the status quo or established norms (Shahinpoor & Matt, 2007).

This chapter explores organizational dissent guided by the following research questions: *(a) how does dissent influence organizational processes?* and *(b) how do organizational processes affect employee dissent?* To this end, this chapter reviews dissent from several perspectives that have contributed to our understanding of dissent and its relationship to organizational processes. It also suggests a way forward by embracing employee dissent as an imperative and legitimate form of employee voice in organizational processes.

Understanding Dissent

Kassing and Armstrong (2002) viewed employee dissent as the primary response to dissent-triggering events or issues. Different types of dissent

exist as the outcome of varying degrees of personal, interpersonal, and organizational factors that make the upward articulation of dissent difficult or fearful. While it is relatively straightforward and consensual what dissent is, there is a lack of clarity and agreement regarding what constitutes dissent and what does not. For one, scholars have interchangeably used organizational dissent and employee dissent. While both organizational and employee dissent refer to the same thing, some distinctions exist between these concepts.

Organizational dissent is expressed within organizational boundaries from all ranks of organizational members on organizational issues involving changes, decision-making, ethical matters, or innovations as part of managerial decision-making and participation processes (Garner, 2013). Dissent can be categorized by the utility that dissent can serve in the organization and by the ways in which dissent is expressed and incorporated via organizational processes (e.g., constructive or disruptive; principled upward or displaced). Dissent, in this sense, typically refers to moralized/principled dissent expressed out of ethical and moral concerns about organizational practices. Graham (1983) defined principled organizational dissent as "the effort by individuals in the workplace to protest and to change the organizational status quo because of their conscientious objection to current policy or practice" (Graham, 1983, p. 2). Principled dissent can manifest in several ways. These include constructive criticism, internal protest within the organization, communication with external audiences, and actions to prevent specific actions (Graham, 1983).

On the other hand, employee dissent involves a more personal and internalized individual process that employees partake in when faced with workplace disagreement or dissatisfaction. Hirschman (1972) proposed the EVL (i.e., exit, voice, and loyalty) framework to describe and analyze how individual employees respond to dissatisfaction or problems in organizations. Drawing on the EVL framework on voice, Kassing (1997) considered dissenting employees to use information at the personal, interpersonal, and organizational levels to determine whether and how they should express their dissenting voice. "At a fundamental level, expressing dissent is a very personalized act that requires employees not only to take stock of their character but also to understand their social and organizational standing in their workplace" (Kassing, 2008, p. 344). Kassing (1997) categorized three types of employee dissent depending on whom the dissenting communication is directed: articulated, latent, and displaced. Articulated dissent is open and

direct communication about their differing views and opinions to effectual organizational members, typically upward in direction. Latent dissent, on the other hand, involves communicating differing opinions to ineffectual audiences, typically coworkers. Lastly, displaced dissent is directed to external audiences outside the organizational boundaries (i.e., friends or family). Subsequently, according to Kassing (1997), dissent does not have to occur within the organizational boundaries.

While dissenting can be experienced at the personal level, influenced by individual employees' decision-making process for dissenting strategies (e.g., Kassing, 1997), Garner (2013) investigated dissenting as a co-orienting and co-constructing process that involves interactions of multiple individuals and groups via complex dynamics. From this perspective, communicating dissent is how employees take ownership of their organizations or participate in organizational conversation for sense-making purposes via co-creating meanings and shared work experiences (Garner, 2013).

There is also some confusion regarding the distinction between dissent and whistleblowing. Kassing (1997) argued that dissent differs from whistleblowing in that whistleblowing represents public accusations of an organization's illegal and unethical behaviors to a third party, such as the media or regulating bodies. Jubb's (1999) restrictive definition of whistleblowing as an act of dissent involving a public accusation against an organization that necessitates disloyalty to that organization also highlights the key difference between dissent and whistleblowing. Jubb (1999) argued that the differences lie in the strict nature of dilemmas whistleblowers face about confidentiality and the proprietary nature of information, which is not the case with dissenters.

Additionally, whether silence is a form of dissent has not been much discussed in the dissent literature, while employee voice scholars consider silence as a form of employee communication (Kang & Moon, 2023). The overall view of dissent is that it requires the transparent expression of viewpoints (Kassing, 1997). Kassing has not recognized silence as a form of dissent. However, despite disagreement or dissatisfaction being commonplace in the workplace, dissenting voices often remain unexpressed because it can result in nothing or, worse, retaliation from peers and supervisors (Rahmani et al., 2023). In this regard, silence can be a strategy that some employees adopt via an active decision-making process weighing the costs and benefits of voicing versus silence (Milliken et al., 2003).

Lastly, online and anonymous employee dissent has emerged as a new form of dissent in the last decade. With the prominence of virtual and digital communication technology in the workplace and online communities, the affordances of communication technologies have increasingly allowed employees to have new means and capabilities to use their voices for sense-making and power balance (Rahmani et al., 2023). The anonymity and asynchronicity that online communication technologies and space provide to users have also allowed employees to engage in online dissent without the fear of potential retaliations (Gossett & Kilker, 2006).

Dissent from Various Conceptual Perspectives

Dissent has been explored from interdisciplinary perspectives with a slightly different focus on the processes and implications of dissent on individuals and organizations. I will examine dissent from three perspectives: organizational communication, rhetorical/ethical perspectives, and strategic communication management.

From an organizational communication perspective, dissent has been primarily examined under the conceptual framework of employee voice and organizational participation. In this tradition, dissent has been viewed as a form of employee voice that can enhance organizational learning via pluralism that brings diverse perspectives and views into organizational decision-making (Kassing, 1997) or open systems for harvesting organizational dissent via various policies and tools (Edmondson, 2006). Under this approach, scholars have explored how organizations can foster a culture that can encourage a free flow of employee voice, including dissent, and establish organizational structures and policies that can facilitate employee empowerment and participation in organizational processes by examining factors that hinder employee voice and participation (e.g., silence or displaced dissent). Employees often do not voice their discontent to their supervisors or dissent about workplace problems out of fear or futility (Milliken et al., 2003; Edmondson, 1999). Instead, disgruntled employees may turn to ineffectual internal or external audiences to vent out their frustrations or to make sense of the situation (Kang, 2021), and this type of ineffectual dissent can catch those who should be informed off guard and may lead to internal organizational turmoil (Edmondson, 2006).

Kassing (1997) proposed a theoretical model to explain variations in employee dissent, drawing from the theoretical foundations of

unobtrusive control theory, independent-mindedness theory, and the EVL model. Kassing viewed dissent as the function of a competing force of control. According to Tompkins and Cheney (1985), the process of unobtrusive or concerted control by individuals occurs "through systematic and subtle control of individuals' decision premises" (Kassing, 1997, p. 316) via organizational incentives or disincentives for employees to accept organizational premises. Kassing (1997) argued that dissent would occur when employees refuse to accept organizational premises but rely on their own decision premises instead, which leads to the experience of a discrepancy between the current and desired state of organizational affairs in the minds of individual employees. This notion of contested control is also similarly echoed in Folger et al.'s (2013) construct of bounded autonomy that explains an individual's decision for the right things to do in organizational life, which lays a conceptual foundation for a rhetorical and ethical approach of dissent.

Folger (2012) noted that perceptions of moral norms explain how individuals are motivated by their duties (deontic duties) when facing ethical decision-making. To Individuals, perceptions of autonomy and obligations shape their decisions and behaviors when faced with a moral dilemma, when their rights (freedom) and duties collide, or when facing opposing duties (Folger et al., 2013). In other words, the perceptions of individual autonomy are bounded by a tension between freedom and accountability, of rights and duties, affecting an individual's ethical behavior, hence *bounded autonomy* (Folger et al., 2013). Bounded autonomy arises from conflicting motivations: the desire for the freedom to act in certain ways (reactance) and the feeling of obligation to behave in specific ways (deonance). The central focus of bounded autonomy is on how resolving these conflicts by establishing boundaries between "free" and "restricted" behaviors can result in the person performing the action seeing it as ethical. At the same time, impartial observers may view it as unethical. This difference in perception depends on whether the behavior is evaluated based on its inherent nature as rights or its intended purpose as instrumental (Folger et al., 2013). In this sense, bounded autonomy is relevant in understanding individual employees' decision-making process to dissent and how organizations may view dissent as unethical, particularly concerning the kinds of dissent that bring out dilemmas between loyalty and principles (Bisel & Adame, 2019; Graham, 1983).

From a rhetorical/ethical standpoint, principled dissent is essential to a democratic society. Organizations are inevitably political, like roiling

arenas hosting contested interests, perspectives, interdependence, and power dynamics (Bolman & Deal, 2021). In this sense, dissent is a natural part of organizational politics and a necessary condition for organizational democracy. Dissent as a voice represents the inherent right of employees to express their voice safely and openly in a democratic organization, as the concept of voice in the liberal political sense is considered a cornerstone of democratic society (Couldry, 2010). Therefore, the value of dissent lies in the notion of voice as an inherently ethical and democratic thing for organizations to extend to their employees. From this perspective, employee dissent represents employee voice, which democratic organizations must practice earnestly, fostering open and decentralized organizational dynamics and culture.

Organizations, as a political arena, inherently entail dissent, struggles, and values associated with it. From a rhetorical/critical perspective, the power disparity among different ranks of employees and leaders becomes pertinent because organizations are contested spheres with various conflicting interests, determining whose views get voiced and listened to (Couldry, 2010). Bickford (1996) similarly pointed out that the lack of attention in democratic politics is due to conflicts and inequality in political interactions that affect both who gets to voice and whose voice gets listened to. Because organizations are made up of different individuals and interest groups with enduring differences in values, beliefs, interests, resources, and attitudes vying for scarce resources, the contested nature of organizational politics creates unavoidable conditions for conflicts and coalitions at the center of its day-to-day operations (Shahinpoor & Matt, 2007). Therefore, organizational democracy exists and is enacted within the daily interactions among the organizational members via the regular contest of the conditions of democracy, participation, and equality (Cheney, 1995). Beyond the rhetorical voice of political leaders, the expression of the people's voice is acknowledged as vital for the effective functioning of any democracy.

Cheney's ideal of organizational democracy as a contested and negotiated domain is similar to Eisenberg's (1994) idea of a democratic organization that promotes open dialogue among organizational members whose diverse views and opinions are freely expressed and appreciated, even if not agreed. Dissent as a discursive process is also reflected in a recent work by Ravazzani and Mazzei (2018), who explored anonymous online dissent by employees under a Habermasian ethical discursive framework. They noted that when conveyed constructively, anonymous

online dissent can initiate a dialogue that facilitates the collaborative construction and equilibrium of various perspectives within an informal and non-institutionalized setting (Ravazzani & Mazzei, 2018).

From the communication management tradition, dissent has been primarily examined from the organizational perspective that values instrumental and strategic merits of employee communication for organizations. Under this tradition, scholars have drawn on theoretical frameworks of relationship management (e.g., Kim & Rhee, 2011) and the social exchange theory (e.g., Kang & Sung, 2017). Under this tradition, scholars have viewed dissent as the extension of the employees' communication behavior (ECB), specifically negative megaphoning (e.g., Krishna & Kim, 2015; Lee & Kim, 2020).

Recognizing the strategic value of employee communication for organizations, Kim and Rhee (2011) introduced ECB by identifying two aspects of ECB—megaphoning and scouting, which they integrated into the concept of microboundary spanning. Megaphoning represents employees' voluntary information-forwarding behaviors beyond the organizational boundaries to external audiences (Kim & Rhee, 2011). Depending on the content of information shared with external audiences, megaphoning can be positive or negative. Scouting involves employees' voluntary efforts to seek out and bring potentially important and relevant information to the organization via sharing and forwarding information (Kim & Rhee, 2011). Microboundary spanning refers to voluntary ECB involving employees taking the initiative to gather relevant information, stay informed about developments, identify potential areas for improvement or growth for the organization, and share such information with internal audiences (Kim & Rhee, 2011).

Studies of employee dissent from this perspective, therefore, have primarily treated dissent as a negative outcome of various employee motivations (e.g., Krishna & Kim, 2015; Lee & Kim, 2020); failed employee communication (Kang & Sung, 2017); and poor EOR quality perceptions (Kang et al., 2023; Kim & Rhee, 2011; Lee & Kim, 2020). The focus of these inquiries has been on displaced employee dissent, such as displaced and de-identified online dissenting toward ineffectual audiences that employees go to vent out their dissatisfaction, frustration, and anger with their organization (e.g., Krishna & Kim, 2015; Lee, 2022) or heed warnings about the organization out of altruistic motives for others (e.g., Lee & Kim, 2020). Particularly, employee dissent that expresses critical comments about their organization via personal social media is something to be prevented, discouraged, and sometimes

punished as it represents employees' disregard of organizational norms and behavioral expectations (Thompson et al., 2020). Consequently, the role of organizational communication officers involves demotivating or neutralizing the negative effects of displaced employee dissent on organizations (e.g., Lee & Kim, 2020).

Scholars examining employee dissent from the communication management perspective have recognized dissent as employee communication that can present both an opportunity and a threat to organizations (e.g., Krishna & Kim, 2015; Kang, 2021). Employee dissent, particularly online dissent, defined under broader notions of employee misbehavior, can be pretty concerning (Thompson et al., 2020). According to McDonald and Thompson (2016), social media enables and mirrors the changing dynamics between private and public boundaries of employees, consequently reshaping and causing disruptions in employee and organizational matters and priorities. Possible opportunities for employee dissent are alluded to as an impetus for advocating for a democratic and safe organizational culture that fosters free expressions of varying perspectives and opinions from employees. For example, Krishna and Kim (2015) argued that dissenting opinion as a negative outcome of organizational relationships with employees provides valuable information to organizational leaders regarding areas of improvement and problems with policies and organizational actions. Similarly, Ravazzani and Mazzei (2018) urged for developing mechanisms to overcome challenges posed by anonymous online dissent in ensuring equal participation and internalization of dissent.

In summary, dissent has been examined at the intersection of multiple perspectives, including organizational communication, rhetorical/ethical, and strategic communication frameworks. Recognizing the unique and shared views of dissent afforded by this intersectionality and confluence of various conceptual frameworks, I believe, is essential to move forward with the discussion on dissent with organizational processes.

How Dissent Influences Organizational Processes

Differences in opinions are constantly present in our social, political, and organizational interactions, and expressing those differences is both a moral and a political obligation for a democratic society (Johnson, 2018; Shahinpoor & Matt, 2007). Johnson (2018), in *Voicing Dissent*, noted that dissent as voiced disagreement has values to society as a democratic

necessity and an epistemic necessity. Without dissent, we run the risk of polarization and dogmatism because we often exchange and consider ideas that we generally find agreeable. Also, dissent as an epistemic necessity helps us to be sure of our reasons and justifications for our actions and choices (Johnson, 2018).

Dissent at the organizational level has significant implications, both in positive and negative ways. In recent decades (as much as in the preceding century), organizations have had to adapt to digital and technological transformation, unprecedented levels of global interdependence and disruptions across all organizational sectors, and public expectations on organizations (Bolman & Deal, 2021). Many organizations have failed to learn to adapt and change due to specific external and internal barriers to change. The nature of organizational knowledge is ambiguous and hard to verify during the decision-making process due to the feedback delay between organizational decisions/actions and their consequences (Senge, 1990). Additionally, the systematic blindness of many organizations, due to the siloed nature of organizational relationships, creates a condition in which management is fearful and defensive of changes (Argyris & Schön, 1996; Bolman & Deal, 2021). Additionally, despite the contemporary managerial emphasis on employee participation and empowerment, organizations remain reluctant to dissent by considering them as criticism and opposition (Shahinpoor & Matt, 2007).

When expressed constructively and within appropriate boundaries, dissent can bring new perspectives and alternative approaches to organizational problem-solving and decision-making (Landier et al., 2009). Dissent often exposes underlying conflicts or problems within the organization that can lead to exploring and creating collective solutions (Johnson, 2018; Tjosvold, 1991). Dissent represents differences in values, opinions, and judgments instrumental to organizational learning (Senge, 1990) and democracy (Cheney, 1995). Thriving organizations under the complexities surrounding organizational environments have *learned capabilities* that are enacted and embedded in their protocols, policies, technologies, and shared cultural norms and practices (Bolman & Deal, 2021). As such, organizational dissent represents organizational capacity, allowing diverse views and knowledge to be incorporated into organizational processes for effective problem identification, innovation and improvement, and decision-making. Leaders must rely on understanding and assessing organizational situations from pluralistic perspectives for organizations to solve problems effectively in an

uncertain, fast-paced, and complicated internal and external organizational environment (Bolman & Deal, 2021; Fletcher et al., 2023). "Now more than ever, decision-makers can't act alone; they must bring diverse perspectives to the table and ensure that those voices are fully heard" (Fletcher et al., 2023, para 2).

However, it is also important to recognize the non-insignificant costs of dissent. For example, unity or group harmony can be harmed by expressing disagreement. Also, dissent can cause further entrenchment of certain views as it can cause the recipients of dissent to become defensive and shut down. While many leaders may express their embrace of dissent, employee participation, and empowerment, their reactions often shift to those of defensiveness when encountering it firsthand (Fletcher et al., 2023). Additionally, it is crucial to recognize that the costs of dissent are not fairly distributed, often subordinated social groups facing disproportionate reprimand for disagreeing (Johnson, 2018) or neglect (Bickford, 1996). The politics of listening, in which interactions in conflict and inequality, lend certain voices not to receive equal attention (Bickford, 1996; Macnamara, 2016). At the organizational level, dissent, when displaced and not managed effectively, can have negative consequences for organizations (Ravazzani & Mazzei, 2018; Samba et al., 2018). Disruptive and opportunistic dissent can demoralize and lead to organizational inefficiency (Landier et al., 2009). Also, displaced employee dissent outside the organizational boundaries could damage organizational reputation by negative communication expressed by employees to external stakeholders (Kang, 2021; Ravazzani & Mazzei, 2018).

How Organizational Processes Influence Employee Dissent

As much as dissent may influence organizational processes, organizational processes also greatly influence dissent. Communication management scholars have mainly focused on organizational factors influencing employee communication, such as employee–organization relationship quality and internal communication (Kang & Sung, 2017; Kim & Rhee, 2011). While the direct evidence linking organizational processes and dissent beyond disruptive, displaced, and de-identified dissent is lacking, we can extrapolate a positive relationship between dissent and supportive and democratic leadership and organizational processes.

Also, studies have found that the organizational communication climate that fosters free speech influences how certain types of employee dissent prevail (Cenkci & Otken, 2019; West & Sacramento, 2023). To foster an organizational climate of psychological safety (Edmondson, 1999), relying on individual and interpersonal virtues of empathy and humility is not enough. That is, structural elements and organizational norms must be placed to safeguard the abuse of power in organizational processes to ensure democratic communication for effective organizational learning. For example, taking turns to speak up during a meeting can lessen the likelihood of a few powerful voices dominating the conversation and bring out the best performance (Woolley & Fuchs, 2011). Also, establishing protocols (norms) for expressing dissenting opinions can reduce the perils of group thinking and bring diverse perspectives to the surface by promoting dissent (Pitesa & Thau, 2013).

Dissent can be muted, expressed, or incorporated via formal and informal organizational channels. Employees can express their dissent in many ways through various stages of interactions within the organization. Dissent is more likely to occur as employees become more involved in their organizational functions and are provided ways to voice their inputs (Kassing, 1997). Recognizing the value of employee involvement and feedback, some organizations incorporate dissent as an instrumental form of participation (Pacanowsky, 1988).

Concluding Thoughts

This chapter provided an overview of how dissent has been conceptualized and examined from various conceptual perspectives. Abandonment brings values and advantages to organizations while some costs of dissent are also noteworthy. There are many ways that public relations scholarship can embrace dissent beyond negative megaphoning as the legitimate ECB that can benefit organizations. For example, fostering positive employee–organization relationships and supportive and open leadership that are supported and communicated with dialogic internal communication can promote diverse employee voices, including dissenting ones. The literature on these associations is robust, albeit no direct link with dissent beyond negative megaphoning has yet been made.

Further, organizational justice, employee empowerment and engagement can be fostered via open organizational climate for dissent by encouraging employees to come forward with their opinions (Yang et

al. 2015). Recent developments on organizational listening in public relations scholarships can also provide valuable insights for understanding dissent as part of organizational processes. Macnamara's (2016) book on organizational listening and Place's (2023) edited volume on strategic organizational listening urge us to consider listening a purposeful and ethical organizational communication corollary that can facilitate democratic organizational communication.

Finally, cultivating an open climate for employee dissent within an organization requires deliberate actions and practices. Here are practical suggestions for creating such an environment. First, create a culture of respectful dialogue by emphasizing the importance of respectful communication, even during disagreements with encouragement of active listening, empathy, and understanding differing perspectives. As part of this effort, diversity should be represented in the decision-making teams and leadership should demonstrate a good example of encouraging and valuing dissenting opinions. Second, establish transparent decision-making protocols that incorporate dissent such as soliciting diverse opinions, considering dissenting viewpoints, and outlining how decisions are reached. As part of the protocols, establishing regular feedback mechanisms and acknowledging and appreciating dissent can be crucial. Lastly, make sure to establish clear communication channels such as suggestion boxes, regular team meetings, anonymous feedback systems, or open-door policies to allow employees to express dissenting opinions without fear of reprisal.

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11

BEDROOM AND BOARDROOM

Workplace Romance and Organizational Gossip

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A workplace romance (WR) is "a nonplatonic relationship between two members of an organization in which sexual attraction is present, affection is communicated, and both members recognize the relationship to be something more than just professional and platonic" (Horan & Chory, 2011, p. 565). Twenty-seven percent of American employees have had a WR (SHRM Research Institute, 2023). WRs are one type of personal workplace relationship (PWR): "voluntary, informal, mutual, and consensual relationships between two members of the same organization that are marked by a strong emotional component and the partners' knowing and communicating with each other as whole, unique persons" (Horan et al., 2021, p. 47).

Beyond WRs, some coworkers get romantically involved for the short-term or engage in sexual activity (SA) outside of a relationship. The frequency with which WR/SA occurs and the interactions between the parties and other employees give rise to gossip. Rumors, disclosure, secrets, communication restrictions, and public messaging concerning these relationships and interactions also occur.

The purpose of this chapter is to synthesize research on organizational communication about WR/SA, particularly gossip, and to interrogate organizational approaches to managing WR/SA. We conclude with

recommendations for research and practice—all with the goal of informing employee communication.

Gossip and Related Phenomena

Based on prior definitions, *workplace gossip* is informal, evaluative communication (talk, texting, email) of a personal nature between (or among a small group of) employees about another employee who is unaware of the communication. Gossip may be positive (praising, defending) or negative (maligning, disparaging; Noon & Delbridge, 1993) and varies in its focus (e.g., the target's performance, career, behavior, relationships). Kurland and Pelled (2000) distinguish between work-related and non-work-related gossip. Given work/life blending, WR/SA gossip encompasses both types (Horan et al., 2021).

A related phenomenon is *rumor*: information that is unconfirmed, speculative, or lacks evidence and tends to focus on events rather than people (Foster, 2004; Noon & Delbridge, 1993). Rumors serve to interpret or make sense of ambiguous or threatening situations about which formal information is lacking (Clegg & van Iterson, 2009).

Because gossip is often gendered as feminine, it is said to concern the private sphere of emotions, the body, the home, and the personal lives of others. In addition, gossip is more strongly linked to interpersonal social control and the upholding of group norms than is rumor. Rumor purportedly occurs in the "male" public sphere of rationalism, the mind, and the workplace (Hafen, 2004). According to this tradition, gossip "is entertaining, whereas rumors are typically about matters of importance" (Houmanfar & Johnson, 2003, p. 119).

Horan et al. (2021) argue it is important to distinguish between the relational definitions and attributions of behaviors of those within the relationship (insider) and outside of it (outsider), as they likely differ (Duck & Sants, 1983). For instance, WR partners may consider workplace affection to be appropriate, whereas other employees see it as inappropriate and gossip about it (Horan et al., 2019).

Self-disclosure and Gossip in WR/SA Development, Discovery, and Risk

In WR Development

Social Penetration Theory (Altman & Taylor, 1973) suggests that we disclose to others at work to form relationships that vary in closeness (Horan et al., 2021). Similarly, we may engage in coworker gossip to initiate WRs/SA. Sharing gossip is associated with workplace friendship formation (Rosnow, 2001) and the reinforcement of workplace friends' social bonds through increased intimacy and enjoyment (Foster, 2004; Hafen, 2004; Michelson & Mouly, 2002; Sun et al., 2023). In fact, Dunbar (2004) asserted that bonding may be gossip's most meaningful function—however, it can be risky.

In WR Discovery

Disclosing one's WR/SA to coworkers runs the risk of employees communicating that information to additional employees. Communication Privacy Management theory (Petronio, 2002) purports that individuals own their private information and have a right to not disclose it. For example, employees may choose to disclose their WRs/SAs to organizational peers and communicate the expectation that the peers will not share it. Even so, peers may share the disclosure in the form of gossip—thus, disclosure is risky.

Quinn (1977) reported that fear of gossip prevented WR partners from disclosing their WRs. Later, Cowan and Horan (2014a) revealed that employees learned of WRs through personal disclosures and impersonal revelations, which includes gossip.

Within the WR/SA

As similarity is key to attraction in WRs (Cowan & Horan, 2014b), communication about shared interests, such as work, occurs. Potentially, colleagues may discuss their protocol compliance, (dis)like of peers, and confidential information. Such communication may place the discloser at risk for punitive action and the receiver in a position to unfairly benefit from shared information. Communication privacy management theory (Petronio, 2002) informs this process, as does relational dialectics theory (Baxter & Montgomery, 1996).

Relational dialectics theory (Baxter & Montgomery, 1996) proposes that individuals may experience competing relationship needs, termed *tensions*. Bridge and Baxter (1992) identified various dialectical tensions in workplace friendships, including *openness-closedness*. Openness-closedness is particularly relevant here, as WR/SA partners may desire to

share information about all aspects of their lives, including work (i.e., openness), at the same time they are motivated to follow organizational confidentiality policies by not sharing certain information (i.e., closedness). This tension is likely more complex in status-differential relationships or those in which one partner has greater access to privileged information. Variations in access likely influence the breadth and depth of disclosure and the potential for conflict when disclosure expectations are violated. Contrarily, WR/SA partners sharing privileged information with each other likely fosters closeness and trust.

It is important to consider the complicating role of SA, particularly *pillow talk* (communication following sex; Denes, 2012), in sharing gossip. Orgasm releases oxytocin, which is linked to trust and factors that may encourage disclosure (Denes, 2018, 2021). Pillow talk presents an organizational risk as partners may disclose in greater breadth and depth (e.g., proprietary information) as they chat or gossip following sex (Horan et al., 2021). Given the short-term influence of these biological outcomes, partners may later regret disclosures—something more common in casual versus committed sexual relationships (Denes, 2012).

WR/SA as a Gossip Topic

Gossip about WRs and employee sexual liaisons "invariably (and rapidly)" spreads throughout the organization (Michelson & Mouly, 2002, p. 59). For instance, fellow employees' romantic and/or sexual relationships were among the most common employee gossip topics (Vallade & Chory, 2013). Fifty-eight percent of US employees report having heard WR gossip (Main & Hansen, 2023). Furthermore, Millennial organizational members reported coworker gossip as a negative WR effect (Chory & Gillen Hoke, 2019). Finally, hierarchical WRs and those believed to be job-motivated were associated with more frequent gossip (Dillard, 1987; Pierce et al., 1996), as was the lack of a WR policy (Chory & Offstein, 2025).

WR participants perceived gossip about WRs as more positive than did third parties (Dillard, 1987), supporting research showing WR participants tend to underestimate WR's negative effects (Chory & Gillen Hoke, 2023). Attributions of WR motives and gender also influence the nature of gossip surrounding WRs. Dillard (1987) indicated that attributions of job motives to female (but not male) WR participants prompted negative gossip, whereas attributions of love motives to male (but not female) participants led to positive gossip. Influenced by

Dillard's results, Pierce et al.'s (1996) WR model proposes that WR generates gossip, a relationship moderated by the WR motive and status dynamic.

Relationships *suspected* of WR/SA also give rise to employee gossip (Cowan & Horan, 2014a). Cross-sex friends worry that coworkers may misinterpret the friendship as sexual or romantic (Elsesser & Peplau, 2006). Similarly, many employees characterized cross-sex workplace friendships they had observed as having a romantic or sexual component (Gillen Hoke & Chory, 2015). Importantly, WRs/SAs attempting to present as simple friendships or mentoring relationships may be subject to even harsher scrutiny and gossip if suspected of WR/SA (Cowan & Horan, 2014a; Gillen Hoke & Chory, 2015).

Boren and Veksler (2015) identified both WR *and* gossip as sources of communicatively restricted organizational stress: "a perceived inability to communicate about a particular stressor" (p. 34). Thus, though gossip about WR/SA occurs, employees may also *avoid* talking about these relationships.

Effects of WR/SA Gossip on Employees

WRs/SAs may spark gossip that damages reputations and relationships with coworkers. WRs/SAs may also deter negative gossip or temper its harmful effects. Here, we describe gossip's effects and the circumstances under which WRs/SAs may moderate them.

On WR/SA Participants' Reputations

Workplace reputation is a belief shared among members of a workplace about a member's overall appeal, favorability, or attractiveness (Baer et al., 2018). Gossip may affect one's reputation (e.g., through lower performance evaluations), and one's reputation (e.g., as having "slept one's way to the top") may stimulate gossip (Sun et al., 2023).

Research indicates that gossip about WRs was associated with WR participants suffering professional reputational damage (Chory & Offstein, 2025). Ragins (1989) noted that gossip about the potential romantic or sexual nature of a female subordinate-male supervisor workplace relationship is especially likely to harm the woman's career development, consistent with research on WR's disproportionate harm to women's professional reputations (Chory et al., 2025) and credibility (Horan & Chory, 2011, 2013). As engaging in a single WR can destroy a

long-held professional reputation (Chory et al., 2025), one "well-placed negative remark by a powerful gossiper" (Giardini & Wittek, 2019, p. 3) can do the same.

Employees with formal power have the ability to ruin reputations through negative WR/SA gossip. However, gossip may also be used by marginalized and lower status employees. For example, secretaries often have privileged access to otherwise private information, and they tend to occupy central positions in networks, both of which enable them to effectively spread reputationally damaging information about their superiors (Kanter, 1977). Their "knowledge of …the mistresses and 'secret' lovers, the office affairs in all their detail" enhances their prestige among similarly situated employees (Clegg & van Iterson, 2009, p. 278) and gives them power over their bosses (Michelson et al., 2010). Similarly, deliberately communicating inaccurate information about other employees may damage their professional status, while strengthening that of the gossiper (Michelson & Mouly, 2002). Relatedly, information manipulation has been linked to WR (Chory & Gillen Hoke, 2023; Horan & Chory, 2009, 2013; Malachowski et al., 2012).

Finally, negative gossip is considered a form of indirect aggression (Baumeister et al., 2004) and implicit threat (Kurland & Pelled, 2000). Likewise, perceptions of injustice and rivalry stemming from WRs/SAs (Chory & Gillen Hoke, 2023; Malachowski et al., 2012) produce feelings of resentment, envy, and/or jealousy (Chory & Gillen Hoke, 2019), resulting in third-party antisocial behavior (e.g., malicious gossip; Baumeister et al., 2004) to restore the perceived inequity (Horan & Chory, 2009; Horan et al., 2021; Malachowski et al., 2012).

On WR/SA Participants' Relationships with Third-Party Employees

Negative workplace gossip fosters interpersonal conflict (Michelson & Mouly, 2002) and damages WR/SA partners' relationships with coworkers. For example, Burt (2005) showed that bankers targeted by negative gossip had trouble establishing productive relationships with colleagues and prematurely left the organization. Similarly, WR gossip was associated with WR participants voluntarily exiting organizations, transferring, or leaving the geographic area (Chory & Offstein, 2025). Furthermore, receiving WR/SA-focused gossip was associated with employees thinking differently about the partners, becoming more aware

of their behavior, and scrutinizing and criticizing them more frequently (Vallade & Chory, 2013).

Although WRs/SAs may be an impetus or topic of gossip, they can also help to prevent negative gossip or temper gossip's negative effects. Giardini and Wittek (2019) offered three explanations particularly relevant to WR/SA as to why individuals may not share negative gossip. First, employees who are friends with one or both of the WR/SA partners are unlikely to share negative gossip because they do not want to harm the partner(s') reputation(s). Second, when the potential gossip receiver is friends with one or both partner(s), employees are unlikely to share negative gossip about the partners because they do not want to jeopardize their relationship with the receiver and/or one or both of the WR/SA participant(s), themselves. Third, employees are unlikely to spread negative WR/SA gossip when they greatly depend on one or both of the partners and/or one or both of the partners has the power to impose loss or sanction (e.g., termination, ostracism) against the gossiper. WR/SA participants who are respected, liked, and well-connected throughout the organization, as well as those who hold formal power, are likely to fall into this category. Note that in all these cases, WR participants enjoy the protective benefits afforded by their own PWRs and status, as well as those afforded by their WR partner.

On WR/SA Participants' Relationships with Each Other

Because gossip can create a workplace environment reproachful of WRs/SAs, employees in such workplaces may be less inclined to initiate or continue their WR/SA, even when WRs/SAs are permissible (Michelson et al., 2010). Moreover, employees may go "underground" (Mainiero & Jones, 2013, p. 197) with their WRs or end them to avoid sanctions associated with policies or norms enforced by the gossip.

Conversely, being negatively gossiped about and ostracized (Gillen Hoke & Chory, 2015; Quinn, 1977), may force partners to rely more heavily on one another for support and companionship. The partners may develop an "us versus them" mentality that increases intimacy, strengthening their WR/SA.

On Third-Party Employees

Employees who heard WR/SA gossip reported feeling ambivalent, amused, curious, and grateful to learn helpful information. They also

experienced increased awareness, caution, and awkwardness in communication (Vallade & Chory, 2013). In addition, WR gossip distracts employees—49% (Main & Hansen, 2023) to 70% (SHRM, 2013) of employees report this—thereby reducing productivity (Lickey et al., 2009).

WRs/SAs may create cliques (Horan & Chory, 2009), leading some third parties to see themselves as out-group members (Chory & Gillen Hoke, 2019; Gillen Hoke & Chory, 2015; Pillemer & Rothbard, 2018; Quinn, 1977). WR/SA gossip among these out-group members is likely to increase their group's solidarity and sense of protection from the WR/SA partners' group (Dunbar, 2004; Michelson & Mouly, 2002; Noon & Delbridge, 1993; Sun et al., 2023). Supporting this reasoning, Vallade and Chory (2013) found that receiving WR-related gossip was associated with an increased sense of camaraderie, inclusion, and belonging with employees other than the gossip targets.

Organizational Effects of Gossip and Rumors about WR/SA

Stakeholders increasingly inquire into company reputation (George et al., 2016), which makes it increasingly vital to understand factors that influence it. Lickey et al. (2009) notes: "An organization's image and public relations can clearly be negatively impacted by workplace romances" (p. 110; see Gurchiek, 2023). Even so, only 3% of HR professionals said their organization's public image was harmed by an exposed WR (SHRM, 2013).

Communication about employees' WRs/SAs may occur internally, via gossip and rumors, or externally through press releases, legal filings, and investigative reporting. Gossip that travels across different companies can affect political behavior and inter-organizational relations (van Iterson & Clegg, 2008).

Corporate executives, HR professionals, and Management and Organizational scholarship often conflate WR/SA and sexual harassment or consider WR/SA relevant only in terms of how it relates to sexual harassment. As such, scholars tend to forego studying the independent effects of WR/SA on firm-level outcomes in favor of examining sexual harassment's effects. Sexual harassment research indicates that the public disclosure (e.g., company press releases, media reports) of harassment by publicly traded firms is associated with negative stock market reactions (Baker et al., 2021; Borelli-Kjaer et al., 2021; Bouzzine & Lueg, 2022).[1]

Recommendations for Practice

Based on our own research and that reviewed here, we offer recommendations for practice.

1. **Organizations should have a protocol and policy regarding WR/SA**. Our views on WR policies (Chory & Horan, 2023; Horan et al., 2021, 2024) align with Boyd (2010), who argued that organizational problems have sources other than WR. If companies have effective policies to deal with these problems, then "there is no need to prohibit one small possible source of them. The social costs of banning workplace romance are just too great…" (p. 334). Still, we understand that some organizations face legal, financial, and/or public relations imperatives to have a reporting protocol. In such cases, we recommend the protocol be readily available on the organization's internal website (Chory et al., 2025; Horan et al., 2024).
2. **If organizations require reporting of WR/SA, they should (a) have one designated HR professional to manage the process and (b) WR/SA participants should dictate how the information is managed**. We recommend that one employee be responsible for WR policy and that WR participants should disclose to this particular employee. The option for online disclosure should also be available (Chory et al., 2025). We echo the directive of Chory et al. (2025, p. 99): "Organizations should also consider how they will keep this information private, as they do with other private employee information (e.g., legally protected health issues), and this privacy policy should be communicated in the WR policy". Organizations tend to be most concerned with protecting the firm from WR-/SA-related damage, but they should also be concerned with protecting the people involved. If one or both WR/SA partners want HR to keep the information private, their request(s) should be honored to the extent possible. If one partner wants it to be kept private and the other wants it to be made public, it should remain private.
3. **Organizations should have press release language prepared to respond to WR-/SA-related media stories**. Such language should include their WR/SA policy and how the organization protects WR participants and other employees. Given that media coverage of *consensual* WR/SA often occurs within the context of sexual

harassment, the organization should clearly describe the *consensual* nature of the WR/SA.

Future Research and Considerations

Many WR/SA and gossip topics warrant further consideration. First, **if a company requires disclosure, at what point must disclosure occur?** Horan et al. (2021) described the ambiguity surrounding flirting and dating goals as well as concerns about the point at which a WR/SA must be disclosed: "Should action be taken when the relationship is made public or becomes exclusive, when sexual contact has occurred, when the couple has gone on three public outings?" (p. 30). Future research is necessary to better understand disclosure timing and impact.

Second**, should an employee's job change due to a close relationship?** Job reassignments, resignations, and terminations are common reactions to WR/SA but not to other types of PWRs (e.g., cross-sex workplace friendships). The question becomes, then, why do employees in certain types of PWRs (e.g., new WRs) face job-related consequences, while those in potentially *closer* PWRs (e.g., career-long best friends) face none? Why are PWRs marked by a [potential] sexual component or physical attraction deemed especially dangerous and how scientifically valid are these reasons?

Third, there is a need to **further examine love contracts**, that is, agreements signed by the partners stating the WR is voluntary, consensual, and unrelated to their organizational relationship, and that either partner may end the relationship without negative job consequences (Mainiero & Jones, 2013). We contend that the term *love contract* may discourage individuals from signing such agreements because their relationships are not [yet] love-based. Many relationships fail, some involve infidelity, and others exist purely for sexual purposes; love is not a goal. Watkins and colleagues (2022) recently reported that romantic partners tend to say "I love you" around the four-month mark, so signing a love contract in the first month of the relationship may feel "too soon" for the partners. Based on our arguments and Horan et al. (2021), we encourage a reconsideration of this label.

An additional consideration is that **sex occurs outside of established relationships** (e.g., extramarital affairs). In addition, an employee in a consensually non-monogamous relationship may have sex with a colleague (i.e., no infidelity). Because these liaisons may only involve short-term (but undefined), non-relationship, or sexual goals, participants

would likely not be motivated to sign a *love contract*. They might also fail to disclose their SAs because it is not a conventional romantic relationship (Horan et al., 2024). When developing WR policies, companies should be clear as to whether the policies pertain exclusively to WRs or they also include employee SAs.

Fifth, **WR/SA scholars are encouraged to more fully explore the range of workplace sexual and romantic relationships that occur**. Research should consider friends with benefits relationships, one-night stands, polyamorous relationships, extra-relational/-marital affairs, consensually non-monogamous individuals in WRs/SAs (no infidelity)—to name a few. Sex occurs in a variety of relationships and forms that may, or may not, constitute WR—it is time WR/SA research aligns with reality.

A final consideration pertains to **established relationships**. Much of the WR research and media coverage focuses on newer relationships. Less understood is the established couple (e.g., married) who works together. It is assumed that established relationships are viewed differently than new ones. These relationships may create a power advantage for the couple. Married couples may also be celebrated by colleagues and the organization, treatment much different than that received by WR/SA partners. Research on established PWRs is encouraged.

Conclusions

WRs/SAs are not uncommon, and one reaction to these relationships is gossip. Banning such relationships is neither practical nor ethical; organizations should be prepared to manage the ensuing gossip and its effects. Accordingly, organizations are encouraged to have clear and considerate WR/SA policies and appropriate external messaging in place to respond to media inquiries or scandals related to WR/SA.

Note

1. Baker and colleagues (2021) examined media reports of managers' sexually-oriented behavior (harassing and non-harassing) in publicly-traded companies and the effect these reports had on firm performance. However, they mischaracterize non-harassing sexual behavior as "workplace romance." What they label "workplace romance" includes WRs/SAs, as well as sex-related crimes (e.g.,

rape), accusations of inappropriate behavior, WRs that involved corporate wrongdoing, and lurid sexual relationships between high-level executives and non-employees.

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12

ORGANIZATIONAL SECRECY

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At its most basic level, *secrecy* can be defined as "consciously willed concealment" (Simmel, 1906, p. 449). Secrets are organizationally significant because, as Keane (2008) noted:

> when we are not privy to the existence and essence of a secret, whether important or trivial, we are forced to accept a reality different from the reality of the secret holder(s). Indeed, we are forced to accept the reality portrayed or presented by the secret holder(s). As such, secret holders occupy a position of power in that by withholding knowledge, they are able to shape a particular construction of reality.
>
> *(p. 109)*

Therefore, understanding how secrecy functions in a context where individual activities must be coordinated toward collective goals is of critical importance for employees, managers, and organizational stakeholders. After all, each of these groups is variously affected by organizational attempts to employ protective mechanisms (Liebeskind, 1997) to institutionalize secrecy practices into their operations and to motivate organizational members to cooperate in strategic concealment and revelation of differential information. As such, they ought to be better equipped to understand what Costas and Grey (2016) describe as the "hidden architecture" of organizational secrecy: "Hiding information from some while sharing it with others creates particular communication grids with different channels and networks; these grids and channels are 'constitutive' of organizations…" (p. 11). This chapter summarizes

recent research in organizational communication, management, and allied fields to explain both the social conditions that enable and constrain organizational secrecy, as well as the social consequences of secrecy practices for organizational members and stakeholders.

Beginning with a critique of the "transparency bias" in organizational theory and practice, this chapter differentiates "organizational secrecy" from related terms such as anonymity, privacy, deception, and organizational ignorance. In so doing, distinctions are drawn between *formal* versus *informal* secrecy in organizations, as well as *internal* versus *external* secrecy practices (e.g., secrecy practices *within* an organization versus *between* an organization and external stakeholders—as is often the case with hidden organizations). This chapter concludes with a discussion of directions for future research, especially concerning the relationship between secrecy practices and ethical communication, power and control, and technological innovation/artificial intelligence.

A Bias toward Transparency

According to the Web of Science, scholarly interest in organizational *transparency* has steadily risen over the last two decades, from a low of two publications in 2000 to a high of 336 publications in 2021. During that same date range, publication records show a parallel, but much more modest, increase in scholarly interest in the topic of organizational *secrecy*—only 247 scholarly manuscripts total, with a peak of 28 publications in 2022. However, these two concepts are inextricably related. To the extent that secrecy involves practices of concealment, transparency implies the opposite: revelation, or at least, the absence of concealment. And, as digital technological advancements have reduced the cost to store and disseminate information, there has been a substantial increase in public expectations regarding the availability and accessibility of data on previously private, confidential, or secret internal organizational operations (Heimstädt, 2017; Wehmeier & Raaz, 2012).

One explanation for the sudden uptick in scholarly attention paid to transparency is that the term has become so valorized in corporate contexts, nonprofit organizing, and political governance, creating something of a zeitgeist around the unquestionable good of visibility. Over the last century, democratic governments have increasingly celebrated and codified practices of "open" governance (such as, in the United States, with the creation of the Federal Register in 1935, the establishment of the Administrative Procedure Act of 1946, and the

implementation of the Freedom of Information Act in 1966) as virtuous prerequisites for clear understanding of complex social problems and informed decision-making on difficult policy issues (Birchall, 2011). Within and beyond the context of political organizations, promises of transparency suggest the possibility of knowledge, truth, and accountability—aspirational and apparently noble goals in the face of high-profile cases of political and corporate greed, corruption, and fraud.

However, the luster of transparency dims when the ideal is subjected to critical scrutiny. A common aphorism is often invoked when public discussion turns to issues of surveillance and security: "If you have nothing to hide, you have nothing to fear". Critical management scholars are quick to remind us, though, that "although information availability has emancipatory potential by providing insight into the circles of power, it simultaneously allows the rulers to monitor their subjects" (Flyverbom et al., 2015, p. 390). Indeed, turning to the political realm, Birchall (2011) warns, "A regime that embraces transparency will only ever be able to go so far before it tips over into totalitarianism…" (p. 12). These fears of total transparency are somewhat unfounded in our current technological moment. Short of recording, publishing, and storing every action of people, perfect transparency is an impossibility. Indeed, even if every organizational detail were surveilled, recorded, and made available to the public, the sheer quantity of information would produce a "data smog" (Shenk, 1997) that would obscure as well as any intentional act of concealment. Nevertheless, many a dystopian novel—such as George Orwell's *1984*, or more recently, Dave Egger's *The Circle*—takes as its starting point a world where demands for openness justify constant surveillance and control and produce ever more oppressive systems for organizing society. That being said, every now and then, science fiction does eventually become reality. Understanding transparency, then, as a persistent, pervasive, and potentially prescient or pernicious myth that exerts significant influence in organizing practices (Christensen & Cornelissen, 2015) is an important starting point for justifying a focus on the lesser-examined inverse: organizational secrecy.

Distinguishing Secrecy from Related Concepts

Given the valorization of transparency as an organizational value, secrecy, as its apparent antonym, has often carried negative connotations of dishonesty, deceit, and unethicality. Certainly, processes of secrecy sequester information, away from critique or question, and so, "no matter

how benign the motives of insiders are, the lack of public scrutiny increases the likelihood that the secret action may have unintended undesirable and possibly unethical consequences" (Anand & Rosen, 2008). While that concern has merit, it is still important to emphasize that secrecy is not the same phenomenon as deception, as Sissela Bok (1989) explained:

> The link between secrecy and deceit is so strong in the minds of some that they mistakenly take all secrecy (especially when protected by silence) to be deceptive. In so doing, they confuse secrecy with what is undoubtedly a common means for preserving it.
>
> *(p. 7)*

In this way, deception might be thought of as a subtype of secrets in which the information being concealed "is that one is misrepresenting the facts" (Gibson, 2014, p. 285). Considering, then, the ease with which secrecy is conflated with related terms, it is important parse out the distinguishing features of *secrecy* in relation to other associated concepts, such as anonymity and privacy.

First, anonymity may be considered a subcategory of secrecy, in which the specific information being concealed is that which would make an entity identifiable. Etymologically, to be *anonymous* means to be nameless or without a name. To be fully anonymous, according to Marx (1999) means that an entity cannot be identified by any dimension of identity knowledge, such as: legal name, locatability (e.g., physical or mailing address, telephone number, email address), pseudonyms (including numeric identifiers like tax ID numbers or account numbers), distinctive appearance or behavioral patterns, social categorization (e.g., belonging to a particular "type" or "class" of entity), or symbols of eligibility/noneligibility (e.g., involving the possession of relevant passwords, codes, tickets, badges, or skills). Research on anonymous communication has sought to better understand source decisions to reveal or conceal identity information (Anonymous, 1998), as well as the conditions shaping receivers' responses to anonymous messages (Rains & Scott, 2007). The power of anonymity lies in "the possibility it affords people to establish a connection with others while avoiding responsibility" (Frois, 2009, p. 151). This consequence of anonymity may contribute to negative evaluations when identity secrecy allows an entity to avoid responsibility for actions that have consequences for

others. However, anonymous communication also allows people in vulnerable or low positions of power and credibility to exert influence, provide feedback, report wrongdoings, or seek support through avenues that might not be readily available otherwise in contexts of high power differences.

One reason for anonymous communication is to preserve the privacy of the communicator. Privacy, "a state of being free from the observation or disturbances of other people" (Bean, 2017, p. 1), typically refers to desires to control access to information considered to belong to a personal domain. As such, privacy overlaps with secrecy "whenever the efforts at such control rely on hiding. But privacy need not hide; and secrecy hides far more than what is private" (Bok, 1989, p. 11). Therefore, while it is feasible for one to focus on secrecy practices that maintain a person's anonymity in the interest of protecting their privacy, this must be understood as a very specific intersection in a constellation of overlapping but distinct concepts.

In conclusion, while terms like deception, anonymity, and privacy may overlap in various ways with organizational secrecy, they each encompass distinct concepts within the broader spectrum of organizational communication and information management. Organizational secrecy involves the deliberate withholding of information and to the extent that these other processes involve practices of concealment, they may at times converge with one another. However, understanding the nuances of these terms is crucial for the future of research in these areas, as we refine our understanding of these distinct and overlapping processes and gain deeper insight into the most hidden organizing practices shaping our social world.

Defining Organizational Secrecy

Scholars in organizational studies, management, public relations, and related fields are increasingly recognizing that, far from being an exceptional or rare form of communication, secrecy is a common and integral part of organizational life. A government agency restricts access to confidential coordinates of a military unit. A company protects plans for a new product to maintain a competitive edge. A couple of colleagues huddle behind closed office doors to debrief after a particularly contentious meeting. Gossip is exchanged at the watercooler, in the hallway, or through the private chat function on a virtual call. All of these moments involve *organizational secrecy*, which Costas and Grey (2014)

define as "the ongoing formal and informal social processes of intentional concealment of information from actors by actors in organizations" (p. 1423). Given the richness of this definition, it is worth breaking down into a few constitutive claims: (1) organizational secrecy is an ongoing process; (2) this process involves acts of intentional concealment; (3) these acts can be performed in formal or informal social contexts; and (4) information is concealed from actors by actors in organizations.

An Ongoing Process

First, this definition of organizational secrecy as an *ongoing process* suggests that it is rarely an isolated event. Rather, secrecy often requires a series of acts to maintain the precarious boundaries between those who know the secret and those who do not. Secrecy, then, is not merely about concealing knowledge, intentions, or actions, but also it entails processes of selective sharing. After all, secrecy processes create "the possibility of a second world alongside the obvious world" (Simmel, 1906, p. 462). For those who are privy to a secret, they are bound together, dependent upon one another's performances with out-group members to maintain the concealed status of their shared knowledge:

Concealed information separates one group from another and one person from the rest.

> What I know and you do not demonstrates that we are not identical, that we are separate people. The difference can create a hierarchy, wherein secrecy cedes social power to those who control the flow of treasured information.
>
> *(Luhrmann, 1989, p. 137)*

While concealed information is almost always perceived to have high value—whether strategic, personal, or otherwise—that value is not necessarily inherent to the informational asset. Rather, the very fact that something is being kept secret can and often does enhance the perception that the information is important, dangerous, or otherwise valuable (Costas & Grey, 2016).

Given the vulnerability of the boundaries between those in-the-know and those on the outs, "secrecy always creates the possibility of accidental or deliberate disclosures or revelations" (Costas & Grey, 2016, p. 12). Organizational actors may attempt to mitigate the risk of

unwanted secret-sharing through the implementation of protective mechanisms, such as (1) punitive rules restricting knowledge-sharing, social interaction, or physical access across units or organizational roles; (2) high-powered compensation schemes incentivizing in-group loyalty and disincentivizing information-sharing with "outsiders"; and (3) isolating design features making contact, collaboration, or information-sharing difficult due to geographical separation and/or secure perimeters (Liebeskind, 1997). However, once implemented, these mechanisms require various levels of ongoing monitoring and maintenance to avoid leakages. After all, "the burden of secrecy may not just be about the fear of disclosure; it may also be about the temptations to disclose secrets. The two may be related: one way to unburden oneself is to reveal secrets" (Costas & Grey, 2016, p. 129). And, certainly, there are often personal and professional motivations to reveal secret information: secret-sharing involves the disclosure of informational assets that are often perceived to be valuable, for the cultivation of interpersonal trust, the performance of intimacy, or for strategic and utilitarian ends.

Of Intentional Concealment

Beyond the recognition that secrecy involves ongoing protective practices to maintain the boundaries between those in-the-know and those not, it is worth lingering on the claim that these practices involve *intentional concealment*. This language suggests that acts of accidental omission or ignorance fall outside the parameters of the term. This distinction is important given increasing scholarly attention to how organizations are necessarily composed of individuals and groups with various interests, specializations, and patterns of ignorance (Roberts, 2022). While a certain amount of shared knowledge is typically required for organizations to coordinate action toward superordinate goals, organizational life is also characterized by differential knowledge and so ignorance is regularly and pervasively created and sustained, whether intentionally or not (Jalonen, 2024). Importantly, organizational ignorance only overlaps with organizational secrecy when it is the *deliberate*, *strategic*, or *willful suppression* of knowledge by some organizational actor(s) that produces conditions of not-knowing among some other (internal or external) actor(s). For example, the maintenance of trade secrets, such as the Google search or Facebook algorithms, is accomplished through secrecy practices that restrict access and suppress knowledge so as to produce organizational ignorance.

Performed in Formal or Informal Social Contexts

A third characteristic defining organizational secrecy is that it may be performed in formal or informal social contexts. From this situational distinction emerges a bifurcated category system in which *formal secrecy* involves the concealment of "knowledge that is codified and documented and shared by official access" (Costas & Grey, 2016, p. 43), and *informal secrecy* involves those secrets that are spread in the more elusive, ephemeral spaces of everyday social interactions. Importantly, it is not only the practices of concealing and protecting information that can be considered formal or informal, but also the sanctions for betrayal. Unauthorized disclosures of information protected by formal secrecy—which tends to be protected by laws, rules, and official regulations—are often punished with legal action or dismissal from employment. Organizations often have powerful resources, such as nondisclosure agreements and other contractually binding documents, at their disposal to enforce formal secrecy; however, the written, codified nature of the information protected by these practices make it vulnerable to being leaked (Ringel, 2019), as demonstrated by high-profile examples of whistleblowing in organizations. In contrast, sharing confidential gossip or clarifying protected tacit knowledge outside of a trusted social or professional clique—the sort of information typically protected by informal secrecy—is more likely to lead to ostracism from the in-group or social disapproval (Fan et al., 2017). Despite the important differences between these social contexts, recent research demonstrates how these contexts inextricably influence each other: "not only can informal secrecy be an (unintended) by-product of the increase or decrease of formal secrecy (Costas & Grey, 2014), but formal secrecy can be a by-product of informal secrecy" (Fan & Liu, 2022).

Taken together, then, the rules and policies dictating practices of formal secrecy interact with and supplement the norms, shared beliefs, and traditions of informal secrecy to shape the culture of secrecy in any given organization and often have consequences for organizational members both within and beyond the workplace. For example, Alumna Kepten (2023) interviewed workers from a covert Israeli national security organization who provided insight into how organizational secrecy practices were consequential as both an external hurdle and a central component of workers' identity-building efforts. While their occupational identities are valued aspects of their sense of self, these workers are also severely restricted in what they can talk about regarding

their jobs outside of a small group of organizational insiders. As Wolfe et al. (2018) explained, the consequences of (formal and informal) organizational secrecy often extend far beyond the workplace because, "when secrecy norms demand the concealment of certain roles—that is, when a person cannot 'claim' personal or occupational identity knowledge—they also forfeit reasonable expectation for others to treat them as that kind of individual" (p. 213). As a result, work experiences that are shrouded in secrecy may amplify perceptions of organizational or occupational in-groupness (what Kreiner et al., 2006 define as *entitativity*) while simultaneously limiting networks of social support.

From Actors by Actors in Organizations

Finally, while it might seem obvious that organizational secrecy involves concealing information from some actors by other actors in organizations, a close consideration of this claim helps us to distinguish between *internal* versus *external* secrecy practices. Internal secrecy practices are often consequences of clear divisions of labor among defined roles and other organizational structures that codify knowledge along the boundaries of categorical or hierarchical power relations. In fact, Max Weber (1924/1968) asserted that a preoccupation with secrecy is an essential, inherent feature of administrative institutions; after all, the cultivation of ignorance outside of one's area of expertise minimizes the likelihood of criticism. Toegel et al. (2022) demonstrated how middle managers purposefully select and recruit organizational members to participate in carefully orchestrated and controlled secrecy processes to promote internal initiatives, especially when they do not initially perceive strong support for a change. This study suggested that secrecy practices captured the attention of recruited participants, enhanced their sense of psychological safety to process negative emotions like anxiety or embarrassment, and triggered a sense of reciprocity whereby participants often felt compelled to support the initiative. In this way, organizational leaders may cultivate support for unpopular initiatives through strategic, selective, and sequenced secrecy practices that build buy-in from key actors in an organization prior to making a more public announcement. While a certain amount of secrecy may be necessary in early phases of innovation, *horizontal secrecy*, which inhibits the flow of information across teams, appears to constrain the development of peer-to-peer relationships and problem-solving across organizational units, often hampering strategic renewal efforts (Schildt et al., 2024).

Whereas internal secrecy practices construct corridors of connection and walls of ignorance between organizational members, external secrecy practices control the flow of information to (potential) clients, competitors, critics, suppliers, supporters, and other external stakeholders. While all organizations have motivations to monitor and control their reputation and projected external image, a concern regarding the external flow of information is a central focus of those entities that scholars now describe as *hidden organizations*: "where the identity of the organization and/or its members is heavily concealed, for a variety of reasons, from various audiences" (Scott, 2015, pp. 503–504). Scott (2013) suggested three key dimensions for analyzing the relative hiddenness of an organization: (1) organizational visibility, ranging from relatively recognizable to relatively anonymous; (2) member identification, ranging from relatively expressed to relatively silent; and (3) relevant audience, ranging from relatively mass/public to relatively local/limited. For organizations operating in the shadows, practices of secrecy, then, constrict the flow of information to external stakeholders in ways that minimize visibility so as to enable relative anonymity, silence member identification so as to limit recognition of agents affiliated with the organization; and restrict the audience for their messaging to a relatively small, local, or selective group of relevant stakeholders. While it may be tempting to assume that hidden organizations are illicit and illegal, to do so is to make the same mistake as to assume that all secrets are unethical and destructive. The wide range of clandestine organizations that operate in the shadows is united by "a persisting pattern of relationships which directly and indirectly links the participants in related secret activities" (Erickson, 1981, p. 189). As such, their organizational activities are shaped by the dialectical tensions of visibility–invisibility and revelation–concealment. As Wolfe and Blithe's (2015) study of Nevada's legal brothel system demonstrated, shadowed organizations have visibility needs (for attracting clients or organizational members, maintaining public relations, etc.) that limit their ability to promise discretion in all operations; however, organizational members also have privacy and identity needs that may at times conflict with superordinate organizational goals. Negotiating the secrecy practices needed to sustain organization-member relations requires careful attention and understanding of the flows of information to external stakeholders.

Directions for Future Research

Considering the extensive body of literature concerning branding and organizational image in communication, management, marketing, public relations, and allied fields, our knowledge of efforts to promote organizational visibility far outpaces our understanding of organizational secrecy. However, as the scholars cited throughout this chapter have advocated, issues of organizational image management involve inextricable relationships between practices of selective openness and closedness, transparency and secrecy, and visibility and invisibility. As our scholarship continues to develop more nuanced insights into these relations, there is much to learn with regard to ethical communication, power and control, and technological innovation/artificial intelligence. Studying hidden, clandestine, and secretive organizational practices is fraught with practical and ethical challenges. After all, "traditional methods of research from both social scientific and humanistic perspectives… rely upon some degree of openness and transparency in the organization" (Stohl & Stohl, 2017, p. 5). Securing site authorization, navigating institutional review board processes, and building trust with organizational insiders all pose considerable barriers to this type of research. However, as we continue to learn from one another, we build our methodological toolkits, refine our ethical sensibilities, and attune our analytical attention to better understand not only that which is visible, obvious, and marketed, but also that which is hidden, absent, or suppressed. This concluding section briefly outlines key questions to drive future research.

Ethical Communication and Organizational Secrecy

- What are the ethical implications of organizational secrecy, especially with regard to its impact on trust, transparency, and accountability within organizations?
- What are the roles of organizational ethical frameworks and codes of conduct in guiding internal and external secrecy practices?
- How do secrecy practices align with and/or resist stated organizational values?
- How can ethical communication practices be integrated into organizational secrecy strategies to minimize negative consequences and maintain ethical standards?

Power and Control Dynamics

- How do secrecy practices reinforce or challenge existing power structures within an organization?
- How do leaders utilize secrecy to exert control over employees, and how do these practices impact employee motivation, job satisfaction, and engagement?
- How is secrecy employed as a tool for manipulation and unethical exercise of power? What can be done organizationally to prevent such abuses?

Technological Innovation and Artificial Intelligence

- What is the role of communication technologies (e.g., messaging apps, social media, collaboration platforms) in shaping organizational secrecy practices?
- How do AI-driven data analysis tools enhance or compromise secrecy strategies, and what are their potential effects on decision-making processes?
- How are organizational leaders managing ethical considerations surrounding the use of AI in managing organizational secrecy, considering issues such as privacy, bias, and algorithmic transparency?

In summary, future research on organizational secrecy should delve into the ethical dimensions, power dynamics, technological influences, cultural variations, innovation impact, legal considerations, and communication technologies that intersect with secrecy practices. By exploring these multidimensional aspects, scholars can contribute to a deeper understanding of the complex interplay between secrecy and various organizational factors, providing valuable insights for organizations striving to balance the benefits of secrecy with ethical and practical considerations.

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13

EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION AND SECRECY BREACHES

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From Edward Snowden and Chelsea Manning to, more recently, the classified US government intelligence leaks from *Discord*, employee secrecy leaks have always been known to have serious implications both for the organizations and for the employees involved. In the case of the *Discord* leaks, several news sources, including Reuters, *The New York Times*, and *Washington Post*, have reported that the leaks revealed high-level secrets about the Russia–Ukraine war and about the US government's spying on its allies. Similarly, in the wake of Hamas' attacks on Israel, a *New York Times* report from 2017 resurfaced. In that report, Goldman et al. (2017) revealed that US President Trump disclosed classified intelligence, given to him by Israel, to Russian officials in a meeting: "The revelation [added] a potential diplomatic complication to an episode that has renewed questions about how the White House [handled] sensitive intelligence" (Goldman et al., para 1).

Secrecy leaks always have implications for the individuals and organizations involved. However, as exemplified by the incidents above, secrecy and their breaches have varying consequences, depending on the kind of information disclosed and the organizations or individuals involved. Scholars from academic fields such as cybersecurity, information systems, law, and management studies have explored secrecy leaks as issues that have implications for proprietary organizational knowledge and information (see Ahmad et al., 2014; Liebeskind, 1997; Wall et al., 2015). For these scholars, organizational knowledge and information are crucial assets that provide competitive

advantage over their rivals. Yet, others like Sussman (2008) have examined how silence and non-disclosure have been used as part of the internal communication strategy for keeping organizational secrets.

In communication scholarship, employee secrecy has often been theorized as a communication management issue, particularly in the era of intensified digital communication (see Albu, 2022; Rice & Searle, 2022). Scholars like Stephens (2018) have been invested in how our inevitable dependence on mobile communications technology introduces complexities into the dynamics of control in the workplace. Such scholarship, though not directly about secrecy, opens the door to understanding how secrecy may influence organizations' expectations about employee communication. This, in turn, invites resistance from employees who may deem attempts at controlling dissemination of knowledge and information as censorship.

In this chapter, I review organizational communication and digital communication research from communication and related fields. I aim to (1) examine the ways in which secrecy has been discussed in the theoretical and empirical literature, including the ways in which secrecy has been linked to the security of organizational knowledge and information; (2) map the trends of the research on secrecy and security breaches (intentional and unintentional) at the intersection of organizational communication and digital communication research; and (3) examine the implications of organizational secrecy rules for employee censorship.

Critical Review of Literature

Secrecy, Organizational Knowledge, and Information

For management and organizational scholars, information and knowledge production, as well as how to leverage them for competitive advantage, are some of the key themes in the scholarly literature. Liebeskind (1997) explained that researchers have probed the ways in which knowledge is converted into a private asset through the deliberate and exclusionary actions of individuals and institutions. Sussman (2008) also stated that "typically, policies constraining or prohibiting employee communication are crafted for the dual purposes of increasing internal efficiency, effectiveness, and civility, and enhancing external competitiveness" (p. 332).

Throughout the literature I reviewed, secrecy and the often-inevitable breaches are interrelated issues of control: control of information, control of organizational knowledge, and control of employee communication (e.g., Grey, 2014). That is, secrecy extends beyond simply concealing information. It is a means by which control of knowledge and information is asserted. Naturally, this control cannot be exercised without instituting control of employee communication practices. A good example is pay secrecy, which, according to Caulfield (2021), is a measure of top-down organizational secrecy that restricts certain topics of interaction. This is despite the fact that, mediated by other factors, pay secrecy influences employees' decision to quit (Rodrigue & Cox, 2024).

In fact, pay is a commonly prohibited topic in many organizations, often regulated by organizational policies on pay disclosures (Scott et al., 2020). According to Scott et al., organizations are reluctant to encourage pay transparency for reasons that "include (1) desire to protect employee privacy; (2) desire to avoid conflict among employees or having to explain pay decisions; (3) disclosure of pay differences may reduce perceptions of pay equity or fairness" (pp. 85–86). Such an example fortifies that notion that disclosure rules are mediated by the need for control of employee communication.

Employees are assumed to produce knowledge through interactions with other employees and with resources provided by the organization. However, according to Liebeskind (1997), several factors account for the degree to which knowledge can be appropriated:

> These include (i) whether knowledge is codified or tacit; (ii) whether the knowledge is, or can be, possessed by individuals, rather than groups; (iii) whether the knowledge can be legally protected; and (iv) whether the knowledge can or cannot be used effectively by rival firms.
>
> *(Liebeskind, 1997, p. 626)*

Organizational knowledge that falls into the realm of "secret" is often codified, possessed by some entity (and is sometimes legally protected), and is deemed to be useful for rival firms. To this end, Sussman (2008) ultimately sees employee secrecy as an important communication management issue where, sometimes, "gag orders" are legitimate means of keeping organizational secrets: "Communication prohibitions [are] explicit rules and policies preventing or forbidding information disclosure. Such prescriptions are designed to protect information, which

if disclosed would jeopardize or put people, practices, products, or ventures at risk" (p. 332).

In the contemporary era, rules governing social interaction may include those forbidding employees from interacting with journalists regarding almost anything related to the organization. The existence of corporate affairs and public relations departments is proof of this strategy. Experts in such departments are trained, among others, on how to strategically communicate about the organization without revealing organizational secrets. As an example, at an organization I collaborated with on a research study, employees who were participants of my study refused to comment on any topics related to rumors of mergers and acquisitions within the industry, of which they were the regulator. Discussion of other issues involving customer grievances and the organization's strategic plan were prohibited by management and were, thus, not entertained during my interviews with participants.

In another example, LoMonte (2019) recounted stories of government employees' frustrations with state orders that make routine information inaccessible to the public. LoMonte narrated,

> Massachusetts Governor Charlie Baker's administration has made state employees so inaccessible for interviews that one journalist complained he was unable even to speak with a state ornithologist for a routine story about the declining population of barn swallows. In New York, the director of the New York State Museum retired in frustration over the rigid control of information under Governor Andrew Cuomo's administration, telling a reporter that his staff couldn't even respond to media questions about ladybugs.
>
> *(pp. 1–2)*

Such organizational or management policies are means of controlling employee communication even when highly confidential information is not involved, as in the examples above. Scholars have explored both the individual and organizational justifications for secrecy rules, both of which are pointed toward achieving control. While organizational leadership uses prohibition polices to control employee communication, individuals use secrets to gain or to project the sense of being in control. To illustrate, Ahmad et al. (2014) identified three types of control organizations use to restrict information access: formal (including risk assessments and policies), technical (comprising the use of firewalls, passwords, and so on), and informal (related to organizational culture).

On the individual level, those who hold secrets use them as leverage because they often assume others would want access to those secrets. Herein lies an inherent danger of secrecy: individuals have a need to hint at possessing secrets to boost their sense of importance (Fan & Grey, 2021). For instance, in the 2017 White House story cited in the introduction section above, Goldman et al. (2017) noted that

> Mr. Trump's boasting about some of Israel's most sensitive information to the Russians could damage the relationship between the two countries and raises the possibility that the information could be passed to Iran, Russia's close ally and Israel's main threat in the region.
>
> *(para 2)*

Therefore, for management, the culture within which organizational members interact among themselves and with external others is crucial to maintaining secrets. This is why "job definitions and the reporting hierarchy of a firm…serve to restrict certain interactions while promoting others" (Liebeskind, 1997, p. 633). As seen in the example above, these formal and informal measures are not always successful at preventing secrecy breaches, especially when the individual revealing those secrets is at/near the top of the organizational hierarchy. Individuals also have an incentive for disclosing secrets because they (the secrets) often generate demand for several stakeholders (Fedorenko et al., 2023).

Consequently, beyond rules and regulations for employee communication, there are other mechanisms, such as structural isolation, where organizational secrets are especially kept away from "outsiders". I have conducted research in an organization that restricts physical access to limit what organizational outsiders learn. While conducting this study, I was only given access to certain floors of the building where I was scheduled to conduct interviews with participants of my study and remember being reprimanded by security personnel for getting off the elevator on a "non-approved" floor. Such measures are expensive, according to Liebeskind (1997), because there are costs involved in acquiring software and putting up physical infrastructure to enforce such isolation. Consequently, "in 2022, the information security products and services market was forecast to exceed 172 billion U.S. dollars, up from 150 billion U.S. dollars in 2021" (Statista, 2023, para 1). Information security involves physical infrastructure such as alarms, access control structures, and surveillance cameras.

Formal and Informal Secrecy

It is important to note that secrecy has been theorized both as informal and formal phenomena. On one hand, formal secrecy, as described in the above section, involves formal processes where organizational members who are privy to certain information are enrolled through formal socialization or procedures, like signing non-disclosure agreements (NDAs). In this sense, those with knowledge of the protected information are deemed as the owners of that information. That is, the secret is the property and is, sometimes, legally protected. On the other hand, Costas and Grey (2014) contend that:

> Informal secrecy can have a particular potency for actors' identity because membership of the in-group involves being chosen by others and requires a greater degree of reciprocal trust than the more bureaucratically orchestrated procedures associated with formal secrecy.
>
> *(p. 1438)*

Nonetheless, Costas and Grey (2014) insisted that informal secrecy is more vulnerable to breaches than formal secrecy because the consequences may be more dire in the case of the former. For instance, because employees may have signed NDAs, there may be legal consequences for breaching them, whereas confidential gossip may only be punished by being ostracized from the in-group. There is no telling which consequence is worse, as this depends on the individual. Liebeskind (1997), however, disagrees about the efficacy of consequences for breaching informal secrecy:

> Social sanctions may do better than the blunt instruments of termination and legal recourse…Social control, then, operates through the threats of losing self-esteem and access to valued others, imposing significant psychological, social, and economic costs on individuals who transgress established norms.
>
> *(p. 635)*

Liebeskind's argument here is draws attention to the symbolic/cultural deterrents built into informal secrecy processes that are inherently absent in formal secrecy.

Furthermore, scholars like Michelson and Suchitra Mouly (2004) describe gossip as a form of secrecy that falls into the informal category.

Fan and Grey (2021) have also studied what they call confidential gossip and explained it to be "organizational secrecy where affiliation and allegiance are channeled via participation in or exclusion from secrets… confidential gossip must, therefore, include practices that mark the line or boundary around itself" (p. 210). Individuals involved in confidential gossip employ social norms and pressure to safeguard their secrets. Thus, confidential gossip is informal secrecy and, therefore, escapes regulation by formal communication management tools and policies.

As a communication management issue, formal and informal secrecy are distinguished by whether or not managers are able to restrict or even prohibit certain kinds of interactions. As discussed above, formal secrecy often requires clearly outlined, standardized processes that typically reinforce organizational hierarchies and bureaucratic practices. However, informal secrecy relies on social pressure/comparison and norms to keep members in check. In this sense, secrecy operates as a normative aspect of organizational life where it shapes "how actors understand, experience and behave towards themselves and others, fostering 'self-discipline' among group members" (Costas & Grey, 2014, p. 1140).

Informational versus Constitutive Approaches to Secrecy

While a majority of the secrecy literature focuses on secrets as information, there are scholars who have theorized the former as constitutive of organizations. These scholars believe that secrecy is both informational and social and can only truly be understood as both object and process (Costas & Grey, 2014). Costas and Grey explained,

> it is impossible to envisage a situation in which something was kept secret and yet no one engaged in keeping it secret; equally, it is impossible to envisage a situation in which people were engaged in the practice of secrecy and yet were not keeping anything secret.
>
> *(p. 1429)*

The existence of secrets is a signal that there are social processes, often routines, rituals, norms or practices enacted to maintain the symbolic or practical value of those secrets. Albu (2022) also noted that secrecy is juxtaposed with transparency as dialectically related and rooted in different discourses. Transparency is defined here as the process that makes something visible (Albu, 2022).

The above juxtaposition means, as opposing sides of a normative organizational process, secrecy and transparency cannot be understood without each other. Like secrecy, transparency is an informational as well as social process that influences what people can see (Flyverbom, 2019). Flyverbom argued that because so much of social life has been translated into digitalized and datafied information, transparency is a process of privileging what is visible, rather than making all things visible, in any given context. Secrecy sits on the other side of transparency, where the former is the result of the privileging of certain forms of visibilities.

Therefore, secrecy is not the absence of communication or the prohibition of communication, but rather a kind of communication created by the tension between concealment and revelation (Fan & Liu, 2022). I add that secrecy belongs to the body of communication types constrained by rules and policies, which are often enforced by (self) surveillance. That is, instead of perceiving of secrecy as an event or a moment, this approach looks at it as a human communication process that produces both concealment and revelation. The secrecy–transparency dialectic dictates that employee communication is either revealing or concealing organizational knowledge and information at all times. Additionally, in terms of employee communication, both secrecy and transparency are controlled by organizational/management policies. When an organization seeks to keep a piece of information secret, there are usually formal and informal policies that guard employee communication with regard to the secret. Similarly, when transparency is desired, there is a set of deliberate efforts to make it happen. In secrecy the process of concealing information becomes prone to revelation (transparency) due to the human and other agents involved.

To extend this constitutive perspective, Fan and Liu (2022) conceptualize concealment and revelation as mediated by time. In their study on archival records, they argued that time is often the mediator between concealment and revelation, as "the existence of the concealed becomes a discoverable vehicle for potential revelation" (p. 1041). This implies organizational secrets are themselves the products of intentional communicative processes and, over time, they become the targets of potential revelation because of the (human) agents involved in their concealment. As discussed earlier, whenever human agents are involved, there is the risk of revelation.

The above is also true of Albu's (2022) review of secrecy and transparency literature, which showed that the concepts are rooted in different temporal discourses. They found that the biggest conceptual

differences between secrecy and transparency include the ways in which they are enacted and at what time they are invoked. Albu's review also shows that transparency is deemed as the absence of secrecy and vice versa because one always fills the void created by the other. This perspective illuminates secrecy and transparency as central aspects of organizational life that are crucial to understanding how control functions.

Secrecy, Transparency, and Concertive Control

As a dominant theme of secrecy and employee communication research, control is conceptualized and represented in different ways. As we turn toward a more constitutive perspective of secrecy, the type of bureaucratic control that exemplifies the review of informational secrecy in the previous sections makes way for postbureaucratic forms, one of which is concertive control (see Barker, 1993; Tompkins & Cheney, 1985). It is the kind in which the center of the control process shifts from managers and supervisors to teams, who are expected to self-manage (Stephens, 2018). In a concertive control environment team members agree on core values, norms, and rules for accountability. However, because achieving organizational goals is the target of these self-managed teams, the rules they corporately create are more effective at controlling individual members' behaviors than even the bureaucratic rules.

Control, conceptualized as a concertive process, allows for a more democratic workplace by recognizing the human need to act situationally. However, such an approach to control is challenging when organizations are resorting to communication and data technologies. An example is workplace policies that require employees to use their own personal mobile devices for work. Stephens (2018) explained that bring-your-own-device policies complicate control processes because they have implications for privacy and knowledge management. I add that such policies also have implications for secrecy breaches as organizations continuously move toward digitalized knowledge and information: "These technological transformations have led to the emergence of datafied transparency which coincides with algorithmic forms of surveillance" (Albu, 2022, p. 385). This situation, again, brings into sharp focus the relationship between secrecy and transparency beyond the functional perspective.

Although organizations have a functional need to keep secrets, the process of keeping those secrets can become so complex that leaks become inevitable, in a digitalized environment. Kwoka (2014) argues that anonymity protections offered by hacking software have made leaks less consequential for leakers. Such reduced risks for leakers present increased costs for organizations and represents an important contemporary dimension to organizational knowledge management vis-à-vis secrecy breaches.

The use of information and communication technologies in the workplace complicates knowledge management and employee communication in such dynamic ways because of how quickly the digital landscape changes. For instance, crisis communication scholars have examined how insider threat has become a major concern regarding employee communication. Rice and Searle (2022) define insider threat as "danger from individuals with privileged levels of access to an organization's resources due to their internal position in the organization, such as employees, contractors or trusted third parties" (p. 469). They also found that the communication norms and practices of an organization—such as those created by teams—could become enablers of insider threat behavior.

Within concertive control systems, especially those with a reliance on digital communication, insider threat is an even bigger issue due to the decentralized modes and processes of knowledge and information dissemination. However, research on transparency, as the cultural opposite of secrecy, shows that the former could become an antidote to secrecy breaches, as it removes the need for deluge leaks and discourages conspiracy theorizing. Some scholars recommend theorizing forms of transparency that disrupt the status quo and offer a "mechanism able to subvert or at least interrupt dominant attitudes toward disclosure's limited and prescribed role in the political sphere" (Birchall, 2014, p. 85).

Subsequently, Birchall (2014) had lamented that mainstream notions of corporate transparency see it as a cultural attitude that leads to openness that is scrutinized by all interested parties. This openness typically excludes trade secrets, organizational or national security, and market-related information. This type of transparency, while based on liberal democratic tenets, is simultaneously entrenched in neoliberal logic. However, Birchall argued that radical forms of transparency have the possibility of interrupting the processes of secrecy. Similarly, Albu's (2022) review explained radical transparency as the kind that is not only

based on informational openness but also on changing the conditions of visibility. In this sense, transparency is seen as an anti-capitalist process that intently guards against neoliberal visions that prioritize economic gain over, what Birchall called, "disclosure without political foreclosure" (p. 77).

Conclusions and Implications

In this section, I provide a summary of the chapter's main points. I also offer some concluding thoughts and discuss some empirical implications of secrecy research. First, even though many scholars do not directly address it, there is a consistent thread in the secrecy research that points to issues of control–control of employee communication. On one hand, several scholars examine bureaucratic control systems as the central mechanisms for preventing secrecy leaks. They argue that using organizational bureaucracy to install strategies for prohibiting certain forms of employee communication has had success in keeping organizational secrets from getting leaked, which in turn increases companies' competitiveness. On the other hand, some scholars believe that the modern employee's need for agency and empowerment has led to less bureaucratic forms of control-like concertive control where employees are required to self-manage and self-censor in the service of organizational goals (Barker, 1993; Gibbs et al., 2022; Tompkins & Cheney, 1985). These forms of control have similar outcomes with regard to secrecy leaks. Some scholars believe bureaucratic systems effectively "use a pre-formulated narrative as a barrier against unwanted intruders" (Liebeskind, 1997, p. 88). Others believe concertive control systems may be better at preventing secrecy breaches than bureaucratic forms.

Second, the research shows that all organizational communication is geared toward both secrecy and transparency. The literature examined here ascertains the pervasiveness of secrecy and transparency, but more importantly, emphasizes that there is no void left by secrecy that is not filled by transparency, and vice versa. Whether it is a bureaucratic or a democratic culture, employee communication is constricted to either favor secrecy or transparency. After all, secrecy and transparency are intertwined in a dialectical relationship where one cannot exist without the other. In both cases, disclosure is the central issue: secrecy requires systems of non-disclosure, which can often backfire, while transparency

requires a certain level of openness (disclosure) that may be difficult to achieve.

Finally, one of the fundamental findings of the secrecy research here is that secrets are kept for both functional and ideological/cultural reasons. The functional reasons for keeping secrets include preventing sensitive knowledge and information from leaking to "outsiders" to create or maintain economic value. To this end Ahmad et al. (2014) suggested that "management needs to develop suitable policies, procedures and guidelines on intra and interorganizational knowledge sharing, screening of applicants prior to appointing them in organizations, and acceptable use of collaborative and communication technologies" (p. 31) to prevent secrecy breaches. However, there are ideological/cultural/symbolic reasons such as when the norms, values, and practices of an organization lead employees to keep secrets, even when they are not sensitive information. Such cultural norms and behaviors can, nonetheless, play an important role on insider threat behaviors when employees feel the need to resist organizational practices.

In terms of implications, the various threads and perspectives indicate that secrecy, in both its theoretical and practical iterations, also concerns censorship. First, when conceptualized as an informational phenomenon, secrecy is centrally concerned with keeping organizational knowledge and information away from unauthorized others. This is achieved by instituting exclusionary communicative practices, sometimes prohibiting certain forms or topics of conversation. There are often rules that restrict social interaction in a bid to protect organizational secrets or to prevent breaches. As soon as an organization decides that its knowledge and information assets are worthy of protection from other entities, employee censorship is invoked to institute it.

In other words, the research has shown that secrecy, as a mechanism of non-disclosure, has censoring effects. When members agree to the mechanisms for keeping organizational secrets they are, by extension, agreeing to censoring systems to which they must comply. Albeit in different ways, censoring systems are applied for both formal and informal secrecy. More importantly, for organizational communication scholars and practitioners, censorship of employee communication through mechanisms of non-disclosure shows that censorship is not only a concern for bureaucratic organizations. Concertive control practices are, at least, equally effective at inviting employees to self-censor in the service of organizational goals. Censorship is also often justified by

security concerns associated with organizational secrets. Managers, leaders, and employees should consider who these systems silence and for what purposes.

Additionally, an important implication of the research discussed in this chapter is that there needs to be more practical and theoretical foci on the relationship between secrecy and transparency, even as digital communication continues to complicate our understanding of their connections. Particularly with the rapid rise of artificial intelligence (AI) and large language models like ChatGPT in the workplace, leaders should reconsider their knowledge management approaches to account for privacy and intellectual property concerns. Scholars, such as Mylly (2023) have warned that trade secrets, particularly, have become vulnerable to AI use, especially as the legal regime struggles to catch up with the pace of technological innovation. Even as scholars and organizational leaders grapple with the tensions between secrecy and transparency, it is imperative on them to think differently about the impact of managerial strategy. As Walter Isaacson insisted about Elon Musk's purchase of Twitter, technological genius cannot replace the need for nontoxic social interactions (Roose & Newton, 2023). Regardless of how many structures of physical isolation, secure cloud storage systems, or cutting-edge bureaucratic systems are put in place, secrecy leaks are, ultimately, a primary concern of organizational culture.

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14

EMPLOYEE WHISTLEBLOWING

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Whistleblowing is the reporting of wrongdoing in organizations by employees to internal or external entities with power to correct the situation (Miceli & Near, 1984). It has been recognized as a form of employee communication for decades, but few public relations and communications scholars have focused on whistleblowing (See Berger, 2005; Greenwood, 2009, 2011, 2015, 2020, 2022; Mazzei & Ravazzani, 2020). Examining that omission is the subject of this chapter.

This chapter provides (a) a brief history of whistleblowing laws and research; (b) introduces evolutionary theory (Darwin, 1979) as it applies to public relations and communication (Greenwood, 2011, 2020, 2022; Greenwood & Kahle, 2007; Marsh, 2012, 2013, 2017; Nothhaft, 2016; Nothhaft & Seiffert-Brockmann, 2023; Seiffert-Brockmann, 2018) and to the golden handcuffs (Berger, 2005; Greenwood, 2011, 2016, 2020, 2022); (c) presents original research showing the limited involvement of corporate public relations and communications executives and practitioners with whistleblowing and their positive attitudes toward their organizations (Greenwood, 2011, 2015, 2016, 2022), unlike government whistleblowers (Greenwood, 2020); (d) supports elevating the concept of the golden handcuffs to a middle range theory under the umbrella of evolutionary theory (Greenwood, 2011, 2020, 2022); (e) suggests future research (Greenwood, 2011, 2015, 2016, 2020, 2022); and (f) offers guidance for addressing whistleblowing and whistleblowers (Greenwood, 2011, 2020, 2022).

Literature Review

Whistleblowing in the United States

Due to the United States' history of enacting whistleblowing laws, Vandekerckhove et al. (2014) identified the United States, along with its English-speaking allies, as the world leader in whistleblowing legislation. During the Civil War, the United States passed the False Claims Act of 1863. It encouraged private citizens to report fraud against the government and allowed them to collect part of the money the government recovered (Lumm, 2010). The 1958 Code of Ethics for Government Service made reporting wrongdoing an obligation of federal employees. The Freedom of Information Act of 1966 made government documents public records and gave citizens the right to access them.

However, the Civil Service Reform Act of 1978 was the first law to encourage whistleblowing among federal employees. It created the U.S. Merit Systems Protection Board (MSPB) to determine the levels of wrongdoing, whistleblowing, and retaliation in government and to protect whistleblowers from retaliation. The MSPB implemented its responsibilities through three federal surveys (U.S. Office of Merit Systems Review and Studies, 1981, 1984, 1993). It defined wrongdoing as "fraud, waste, and mismanagement" (1981), and later as "fraud, waste, and abuse" (1984, 1993). It defined whistleblowing as giving information about wrongdoing to internal and/or external entities, and it defined retaliation as employer reactions ranging from poor performance appraisals to firing.

The Sarbanes-Oxley Act of 2002 was the first legislation to protect employees of publicly traded corporations from retaliation for reporting financial fraud (Moberly, 2012). It also required those corporations to provide an anonymous whistleblowing channel to the audit committees of their corporate boards of directors. Unfortunately, Sarbanes-Oxley did not provide the whistleblower protection it was intended to provide, due in part to administrative and judicial actions, and whistleblowers' disclosures were not heeded enough to prevent the financial crisis of 2008. The Dodd-Frank Act of 2010 strengthened Sarbanes-Oxley by addressing the issues that undermined corporate whistleblower protection, including by extending Dodd-Frank's protection to employees of non-publicly traded subsidiaries of publicly traded corporations. However, Dodd-Frank's most significant departure from Sarbanes-Oxley was its introduction of a monetary incentive for reporting financial fraud (Moberly, 2012).

Whistleblowing in the United Kingdom and the European Union

The United Kingdom's Employment Rights Act 1996 allowed whistleblowing by citizens but did not protect them from their employers (Lewis, 2001). The U.K.'s subsequent Public Interest Disclosure Act (PIDA) prioritized whistleblowing in the public interest (Lewis et al., 2014) and protected employees who reported externally (Yeoh, 2013). Before the European Union (EU) adopted the Whistleblower Directive (European Parliament & the Council, 2019), European countries tended to favor either the PIDA's requirement for internal whistleblowing (Ashton, 2015) or the False Claims Act's financial incentives for external whistleblowing (Faunce et al., 2014). The Whistleblower Directive required companies and local governments over a certain size in EU countries to protect whistleblowers and create whistleblowing reporting channels (European Parliament & the Council, 2019).

Whistleblowing Research

Management scholars analyzed the three MSPB surveys (U.S. Office of Merit Systems Review and Studies, 1981, 1984, 1993) to identify predictors of wrongdoing, intent to blow the whistle, and retaliation (Miceli et al., 1999) using various theories (Miceli et al., 2008). Resource dependence perspective (RDP), one of the more popular (Mesmer-Magnus & Viswesvaran, 2005), proposed that organizations acquired resources from their environments and were dependent on them (Pfeffer & Salancik, 1978). Using RDP with the federal data, researchers found seriousness of wrongdoing (e.g., dollar amount and frequency) predicted whistleblowing, and seriousness of wrongdoing and dependence on the wrongdoing predicted external whistleblowing (Miceli & Near, 1985). Seriousness of wrongdoing (e.g., dollar amount, frequency, and number harmed) also predicted retaliation (Near & Miceli, 1986). In surveying employees of a military base to explore gender differences in retaliation, Rehg et al. (2008) found having low power (i.e., not being a supervisor, having no informal power, and not being required to report wrongdoing) predicted retaliation for males; seriousness of wrongdoing (i.e., dollar amount, frequency, number harmed, and wrongdoer's power) predicted retaliation for females; and retaliation's negative effect on relations with supervisors for both genders was greater for females (Rehg et al., 2008).

Whistleblowing as Employee Communication

Among the few public relations scholars who acknowledged whistleblowing as employee communication, Berger and Reber (2006) surveyed and interviewed public relations executives about methods to effect change in their organizations (i.e., dissent) and found that external whistleblowing was rarely used. Kang and Berger (2010) surveyed members of the Public Relations Society of America about dissent and also found that few respondents engaged in whistleblowing (referred to as leaking). In comparing methods of dissent between public relations practitioners in South Korean and the United States, Kang, Berger and Shin (2012) found that neither group used whistleblowing (characterized as leaking) frequently, but South Korean public relations practitioners engaged in it significantly more often than their U.S. counterparts. Kim and Rhee (2011) used the term megaphoning, rather than whistleblowing, to describe employees' communication of organizational information to external stakeholders: positive megaphoning conveyed positive information and negative megaphoning conveyed negative information. Mazzei and Ravazzani (2020) characterized whistleblowing as a preventative strategy to avoid crises within organizations when whistleblowers provided the information internally.

The only studies focused solely on whistleblowing within the field of public relations were a quantitative study using two surveys of top-ranking, corporate public relations and communications executives and practitioners (Greenwood, 2011, 2015, 2016, 2022) and a qualitative study using in-depth interviews with government and government contract whistleblowers (Greenwood, 2020). The quantitative study replicated the federal studies (Miceli et al., 1999) for a corporate audience. It also asked about organization-public relationships (Grunig & Huang, 2000; Hon & Grunig, 1999; Huang, 1997). The study found that top-ranking public relations and communications executives were more aware of wrongdoing than others but did not report it more frequently (Greenwood, 2022). In fact, the majority of respondents did not view reporting wrongdoing as a job duty.

As with Miceli and Near (1985), seriousness of wrongdoing (i.e., dollar amount and frequency) predicted whistleblowing. Similar to Rehg et al. (2008), less time in position and a poor job performance rating (i.e., low power), being female, and blowing the whistle externally predicted retaliation. However, whistleblowers with higher education levels, higher salaries, and supervisory positions experienced less retaliation than

others. Top-ranking executives were more positive toward their relationships with their employers than other employees were. Nevertheless, awareness of wrongdoing, whistleblowing, and retaliation had a negative effect on all relationship quality outcomes (trust, control mutuality, commitment, and satisfaction) and communal relationship type. Whistleblowing also had a negative effect on exchange relationship type, but awareness of wrongdoing and retaliation did not (Greenwood, 2022).

The government interviews (Greenwood, 2020) focused on wrongdoing the respondents had uncovered, their method of reporting it, any retaliation they experienced, their relationships with their employers, and their interaction with public relations and public affairs representatives. All whistleblowers said they believed reporting wrongdoing was a job responsibility, and all had done so, either internally, externally, or externally after reporting internally. None had had any interaction with public relations or public affairs personnel, directly or indirectly, nor had they sought any. Their attitude was that such contact would have been detrimental to their own interests because those employees were focused solely on protecting the organization's image and not on assisting whistleblowers. Suggestions for improving public relations/public affairs personnel's role included acting as intermediaries between potential whistleblowers and the organization, identifying whistleblowing paths, and helping whistleblowers follow those paths "before the problem went to the lawyers" (Greenwood, 2020, p. 1057).

The Utility of Evolutionary Theory as a Metatheory for Public Relations

It is well-known that public relations scholars have borrowed middle-range theories (Merton, 1967) from other fields (Greenwood, 2010; Prior-Miller, 1989). It is also well-known that the field has rejected the need for a unifying theory, or metatheory (Grunig, 1989), despite the call for one (Ferguson, 2018). Nevertheless, the search has continued (Sallot et al., 2008) but without result (Volk, 2016). This lack of agreement could reflect differing worldviews (Grunig & White, 1992) or the lack of a uniform structure with which to evaluate differing paradigms (Curtin & Gaither, 2005). Still, some feel the right metatheory should be able to accommodate multiple middle-range theories (Greenwood, 2010, 2022),

or multiple paradigms (Marsh, 2013) with differing world views (Greenwood, 2022).

Evolutionary theory provides the scope to be that metatheory (Greenwood, 2010, 2011, 2020, 2022). Evolutionary theory offers biological theories (i.e., ultimate theories) to explain natural selection and sociological theories (i.e., proximate theories) to explain natural selection's results (Scott-Phillips et al., 2011). Proximate theories could be equated to Merton's (1967) middle-range theories in sociology (Greenwood, 2010, 2022) because many are drawn from the social sciences (Scott-Phillips et al., 2011). Several public relations scholars have proposed a role for evolutionary theory in public relations theory building, beginning with Cutlip (Cutlip, 1952, in Cutlip et al., 1994) who introduced ecology as a metatheory for public relations in its role of facilitating organizations' adaptation to their changing environments.

Moloney (2006) proposed viewing public relations' use of social media as an essential component of cultural evolutionary psychology. J. E. Grunig and L. A. Grunig (2008), in discussing the need for public relations to adapt to changing times, suggested, "[T]he future of the Excellence theory should be evolutionary change" (p. 292). Marsh (2018) proposed that corporate social responsibility could be explained by indirect reciprocity, in which benefits exchanged on the basis of mutual gain, or reciprocity (Cords, 1997), extend to others not involved in the original transaction. However, Greenwood (2008, 2010, 2011, 2020, 2022) was the first to call for using evolutionary theory, including evolutionary biology (Hamilton, 1964a, 1964b), evolutionary psychology (Cosmides et al., 1992), and consilience (Wilson, 1998), as the metatheory for public relations, which several public relations and communication scholars acknowledged (Marsh, 2012, 2013, 2017; Nothhaft, 2016; Seiffert-Brockmann, 2018). That call resulted in the growth of an evolutionary based sub-discipline involving public relations, organizational communication, and strategic communication (Greenwood, 2022; Nothhaft & Seiffert-Brockmann, 2023).

Evolutionary Theory and Whistleblowing

Greenwood (2020) operationalized evolutionary concepts to represent whistleblowing and organization-public relationships (2010, 2011, 2022). She operationalized Machiavellian intelligence, which represents manipulation (Byrne & Whiten, 1997; Whiten & Byrne, 1997), as organizational wrongdoing (Greenwood, 2022). She operationalized

cheater detection, which represents recognizing manipulation (Cosmides & Tooby, 1992; Orbell et al., 2004), as awareness of wrongdoing. She operationalized cooperation, which represents acting with another so that both benefit (Trivers, 1971), and reciprocity, which represents an exchange of benefits for future gain (Cords, 1997), as exchange relationship. Finally, she operationalized reciprocal altruism, which represents giving more than one receives (Trivers, 1971), but which could also be viewed "as a symbiosis, each partner helping the other while he helps himself" (p. 39), as communal relationship (Greenwood, 2022).

The Golden Handcuffs

The Golden Handcuffs in Business

The concept of the golden handcuffs is found in business (Cappelli, 2000; Sengupta et al., 2007) and public relations (Berger, 2005; Greenwood, 2011, 2016, 2022). In business, the term refers to compensation, the primary tool in recruiting and retaining employees, and can include deferred compensation programs such as stock ownership (Cappelli, 2000). Business researchers have attributed stock ownership programs with increasing corporate performance by engendering an attitude of commitment to the organization and its values, called the golden path, or increasing retention and reducing labor costs for retraining, called the golden handcuffs (Sengupta et al., 2007). Although Sengupta et al. (2007) supports the golden handcuffs, other researchers have found no impact from stock ownership on attitudes, such as commitment, or behaviors, such as retention (Pierce et al., 1991, in Williams & MacDermid, 1994).

The Golden Handcuffs in Public Relations

Public relations researchers used the term golden handcuffs to refer to the salary, benefits, and power awarded to higher level employees (Berger, 2005; Greenwood, 2011, 2016, 2020, 2022). Greenwood proposed evaluating her findings for whistleblowing (2022) in light of evolutionary theory. She found that rank predicted awareness of wrongdoing, which supports the role of top-ranking relations and communications executives in detecting manipulation by their organizations (i.e., cheater detection). However, awareness of

wrongdoing did not lead to a significant increase in whistleblowing among that group, which supports the idea that the fear of retaliation (i.e., the loss of the golden handcuffs) is a factor in not blowing the whistle and that the golden handcuffs represent an exchange relationship between upper management and their organizations. Seriousness of wrongdoing (i.e., the dollar amount and frequency) was the only predictor of whistleblowing, which supports the concept that the motivation for whistleblowing is reciprocal altruism (i.e., giving more than receiving, or being rewarded in the future).

Whistleblowers with more education, higher salaries, and supervisory status experienced less retaliation than others, which supports the idea that the exchange relationship represented by the golden handcuffs provides protection from retaliation. Awareness of wrongdoing and retaliation did not affect exchange relationships negatively, which supports the concept of cooperation (i.e., acting so both parties benefit) and reciprocity (i.e., exchanging benefits for future gain) as components of the exchange relationship. Top-ranking public relations or communications executives had the most positive relationships with their organizations, which supports the value of the golden handcuffs to high-ranking employees and their employers. The role of the golden handcuffs in whistleblowing appears to be based on its position in an exchange relationship between higher-level employees and the organization, which effectively reduces whistleblowing by those employees and contributes to their evolutionary success through higher income, benefits, and power. Although the broader implications of these findings remain to be determined, they argue for elevating the golden handcuffs to a middle-range theory under the umbrella of evolutionary theory to allow for further research.

Suggestions for Future Research

Kang and Berger (2010) and Greenwood (Greenwood, 2011, 2015, 2022) attempted to reach public relations and communications executives and practitioners about their involvement with whistleblowing. Both experienced low rates of responses from those groups. More research is needed to determine if the golden handcuffs are the reason public relations and communications executives and practitioners do not report wrongdoing or engage with whistleblowers more often and what changes would be needed to encourage or require more reporting and engagement. Future research could identify the level of knowledge in

organizations about the legal and procedural functions of whistleblowing, assess the current location of the whistleblowing oversight function, and address the role for public relations and communications executives in those functions. There is also the need for further research on the impacts of awareness of wrongdoing, whistleblowing, and retaliation on organization-public relationships (Greenwood, 2022).

Recommendations for Dealing with Whistleblowing and Whistleblowers

Statute, rule, and policy dictate how much involvement public relations and communications executives and practitioners will have with whistleblowing and whistleblowers. However, it is critical that these executives are familiar with all aspects of those requirements in order to advise the organization on whistleblower best practices. They should advocate for whistleblower protections, help develop whistleblowing channels, publicize those channels throughout the organization, and encourage the organization to honor the commitment to whistleblowers that those channels represent. Achieving that level of familiarity requires cross-disciplinary knowledge and collaboration with other departments in the organization, including, legal, finance, and human resources (Greenwood, 2011, 2022; Pompper, 2014); achieving that level of communication requires technical and strategic expertise and resources; and gaining the support of management requires diplomacy, strategy, and communication. Gaining that support through open and transparent communication (Grunig & Grunig, 1992) could create a welcoming climate for bringing concerns to management through internal whistleblowing (Greenwood, 2011, 2022), and honoring those who have come forward (Meikle, 2023) could encourage less external whistleblowing. Regardless, it is essential that management take whistleblowers' concerns seriously and work to correct whatever wrongdoing they have exposed. Although one cannot ignore the potential risk in speaking up, public relations and communications executives and practitioners must acknowledge and embrace their role as ethical counselor to management (Berger & Reber, 2006; Bowen, 2008), both for the organization's sake and for their own self-respect (Greenwood, 2022).

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PART III

Employee Communication and Organizational Process

15

CAUSES, CONTEXTS, AND CONSEQUENCES OF EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION

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Even though employee communication has been studied for decades, it has begun to receive unprecedented attention from scholars and practitioners since the corona-virus pandemic. As the pandemic has accelerated structural changes in organizational and managerial process (Quaratino's Chapter 32), it has given scholars an opportunity to revisit key concepts such as leadership (Yue et al.'s Chapter 21), organizing (McAllum et al.'s Chapter 18), and belonging at work (Allen's Chapter 35). In this changing context, managers and leaders are facing new challenges such as socializing new hires, employee engagement (Dhanesh & Duthler's Chapter 38), job embeddedness, isolation, psychological safety, hybrid work environments (Quaratino's Chapter 32), and employee well-being (Dong & Lee's Chapter 25).

Organizational communication and public relations, which were born and developed as distinct disciplines, have contributed to enriching the body of knowledge on employee communication. Organizational communication literature has investigated employee communication to enhance our understanding of internal organizational functions and workplace interactions, as represented by superior–subordinate communication, feedback, listening, intergroup conflict, training effects, decision-making, and managerial and/or organizational communication climate (see Buzzanell et al.'s Chapter 3). Meanwhile, the public relations literature has considered employee communication in the

context of employee–organization relationships (EORs; see more details in Tam & Kim's Chapter 2).

Given the broad scope of employee communication research and the varying approaches to employee communication, a "comprehensive and exhaustive" review of the antecedents, contexts, and consequences of employee communication is beyond the scope of this chapter. In addition, as employee communication is defined differently depending on the approach taken, this chapter delimits its scope to employee communication behavior as a phenomenon and discusses several key concepts that have been used in extant research to explain such behavior. This chapter will use the contributed chapters to our handbook as guiding references.

There has been a great deal of empirical research on employees' communicative behavior across the disciplines of organizational communication and public relations. Notable examples of such behavior include boundary spanning (Perez & Lee's Chapter 4), sensemaking and sensegiving (Kim's Chapter 5), voice (Garner's Chapter 6) (Morrison, 2014, 2023; Van Dyne & LePine, 1998, p. 4), silence (Bisel & Okpaireh's Chapter 9), allegiant communication behavior (see Tam & Kim's Chapter 2), dissent (Kang's Chapter 10) (Ravazzani & Mazzei, 2018), gossip (Horan & Chory's Chapter 11), secrecy breach (Wolfe's Chapter 12), whistleblowing (Greenwood's Chapter 14), quiet quitting (Chon & Park's Chapter 8), scouting, megaphoning, and microboundary spanning (Kim & Rhee, 2011), search, interpreting, and sharing (Mazzei et al., 2012) coworker communication (Heide & Simonsson, 2011), and active communication behaviors (Mazzei, 2010). Regarding employees' active communication behaviors, Verhoeven and Madsen (2022) proposed a typology of eight employee communication roles, including embodier, promotor, defender, relationship-builder, scout, sense-maker, innovator, and critic.

In explicating these various types of employee communication behavior, extant research has explored their antecedents, elements, processes, and outcomes in diverse contexts and situations. However, given the different paradigms of inquiry, from interpretivism, critical theory, to post-positivism, we recognize that caution is needed when utilizing these particular terms together in this chapter to explain employee communication behavior. We acknowledge that understanding employee communication behavior requires a holistic approach that more comprehensively examines its environment, actors, and processes. As Mease notes (Chapter 22),

> to analyze an organizational environment is not just to analyze the actors that are the pieces of the environment. It also requires attention to the arrangement of those actors (human and non-human) and the processes that continually brings them into relationship that make it possible to say and do certain things and not others.
>
> *(p. 231)*

To help cultivate positive employee communication and workplace climates, several communicative processes have been investigated, such as dissent-welcoming organizational cultures, workplace mentoring, and employee resilience building (see Long & Buisker's Chapter 24), organizational listening (see Macnamara's Chapter 26), the role of organizational culture in ethics, ethical leadership and ethical internal relations (Bowen's Chapter 16), and employee engagement and coworkership (Verhoeven & Madsen, 2022; Andersson et al.'s Chapter 20). Corporate heritage management (See Martino & Lovari's Chapter 17) has also been suggested as constituting a part of internal communication strategies and campaigns that empower internal stakeholders.

Literature Review

Employee Communication Behavior as an Interconnected Phenomenon

As Mease explains (Chapter 22), organizational environments constantly change, and actors' actions are often interrelated:

> as one of those many actors in motion, our attempts to influence and act upon an organizational environment do not create change in a stable monolithic organizational environment, but rather influence the actions and flows of the many interrelated organizational actors and actions that are in motion with us.
>
> *(p. 228)*

To the authors' knowledge, however, there has not yet been an explicit attempt to broadly conceptualize employee communication behavior based on the understanding that employee actions such as voice, dissent,

whistleblowing, gossip, silence, megaphoning, and silence are interconnected.

While many of these terms have often been studied separately, some are conceptually linked, for example, voice (Garner's Chapter 6), dissent (Kang's Chapter 10) and whistleblowing (Greenwood's Chapter 14), in terms of discussing problems and suggesting improvements (Gorden, 1988 as cited in Garner's Chapter 6). However, whistleblowing is also often characterized as leaking (Greenwood's Chapter 14) or seen as publicly making accusations of an organization's illegal and unethical behaviors to a third party (Kassing, 1997, see Kang's Chapter 10). Dissent is considered a type of employee voice, "expressed out of ethical and moral concerns about organizational practices" (Kang's Chapter 10, p. 100); it is also characterized and categorized according to active/passive and constructive/destructive voice (Gorden, 1988, as cited in Garner's Chapter 6). Voice, even though generally associated with employee feedback about the organization, can also pertain to expressing frustrations and dissatisfactions. It is also described as employees' upward communication, as opposed to downward (or top-down) communication under an authoritative approach (Garner's Chapter 6).

Interestingly, voice is also connected to silence as part of employees' responses to organizational problems (Farrell's 1983 neglect as the fourth dimension to Hirschman's 1970 exit-voice-loyalty model); some employees choose to be silent. Megaphoning (Kim & Rhee, 2011) is similar to word-of-mouth communication, and both can be either positive or negative with regard to the organization. A key difference, though, is that amplification is assumed in the concept of megaphoning, while word-of-mouth indicates valence (positive or negative) only. Moreover, while gossip sounds similar to word-of-mouth communication in a sense that positive or negative information spreads about a specific target, the target of such communication is often aware of the communication, which is informal (Horan & Chory's Chapter 11).

Consequences of Employee Communication Behavior

Scholars have identified several benefits of employee communication behavior. For example, employee voice is known to provide benefits for employees and organizations such as increasing employee satisfaction (Holland et al., 2011; Ruck et al., 2017), in-role performance, and creativity (Ng & Feldman, 2012) and decreasing depletion (Lin & Johnson, 2015) and turnover (Burris et al., 2012) (Garner's Chapter 6).

Moreover, even though employee silence is understood as employees' purposeful withholding of information that could help improve the organization, not all employee silence is harmful or negative. Some employees actively choose to withhold information for cooperative motives or keep corporate secrets to benefit the organization (Bisel & Ojpaireh's Chapter 9). Employee silence can also be considered rather strategic and useful in that it can help an organization achieve its goals to some extent; otherwise, an organization could be overloaded by too many voices and unable to properly respond to all of them (Bisel & Ojpaireh's Chapter 9). Employee activism may also positively influence organizations' ethical practices and corporate citizenship (Hung-Baesecke & Delmo's Chapter 33).

Meanwhile, Kim and Rhee (2011) suggested that employee communication behavior brings strategic value to the organization and affects public relations outcomes. For example, information forwarding and sharing organizational accomplishments to external stakeholders (i.e., positive megaphoning) contributes to the shaping of the organization's positive image and can serve as a voluntary promoting and advocating behavior (Kim & Rhee, 2011). Scouting behavior also provides certain benefits: as it refers to non-designated employees' voluntary information-seeking behaviors regarding task- or organization-related problems, the collated information from these self-motivated environmental scanners can be as a significant source of information. Kim and Rhee (2011) also pointed out that "employee megaphoning not only provides opportunities for maximizing strategic opportunities for organizations, but also opportunities to minimize strategic threats such as revealing organizational secrets or exaggeration of managerial responsibilities in crises" (p. 262).

Despite its benefits, there are also negative outcomes of employee communication behavior. For example, when employees are internally withholding opinions, ideas, and information that could potentially help teams and organizations improve, those teams and organizations might miss out on the opportunity to learn from potentially very valuable feedback and address certain issues. To this point, Bisel and Ojpaireh (Chapter 9) advise that employee silence can incur significant costs not only for the organization but also for the involved stakeholders and organizational members, which can include high turnover, low job satisfaction, and poor self-and other-reported task performance (Hao et al., 2022). Interestingly, Rhee and Moon (Chapter 39) argued that recent organizational crises have occurred because of employees'

communication behaviors. In particular, they suggest that anonymous online megaphoning should be further researched in the context of internal crisis communication, as negative megaphoning can facilitate the spread of bad information about organizational conduct and result in the creation of a negative image of the organization. Relatedly, Kim et al. (2022) explored how start-up company employees evaluate their employer on an anonymous platform, Glassdoor.com, and discussed reputational challenges and opportunities caused by employees' communicative behavior. Ultimately, they concluded that because start-up companies do not have an established reputation, employees' communicative behaviors about their employer are crucial especially in attracting and retaining talented employees. Moreover, they suggested that reputation-building starts with the firm's internal reputation. Secrecy breach also has consequences, such as the organization's competitive advantage loss (Karikari's Chapter 13).

Key Concepts as Antecedents, Causes, and Processes

Ethics, Leadership, Symmetrical Communication, and Organizational Culture

When an organization is perceived as ethical, employees tend to experience commitment to and satisfaction with the organization (Curtin et al., 2011). Similarly, when an organization is perceived as behaving ethically toward its key stakeholders, from customers, partners, to employees, the organization tends to experience relational improvement and avoid conflicts with stakeholders (Kim & Krishna, 2017). As Bowen suggests, "[a] vital area of consideration for employee engagement is ethics – and how, or if, an organization's culture inspires ethical thought and action throughout the organization among leaders and followers" (Bowen's Chapter 16, p. 164). Then it is the leaders who should incorporate ethics into organizational decision making and practices (Bowen's Chapter 16). Therefore, leadership is a crucial element of organizational culture in enacting ethics in the organization (Bowen's Chapter 16).

There are several types of ethical normative leadership, such as authentic leadership (Qin & Men, 2023) and servant leadership (Eva et al., 2019). Yue et al. (Chapter 21) introduced emerging types of leadership communication behaviors, such as diversity-oriented leadership and family supportive leadership. Bowen notes, "[a]uthentic

leaders go beyond transactional or transformational leaders in concern for employees, genuineness, and ethical narrative, voicing of ethical commitments, and concern or respect for others" (Chapter 16, p. 166). Authentic and ethical leadership can cultivate a two-way communication climate in an organization and, in turn, enhance employee engagement and quality organization–employee relationships (Men & Stacks, 2014). Two-way symmetrical communication, which is developed based on the presumption that people need to interact with other people through communication to adjust what they think and how they behave (Grunig, 2001), is key to obtaining positive outcomes such as empowering employees (Liden et al., 2000), enhancing organization–employee relationships (Lee, 2022), and increasing employee creativity through employees' feedback-seeking (Lee & Kim, 2021).

Organizational culture is factor that affects employees' perception of the quality of the organization–employee relationship as well as their turnover intention (Kim et al., 2017). While an authoritarian culture is known as a type of turnover culture, an organizational learning culture (Egan et al., 2004) and a team-oriented culture (O'Reilly et al., 1991) may discourage employee turnover intention (Kim et al., 2017; Kim et al., 2022). Similarly, participatory culture is known to engender positive organizational outcomes including employee retention and employee support (Grunig et al., 2002). An organizational culture that discourages dissent can create serious issues for organizations, as failing to listen to employees' constructive feedback and address the issues may lead to crises (Shahinpoor & Matt, 2007). Such a culture also results in employee turnover, low employee morale, and low productivity (Shahinpoor & Matt, 2007). As Bowen notes, "[a] crucial component of culture is that an ethical climate within the organization encourages discussion, openness, and transparency" (Chapter 16, p. 165).

Employee–Organization Relationship

While EOR has been explained by several antecedents, such as symmetrical communication and leadership, it has also been conceptualized as an antecedent in explaining employee communication behavior and other types of employee behaviors. For example, Lee and Kim (2017) found that two types of EOR, communal and exchange relationships, increase both positive and negative megaphoning and scouting. In addition, employee communication behaviors are facilitated by organizations' authentic behavior. Examining a crisis setting, Kim

(2021) revealed the mediating role of EOR in the relationship between two-way symmetrical communication and organizational resilience. Possible consequences of EOR include turnover intention, organizational citizenship behavior, and perceived organization–employee dialogic communication (Tam & Kim's Chapter 2).

Organizational Justice and Supervisory Justice

Organizational justice refers to "individuals' perception of the fairness of treatment received from an organization" (Nadiri & Tanova, 2010, p. 34) and it consists of three dimensions; distributive justice, procedural justice, and interactional justice (Kim et al., 2017). Supervisory justice refers to "the degree of fairness in procedures executed by supervisors in the organization" (Akram et al., 2018, p. 3). When employees positively evaluate an organization's justice and supervisory justice, they are more likely to have a better EOR quality and, in turn, are less likely to have turnover intentions (Kim et al., 2017). Meanwhile, Tulubas and Celep (2012) found that perceived justice can predict members' silence while trust in a supervisor mediates the effect of perceived justice on members' silence. Their findings suggest that members could use silence as their strategy in responding to organizational injustice.

Organizational and supervisory justice are also relevant to other contexts, including change management and organizational citizenship behavior. For example, Koivisto et al. (2013) reported that employees' perceived fairness at their workplace plays a crucial role in reducing their feelings of threat especially in the context of organizational change. More specifically, they found that supervisory justice moderates the relationship between organizational justice and experienced threat during organizational change only when the supervisor is perceived to represent the shared identity of a group. Meanwhile, Tepper and Taylor's (2017) study suggests that supervisors' procedural justice leads to supervisors' organizational citizenship behavior, which in turn influences subordinates' procedural justice perceptions, directly influence subordinates' organizational citizenship behavior.

Cultivating Positive Outcomes for Both Employees and the Organization

As noted earlier, employee communication behavior has positive and negative consequences. To create positive outcomes for both employees

and organizations, there are several concepts to consider, including employee engagement, organizational listening, employee appreciation, and bridging strategy as an action-based, relational approach.

Employee Engagement

The most credited definition of employee engagement refers to the extent to which employees are cognitively, affectively, and behaviorally present and dedicated to their roles in helping achieve organizational outcomes (Macey & Schneider, 2008; Karanges et al., 2015; Dhanesh, 2017, see Tam & Kim's Chapter 2). Furthermore, research has underlined the social dimension of employee engagement, meaning the social connection and the sharing of values with colleagues (Soane et al., 2012). The definition of employee engagement has been an explicit concept for public relations scholars but an implicit concept for organizational communication scholars (Andersson et al.'s Chapter 20). While the public relations literature has mostly focused on the antecedents and outcomes of employee engagement as well as its impact on performance (Andersson et al.'s Chapter 20), the organizational communication literature has emphasized both constructive and destructive employee engagement.

Recently two concepts of employee engagement have emerged: co-workers' communicative engagement (Andersson et al.'s Chapter 20) and co-creational employee engagement (Lemon's Chapter 27). Adopting a social constructive perspective, Andersson et al. (Chapter 20) suggest a communication-centered perspective with respect to co-workers' engagement: "Engagement is communicatively constituted in organizing (…) as employees engage in formal and informal positive and negative communication events" (pp. 210–211). It is meant, therefore, as a communication phenomenon similar to the idea of employee communication behavior (Kim & Rhee, 2011; Mazzei, 2010; Mazzei's Chapter 19). Meanwhile, applying the co-creational approach to employee engagement, Lemon suggests that "employee experiences transform into a non-linear and non-functionalistic process and products that truly capture what it means to both construct and contribute to an organization" (Lemon's Chapter 27, p. 280). While the functionalistic approach privileges the management role in the communication process, a meaning-making and co-creational approach emphasize the role of all organizational members (Lemon's Chapter 27). Indeed, internal publics exist and engage within an organization and determine how meaning is

created through co-creational lived experiences (Lemon's Chapter 27). In short, engagement is understood as a process and product that honors human beings and their lived experiences (Lemon's Chapter 27).

Organizational Listening

As distinguished from interpersonal listening, organizational listening (Macnamara's Chapter 26) constitutes a part of organizational settings. Real listening is different form hearing and from some forms of fake listening. Listening is "constructing meaning from and responding" and includes "seven canons of listening": recognition, acknowledgment of others' views and expressions of voice; paying attention to others; interpreting what others say receptively and empathetically; understanding others' views, perspectives, and feelings as much as possible; considering what others say; and responding in an appropriate way (Macnamara's Chapter 26, p. 269). Listening to employee voice is known to create benefits including employee engagement (Macnamara's Chapter 26), commitment, performance (Reed et al., 2016), and positive EORs (Qin & Men, 2021).

Critical Design of Employee Communication

Long and Buisker (Chapter 24) proposed a critical communicative design approach to positive employee communication, focusing on how to improve the quality of organizational members' experiences. Their critical design perspective foregrounds communication as a constitutive force of organizing, drawing on the critical theorization of communication to develop an ethical stance.

> Positive employee communication envisioned from a critical lens upholds values of inclusivity, care, equity, participation, and justice in everyday organizing, recognizing that positive employee communication is always implicated in imbalanced and intersecting power relations of organizational hierarchy, gender, race, class, education, and other differences.
>
> *(p. 246)*

From a critical design perspective, organizations can design four processes (a strategy): cultivating a culture that welcomes dissent; enacting care and justice leadership (in particular, the care ethics as stated by Buzzanell), building mentoring relationships, and fostering

employee resilience processes (see Buzzanell's Communication Theory of Resilience, 2010).

Employee Appreciation

Employee appreciation is a job resource for managers (Stranzl et al.'s Chapter 23) to support employee engagement. Communication by leaders and internal communication are important to convey appreciation (Chapter 23). More specifically, what is needed is an appreciative working climate, which can be co-created by supervisors, internal communication professionals, and employees. In addition, a sense of employee appreciation should be sustained by explicit appreciative communication behavior (Chapter 23). Supervisors and managers have a responsibility for such appreciation communication, but they also depend on organizational resources, support, and appreciation from their supervisors (Chapter 23), which can create tensions between the expectations toward supervisors and the resources given by the organization (Chapter 23). Although few studies have examined the effects of employee appreciation, extant studies have revealed that appreciation leads to employees' job satisfaction and feelings of success (Pfister et al., 2020; Tessema et al., 2013).

Bridging and Buffering Strategies

Bridging strategy is defined as "a relationship-centric, action-focused strategy for problem solving" (Kim & Krishna, 2017, p. 561). By contrast, buffering strategy is "an organization-centric, message-focused strategy for image/impression management" (Kim & Krishna, 2017, p. 561). An organization that is inclined toward bridging strategy consciously identifies and evaluates the potential consequences of its decisions, policies, or behaviors on its stakeholders (Kim & Krishna, 2017) and is willing to revise its decisions or behaviors to minimize negative consequences (Broom & Sha, 2013). Organizations use bridging strategy to adapt to the environment and ensure that organizations' behaviors conform to societal norms and expectations (Kim & Kim, 2016; Yue, 2022). While buffering strategy aims to control and manipulate publics, bridging strategy aims to reduce the gap between an organization and publics; therefore, it is re-symmetrical, relationship-based, and can be more effective than buffering strategy in communicating with employees (Yue, 2022).

Conclusion

Observing the virtual debates in this handbook among scholars from both disciplines, this chapter reports that the process of mutual fertilization between the two disciplines is advanced with regard to employee communication research, as almost all authors refer to both disciplines and mix and develop concepts by leveraging all the available knowledge. All contributed chapters in this section provide strong evidence of this mutual fertilization and create a sort of galaxy of terms and concepts, combined to construct constellations. New universes emerge when employee communication is considered as being intricately intertwined with today's organizational processes. This new galaxy can gift us a new vocabulary, as well as new ways to understand and engage with the organizational world around us. These elements are taken together by a kind of gravitational interaction: an "interaction between particles or bodies resulting from their mass. It is very weak and occurs at all distances" (Collins Dictionary).

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16

ENACTING ETHICS BEYOND INSTITUTIONALIZATION

Creating Ethical Culture, Leadership, and Employee Communication

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Ethics in organizations can be difficult to foster. Scholars examined the facets of organizational culture that can help define the values of an organization, build its ethical framework, and sustain it. However, communication theory has been slow to incorporate the major theories of moral philosophy as value drivers in an organizational context, resulting in much of the body of work of this scholar (Bowen, 2000, 2002, 2004b) and a few others (Bivins, 1992; Seeger, 1997; Sims, 1991) as well as some management scholars (Goodpaster, 2007; Kaptien, 2003).

Research shows that employees experience greater levels of commitment and satisfaction when they work at an organization they perceive to be ethical (Curtin et al., 2011). Those outcomes also mean enhanced employee communicative behaviors (Kim & Rhee, 2011), which tend to better the organization overall. A strong organizational culture is believed to inspire employee engagement, defined by Verčič and Vokic (2017) as the creational concepts of involvement, satisfaction, enthusiasm, and commitment. A vital area of consideration for employee engagement is *ethics*—and how, or if, an organization's culture inspires ethical thought and action throughout the organization among leaders and followers (Bowen, 2004b).

Leadership, internal communication, and employee communication play vital roles in definition, transmission, and inclusion of ethical values within management. Leaders are expected to model the values of their organization and incorporate such ethics into operations, from policy-making and strategy formulation to decision-making, that affect internal and external stakeholders. This chapter offers an overview of the literature as well as a conceptual model going beyond institutionalization to inspire an "enacted" ethical organizational culture, in turn fostering commitment, satisfaction, and engagement among employees.

The Role of Organizational Culture in Ethics

Organizational culture can be thought of as the internal worldview of an organization: how it communicates and what it values. Organizational cultures can be, to varying extents, summarized as either authoritarian or participative (Smircich & Calas, 1987). Authoritarian cultures are those with hierarchies, a centralized organizational structure with defined individual responsibilities, and a control culture that is formalized (Jablin, 1987). Participative cultures are those in which employees share responsibility, innovate, and work in teams, and they often exist in a decentralized structure with less stratification (Siebold & Shea, 2001). These theoretical approaches help scholars to understand what a culture values.

Organizational structures are influenced by the size and type of organization and the industry in which the enterprise operates. Although the size and nature of the industry affects organizational culture, it can be more or less authoritarian or participative by degrees inside the organization, perhaps best conceptualized as a continuum (Weick, 1987). Generally, more participative organizational cultures are thought to have advantages for employees over cultures that are highly authoritarian (Siebold & Shea, 2001; Smircich & Calas, 1987; Sriramesh et al., 1992). Organizations with participative cultures experience greater employee support, retention, and levels of employee motivation and effectiveness than organizations with authoritarian cultures (Grunig, 1992a; Grunig et al., 2002). Participative cultures hold the traits of valuing people, rewarding innovation, welcoming participation and input, and offer many more relational aspects than does a primarily authoritarian culture (Grunig, 1992a, 1992b). Importantly, they often allow for ethical discussion, and research shows a sense of ethics is valued by employees,

who want to be inspired by belief in the ethics and mission of the employer (Neill & Bowen, 2021).

Organizational cultures are created by internal relations through communication efforts (both planned and un-planned) and campaigns designed to stress certain aspects of internal culture. In addition, communication climates also determine the type of culture that is present within an organization. A crucial component of culture is that an ethical climate within the organization encourages discussion, openness, and transparency (Shin, 2012). Communication networks have a role to play, both formal and informal, within an organization's culture (Brass et al., 2004; Krackhardt & Hanson, 1993; Wasserman & Faust, 1994).

Ethical Leadership and Intention

There are many leadership theories within interdisciplinary academic literature that can help inform our understanding of how leaders create organizational culture—and how they enact the ethical values of the organization, incorporating ethics into daily activities, employee performance reviews, and routine discussions of strategy. Although there can be many leaders within an organization, CEOs are leaders by definition, tasked with the final authority and responsibility of managing the enterprise. The Chief Communication Officer (CCO) not only communicates but also is heavily involved in strategic planning, defining mission and values, and in the dominant coalition's decision-making for the organization, as well as advising on the ethical course of action (Bowen, 2006).

Leadership is a vital determinant of organizational culture, especially at the top of the organization through the CEO. Although communication measures are instituted by the CCO, and carried out via the internal relations function, the CEO often sets the agenda for those communications, and drives the mission, goals, and day-to-day concerns of the enterprise (Mayer et al., 2010). Therefore, the CEO is arguably the most important component in creating an ethical organizational culture. One ethicist (Goodpaster, 2007) explained, "The leader is the principal architect of corporate conscience and the one who must (…) give substance to the moral agenda of the organized group. That agenda includes orienting, institutionalizing, and sustaining conscience in the corporate culture" (p. 7). Goodpaster's perspective is important because this chapter argues that it is not enough to orient, institutionalize, and sustain conscience, but that an ethical conscience must be *intentionally*

put into action and modeled through the organization with ethical leadership before it can be sustained in the organizational culture.

There are well-studied types of ethical leadership, such as authentic leadership or servant leadership, as normative leadership approaches, often also involving narrative, storytelling, and moral courage. Authenticity is defined as being genuine (Bowen, 2010). That concept, when applied to leadership, also centers on normative ethical behavior as well as honesty, candor, contextual full disclosure, and genuineness (Bowen et al., 2016). Leaders convey genuineness, concern, ethical sincerity, listening behaviors, dialogue and other interactive communication behaviors, decisiveness, and truly seek the input of employees (Avolio et al., 2004). Sometimes authentic leaders portray high levels of emotional intelligence creating trust (Qin & Men, 2023), and also display high levels of rational decision-making behaviors (Hsiung, 2012). Authentic leaders go beyond transactional or transformational leaders in their concern for employees, genuineness, ethical narrative, voicing of ethical commitments, and respect for others.

Servant leadership is another ethical and normative approach in which leaders serve to facilitate the success and flourishing of the stakeholders connected to their organizations. Servant leaders are "called" (Greenleaf, 1970) by an obligation to facilitate success rather than a desire for power or control. Another ethicist (Kidder, 1995, 2005) added that the dilemmas to be faced as a servant leader also require a great deal of moral courage and discernment between "right versus right" options.

Servant leadership style has also been linked in studies to high levels of emotional intelligence (Zhang & Adegbol, 2022), ethical listening (Neill & Bowen, 2023), and a flexible, integrative consideration of numerous perspectives (Bowen et al., 2016). These multifaceted considerations form an intentional approach to act with ethical consideration and rectitude. Furthermore, scholars (Hughes et al., 2005) argued, "… empathy includes forming an intention to pay attention to others" (p. 67). Followers, organization managers, and team members often attend to the priorities, values, and leadership style expressed by the CEO, indirectly as group norms or directly as part of their strategic initiatives and performance evaluations. Leadership styles vary, but these factors must be considered as a part of the confluence that helps to foster an *enacted* ethical culture within an organization.

Institutionalization, Dialogue, Narrative, and Enacted Ethics

Ethics in an organizational culture can be a dynamic living, changing, and ongoing discussion or it can be a policy in a long-forgotten manual. Institutionalization is the process through which an organization codifies an approach to ethics in its policy and procedures. Almost every organization has an institutionalized code of ethics, and publicly traded organizations in the United States are required to have a code of conduct. However, the existence of those documents matters little in terms of how the organization actually views ethics. Rather, an organizational culture that supports ethics goes beyond the creation of documents and institutionalization—it models the behavior and discusses the values espoused.

Institutionalizing ethics through policy, reward schemes, training, and action shows internal publics that the organization is serious about ethical behavior. The relationship between espoused values and values-in-action is a dangerous one because a lack of congruence can lead to failure and hypocrisy (Goodpaster, 2007). However, arguing on behalf of dialogue, discussion, and moral debate, Goodpaster (2007) added that regularly comparing actions and values can help the organization fulfill both its values and goals for action, lessening hypocrisy (p. 154). Leaders who engage in regular narrative, storytelling, and listening to employees surrounding ethical issues were perceived to be more authentic and ethical in their leadership (Grojean et al., 2004; Men, 2014). Research (Bowen, 2002) found that open, ongoing, and regular discussions about ethics resulted in better issues management decisions than assuming ethical behavior happened without discussion.

Free, open, and ongoing discussion, in which ideas are put on the table and dissected without bias but purely through rational criticism, thought, and analyses, are highly encouraged by moral philosophers (Kant, 1948; Mill, 1861/1957; Singer, 1994) and business ethicists (Kaptien, 2003) alike. These types of discussions also appear to be the basis for creating genuine ethical reflection and discourse in an organization's culture—a culture that could support ethical analyses, which often include the CCO as conscience counselor (Bowen, 2008).

A worldwide study of 1827 public relations professionals found a counseling function role (Bowen et al., 2006). When acting as a conscience counselor, the CCO advises the dominant coalition on ethical matters from the perspectives of both protecting the organization's reputation and understanding the values and views of publics both internal and external. Often, the CCO represents the views and values of external publics, sometimes critical ones such as activist groups, to the

dominant coalition. In that way, decisions can be more strategic, reflective (Van Ruler & Verčič, 2005), and robust than simply taking a management perspective or legalistic view (Bowen & Heath, 2005).

Philosophical Requirements for Ethical Internal Relations

The philosophical requirements for ethical decision-making call into play the expertise uniquely owned by the internal communication or public relations function due to its connections with, and understanding of, strategic publics, stakeholders, and employees. Some basic tenets of ethics (see below) based on rationality and Kantian deontology should be examined in order to enact the conscience counselor role with probity.

Rationality. The hallmark of ethical analysis is that it is not entered into capriciously, but is based on logic and rationality, which promote consistency, replication, justice, and fairness (Sullivan, 1989). By basing decisions on research, facts, and a standard analytical procedure, organizations can engender trust and long-term relationships with publics and stakeholders (Bowen, 2004a, 2005). Analyses should be as objective, independent, and open to as many varied perspectives as possible—a concept known as *moral autonomy* (Kant, 1948). By making analyses rigorous and multisided, resulting decisions are more thorough, inclusive, and enduring. Although it is commonly conceptualized as absolute independence, a philosopher noted that "rationality emphasizes partiality" (p. 67) by analyzing decisions in terms one would be happy in receiving oneself (Goodpaster, 2007).

Respect. Almost every form of moral philosophy in existence contains a key tenet of respect, sometimes referred to as maintaining dignity, non-usury, or reversibility. The rights of humans are inherent regardless of their place, socioeconomic status, demographic status, or other variables, eliminating bias. Deontology (Kant, 1793/1974) excels at creating decisions based on dignity and respect because it is based in the equality, inclusion, and respect (and therefore moral duty) of all people.

Treating stakeholders with dignity and respect results in better decisions, counseling, inclusiveness, and improved strategy. In this manner, public relations serves an ethical role that facilitates an organization's position within society (Bowen, 2010). If respect is used as the core basis of decision-making, resulting decisions can be understood by stakeholders even if not agreed-upon, making them rationally defensible because they do not alienate or infringe upon dignity.

Idealism or Principled Behavior. CCOs must be conversant with ethics, able to engage in a rational analyses, and able to articulate their conclusions. Ethical decisions cannot be made in a moral vacuum, a legalistic or compliance-based culture, or a culture that coerces (Goodpaster, 2007). However, if the moral autonomy necessary to engage in ethical analyses is present (Bowen, 2006), the CCO can help lead and create organizational values and implementation in operations and policy. Many CCOs report such behavior and observe that ethics is needed in uncertainties, competing right answers, or competing duties (Bowen, 2008).

Deontology. Wright (1985) studied moral development among practitioners: as they gain experience, along with age, they are more likely to employ moral principles, idealism, and duty-based methods of problem solving than those based in moral or cultural relativism. Millennial public relations professionals were found to prefer deontology (Curtin et al., 2011). At the deontological principled or autonomous levels of reasoning, these managers become leaders and work to solve conflict.

Deontology is arguably the most rigorous form of ethics (Baron, 1995). Its creator, Immanuel Kant, outlined three categorical imperatives: universal obligation, dignity and respect, and good intention. Universal obligation means that the decision-maker could obligate all other rational people to do what he or she is about to do (Sullivan, 1994). Kant's rule commanded us to treat others as ends in and of themselves; rather than means to an end, preventing usury, exploitation, and selfishness (Kant, 1785/1964). And the rule of good intention required decision-makers to act only on good intention or what Kant termed a morally "good will" (p. 154) to act from good intent.

The deontological framework considers intention and combines well with an organizational culture and leadership that seek to be ethical, instilling ethical consideration throughout its activities. Furthermore, these three rules are consistent with autonomous and principled decision-making, rather than cultural norms or role conformity. They require rationality, autonomy, and critical analysis to implement. Employing these three standards in internal communication would strengthen the rigor and defensibility of organizational ethics and policies, and foster an organizational culture of ethics.

Moral courage. Moral courage, or the willingness to raise and argue difficult issues, often in the face of opposition (Kidder, 2005), plays an ethical role for the CCO. Moral courage requires not only ethical

expertise but also respect within the dominant coalition. CCOs who are encouraged to dissent often present valuable information in the form of avoiding "groupthink" (Bowen, 2009), thereby resulting in more strategic decisions overall (Van Ruler & Verčič, 2005).

Another study (Bowen, 2005) stressed the value of ethical discussion within the communication climate as a way to create sound and inclusive group analyses, as opposed to simply assuming that ethical decisions are made when good people are hired. This finding reinforces ethics as part of internal communication, resulting in engaged employee behaviors and actions at all levels (Mazzei et al., 2019). This chapter offers an approach designed to instantiate ethics throughout the organization beyond institutionalization termed "enacted"ethics in the model introduced below.

Conceptual Model: ENACTED Ethics

Institutionalization of ethics into an organizational culture is a concept described in the literature as needing constant attention and reinforcement in order to be successful (Sims, 1991, 1994). Even with strong codes of ethics, institutionalization has been found to be dependent on organizational culture, current leadership, and may be lacking an element of fortitude (Bowen, 2002; Goodpaster, 2007; Sims & Brinkman, 2003). Therefore, this chapter seeks to enhance our understanding and augment that concept with a conceptual model based on the principle of enactment.

A key feature of this chapter is the concept of enactment: it is an acronym, but above all it indicates an active behavioral element related to ethics. Enactment implies that leadership and employees at all levels are acting in accordance with ethical values and standards espoused by the organization. It also means that ethics is a demonstrable and active part of the organizational culture, modeled and discussed in narrative, as opposed to a rarely-used element of policy. The ENACTED acronym signifies: engaged, narrative, authentic, conscience, theoretical, empowered, and decisive.

Empirical research described in a prior study (Bowen, 2015), combined with the moral philosophy literature, and organizational culture and leadership, resulted in a refined model of institutionalization, designed to create a long lasting ethics within an organizational culture. Please see the summary Table 16.1 of the ENACTED ethics model and the description of the acronym.

Table 16.1 The model for "ENACTED Ethics," summary of key concepts and acronym

Enacted ethics model and acronym		
Term	*Action/question*	*Philosophical keys to the concept*
Engaged	Are we listening, caring, and attentive?	Listening, leading by example, taking action proving words
Narrative	Can we talk about this? Can we tell stories and engage in dialogue?	Dialogue, honest, storytelling, open discussion, researching, learning, teamwork, group discussion
Authentic	Are our actions in line with our values? Are we on the inside who we appear to be on the outside?	Integrity, genuineness, openness, veracity
Conscience	We can do this thing; but, *should* we do this thing? Is it right?	Justice, rights, fairness, consequences, ought, and outcome
Theoretical	Are we rational, maintaining respect, doing our duty, and hold the intention to do the right thing?	Rationality, respect, idealism, principal, duty, moral, intention to do what is right
Empowered	Are we able to act on what we determine to be right, without constraint or fear?	Autonomous, objective, authority, influence, unselfishness, activist, power
Decisive	Are we ready to determine and argue for	Moral courage, unafraid, without fear of reprisal,

Enacted ethics model and acronym		
Term	*Action/question*	*Philosophical keys to the concept*
	what is right, with moral autonomy?	belief in one's analysis and values, conviction

This table, in summarizing numerous complex constructs, hopes to provide a roadmap to ingraining ethics in an organizational culture. The enacted ethics model resolves a main problem in the literature on sustaining ethics: it goes beyond the institutionalization of ethics to include a change to organizational culture in which ethics become self-sustaining through action. This long-term approach requires attention to action from leaders to model ethical behavior as a starting point, but becomes ingrained into actions at all levels by employees acting on organizational values over time. In this manner, the culture adopts an enacted sense of ethics that is no longer dependent on a leader but has become a part of the institution, acting routinely.

Conclusion: Intentionally Ethical Internal Communication

As highlighted by the studies reviewed here, there are numerous reasons to include ethics in internal communication, such as fulfilling moral autonomy shared value and social responsibility, employee engagement, enhanced behaviors, and even a sense of employee safety and emotional security. However, making ethics enacted goes beyond simply institutionalizing ethics into the routine operations of an organization. Going further than institutionalization to make ethics enacted throughout the organization is a multi-faceted and complex pursuit to undertake—but great efficiencies can result from these efforts.

Practical Suggestions

To make an organization, and its internal communication based on enacted ethics, one must pay a great deal of attention to organizational culture, instilling a participative and open approach to discussion and narrative about ethics, identifying and resolving ethical dilemmas, and working inclusively of numerous perspectives among employees. Leadership must also demonstrate the ethical traits of enacting and

authentic and servant leadership style, facilitating success, support, and understanding for employees at all levels throughout the organization. Leaders must intentionally work ethics into their discussions, decisions, and communications, to offer the ability to model ethical values and behavior to employees at all levels. It is essential that ethics be included in daily decision-making and employee performance reviews. Incentivizing ethical behavior with rewards and recognition also play an important role in the enacted culture of ethics. The "enacted" acronym displayed in Table 16.1 should be memorable and useful in helping internal communicators enact an ethical organizational culture and model ethical behavior.

Communication managers should familiarize themselves with the ethical tenets reviewed in this chapter. Using duty-based, deontological ethics offers an opportunity to examine the intention undergirding decisions, as well as the universal principle at hand, and maintains dignity and respect for internal employee stakeholders and external publics.

In summary, as the most rigorous form of ethics, deontology can enhance the moral rectitude of organizations while helping them to become a fulfilling part of employees' lives, resulting in efficiencies such as lowered turnover, increased engagement, improved relationships, positive employee behaviors, and good intention that offers a strategic resource for the future. This model should address gaps in institutionalization and help foster ethics as an important part of internal communication for the long term. Enacting a commitment to ethics through modeling and instilling the concepts discussed above in routine use means that ethics will be self-sustaining, frequently used by employees at all levels, a sustained part of organizational culture, and extend into the future.

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17

CORPORATE HERITAGE FOR EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION

Investing in History to Shape the Future

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Corporate heritage—which has been investigated especially as an external communication strategy—represents a strategic leverage for internal and employee engagement in organizations, claiming for monographic studies by international scholars. Corporate heritage management, currently gaining international prominence (Aaker, 1996; Balmer, 2017; Urde et al., 2007), can be implemented by companies that possess historical significance as well as those that do not have a long or ancient history. It serves as valuable platforms for cultivating corporate culture and identity, by fostering quality relationships among employees and external stakeholders such as customers, visitors, business partners, educational institutions, government bodies, and local communities.

This chapter delves into various communication contexts and media that, both on and offline, shape a company's heritage mix addressed to support internal relationships (Martino, 2013; Napolitano et al., 2018). The levers include corporate museums and collections, historical archives, ceremonies and special events, identity and workplace design, communication campaigns, training, as well as publishing initiatives, with a particular focus on company monographs and multimedia, and implications for theory and practice.

Corporate Heritage and Identity for Employee Communication

Corporate History and Memory

Several international studies have investigated the strategic-operational models supporting the management of corporate memory and heritage, but they have only rarely focused on those internal and organizational strategies which are, instead, at the basis of an effective heritage management process from the top. In the New Millennium and especially after 2010, several trends can explain a worldwide spread of heritage branding strategies and, as a consequence, a growing attention by international scholars in several disciplines. It is possible to mention the evolution of strategic communication from a marketing approach to a corporate and integrated one, promoting organizations beyond products and services (Argenti, 2009; Cornelissen, 2011; Goodman & Hirsch, 2010). Moreover, from the unique experience of *historical companies*,[1] the topics concerning organizational longevity, vitality, and memory are attracting a growing interest by both scholars and professionals (de Geus, 1997; Giaretta, 2004; Rossato, 2013; Stadler, 2011), since a condition of "permacrisis", institutionalized by COVID-19 pandemic, seems to dramatically challenge life expectancy that is already short for private companies.

Furthermore, organizational studies have developed the concept of organizational memory and investigated its role as an intangible asset (Kransdorff, 2006; Wexler, 2002). This scholarship draws upon knowledge management and cultural approaches. Through these approaches, studies may orient toward *instrumental* uses or, alternatively, toward *expressive* and narrative perspectives by organizations. Results suggest that organizations tend to rediscover their own memory and roots when they cope and adapt to a changing environment, as the awareness of the past can reinforce corporate identity and reputation, by cultivating relationships with the stakeholders and attitudes toward innovation. Organizational changes and crises, as well as relevant corporate anniversaries, can offer companies decisive occasions for rediscovering their history and activate it as a strategic identity asset (Martino, 2013). Such an attitude concerns primarily—but not exclusively—those ancient companies that are at least centennial and value relationships with the internal and external stakeholders, based on ethical values and the communication of a lively company culture.

Corporate Heritage and Identity Management

Our perspective considers the *corpus* of studies on heritage management developed, especially in the last 15 years, both in Italy and abroad (Balmer, 2017; Martino, 2013; Martino & Lovari, 2016; Napolitano et al., 2018), for application into the field of internal and employee communication (Mazzei, 2014; Men & Bowen, 2016).

Studies exploring the temporal dimension of branding (Burghausen & Balmer, 2014) have argued the special relevance of an historical approach especially for corporate marketing and communication strategies. Indeed, in an age characterized by economic crisis and globalization, companies become conscious that "any brand, but especially those that are struggling, can benefit from going back to its roots and identifying what made it special and successful in the first place" (Aaker, 2004, p. 7).

Corporate heritage represents an attribute of a company's identity that cannot be imitated by competitors: it values history and authenticity (Gilmore & Pine, 2007) as a basis for distinctiveness in market and corporate positioning (Aaker, 1996, 2004; Balmer, 2017; Balmer & Burghausen, 2018). Every organization (not only centennial ones) has a history and heritage to strategically value, according to some prerequisites focused by a specific *heritage quotient model*, developed by Urde *and colleagues* (2007) and further developed by scholars (Martino, 2023). According to this theoretical model, the heritage potential residing in a company's identity results not only from corporate longevity, as a pure chronological attribute, but also from a wider set of prerequisites: reputation and track record, guaranteed by quality behaviors and products pursuing a company's mission; integrity of company's core values and business ethics; symbolism, or even "iconism" supporting an identity-driven communication strategy; not least, a strategic investment in preserving and valuing corporate history, ideally starting from the creation of a company historical archive as a fundamental platform of heritage management.

Heritage branding process can be defined as a *communication strategy of organizational memory*, which implies not a nostalgic effect but rather the continuity of a company's identity among past, present, and future (Weindruch, 2016). The management of brand heritage includes different stages, such as analysis, activation, and constant stewardship of the heritage potential (Urde et al., 2007). At the executive level, such a process combines several online and offline initiatives: not

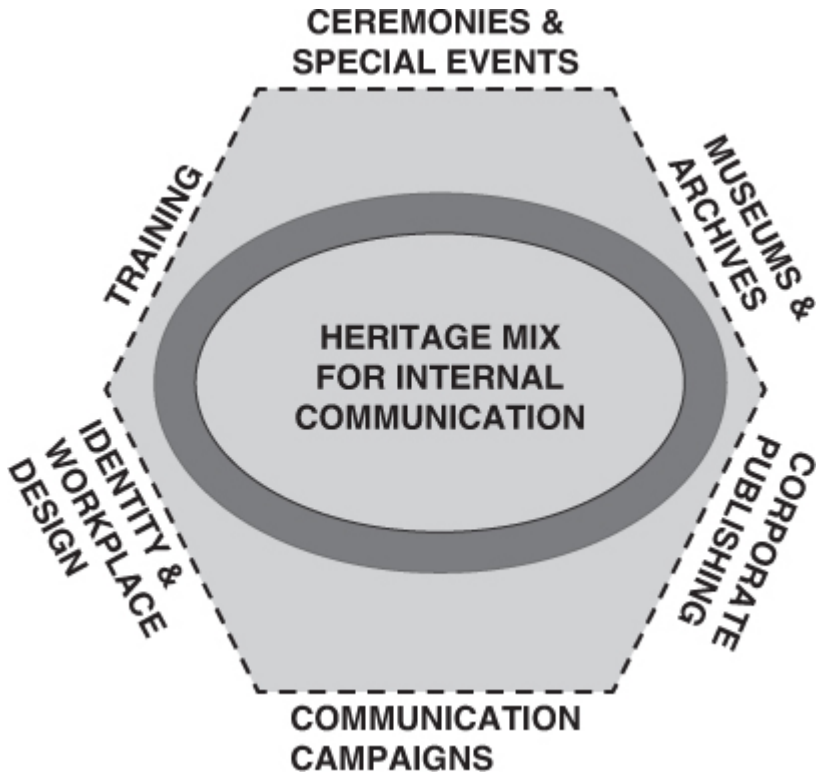
only traditional marketing channels (i.e., advertising, point of purchase, product system and packaging etc.), but also visual identity and workplace design, events, digital platforms, training, and orientation. Furthermore, it is possible to mention some distinctive heritage contexts and tools, such as historical archives, company collections and museums; corporate anniversaries and ceremonies; and corporate publishing and audiovisual storytelling (Martino, 2013; Napolitano et al., 2018).

In the last decade, several theoretical studies have explored heritage branding especially as an emerging corporate communication strategy (Balmer, 2017). This process strictly connects to the opportunity for companies to cultivate quality relationships with the stakeholders, starting from the establishment of a distinctive identity (Albert & Whetten, 1985; Birkigt & Stadler, 1986; van Riel & Balmer, 1997), rooted on corporate culture and core values and aware of a company's history. The assumption that corporate heritage is a key component of corporate identity and the identification process (Aaker, 1996), and that, so conceived, it unfolds in internal communication processes, clearly enlightens the primary role of employees and organizational stakeholders to activate internally a strategic process of heritage management, which could integrate also external key publics, such as customers, opinion leaders, and local community.

Corporate heritage must be considered the result of a *relational and political process*, constantly negotiated with the stakeholders. On the one hand, organizations create their own collective memory starting from the "official" aspects of corporate history that corporate leaders are interested in valuing in the present and to shape the future (Kransdorff, 2006; Weindruch, 2016). On the other hand, the recovery of a company's heritage can become, in some cases, a passionate community experience, often engaging the internal community (e.g., offering testimonies and oral memories of the past) and other key publics such as collectors, business partners, and long-standing clients.

Internal "Heritage Mix": A Strategic Kit for Organizations

The following sections offer a review of several contexts and channels, both analogical and digital, supporting a process of heritage management rooted in internal relationships (summarized in Figure 17.1): ceremonies and special events; corporate identity and workplace design; historic archives and museums; corporate publishing; communication campaigns; training services and activities.



▶ Long Description for Figure 17.1

Figure 17.1 The heritage mix for internal communication and employees engagement.

Such components of the internal *heritage mix* (Martino, 2013) are strictly interconnected one to other and largely overlapping to the initiatives dedicated to external stakeholders. Thus according to an integrated communication approach and considering the continuous interaction between offline and online environments, as well as between private and public dimensions in contemporary communication ecologies.

Ceremonies and Special Events

As previous studies highlighted, organizations tend to rediscover their own historical memory especially when they face moments of discontinuity and change in their own life such as internationalization, business mergers and acquisitions, and financial quotations, whose success requests an identity "re-foundation". The same happens when companies are near to celebrating relevant corporate anniversaries, especially centenaries or other "round" company birthdays (25, 50 years or other full decades): on the one hand, they stand as a moment of strategic balance and restarting in a company's history, on the other they

claim—as a form of social obligation—a wide stakeholder engagement (Weindruch, 2016).

A celebratory program should start just from the internal stakeholders and, if possible, engage them not only as publics, but rather as major actors and partners into a multiplicity of initiatives also involving the local community and all the stakeholders. Indeed, the meaning of celebrating a company birthday is to regenerate the sense of a communal belonging by means of "ceremonies" and "rituals" (Deal & Key, 1998) able to engage and put together—ideally without any exclusion—company leaders, employees, and key publics such as families, retired personnel, business partners, top clients, opinion leaders, institutions, consumers, media systems, and local community. Thus, anniversaries play an important role for corporate identity and, if memorable, can mark milestones in a company's history, with positive effects on employees' loyalty and engagement.

The focus of corporate anniversaries is usually a special live event, such as an historical retrospective or exhibition, dedicated to employees as well as external publics, hosted at the corporate headquarters or in prestigious independent cultural centers. Anniversaries can be communicated in advance, stimulating a "teaser effect", and can also express a strategic *legacy* that is valuable in the medium to long term at the level of stakeholder engagement. For example, this could be achieved by publishing a corporate monograph, creating a corporate historic archive, and/or company museum to institutionalize the investment in corporate heritage. Not least, an anniversary can be an ideal opportunity to launch and celebrate new corporate activities: a company site, an innovative business, a welfare program, or other special activities and "gifts" dedicated to the internal stakeholders, as a form of thanksgiving (not necessarily intended as a monetary incentive) for their loyalty and commitment on the job.

A strong internal communication commitment distinguishes the special event planning for the 50th anniversary celebrated in 2012 by Enel Group, leader in Italy in the energy sector (Martino & Lovari, 2014). In addition to a multi-channel marketing and corporate communication campaign, several initiatives were dedicated to current and former employees and their families: online contest, in-house and external historical exhibitions, internal media activity (house organ, corporate radio and television, Intranet, monographs), and in-house billposting. Among the special events promoted all around Italy and abroad, in the countries where Enel carries on its business, the

company's sites simultaneously hosted a party for the "family birthday", in which more than 10,000 workers and their children actively participated.

Another privileged observatory is offered by BEA World—The International Festival of Events and Live Communication. In this frame, a Best Event Awards was launched in 2006 to promote excellence in event communication, to dedicate a specific category "Celebration and festivity" to reward those corporate events organized to commemorate a recurrence or anniversary by companies from all around the world.

Identity and Workplace Design

Corporate heritage can become a living part of a company's identity by investing in visual communication, strategic statements, and workplace design.

At the basis of a wider brand identification system, the logotype can be considered the most essential and recognizable icon representing an organization and its community, in which employees and managers should recognize the sense of a collective belonging. The visual identity of a company can evoke company history, for example by the graphic design or lettering style. An explicit reference to tradition tends to be embedded into a company's brand—sort of modern "heraldic crest"—as the result of a *restyling* process to support special events or anniversaries, for example by mentioning company's age, the date of foundation, a relevant corporate "birthday", or other historical symbols (e.g., founder, places, etc.).

The value of tradition, when rooted, can also be inscribed into a company's mission statement. By inserting in such a strategic text the different rhetorical reminders of the past, these statements can not only underline historical continuity as a basis for reputation, but also inspire those behaviors by employees, collaborators, and managers in line with stakeholders' and society's needs.

Workplaces and company headquarters can be strategic contexts to value and reinforce a company's heritage by evoking its corporate history and "icons" (Weindruch, 2016) in several ways: historical setting-ups, in-house permanent exhibitions with art or historical content, and heritage-style merchandising dedicated to employees. Not least, factory or institutional tours open to family and external visitors can include, when present, an in-house organization's museum.

This is the case of those universities, not only ancient or centennial ones, whose internal communications, locations, and merchandising strategically value tradition and affiliation to a long-standing cultural history (Martino, 2013). Among them is Sapienza University of Rome in Italy, one of the most ancient universities in the world. Its identity system (rebranded in 2003 for its 700th anniversary) reproduced the cherub inscribed by Francesco Borromini in the dome of Saint Ivo Church, which hosts the ancient Studium Urbis in Rome. All these elements related to design, symbols, and brand identity should be strategically communicated to new personnel, employees, and students to live the value of heritage branding in daily organizational activities.

Historical Archives and Corporate Museums

Historic archives and corporate museums, whose foundation is often a legacy consequent to an important company anniversary, are the two major centers conserving and valuing corporate memory and culture (Bulegato, 2008; Coleman, 1943; Danilov, 1991, 1992).

A historical archive represents a privileged source of organizational memory and intelligence, by supporting a company's legal, research, and creative activity, especially in the field of communication and design (Wexler, 2002), with services that are open sometimes also to a variety of external publics (e.g., scholars, students, professionals, journalists). Corporate museums, in contrast, are distinctive for their explicit focus on exhibition and public engagement: this characteristic allows them to serve as a powerful medium for shaping and communicating a company's identity (Martino, 2013). Museums play a vital role in conveying a company's cultural identity to the community and stakeholders, by cultivating a unique and privileged relationship with employees and managers. Indeed, the primary role of these cultural centers is an internal and organizational one: they are depositories of values, archetypes, and identity symbols for companies interested in recovering, preserving, and researching their own past as communicative capital to be strategically re-used in the present. This process, driven by a collective identity process, aims to engage all the stakeholders, including employees.

Corporate historical archives and museums do not limit themselves to a form of pure conservation, representation, and celebration of the past, but play an identity and creative function: within such centers, indeed, corporate past is reconstructed and rewritten by organizations in a

dynamic way (Parker, 2002), shaping the vision (and, thus, the future) of an organization by selecting what leaders want to preserve or, instead, to condemn to organizational decline and "amnesia" (Kransdorff, 2006).

A strategic interchange is especially the one between the historical archive and the departments/roles responsible for communication and other kinds of creative activities. On the one hand, archivists are called on to support current corporate activities with inspiring identity contents and historical information retraced from a company's heritage; on the other, communication managers have the responsibility to deposit in real time into the historical archive those projects and campaigns developed over time, to foster contents available, in the long period, for new campaigns and activities.

Italy offers a very special observatory in this area, since the number of corporate museums and historical archives are spread all around the country, also among Small and Medium Enterprises and local firms and especially in the sectors representing the "Made in Italy" excellence worldwide. For instance, a network of 130 corporate museums and cultural centers is the one promoted by Museimpresa, the Italian Association of Business Archives and Corporate Museums. The association was founded in 2001 by the major Italian entrepreneurial associations and a pool of world-wide known heritage brands, among which Alessi, Alfa Romeo, Barilla, Birra Peroni, Ducati, Ferragamo, Olivetti, Piaggio, and Pirelli.

Among them, an excellent example for a museum as leverage for internal relationships is represented by Alessi, historical Italian home design producer. Alessi museum in Omegna (Piedmont) has been conceived, since its creation in 1997, as a strategic archive and internal laboratory preserving the memory of design products and projects produced in the past by the company, as well as by its partners and competitors. The museum's rooms host daily meetings, educational training, cultural events that foster and enhance the internal and creative community of designers and professionals. They are also open to external users upon request.

Corporate Publishing

Among the several channels supporting the internal heritage mix, a special role is played by corporate publishing. This is a very heterogeneous sector, including several genres to create and diffuse original heritage contents toward the internal stakeholders:

- company profile, that should include not only facts and figure about the organization, but also information about its mission and history;
- company books, dedicated to the official storytelling on corporate history and activities, often celebrating special corporate events, and anniversaries;
- house organs, corporate magazines and newsletters, representing—both in their paper and digital edition—one of the most relevant channels of internal communication, diffusing information and contents about a company's history and life among employees and managers;
- corporate video, reporting the visual storytelling of a company's history and major historical figures, produced internally or in partnership with specialized communication agencies;
- welcome books, ethical codes, and other internal manuals, introducing an organization's rules and values to the incoming members, also with paying specific reference to corporate history.

In a highly digitalized world, a growing prominence is gained by multimedia contents focused on corporate heritage, such as audiopodcasts, short movies, and documentaries retracing the history of organizations, products and entrepreneurs, in continuity with a very illustrious tradition of industrial cinematography along the 20th century (Hediger & Vonderau, 2009; Robertson, 2001). In the recent years, relevant international productions have been promoted by some of the most relevant "Made in Italy" brands in collaboration with well-known authors: among the examples, it is possible to mention the 2021 movie *Salvatore: Shoemaker of Dreams*, dedicated to Salvatore Ferragamo by the famous director Luca Guadagnino. It is also worthy to remember the contemporary Italian corporate movies production, addressed to both the internal and external stakeholders, which has been rewarded from 2023 by the national "Film Impresa Award" by Unindustria Association, valuing a brilliant tradition of companies' audiovisual storytelling.

A special role for internal heritage management is also played by the other genres of corporate publishing. A company's heritage can inspire, for example, the writing of ethical codes and charters of values explicitly remanding to the founder's moral legacy. This is the case, for example, of the well-known "The Testament of a Furniture Dealer": a document written in 1976 by Ikea's founder Ingvar Kamprad and further integrated in 1996 with a short corporate dictionary defining the set of values "to

create a better everyday life for the many people by offering a wide range of well-designed, functional home furnishing products at prices so low that as many people as possible will be able to afford them". Another classic example is the *Decalogue* about the rules of people management written by Michele Ferrero, son of Pietro, the founder of the Italian food corporation Ferrero, the house of the worldwide famous Nutella brand.

In a corporate heritage strategy, company books play a central role. These include entrepreneurial historiographies, biographies, and other cultural and corporate editions (including catalogues of corporate historical collections and exhibitions) that are promoted by companies and organizations to preserve their corporate history, life, and identity, and to communicate them to the stakeholders (Hasenbeck & Wolf, 2011; Martino, 2023). Company books represent not only a static and exclusive cultural "object", but rather an "objectivation" resulting from a process of *meta-communication* about corporate identity, starting just from company's leaders and the internal stakeholders (Delahaye et al., 2009).

The potential of such monographs for corporate heritage (when they are not simply conceived as a form of glossy "image book") is then to exalt, more than any other medium, the biographical and reflective experience that company leaders can invest in when deciding to reconstruct and narrate a company's story (Czarniawska, 1997; Czarniawska & de Monthoux, 1994). Indeed, such a powerful analogical medium stands as the most complex identity and cultural context for organizations (Invernizzi & Romenti, 2020; Klug, 2016): on the one side, they have an opportunity to look inside themselves and rediscover their own "soul" and core values assuring success over time (Schein, 2000); on the other, this genre of storytelling is effective when capable of representing a company as a community of persons, expressing their own stories and faces (Martino, 2023).

A rooted corporate publishing tradition distinguishing the Italian case is currently valued by some specialized centers, aiming at collecting and preserving several genres of company monographs. Among the experiences, BiblHuB is the specialized research library Sapienza University of Rome dedicated since 2018 to corporate heritage and narratives. The aim is to collect company books from private, public, and nonprofit organizations, to study and value them by means of cultural, educational, and scientific activities.

Internal Communication Campaigns

Corporate heritage can be the focus of specific internal communication campaigns. Analogical and digital channels offer to companies the opportunity to value their own culture and history according to a transmedia and *history-telling* approach (Martino, 2018).

Thanks to digital reproducibility, corporate heritage, preserved by a company's historical archives, can be actualized and re-used by companies in several contexts, also addressed to employees: intranet, internal social media channels (i.e., Facebook Connect, or other platforms), organizational contests, app, instant messaging tools, and integrated digital campaigns. Digital connections and online networks offer the opportunity to value the community and participatory potential of corporate heritage: for example, by means of internal campaigns addressed to research and collect historical documents, products or oral memories from actual and former employees, or to engage the internal stakeholders in producing and sharing grassroot heritage contents (e.g., photographs, texts, videos), also in the form of a creative contest dedicated to internal stakeholders.

In general, former and current employees and their families stand as fundamental stakeholders: on and offline campaigns can stimulate them not only to strategically use corporate heritage and museums, but first of all to collectively contribute to reconstruct the past. Indeed, they can be engaged to provide companies with those historical objects and testimonies that are the essential contents of a corporate heritage strategy investing in corporate expositions, archives, museums, and monographs. Corporate birthdays can offer the ideal occasion for an integrated corporate campaign starting just from the internal community, to stimulate wide-range employee engagement and internal media activation (Martino & Lovari, 2016).

Training Services

Internal relations represent a privileged context for involving the several components of a company's community by specific formative and orientation initiatives to inform employees and managers both at the technical and cultural level, to align their behaviors to corporate values, mission, and "house-style".

Corporate heritage can have a relevant part in organizing meetings and delivering formative programs, especially when hosted by historical company sites or in-house corporate museums. Furthermore, a specific historic training should be dedicated to incoming interns, apprentices,

and managers by offering them an “immersion” within company culture and history. This is possible by means of workshop or “induction tours” along the corporate museum, archives, or other sites with special historical relevance.

Formative and learning initiatives based on corporate heritage can also support specific programs of change management to promote organizational changing or even extraordinary business operations (such us mergers and acquisitions, financial quotations, and internationalization), expressing a potentially disruptive effect for corporate identity. Company archives and museums can be conceived as key assets supporting change management strategies carried on by multinational companies and corporations: they represent cultural “laboratories” to regenerate company culture, its symbols, and rituals and educate employees, managers, and business partners to a company’s values.

This is the example of the historical beverage corporation Birra Peroni-Nastro Azzurro promoting an integrated strategy of corporate heritage management whose focus lies in the historical archive and corporate museum. Founded in Rome in 2000-2001, both these cultural centers are overseen by the Corporate Relations department and collaborate with the Human Resources department and other business units. In order to bolster the corporate identity and reputation on the global stage, training and orientation programs with a primary focus on heritage-related contents are tailored for employees, new recruits, and business partners, hosted by the spaces of the company’s historical archive and museum.

From 2023, Birra Peroni’s Human Resource Department has institutionalized a periodic activity of employer branding and induction dedicated to groups of internal “special guests”, such as newly hired employees, interns, and advisors. Corporate heritage is the focus of a specific *onboarding program* to “immerse” the newcomers in Birra Peroni-Nastro Azzuro’s brand history and culture: the service includes a welcome coffee, a factory tour to observe industrial processes and products, a visit to the historical archive and museum, and a final tasting with a beer expert.

Conclusions

Communication contexts, tools, and experiences suggest that internal relationships must be considered and valued as a fundamental platform

for heritage management strategies, starting from company's culture and identity (Albert & Whetten, 1985; Birkigt & Stadler, 1986; van Riel & Balmer, 1997). The strategic role that culture and identity play for community building strategies—the basis of the sense of organizational belonging among workers—also explains a growing investment in corporate heritage after the COVID-19 pandemic. This trend is documented in Italy by a healthy company publishing activity (Martino, 2023), as well as by the growth in number of historical museums and archives affiliated with the Museimpresa association, as shown on the official website.

Employees and managers represent the primary stakeholders for establishing and empowering corporate identity, by a strategy aiming at preserving and valuing a company's history in the form of enduring heritage, to foster quality relationships with the economic and social stakeholders. Indeed, corporate heritage can have a positive effect on the trio *symbols-messages-behaviors* that Birkigt and Stadler (1986) proposed as the elements of the classic corporate *identity mix model* by van Riel & Balmer (1997), further developed by Mazzei (2014) who added *relationships*, meaning those indirect and interpersonal networks —first of all, of employees—for which an organization is the object, rather than the promoter, of communication (Balmer & Gray, 1999). For companies willing to preserve and strategically invest in corporate heritage, it can serve all the major specific scopes of internal communication strategies and campaigns: to enable and empower people in the organization; to cultivate corporate identification and communal belonging; to engage the internal stakeholder; and, not least, to manage the change and promote innovation (Invernizzi & Romenti, 2020).

Practically, the internal *toolkit* can be used to value and integrate into a strategic mix the several contexts and tools supporting, both on and offline, an internal process of corporate identity and heritage management, as a basis for external positioning and communication for which employees can play a strategic role of *ambassadorship* and *megaphoning* (Heide & Simonsson, 2018; Kim & Rhee, 2011). On the one hand, the rediscovery of social and corporate memory, intended as a form of social and corporate heritage, seems to be strictly related with the rise of digital channels and social media platforms, producing and spreading messages and images which can make the "communication of the past" appealing for the media system, and, above all, engaging for different online publics. On the other hand, the experience of long-standing and institutionalized companies suggests to not underestimate,

especially in an hyper-mediated and post-pandemic word, the organizational relevance of those organizational rituals, symbols, and analogical media—such as company book, museums, and celebrations—expressing a very special power in supporting a strategic *meta-communication* process in the long-term and, thus, the foundation of a consistent and lively corporate identity.

Note

1. In Italy, such a rising sensitivity is demonstrated by several associative networks and normative initiatives which have been launched, especially from 2000, to promote historical companies' culture and their leading role in the national entrepreneurship. In particular, we can mention the specific labeling the Italian Ministry of Enterprises and Made in Italy reserves from 2020 to those historical companies with more than 50 years of successful business activity; and the Corporate Heritage Awards, recognizing the best corporate heritage campaigns promoted by Italian firms since 2022.

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18

EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION AND ORGANIZING IN NOT-FOR-PROFITS

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Some might wonder why a book about "employee" communication includes a chapter about nonprofit organizing. One reason is that volunteers constitute a significant global workforce: The United Nations Volunteer program's (2021) *2022 State of the World's Volunteerism Report* estimates that 6.5% of the adult population engages with a volunteer-involving organization, and the volunteer sector accounts for 2.4% of global GDP. These figures support Tice et al.'s (2013) assertion that recent decades have witnessed "a 'global associational revolution,' a major upsurge of organized, private, voluntary and nonprofit activity" (p. 1). Given the importance of the nonprofit and voluntary sector, this chapter has three objectives: (1) to define what a nonprofit organization is; (2) to discuss trends and tensions in nonprofit contexts that affect employee communication; and (3) to set out a research-informed agenda for future scholarship on nonprofit organizing and employee communication.

What Is a Nonprofit Organization?

Defining a nonprofit or not-for-profit organization (NPO) is challenging. The nonprofit (Frumkin, 2009), civil society (Salamon & Anheier, 1997), third (Macmillan, 2013), or voluntaristic (Smith et al., 2017) sector in which NPOs operate is highly heterogeneous. NPOs are found in

multiple settings, including education, healthcare, welfare, arts and culture, environmental protection, and sports (Wolf, 2022). Their size ranges from small grass-roots volunteer-only organizations (e.g., local performing arts' collectives) to large, hierarchical organizations with multi-million-dollar budgets that employ professional staff (e.g., university teaching hospitals). NPOs' organizational structure and legal framework differ depending on national context (e.g., an organization with a 501(c)(3) tax designation in the United States or a registered charity in Aotearoa New Zealand).

At first glance, the term "non-profit" might seem to tell us only what NPOs are not: Such organizations do not distribute profits back to their owners like private businesses do but use any profit generated to further their organizational mission. Defining NPOs in oppositional terms, however, leads analysts to assess NPOs according to capitalist, for-profit criteria. Accordingly, NPO scholars have identified five structural elements that make organizations "non-profit" (see the Center for Civil Society Studies Archive, 2023; Salamon & Anheier, 1997). In addition to being (1) non-profit-distributing, NPOs are (2) institutionalized "to some degree in terms of their organizational form or system of operation" (Morris, 2000, p. 29), (3) independent from government control, (4) self-governing, and (5) made up of members who contribute voluntarily to the organization's mission.

Key Issues in NPO Organizing

The fifth characteristic—choice or uncoerced participation—raises key issues for employee communication in NPOs. Although some NPOs have paid workforces with few or no volunteers, NPOs that rely heavily on volunteer labor must create commitment and sustain motivation. To retain this workforce, NPOs must understand volunteers' "psychological contracts" or expectations about responsibilities, recognition, and rewards. Manuals about volunteer management encourage NPOs to demonstrate appreciation, offer symbolic rewards, and foster meaningful involvement (e.g., Brudney, 2016). Many NPOs use Clary et al.'s (1992) popular volunteer functions inventory (VFI) to identify volunteers' motivations. According to the VFI, volunteering allows individuals to express their *values*; gain relevant *career experience*; create *social connections*; develop *understanding* and skills; protect themselves against a *negative sense of self*; and enhance *positive self-worth*. Because volunteers with varied views of what volunteering means—unpaid work,

activist activity, or a form of serious leisure, among others—will have different sets of motivations, NPOs need to adjust volunteer assignments accordingly.

Arguably, most volunteers expect to experience relatively high levels of freedom and flexibility in their roles (Einolf & Yung, 2018; Pearce, 1993). Consequently, NPOs can find that their ability to monitor volunteer workers is limited, especially in the case of "peripheral" volunteers whose contribution is not central to achieving organizational mission. Astonishingly, in comparison to the voluminous research about volunteer motivation and commitment, few studies describe volunteer exit or how NPOs might "fire" volunteers who perform poorly, hold incompatible values, or deliberately ignore or undermine organizational practices (McAllum, 2013). Wayward volunteers may do damage even if they engage only sporadically or are no longer officially on an NPO's books. This happened in McAllum's (2018) study where volunteers for Refugee Services, an NPO that helps refugees with resettlement and socio-cultural integration, broke organizational rules but continued to insist that they were "Refugee Services volunteers", even after the end of their mandate. This lack of clarity about when volunteers' membership expires and when they stop representing or being part of an organization offers an excellent example of fuzzy or permeable organizational boundaries (Bimber et al., 2012).

The difficulty of identifying when volunteers are "in" an organization or not problematizes the idea that organizations are pre-existing containers within which "communication flows or information is transmitted" (Koschmann & Campbell, 2019, p. 175). Instead, volunteers and other NPO members' way of communicating is "a social process that *creates* meaning rather than simply expressing it (Kuhn, 2008),…a central organizing process that produces organizational life (Ashcraft, Kuhn, & Cooren, 2009)" (Sanders, 2015, p. 209, our italics). From this perspective, communication is constitutive of the type of organizing that gets done and the type of organization that an NPO can become.

An Evolving NPO Landscape

Communication with other stakeholders also influences how NPO organizing unfolds. The contemporary socio-economic and political environment means that three of the five key elements in Salamon and Anheier's (1997) definition of nonprofitness are less likely to be present in a pure form: (1) NPOs' non-profit-distributing orientation; (2) NPOs'

independence from government; and (3) NPOs' self-governance and autonomy. Specifically, as the economies of developed nations that formed part of the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development deregulated during the 1980s, they privatized many state entities that provided education, healthcare, and social welfare services. Governments hoped NPOs would pick up the slack and offered short-term, competitive government contracts to those that did so (Ganesh & McAllum, 2012). Subsequently, NPOs have lived through an era of "sector bending" (Dees & Anderson, 2003), such that the NPO sector now embraces a wide range of private/public organizational hybrids. NPOs that partner with government institutions or accept government-funded contracts often face regulatory constraints, demands for documentation and accountability, and pressure to demonstrate they have efficiently achieved predetermined outcomes, all of which threaten their self-governance and autonomy. In addition to NPO-government partnerships that predominate in the United States, the United Kingdom, Australia, and Aotearoa New Zealand, new organizational forms such as "'social enterprises' that combine volunteer contributions, sales/fees from users, and public subsidies,…fourth sector organizations, for-benefit organizations, blended value organizations, for-profits with a non-profit soul" (McAllum, 2018, p. 535) experiment with and blend for-profit and nonprofit practices, particularly in Europe. These trends exacerbate several tensions in nonprofit contexts that affect employee communication: mission-money and consensus-conflict.

Tension 1: Mission–Money

NPOs that spend large amounts of time seeking external funds and justifying how they use the monies they receive frequently experience mission drift. Because NPOs are increasingly "guided by internal efforts *and external mandates* to build capacity" (Shumate et al., 2017, p. 155, our italics), mission drift leads organizations to invest time, energy, and resources in achieving more easily achievable outcomes and abandon their efforts to serve society's neediest members because results are less certain, more intangible, and if they occur at all, take time. In a precarious funding environment, NPOs whose original mission targeted non-profitable, ambitious, less easily measured goals may choose to prioritize short-term efficiency and effectiveness. In light of these problems, many academic analysts and practitioners highlight the importance of NPOs' fidelity to their social mission and decry externally

imposed demands to adopt business-like principles and practices imported from market capitalism (Eisenberg & Eschenfelder, 2009; Ganesh & McAllum, 2012; Weisbrod, 2004). Volunteers frequently criticize marketized demands that take the joy out of their involvement or clash with organizational practices based on values such as reciprocity, equality, concern for social justice, and cooperation (Kreutzer & Jager, 2011).

Yet even mission-driven NPOs contain challenges for workers. Employees in the sector receive lower salaries, experience significantly longer work weeks, and donate more "volunteer" hours than their private sector counterparts (Frumkin, 2009). The tendency of employees and volunteers in NPO settings to view their work as highly meaningful makes these workers more prone to over-work and burnout. Dempsey and Sanders' (2010) analysis of social entrepreneurs' autobiographies is illustrative. They note that these popular portrayals, which draw on broader social discourses about meaningful work, "celebrate a troubling account of work/life balance centered on self-sacrifice, underpaid and unpaid labour and the privileging of organizational commitment at the expense of health, family and other aspects of social reproduction" (p. 437). Even more concerning is that organizations can deliberately "paint an exaggerated picture of pro-social impact" (Michaelson et al., 2013, p. 86) to justify longer hours and lower pay.

Given that privileging one pole of the tension, either money *or* mission, over the other is problematic, others suggest that the market/mission tension does not only generate contradictory demands with which NPOs must grapple but that this tension can be productive and generative (Sanders, 2015). Vásquez et al. (2022) likewise invite readers to consider that

> interdependent and mutually exclusive opposites reflect back on and impose on each other (Putnam et al., 2016)…this constant motion creates and maintains the organization (Smith & Lewis, 2011). This approach not only recognizes that the combination of opposing logics raises contradictory demands, [but] it also explores how these demands are interrelated and mutually constitutive.
>
> *(p. 520)*

Making this conceptual and practical move sidesteps the tendency to reduce business practices to a uniform, homogeneous set of organizing practices based on competition and self-interest. Indeed, productive inter-

sectoral collaborations and some of the "new" organizational forms described above provide evidence that "business as usual" is also undergoing significant transformation. Embracing the ambiguities that are present within the mission/market tension also avoids either-or thinking that demonizes or marginalizes commercial practices and privileges nonprofit-ness, while ignoring volunteers and other organizational members' desire for multiple, overlapping goals. Meijs and Ten Hoorn (2008), for instance, found that volunteers expected their role to be flexible and fun, yet they also valued efficiently run NPOs that offered well-structured volunteer assignments.

Tension 2: Visible Consensus–Invisible Conflict

A second tension hinges around the assumption that NPOs offer consensus-based, inclusive cultures in line with Lohmann's (1992) vision of NPOs as a "Commons", or an "organizational space containing activity focused on prosocial behaviors, mutuality, voluntary labor, and the production of collective goods" (Dart, 2004, p. 292). NPOs, then, should be characterized by shared purposes and resources, reciprocity, and fairness. The idea that a transcendent mission and shared identity unite NPO members appears in the frequent use of family metaphors or the tendency to refer to colleagues as friends (Golden-Biddle & Rao, 1997; Mikkelsen, 2012). Consequently, the literature illustrates a desire to avoid or reduce conflicts within NPO settings (Lewis et al., 1997). Golden-Biddle and Rao's research (1997), for instance, revealed that members of a nonprofit board avoided publicly visible conflict by "informally [orienting] the new, more junior members to the norms [of 'pulling together'] by explaining that such disagreement was unfortunate" (p. 599). When non-confrontation was impossible and conflict occurred, board members tried to reestablish agreement rapidly or used a third party. Other studies likewise document NPO members' tendency to downplay conflict by referring to it more neutrally as "difficulties" (Kreutzer & Jager, 2011), "differences of opinion" (Kerwin et al., 2011), or "frictions" (Mikkelsen, 2012). Mikkelsen also found that workers diminished the significance of conflict by blaming it on personality clashes or unavoidable tensions between various organizational subcultures. These practices, which frame conflict as an interpersonal and organizational threat, structure ongoing actions, become institutionalized, and become part of the organizational culture (Lewis et al., 1997; Mikkelsen, 2012).

Yet, as in all organizational settings, conflict is inevitable in NPOs, because they are composed of highly diverse individuals, including paid and volunteer workers, donors, board members, local community groups, and beneficiaries, who need to determine shared objectives and coordinate their activities to achieve these goals (Allyn, 2011; Lewis et al., 1997; Mikkelsen, 2012). Subsequently, they may not make sense of the same situation in the same way, particularly because NPOs "exist without clear and simple lines of ownership and accountability" (Frumkin, 2009, p. 3) due to their multiple stakeholders. NPOs are also more likely to experience conflicts because they must deal with multiple, conflicting organizational identities due to the money/mission tension described in the previous section. Roy and Perrin (2018) argue that NPO members' commitment to specific social values leads them to voice their opinions more forcefully, especially when the NPO's culture encourages dialogue, informal interpersonal relationships, and consensus during decision-making.

Moreover, organizational members with ambiguous job duties and fewer resources may experience more role, task, and status conflict than workers in other sectors (López-Cabrera et al., 2020). Whereas task conflict involves disagreements about what tasks should be carried out and process conflict addresses how tasks should be accomplished, status conflicts occur when organizational members try "to challenge or alter the implicit or explicit established hierarchy" (López-Cabrera et al., p. 4). Status conflicts may be more frequent in nonprofits where paid employees and volunteers work together for several reasons: paid staff and volunteers have divergent views on how to handle situations (Wandersman & Alderman, 1993); paid staff feel frustrated by volunteers' lack of proficiency, expertise, or level of commitment (Rimes et al., 2017; Wandersman & Alderman, 1993); paid staff fear replacement by a volunteer workforce (Macduff & Netting, 2007); and programs to manage volunteers are unwieldy, costly, and/or ineffective (Netting et al., 2004).

Allyn (2011) also contends that NPOs face a unique type of conflict that he calls "mission mirroring", which "occurs when an organization becomes enmeshed *internally* in the same conflicts it was founded to deal with *externally*" (p. 762, italics in the original). Allyn describes situations where an organization focused on combating racism is accused of prejudiced or hateful speech or behavior. We also see organizations that are committed to improving their clients' mental health overloading their employees and pushing them to the edge of burnout. Thus, Allyn

concludes that conflict is part and parcel of mission-centered organizations and strongly recommends deconstructing a vision of "no conflict in non-profits". Pearce (1993) describes conflicts as "one of the unpleasant secrets of non-profit organizations" (p. 142).

Theoretical Tools for Analyzing Employee Communication in NPOs

As this chapter has shown, organizational communication and volunteer/nonprofit research suggests that NPOs are not unmitigatedly mission-focused, cohesive, inclusive, or positive spaces. Instead, they are made up of myriad sets of oppositions, including but not limited to mission/money and consensus/conflict. Many other oppositions such as informality/formality (Vásquez et al., 2022), autonomy/control, intimacy/distance (McNamee & Peterson, 2014), and volunteerism/professionalism (McAllum, 2018) play out in NPO communication and organizing.

A variety of theoretical concepts, including tensions, dialectics, and paradoxes, explain how elements come into opposition within NPOs. The first term, *tensions*, refers to the "stress, anxiety, discomfort, or tightness in making choices, responding to, and moving forward in organizational situations" (Putnam et al., 2016, p. 69). Such stress implies the existence of opposing elements that confront each other in interaction. The second concept, *dialectics*, describes this "dynamic interplay and articulation together of opposites" (Mumby, 2005, p. 23). Communication researchers Baxter and Montgomery's (1996) definition of dialectics as "pulls" or "tugs" in different directions likewise highlights this continual push–pull dynamic within interactions. Members of NPOs may manage dialectics by favoring one pole over another, finding a balance, or trying to create an overarching category that overcomes the oppositional interpretation of the situation. For example, members of an alternative organization or politically oriented NPO that prioritizes inclusion overcame the tension between individual-centric *freedom* (respect for expertise, professional specialization, and personal goals) and collectively oriented *equality* (prioritization of shared knowledge, task adaptability, and group goals) by changing the meanings given to equality. Instead of insisting that all members be equally involved in all tasks and decision-making processes, organizational members prioritized equality of access to information about what was happening and how it was being carried out.

Contradictions can also lead to *paradoxes* or "contradictory yet interrelated elements that exist simultaneously and persist over time. Such elements seem logical when considered in isolation but irrational, inconsistent, and even absurd when juxtaposed" (Smith & Lewis, 2011, p. 386). This juxtaposition can, in the long run, lead to outcomes that generate feelings of powerlessness, cynicism, and even despair among NPO members (Putnam et al., 2016). For example, paradox underpinned a domestic violence prevention NPO whose feminist organizational philosophy promoted empowerment while everyday organizational practices disempowered staff and volunteers (D'Enbeau & Kunkel, 2013). Yet, paradoxes can be managed if organizational members find ways to meet and even embrace multiple, divergent demands.

Another essential element in the theoretical toolbox of NPO communication is the integration of critical perspectives, which allow a focus on issues of power, difference, inclusion/exclusion, and social justice (Atouba et al., 2021). The role of nonprofit organizing and volunteering in creating, reinforcing, or eliminating inequalities based on race/ethnicity, gender, immigration status, income level, work-related differences (e.g., type of job, employment status), and dis/ability needs to be investigated. That is, while unemployed or retired people may experience pressure to "volunteer", members of vulnerable or marginalized groups can be excluded, replicating discourses that make some employees more "worthy" than others. What Haski-Leventhal and Meijs (2011) call "volunteerabilty" and "recruitability" can operate at the levels of national/regional policy (e.g., workfare schemes where unemployed people must volunteer in order to receive social assistance) and organizational structure and process (e.g., women are less likely than men to be invited onto NPO boards). The difference also expresses itself in interpersonal decision-making in NPO contexts. For instance, the project manager for a retirement home in Roker et al.'s (1998) study decided that adolescent students with a learning disability should not organize a lunch for residents with dementia because the two groups "just ended up confusing each other" (p. 735). In such cases, those whose identities are marginalized "can be treated as second-class volunteers because the quality of their volunteering can be perceived as inferior to that on offer by more 'capable' or 'powerful' volunteers" (Ganesh & McAllum, 2009, p. 362).

Critical analyses of power can also pinpoint when organizational cultures that privilege community-building and inclusion shut down space for dissent or camouflage fractures in perspectives, goals, and

practices. As we have already discussed, seemingly positive organizational initiatives such as the promotion of meaningful work or corporate volunteering programs can be coercive, pushing volunteer and paid NPO workers to engage with more intensity than they would have done without organizational intervention. A "family" atmosphere can generate expectations that staff members or volunteers be continually available to carry out the organization's mission and lead those who cannot or do not want to contribute at that level to be viewed as "betraying the cause".

More broadly, because of NPOs' purportedly altruistic focus, most scholars ignore their dark side. Yet, it is evident that although NPOs provide numerous public services by, for example, advocating for affordable housing, connecting families with disability services, or encouraging children to engage in local sports, they may serve a small, elite portion of the population. This potential exclusivity may mean that NPOs may not serve the common good but act in ways that increase inequity rather than diminish it (Wolf, 2022).

Future Research on Employee Communication in NPOs

Future research on employee communication and organizing in NPOs needs to engage more deeply with the unique value-centric tensions within NPOs and the strategies that NPO members use to make sense of and manage these tensions. Which values clash, and how are they managed—or manipulated—in organizational discourse when disagreements about the values that should guide organizational decision-making, interpersonal relationships, and task priorities emerge?

Other streams of research will need to consider how the COVID-19 global pandemic has reworked the NPO landscape, generating new tensions such as risk/safety and proximity/distance, and reconfiguring patterns of inclusion and exclusion. The pandemic disrupted volunteers' formal organizational involvement and where both employees and volunteers worked: Some paid NPO employees were furloughed or lost their jobs, and many older volunteers or those with responsibilities for vulnerable family members stopped in-person volunteering. Health and safety concerns, which led to social distancing rules and restrictions on group gatherings and travel, prompted volunteers to engage in more individualized forms of service provision, including informal, self-organized, local initiatives (e.g., delivering food and medications to vulnerable neighbors; Trautwein et al., 2020) and a jump in virtual

work/virtual volunteering where NPO workers or volunteers interacted with beneficiaries and coworkers using video-conferencing software (e.g., Pickell et al., 2020). Online involvement reopens the scholarly debate about the differences between ongoing and "episodic" volunteering (e.g., Cnaan et al., 2022).

Virtualization changes the meanings of connection (Harris, 2021) and challenges the assumption that NPOs should privilege face-to-face engagement. Indeed, during the pandemic when infection rates were high, in-person interactions between NPO workers and beneficiaries became tense when members of one or both groups were un/vaccinated (Choi et al., 2023). Although context-specific, these data highlight the need for research how NPO workers manage and respond to "social divisions such as views on mask mandates and support for the current government and their policies, which the pandemic brought to the surface" (McAllum et al., 2024, p. 657). Longitudinal research needs to assess if these changes have become embedded in NPOs and how they influence employee relationships and communication.

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19

EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION

Resources, Behavior, Enablement

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Employee communication is generally defined as the communication flow between people operating within the boundaries of an organization and for this reason very often it is also referred to as internal communication. Behind this vision there is the idea of organizations as systems made by subsystems and linked to other systems situated in an external environment.

This chapter argues for a new vision of employee communication, abandoning the *system perspective* (SP) and its focus on organizational boundaries. Matching management, public relations, and organizational communication literature, this chapter proposes an understanding of employee communication rooted in the *resource perspective* (RP) and focuses on the *interactive processes generating knowledge and employee engagement* and on the underpinned *employee communication behavior* (Mazzei, 2010) that cannot be prescribed but only sustained by means of enabling communication strategies.

Furthermore, this chapter presents the *Enabling Model of Employee Communication*. It operationalizes the definition of employee communication based on the RP to offer a framework for employee communication management (Mazzei, 2014; Mazzei & Quaratino, 2020). Finally, it offers insights into theoretical and practical implications and directions for future research.

Employee Communication from a System Perspective

Employee communication is usually defined by referring to organizational boundaries, meaning that it is internal to those borders. Although different definitions exist across disciplines such as public relations, corporate communication, and organizational communication, these definitions of employee communication implicitly or explicitly consider the organization a system continuously interacting with its external environment, while employee communication stays in an organization's internal environment, thus implying internal communication. Therefore, the organizational boundaries are the criterion to distinguish internal from external communication flow. As employees are members of the organizational system situated inside it, they are primary stakeholders and the targets of an organization's internal communication (Argenti, 2009; Cornelissen, 2020; Cutlip et al., 2006; Goldhaber, 1993; Grunig & Hunt, 1984; Grunig, 1992; Kalla, 2005; Kitchen, 1997; Men & Bowen, 2017; Men & Tkalac Verčič, 2021; Sholes, 1997; Yeomans & FitzPatrick, 2017). This consolidated stream of studies is very valuable insofar as it provides the basis for understanding the functioning of information flows, the level and effects of employee communication, the criteria for its effectiveness, and many other essential aspects.

Nevertheless, organizational boundaries are an inaccurate criterion to be used to define employee communication for several reasons. First, all employees are members of the external public who receive messages from multiple sources and media channels. Organizations must be careful to communicate news internally before employees can learn about it from the general and social media. It is almost impossible to isolate internal from external communication flows as they are blurred (Mishra et al., 2014; Cornelissen, 2020). Furthermore, globalization has blurred the distinctions between boundaries that become permeable (Tkalac Verčič et al., 2012).

Therefore, the term "internal communication" itself shows to be inadequate to express the nature of this phenomenon (Mazzei, 2010) and it arises a need to reach a more comprehensive definition of employee communication exploring other perspectives than the system one.

Employee Communication from a Resource Perspective

Drawing on the Resource-Based Theory of the company (Barney, 1991) taken from management literature, the Constitutive Theory of Communication (Cooren et al., 2013) from organizational

communication, and the Situational Theory of Publics (Grunig, 1978) and its evolution as Situational Theory of Problem Solving (Kim & Grunig, 2011) from public relations, this chapter proposes a definition of employee communication that abandons the concept of organizational boundaries and instead focuses on intangible resources for the competitive advantage of the company and on employees' communication behavior in generating those resources (Mazzei, 2010).

The Resource-Based Theory of the company states that competitive advantage stems from firm-specific resources that assure its uniqueness in its industry (Barney, 1991; Rumelt, 1984). Some authors suggest that knowledge-based resources are the less imitable and highlight the processes individuals use to integrate their tacit and specialized knowledge with that of their teams (Grant, 1996).

The processes of organizational learning and knowledge generation build on a network of trust relationships that foster the exchange and sharing of resources, both within and among organizations, and set up the social capital of a company (Coleman, 1988). Skills, behavior, and interactions of individuals form the foundation of intangible resources for competitive advantage (Colbert, 2004). Knowledge tends to be embedded in workers' competencies and abilities and its creation and sharing depend upon the social interactions between employees and with external communities (Snell et al., 2001). Together, these concepts emphasize that the behavior of organizational members and the social interactions within trust relationship networks from the milieu for the creation of intangible resources (Coleman, 1988).

To describe the generation of knowledge and trust, one can adopt an approach that considers communication as the foundation of organizational structures and processes (Cooren et al., 2013; McPhee & Poole, 2001; Putnam & Nicotera, 2009; Taylor, 1993). This theoretical framework adopts a constitutive organizing perspective, according to which communication is equivalent to organization and creates the social context of organizations (Putnam et al., 1996; Tompkins & Wanca-Thibault, 2001). This stream of literature has been systematized under the concept of the Communicative Constitution of Organization (CCO) Principle (Ashcraft et al., 2009).

The constitutive approach states that communication is a social process of interaction and/or interpretation that gives sense and meaning to social reality, organizational actions, events, and organizational roles and processes. This concept of communication is consistent with the Resource-Based Theory of the company, which is based on the creation

of intangible resources by means of interactions among the organizational members. Therefore, the responsibility of effective communication lies not only in the hands of managers but also in the ones of all organizational members. The CCO perspective puts at the center the notion of employee communicative action (Heide & Simonsson, 2011; Mazzei, 2010). All voices in the organizational arena take part in the organizational processes and polyphony, disagreement, and ambiguity are part of this co-constructed phenomenon (Mazzei & Ravazzani, 2017).

To understand the concept of communicative actions of employees, it is also worth referring to Situational Theory of Problem Solving (STOPS) (Kim & Grunig, 2011), the evolution of the Situational Theory of Publics (Grunig, 1978). STOPS examines publics' different situational perceptions and communicative behaviors toward a specific issue. Publics can either passively or actively seek, evaluate, and spread information. Kim and Rhee (2011) adopted STOPS in conceptualizing employees' megaphoning behavior as employee's positive and negative external communication behavior about their organization. They also proposed scouting for explaining employees' voluntary communication efforts to gather strategic organization-related information outside and disseminate the acquired information internally. To capture no designated employees' voluntary positive megaphoning and scouting, they coined the term microboundary spanning.

The analysis of the literature so far revealed that intangible resources are the most valuable for the competitive advantage of a company, and they require trust relationships and active communication behavior from people involved in knowledge generation.

Among all the intangible resources key for the competitive advantage, there are specifically two that are catalytic for the organizational functioning and therefore are linked to the phenomenon of employee communication: *knowledge* and *employee engagement*. Knowledge fuels working processes, it is essential for the value generation of every company, and it is generated through interactive processes put in place by people, as said so far. Furthermore, knowledge lies in employees' mind. Why should employees apply their own knowledge in favor of the company for which they work? It is because of the willingness to contribute to the company's goals, that can be called employee engagement and that triggers people to use knowledge in favor of their organization. In fact, engaged employees put vigor, that is a high level of energy while working, and behave with a strategic focus on

organizational purposes (Mazzei, 2018). Employee engagement leads to employee communication behaviors that are strategic for value creation, such as company advocacy, whereas disengagement leads to employee communication behavior damaging the company, such as badmouthing managers with external constituencies (Mazzei et al., 2019). Knowledge and employee engagement are catalyst resources that fuel company processes and mutually reinforce each other.

To sum up, based on the Resource-Based Theory of the company, the Constructive Theory of Communication and the Situational Theory of Problem Solving and its evolution as Situational Theory of Problem Solving, *employee communication is defined as a set of interactive processes aimed at generating the catalytic resources that make a company work. These two resources consist of knowledge to fuel working processes and employee engagement that trigger employees to apply their knowledge to company processes* (Mazzei, 2010). This definition can be referred to as *RP on employee communication*, to distinguish it from the system one.

The RP definition of employee communication and its first empirical investigation has been presented and discussed with a panel of managers and experts during the founding meeting of the Centre for Employee Relations and Communication (CERC) at IULM University on December 12, 2008. From than onwards, the CERC (formerly called Internal Communication Laboratory) started to operate as a research center and sustained all the following studies discussed in this chapter.

System and Resource Perspectives on Employee Communication Confronted

To explore the definition of employee communication according to the RP, this study proposes a confrontation against the SP. The two perspectives are built delineating the following variables: employee communication definition criteria, aims, criteria for categorizing employees, channels, and linkage of employee communication with human resource management systems.

Employee communication definition criteria in the SP are mainly organizational boundaries and distinguish between the employee and external environment (Grunig & Hunt, 1984). In the RP, they are intangible resources such as employee engagement (Kang & Sung, 2017), knowledge (Kalla, 2005; Mazzei, 2010), and culture (Men & Bowen, 2017).

Employee communication aims in the SP include mainly targeting messages toward employees and creating their willingness to be a member of the company. In the RP, the aims are to sustain employee engagement (Arif et al., 2023; McCown et al., 2023; Pološki Vokić et al., 2021; Tkalac Verčič & Pološki Vokić, 2017) and promote supportive employee communication behavior (Andersson, 2019; Kang & Sung, 2017; Lee et al., 2018; Ruck, 2020; Thelen & Men, 2020).

Criteria for categorizing employees in the SP include hierarchy, organizational roles, age, and level of education. In the RP, the main segmentation criteria are based on attitudes and behavioral intentions (Men & Bowen, 2017).

Channels and instruments in the SP disseminate mostly information toward employees in a push manner. In the RP, most relevant communication channels and instruments offer information to be used in a pull manner and are based on contents generated by employees.

Linkage of employee communication with human resource management systems in the SP conveys job-related information such as contracts, benefits, career paths, and reward systems. In the RP, employee communication is specifically related to organizational well-being and to professional development and conveys strategic information about human resources practices.

RP is becoming a more acceptable definition of employee communication than SP among organizations. A study sought to understand whether the concept of employee communication prevailing in companies is closer to the system or to the RP using the given criteria (Mazzei, 2010). Findings have shown that the definition of employee communication given by the respondents in almost all cases leans toward the RP. Most companies define employee communication by referring to intangible resources, such as knowledge, or to communication behavior. Many companies expressed an aim of creating a climate for active communication behavior such as knowledge sharing, collaboration, and creativity. All interviewed companies use communication channels and instruments that give employees the opportunity to express themselves. This is consistent with the RP because interactive communication tools encourage employees' active communication behavior. Digital channels are becoming more and more pervasive under the form of internal social media and digital workplaces thus opening new communication arenas (Madsen, 2021). Their use will be central in the hybrid work context integrating remote and in presence work (Mazzei et al., 2023) and will require new managerial processes to support employee communication

behavior (Pekkala, 2020). Their use also connects employee communication and human resource management systems, as would be consistent with the RM. The RP depicts many characteristics of the way managers perceive employee communication and therefore it provides a way to fill the gap between theory and practice.

The Employee Communication Function as an Enabler of Organizational Processes

One of the major managerial implications of the RP is that all organizational members are active communicators as they are the communication agents in all organizational processes. This implies a major change in the role of the employee communication department in organizations: from message-sending to enabling.

Over the years, an increasing number of studies underlined that all employees have a key communication role for several reasons: the relational essence of the intangible resources that create competitive advantage (Mazzei, 2010); the post-bureaucratic nature of modern organizations (Heide & Simonsson, 2011); the emergence of the communicative organization (Zerfass & Franke, 2013); the role of employees as both receivers and senders in the crisis communication arena (Frandsen & Johansen, 2011); and the emergence of a more connected, digitized, and transparent world (Men, 2021).

Other studies offer further categorization of employee communication behavior. For example, exploring, interpreting, sharing, and acting (Mazzei, 2014); search, interpreting, and sharing (Mazzei et al., 2012); interpreting, making sense, and producing the organization (Heide & Simonsson, 2011); embodier, promotor, defender, relationship-builder, scout, sense-maker, innovator, and critic (Verhoeven & Madsen, 2022); and prosocial voice and silence and antisocial voice and silence (Mazzei, 2025).

Employee communication behavior supporting organizational processes and aims cannot emerge by means of prescriptions and control techniques, but more indirectly and genuinely through the management of a series of levers. We can express this concept as *enablement* (Mazzei, 2014).

Supportive employee communication behavior can be sustained through long lasting and high-quality relationships (Grunig et al., 2002; Ki & Hon, 2007, 2012). More broadly, employee communication

behavior can be nurtured to create an engaging workplace context through an inclusive employee relations approach instead of a hierarchical one; a developmental human resources management approach, which goes beyond the mere accommodative one; and a fair organizational justice approach, which depends on the perceived fairness and consistency of organizational procedures (Mazzei et al., 2019).

The concept of enablement has been applied to employee communication as part of the consultancy role of communication professionals (Zerfass & Franke, 2013). They have the role of supporting and facilitating employees in their communication roles (Heide & Simonsson, 2011) becoming designers of employee experience in companies (Men, 2021).

Therefore, the role of the employee communication department is to create a wholistic employee experience aimed at shaping both perceptions and attitudes, and actions and behavior of employees (Men, 2021) playing an enabling role (Men & Bowen, 2017). Enablement-oriented communication strategies can balance the paradox of obtaining desired employee communication behavior from employees while avoiding prescriptions and control mechanisms that would be ineffective (Mazzei & Ravazzani, 2017). Employee *enablement consists of the development of communication strategies in a framework of consistent workplace conditions that promote effective and positive employee communication behavior*.

Based on this background, another study (Mazzei, 2014) explored the perceptions of managers about the relevance of employee communication actions and investigated if the same companies had implemented specific employee communication strategies. The study found that managers consider employee communication behavior as the basis for company success, specifically for the implementation of the company strategy and a source of competitive advantage, knowledge creation and sharing, stakeholder engagement, and reputation building processes.

From the RP, employee communication is no longer a communication flow occurring only inside the organizational boundaries, but it is an ingredient in the generation of knowledge, reputation, loyalty, brand, and business opportunities, and is expected to perform as an enabling function. As a consequence, employee communication plays an important role in enabling employees to be strategic communicators. It provides the context for organizational actions, the meaning of events, knowledge, information, and motivation (Mazzei, 2014). For employee

enablement, it is crucial to adopt strategies based on the integration of employee communication with human resource management, as had also been found in earlier studies, and with relationship-building practices (Mazzei, 2014).

The Enabling Model of Employee Communication: An Empirical Test

The theoretical framework of the RP of employee communication gave birth to the Enablement Model of Employee Communication (Mazzei & Quaratino, 2020). This model offers a managerial framework for the management of employee communication, as it has become a specialization in the area of communication (Tkalac Verčič et al., 2012).

The Enabling Model of Employee Communication features some specific characteristics of employee communication. First, it is supposed to be strategic, that is, supervised by top management, equipped with ad hoc resources, and recognized as a source of value. Second, when run with a managerial approach, The Enabling Model implies the adoption of planning and evaluation methods typical of the managerial cycle. Third, it aims to activate employees based on the supervisor–employee dialogue and on the creation of voice contexts for the free expression of employees. Fourth, it is open to experimenting the new social arenas that arise from digitization.

These characteristics should enhance the generation of the most important intangible resources for the competitive advantage and in particular the engagement of employees as prerequisite for strategic employee communication behavior.

The Enabling Model of Employee Communication has been operationalized by developing scales to measure each of its characteristics (Mazzei & Quaratino, 2020). The quantitative instruments to measure the Enabling Model of Employee Communication can reveal its usefulness for benchmarking among companies, over time, and for carrying on comparative analysis among countries.

This quantitative instrument has been tested in Italy in 2019 (Mazzei & Quaratino, 2020), in a context preceding the major changes brought by the 2020 pandemic. Findings showed that for the companies in the sample employee communication was becoming strategic, and its dedicated department increasingly adopted a managerial approach. Findings also indicated that enabling employees is a relevant aim

together with employee alignment. The study's analysis revealed that companies operating in a new or radically changing industrial sector and adopting a competitive strategy based on innovation, a horizontal organizational model, and a participatory managerial style are keener to adopt an Enabling Model of Employee Communication. Moreover, a linear regression confirmed that the existence of an Enabling Model of Employee Communication has a positive impact on employee engagement.

All in all, this chapter suggests a definition of employee communication that supports the organizational processes essential for generating intangible resources that fuel organizations: namely knowledge and employee engagement. Due to the relational and interactive nature of these organizational processes, this definition focuses on communication behavior of employees, the core of the present and future employee communication. The major implication is the enabling role of employee communication operationalized by means of the Enabling Model.

Theoretical and Practical Implications

Adopting an RP on employee communication, the need for a change in language emerges (Mazzei, 2010; Tkalac Verčič et al., 2012). The expressions "employee communication" and "internal communication" could be revisited. The term "internal", which refers to the organizational boundaries, could be replaced with "creative", "collaborative", or "organizational". The term "employee", which refers to the internal stakeholders, could be replaced by "workforce", "co-workers", or "organizational members", all of whom may have contracts based on their affiliation with the organization. The term "communication", which implies targeting messages in strategic communication, could be changed into "relationships", "behavior", or "interaction" (Mazzei, 2010). Changes in language shape the perception of reality and at the same time modify the reality itself.

The adoption of a definition of employee communication based on an RP represents the evolution from a company-centered vision, where the company and its managers are the only actors of communication, to an employee-centered vision, where they are key performers in the communication arena. This revised definition opens room for studies on communication taking the perspective of the entire organizational system.

New studies on employee communication should be focused on communication and organizational processes to understand the interplay among a wide span of interacting elements. New streams of study should explore the drivers of employee communication behavior in different industries and countries; and the link between employee communication and human resource management systems and marketing, to understand the impact of employee communication strategies at large. Under this lens, research should investigate the perspective of managers but in particular the perspective of employees.

Because the enabling role of employee communication is a new one, scholars and educators should promote this process by providing cultural stimuli and developing an appropriate education program. In particular, the Enabling Model encourages integrating management, marketing, and human resources management content in the education programs in communication.

The enabling perspective implies a major managerial implication: the evolution of employee communication from a message-targeting function into the one of enabler of employees and managers. The employee communication department should identify the specific strategic communicative actions that are desirable in a specific organization, and for specific groups of employees and managers who have different attitudes and behavioral intentions. Employee communication managers should design proper enablement strategies. Because employee communication should be integrated with motivation, training, and coaching programs, it is essential to forge a link between employee communication and human resource management systems.

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20

COWORKERSHIP AND ENGAGEMENT

Toward a Communication-Centered Perspective

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Over the last two decades, employee engagement has become a central management concern and attracted significant attention from managers, consultants, and researchers (Mazzei, 2018; Schaufeli, 2015). An engaged workforce is linked to several positive outcomes potentially consequential to the competitive advantage of organizations (Saks, 2019). However, data from The Gallup Organization indicates that in 2022, only 23% of the global workforce can be considered engaged (Gallup, 2023), explaining why managers consistently rank employee engagement as one of the most crucial managerial challenges (Schaufeli, 2015).

Although employee engagement often is considered to be a multidimensional construct, it is predominantly perceived as a psychological construct, encompassing personal traits and affective states, as well as the behaviors these imply (Macey & Schneider, 2008). This psychological approach tends to focus on the individual and the "inner" motors of engagement. Furthermore, engagement and communication are most often considered as separate variables, quantitatively measured through surveys (see e.g., Saks, 2006, 2019; Schaufeli et al., 2002, 2006). Furthermore, in both the practitioner and academic literature, employee engagement usually refers to positive

employee traits, states, and behaviors (Bakker & Schaufeli, 2008), such as extra-role behavior (Macey & Schneider, 2008). To be considered engaged, employees should accordingly perform their work vigorously, diligently, and absorbedly (Schaufeli, 2015), exceeding their job description.

In this chapter, we review how employee engagement has been studied in the fields of organizational communication and public relations. Based on this review, we suggest a communication-centered approach to engagement, which differs from the psychological perspective on both epistemological and ontological grounds. The communication-centered approach rejects the idea of engagement and communication as two separate variables, and rather views engagement and communication as highly integrated. Furthermore, an interest in relational and interactive processes outweighs concerns for the individual and the link between psychological states and behaviors. In line with a CCO perspective, the communication-centered approach does not view communication as a tool or variable, but rather as a constitutive part of engagement (Heide & Simonsson, (2018). Thus, engagement is seen as a communication phenomenon—it is constituted in communication, but engagement is also enacted in communication. In line with this, the communication-centered approach opposes the traditional, positivistic view of social reality, where researchers try to describe an "objective" reality existing "out there". Reality is a social construction produced and reproduced in human interactions and communication (Berger & Luckmann, 1966; Gergen, 1985, 1999; Schütz, 1967). Moreover, from a social constructionist perspective, we prefer to use the term "coworker" rather than the more common "employee". Coworker entails that organizational members are active agents who produce and reproduce social reality by communicating.

Employee Engagement

In colloquial language, engagement often means involvement, commitment, passion, enthusiasm, absorption, focused effort, zeal, dedication, and energy (Schaufeli, 2014). Although its origin is somewhat unclear, the term "employee engagement" is believed to have been introduced by Gallup in the 1990s (Mazzei, 2018; Schaufeli, 2015). In the academic literature on employee engagement, Kahn's (1990) seminal article is usually considered to contain the first definition of engagement in the context of work. However, it was not until the

research on engagement conducted by the "Utrecht group" that the interest in engagement soared (Guest, 2013), and additional studies followed up the work of Kahn (Bailey et al., 2017). Bailey et al. note that the "Utrecht group's" conceptualization of engagement as a more stable, enduring, and positive psychological state that is possible to measure through quantitative methods dominates research on employee engagement. In a literature review, Bailey et al. identified 214 studies on engagement of sufficient quality from an initial 5,168 peer-reviewed work, showing that engagement has become a central concern within management research.

Employee Engagement in Organizational Communication and Public Relations

In this section, we present our read of how employee engagement has been addressed in the organizational communication and public relations literature.

Employee Engagement in the Organizational Communication Literature

In contrast to the explicit attention given to engagement in the employee engagement literature, the organizational communication literature rarely has employee engagement or engagement as the focal, explicit topic of study. However, when engagement is understood as a communication phenomenon concerning employees' engagement with other humans and nonhumans in communication events in and through which they collectively produce social reality, employee engagement becomes a central, although implicit, topic in the organizational communication literature—as a dimension of employees' communication.

Table 20.1 provides an overview of organizational communication topics in which employees' communicative engagement is an implicit dimension. As previously mentioned, providing an exhaustive overview of the organizational communication literature is beyond the scope of this chapter. Moreover, some of the topics overlap. Thus, the primary purpose of the overview is to illustrate the centrality of employees' communicative engagement to the research field of organizational communication.

Table 20.1 Overview of topics in organizational communication in which employees' communicative engagement is an implicit dimension

Overview of topics in organizational communication in which employees' communicative engagement is an implicit dimension
Organizational socialization (e.g., Jablin, 1984)
Organizational identity and identification (e.g., Cheney, 1983)
Workplace relationships (e.g., Sias & Jablin, 1995) and communication networks (e.g., Monge & Contractor, 2003)
Emotions and compassion in the workplace (e.g., Miller et al., 1988; Mumby & Putnam, 1992)
Power, control, and resistance (e.g., Conrad, 1983; Contu, 2008; Deetz, 1992, 1998; Mumby, 1997)
Workplace groups, teams, conflict, and decision-making (e.g., Kuhn & Poole, 2000; Larson & LaFasto, 1989; Poole et al., 1985; Putnam & Stohl, 1990)
Gender in the workplace (e.g., Buzzanell, 1994)
Workplace democracy and participation (e.g., Cheney, 1995; Miller & Monge, 1986; Stohl & Cheney, 2001)
Leadership (e.g., Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014) and management communication (e.g., Cooren & Stücheli-Herlach, 2021)
Information and communication technology (e.g., Treem & Leonardi, 2013)
Organizational knowledge and knowing (e.g., Child & Shumate, 2007; Garner, 2006; Iverson & McPhee, 2002; Zorn & Taylor, 2004)
Organizational culture (e.g., Pacanowsky & O'Donnell-Trujillo, 1983)
Organizational change (e.g., Lewis & Seibold, 1998)
Incivility (e.g., Gill & Sypher, 2010), destructive workplace behavior, and dissent (e.g., Kassing, 1997, 2002; Lutgen-Sandvik & Sypher, 2010; Waldron, 1994), and bullying (e.g., Lutgen-Sandvik, 2008)

Overview of topics in organizational communication in which employees' communicative engagement is an implicit dimension
Globalization and organizational communication (e.g., Connaughton & Shuffler, 2007; Gibbs, 2009)
Upward communication (e.g., Tourish & Robson, 2006) and voicing (e.g., Christensen & Christensen, 2022)
Branding (e.g., Mumby, 2016; Vásquez et al., 2013)
Strategizing (Vásquez et al., 2018)

Our read of this condensed overview of the organizational communication literature makes it possible to identify and distinguish two apparent implicit approaches to employees' communicative engagement: research focusing on employees' constructive communicative engagement and research focusing on employees' destructive communicative engagement. In the following, we will unpack these two current approaches by reviewing some illustrative examples from the vast body of literature.

Employees' constructive communicative engagement has received the most attention in the organizational communication literature. The epithet "constructive" here refers to communicative engagement that, for example, constructively contributes to a shared common purpose in the organization. The centrality of a common purpose for an organization dates back to classic organization theory and Barnard's (1938/1968) seminal *The Functions of the Executive*, in which he proposes that "An organization comes into being when (1) there are persons able to communicate with each other (2) who are willing to contribute action (3) to accomplish a common purpose" (p. 82). Barnard mainly talks about formal organizations. However, this notion can include partial and alternative forms of organizations and collectives with a certain degree of organizationality—as long as they demonstrate some shared purpose.

Moreover, contributing to a common purpose is not the only form of constructive communicative engagement. Communicatively engaging in promoting well-being, colleagues' a sense of pride, increase trust, and even provide dissenting voices to improve organizational processes or employees' situations can also be considered constructive forms of communicative engagement (cf. Verhoeven & Madsen, 2022).

Employees' destructive communicative engagement has received less attention in the organizational communication literature. Still, as shown in Table 20.1, some studies have shed light on critical destructive communicative engagement, such as workplace incivility, gossip, rumor, and bullying. Lutgen-Sandvik and Sypher (2010) define destructive interactions at work as interactions in and through which "people are harmed, workgroup communication deteriorates, and trust and cooperation declines" (p. 1). Thus, destructive communicative engagement is when employees intentionally or habitually engage communicatively in ways that, for example, are harmful to others, the communication climate, or organizational process and performance. One example is Lutgen-Sandvik's (2008) study of employees' responses to adult workplace bullying. While the study does not investigate employees' destructive communicative engagement, it offers important insights into the consequences of such destructive engagement and how employees respond to and cope with it.

Employee Engagement in the Public Relations Literature

Engagement has been considered an essential concept in the public relations literature for a long time and has attracted significant attention from public relations researchers in the 21st century. Taylor and Kent (2014) found that the concept of engagement appears in public relations literature on social media engagement, employee engagement, CSR and engagement, civic engagement and social capital, and dialogic engagement. Following their review, Taylor and Kent note that public relations researchers usually stress the importance of engagement but rarely properly conceptualize it.

The notion of engagement as just about any form of interaction has been critiqued by Johnston and Taylor (2018), who argue that this makes engagement an empty concept explaining everything and, thus, nothing. Instead, Johnston and Taylor call for a more unified conceptualization of engagement. However, Jelen-Sanchez (2017) argues that the lack of a unified definition of engagement in the public relations literature can be partly explained by the multi-paradigmatic state of public relations research. Five decades ago, Kuhn (1970) introduced the concept of incommensurability, which means that researchers with various ontologies and epistemologies do not understand each other. These researchers understand the world differently and have different understandings of how to produce knowledge (see also Burrell &

Morgan, 1979; Chia, 1995). Jelen-Sanchez (2017) claims that this produces semantic incommensurability between paradigms, partly due to public relations being a global field, which contributes to cultural incommensurability. These incommensurabilities make a unified conceptualization of engagement impossible.

While there is a growing interest in employees as active communicators (e.g., Mazzei, 2010; Mazzei, Butera & Quaratino, 2019; Ravazzani & Mazzei, 2018; Verhoeven & Madsen, 2022), we limit our review that follows to the public relations literature having an explicit focus on employee engagement. As pointed out in previous reviews (e.g., Dhanesh, 2017; Taylor & Kent, 2014; Shen & Ren, 2023), most public relations research on employee engagement focuses on how organizations can engage employees and the relationship between employee engagement and organizational performance. For example, in an influential paper on employee engagement, Welch (2011) suggests that engagement, conceptualized as a multidimensional construct comprising an emotional, cognitive, and physical dimension, can be influenced by internal communication and leads to several positive outcomes, such as increased innovation and competitiveness. Moreover, several studies empirically investigate how internal communication contributes to engaging employees and what this engagement leads to using a quantitative methodology, thereby striving to generate knowledge of direct practical use to managers on the antecedents and outcomes of employee engagement. Examples are Arif et al. (2023), Kang and Sung (2017), Karanges et al. (2015), Tkalac Verčič and Pološki Vokić (2017), Tkalac Verčič and Men (2023), and Walden et al. (2017), who draw upon the established conceptualization and operationalization of work engagement as employees' (self-reported) degree of vigor, dedication, and absorption, and Shen and Jiang (2019), who draw upon the established conceptualization and operationalization of work engagement as employees' (self-reported) emotions, thoughts, and (attitude toward) behavior. Ruck et al. (2017) also draw upon Kahn's (1990) notion of personal engagement and conceptualize and operationalize engagement as employees' (self-reported) emotions, thoughts, and (attitude toward) behavior. However, besides employees' engagement in their work role (i.e., work engagement), Ruck et al. (2017) are also interested in organization engagement, concerning employees' role as members of an organization and how employee engagement contributes to organizational performance (Saks, 2006). However, as Guest (2014) points out, unlike work engagement, the literature on organization

engagement lacks clear definitions, established measures, and empirical research in general. Guest (2013) even warns that organization engagement might be a management fad that will lose attraction when a new, more attractive concept appears.

As shown through this sample of the quantitative public relations literature on employee engagement, engagement is in this literature mainly approached as a psychological phenomenon, and researchers draw upon the influential conceptualizations in the employee engagement literature (e.g., Kahn, 1990; Saks, 2006; Schaufeli et al., 2002). While these quantitative studies acknowledge and address the behavioral dimension of engagement in their respective studies, they all investigate employees' self-reported attitudes toward behavior rather than actual observable behavior and employees' experiences of such engagement.

Although the public relations literature on employee engagement is dominated by research on how organizations can engage employees and the relationship between employee engagement and organizational performance, a growing number of studies qualitatively explore how employees understand and experience engagement. For example, Lemon and Palenchar (2018) provide insights into how employees experience and perceive engagement in the workplace—drawing upon Heath's (1993) notion of zones of meaning. Lemon and Palenchar identify six "zones of engagement" that make up a complex meaning-whole, providing insight into how employees make sense of engagement.

In ensuing studies, Lemon (2019a, 2019b) further explored the lived experience of employees and how employees make sense of engagement, highlighting the importance of dialogic communication for cultivating employee engagement and raising awareness of the potential darker sides of employee engagement, such as the physical and emotional exhaustion that comes with extended periods of high engagement and potential over-engagement.

Lastly, responding to calls for more in-depth studies on disengagement made by Lemon and Palenchar (2018) and Jelen-Sanchez (2017), Shen and Ren (2023) interviewed Chinese employees working in public relations agencies. Based on the interview findings, Shen and Ren conceptualize disengagement as comprising an attitudinal dimension (i.e., employees' indifference to work) and a behavioral dimension (i.e., employees slacking off during work and withdrawing from their work, organizations, and colleagues).

Employee Engagement in Organizational Communication and Public Relations: A Comparison

This condensed review of how the organizational communication and public relations literature has approached employee engagement enables us to compare the two bodies of literature. While we here present them as two separate bodies of literature, there is of course a certain overlap and integration between them. However, in order to better understand how these two bodies of literature can complement each other and further advance the understanding of coworker engagement, we have highlighted the core and most salient patterns within each area. Based on the review, we briefly compare how the two bodies of literature conceive of the nature of engagement, how they produce knowledge about engagement, and which value they, explicitly or implicitly, attach to employee engagement.

There is a difference in how the two bodies of literature view the nature of engagement. In the organizational communication literature, engagement is implicitly, predominately understood as a communication phenomenon, more specifically as a dimension of communication practices or processes indicating to what degree employees are communicatively engaged in a communication event. Contrarily, with a few exceptions, the public relations literature predominantly understands employee engagement as a psychological phenomenon.

There is also a clear difference in how the two bodies of literature approach and produce knowledge about engagement. Although surveys are also used within the organizational communication literature, employees' communicative engagement is often approached through researchers' immersion in particular sites and peoples' lifeworld and observations of communication events, and the knowledge produced is a result of such immersion and observation. In contrast, the public relations literature predominantly utilizes surveys building on existing psychological notions of employee engagement. Thus, while the public relations literature claims to contribute an understanding of the antecedents and outcomes of employee engagement, few researchers have produced knowledge of engagement as such (for exceptions, see, e.g., Lemon, 2019a, 2019b; Lemon & Palenchar, 2018).

Lastly, while the public relations literature primarily depicts engaged employees as a desirable state, the implicit understanding in the organizational communication literature of engagement as both constructive and destructive highlights that engagement does not

necessarily need to be desirable. Assuming that high engagement is desirable, a priori can limit our ability to investigate and produce a nuanced understanding of the phenomenon. This highlights why a communication-centered understanding of engagement, in which employees' sensemaking and communication practices are placed in the limelight, is valuable for further knowledge development on employee engagement.

Developing a Communication-Centered Perspective on Coworker Engagement

Thus, although we clearly see the merit in psychological conceptualizations of engagement and acknowledge that engagement is perceived as a multidimensional concept in the public relations literature (Johnston, 2014), we consider it essential that future research and practitioners also develop a communication-centered perspective on coworker engagement as this is important for a more nuanced understanding of how engagement is communicatively constituted in organizing and the significance of engagement to organizational processes. In this final part, we discuss what such a perspective would imply for research as well as practice.

Although the conceptualizations of engagement as a behavioral construct usually refer to unique, extra, or atypical employee behavior (Macey & Schneider, 2008), we argue that as a communication phenomenon, engagement is best captured in the broader meaning of the verb engage, that is, "to begin and carry out an […] activity" (Merriam-Webster, n.d.). When communicating with humans and nonhumans, employees engage in (formal and informal, constructive and destructive) communication events, such as making meaning, ideating, representing, and bullying, in which employees, communicatively, can display a varying degree of engagement. Thus, a communication-centered perspective understands engagement as a communication phenomenon, namely when employees communicatively engage with human organizational members, nonmembers, and nonhuman things and objects in communication events (see Cooren et al., 2011) before, during, and after work.

As noted, in much of previous research, communication has been seen as one of several variables driving engagement. A communication-centered perspective on coworker engagement implies instead a view of communication as an integral part of engagement. Thus, while there

previously has been a strong focus on how internal communication, or primarily communication from top- and middle-level managers to subordinates, influences employee engagement, a communication-centered approach views engagement as a dimension of communication. Coworker engagement is not something primarily injected from an external communication source but constructed in an interactive process where the coworker acts as an active communicator (Heide & Simonsson, 2018). As a consequence, there is a shift in focus from how managers' communication influences coworker engagement, to how coworkers act as engaged communicators or how they engage in communication. This shift is further based on the idea of coworkers as active subject agents rather than as receivers or targets of communication (Heide & Simonsson, 2011).

A communication-centered approach further implies an ambition to nuance the understanding of coworker engagement and acknowledge the many engagement-related tensions. As discussed in this chapter, engagement may be constructive and destructive to the organization's overall purpose. For example, in times of organizational crisis, coworkers who do not feel listened to by their managers may engage actively in negative ambassadorship. It should also be noted that communicatively, coworkers can display various degrees of engagement. High levels of constructive engagement are traditionally understood as employee engagement in the literature, for example, communication behavior in customer interactions that can be described as vigorous, dedicated, and absorbed. However, although highly engaged employees are a managerial ideal, it is not always constructive. Over-engagement may lead to health problems (Bakker et al., 2011), but there are also other, more subtle, limiting aspects of high degrees of engagement. For example, being moderately or lowly engaged in a meeting at some points enables other coworkers to engage more strongly. Additionally, detachment is important for reflexivity, so communicatively disengaging gives time for reflection.

A communication-centered perspective would imply that practitioners such as HR and communication specialists take an interest in and support both managers and coworkers. Coworkers, as well as managers, construct and express engagement in various communicative interactions. Providing support does not primarily or necessarily involve guidelines or communication training, but rather facilitating conversations on questions such as: In what kind of communicative interactions do you feel highly engaged? What are possible barriers to

engaging in communication? What kind of communicative interactions do you feel secure and competent to engage in?

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21

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION

A Multidisciplinary Review of Theoretical Approaches, Applications, and Emerging Opportunities

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Leadership Communication

Leadership communication has been a richly studied topic across various disciplines, such as organizational communication, public relations, organizational science, and psychology. Much like the concept of leadership, which has been defined in various ways, leadership communication has also been conceptualized through multiple approaches. One of these approaches is the classic linear approach, which views leadership communication as a one-way process where leaders create and transmit messages to their followers with the intention of achieving predetermined outcomes of influence (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2016). The interactional model, on the other hand, defines leadership communication as a multidirectional phenomenon, encompassing two-way communication between leaders and their followers. It includes both planned and unplanned messages, as well as verbal and nonverbal communication. Yet, the interactional model falls short of fully exploring all the intricacies of leadership communication processes and outcomes, such as message selection, sense-making, and retention (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2016). To account for the complexity of leadership communication and its embedded social influence, the third approach,

known as the systems view of leadership communication, has emerged. This perspective considers leadership communication as a fundamental life process, wherein leaders and followers construct, convey, select, and make sense of messages that impact their lives. It acknowledges the interplay of leaders' and followers' unique attributes, such as needs, values, attitudes, goals, education, and cultural backgrounds, in influencing or being influenced by the communication process (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2016).

Despite the various ways leadership communication is defined, there is widespread agreement that communication plays a central role in leadership. The fact that organizational leaders dedicate 70%–80% of their time to communication (Wajcman & Rose, 2011) underscores its significance in both leadership studies and practical applications. Recognizing its criticality, some communication researchers advocate for adopting a communicative lens to comprehend leadership more deeply. One example of this perspective comes from the communicative constitution of organization (CCO) theorists in the field of organizational communication, who view communication as the fundamental element that shapes and constructs leadership (Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014). Embracing this communicative lens has led to a greater understanding of leadership as a social, discursive, and co-constructed phenomenon.

Acknowledging the value of communication as a valuable resource that complements the leadership repertoire (Men & Bowen, 2016; Yue et al., 2021), researchers in organizational communication and public relations have made significant progress in exploring and defining various leadership communication styles that lead to positive organizational and employee outcomes. These positive outcomes include fostering positive relationships between the organization and employees (Yue et al., 2023), satisfying employees' psychological needs (Men et al., 2021), promoting employee engagement (Jiang & Luo, 2018), and more.

One notable example of a leadership communication style is **transparent leadership communication**, initially studied as a form of organizational communication. It encompasses three key elements: participation, accountability, and substantiality (Rawlins, 2008). Participation involves leaders actively involving their followers in the decision-making process, considering their informational needs, and making well-informed decisions (Jiang & Luo, 2018). Accountability requires leaders to communicate both positive and negative information and be open to opposition and criticism. Finally, substantiality refers to

leaders providing truthful, substantial, and useful information to their followers (Ji & Hong, 2023).

Charismatic leadership communication is another highly effective style that embodies leaders' communication about vision, passion, and care (Men et al., 2021). Vision entails inspiring followers with an exciting future and motivating them to pursue higher goals. Passion involves energizing followers by demonstrating personal excitement, enthusiasm, and confidence in achieving organizational objectives. Care centers around supporting followers by attentively listening to their needs, showing empathy toward their feelings, and expressing confidence in their abilities and potential. Top leaders' charismatic rhetoric has been found to have positive effects on employees during organizational changes brought on by events like the COVID-19 pandemic (Yue, 2021a). Charismatic leaders incorporate various communication elements to appeal to their followers, including (1) references to collective history and the connection between the past, the present, and the projected future; (2) an emphasis on the collective identity; (3) an emphasis on followers' self-worth and reinforcement of the collective efficacy; (4) references to leaders' similarity to followers; (5) a focus on values and moral justifications as opposed to tangible outcomes and pragmatic justifications; (6) references to distal goals and future; and (7) references to hope and faith (Shamir et al., 1994).

In addition to the leadership communication styles mentioned earlier, other styles have also been closely associated with effective leadership communication. The first is **communicative leadership**, which is observed in leaders who "engage employees in dialogue, actively share and seek feedback, practice participative decision making, and are perceived as open and involved" (Johansson, 2017, p. 11). **Leadership listening** emphasizes the critical role of active listening in leadership communication. This means attentively and non-judgmentally attending to and appreciating individual followers' thoughts, feelings, and concerns (Lloyd et al., 2017). **Authentic leadership communication** style is distinguished by the openness, transparency, consistency, honesty, and truthfulness exhibited by leaders in their communication. Essentially, authentic communication requires leaders to express their genuine thoughts and emotions openly, demonstrate consistency between their beliefs, words, and actions, and guide their communication with a positive moral compass (Men et al., 2018).

Research Paradigms and Theoretical Approaches to Leadership Communication

Scholars from diverse sub-disciplines within the field of communication, such as public relations, organizational communication, and business communication, have shown considerable interest in studying leadership communication. Therefore, the theoretical approaches discussed below align with the traditions of these disciplines.

Broadly speaking, the study of leadership communication embraces both postpositivist and social constructionist paradigms. However, it is notable that the social constructionist paradigm finds greater application within the realm of organizational communication, whereas the postpositivist perspective tends to be more prevalent in research conducted by scholars in public relations and business communication, aligning with the traditional focus of leadership studies. The postpositivist view emphasizes the objective and rational aspects of leadership communication within organizational contexts. They follow the strategic management paradigm in public relations and adopt a functional lens to examine leadership communication. In this approach, leadership communication is perceived as a strategic process with leaders acting as communication agents for the organization (Men & Bowen, 2016; Yue et al., 2021). Previous research following this approach has identified various leadership communication styles, attributes, and characteristics that impact organizational dynamics and employee outcomes, as discussed earlier. These studies often employ quantitative methods such as surveys and experiments, drawing on the roots of industrial and organizational psychology and the postpositivist tradition. However, a critique of this approach is its focus on leaders, overlooking the importance of mutual effects and employees' roles in the co-construction of meaning (Fairhurst, 2008).

Turning to the field of organizational communication, a paradigm shift in ontology and epistemology occurred in the 1980s. This shift marked a departure from the traditional "container model", which confined communication within organizational units (Tompkins, 1984). Currently, a prominent group of organizational communication scholars holds the view that communication is constitutive of organizations. According to this perspective, organizational reality is socially constructed through the interactions among its members, involving the use of symbols, words, and actions (Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014;

Tourish, 2019). This paradigm shift highlights the dynamic and influential role of communication in shaping and defining organizations.

The concept of communication as central and constitutive of leadership, whereby communication shapes and forms leadership, is grounded in the CCOs perspective (Cooren, 2001). From this standpoint, leadership communication is viewed as a circular interaction where both leaders and employees collaboratively construct meaning. The outcomes of leadership communication are influenced by the relationships among leaders, followers, messages, and contexts, as well as the interpretive activities of those involved (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2016). This communication-centered understanding of leadership is referred to as discursive leadership (Fairhurst, 2008), the systems model (Ruben & Gigliotti, 2016), or communication as constitutive of leadership (Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014; Putnam & Nicotera, 2009). Discourses such as framing, sense-making, sense-giving, and agenda-setting have gained prominence in this perspective as they capture the central role of interaction and dialogue in the social construction and sharing of meaning within organizations (Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014). As a result, studies influenced by this approach often concentrate on a single organization or unit, enabling researchers to conduct in-depth analysis and gain a comprehensive understanding of specific organizational constraints and contextual opportunities (Johansson, 2017). Qualitative methods, including interviews and observations, are frequently utilized to explore leadership communication within a particular setting and moment (Johansson, 2017). However, a controversy surrounding this perspective arises from the observation that in practice, leaders and managers often struggle to fully embrace this viewpoint (Johansson, 2017).

It is important to recognize that both the postpositivist and social constructionist perspectives contribute valuable insights to leadership communication research, as leadership communication inherently involves both strategic and meaning-centered aspects. The following section provides a brief overview of several theories and frameworks commonly employed by scholars studying leadership communication from a predominantly postpositivist perspective. While not exhaustive, this list serves as a foundational resource for exploring leadership communication and its underlying theories.

Motivating Language Theory (MLT). MLT was conceptualized as a communicative path to facilitating employee motivation at work (Sullivan, 1988). It highlights the significance of leaders using

motivating language, which includes three key components: meaning-making, empathetic language, and direction-giving. Meaning-making involves providing employees with a sense of purpose and cultural guidance related to their work. Empathetic language entails offering support and compassion to employees and showing genuine care for employees' well-being and sensitivity to their needs. Direction-giving language focuses on providing clear and transparent work direction, expectations, and feedback. By utilizing these forms of oral communication, leaders can effectively stimulate higher levels of motivation among their followers, consequently benefiting both individuals and the organization as a whole. Within the field of communication, motivating language has primarily been treated as an exogenous variable and has consistently exhibited significant positive associations with various workplace outcomes, including employee–organization relationships (EORs), organizational culture, employee engagement, performance, advocacy, creativity, and intention to stay (Mayfield & Mayfield, 2018; Tao et al., 2022; Yue, 2021b).

Relationship-based theories. Relationship-based theories, such as social exchange theory (SET), leader-member exchange (LMX) theory, and relationship management theory, shed light on the impact of leadership communication on employee outcomes through the norm of reciprocity. SET suggests that employees engage in an ongoing exchange with their employers, contributing their time, skills, and effort in return for rewards and benefits. When this exchange is perceived as fair and balanced, employees develop positive attitudes and behaviors, such as commitment, loyalty, and pro-organizational behaviors, driven by principles of reciprocity (Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005). Empirical research has provided evidence that effective leadership communication, encompassing leader–member conversational quality, motivating language, responsiveness, transparency, and charisma, plays a significant role in facilitating social exchange and positively influencing employee outcomes (e.g., Bakar & Connaughton, 2009; Ji & Hong, 2023; Jian & Dalisay, 2017; Yue, 2021b).

LMX theory adopts a social exchange perspective to explain the quality of the *dyadic* relationship between leaders and followers (Wayne et al., 1997). High-quality LMX is characterized by mutual respect, trust, and obligation, and is considered a precursor to various employee attitudes and behaviors. Research has identified a reciprocal link between LMX and communication variables; communication variables such as frequency and message characteristics have been found to predict high-

quality LMX (e.g., Lloyd et al., 2017). Conversely, LMX also positively impacted subordinates' perceptions of communication satisfaction (e.g., Cranmer & Myers, 2015).

Within the domain of public relations, the tradition of relationship management has prompted investigations into the impact of leadership communication on EORs. EOR is typically assessed through employees' perceptions of trust, satisfaction, control mutuality, and commitment to the organization (Kang & Sung, 2017). Within this context, EOR often serves as a mediator, integrated with SET, connecting leadership communication constructs with other employee outcomes. For example, research has shown that empathetic supervisory communication has a positive impact on EOR, which in turn reduces employees' turnover intention (Yue et al., 2023). Similarly, family-supportive leadership communication has also been shown to foster EOR, leading to increased employee creativity (Lee & Kim, 2023).

Self-Determination Theory (SDT). SDT has been applied to elucidate the role of leadership communication in fulfilling employees' basic psychological needs, ultimately influencing employee attitudes, behaviors, and the quality of their relationships with leaders and organizations. SDT emphasizes the significance of psychological need satisfaction, positing that individuals possess inherent needs for autonomy, competence, and relatedness (Deci & Ryan, 2000). In a study by Men et al. (2021), it was found that the use of motivating language by startup CEOs contributed to the satisfaction of employees' psychological needs, thereby enhancing the quality of employee–startup relationships. Furthermore, Ji and Hong (2023) established a positive relationship between CEO's transparent communication and employees' need satisfaction, which in turn promotes information sharing and a willingness to engage in activism.

Social Identity Theory (SIT). SIT is a framework that explores how individuals perceive themselves in relation to a specific group. The theory suggests that individuals develop a social identity based on their group memberships, and the stronger their identification with a particular group, the more they define themselves in terms of that group and strive to conform to its norms and values (Tajfel & Turner, 2004). In the context of leadership research, leaders are considered "entrepreneurs of identity" with the ability to shape and mobilize followers toward a collective goal through the manipulation of group prototypes (Reicher & Hopkins, 2001). Leaders achieve this by employing social identity constructions and framing, which involve using rhetoric and

communication to establish and redefine the group's identity and purpose. Research suggests leaders use inclusive language (e.g., "we" "us", "them"), refer to collective entities (e.g., society, nation), and use positive social identity language (language containing praise, satisfaction, and positive group values) to foster similarity between leaders and followers, increase followers' identification with the group, and their willingness to engage in collective action to realize the leader's vision (Seyranian, 2014). Recent research, drawing on SIT, has also found that leaders' use of motivating language can enhance employees' organizational identification by cultivating a positive organizational emotional culture (Yue et al., 2021).

Leadership Communication in the New Era: Emerging Trends and Applications

Emerging Types of Leadership Communication Behaviors

In recent years, new leadership styles have emerged to meet stakeholders' evolving needs and to help organizations navigate through the ever-changing market and global environments. In this section, we focus on two timely leadership styles that have entered scholarly conversations: diversity-oriented leadership and family supportive leadership.

With the growing discussions on diversity, equity, and inclusion in society, researchers in public relations and organizational communication have begun to explore the nature and impact of diversity-oriented leadership. **Diversity-oriented leadership** refers to leadership behaviors that seek, encourage, and appreciate the contributions of and feedback from employees of diverse backgrounds and characteristics (Lee et al., 2021). It signals leaders' commitment to cultivating a workforce that is representative of all segments of society and to treating and valuing each member of such a workforce fairly and equally (Lee et al., 2021). While diversity-oriented leadership has garnered increasing scholarly attention, leaders' diversity-oriented *communication* has not been explored much. The most recent explication of diversity communication remains on an organizational level. For example, Men et al. (2023) conceptualize diversity communication as the organization's efforts in communicating their commitment and efforts to support diversity within the organization. They show that organizational diversity communication benefits the development of an inclusive organizational environment and

employee engagement. Given the limited research on this construct, we invite future research to explore the nature, process, and outcomes of leaders' diversity communication.

Another type of leadership that has attracted scholars' interest in recent years is family supportive leadership. The COVID-19 pandemic and transition to remote working have brought enormous challenges and problems to employees, such as blurred work–life boundaries as well as mental and physical health issues for the employees and their families (Lee & Kim, 2023). Family supportive leadership has emerged as a much-needed type of leadership to mitigate those problems. **Family supportive leadership** represents leaders' efforts to help employees obtain a harmonious work and family life cycle (Jin et al., 2022). These leaders actively communicate with employees about their work and family-related concerns, offer flexible work schedules to accommodate family needs, and provide support and resources to address work and family life challenges (Lee & Kim, 2023). Studies have shown that family supportive leadership reduces employees' mental stress, fulfills their social and emotional needs, strengthens their connection with the organization, and enhances their creativity at work (Jin et al., 2022; Lee & Kim, 2023).

Leadership Communication in the Artificial Intelligence Era

Artificial intelligence (AI) is rapidly revolutionizing professional communication and interpersonal interactions. To effectively leverage AI for leadership communication, organizational leaders and internal communicators should cultivate a comprehensive understanding of its workings and potential applications. Whether the task at hand involves drafting shareholder letters, delivering employee keynote speeches, or navigating crisis situations, AI can play a pivotal role in optimizing leaders' communication strategies by taking into account their past communication patterns, the specific scenarios they encounter, the target audience they address, and the available communication channels at their disposal.

For instance, prior to addressing a crisis, leaders can utilize AI to practice their responses. AI systems can generate potential arguments, assess their quality and persuasiveness, and provide feedback to enhance their effectiveness. Additionally, leaders can employ virtual reality or augmented reality technologies to simulate real speaking environments, allowing them to rehearse interactions with their audience and build

confidence in presenting in various settings. Moreover, AI can enhance leaders' communication efficiency and effectiveness in reaching diverse stakeholders by tailoring messages at scale and ensuring greater personalization and relevance.

Another domain in which AI can enhance leadership communication efficiency is through virtual assistants. These tools, including internal chatbots, facilitate quick and easy access to information such as company policies, benefits, and procedures, thereby freeing up the time of line managers and lower- to middle-level management. This time can then be redirected toward more strategic and creative initiatives.

However, it is essential for leaders to exercise caution when relying solely on AI-generated content, as the ease of content creation through AI tools like ChatGPT also introduces the potential for producing inaccurate or low-quality output. Fact-checking and source tracing are imperative, as illustrated by a recent incident involving a New York lawyer who unknowingly cited fabricated cases generated by ChatGPT in a legal brief. Despite boasting 30 years of experience, the lawyer had never used ChatGPT before and was unaware of the possibility of encountering false content (Garfinkle, 2023). This serves as a stark reminder of the critical importance of exercising discernment and not solely relying on AI-generated content without proper verification.

In conclusion, AI tools like ChatGPT are unlikely to replace human communicators in content creation. While they can swiftly produce simple, action-oriented communication materials such as newsletter articles and emails, it still requires the expertise of skilled communicators to infuse authenticity into the content, ensuring alignment with the brand voice and the unique personalities of the leaders. It is crucial to acknowledge that, ultimately, employees yearn for genuine, authentic, and human communication from their leaders, which remains irreplaceable by AI-driven technologies.

Practical Guide to Effective Leadership Communication

With the role of leaders as communication agents for organizations increasingly recognized, those that strive for communication success need to proactively train their leaders to become effective communicators. For top leaders like CEOs whose communication responsibilities span both internal and external domains, organizations should foremost equip these leaders with a public relations mindset. They need to be made aware that their communication choices have

significant consequences for the organization's reputation and public perceptions (Men & Bowen, 2016). After all, CEOs are the natural spokesperson for the organization and their inherent connection to their organization cannot be overlooked. Furthermore, it is imperative for top management to recognize the strategic value of communication in achieving business objectives. Investing in communication functions and training leaders at all levels in communication skills should be viewed not as an incidental expense, but as a justified and valuable strategic investment.

For leaders at all levels, organizations should coach them on best practices of leadership communication, such as using visionary communication or meaning-making language to inspire employee confidence for the future, establish a sense of direction, purpose, and meaningfulness; employing direction-giving language to provide clear guidance, expectations and feedback, ensuring informational transparency; utilizing empathetic and caring language to provide emotional support and compassion to forge a deeper bond and nurture trust; embracing inclusive language to emphasize commonality, collectivity, fostering a sense of belonging and organizational identification; and applying enabling and empowering language to instill hope, fuel passion, and drive change. While the specific communication approach should be tailored to the circumstances and communication objectives, ample research supports the effectiveness of transparent, authentic, empathetic, and responsive communication from leaders. The communication team should serve as counselors, trainers, content creators, and facilitators. They can assist leaders in developing messages that align with organizational goals, purpose, and values, while also considering the leaders' individual leadership styles and personalities.

Equally, if not more critical, in effective leadership communication is the practice of leader listening. Leaders should proactively listen to their employees or followers, actively seek feedback and input, and genuinely acknowledge and act upon the voices of their team members to complete the communication loop. To support leaders in becoming better communicators, alongside the aforementioned "know-how", relevant processes and tools should be put in place. The emergence of technologies such as internal social media, metaverse, chatbot, and generative AI offers creative ways for leaders to both speak and listen. These technologies can revamp leader communication and provide unprecedented opportunities for leaders to enhance their communication competence. While due diligence needs to be paid to accuracy, privacy

issues, and ethical considerations, it is important for leaders in the AI era to embrace the "co-pilot" mindset, striking a balance between leveraging AI capabilities and leveraging human intelligence for more efficient and effective leadership communication.

Conclusion

This chapter provides a comprehensive review of theoretical approaches in public relations, organizational communication, and business communication that pertain to the study of leadership communication. By exploring these various perspectives, it offers multidisciplinary insights into this critical area of study. This chapter summarizes recent theoretical advancements and empirical research findings concerning leadership communication strategies, styles, and skills, as well as their influence on employee and organizational outcomes. This chapter also identifies emerging trends, issues, and challenges that organizational leaders are currently confronted with in today's volatile, uncertain, complex, and ambiguous environment and provided practical guidance for leaders to enhance their communication effectiveness.

As the role of leaders as organizational communication agents become more and more ubiquitous and expected, it is imperative to expand theory-informed research to better understand the interplay between communication and leadership and its implications for both leadership effectiveness and organizational success. Future researchers should strive to integrate functional and interpretive perspectives and adopt a holistic approach to understanding the antecedents, processes, contexts, and outcomes of effective leadership communication. Special attention should be given to investigating emerging and challenging issues, such as leadership communication during turbulent times (e.g., change and crisis), leadership communication strategies for conflict resolution, and leadership communication in the remote/hybrid work contexts, and leadership communication mediated by emerging technologies. It is important to remember that while not every effective communicator is an effective leader, every effective leader must be an effective communicator.

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EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION AND ORGANIZATIONAL ENVIRONMENT

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As you begin reading this chapter, the thought may have crossed your mind, "What exactly do we mean by organizational environment?" A quick search on Google Scholar reveals a decades-old, contested scholarly concept. Although the term continues to appear in scholarly research, it typically emerges as an unquestioned colloquial concept deployed in the service of developing other theoretical concepts. The term loosely refers to the state of an organization affecting a particular phenomenon of interest. Individual employees, managers, or leaders often seek to impact environments in the hope of influencing a more specific phenomenon of interest. These professionals' or academics' experiences and priorities lead them to emphasize different elements of environments. Unfortunately, a comprehensive review of these approaches to environment—in their various distinctions and similarities—is beyond the scope of this chapter. Instead, this chapter offers a different approach. The forthcoming pages consider what it means to take the metaphor of organizational environment seriously. In other words, what can scholars and practitioners see, analyze, and engage when using environment (in the sense of an ecology or what some might call the "natural environment") as an organizational metaphor.

I take this approach for two reasons. First, communication scholars have long studied the power of metaphors to shape how we engage in organizational action (Putnam & Boys, 2006), drawing on a broader

interdisciplinary field that explores the centrality of metaphors to human interaction and collective meaning making (Cornelissen, 2006; Lakoff & Johnson, 2003). By exploring organizational environment as metaphor, this chapter draws parallels between the ways organizations and ecological environments exist and function. Analyzing this metaphor as a heuristic (rather than a prescriptive device) highlights the possibilities for thought and action that this metaphor offers organizational actors. Second, contestation over organizational environment as a theoretical tool points to the fact that the term is already used as a framing device rather than a distinct organizational phenomenon. In his own attempt to summarize literature on organizational environment, Frishammar (2006) notes that different perspectives "seem to determine how researchers as well as practitioners conceive of the concept of environment, what they mean when using the term, as well as what concept the term is thought to refer to" (p. 23).

I come to this task as a scholar and practitioner who finds her academic home in Organizational and Cultural Communication. My work draws heavily on sociomaterial and relational ontologies to address questions typically associated with the Communicative Constitution of Organization (CCO; Boiven et al., 2017), especially as they intersect with the constitution of cultural norms, identities, and power structures. This background influences how I perceive the ecological environment and how I deploy it in this chapter: I move away from an understanding of environment as something separate that surrounds one's phenomena of inquiry. Instead, I embrace an environmental lens that addresses our daily choices, norms, and patterns of interaction as part of the environment, as both shaped by and shaping ongoing shifts in our global ecology. This assumption corresponds with shifts away from a "container" metaphor of organization toward the more commonly used constitutive model in organizational communication (for a succinct video explanation see Koschmann, 2021). While my theoretical background clearly informs my approach, drastic shifts among more natural spaces in the wake of COVID shutdowns demonstrated human integration with the natural environment, illustrating the interconnectedness of humanity, plants, animals, and other natural elements as part of the natural environment.

To unpack the parallels between ecological environment and sociomaterial approaches to organizing, the bulk of this chapter engages shifting assumptions as demonstrated in four principles. These principles draw on the organization as environment metaphor as it intersects with developments in organizational communication theory addressing

change, webs of connection, power, and processes of communication. Each section connects an environmental principle to existing work in organizational communication and identifies what this might mean for the study and practice of employee communication in organizations.

However, as I worked to take the organizational environment metaphor seriously and brought it into conversation with my own scholarly background, the voices of native colleagues[1] grew ever louder in my mind. Their calls and guidance to acknowledge all of our relatives —plants, animals, and minerals—and to hear the lessons each teaches in their own subtle way echoed in my thoughts. It became evident that taking organizational environment seriously—and perhaps the sociomaterial study of organizational communication writ large—requires attention to indigenous ways of organizing and creating space for indigenous voices that are rarely attended to in organizational and organizational communication studies. Thus, this chapter concludes with a call to attend to indigenous ontologies and epistemologies, not only as significant to analysis of organizational environment but also as they might inform CCO organizational scholarship more broadly.

Shifting Assumptions and Associated Principles

The proceeding section of this chapter brings together existing trends in organizational literature and the metaphor of organizational environment. Doing so enables novel interpretations and applications of organizational environment as both a practical and academic framework for assessing organizations. To do so I address the intersections of existing organizational communication literature and the environmental metaphor through four assumptions that I label as Environmental Principles: #1 Environments constantly move and change, #2 Environments are webs of interconnection, #3 Environments are incredibly powerful, and #4 Communication takes many different forms in an environment. By connecting to both existing literature and the environmental metaphor, I hope readers gain a novel perspective on what it might mean to take up existing threads in organizational communication, and what it might mean to act intentionally as a member of an organizational environment.

Environmental Principle #1: Environments Constantly Move and Change

Our global ecological environments are in constant states of motion and change. Whether daily cycles that revolve around a rising and setting sun, passing seasons over the course of a year, plants or animals advancing through a life cycle, or the inevitability of catastrophic events; ecological environments offer a paradox of stability and predictability built on motion, movement, and constant change. Broader cycles of change are often made up of many tiny little changes; each wave inching forward and back as the tide rolls in and out, temperatures inch up and down as days grow longer and shorter marking the changing seasons. When we look closely at the seeming stability of the environment—even the mountains, rivers, and land we walk upon—we see that the environment is teeming with motion and change. If we are to take organization as environment seriously than we must attend to the ways that even those structures of our organization that appear stable are sustained by constant motion and change.

Similarly, organizational scholars increasingly assume that organizational change, disorganization, or (in)stability is a natural state of organizations (Vasquez & Kuhn, 2020). This notion of change is embedded in CCO research that rejects conceptualizations of organizations as static monolithic entities. Instead, it assumes that organizations are in constant states of becoming. They exist because of the everyday action that we take on behalf of the organization. By example, organizations open each day because people show up and take part, and people show up and take part because of communicative efforts that convince them to be there. Rather than taking the seemingly stable and static state for granted, organizational communication scholars explore how stability is accomplished. Among other things, communication scholars have explored the role of decision-making and its pursuant implications (Schoeneborn, 2011), how texts become authoritative as they are cited across organizations by organization actors (Kuhn, 2008), and bodies as they move through and occupy in space (Brummans & Vezy, 2022; Mease & Terry, 2012). Recently this work points to the fact that organizational stability and change are not opposing forces, but mutually imbricated (Mease, 2021). This work acknowledges that stability is not an interruption of motion and change. Rather, the two are always imbricated and mutually implicated.

Reading the literature and metaphor together offers several insights into how one might analyze and act as members of an organizational environment. First, it reminds us that to analyze an organizational environment is not to look for a stable structural force that surrounds

organizational actors from a distance, but to analyze it as something that we are a part of. An organizational environment is not separate and surrounding us. Rather, we are moving among the flows and motions of the organizational environment of which we are a part. Flows of bodies, information, and money are some of the most noticeable elements that make up the organizational environment. Second, it follows that organizational environments are in motion because they are made up of an infinite set of actions and actors that act in coordination (although sometimes not) to sustain an organization. Thus, as one of those many actors in motion, our attempts to influence and act upon an organizational environment do not create change in a stable monolithic organizational environment, but rather influence the actions and flows of the many interrelated organizational actors and actions that are in motion with us. When we take organizational environments seriously, we acknowledge that our job is not to capture and control, but to engage and to channel the motion that is inevitable.

Environmental Principle #2: Environments are Webs of Interconnection

If nothing else, ecological studies of the environment teach us that elements of the environment are interconnected. Interconnections take on many forms. At the most basic level, behavior and actions by a single member or group can have far reaching implications across the environment. This was particularly evident as COVID shutdowns across the globe unexpectedly altered patterns of action and behavior in other aspects of the ecological environment. We can also see how elements in the environment grow and become something new through relationships of connection and exchange in an environment. A field of seeds becomes a field of flowers, not by its own volition, but by its relationship with and integration of rain, sun, and soil. All of these are interconnected in the flower, which will continue new connections with the surrounding environment as it matures and dies. Moreover, species that are in harmony within one ecosystem may be invasive in a different ecosystem due to the absence or presence of related species of plants, animals, or minerals that provide balance in one context, but not in another.

Ecological and organizational sciences share a common theoretical foundation of systems theory. However, systems theory emphasizes distinct related parts, while generally maintaining the environment as a separate surrounding. More recent work in organizational

communication research approaches webs of interconnection through relational ontologies (Kuhn et al., 2017). Grounded in socio-material perspectives, relational approaches to organizing explain organizational constitution by examining how organizations come to exist through relationships. Those relations constitute both the organizations and the constitutive pieces that make up those organizations (Cooren & Caidor, 2019). For example, by showing up at workstations or meetings each day, and processing information or physical products and passing them on to the next step in a process, individuals take their place as one part in a flow that constitutes the organization. At the same time the individual themself is constituted as an employee of the organization by the very same relationships and flows. Through those relationships they take on a specific role and occupation, while those same relationships, services or products constitute the organization itself. As interrelated elements of organizations, we are both *of* and *in* relationships. As communication scholars, we have also focused on texts—such as a budget or a policy—noting that those texts influence or constrain organizational constitution, only in so far as they are animated or brought to life through complex relationships of influence on individual people, choices, and actions (Taylor & Van Every, 2000). In turn, objects might also channel human presence and influence in spaces where their bodies are not present through texts, photographs, or looming office spaces (Cooren, 2012).

Again, the question becomes what novel insights emerge by intentionally bringing the metaphor of organizational environment in to conversation with this thread in organizational communication research. Perhaps one of the most insightful conclusions from this merger is how we conceive of our capacity to act and influence an organization as environment. Traditional conceptions often depict organizational environments as more or less empowering to individual people, which maintains focus on whether the environment enhances or inhibits individual's ability to influence others. But if environments are webs of interconnection in which we are all embedded, human and non-human alike, then our ability to influence is ALWAYS about our place in the environment, and the relationships that define that place (Kuhn et al., 2017). This would point us to examine our place in an environment by mapping our own relations, to other humans, to resources, to spaces, to objects, and their relations to others. Such mapping will foster understanding of how all of those pieces collectively constitute our place in/and the environment. Thus, to consider how an employee's actions and choices are shaped by organizational environments, or how they have the

capacity to shape an organizational environment, we must expand beyond questions of power and constraint in individually isolated relationships. Instead, we must analyze organizational environments as constellations of relationships that enable us to shift the inevitable flows of organizing. What works for an employee or leader in one location with its unique set of relations, may or may not work in another locations with its distinct set of relations. This brings us more clearly to the question of power.

Environmental Principle #3: Environments are Incredibly Powerful

When considering the power expressed by the natural environment, extreme weather and natural disasters come to mind. The power of these events manifests as disruptions of the expected cycles and patterns of an environment. However, that power is not a possession. It is an expression manifest in action: air as wind, water as rain or flooding, heat that dehydrates, cold that freezes, fire that burns, viruses that infect, and so on. Moreover, the power of a hurricane, flood, drought, or earthquake, for instance, is not the result of intent, but the confluence of many processes and pieces set in motion. For example, temperatures, moisture, and winds make up weather fronts that in turn collide to make up tornados or hurricanes. Each small piece plays a part, regardless of intention. A second insight about power emerges from the principle that environments are paradoxically stable and always in motion. This requires looking beyond disruptions to examine power in the predictable movement of environments; in seemingly stable environments that foster growth and life. When soil, light, and water come together in optimal ratios plant life prospers, supporting animal life in turn. This, too, is an expression of power. In short, environments are not powerful because they can impose their will, they are powerful because the balance of paradoxical yet predictable stability and change creates *and* destroys. The power to create and destroy does not lie in a single element, but in the balance and disruption of the many elements in relationship with one another. Power is both sublime and mundane.

Organizational communication scholars have conceptualized power in similarly decentralized ways. For example, socio-material research suggests that agency, or the capacity to make a difference, is always a collective function rather than the property of a single actor (Kuhn et al., 2017). Similarly, organizational communication often draws on

Foucauldian concepts of power that emphasize how power always *moves through* people, objects, and bodies; not possessed by any single being (Foucault, 1995). Foucault also emphasized that power is more often a process of production rather than a process of destruction, although destruction may occur in the service of that production. For example, in a capitalist economy we are compelled to engage in "professional" behaviors as a means of producing our own identities as valued, competent workers. However, as we engage in that self-production as a worker, other possibilities for professional identities are diminished and/or extinguished. Thus, power lies in the ability to compel one kind of production over another. Ashcraft explores this type of power in the ways we endorse or condemn certain relations of affect (Ashcraft, 2019). Still others demonstrate how authority emerges in organizing when people consistently draw on the importance of a particular issue as critical, text as authoritative (Kuhn, 2008), or a decision as binding (Schoeneborn, 2011). Without the consistent return to or connection to these issues, texts, or decisions they do not express power—they would simply fade away as a non-event or non-entity. Thus, organizational communication research offers ways to conceptualize power as distributed, relational, subtly productive (and consequently destructive), and always in motion.

What do these insights mean for attempts to analyze or act in relationship with organizational environments? Power in an organizational environment cannot be practiced or analyzed in isolated individuals or incidents. Organizational environments (and our place in them) are powerful because they are composed of a contingent set of relationships that foster certain forms of life and destroy others. Whether one opposes or approves of that power, analyzing or acting on the power of an organizational environment requires an understanding of relationships among the many actors and processes that participate in and constitute the organizational environment. To analyze an organizational environment is not just to analyze the actors that are the pieces of the environment. It also requires attention to the arrangement of those actors (human and non-human) and the processes that continually brings them into relationship, making it possible to say and do certain things and not others. What might look like an individual possessing power or imposing will, upon closer look is an organizational environment that fosters some acts and relationships, while making others unimaginable. Moreover, while the power of the organizational environment may be most salient when expected cycles, movement, and relations are disrupted or threatened (a flood, a fire, a hurricane)—organizational actors and

scholars must acknowledge that organizational environments, as constantly in-motion webs of inter-connection, are always expressing and circulating power. Both the predictably "normal" organizational environments that produce particular forms of living, and the disruptions to those organizational environments are indeed expressions of power. While employees can express power in the relationships that exist, this principle reminds us that employees can also (as interconnected elements of the organizational environment) express power by imagining and establishing relationships and flows that are yet unimagined.

Environmental Principle #4: Communication Takes Many Forms in an Environment

Environments are full of well-organized coordinated processes that produce predictable outcomes or products—and yet language is not the primary means of that coordination. Gravitational pulls, radiation of the sun, shifts in temperature, and flows of elements all elicit timely, coordinated action, growth, and rest in the natural environment. Thus, in an ecological environment, communication occurs in numerous formats, each of which uses some form of connection or relationship that compels a response. Consequently, in the ecological environment, communication rarely compels coordinated responses through language; it typically manifests through a diverse array of material forces.

In a similar manner, sociomaterial approaches to communication have called for organizational communication scholars to expand definitions of what counts as communication. Early iterations of this expansion moved beyond human language to account for non-human communication examining how objects speak through or for human actors; including processes like presentification (Cooren et al., 2008) or ventriloquism (Cooren & Sandler, 2014). More recent work has built on this expansion calling on scholars to think beyond the linguistic focus on meaning making altogether. This work reconceptualizes language and meaning as just one form of communication, taking up the ways that sociomaterial entities communicate (think of the way a doorway directs traffic, or the ways gravity and rocks direct the flow of water down a mountain), as well as communication through affective relations that evoke feelings and intensities in excess of meaning making processes (Ashcraft, 2019). Thus, organizational communication researchers have expanded concepts of communication beyond human processes of meaning making to consider how non-human actors participate in

meaning making, and to consider how communication occurs in excess of meaning making processes, through a variety of affective, energetic, and physical encounters that evoke responsive communicative relationships.

It follows that when employees consider communication using the metaphor of the organizational environment, they might consider more than symbolic forms of language and non-verbal communication by looking beyond a sender–message–receiver model of human communication. When we take the metaphor seriously, communication processes in an organizational environment are as vast as processes of communication in the ecological environment that inspire and potentially coordinate (successfully or not) the flows of action that constitute the stability of an environment. In any organizational environment, an analysis of organizational communication is not limited to analysis of human interaction, or even to an analysis of the texts and symbols that occupy a given space. If we take the organizational environment seriously, communication analysis and action must attend to the ways material factors affect flows of bodies in space, and how affective energies and intensities (the "vibes" in popular 2025 discourse) connect, coordinate, and create/destroy particular relations that constitute the environment. As scholars and practitioners of communication among organizations, we have to attune (Mease & Branton, 2024) to the many aspects of an organizational environment that communicate a sense of welcome, rejection, encouragement or possibility; each fostering and preventing particular relationships and thus communicating the organizational environment into existence.

On Being Good Relatives: Opening to Indigeneity

When I set out to write a chapter that captured what it means to take the environmental metaphor seriously, I began with the expertise I had developed through years of scholarly training and focused expertise on sociomaterial scholarship. Yet the invitation to take the environmental metaphor seriously led me to recognize how this theoretical grounding in European philosophy and academic theory fails to acknowledge and value longstanding indigenous ontologies and epistemologies that resonate with this perspective while adding ethical and practical depth. The remainder of this chapter is not a demonstration of expertise in indigenous organizational ontologies (for a recent literature review of indigenous management and organization literature, see Salmon et al.,

2023). Rather it attempts to re-orient considerations of organizational environment—and sociomateriality of organizational communication more broadly—to amplify indigenous experiences, ways of knowing, and organizing as it potentially resonates, challenges, and improves existing work. I aim to highlight some of this resonant work and call all scholars to reimagine the organizational–academic–indigenous relationship, while also laying out what might be some ethical parameters for those who seek to amplify indigenous approaches and voices as allies. Dutta and Elers (2020) have made a similar call in the field of Public Relations.

Indigenous ontologies and epistemologies offer several points of resonance to the organizational environment approach outlined in this chapter and to the sociomaterial approach that undergirds the chapter. First, many indigenous approaches highlight the importance of all elements of the environment—plant, animal, and mineral—as relatives. In her own amplification of indigenous relationality trawlwulwuy woman and geography scholar Tynan (2021) highlights that understanding relationality conceptually is only a first step, "to *feel* the world as kin is to enact a relational ethos and the responsibilities and accountabilities that accompany it" (p. 600). As such, she asks humans (as both researchers and organizational practitioners) to attend to the ways the environment and its various elements not only communicate but also teach us ways of being and relating as part of an environment—not to categorize the world from a distance but to "create stronger relationality (or ceremony) between entities" (p. 606). Accordingly, the role of scholars and practitioners may be less about analysis, control and influence, and more about learning from and strengthening ties to the environment we live in. Employees and scholars might strengthen ties to the indigenous and native people, experiences, and worldviews currently silenced by refusal of those ties in our everyday mundane practices of organizing and research, and by our detachment from the organizational-ecological environment.

Second, indigenous approaches that highlight relationality and interconnectedness as fundamental resonate with interconnectedness of the organizational environment metaphor and with the relational constitution approach of sociomaterial scholars. Leaning into this resonance pushes for more careful consideration of the ethical commitments that lie latent in sociomateriality and organizational environment approaches to organizing. Littletree, Belarde-Lewis, and Duarte's (2020) conceptual model to advance indigenous knowledge

organization practices positions relationality at the core of knowing oneself and the world, as well as the ability to express understanding and organize accordingly. They carefully note that their work is born out of a commitment to their own indigenous communities, but also calls to the larger field of knowledge organizations and information sciences (and I might add communication) to center relationality in research and practice as a "decolonizing technique that allows Indigenous ontologies to emerge in otherwise colonial institutions" (p. 423). When applying their work to the organizational environment metaphor, they remind both scholars and employees alike that relationality is not simply an intellectual exercise. It is an ethical matter of our everyday relations that foster access and voice, which produce who and what can be heard and valued in the practice and study of organizational environments. As employees and leaders who are both of and in organizational relations (principle #2) that both produce and destroy (principle #4), it reminds us that every connection and every decision we make has implications for who and what can be heard and survive in the environments we create.

Thus, I invite scholars and practitioners alike (including myself) to carefully consider how to amplify indigenous people's voices and native ways of knowing in scholarly and organizing practices. This requires intentional effort to understand—in both mind, body, and relationship—how indigenous experiences and ways of knowing might be amplified in scholarship and practice of organizational environments. Doing so requires acknowledging the breath, variety, and complexity of indigeneity across global contexts. Additionally, this call should not be conflated with a call for scholars to consider indigeneity as an object or methodological tool for research (although this is a worthy and necessary endeavor). It is a call to self-reflexively engage indigenous knowledge and indigenous people in research, organizing, and leadership practices themselves, regardless of whether the practices are self-evidently indigenous concerns. As my colleague Ted Hibbler calls it, it is a call to "indigenize" our everyday organizational practices and scholarship. It follows that opening space for indigeneity and native ways in organizational environment or sociomateriality studies is not simply a cognitive and intellectual exercise that can be performed through texts. The scholars highlighted here offer a call that requires attention not only to how we exercise our voices in scholarship, but also to how we exercise our own silence and how we engage our bodies in the practice of learning from and honoring all of our relatives.

Thus, taking the metaphor of organizational environment seriously calls both scholars, leaders and organizational employees (#1) to attend to the everyday changing and evolving nature of organizational environments, (#2) to embrace the interconnections of those everchanging flows that simultaneously constitute both organizational environments as well as the elements that make up that environment, (#3) to reconceive of power as manifest in the (im)balance of those interconnections that both create and destroy, and finally (#4) to attune to the many forms of communication that occur in organizational environments, including but not limited to language. While I have pointed to theoretical foundations for this work that are already prevalent in the field of organizational communication, I have also suggested that scholars and practitioners ethically and more intentionally attend to and amplify the contributions that indigenous people and native ways of knowing might offer this work. In doing so, I hope to have convincingly proposed that taking the organizational environment metaphor seriously remains a fruitful endeavor.

Note

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23

EMPLOYEE APPRECIATION—A COMMUNICATION PERSPECTIVE

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Fostering a strong employee-organization relationship has been recognized as important for quite some time. However, during the COVID-19 pandemic that gripped the world in the early 2020s, the importance of working seriously on this relationship became strikingly clear:

> If the past 18 months have taught us ansything, it's that employees crave investment in the *human* aspects of work. (…) Yes, they want pay, benefits, and perks, but more than that they want to feel valued by their organizations and managers.
>
> *(De Smet et al., 2021, p. 1, italics in original)*

This quote highlights the need for employees to feel appreciated at work, which has been particularly evident during this extraordinary crisis situation. However, extant research suggests that it is not only during a crisis that employees benefit from an appreciative working climate, as perceiving appreciation is linked to a range of positive outcomes at work (e.g., Pfister et al., 2020a, b; Semmer et al., 2019; Stocker et al., 2010, 2014, 2019). Yet, research on appreciation in the workplace is not very systematic (Semmer et al., 2016), and the communication perspective on employee appreciation is largely missing. This is surprising considering that appreciation can be easily communicated at different organizational levels (Semmer et al., 2019) and "internal communication exerted at both organizational and leadership levels influences the way employees think

and act, which is an important manifest of [an organizational] culture" (Men, 2021, p. 6). Scholars claim that this lack of attention to appreciation "may well be due to the fact that few people would doubt its importance, implying that it is assumed to be a matter of course rather than something requiring a special focus" (Semmer et al., 2016, p. 15).

This chapter aims to contribute to filling this research gap by focusing on employee appreciation from a communication perspective. First, the literature review provides insights into how the concept of appreciation is defined and researched. We then present findings from our own research, which focused on the communication of appreciation in the workplace, particularly in times of crisis, and the co-creation process of an appreciative working climate.

Literature Review on Employee Appreciation in the Workplace

Appreciation in the workplace is researched in several disciplines, including organization studies, management, human resources, work and organizational psychology, occupational health, nursing science, and communication. The definitions of appreciation vary between conceptualizing it as a perception (Weiss & Zacher, 2022) or feeling (Davis et al., 2021; Lutgen-Sandvik et al., 2011), or as a communicative behavior (Apostel et al., 2018; Stocker et al., 2019). Authors that conceive appreciation as a perception or feeling see it as a response to a perceived receipt of gratitude (Davis et al., 2021), respect (van Quaquebeke & Eckloff, 2010) or recognition that tells employees what they did or said is socially rewarded by others (Weiss & Zacher, 2022), or that they are being valued by others even without explicit recognition or reward (Lutgen-Sandvik et al., 2011). While in these conceptualizations of appreciation the communicative act is termed gratitude or recognition, others refer to appreciation as "specific behaviors that explicitly signal acknowledgment and recognition of one's work" (Apostel et al., 2018, p. 4). These signals can be directed at an individual and/or group and "may include things such as awards for best team, birthday cakes, (…) recognition of women workers on Mother's Day" (Najera, 2008, p. 296), or verbal praise in the form of "Thank you for this idea!" (Wood et al., 2007, p. 391). Stocker et al. (2019) explicitly refer to appreciation as communication by defining it "as communicating that one values someone else; the term may refer to (a) unconditionally acknowledging the person as an individual or (b) acknowledging his or

her performance, behavior, or qualities" (p. 333). Looking at these definitions, it is clear that appreciation is closely related to other concepts such as gratitude, respect, recognition, and acknowledgment, and some authors consider these terms to be equivalent (Pfister et al., 2020a; Beck, 2016). Pfister et al. (2020a) furthermore note the closeness of appreciation to the emotional component of social support.

In the work context, appreciation is discussed as a job resource (e.g., Stocker et al., 2014, 2019) that fulfills basic human needs (e.g., needs for competence and relatedness), fostering several individual and organizational outcomes. Key findings are that perceiving appreciation is positively associated with job satisfaction (Elfering et al., 2017; Garrido Vásquez et al., 2020; Muskat & Reitsamer, 2020; Pfister et al., 2020a; Stocker et al., 2010, 2019), job engagement (Einwiller et al., 2021; Gulyani & Sharma, 2018), work happiness (Gulyani & Sharma, 2018), perceptions of self-efficacy (Stocker et al., 2019), feelings of success at work (Pfister et al., 2020a), and employees' self-esteem (Semmer et al., 2019). Study results furthermore show that the perception of appreciation is positively related to employees' affective well-being, which comprises aspects such as increased contentment, feelings of serenity as well as less anxiety and depressive symptoms (Kranabetter & Niessen, 2019; Pfister et al., 2020b; Pohrt et al., 2022; Stocker et al., 2014, 2019). With regard to the employing organization, appreciation is associated with stronger affective commitment (Einwiller et al., 2021; Elfering et al., 2017), less feelings of resentment, that is, anger, indignation, disappointment toward one's organization (Pfister et al., 2020a; Stocker et al., 2010), and reduced turnover intentions (Apostel et al., 2018; Davis et al., 2021).

A key research question for scholars and practitioners is how to foster perceptions of appreciation. For example, Stocker et al. (2014) determined several forms of appreciation in a sample of 139 employees in Switzerland by asking participants to describe appreciative situations at work over the course of a working week. The researchers identified five behavioral categories:

> *praise and gratitude* (e.g., praise, compliments, saying thank you, and positive feedback), *trust and responsibility* (e.g., expressing trust, asking the employee for advice, honoring competency, assigning interesting tasks or new responsibilities to the employee), *support and respect* (e.g., emotional support, instrumental support, spending time, listening carefully, respecting my needs, saying sorry), *motivated cooperation* (e.g., motivated teamwork, joy, good

> mood in team, finding solutions together), *tangible reward and promotion* (e.g., getting a present or a bonus, being invited, being promoted).
>
> *(Stocker et al., 2014, p. 82, italics in original)*

Praise and gratitude were by far the most frequently reported category. The results of this project show that communication plays an important role in expressing appreciation, while only some forms of appreciation are tangible.

There is also a great debate about responsibilities in addressing appreciation at work. The role of managers/supervisors as communicators of appreciation is particularly pronounced (e.g., Apostel et al., 2018; Davis et al., 2021; Elfering et al., 2017; Kranabetter & Niessen, 2019). Besides, the role of coworkers and customers (Stocker et al., 2014; Muntz & Dormann, 2020) is highlighted. Aside from these sources, Beck (2016) emphasizes the engagement of executive managers and internal communication professionals. To deepen the communication perspective on appreciation, the remainder of this chapter provides insights into the main findings of our research on the communicative drivers and effects of appreciation during organizational crises (Einwiller et al., 2021; Stranzl, 2021), employees' expectations regarding appreciation during crises (Stranzl & Ruppel, 2023), and on the co-creation process of an appreciative working climate (Stranzl & Ruppel, 2024).

Appreciation during Organizational Crises

When an organization is hit by a crisis, its employees are seen as key supporters in overcoming such a situation (Frandsen & Johansen, 2011; Heide & Simonsson, 2019, 2021; Mazzei et al., 2019). Their

> engaged behaviour is crucial in order to protect the reputation of the company from false criticism, to spread correct information, to sustain the corrective actions the organization is implementing to face the crisis and to relaunch the organization when the crisis is over.
>
> *(Mazzei & Butera, 2021, p. 176)*

The crisis context of the COVID-19 pandemic was particularly challenging for employees as many people had to work under aggravated

conditions and experienced personal and job-related uncertainties. From the beginning, organizations were held accountable to respond to the crisis and to give employees something back for their continued job engagement and extra efforts (Ruppel et al., 2022). Employee appreciation was publicly debated and internally expected.

Communicative Drivers and Effects of Perceived Appreciation during the COVID-19 Pandemic

To examine the role of internal communication in general and appreciation in particular during the acute phase of the COVID-19 pandemic, we conducted a survey among employees in Austria working in different types of organizations and sectors (Einwiller et al., 2021). Based on the social exchange theory (Blau, 1964; Cropanzano & Mitchell, 2005), we argued that employees demand resources from their employer during challenging times such as a pandemic, which are then reciprocated in terms of continued job engagement and extra efforts. Internal communication is particularly important for providing non-economic resources of an informational and emotional nature. Based thereon, we differentiated between two forms of internal communication, informational (i.e., factual and substantial information conveyed in a transparent manner) and relational (i.e., appreciation and the opportunity for participation). While informational communication had been considered highly relevant during a crisis (e.g., Heide & Simonsson, 2019), we assumed that relational crisis communication, and here particularly appreciation, may be just as important, or even more important, to engender continued support by employees during such challenging times.

Participants in our survey (N = 1,033) were asked to assess the transparency of their organization's internal communication during the crisis, their satisfaction with the information they received, the opportunity they were given to participate and, importantly, their perception of the appreciation they received from their executive management. To assess perceived appreciation, participants were asked to indicate the extent to which the following statements apply to them: "My employer thanks employees like me for their commitment during the Corona crisis; During this time, employees like me are highly valued by management; It is openly communicated that the work of employees like me is important" (Einwiller et al., 2021, p. 243). Participants were furthermore asked how much they accepted their executive

management's decisions, how much they felt affectively committed to their organization, and how engaged they were in their job.

The results show that informational crisis communication positively affected employees' acceptance of their executive management's decisions during the pandemic, which fostered their job engagement. However, the effect of relational crisis communication had an even stronger effect on job engagement through strengthening employees' affective commitment with their employer. Appreciation emerged as the strongest driver of affective organizational commitment, which was most important for employees' job engagement. Interestingly, further analyses of these data revealed that employees who worked mainly on-site felt less appreciated by their employer and perceived the communication as less transparent during the acute phase of the pandemic than employees who worked mainly from home (Stranzl, 2021). In summary, the study highlights the importance of investing in the employee-organization relationship by expressing appreciation to employees for their support, while at the same time providing employees with relevant crisis information (Einwiller et al., 2021).

Employees' Expectations of Appreciation during the COVID-19 Pandemic

The importance of relational crisis communication based on appreciation is further underscored by an interview study of 32 remote and on-site employees from multiple organizations conducted in Austria in 2021, one year after the outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic (Stranzl & Ruppel, 2023). The study focused particularly on employees' different perceptions and experiences of appreciation, and how communication managers responsible for internal communication can help to address appreciation. Interviewees were asked, for example, about their personal definition and meaning of appreciation. Furthermore, they were encouraged to reflect on specific situations where they felt appreciated by their executive management, line managers, colleagues, or costumers. We also asked about critical situations in which employees missed appreciation efforts during the first year of the pandemic.

The study revealed that there are several ways for organizations to appreciate employees as individuals as well as their performance and their extra efforts during a crisis. Not surprisingly, our study participants valued monetary forms of appreciation (i.e., a bonus, voucher, additional vacation, or a salary increase). In addition, interviewees mentioned

concrete offers of support including work materials and psychological support. Beyond these benefits and offers of support, they perceived receiving transparent communication on topics like how the crisis is being managed, what potential effects it has on the organization and how the executive management plans for the future as appreciative. They expected first and foremost their CEO to actively communicate appreciation and specifically mentioned the positive feeling from getting a personalized thank you message from executive management. The study further showed that the topic of appreciation is highly emotional, even more so when employees don't feel appreciated. Many of our interview partners did not experience any appreciation from their organization. The following quote from a person who had to work on-site during the pandemic illustrates their disappointment: "A thank you from the management would be appropriate because we work on-site every day, have contact with hundreds of people and get neither thanks nor anything else from our management" (Stranzl & Ruppel, 2023, p. 17). Another interview partner lamented: "Apart from motivational speeches like more, faster, better, bigger, nothing comes. Despite the growth, there wasn't even a Christmas present for anyone this year" (p. 18). Moreover, the narratives indicate several individual and organizational benefits of feeling appreciated during an organizational crisis situation. For example, our interviewees mentioned that receiving appreciation created a positive feeling about the job and its demands despite the many challenges and high levels of uncertainty. Interviewees perceived their management's appreciation efforts as a form of compensation that helped them to cope better with stress. In addition, feeling appreciated for their efforts during the pandemic strengthened their connection to the organization and motivated them to support organizational decisions while facing the personal and economic challenges involved.

The results of the study suggest that it is essential for organizations to gain knowledge of employees' situational needs and demands in order to manage internal crisis communication effectively. Employee appreciation should be a clearly defined objective of strategic communication in a crisis situation. Depending on employees' specific situation (e.g., working on-site or from home) various forms of expressing appreciation must be carefully considered. Internal communication professionals serve as strategic partners and enablers for their CEO and other managers to support them in their appreciative crisis communication. They also serve as role models through their own initiatives and communication practices. In addition, the interview results point to the importance of an

overall appreciative working climate, which is directly reflected at the relationship level in a crisis situation.

Co-creating an Appreciative Working Climate

Internal communication by several stakeholders shapes organizational culture (Men, 2021), with managers and communication professionals playing key roles in fostering an appreciative working climate. Therefore, the aim of our study (Stranzl & Ruppel, 2024) was to capture employees' expectations of why, how and by whom appreciation should be expressed in order to define communication responsibilities and dependencies. Three focus groups were conducted at the beginning of 2023 to thoroughly examine the reasons for receiving appreciation in the workplace, which forms of showing appreciation are appropriate and who can and should be involved in appreciating employees. A total of 19 employees from different professions, with higher and lower incomes, who were working in organizations based in Austria participated. The study captured the perspectives of employees without management function who were working on-site or partly remotely.

With respect to the reasons why someone should receive appreciation at work, two different areas emerged from the discussions: (1) personal characteristics and qualities and (2) work-related behavior. The first area highlights the relevance to appreciate employees for their individual personality, their professional competence, and their prior work experiences. In addition, employees expected appreciation for their honesty, punctuality at work, reliability, spontaneity, and flexibility. It also includes employees' social competences and their loyalty to the organization. The second area focuses on employees' work-related behavior. It includes appreciation for the completion of regular work tasks, success-neutral endeavors, individual achievements, job-related and non-job-related extra efforts, and situational extraordinary engagement. Further, employees expect appreciation for their team spirit, communication behavior, contribution to the organization's development and success.

Like Stocker et al. (2014), we assessed the different forms in which appreciation is expressed in the workplace. As an extension of Stocker and colleagues' study we not only captured what employees experience but specifically explored how they expect appreciation to be shown. Six categories emerged from the analyses: First, *monetary and material recognition* is experienced and expected (e.g., bonuses, gifts), which is

comparable to Stocker et al.'s category of tangible reward and promotion. Second, *thanks, praise and esteem* are considered relevant to foster perceptions of appreciation (e.g., praise for performance, parties, individual thank-you messages, when the company fosters its external image), which emerged similarly as an important category in Stocker et al.'s research, who termed it praise and gratitude. However, our data set also includes the aspect of esteem, which refers to employees' perception of being valued when their organization improves its external image, which then reflects positively on them. Third, employees expect to receive appreciation by genuinely *being seen and taken seriously*. This includes taking time to get to know someone, trying to understand an employees' situation, taking time and listen to needs and demands, giving feedback, and being transparent. This extends Stocker et al.'s category of support and respect. The fourth category of appreciative forms concerns the *treatment* of employees. Employees feel appreciated when interactions are respectful, trustful, and empathic, which overlaps with Stocker et al.'s category of trust and responsibility. Two more categories of appreciative forms emerged from our research, which were not identified by Stocker and colleagues. As a fifth form, employees perceive the *design of the general work environment* as a signal of appreciation (e.g., workspace equipment, safety, contract, space for exchange, onboarding process). Sixth, employees feel appreciated when they perceive *purpose and perspective* at work. This includes having meaningful tasks, development opportunities and opportunities to participate. Notably, all forms of appreciation have a communicative aspect. While they can be combined, they are not expected to be shown at the same time.

The data set emphasizes that employees hold their line managers accountable for appreciating them, which can be deduced from their specific working relationship: employees interact regularly with and are closer to them than to the executive management. Line managers know employees tasks, needs, duties, and can respond quickly. Following, line managers should be aware of their communication responsibility to enhance employees' perceptions of appreciation, for which they need knowledge and training. This leads to the strategic role of internal communication professionals in co-creating an appreciative working climate. It is up to them to identify and gather the expectations of different groups of employees, prioritize their needs and develop an overall strategy that will help lay the foundations for an appreciative organizational culture. They do this by listening to employees and

providing them with a range of resources. They also enable employees and line managers to communicate appreciatively with each other. This means that they support them in their daily communication through interactive platforms and communication formats, trainings, and by issuing general rules and a code of conduct, which they help to enforce. Finally, they also serve as role models for good and appreciative communication in their organization.

Discussion of Empirical Results and Implications

Our research so far highlights the need to study and discuss employee appreciation from a communication perspective, as explicit communication behaviors (e.g., thanking, providing transparent information, offering opportunities for dialogue and feedback, explaining bonuses) by certain communicators play a central role in fostering employees' perceptions of appreciation.

Importantly, practicing appreciative communication selectively in specific situations (e.g., crisis, change) is not sufficient. The COVID-19 pandemic clearly shows that organizations and employees benefit from the investment in an overall appreciative working climate (Stranzl & Ruppel, 2023). Our focus group data (Stranzl & Ruppel, 2024) support this by revealing reasons why someone should be appreciated at work and what forms of appreciation are favored by employees. Importantly, the focus groups clearly support previous research on the specific role of line managers in appreciating employees (e.g., Davis et al., 2021; Elfering et al., 2017; Kranabetter & Niessen, 2019). They are themselves dependent on organizational resources (e.g., time, budget, technical solutions), support (e.g., communication training) and, most importantly, appreciation from their superiors. As Stocker et al. (2014) point out, leaders depend in their appreciative communication also on "their own desire for appreciation" (p. 90). Following, middle and line managers communicate in a field of tension between the expectations placed on them and their dependencies on the organizational environment and culture. For example, demonstrating highly valued forms of appreciation such as transparency and trust depends on how these values are embedded in the overall culture of the organization. These findings underline the importance of relationship work of communication professionals (Men, 2021). In their role as strategic communication partners, they can set communication conditions, develop various communication measures and act as role models for employees and

managers at all levels. It is their task to promote an appreciative working climate by enabling all internal communicators in their appreciative communication (Stranzl & Ruppel, 2023).

There are some important ethical issues for responsible communicators to consider. These relate to the tension between genuine appreciation and trying to push people to their limits. Organizations must be careful in expressing appreciation as common forms, such as a bonus, salary raise, gift, or specific meaningful tasks can foster excessive emotional involvement and possibly unhealthy levels of job engagement. Some appreciation efforts may foster behaviors that encourage employees to go above and beyond their regular job roles by creating pressure to do so. To prevent this, communication professionals should act as strategic partners for employees and management. Their knowledge on interpersonal communication, strategic communication, and the power of communication is an important resource of support. It is their responsibility to make internal communicators aware of the relevance of employee appreciation, what works, and also how appreciation has limits, critical aspects, and risks. This responsibility goes beyond the role of an enabler to improve leadership communication. However, this critical perspective on ethical issues and dependencies is frequently lacking.

Directions for Future Research

The discussion and studies presented in this chapter shall serve as a starting point for more research on employee appreciation from an internal communication perspective. While extant research focused particularly on the effects of appreciation in the workplace, we suggest extending the research focus on the communicative process of engendering an appreciative working climate. In this regard, *first* leadership communication is deemed highly important. The debate would benefit from further insights on middle and line managers' expectations, needs, communicative practices and dependencies concerning employee appreciation. In the context of appreciative leadership, perceived fairness requires more attention. As Beck (2016) emphasized, employees sometimes perceive appreciative efforts as unfair: "There's a bonus for some reason, and people get concessions that you don't get. It makes you feel like, Oh, my job's not as important" (p. 346). Similar experiences were reported by employees with respect to a Corona Bonus, which some received during the COVID-19 pandemic

(Stranzl & Ruppel, 2023). *Second*, a nuanced focus on the role of co-workers would stimulate the debate about dependencies. *Third*, more research is needed on the specific roles of internal communication professionals in the co-creation process of an appreciative working climate.

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CARE, JUSTICE, AND RESILIENCE

Designing Positive Employee Communication from Organizational Communication Perspectives

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Organizational communication scholars have studied various communication processes that contribute to positive workplace climates, including participatory decision-making, ethical leadership, an inclusive culture, employee socialization and mentoring, and employee well-being policies and programs. In this chapter, we aim to synthesize this rich body of literature and highlight several communicative processes that are essential for positive employee communication.

As we consider ways to enable positive employee communication, we draw from influential strands of thought in organizational communication studies to develop *a critical communicative design approach*. Our approach foregrounds communication as a constitutive force of organizing, conceptualizing communication as the means by which organizations are established, designed, and sustained. From this lens, we view organizations and organizing as "discursive-material configurations" that "are reproduced and coproduced through ongoing interactions" (Brummans et al., 2014, p. 173). Additionally, the critical communication design approach draws from feminist, queer, decolonial, and critical theorizing of organizational communication to develop its analytical edge and ethical stance (for a review, see Larson et al., 2022). Positive employee communication envisioned from a critical lens

upholds values of inclusivity, care, equity, participation, and justice in everyday organizing, recognizing that positive employee communication is always implicated in imbalanced and intersecting power relations of organizational hierarchy, gender, race, class, education, and other differences. Designing positive employee communication then requires critical reflexivity to understand ongoing power negotiations and to "create opportunities for stakeholders to significantly contribute, meet the individual needs of the people present in an organizational situation, and attempt to disrupt uneven power relations" (Larson et al., 2022, p. 16). Finally, we posit that this design approach highlights the pragmatic nature of organizational communication research (Craig, 1999) and its goal is to improve the quality of organizational members' experiences (Mumby & Stohl, 1996). We view design as "an activity of transforming something given into something preferred through intervention and invention" (Aakhus, 2007, p. 112). The goal of design is not to prescribe individual strategies, but to cultivate holistic, self-sustainable systems that make the organization a better place to work.

We argue that this critical communicative design approach to positive employee communication moves our focus from individual and group-level remedies to systematic adjustments and structural changes, from short-term, one-time solutions to holistic assessment with emphasis on mid- to long-term considerations, from dominating managerial stances to more humanistic and employee-centered perspectives, and from one-size-fit-all solutions to incorporating more fluidity into organizational policies and structures. It is from this approach that we synthesize the current literature and provide theoretical and practical implications to capture and envision processes that constitute positive employee communication.

Four Design Processes

Synthesizing the extant organizational communication literature from the critical communication design framework,[1] we foreground four design processes important to cultivating a positive environment for employee communication: (a) cultivating a dissent-welcoming culture, (b) enacting care and justice leadership, (c) building mentoring relationships, and (d) fostering employee resilience.

These four design processes for positive employee communication correspond with and build upon the four foundational problematics of organizational communication proposed by Mumby and Stohl (1996):

problematics of voice, rationality, organization, and organization–society relationship. *The problematic of voice* addresses the issue of power and control within organizations, focusing on who gets to speak and be heard. Cultivating a dissent-welcoming culture speaks to this problem as it entails designing structures and practices that promote diverse voices. *The problematic of rationality* interrogates how rationality is privileged in organizational decision-making and professional settings in general. Enacting care and justice leadership deals with this problematic by highlighting how leaders can embrace emotionality to encourage positive communication in the workplace. *The problematic of organization* highlights the ways that we think about organization and organizing. We argue that we can approach our organizational life by focusing on the key relationships that are holding us together (or pushing us apart). We further argue that one of the most important relationships that can foster positive employee communication is mentoring. Finally, *the problematic of organization–society relationship* explores the interplay between organizations and their broader societal contexts. We believe that for organizations to sustain and thrive, it is important to take a proactive and collectivist approach to foster employee resilience. It is through a resilient workforce that the organization can tackle changes and crises.

In what follows, we provide insights on how each design process has been studied, why this process is important to positive employee communication, and how such a process can be enacted in a specific organizational setting by focusing on empirical research.

Dissent-Welcoming Organizational Cultures

Organizational communication scholars have conceptualized organizational dissent as a process-based phenomenon. Kassing (1997), for instance, argues that dissent within organizations occurs through two steps: feeling apart from one's organization and vocalizing dissent by "expressing disagreement or contradictory opinions about one's organization" (Kassing, 1997, p. 312). Yet, dissent interactions do not always involve conflict between interlocutors, as dissenters might express their opinions about an organization to audience members who have no agency to address their concerns. Kassing (2011) elaborates upon this notion by proposing three types of dissent: upward, lateral, and displaced. First, upward dissent is expressed toward management with the power to make changes, and it occurs in instances where the dissenter feels that their criticisms will be viewed as constructive and does not fear

retaliation. Second, lateral dissent often unfolds when employees are distrustful of management and express dissent to organizational peers who do not have the power to address the dissenter's concerns. Finally, displaced dissent occurs when an organizational member explains their disagreements with people outside the organization, such as family or friends, given that this dissent process can be safer if the dissenter is not a member of a dissent-welcoming culture.

Numerous studies have explored how organizational dissent unfolds before multiple audiences, including managers, organizational peers, and non-members of the organization (Kassing, 2000a; Kassing, 2000b; Kassing & Avtgis, 1999). However, such work, according to Garner (2013), defines dissent from the perspective of the dissenter, and theorizes dissent as a "discrete event" (p. 374), overlooking how audiences of dissent "might co-construct dissent through their interactions with a dissenter" (p. 375). Rather than conceptualizing dissent as a one-time event, Garner (2013) concludes that dissent is a continuous phenomenon because a response to a dissenter "will shape employees' future dissent expressions" (p. 391). As such, more recent organizational dissent scholarship has understood dissent as a dynamic workplace process wherein dissent accumulates; one dissent interaction always provides context for interpreting later dissent discourses (Garner, 2022; Zaini et al., 2017). This work points to the possibility that organizations can possess cultures that facilitate or silence dissent, and Garner's (2013) research shows how three types of organizational members all contribute to whether or not an organizational culture compels or stifles dissent: the dissenter(s), manager(s), and coworker(s).

Creating an organizational culture that welcomes dissent both enhances organizational performance and promotes employees' well-being. Redding (1985) argued that dissent "should occur with considerable frequency in most organizations" (p. 246), given that "the quality of decision making is generally improved by open debate and dissent" (p. 251). Empirical evidence largely supports this claim. Bisel et al. (2012) discovered that management's dissent suppression tactics hinder organizational learning and adaptation. Further, Zaini et al. (2019) found that faculty productivity at universities increases when administrators improve channels for expressing dissent. Having a safe space to disclose concerns is also necessary for employees to feel valued within their organization (Gossett & Kilker, 2006). Yet, research continually confirms that employees who are dissatisfied with organizational conditions often avoid dissent in fear of backlash from the

organization (Bisel & Arterburn, 2012; Bisel et al., 2011). Organizations, therefore, can strive to cultivate positive communication by designing workplace cultures in which employees do not fear retaliation for dissent expression.

Ford et al.'s (2021) study provides practical advice for organizations seeking to welcome employees' expressions of dissent. Having studied the relationship between organizational tolerance for sexual harassment and employees' willingness to voice harassment they suffered, the authors found no correlation between these variables. Moreover, even survivors in organizations intolerant of sexual harassment often remained silent about their experiences because they were fearful of retaliation, worried that the organization would not stop the problem, or concerned about re-traumatizing themselves by voicing their experiences. Expressing dissent is uniquely difficult in instances of sexual harassment; however, employees' silence about organizational problems is a broad, pervasive workplace phenomenon. As such, Ford et al. (2021) assert that organizations must implement anonymous reporting outlets for dissent to minimize risks associated with disclosing workplace concerns—a type of policy that lays the foundations for a dissent culture that is more welcoming.

Care and Justice Leadership

Detaching from psychological conceptualizations of leadership — which understand leadership as a trait of an individual — organizational communication scholars deploy a social constructionist perspective, asserting that leadership is a relational phenomenon. Fairhurst and Connaughton (2014a) outline six value commitments that undergird a communicative understanding of leadership: (a) leadership is transmissive in that it can only occur through interaction; (b) leadership centers neither leaders nor followers; (c) leadership communication results in influential acts within the organization; (d) leadership is power-based and its definition is always subject to contestation; (e) leadership occurs differently in various places around the globe; and (f) leadership should be reflexive and strive to adjust to uphold moral principles. With these value commitments in mind, Fairhurst and Connaughton (2014b) conceptualize leadership as "the *comanagement* of meaning, in which followers or other leadership actors also manage meaning" (p. 407). As such, followers are not merely passive recipients of a leader's orders; they are active participants in shaping how both parties understand

leadership. Uhl-Bien (2006) furthers that relational, communicative processes enable leaders and followers to construct what leadership means and guide future leadership practices. From a social constructivist perspective, then, leadership cannot exist outside the communicative practices that define it—communication that neither privileges leaders nor followers in their abilities to create meaning (Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014a). Because leadership is a wholly communicative phenomenon, Fairhurst (2009) argues that "leadership is, in effect, a design problem" (p. 1609). Simply put, definitions of leadership may vary depending on the specific interactive processes of a particular organization. Fairhurst (2009) maintains that "Those who aspire to lead must figure out what leadership is in the context of what they do and persuade themselves and others that they are doing it" (p. 1609). In search of communicative practices that support organizational efforts to engage in ethical leadership, we fuse social constructivist notions of leadership with feminist and decolonial organizational theorizing. We argue that leadership committed to basic principles of care and justice might productively guide organizational members' efforts to define leadership and create positive experiences for employees.

Incorporating notions of care and justice into organizational leadership has the potential to facilitate positive employee communication. Buzzanell (2010a) articulates that care ethics within organizations involve "caring *for* others in the altruistic or nurturing fashion" (p. 66), while Moorman (1991) identifies organizational justice as concerned with "the ways in which employees determine if they have been treated fairly in their jobs" (p. 845). Although care and justice ethics have been theorized as opposites, research shows how they productively complement one another. For instance, Buzzanell et al. (1997) studied feminist practices within alternative organizations, which often adopt ethics of care through their leadership strategies by focusing on the importance of building organizational community. The authors explain that within alternative organizations, "Leaders place themselves at the heart of activity rather than at the top" (p. 289). These care-oriented organizations collapse hierarchies between leaders and followers by emphasizing the importance of connection, rather than control. In doing so, they center justice by inviting diverse opinions to contribute to organizational conversations. Similarly, Parker (2020) theorizes the notion of catalytic leadership, a decolonizing "set of communication practices for doing social justice leadership in equitable partner *with*, instead of *on*, communities" (p. 13). Catalytic leadership promotes

justice, building communities of care while operating under the assumption that all voices have value. Ultimately, co-constructed leadership rooted in care and justice sponsors productive employee communication because it gives all people the ability to define what constitutes a positive workplace experience.

Long et al.'s (2020) study exemplifies how ethics of care and justice promote positive interactions among colleagues. Through an autoethnographic analysis, the researchers reflected on a long-term, collective teaching project, identifying their work together as a form of "feminist collaboration" (p. 492). Qualities of their feminist work habits included: shared leadership, grounded participatory processes that gave all members of the team a voice, flexibility surrounding one another's conflicting work and life priorities, and caring about one another "as holistic people" (p. 500). At the same time, the authors warn that the ethics of care and justice exhibited through their feminist collaboration should not be received as universally prescriptive. Moreover, rather than creating firm rules about care and justice in a workplace, organizations should strive to be adaptable and to constantly reflect on how diverse experiences and perspectives change organizational dynamics.

Workplace Mentoring

Mentoring is defined as "a communication relationship in which a senior person supports, tutors, guides, and facilitates a junior person's career development" (Hill et al., 1989, p. 15). Workplace mentoring relationships are traditionally characterized by reciprocity, developmental benefits linked to the mentees' work and career, and regular/consistent interactions between mentors and mentees (Long et al., 2014). In this dyad arrangement, mentors usually act as coaches, helpers, and consultants in mentees' professional development. At the same time, they provide psychosocial support, such as counseling, encouragement, and friendship, and they assist the mentee in interpreting organizational realities (Bokeno & Gantt, 2000).

In addition to the traditional mentoring model, workplace mentoring can also take on the form of reverse mentoring, mentoring network, advocate mentoring, and episodic mentoring. *Reverse mentoring* is "an innovative way to encourage learning and facilitate cross-generational relationships. It involves the pairing of a younger, junior employee acting as mentor to share expertise with an older, senior colleague as mentee" (Murphy, 2012). Reverse mentoring can function as a talent-retaining

tool for younger generations. *Mentoring network* can be defined as "the set of people taking an active interest in a protégé as well as action aiming at advancing the protégé's career by providing career-related and psychosocial functions" (Kim & Kim, 2007, p. 45). Offering mentees a "constellation" of mentors from different life domains, mentoring networks can help workplaces meet their socializing, retention, and career goals, fostering non-hierarchical, cross-cultural, interdisciplinary partnerships, and cultivating collaborative and inclusive cultures (Long et al., 2014). Mentoring relationships can also center on justice and advocacy. An *advocate-mentor* usually has social privilege, must verbally and nonverbally express a deep commitment to seeking social justice on behalf of their mentee, and understands the importance of emotional safety in their role as mentor, advocate, and change agent (Harris & Lee, 2019). Different from established mentoring relationships, mentoring can also occur in episodes. Scholars have studied *episodic mentoring* as consisting of developmental interactions that occur when two parties exchange knowledge, engage in relationship building, and enact social support (Fletcher & Ragins, 2007). These communication moments live in specific instances, occur at freely chosen times, and are agreed upon by mentors and mentees (Parse, 2002). Episodic mentoring is a way to receive and provide "just in time" career advice and psychological support from fellow organizational members in an informal or unstructured way. This advice and support help the individuals' career development, work/life balance issues, and management of workplace politics (Long et al., 2014).

Mentoring can be a crucial process for positive employee communication for four reasons. First, mentoring processes demonstrate that organizations and leaders respect, care, and value their employees' growth and well-being. Second, mentoring socializes employees to learn about their jobs and the cultures of the organization, creating knowledge that operates as building blocks for employees to develop their understanding of the organization. Third, mentoring fosters relationships that enhance retention, building trust, friendship, and belonging among colleagues. Finally, when a mentoring culture is in place, employees feel more involved, have a sense of community, and are more willing to take risks to engage in formal and informal employee communication.

Ragins and colleagues (2017) highlight the positive benefits of mentoring relationships to employee communication. Specifically, they conducted three interrelated studies with 3,813 workers to examine how high-quality mentoring relationships can buffer employees from the

negative effects of ambient discrimination at work, which is defined as the knowledge or awareness of discrimination aimed at others in the workplace. The authors found that high-quality mentoring relationships can buffer negative outcomes of ambient discrimination, such as reduced employee organizational commitment, physical symptoms of stress, insomnia, and stress-related absenteeism. Mentors in high-quality relationships engaged in holding behaviors to help employees deal with anxiety-producing workplace experiences (Kahn, 2001), such as offering receivers a safe space to share their experiences, empathetically acknowledging their feelings, and enabling perspectives that help receivers make sense of the situation and rebuild their ego integrity. Importantly, Kahn (2001) states that organizations need to actively promote, reward, and support the development of high-quality mentoring relationships. Trainings can be provided to mentors and mentees to learn about holding behaviors, perspective taking, active listening, and empathic communication. To improve those mentoring relationship qualities, organizations and leaders can also work on creating effective mentor-mentee matches, monitoring/supporting the relationships, and evaluating program effectiveness.

Employee Resilience Processes

Resilience commonly refers to the capacity to endure or bounce back from difficulties. As workplace changes become increasingly common and stress levels increase, resilience emerges as a desirable skill that employees must cultivate. Nevertheless, trait- and skill-based framing of resilience are not sufficient to highlight the potential of employee resilience in fostering positive employee communication. When framed as a trait, resilience becomes a cognitive characteristic that employees either possess or do not possess. In the workplace context, this framing encourages a generic metric to assess resilience in the hiring process and views resilience as a static character instead of something that organizations and individuals can develop. It also follows the neoliberal logic that it is employees' own responsibility to enact resilience, absolving organizations of responsibility for cultivating resilience. When organizations reframe resilience as a skill, however, they acknowledge that resilience can be learned.

Buzzanell's Communication Theory of Resilience (CTR) framework is foundational to understanding resilience as communicative processes. According to CTR, human resilience is "constituted in and through

communicative processes that enhance people's abilities to create new normalcies" (Buzzanell, 2010b, p. 9). In organizational communication, resilience refers to "the processes by which individuals and organizations reintegrate and foster productive change during and after career setbacks, material and personnel losses, disasters, or other obstacles" (Buzzanell, 2018, p. 14). A communication perspective on studying resilience focuses on the question of "what resilience looks like in different contexts, how the processes unfold, and how we can envision resilience as a design aspect rather than mistaking the entity or person for the process" (Buzzanell, 2010b, p. 3). According to CTR (Buzzanell, 2018), resilience, triggered by loss or disruption, involves five essential communicative processes: (a) crafting normalcy by engaging in daily rituals to gain a sense of control, (b) affirming identity anchors by holding onto the identity labels that help employees confirm who they are, (c) maintaining and using communication networks to engage in sensemaking and support-seeking, (d) enacting alternative logics, where individuals use non-traditional or creative ways of sensemaking or reframing ambiguous situations, and finally, (e) emotion work to legitimize negative feelings while simultaneously foregrounding positive emotions and productive action.

From a critical communicative design perspective, organizations can intentionally develop structures and resources to support their employees to enact these five processes, which we term as resilience-cultivating organizational processes. To a certain extent, the processes we previously discussed, such as cultivating a dissent-welcoming culture, sharing leadership, and fostering mentoring relationships can all be part of the employee resilience-cultivating organizational processes. One consideration that is important in designing resilience-cultivating organizational processes is to take on a proactive long-term approach instead of only viewing resilience as a reactive response. Buzzanell (2018) highlighted that resilience can be proactively cultivated as organizations invest in the bases for resilience enactment prior to and after the trigger point activation. In addition, when thinking about these processes, organizational leaders need to not only aim at fostering individual employee resilience (individual adaptation) but also consider practice and policy change (collective transformation). For example, organizational members might experience chronic burnout from work. To foster employee resilience, organizations can provide counseling services and/or holistic employee wellness programs (meditation or yoga). Nonetheless, changes must occur in the leader-member communication

process (e.g., how work expectations are communicated) and at the broader organizational level (e.g., policy change, evaluation systems, or staffing). Ultimately, resilience-cultivating processes aim to make sure that employees are supported and enabled by resources, knowledge, and the communicative structures to enact adaptive and transformative organizing processes individually and collectively.

Resilience-building can be an important design process that organizations invest in to achieve the goal of positive employee communication. First, resilience-cultivating processes that treat their employees with dignity and as whole persons can show that organizations care. Programs and policies that support work-life priorities and provide material support and flexibility during times of hardship can go a long way in attracting and retaining talents. Second, resilience processes recognize the importance of our mental health and consider ways to find meaningfulness at work. Workplaces often downplay emotionality to privilege rationality and adhere to professional norms. However, positive employee communication relies on positive emotions and mindset. Finally, resilience-cultivation operates as a design principle for continuing to build a workplace that upholds employee dignity. When organizations pay more attention to providing resources that facilitate employee resilience instead of demanding resilience of its employee, employees feel supported and respected—which can help activate resilience processes at both individual and group levels.

Wagner-Kinyon (2018) examined hotel employees' everyday accomplishments of resilience labor in the face of an ongoing multifaceted organizational change. Interviews revealed participants enacted three resilience practices: (a) banding together to engage in collective sensemaking and protect one another from negative influences; (b) seeking to obtain a sense of autonomy, integrity, and flexibility; and (c) creatively navigating the organizational structures to move forward in an ambiguous or difficult situation. These resilience practices enabled employees to adapt to the changes and everyday challenges at work. At the same time, they perpetuated the neoliberal logic underlying resilience; that is, engaging in resilience labor is considered employees' responsibility and organizations reward/punish employees based on how well they adhere to an organization's prescribed "resilience." Such logic is problematic, as it evades an organization's responsibility to facilitate employee' resilience processes. The author calls for proactive organizational efforts to facilitate employee resilience by setting up communication venues for frequent open communication to discuss the

vision and practical concerns of change. Organizational leaders can also be more proactive in communicating the visions of change and listen to employees to capture their knowledge and the transformative power of employees' alternative practices during change. Overall, the study illustrated the need for organizations to truly acknowledge and honor employee experience and expertise, and use that as a base to design material and communicative infrastructures that enhance employee resilience during times of challenge.

Implications and Future Research

In summary, we synthesized literature on four design processes, dissent-welcoming culture, care and justice leadership, mentoring relationships, and resilience-cultivating programs to constitute positive employee communication. These communicative processes value situated and embodied knowledge of employees in organizational policy and procedure creation, embrace relationality in building inclusive organization and team cultures, uphold ethics of care and justice in everyday leadership practices, and honor human dignity throughout the job and organizational design.

We end the chapter by offering a set of suggestions for organizations and leaders to continue responding to the design challenge of building positive environment for employee communication from an organizational communication perspective. First, design is human-centered. The four design processes to positive employee communication we discussed in the chapter can look different in different organizational settings, but they all need to center employees' voices, well-being, relationships, and dignity. When employees feel heard, respected, valued, cared for, and part of a larger community, positive communication can be enacted and sustained. Second, designers also need to be committed and highly reflexive in the process of designing such communicative processes. Commitment from the organizational stakeholders and decision makers are important to ensure long-term investment and strategic planning and to nurture positive employee communication. Third, design is not done in one try; it requires constant feedback and modifications. Therefore, leaders need to be reflexive and seek honest feedback to inform the next design iterations. Finally, design is holistic. All design processes we discussed are interconnected with one another and can be implemented at interpersonal, group, and organizational levels. Leaders committed to positive employee communication need to

consider these interconnections and leverage organizational momentum to cultivate employee dissent, leadership, mentoring relationships, and resilience performances.

We call for scholars to continue examination of various processes that contribute to positive employee communication in a variety of organizational settings. While current research often focuses on employee actions and individual strategies, organizational communication research can focus on structure, culture, and policy design and implementation. Research methods such as longitudinal case study and organizational ethnography can capture how such changes are carried out in specific contexts, as well as evolutions of such programs or structural changes at individual, group, and organizational levels. Another fruitful line of research would be to explore the dark side of organizational communication, including processes that block, constrain, and toxicate positive employee communication. This focus on the dark side can explicate the complexity, tensions, and negotiations that are required to realize the positive potential of these organizational processes. We also call for research and theorizing efforts grounded in non-U.S. Euro organizational settings, as well as theorizing that taps into local knowledge from a variety of organizations, such as non-profits and more fluid organizing forms. Theoretical and practical insights gained from non-Western, non-corporate settings can generate new logics for designing positive employee communication.

Note

1. We reviewed relevant content in the handbooks of organizational communication and other influential edited books such as *Destructive Organizational Communication: Processes, Consequences, and Constructive ways of Organizing*, and *Movement in Organizational Communication Research: Current Issues and Future Directions*. We also searched and reviewed relevant articles in flagship organizational communication journals such as *Management Communication Quarterly*. The articles selected in this chapter reflect key theorizing efforts on these topics from an organizational communication perspective. In our synthesis, the goal is not to do a comprehensive review of empirical articles on these topics, but rather to showcase key ideas that have been developed about how organizational communication scholars,

guided by a critical design lens, have theorized/conceptualized positive employee communication.

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25

EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION AND WELL-BEING

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The COVID-19 pandemic has dramatically transformed organizational operations. To mitigate the spread of the virus and protect employees' health, a novel working mode—work from home—has been widely adopted, vastly changing employees' work and life dynamics (Deutrom et al., 2022). This sudden shift occurred without adequate organizational preparation or employee training, leaving many employees in a no-choice situation and increasing their pressure to balance professional responsibilities and personal life (Michinov et al., 2022). Scholars have pointed out that work-from-home employees often experience negative psychological states, including feelings of isolation, uncertainty, and overwhelm (Kaufman & Taniguchi, 2021). In the United States, a significant number of employees have articulated that they have experienced depression and anxiety more frequently than in any other period in their career (Epperson, 2021).

As a result, ensuring employee health and well-being became a critical focus for organizations. Affective well-being, which refers to an individual's level of pleasure, concentration, engagement, and energy (Watson et al., 1988), has gained attention across disciplines because it not only predicts positive mental states but also enhances job performance by increasing productivity, improving job satisfaction, and easing work-related stress (Wright & Cropanzano, 2004). Effective employee communication is crucial in improving employees' affective well-being at work, especially during organizational crises (Lee, 2022). Additionally, coping strategies—cognitive and behavioral approaches to managing challenges—were highlighted by public relations scholars and found to be nurtured by effective communication strategies (Li, Lee, et al., 2021). Therefore, this chapter explores how transparent communication, as a strategic approach to employee communication, affects employees' affective well-being while working from

home during the pandemic turbulence/crisis by discussing various types of coping strategies.

Employee Well-being

Well-being is a multi-dimensional construct; it can be understood as one's overall satisfaction with life or contentment in specific domains (e.g., job-related) (Hosie & Sevastos, 2010). From the perspective of employees, well-being can be assessed by considering both positive and negative affect, along with their cognitive evaluations of job satisfaction (Cotton & Hart, 2003).

When discussing the well-being of employees within the workplace, scholars have highlighted the concept of affective well-being, which refers to a state of mind that includes the balance between positive and negative affect experienced by employees at work (Schimmack & Diener, 1997). The average levels of positive and negative affect are uncorrelated and suppress each other: when an individual feels more often and intensely about one type, they would feel less intense about another (Diener, 1984). In general, positive affective represents a state of "high energy, full concentration and pleasurable engagement", whereas negative affect is manifested by "subjective distress and unpleasurable engagement that subsumes a variety of aversive mood states, including anger, contempt, disgust, guilt, fear, and nervousness" (Watson et al., 1988, p. 1063). Warr (1990) described the measurement of context-free affective well-being on a feeling and emotional focus, which includes axes of displeased–pleased, anxious–contended, and depressed–enthusiastic. While a large number of measures of affective well-being have been developed over the past decades, Daniels (2000) articulated that job-related affective well-being most highlights the degree of employees feeling pleased. Warr (2007) has further worked on job-related affective well-being, suggesting *pleasure* and *activation* as two primary dimensions.

Drawing upon Warr's (2007) work, van Horn et al. (2004) have illustrated affective well-being through a lens of emotional, cognitive, and behavioral perspectives: emotional exhaustion, job satisfaction, and organizational commitment. Emotional exhaustion highlighted a feeling/emotional aspect, aligning with Warr's (1990) depressed–enthusiastic spectrum. Both job satisfaction and commitment are linked to the displeasure–pleasure axes. However, job satisfaction reflects a behavioral and cognitive essence, while organizational commitment involves employees' identification with and intentions of engaging in their workplace. Furthermore, Mäkikangas et al. (2016) have systematically reported the long-term development of employee well-being, emphasizing that employees' positive affective well-being can be manifested in the states of work engagement and job satisfaction, whereas the job-related negative affect includes workaholism (i.e., a highly activated

working status but displeased) and burnout (i.e., deactivated and displeased in a job role; a form of exhaustion).

Working from home during the pandemic may threaten employees' affective well-being. First, employees should comply with this mandatory working mode without considering personal preferences and job nature (Michinov et al., 2022). Moreover, the physical separation of employees from their organization may result in employees' negative state of mind toward their jobs. For instance, they may feel isolated when they can only communicate with their supervisors and colleagues via the Internet (Galanti et al., 2021); they may also feel worried and burned out because of the shift in work arrangements (Rodríguez-López et al., 2021). Therefore, while working from home brings several benefits to employees, such as facilitating work flexibility, time-saving, and protecting employees' physical health from the virus, it may generate negative personal psychological states, such as burnout, loneliness, and depression at work (Michinov et al., 2022).

Following the existing scholarly work, we conceptualize work-from-home employees' positive affect well-being during the pandemic as an activated and pleased inner state that can be represented by job satisfaction, commitment, and engagement.

Transparent Communication

Transparent communication, an excellent communication strategy in public relations, has been deemed as a fundamental element of nurturing trust and credibility within an organization (Men & Bowen, 2017). Balkin (1999) identified three analytically distinct constructions of transparent communication: informational substantiality, participation, and accountability. *Informational substantiality* (i.e., disclosure) refers to the extent of the truthfulness and substantial completeness of the information that an organization provides to its audiences (Rawlins, 2008a). *Participation* denotes an organization's involvement in understanding and identifying its employees' needs for making accurate decisions (Men, 2014). *Accountability* indicates an organization's openness to public judgment and evaluation of its words, actions, and decisions (Rawlins, 2008b). With the rise of transparency in organizations, a growing body of literature has highlighted its role in ethical communication (Kim, 2018) and emphasized its benefits, such as enhanced employee engagement (Jiang & Men, 2017), increased trust (Zainab et al., 2021), and improved corporate reputation (Van Riel & Fombrun, 2007).

Transparent communication within an organization may help nurture employees' affective well-being, especially in the working-from-home environment. As mentioned earlier, affective well-being is a pleasant and activated state at work, represented by job satisfaction, commitment, and engagement. Extant literature widely demonstrated that a favorable work

environment produced by leaders/supervisors would bring pleasant influences on employees. For example, studies showed that the leaders' supportive and empowering behaviors can reduce employees' work-related stress and promote their well-being (e.g., Wu & Chen, 2023). Specifically, the open and genuine communicative behaviors of leaders may enhance employees' perceived emotional support, thereby improving their well-being (Aycan & Eskin, 2005).

Organizational transparent communication aligns with the prerequisites for forming positive employee well-being mentioned above. First, trustworthiness/credibility is crucial in transparent communication as it requires both truthful and useful information to be given to the audience (Rawlins, 2008b). Second, the genuine, supportive, and empowering manner of leaders shows respectful organizational characteristics/environment, which is a core component of participative transparent communication: when an organization seeks feedback from employees to identify the information that they need, it is showing its respect to the employees (Thelen & Formanchuk, 2022). Third, accountability in a favorable organizational culture is one of the dimensions of transparent communication (Balkin, 1999). In addition, internal public relations scholars have repeatedly demonstrated the association between transparent communication and employee job satisfaction, commitment, and engagement (Lee & Dong, 2023), which could be manifestations of positive affective well-being. Therefore, work-from-home employees' affective well-being might be nurtured when an organization communicates transparently.

Coping Strategies

Coping refers to a set of cognitive and behavioral efforts to "master, tolerate, or reduce external and internal demands and conflicts among them" (Folkman & Lazarus, 1980, p. 223). It is a dynamic process that spans cognitive, behavioral, and emotional dimensions in individual response, which are inherently contextual and subject to change over time (Duhachek, 2005). Coping, as a source of resilience (Kam et al., 2018), has garnered much scholarly attention across various disciplines, including sociology, anthropology, psychology, and clinical.

Dichotomous Coping Strategies: Problem-Focused and Emotion-Focused Coping

Initially proposed by Lazarus and Folkman (1984), coping can be regarded as a dichotomy classified into problem-focused and emotion-focused strategies. Scholars widely agreed that problem-focused coping mirrors positive adaptations, whereas emotion-focused coping reflects negative adaptations (Wright, 1999). To be more specific, *problem-focused coping* involves actively attempting to reduce stress by modifying or eliminating its sources through

individual behaviors; *emotion-focused coping* focuses on alleviating the emotional distress associated with challenging issues (Lazarus & Folkman, 1984). Examples of problem-focused coping include analyzing stressful situations, developing solutions, and implementing plans to address the situation and its resulting stress. *Emotion-focused coping*, on the other hand, involves maintaining silence, distancing from the threat, denying negative emotions, and disengaging in behaviors (Kassing, 2011). Therefore, problem-focused coping is essentially considered a proactive strategy, whereas emotion-focused coping is considered an avoidance strategy (Hershcovis et al., 2018). Consistently, Latack (1986) has labeled these two approaches as control- and escape-oriented coping strategies, reflecting their proactive and avoidance/escape features.

Multidimensional Coping Strategies

Coping has also been conceptualized from a multidimensional perspective, considering its "highly complex and nuanced nature" (Duhachek, 2005, p. 49). Duhachek (2005) has proposed a systematic conceptualization of coping spanning cognitive, behavioral, and emotional dimensions with eight coping strategies: *action* (i.e., taking actions to directly address stress), *rational thinking* (i.e., preventing subjective emotions from affecting behaviors), *emotional support seeking* (i.e., utilizing social resources to improve one's emotional state), *instrumental support seeking* (i.e., utilizing social resources to take actions to deal with the stressful situation), *positive thinking* (i.e., maintaining a positive outlook on issues), *avoidance* (i.e., physically or psychologically distancing oneself from the issue), *emotional venting* (i.e., recognizing and expressing one's emotions), and *denial coping* (i.e., mentally negating stressors). Among these strategies, cognitive coping includes rational thinking, positive thinking, avoidance, and denial; behavioral coping involves action and instrumental support; emotional coping contains emotional support seeking and emotional venting (Jin, 2009, 2010). Although coping strategies correlated with one's inner state vary in their active and passive levels from a psychological perspective, avoidance and denial are generally considered passive coping strategies. In contrast, strategies such as taking action, engaging in rational thinking, and seeking emotional support are understood to have an active or proactive nature (Duhachek, 2005).

Coping Studies in Public Relations

Public relations scholars have examined coping through both dichotomous and multidimensional perspectives. Against the backdrop of the COVID-19 pandemic, Li, Sun, et al. (2021) have investigated the impact of transparent communication on employees' adoption of problem-focused and emotion-focused coping strategies, aiming to alleviate uncertainty due to organizational

changes. Similarly, Tao et al. (2022) have explored coping strategies, finding that leaders' motivational language and individuals' perceived self-determination influence employees' coping intentions during a crisis. Additionally, Li, Lee, et al. (2021) have delved into coping strategies in the context of workplace gender discrimination, linking them to employees' perceptions of the employee-organization relationship and communicative behaviors.

Meanwhile, public relations research has proven the applicability of Duhachek's (2005) multidimensional scale for evaluating individuals' coping strategies in crisis communication. For example, Jin et al. (2007, 2008) have proposed that individuals facing crisis situations may adopt cognitive and conative (i.e., behavioral) coping strategies, suggesting that people appraise crises differently and employ varied coping strategies to deal with their stressful issues. Jin and Hong (2010) have investigated the interplay between coping strategies to establish a mechanism in the coping model. Specifically, they examined the roles of rational thinking and emotional venting in influencing individuals' intention of instrumental support, thereby motivating their actions during a crisis.

The pandemic-induced shift in working modes suggests that organizations should help employees navigate this unique and stressful situation to maintain positive inner states at work. The following sections aim to discuss how coping strategies may play a significant mediating role between transparent communication and employee well-being.

Transparent Communication and Coping Strategies

Previous research suggests that effective internal communication can serve as a valuable resource in cultivating employees' coping strategies (Li, Sun, et al., 2021). Specifically, when employees perceive a sense of control over situations, they are more inclined to adopt active/proactive coping strategies over passive ones (Jin, 2009, 2010). Moreover, employees who experience psychological satisfaction, such as autonomy in tasks and confidence in their abilities, are more likely to engage in active/proactive coping strategies due to their perceived sense of control (Yeung et al., 2016). Transparent communication, characterized by efforts to provide substantial information, encourage employees' participation, and demonstrate accountability, can foster a sense of belongingness within the organization, enhance employees' perceived control over organizational change situations, and instill confidence in addressing stressful issues; this, in turn, motivates employees to adopt problem-focused coping strategies (Li, Sun, et al., 2021).

From a dichotomous perspective, the emotion-focused strategy, where individuals attempt to avoid and escape from the problem to reduce emotional stress, is more susceptible to communication outcomes than the problem-

focused strategy. For instance, Tao et al. (2022) suggested that employees who feel confident and autonomous due to effective internal communication are inclined to adopt problem-focused strategies rather than emotion-focused ones. Likewise, Li, Sun, et al. (2021) have highlighted that organizations fostering transparent communication with employees during organizational change tend to encourage proactive coping strategies over passive ones.

However, it is crucial to recognize the dynamic nature of strategies, as individuals may respond to different situations by coping with their emotions in diverse ways (Jin, 2009). Arguing the term emotion-focused is "ambiguous and potentially misleading", Baker and Berenbaum (2007) suggested a specific type of emotional-focused strategy: emotional-approach coping, conceptualized it as "actively identifying, processing, and expressing one's emotions, thus providing information about one's goal status" (p. 96). This concept aligns with Duhachek's (2005) multidimensional concept of coping, involving emotional support seeking and emotional venting as active coping strategies. Scholars (e.g., Li, Sun, et al., 2021) have also recognized the limitations of dividing coping strategies in a dichotomous approach and underscored specific coping tactics, emphasizing further explorations of multidimensional coping strategies as communication outcomes.

Transparent communication may also trigger employees' active/proactive coping strategies from a multidimensional perspective. First, the trustworthy and supportive attributes of transparent communication may facilitate employees in processing and expressing emotions as a coping strategy during the pandemic and organizational change (Yue et al., 2019). Moreover, when employees perceive that their organizations genuinely care about their concerns and make efforts to comprehend and identify employees' needs, they are more likely to generate positive psychological responses (Lee & Dong, 2023), which corresponds to cognitive outcomes in coping (e.g., rational thinking and positive thinking). Furthermore, the positive inner states generated by transparent communication, such as feeling empowered, optimistic, and confident at work (Honcoop, 2023), have been proven to motivate employees' actions (Wenzel et al., 2019). Instrumental support seeking and taking actions to address stress as proactive coping strategies may thus be motivated through a transparent and ethical communication approach, as well as positive and empowered psychological states.

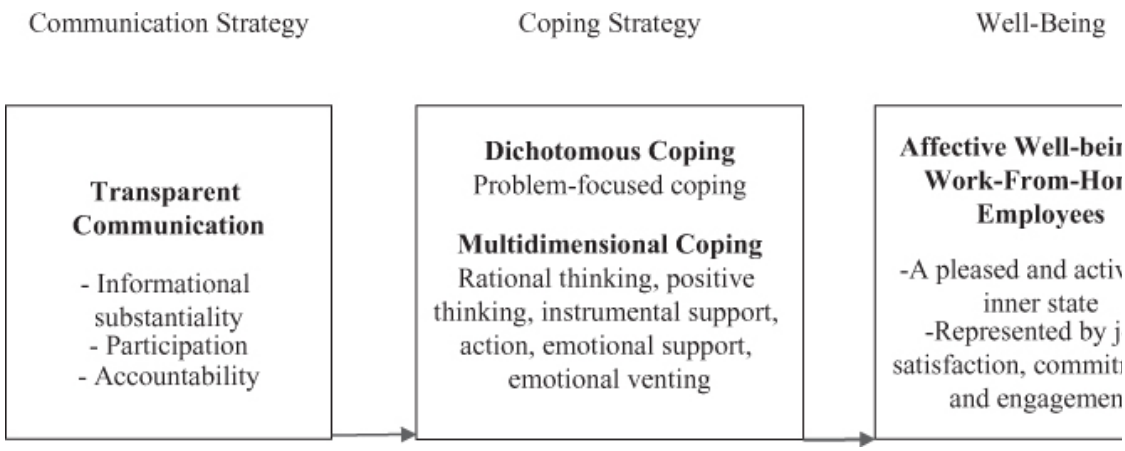
Conversely, organizations lacking transparent communication may instill less certainty and controllability among employees; this impact may be exacerbated during the pandemic due to its unstable, uncertain, and uncontrollable nature (Li, Sun, et al., 2021). As a result, the lack of certainty and controllability may evoke employees' intention to perform passive coping strategies, such as denial and avoidance (Jin, 2010). Therefore, previous literature has shed light on the association between transparent communication and coping strategies: organizations that communicate transparently with

employees working from home are more likely to motivate employees' active/proactive coping strategies encompassing cognitive, emotional, and behavioral aspects, compared to passive coping strategies.

Coping Strategies and Affective Well-being

Furthermore, coping strategies, particularly active/proactive coping tactics, may be positively associated with work-from-home employees' affective well-being. Previous studies have consistently highlighted that problem-focused coping strategy is positively correlated with employee perceptions of organizations and psychological states. This includes feelings of satisfaction and trust in their organizations, heightened engagement at work, and a sense of controllability and reduced certainty (e.g., Li, Lee, et al., 2021; Li, Sun, et al., 2021; Tao et al., 2022). These positive employee sentiments align with the rationale of affective well-being, which emphasizes employees' positive states such as satisfaction, enthusiasm, and pleasure (Mäkikangas et al., 2016).

Moreover, as mentioned earlier, while an emotion-focused coping strategy is generally seen as passive, certain tactics/strategies (e.g., emotional venting) could be perceived as active behavior (Jin, 2009; Jin & Hong, 2010). By expressing negative emotions in this manner, employees may experience a sense of support and engage in meaning-creation, ultimately enhancing their well-being at work (Mikkola, 2019). Mikkola (2019) further distinguished active emotional venting from the types of passive emotional coping strategies, indicating venting is a process of "legitimizing" one's feelings rather than "criticizing or belittling them" (Mikkola, 2019, p. 152). In addition, public relations studies have indicated that employees who actively cope with difficulties tend to develop positive perceptions and behaviors toward their organization, even in challenging situations such as the pandemic crisis (e.g., Tao et al., 2022). Therefore, it is reasonable to state that work-from-home employees who tend to cope with stressful issues through active strategies are more likely to develop affective well-being at work.



▶ Long Description for Figure 15.1

Figure 25.1 An overview of the mechanism linking transparent communication, coping strategies, and employee affective well-being.

In summary, transparent communication may motivate work-from-home employees to adopt active coping strategies to address stressful situations during the pandemic, thereby nurturing affective well-being at work. We propose an integrated framework focusing on coping strategies in bridging internal communication and employees' psychological outcomes as follows.

Theoretical Implications and Suggestions for Practices

This chapter provides insights into how internal communication may nurture employee well-being during a sudden and unplanned crisis (i.e., a pandemic). Specifically, focusing on transparent communication, we highlighted the effectiveness of transparent communication in developing employees' affective well-being at work. In other words, organizational communication that emphasizes disclosing substantial information, addressing employees' information needs, and being open to public evaluation may enhance employee well-being, especially during the turbulent organizational times.

Moreover, the role of coping in linking transparent employee communication with the affective well-being of work-from-home employees should be emphasized. Previous literature (e.g., Li, Sun, et al., 2021) has widely recognized the problem-focused coping strategy as effective for managing work-related stress. In contrast, emotional coping has often been viewed as a passive strategy, generally considered less effective in alleviating negative psychological states. Recognizing the limitations of a dichotomous approach to coping, we further discussed coping tactics through cognitive, behavioral, and emotional dimensions, challenging the notion that an emotion-focused strategy is inherently less effective. Specifically, by discussing emotion-related coping tactics: emotional venting and emotional support seeking, we suggest that they can facilitate the connection between transparent communication and employee affective well-being. Other positive tactics across cognitive and behavioral levels, such as rational thinking, positive thinking, instrumental support, and action, may also play significant roles in this process.

Accordingly, organizational leaders and public relations practitioners should consider transparent communication a crucial corporate communication strategy in a working-from-home setting to cultivate employees' coping intentions and affective well-being. When employees perceive that their organization communicates transparently, they are more likely to express their concerns and feelings, actively plan for and address stressful situations, and thereby foster positive psychological states, both in daily work and during

crises (Men & Stacks, 2014; Yue et al., 2019). Furthermore, executive leaders and public relations practitioners should establish open channels for employees to discuss their negative experiences, issues, or concerns, helping them cope with negative emotions more effectively while working remotely. We also suggest public relations practitioners collaborate with the Human Resources Department to develop employee training programs focused on coping strategies. These programs may introduce various coping mechanisms, provide guidance on implementing coping strategies (e.g., identifying factors that nurture rational thinking and positive thinking in stressful situations), and offer adequate resources to support employees' coping efforts.

Directions for Future Research

Considering the effectiveness of transparent communication as a key internal communication strategy for cultivating employees' affective well-being, future studies may further explore how other types of employee communication at different levels (e.g., leadership communication from CEO, supervisors, and peers) impact employees' well-being in various contexts. Furthermore, future studies may go beyond affective well-being to examine how employee communication influences other types of well-being, such as well-being focusing on life in general. In addition, employees may adopt various coping strategies in terms of cognitive, emotional, and behavioral dimensions to address different stressful issues (Duhachek, 2005). For example, taking action to address personal issues may be more feasible than during a pandemic, as the latter is less controllable. Moreover, there are interconnections among coping tactics; for instance, rational thinking may lead to seeking instrumental support and motivating actions (Jin, 2009). Future studies are encouraged to delve deeper into coping strategies across various contexts and explore the associations among tactics.

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26

ORGANIZATIONAL LISTENING BY EMPLOYERS AND EMPLOYEES

The Communication "Glue" for Organizational Success

Jim Macnamara

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As well as being philosophically described as "the organizing element of human life" (Littlejohn & Foss, 2008, p. 4) and the basis of human society (Carey, 2009), communication has been referred to in academic and professional literature in a practical context as the "glue" that holds organizations as well as groups, teams, communities, and societies together (Maneerat et al., 2005). The fundamental role of communication in organizations is specifically recognized in *CCO theory*, which notes that "communication constitutes organizations" (Schoeneborn et al., 2019, p. 475), also referred to as the *communicative constitution of organizations* (Vásquez & Schoeneborn, 2018).

The focus of this chapter is organizational listening within the context of what is commonly called organizational communication as well as internal communication, employee communication, and employee relations in public relations and corporate communication literature. The single term "organizational communication" is used to collectively refer to these functions and their practices. Many discussions of communication, dialogue, and engagement assume listening is an inherent part of communication. However, recent research has problematized this assumption and raised specific considerations in relation to listening in an organizational context.

Communication and Voice

While recognizing the legitimacy of one-way communication for informing and persuasion in some circumstances, such as advising people of health risks and mobilizing behaviors such as vaccination and safe working practices, literature has long recognized communication as a *two-way* dialogic process (Johannesen, 1971). It is salutary to note that the English term is derived from the Latin root *communis* meaning "common" or "public" and, more specifically, the Latin noun *communicatio*, which denotes "sharing" as well as "imparting" (Peters, 2008, p. 689) and the Latin verb *communicare* meaning to "share or make common" (Cobley, 2008, p. 660). For those who prefer more contemporary references, current dictionaries define communication as "the imparting or *interchange* of thoughts, opinions, or information by speech, writing, or signs" (Dictionary.com, 2023) [emphasis added] and as "a process by which information is *exchanged* between individuals" (Merriam-Webster, 2023) [emphasis added]. Sharing and exchange of information require listening, not only transmission of information and messages.

However, rhetoric with its focus on speaking remains one of the major traditions of human communication scholarship and practice expounded in numerous communication studies texts (Craig & Muller, 2007; Littlejohn et al., 2017). For most of the 20th century and even into the 21st century, human communication has been widely studied as *speech* communication, particularly in North America (Cohen, 1994). Much contemporary research continues to focus on voice (Couldry, 2010), speaking, and "speaking up" (Crawford, 2009, p. 526). In his classic text, *Communication as Culture*, James Carey observed that "the transmission view of communication is the commonest in our culture" (Carey, 2009, p. 12) and contemporary texts on communication criticize a continuing "dominance of a transmission (sender-receiver) model of communication" (Craig & Muller, 2007, p. 1). Fiumara (1995) lamented that listening has often been "a secondary issue" in studying and practicing communication (p. 6).

Noted communication studies scholar Robert Craig succinctly defines communication as "talking and listening" (2006, p. 39). In discussing voice, Couldry described it as "the implicitly linked practices of speaking and listening" (Couldry, 2009, p. 580). However, recent studies have challenged implicit recognition of listening and argued that listening needs to be made explicit including in organizational communication (Macnamara, 2019). Explicating listening in organizations requires embedding listening in organizational processes, which in turn influences organizational processes in a reciprocal relationship, as discussed in following sections of this chapter.

To implement these processes effectively, it is necessary to understand what constitutes listening. While that might seem obvious, many conflate hearing with listening and some harbor fear that listening requires agreement, consensus, or even acquiescence. If too much is expected of listening, the process is bound to fall short. On the other hand, it is important to recognize

that, as well as non-listening, there are many forms of fake listening such as *pretend* listening (Bussie (2011, p. 31), *pseudolistening* (Adler & Rodman, 2011, p. 136), and *cataphatic* listening that assigns speakers and what they say into categories, often pejoratively such as "naïve" or "complainer" (Waks, 2010, p. 2749). At least 35 types of listening have been identified in research literature. Commonly discussed types are listed in Table 26.1.

Table 26.1 Common types of listening discussed in research literature

Type	***Description***
Attentive	A focused form of listening incorporating empathy, acceptance, congruence, and concreteness (i.e., focussing on specifics)
Inattentive	Not paying attention to what others say (see also "Interruptive" and "pretend" listening
Active	Similar to attentive listening, but includes verification (e.g., repeating back what is heard to confirm fidelity)
Inactive	Listening that may hear and understand others, but gives no verification or feedback (i.e., silent and unresponsive)
Empathetic	Paying attention to another with empathy (i.e., emotional identification, compassion, feeling, and insight)
Compassionate	The listener sets aside all thoughts, judgements and feelings and simply offers "hospitality to another's pain" or viewpoints
Therapeutic	Practiced in professional fields such as psychotherapy and counselling. Often is primarily cathartic (i.e., the speaker may feel better as a result of being listened to, but the listener does no more than give attention. Or the listener may give professional advice
Mindful	Attentive, careful listening that is sensitive to the other or others, similar to empathetic
Interruptive	Anticipating what others will say and interrupting, or "tuning out" and thinking about what to say next
Pretend	Mimicking listening in various ways, such as feigned interest when others are speaking (i.e., thinking about what we are going to say next)

Type	*Description*
Pseudo	Pretending to listen; similar to pretend and interruptive listening
Defensive	Takes comments as a personal attack or criticism and focuses on mounting a defense or even counter attack
Monologic	Speaking without listening; effectively a refusal to listen while another speaks (therefore similar to “straight line” listening)
Dialogic	Respectful interplay between speaking and active listening
Transactional	Similar to dialogic, involves speaking and active listening; working things out in discussion
Interactive	Similar to dialogic, involves speaking and active listening
Performative	A relational stance and dialogic performance in which listeners ethically engage in an act of learning from others across difference
Proactive	Voluntarily seeking out opportunities to listen and offering to listen to others
Indirect	Listening via mediation such as research reports, media monitoring, and through delegated listening
Delegated	Listening that is delegated such as to researchers and pollsters, customer relations staff, social media monitors, etc.
Apophatic	Listening in which the listener puts aside predetermined categories and is silent, and open to understand what the speaker says
Cataphatic	Interpretation through assigning what others say into categories often pejoratively

Source: Macnamara (2024).

Interpersonal Listening

For those who seek a succinct definition, the International Listening Association (ILA) established an expert working party to a produce a

definition of listening in 1995 as follows: "Listening is the process of receiving, constructing meaning from, and responding to spoken or non-verbal messages" (International Listening Association, 1995, p. 4). While drawing attention to some key principles such as constructing meaning from and responding, psychological, therapeutic, ethics, political science, and the large body of interpersonal communication literature identify some additional important elements. These have been summarized as "seven canons of listening" (Macnamara, 2016, pp. 41–43) as follows:

1. *Recognition* of others as having a right to speak and be treated with respect (Bickford, 1996; Honneth, 2007; Husband, 2009);
2. *Acknowledgement* of others' views and expressions of voice, the importance of which has been highlighted in reviews such as those of the MIT Collaboratorium (Klein, 2007);
3. Paying *attention* to others (Bickford, 1996; Honneth, 2007; Husband, 2009, p. 441);
4. *Interpreting* what others say receptively and empathetically (Husband, 2000; ILA, 1995, p. 4);
5. *Understanding* others' views, perspectives, and feelings as far as possible (Bodie & Crick, 2014; Husband, 2000);
6. *Considering* what others say (Honneth, 2007; Husband, 2009); and
7. *Responding* in an appropriate way (Lundsteen, 1979; Purdy & Borisoff, 1997). Responding *per se* is often not enough, as response could be blunt rejection. Scholars agree that "appropriate" does not necessarily mean agreement or acceptance of what is said or requested, but research shows that demonstration of consideration and an explanation is required in cases of non-agreement.

It is clear from these elements that listening is distinctly different to hearing. Individual human hearing involves signals in the form of sound waves striking the human eardrum (the *tympanic membrane*). Listening occurs only when these signals are interpreted in the auditory cortex located in the temporal lobe the brain and result in some cognitive, affective or behavioral response. In short, listening involves processing of what is heard and some response as noted above. Listening in an organizational context embodies these distinctions and some additional factors.

Organizational Listening

Interpersonal listening is important in organizations as part of communication between managers and employees and between employees, as noted in CCO theory and a large body of human resources (HR) literature. However, as

identified in The Organizational Listening Project (Macnamara, 2016, 2019, 2020, 2024), three characteristics of listening in and by organizations bring added requirements and responsibilities.

Scale

Whereas interpersonal communication requires listening in dyads (two people) or small to medium-size groups, organizations are commonly expected to listen to thousands or even hundreds of thousands of employees as well as customers, members, and other stakeholders. Governments commonly need to listen to millions of people. As Dobson notes, organizations face the challenge of "scaling up" capabilities for listening (2014, pp. 75, 124).

Delegated

Because of scale, listening in organizations is largely delegated. Internal listening is delegated to functions such as research or HR departments, internal social media platforms, as well as external research or management agencies, while external listening is delegated to social and market research; customer relations; complaints departments; stakeholder engagement teams; social media monitoring staff or agencies, and public consultation teams.

Mediated

A third related characteristic of organizational listening is that it is mostly mediated. While not underplaying the importance of interpersonal communication including face-to-face interaction, organizational listening by both employers and employees has to be applied to internal emails, written documents such as plans and reports, organization website content, presentations at events, internal social media posts, publications such as newsletters, responses in employee surveys, and staff suggestions.

Also, organizational listening on the part of employers and employees needs to be applied to external communication such as customer feedback in surveys, social and market research, media reports, and public social media posts. These reflect the voices of external stakeholders to whom the organization needs to listen as part of its stakeholder engagement and organization–public relations and which, in turn, inform and influence processes with an organization.

A number of studies have focussed attention on organizational listening to the "voice of consumers" such as those of Brandt who notes that while organizations collect large amounts of data from and about their customers and consumers generally, they often fall short in analyzing and responding to what they receive (Brandt, 2020). Other studies have addressed organizational listening to the "voice of stakeholders" broadly (Macnamara, 2020). With

recognition of employees as among organizations' most important stakeholders, studies have also focussed on the voice of employees (VOE).

The Voice of Employees

It should go without saying that employees should listen to their employers represented by managers and supervisors. The VOE has received significant attention in management studies and is a particular focus in HR management as well as organizational communication and public relations.

Research increasingly shows that the VOE contributes substantial benefits for organizations. For example, studies show that employee voice is directly connected to organizational engagement, satisfaction, loyalty, retention, and productivity (Bashshur, 2015; Ruck et al., 2017). The Society for Human Resource Management (2023) says "listening to employee issues and concerns builds loyalty and drives improved productivity". Also, a recent study reported that "employees' upward expression of challenging but constructive concerns or ideas on work-related issues can play a critical role in improving organizational effectiveness" (Ruck et al., 2017).

The 2020 Gallup Q^{12} employment engagement study that examined 112,000 work units involving a total of 2.7 million employees in 276 organizations in 96 countries reported that employee engagement is significantly connected to 11 key areas of organizational performance. These include reduced absenteeism; reduced staff turnover; reduced safety incidents; reduced quality defects; and increased productivity, customer loyalty, engagement, and profitability (Harter et al., 2020; Sorensen, 2023). Meaningful employee engagement requires listening.

Empirical research conducted as part of The Organizational Listening Project supports these studies and claims. For example, increased organizational listening in Achmea group companies in Europe including insurance giant Interamerican in Greece increased employee satisfaction and reduced staff turnover to less than 1.5% (Macnamara, 2020, 2024). A flow-on benefit of increased employee loyalty and retention is reduced costs of recruitment and training. An Imagine Innovation Program established by Interamerican, which involved an online platform for employee ideas with prizes and recognition for winners, resulted in a number of successful new products based on employee input.

The qualifier and condition for achieving these benefits is that there needs to be effective organizational listening as well as expressions of voice (speaking). Appropriately, a number of researchers have now turned attention to organizational listening.

Theoretical Implications

The growing body of research on organizational listening offers a significant contribution to theory in organizational communication and public relations, as well as its closely related practices such as corporate and government communication.

As noted by Deetz (2001) and in CCO theory, organizations are formed and maintained through communication. Organizational listening theory ensures that organizations are more than the voices of their founders, leaders, and marketers by facilitating relationships, collaboration, co-design, and co-production, realizing the benefits identified from listening to the voices employees as well as customers and other stakeholders. Organizational listening theory also expands major approaches to organizational communication such as those identified by Shockley-Zalabak including the *human relations* approach, the *systems-interaction* approach that focusses on how "people, technologies, and environments integrate to influence goal-directed behaviour" (Shockley-Zalabak, 1994, p. 5), and *interpretative-symbolic-culture* and *meaning-centered* approaches (Shockley-Zalabak, 2015) that identify how organizational behavior is shaped by meaning-making among organization members. Despite the breadth of research into organizational communication, most focus is on interpersonal communication and interpersonal listening to which the scaled, delegated, mediated approaches of organizational listening can add scope and inclusivity.

In a summary of paradigm shifts in public relations theory, Taylor and Kent (2023) noted an evolution from Excellence theory (Grunig et al., 2002) to *dialogic public relations* and *engagement* as well as *network theory* that reflects influences such as globalization and technological developments. Drawing on the seminal work of Buber (1958), Bakhtin (1981, 1986), and others, Taylor and Kent have written extensively on a dialogic approach in public relations (Kent & Taylor, 2002; Taylor & Kent, 2014). They call for more than dialogue in the sense of two or more people speaking to advocate a *dialogic* approach, which they describe as a philosophical stance oriented to open interactive communication in which the views and interests of others are recognized and respected. Elsewhere, Lane and Kent (2018) refer to dialogue as "an *orientation* in which participants display positive attitudes to each other and the process of communication in which they are involved" as well as "a highly specific form of two-way communication that is generated out of that orientation" (p. 63) [emphasis added]. But this broad philosophical conceptualization is as far as most discussion of listening goes in public relations literature. For instance, in a detailed review of the interconnected concepts of dialogue and engagement, Lane and Kent mention listening only once, briefly stating "take time to listen, to reflect, and to respond" (2018, p. 65). In discussing the use of social media, Kent and Taylor (2016) go a little further in noting that "the capacity of social media … for listening and to bring images, videos, audio, access to information, genuine relationship building

potential, and a host of other possibilities to organization–public interactions has barely been scratched" (p. 63). They call for organizational leaders to be trained in dialogue and be "willing to listen to the actual voices of stakeholders and publics" (p. 66). However, this does not necessarily progress thinking beyond interpersonal listening to identify how listening to stakeholders might be accomplished in the context of delegated, mediated organizational listening at scale. Organizational listening as it is described in a growing number of studies provides an important contribution to evolving public relations theory.

Organizational Listening in Practice

When organizations identify a need to listen, or listen better, a common strategy is to seek out a technology as a "silver bullet" or make a grand gesture such as a "listening tour". However, a key finding of The Organizational Listening Project was that organizations with the most advanced communication technologies were often among the worst listeners and organizations with less communication technologies were often among the better listeners. This raised the question of what leads to open inclusive attentive and effective organizational listening?

An architecture of Listening

Analysis showed that the foundation of organizational listening is the *culture* of the organization. An organization's leadership and management must want to listen. The organization needs to recognize that relationships, engagement, and trust necessitate listening as well as speaking. Furthermore, stakeholders including employees very often have something of value to say, as demonstrated in the Interamerican case study undertaken as part of The Organizational Listening Project.

Organizational culture also needs to address the *politics of listening* in which some people are listened to while others are ignored. Many organizations are prone to selective listening, which leads to skewed understanding of opinion and views and denies organizations potentially valuable input and feedback.

Once an organization has a culture of listening that is open and inclusive, organizational listening at scale including through delegated departments and units monitoring mediated forms of voice requires *policies* and *systems* for listening. These can be enabled and enhanced by assistive technologies that, in turn, require allocation of *resources* such as staff with the necessary *skills* to use the tools available.

Assistive technologies and tools for large-scale organizational listening to mediated voice include:

- Content analysis of social media, often referred to as *social listening*. It needs to be noted, however, that social media content is not a representative sample of viewpoints;
- Surveys and interviews, which can be conducted using online platforms;
- Machine learning textual analysis applications, which are particularly important given that people express themselves in words, not numbers, such as in emails, letters, complaints, open-ended comments in surveys and interviews, and submissions to consultations;
- Voice to text software that can translate recorded voice calls to call centers and help lines into text for analysis using textual analysis applications;
- Inclusive in-depth qualitative research methods such as participatory action research that involves collaboration and co-design, appreciative inquiry, and interpretative phenomenological analysis.

The use of assistive technologies for large-scale listening takes organizations into the world of natural language processing using machine learning, algorithms, and increasingly advanced artificial intelligence (AI) applications and advanced data analytics. This is particularly necessary in very large organizations such as multinational corporations and national government departments and agencies that can receive hundreds of thousands or even millions of messages in various forms. These technologies bring risks of unwanted surveillance and invasion of privacy through data collection and analysis. Critical scholars express concern about digital surveillance and the effects of algorithms such as *algorithmic filtering* (Caplan, 2018; Gillespie, 2018). As Caplan says, in many if not most online platforms, algorithms decide "the inclusion or exclusion of information" (Caplan, 2018, p. 564). Algorithms also can lead to *filter bubbles*—recipients of information receiving only what they are disposed to receive or what others decide they should receive, also referred to as *echo chambers*. Algorithms are also known to lead to errors when the data used in calculations is out of date or incomplete.

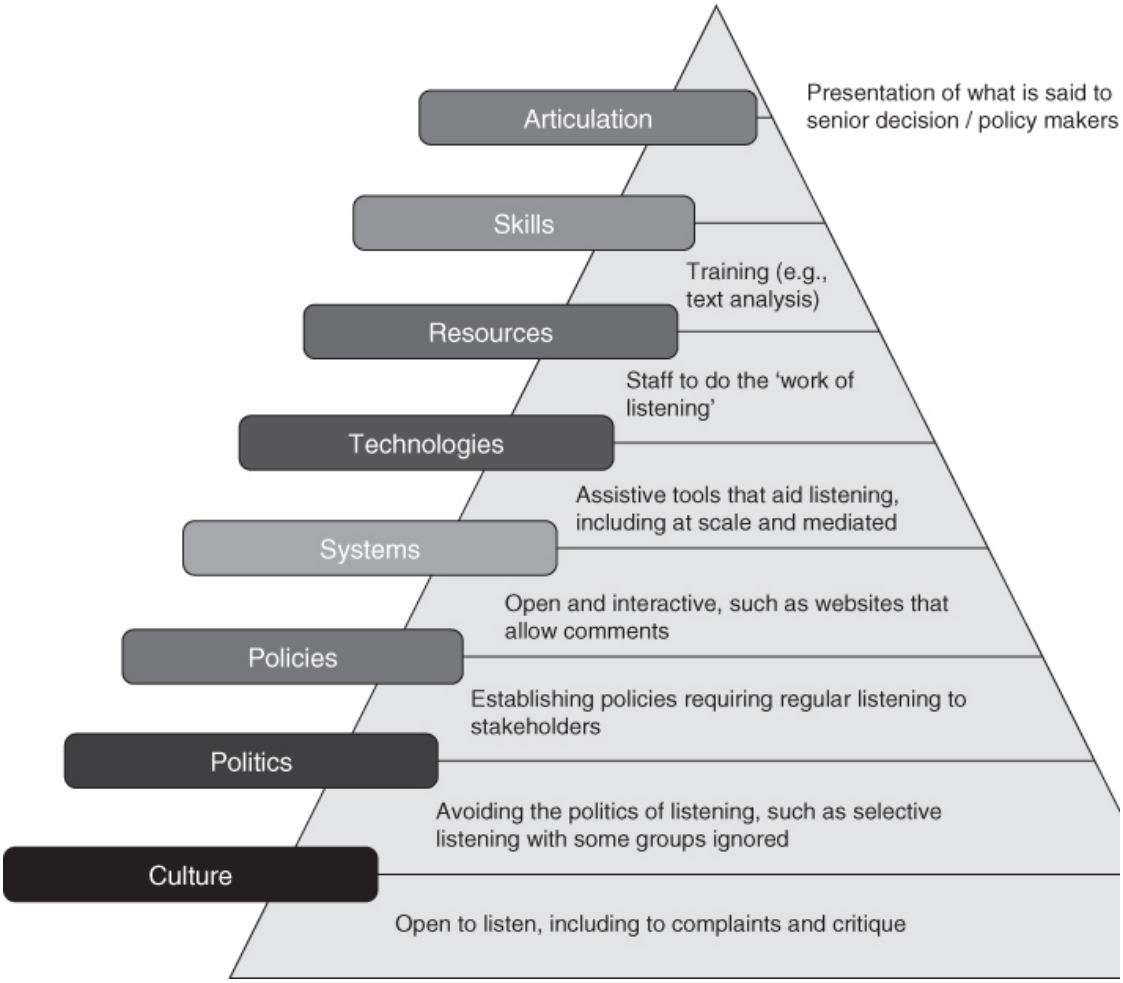
Operationalizing an *architecture of listening* involving listening systems requires close attention to the integrity of data collected and ethics in how information is used. Exploitive and manipulative uses of employees' or other stakeholders' information, feedback, and comments are not what is proposed in advocating organizational listening. Ethics is also a consideration in relation to organizational listening in the sense that *not* listening to others can be considered unethical in some circumstances.

Systems for scaled, delegated, mediated organizational listening do not replace face-to-face meetings, conferences, and "town halls", which remain important methods for organizational listening. They extend interpersonal listening to cope with scale, delegation, and mediation. Improved

organizational listening in government, corporations, non-government organizations, non-profit groups, and major institutions will address a "crisis of listening" that has been identified in research (Macnamara, 2024) and help redress the "crisis of trust" that plagues many societies (Garland, 2021).

Whichever methods of organizational listening are used, the final important stage is *articulation* of what is received and processed to decision makers and policy makers. Unless this occurs through reports and presentations that are received and acted on, many individuals and groups in society remain the "unlistened to" and the "insufficiently listened to".

These eight elements illustrated in Figure 26.1—culture, politics, policies, systems, technologies, resources, skills, and articulation—are collectively referred to as an *architecture of listening* because they need to be reflected in the design of an organization and deployed in a coherent complementary way. They cannot be simply "tacked on" to an organization like fake facades on a building. Ad hoc application of one or a few elements will not achieve effective ethical organizational listening. On the other hand, proposing an *architecture of listening* to facilitate large-scale organization–public communication is not intended to be prescriptive or suggest a single solution. The overall framework of an *architecture of listening* not only leaves room for, but also encourages customization, innovation, and creativity. Like built architecture, there can be many forms and styles and infinitely varying scales. Furthermore, it is not only about creating structures, but also about creating spaces that are welcoming and inclusive in which people can interact with and within organizations in mutually beneficial ways.



▶ Long Description for Figure 26.1

Figure 26.1 The elements of an *architecture of listening* for organizations (Macnamara, 2016, 2019).

An architecture of listening counterbalances the brutalist "architecture of speaking" that has shaped communication by organizations, particularly since the era of broadcasting and mass media advertising and publicity informed by mass communication theory, *press agentry* and *public information* models of public relations (Grunig & Hunt, 1984), and Modernist experts-know-best approaches in organizational communication.

Organizational Processes

It is self-evident that employer/management communication has significant influence on organization processes. Employers and their representatives in management are appointed and authorized to make decisions in relation to the goals, strategy, finance, and operations of an organization. In these processes, listening by employees is essential. If employees do not listen—in the sense outlined previously rather than simply hearing—employer instigated processes are bound to flounder and fail.

What is less recognized and implemented in practice is that listening by employers can have a major impact on organizational processes—positive or negative. On the positive side, listening openly, actively, and attentively to employees as part of organizational communication can result in new improved processes and systems and even contribute to development of new products and services. Employees have *lived experience* of organizational processes and systems—lived experience being an increasingly recognized source of knowledge in the human sciences.

Furthermore, implementation of an *architecture of listening* itself influences organizational processes by contributing specific policies, systems, and technologies for listening; assigning resources to listening; and developing skills for listening including at scale and through mediated methods.

A final consideration for organizational communication is to note that, far from being a passive period in communication, listening is a communicative act. And not listening is also a communicative act that says a lot to stakeholders.

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27

EMPLOYEES' LIVED EXPERIENCES AND THE CO-CREATIONAL EMPLOYEE ENGAGEMENT APPROACH

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Communication is the root of all organizations (Botan, 2018), and without it and its subsequent meaning, organizations would not exist. An organization is simply an idea without the various stakeholders who represent, support, and uphold the organization. The long-term sustainability of an organization is rooted in a co-creational approach (Botan & Taylor, 2004), which values all members, not just management. Given the recent turbulent years and the lasting repercussions of the COVID-19 pandemic, organizations across the world have faced many setbacks, which forced change, agility, and adaption, especially when it came to the ways in which people communicated. A co-creational approach, rooted in meaning-making, among all internal publics is crucial in this new frontier, where investing in people is how organizations will continue to survive future unsettled times. Therefore, co-creational employee engagement should be a top priority for organizations, and not because it impacts the bottom line, but because it can positively impact the lives of internal audiences.

Public relations scholars understand that the act of communication and its content are inherently rooted in meaning (Heath, 1993). A meaning-making approach understands the complexity of organizational life and sees internal publics as partners in this process instead of a

means to an organizational end (Lemon, 2019a). The practice of public relations has transitioned from being a tool to manage communication and relationships to becoming a co-creational profession that allows organizations and publics to create and coordinate meaning together (Taylor, 2018). When applied to employee engagement, employee experiences transform into non-linear and non-functionalist processes and products that truly capture what it means to both construct and contribute to an organization (Lemon & Palenchar, 2018). A co-creational approach applied to employee engagement is a long-term opportunity for the field of public relations as well as organizational communication (Botan & Taylor, 2004).

The purpose of the following chapter is to advocate for scholars and practitioners to adopt a co-creational approach to employee engagement. By overviewing the co-creational employee engagement strategy, future research and practice can envision how co-creation might play out within the organizational setting. Co-creation recognizes the intrinsic value of all internal publics, which aids in the development of social capital with the consequences affecting organizational solidity and a civil society (Taylor, 2018). Even though the focus is on people and not financial ambitions, the organization will still reap the benefits by meeting its goals. Internal publics as meaning-making partners become the conduit for organizational success.

This chapter begins with an overview of employee engagement as well as the co-creational and functionalistic approaches in public relations. A co-creational employee engagement strategy is provided along with implications for theory and practice. A section for future research concludes the chapter.

Employee Engagement Scholarship in Public Relations

Engagement scholarship in the public relations discipline has a rich history with multiple decades of research. Engagement is defined as "both an orientation that influences interactions and the approach that guides the process of interactions among groups" (Taylor & Kent, 2014, p. 384). Rooted in dialogue, engagement provides a framework for investigating, understanding, and addressing complex issues and problems (Johnston & Taylor, 2018). Within the field of public relations, engagement represents the "interpersonal, organizational, network and community processes that contribute to society" (Taylor, 2018, p. 103). Dialogic engagement facilitates the development of social capital for

both organizations and publics (Taylor & Kent, 2014). Ultimately, "engagement is what it means to be a human, to be a part of a group or organization, to exist in a network and to be a contributing member of society" (Taylor, 2018, p. 103). Of interest to this chapter is to explain the value of understanding how internal publics exist and engage within an organization and how meaning is created through co-creational lived experiences.

Employee engagement is defined "as the harnessing of organization members' selves to their work roles; in engagement people employ and express themselves physically, cognitively, and emotionally during role performances" (Kahn, 1990, p. 694). Employee engagement is different from work engagement or job engagement, and the terms should not be used interchangeably. The psychological conditions that encourage people to express themselves and enact a high level of presence that leads to being fully present, include meaningfulness, safety, and availability; this is the root of employee engagement, which results in quality performance, individual experiences, and productivity (Kahn, 1992). When presence and authenticity are integrated into roles, internal publics contribute to the shared understanding of the organization (Kahn, 1992); in other words, the result is co-creational meaning-making.

The co-creational approach. Shared understanding rooted in meaning-making is the foundation of the co-creational approach. The co-creational approach was first introduced by Botan and Taylor (2004) as the future of the public relations field, with the authors arguing that it has the potential to be the most valuable lens for theory and practice. The co-creational perspective purports that "publics as cocreators of meaning and communication [is] what makes it possible to agree to shared meanings, interpretations, and goals" (Botan & Taylor, 200, p. 652). In this way, audiences are more than a means to an organizational end or goal and become partners in the construction of meaning and are regarded as having intrinsic value (Botan, 2018). Co-creation is focused on understanding and empathizing with another person as a way of creating social capital (Taylor, 2018). This lens is particularly useful for organizations since it sets the precedent that the internal culture values every perspective and inspires all audiences to participate in organizational meaning-making (Botan & Taylor, 2004). Internal communication in all forms is the mechanism for which meaning is co-created among organizational members (Botan, 2018).

The meaning-making, co-creational approach applied to employee engagement is one of public relations' unique contributions to this body

of scholarship. Heath (1993) stated that, "meaning is essential to the study and practice of public relations" (p. 141). Internal publics co-create the environment through communication and its associated meanings, enabling the organization to embrace change and emergent issues, ensuring longevity and sustainability through a willingness to constantly evolve (Botan, 2018). Stagnation is where and when organizations begin to suffer, and relying on the functionalistic, bottom-line approach is a fast way to become stagnant. Co-creation allows organizations to become players, not detractors, in cultivating a civil society that benefits everyone (Taylor, 2018).

The functionalistic approach. The functionalistic perspective is a position that privileges management opinions and is primarily focused on advancing organizational interests (Lane & Kent, 2018). When an organization centers solely on profits, all publics are perceived as resources that need to be managed to meet organizational objectives and goals—this is especially true for internal audiences. Communication then becomes the tool to ensure internal publics are aligned with management perspectives, including the values and goals of the organization (Heide & Simonsson, 2018). In this way, communication becomes a tool to control and command internal publics instead of it being a rich resource to revolutionize the workplace. This approach misses the complexity and dynamic meaning that buttresses much of the employee experience (Jelen-Sanchez, 2017). In addition, when management chooses to use a functionalistic approach, internal publics become minimized, devalued, and disregarded, which negates the fundamental nature of engagement as a process and product that honors human beings and their lived experiences (Lemon & Boman, 2022).

Meaning-making and co-creational research. Recent public relations scholarship has investigated the ways in which meaning-making and the co-creational approach materialize within organizations. For example, Arif et al. (2023) conducted a survey of 530 government employees in Malaysia to investigate the strategic employee attributes that result from internal communication and employee engagement. The research determined that meaningful internal communication positively influenced employees to enact strategic behaviors such as exercising emotional intelligence and contributing to organizational goals. Ji and Hong (2023) also operationalized employee engagement from a co-creational approach to investigate the effect of transparent leadership communication and CEO activism on employee engagement. Survey data from 600 U.S. employees exhibited that transparent leadership

communication is positively associated with the psychological needs of employees. Last, Tao et al. (2022) relied on survey insights from 490 U.S. employees to illustrate that empathetic, meaning-making communication from leaders is crucial to employee engagement during times of crises.

Even with the advancements in scholarship that examine the role of meaning-making as it relates to employee engagement, absent from or minimally represented in the conversation are employees' voices captured using interpretive methods. In addition, the focus is primarily on the function of management and communication associated with this source. This results in the notion that public relations solely prioritizes relationships and communication that primarily sustain the lifecycle of the organization at the managerial level (Hurst & Johnston, 2021). While important, it misses the value of internal meaning-making partners.

Meaning-making applied to employee engagement. The meaning-making process, zones of meaning, developed by Heath (1993) is an ideal tool to understand how meaning manifests in public relations. Specifically, the zones of meaning derive from the rhetorical orientation and demonstrate how meaning is created within organizations (Heath). Burke's (1966) work was the impetus for the zones of meaning, which described that meaning is constructed and communicated though terministic screens. Terministic screens serve as the channels in which people filter and arrange their interpretation of reality. In addition, the terministic screens help people determine the best way to respond to situations based on their interpretations. Once the actions and discourse patterns that emerge from the terministic screens become observable, the zones of meaning are established. Heath stated that "we no longer perceive reality without the intrusion of terministic screens" (1986, p. 85). It is important to note that the zones of meaning are inherently complex since they are not fixed and develop from shared meaning making across and among organizational members. In this way, the zones of meaning transition into becoming both the product and drivers of engagement (Lemon & Palenchar, 2018).

Zones of engagement. Previous scholars attest to the need to investigate and conceptualize employee engagement from multiple dimensions so that the complexities and nuance that bolster organizational life are captured (Dhanesh, 2017; Heide & Simonsson, 2018). In doing so, the numerous, context-based interpretations that are constantly shifting and changing can be brought to the forefront.

The zones of meaning are the foundation of the recently developed zones of engagement (Lemon, 2019b; Lemon & Palenchar, 2018), which serve as a mechanism to better understand how internal publics assign meaning to their engagement experiences. Previous work has identified specific zones to capture the internal publics' lived experiences (e.g., Lemon & Palenchar). However, the number of zones of engagement is numerous, based on context, and ever changing (Lemon & Palenchar), which illustrates how complex the engagement experience is for internal publics. In addition, the zones can be used as interpretive frames to uncover how meaning is constructed (Heath, 1993).

Lemon and Palenchar (2018) used the six zones of engagement as a starting point to illustrate the complexity of the employee engagement experience. In their qualitative interview study, the zones of engagement emerged as interpretive frames from the lived experiences of employees (n = 32) in various organizations and at a variety of different levels. The zones included: (1) employee engagement experiences as occurring from non-work-related experiences at work; (2) employee engagement as freedom in the workplace; (3) employee engagement as going above and beyond roles and responsibilities; (4) employee engagement as occurring when work is a vocational calling; (5) employee engagement as creating value; and (6) connections as building employee engagement experiences. This study demonstrated that meaning emerges from each interpretative frame and is experienced by all internal publics, not just nonmanagement and management employees.

Lemon (2019b) further developed the zones of engagement by investigating how they operate within a single case study. The case study (n = 77) examined the ways in which the zones of engagement emerged within a government contractor located in two different states in the United States. The six previously researched zones of engagement had a unique interplay for the government contractor employees. First, work as a vocation and freedom in the workplace zones were non-existent at that moment in time for the participants in this study since it was beyond the scope of what is currently meaningful for them. Given the constantly changing nature of meaning, this zone could shift in the future. The zone for creating value did emerge but management could do more in this area to communicate the value of the work being done by organizational members. The zone for building connection was further developed at the organizational level (mission) and the interpersonal level (colleagues), where these connections created meaningful engagement experiences. The zone for non-work-related experiences did emerge for the

participants in this study and contributed to how they engaged. The zone for going above and beyond was also present for participants. However, it was most often referred to as discretionary effort or always doing more than what is expected. This had a negative association since most people felt as though such levels of overtime effort would lead to burnout and disengagement. Taken together, the zones of engagement within this unique case demonstrate the complex interchange of how internal publics assign meaning to different engagement experiences.

The zones of engagement are symbolic exchanges that are the root of meaningful experiences. In this way, employee engagement becomes repositioned as a strategic, interactive process that is rooted in symbolic, meaningful interactions (Lemon, 2019b). The zones of engagement should not be planned, prompted, or limited to a single zone since overlap may exist, given the complexity of employee engagement (Lemon & Palenchar, 2018). Here, the process of meaning-making becomes fluid and not stagnant (Saffer, 2016) and can be used to develop a robust, yet nuanced picture of how meaning is created through engagement for internal publics. This approach to studying and examining employee engagement gets beyond survey measures and experiments that simply do not have the capabilities of capturing such depth of nuance. When it comes to studying employee engagement, the goal should be to do so through lived experiences.

The Grand Strategy for Co-creational Employee Engagement

Given the aforementioned history and value of applying the co-creational approach to employee engagement, offering a set of tenets that refine understanding and provide implications for theory and practice are necessary. Building on Botan's (2018) grand strategies for co-creation, this section details the grand strategy for the cultivation of co-creational employee engagement in the workplace. These principles offer all disciplines a way to re-envision employee engagement in a way that values and privileges the employee, who is a person, not an asset to be managed on a balance sheet. These tenets are the foundation for the ethics of care applied to the employee engagement framework, which repositioned employee engagement as an ethical practice that organizations should prioritize (see Lemon & Boman, 2022).

Botan (2018) discussed how the *environment*, *change*, *publics*, *issues*, *research*, *communication*, and *practitioners* impact the grand strategy of

co-creation. When applied to co-creational employee engagement, additional nuance is integrated, where the primary focus is within the organization. To begin, in terms of the *environment*, the organization is subordinate to the environment, which means change is inevitable for all publics. When it comes to co-creational employee engagement, internal publics work together to co-create meaning that is often in response to changes within the internal environment. Management should also be in-tune with the company culture as a way to ensure meaning is created with and among all organizational members.

In terms of c*hange*, the co-creational strategy understands that change is natural, yet mandatory for organizational stability. When applied to employee engagement, change is a crucial asset to maintaining a healthy workplace. Processes and procedures should be living entities that are constantly reviewed and reconsidered based on the experiences of internal publics. This welcomed practice allows organizations to shift away from the old adage: "the reason we do this is because it has always been done this way".

When considering *publics*, the co-creational grand strategy adopts a relational approach that advances the interests and agendas of all publics without privileging one over the other. For co-creational employee engagement, all internal publics are valued, not just management. Internal publics are the reason an organization exists, so they should be prioritized and valued.

The co-creational strategy sees public relations as an issues management practice. *Issues* are opportunities for organizations, where a lack of issues means that an organization is not growing and progressing. Applied to co-creational employee engagement, issues involving internal publics are a natural part of organizational life and can be potential openings for growth. For example, the worldwide COVID-19 pandemic created several issues for organizations that required more agility and flexibility to accommodate the needs and safety of internal publics; for many organizations, this major issue was an opportunity to shift practices that might have become stale.

The *research* component of the co-creational grand strategy assumes that collecting information is ongoing, strategic, and evaluative. All decisions are rooted in research. The same principle applies to co-creational employee engagement. Here, research is conducted internally to assess employees lived experiences with regard to engagement. In addition, internal listening mechanisms for employees to exercise their

voice are crucial to the meaning-making process. It is important that many methods are available for internal publics to provide feedback.

As mentioned above, organizations are the result of *communication* among publics, which is the same approach for the co-creational grand strategy. For co-creational employee engagement, internal communication is the mechanism by which employees create engagement experiences. Both dialogic and formal, strategic internal communication construct employee engagement experiences (Lemon, 2019a). However, dialogue and active listening are crucial to co-creational employee engagement.

The last element of the strategy is to consider the role of the *practitioner*. When it comes to the co-creational strategy, the communication team are experts on all publics. Because they are the experts, they should have a seat at the table and input in all germane strategies. For co-creational employee engagement, the concern and care for internal publics remains the same. The role for promoting and constructing co-creational engagement is not housed under the human resource function, but instead within the communication department since internal communication is at the heart of these experiences. The communication practitioner should still have a seat at the table, providing knowledge and suggestions for management based on the ongoing research of internal publics. Most importantly, personal and professional ethics should be guiding every decision made by the practitioner when it comes to internal publics and co-creational employee engagement.

The proposed grand strategy for co-creational employee engagement provides an actionable outline of how such approach looks in practice. In addition, it complements the zones of engagement as a tool for both researchers and practitioners. The grand strategy serves as a framework to provide evidence for how the co-creational approach can operate within the boundaries of an organization. When utilized, employees feel valued and appreciated, which increases their long-term commitment to the organization.

Implications for Managers and Practitioners

Offering suggestions for how co-creation looks in practice is crucial for organizations to be open and willing to adopt this grand strategy. First, organizations should consider the role of trust within the organization. For people to become meaning-making partners, they have to be willing to express their voice. However, no one will express their voice if a

culture of trust and transparency does not exist. Managers should consider the ways in which they *show* their employees they trust them. For example, if monitoring employees is an option, does management choose not to implement such organizational practices? Deciding not to monitor employees would demonstrate that they are trusted to accomplish assigned work tasks without being micromanaged. Additionally, if employees share feedback that is contrary to management or their practices, how is this received? If it is welcomed, more people will be open to sharing their voice.

Second, when developing organizational goals, all employees need to be part of the brainstorming and planning process. They need to have an investment in the future of the organization and contributing through goal setting can be a useful approach. Town halls, anonymous surveys, and one-on-one meetings should drive goal development and future planning. Creation of spaces for dialogue to occur is key for internal publics to engage with these experiences.

Third, management should commit to an ongoing review of standard operating procedures to see if they fit the current internal publics. All employees should also have a say in these procedures, providing feedback on items that no longer serve the workforce and suggesting ones that could be more beneficial. When adding new procedures, management needs to consider the employee, not the organization first. For example, is the vacation policy one that honors and encourages time away from the office to become rejuvenated? If not, the policy should be reevaluated. In addition, does the company culture value vacation time or are people made to feel guilty when taking time off? If the answer is no, work needs to be done to change the culture.

Fourth, managers should be trained in how to use dialogue to cultivate engagement with internal publics. Dialogue is different than two-way communication, where a message is simply sent and feedback is provided (Lane & Kent, 2018). When engaging in dialogue, "interlocutors treat each other with respect, solicit feedback from others, and, importantly, [are] willing to be changed" (Kent & Lane, 2017, p. 569). In this way, dialogue is "a particular form of repeated, responsive, two-way communication" (Lane & Kent, 2018, p. 69). Kent and Taylor (2002) offered five principles that underpin a communicative exchange rooted in dialogue. The tenets include: *mutuality*, or acknowledging how and when relationships develop in an organization; *propinquity*, or recognizing that communication exchanges are often spontaneous; *empathy*, or supporting and respecting other communicators; *risk*, or

embracing the inherent vulnerability in all relationships; and *commitment*, or investing in the dialogic exchange. A dialogic orientation recognizes the value in all communicative partners and understands that they are meaning-making partners who contribute to and therefore, co-create organizational reality (Taylor & Kent, 2014).

Providing opportunities for dialogue is crucial for meaningful engagement, yet some people are not skilled in this area. Therefore, organizations need to provide leadership training to help people develop this unique skillset. For example, leaders can further develop their dialogic skill set by participating in trainings with the Dialogue Training Academy, the Dialogue Institute, or the Fanning Institute for Leadership Development at the University of Georgia. Although primarily designed for management, the courses and programs provided by these resources would help anyone improve their abilities to engage in dialogue.

Directions for Future Research

The first suggestion for future research is to use qualitative methods to capture of the lived experience of communication practitioners tasked with employee engagement strategies to see if they are relying on a co-creational approach, and if not, how they can begin to shift into adopting it. Given the post-pandemic work environments, future research should also investigate how internal publics create meaning even when working remote some or all of the time. Meaning making can still be accomplished even when spatial distances exist, but what and how that looks needs additional research. Conducting interviews or relying on mixed method approaches, such as surveys and interviews, to capture the experiences of people who work remotely would be useful.

In addition, research into ethical considerations associated with meaning-making should be pursued to ensure organizations are upholding how they treat employees with intrinsic value, which is in line with co-creational employee engagement. Lee and Yue (2020) called for future research to explore ethical issues related to internal communication, employee engagement, and internal stakeholders' well-being. Ethics is essential to any organization and aids in relationship building by ensuring that employees are treated with fairness and the organizational culture is rooted in trust (Men & Bowen, 2017). Therefore, future studies should rely on case studies to conduct an in-depth examination of both ethics and organizational culture. Furthermore, a comparative case study of two or three organizations

would be fruitful in better understanding the ethical considerations related to how employees are treated.

In terms of methods, more autoethnographic and ethnographic studies are warranted to capture the lived experience of employees in real-time, providing deeper insight into how meaning-making manifests for them within their organization. In general, the public relations discipline lacks in-depth investigations using such methods (L'Etang, 2012). Additionally, James (2012) encouraged public relations scholars to utilize autoethnography as a method to capture the rich, yet sometimes "messy" experiences of the practice. Everett and Johnston (2012) also suggested that ethnographic methods are the ideal tool to capture co-creational public relations since this approach can provide a robust investigation into organizational culture. More recently, Lemon and Macklin (2021) called for future research to capture individual engagement experiences overtime via longitudinal autoethnography. This method would allow internal stakeholders to share how their engagement experiences transitioned overtime. In using autoethnographic and ethnographic methods, the complexity and intricacies of co-creational employee engagement would be illustrated.

Conclusion

In conclusion, management should consider how to adopt co-creational employee engagement as part of their organizational culture. Additionally, employee engagement scholars are encouraged to use the ideas presented in this chapter as the foundation for future studies. As a field, it is time to move beyond the functionalistic approach to a more humane, understanding of employee engagement by adopting the co-creation. In doing so, internal publics become valued and treated with the upmost respect in their role of meaning-making partners.

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PART IV

Emerging Trends in Research on Employee Communication and Organizational Processes

28

CONNECTION, OR COMMUNICATING THE PLACE AND PURPOSE OF WORK ON SOCIAL MEDIA

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> Be a partner. That's something Starbucks likes to say… Let me tell you what I feel to be a partner is: sleeping in your car because you couldn't pay rent—this is to be a partner; the queer individual being told they can't be proud of who they are—to be a partner; the worker of color experiencing blatantly casual racism and just has to fake a smile and take it—to be a partner; being told your labour isn't skilled or you aren't good enough; being fired because you wanted to make your workplace better not just for yourself but for everyone coming in—this is what it means to be a partner.
>
> —*@sbworkersunited, TikTok*

That social media have changed how people work and make sense of their work was obvious before they started harnessing the power of these platforms to create change. As the above quotation, drawn from an account for unionizing Starbucks workers, makes vivid, employees harness social media to coordinate and communicate goals, but they often do so with a vision that goes beyond singular workplaces. Simultaneously, the approach to social media in organization, communication, and management research often remains narrow, internalized, and administrative. Although social media transform and

make visible (Treem & Leonardi, 2013) the communicative practices through which people organize, researchers and managers alike often regard social media as interlopers that affects labourers' performance (Cao et al., 2016), productivity (Ma et al., 2024), and/or success in the workplace (Chu, 2020; Zhu et al., 2024). But the disaffected experiences and unionizing efforts of workers organizing via social media carry impactful lessons beyond the platforms through which those messages are shared and beyond the singular contexts of their stories. From Facebook (Bartels et al., 2019) to forums (Gossett & Kilker, 2006), researchers have neglected Orlikowski's (1992) warning against treating social media use in organization as either entirely deterministic and external or strategic and internal. Without discounting the importance of inquiry that puts social media at the forefront of organizational research, we argue that the primacy with which researchers have treated these technological influences stymies the exploration of constitutive and connective force of communication on social media by maintaining an insular and disconnected understanding of employment itself.

The (now relative) recency and (still evolving) novelty of social media in the landscape of management, alongside longstanding contextual and theoretical emphases on corporate forms in organizational scholarship (Cruz & Sodeke, 2021), render researchers' and managers' notions of the relationship understandable albeit limiting. We refer to norms of disconnection to denote how researchers circumscribe peoples' use of social media in terms of place and potential to justify its legitimacy as organizing through separation from non-employment discourse. Put differently, scholars and managers often treat social media use as a thing to be either controlled or commodified, but we argue that the existing conversations and emerging communities on social media offer can be better understood as connections between and transcending the internal or external boundaries of work in ways that show how employees make sense of work. In many ways, primarily referring to people as employees in this research illustrates our central contention: researchers and managers objectify how social media affect people as employees instead of engaging with employees as people when responding to the disruptions of social media and technology. Specifically, we note two counterproductive assumptions embedded in these norms: (1) emphasizing platform effects over organizational agency and (2) reframing communal enactment of resilience as counterinstitutional opposition. To better understand how employees' use of social media affects workplace organization, researchers and managers

must stop thinking only in terms of employees and media or in the context of and for the purposes of work. It is time to consider these social arrangements in the context of the economic and political conversations and stories of which they are always and already a part.

From Marx's call for workers of the world to unite, to Friedman's insistence that profit is the only responsibility of business, work and theorizing about work are and have never been insulated from the contentions and politics and of communities, states, and economies. As the people of @sbworkersunited articulated, workplaces are not removed from the societal concerns of poverty, homophobia, racism, precarity, and change; they are the site and subject of controversy and political conversation. Social media have changed the nature of these conversations, but their more profound effect is to have obviated, made visible, the need to dispense with the pretense that experiences of work can or should remain at work or centered on work. Thus, we argue both managers and researchers must consider how social media have reshaped peoples' sensemaking about work and the world through discursive connection. In this chapter, we explore two areas of discursive connection between peoples' micro-stories of work and the macro-narratives of social organizing, including: (1) digital labor and precarity and (2) online antiwork advocacy. We also examine research that exemplifies how inquiry and management can move beyond norms of disconnection and rethinking assumptions about the nature of organization and organizational research. Across each of these areas, we explore how people qua employees use social media to make sense of their experiences, to connect with others and hear their stories, and to constitute the world of work even as they define and redefine the very boundaries and meanings of employment.

Connecting Place: Digital(izing) Labor

Even before the COVID-19 pandemic, scholars were exploring how precarity in digital labor (Bulut, 2015), gig work (Petriglieri et al., 2019), and media content creation (Gregersen & Ørmen, 2023) were transforming the relationships between companies and those who create, provide, and constitute their services and products. Even as legal battles were, and continue to be, fought to legally classify these relationships as employment, the pandemic necessities of remote and online work further disrupted norms of organizing and place (Leonardi et al., 2024). Place itself is important to organization both legally and managerially. In the

United States the dispersed nature of online work creates a justification under the Right-to-Control test, an English common law standard, to decline employee status and legal protections to workers based on (among other criteria) the necessity of a shared location for work (Malik, 2017). Following this logic, when the common thread of work is digital space instead of physical place, it no longer considered part of the legal or academic domain of employment. Organizational scholars have centered place in long-standing lines of inquiry (e.g., Elsbach, 2003) that gained new urgency with onset of the pandemic (e.g., Myers et al., 2024), but they have also used place-based logics, like the above, to either emphasize platforms effects over organizational agency or to exclude important areas of social media research from organizational inquiry. Thus, in this section, we engage with inquiry on digital labor—defined as work shaped by and involving extensive interaction with online platforms and/or digital devices (Jarrett, 2022)—to reimagine the role of place in research on organizing and social media.

The Right-to-Control standard for employment classification echoes both (a) calls for research on the organization and technology (Orlikowski & Scott, 2008) and (b) normative emphases on platforms and platform effects over managerial choices in research on social media and employment. Urging analysis of "the fusion of technology and work in organizations," Orlikowski and Scott (2008, p. 434) argued that the scarcity of scholarship centering technology derived from a tendency for researchers to consider it "simply part of the institutional infrastructure", what they called "an 'automated plumbing' view of technology" (p. 436; quoting Zammuto et al., 2007, p. 751). Leonardi and Vaast (2017) repeated a similar argument when urging researchers to take up the responsibility to explore social media, specifically in terms of its technological affordances—constraining and enabling organizational actors. Thus, to advance these cases and to justify technology and social media as relevant and worthwhile domains of organizational research, both sets of authors made similar moves to justify these contexts as organizational by emphasizing the sites of interaction most easily homed to a shared place—namely the digital and social media platforms employees use. But to build on Zammuto's metaphor, it is valuable to examine the sites where people and plumbing meet; it is also foolish to ignore the content of those interactions in favor of considering the apparatuses that contain them. Regardless of how far the pipes get from that original site, they are all connected when clogs occur and pipes burst and sewage spews. Without understanding the blockage, knowledge of

the toilet and pipes is only marginally useful for managers with a single metaphorical plunger.

Put more directly, by emphasizing platforms and their effects on employees, scholars and managers sidestep the duty to critically analyze managerial actions in favor of putting the social media sites in the analytic spotlight. For example, recent work has examined the affordances (Ma et al., 2024) and uses and gratifications (Liu & Bakici, 2019) of company-specific, enterprise social media platforms toward infantilizing ends, such as "encourag[ing employees] to join such internal social media communities to experience fun and build emotional capital… [which] lead employees to be more attentive and involved" (p. 13). Although this research has value, both the attitude toward employees and aims of this work illustrate the limitations of platform-foregrounded, communication-and-organization-backgrounded research. Additionally, normative emphases on platform affordances also substantiate a productive paradox and reify the centrality of businesses which either find that social media (a) significantly constrain their ability to respond to wide-ranging and uncontrollable public-criticism (Thompson et al., 2020) or (b) enable such extensive and wide-ranging control it is impossible to manage (Hassard & Morris, 2022). In turn, this type of paradox of enabling and constraining reproduces a desire to focus on platform effects instead of peoples' agency and voice. After all, when managers can do simultaneously nothing and everything, agency is a moot point for people; when managers and scholars ascribe platforms the agency to enable and constrain, people are a moot point for organization and inquiry. Just as digital laborers are displaced and thereby discounted as engaging in organization so, too, the normative emphases on affordances and platform effects displace the centrality of communication and social interaction in organizing and organizational inquiry.

As businesses shift toward digitalization (Leonardi & Treem, 2020) and begin reflecting the displaced, disconnected status quo of digital labor, researchers remain fixated on platforms while paying no attention to the man(ager) behind the curtain. Scholars examining digital labor practices, particularly those outside the frameworks of organization studies, provide a glimpse at the potential impact of this displacement. Duffy and Sawey (2022), using the familiar language of in/visibility, described the tension between platform/brand visibility and individual visibility. They noted that, as brands became more visible, workers and their work became invisible—depersonalized, devalued, delegitimized—

as employees and participants in economic and social life, whose social media labor was simply not a real job because it lacked the shared social and physical space of work. In turn, these types of displacement engender further separation from the realm of legitimate work, and in turn, digital laborers face losing legal employment status, worsening economic precarity, and eroding foundations organizing collective action (Shiffman, 2022). This type of insight, regarding people's micro-stories of work and the macro-narratives of political and economic injustice and transformation, is what justifies the rejection of norms of disconnection.

The lesson for organizational scholars, then, is to look beyond normative places of work and toward displaced digital labor, social media work, and other organizing contexts that are often excluded from research because they do not sufficiently resemble the corporate organizing forms that remain the normative domain of the discipline. Cruz and Sodeke's (2021) urgent remonstration of scholars' continued reliance on Eurocentric theorizing about organizing forms and values clarifies the unjustifiable and damaging implications of these assumptions about the nature of work, place, and the underlying question about employment defined by a right to control. Contemporary scholarship on digital labor, gig work, and social media content creation make few things more apparent than the transition from physical to digital places of control in organizing practices. Pandemic-inspired research on remote work has done the same. The need to reconsider spatial understandings of organization not only fits with the spate of research that emphasizes the communicative construction of organization (Boje, 2001, 2008; Putnam et al., 2008), but also can absolve scholars of the tendency toward self-flagellation and diminution when the contexts we research do not sufficiently resemble the normative Platonic Form organization to which scholars desperately cling. Dispensing with the need to discount the theoretical and practical import, the translational significance, of research that examines social processes of organization outside the workplace by referring to such contexts and theorizing as alternative organizing (e.g., Cruz, 2017; Jarvis & Eddington, 2021) will improve both theoretical development in the field and its impact beyond the academy.

Connecting Purpose: r/antiwork

In the typical manner and style of many online communities, and subreddit forums specifically, the generational criticism presented in the

most upvoted post on r/antiwork in 2023 was blunt. Titled "This is so true….", the post is a simple, three-panel meme with horizontally stacked images and captions. The first picture shows a couple from the early 20th century in formal dress and with a tree in the background; the caption reads: "we will make a better world for our children". The second picture shows a couple from the mid-20th century in formal dress with a yellow background; the caption reads: "we will make a better world for our children". And the final image shows a recent picture of an elderly couple with neon graphs and 100-dollar bills in the background; the caption reads: "fuck you entitled brats". Both the content and the tone of the post reveal much about the philosophy of work debated and celebrated on r/antiwork, a forum with over 2.5 million members which describes itself as "Unemployment for all, not just the rich! A subreddit for those who want to end work, are curious about ending work, … and want personal help with their own job/work-related struggles" (/r/antiwork, n.d.).

Despite the caustically humorous tone of their contributions on the forum, users often seek normalcy amidst work disruptions. These communicative and communal processes of sensemaking allow users to connect their experiences with the social landscape of antiwork advocacy constructed on the forum and offer insight into the alternative purpose of work and organization that many on the forum see as the future of employment and economics. It is also these enactments of communicative resilience, social processes of constructing normalcy following disruption (Buzzanell, 2010, 2018), that norms of disconnection in organizational scholars' approach to social media reframe as acts of counterinstitutional opposition. Thus, in this section, we engage with r/antiwork and its advocacy as a foil for these scholarly norms and to reimagine the role of purpose in understanding employees' use of social media.

Framing r/antiwork or similar social media communities solely as oppositional or counterinstitutional forces contrary to the purpose or existence of organization is a scholarly and managerial misstep embedded in the norms of disconnection. Much like the norm discussed in the previous section, this tendency is as understandable as it is negative for robust inquiry. Prior to the questions of business' legal vulnerabilities, privacy standards, and the establishment of boundaries through company social media policies (Banghart et al., 2018; Jacobson & Tufts, 2013), many researchers outside of organization studies were approaching technology generally and social media specifically with

trepidation or alarm (e.g., Turkle, 2005). So, the introduction of communication technology to the workplace and their eventual rise to ubiquity led scholars to approach these digital tools with skepticism, as a potential threat to the normative practices of work that employers should guard against (e.g., Cohen & Cohen, 2007). In organizational communication specifically, Gossett and Kilker's (2006) examination of online dissent, reinforced this norm by describing the forum Radioshacksucks.com as a counterinstitutional site. By framing their inquiry in terms of the forum's externality and oppositional attitude, Gossett and Kilker characterized employees' use of the site as a potential threat to the company.

Despite the insistence at the conclusion of their work that, "counterinstitutional web sites [sic] provide an outlet for member voice outside the control of the organization" (p. 81), Gossett and Kilker's suggestion that managers would be best served by surveilling those conversations, ostensibly to nip problems in the bud, undermines that interest in serving member voice and transmogrifies members' use of their voice from an enactment of resilience into an oppositional act. In so doing, they argued that the public nature of online forums, like social media, could allow managers to monitor them and then "interven[e] before these individual moments of discontent coalesce into collective acts of open rebellion (strikes, lawsuits, etc.)" (p. 82). To be clear, we do not argue that, through this work, Gossett and Kilker intended to encourage or legitimize the kinds of union-busting tactics and retaliatory acts documented in recent scholarship (e.g., Lazar et al., 2020). Nonetheless, their work demonstrates how even critically-inflected scholarship can reify these norms of disconnection and undermine workers' exercise of voice. Returning to the context of antiwork advocacy illustrates an alternative.

Engaging with radical scholarship about antiwork movements outside the realm of social media illustrates the value of reconnecting conversations about organizational purpose to their political and economic contexts and beyond just their commentary about experiences at work. For example, Sherwin's (2022) exploration of antiwork activism in the Welfare Rights Movement illustrated the necessity moving beyond the context of employment contexts because of its emphasis on the legacy of enslavement. The movement was associated with the National Welfare Rights Organization and led by "Black welfare recipients [advocating] against intrusive caseworkers, unjust benefit cut offs and inhumane sterilizations" (p. 187). Sherwin evoked the movement as

joyous and centered on an argument substantiated by the history of violent dispossession and racially motivated economic subjugation: work does not fix poverty. This antiwork advocacy was built on challenging the purpose of work, questioning evaluative social logics of work ethic, and realizing the "freedom dream of a world with 'no workers'" (p. 203). Given the radical nature of these arguments, Sherwin also documented how this type of advocacy emerged and was maintained through collective acts of strategic concealment and toleration of ambiguity, which advocates described in reflexive comparisons between their organizing and that of their contemporaries like the Black Panther Party. Notably, these are organizational insights; they clarify the strategic and communicative processes through which the movement organized their advocacy. Although this work is as markedly different from contemporary social media research as the Welfare Rights Movement is from r/antiwork, Sherwin explicated the value of centering how advocates questioned the of purpose and values used to justify economic and political context by "highlight[ing] and hom[ing] in on moments of bold, counter hegemonic expansions of imagination and possibility" (p. 200) and "locat[ing] memories that do not conform to the predispositions of the present, that do not serve to legitimate contemporary configurations of power" (Hartman, 2019, as cited in Sherwin, 2022).

Returning to the discursive landscape of advocacy and story on r/antiwork, it is deeply unsurprising that scholars and managers and other onlookers might reframe such sites as threats because of politically radical or tonally crass elements of the community's talk. And researchers and managers must be conscious of the theoretical frameworks that they use to make sense of these contexts, the manner in which they discuss them in scholarly work and, especially, the methods they use to monitor, analyze, and engage with these communities. Social media research is a powerful tool, and people should be concerned about the concentration, privatization, and commodification of data access in research (Gilbert et al., 2023). Both these trends and the threat of surveillance or monitoring threaten to colonize these spaces of voice (Deetz, 1992). Intrusion into these spaces serves neither the interests of researchers, managers, or the workers for whom these spaces are communal enactments of resilience. It is precisely because employees craft these communities to facilitate reimagining of corporate purpose and futures that their voices can "resonate in cyberspace [where] technology has allowed many voices to be connected" (Mitra, 2001, p. 44). Moreover, as much as researchers and managers operating under

these norms of disconnection frame communities like r/antiwork as threats to specific organizations, through the sharing of specific, negative stories, they do so in ways that disconnect those stories from the economic and political contexts through which employers justify the practices the r/antiwork community derogates. These are criticisms built through connected voices, through shared experiences, and through collective sensemaking about work and its purpose. And through these social media connections, radical reimagining becomes possible.

Reconnecting Work

This chapter has examined what we view as the shortcomings of norms of disconnection in organizational and communication research on employees' use of social media. By reconnecting place and re-examining purpose in researchers' and managers' approaches to employees' use of social media, we have argued for the value of moving beyond the context of workplaces and platforms and toward consideration of the social, political, and economic discourse about work. Although this contention does not imply a singular, legitimate path forward for researchers examining social media, organizational and communication scholars are uniquely positioned to explore these connections in ways that those in other disciplines are not. Moreover, practitioners and managers can take these ideas as an impetus for reconsidering their agency in organizing and their respect for employees' voice with the aim of benefiting their colleagues and organization. Additionally, despite endeavoring to offer fair interpretations of the literature, we will have missed examples of excellent scholarship that already move beyond the norms and trends noted herein. But these interpretations are not universal claims about organizational research but a call to engage with theory and organizing in useful ways.

The norms we have examined in this chapter are not universal within organizational and communication scholarship, but they are impactful. To this end, we offer several recommendations for this reconsideration of managers and researchers. First, managers can honor the importance of social media as a connective force by listening without seeking to monopolize or control it within or outside of the workplace. People deserve earnest and genuine consideration of how outside forces affect them at work, and how their work lives affect their sensemaking about societal, political, and economic arrangements. Second, researchers can engage with these arguments to reconceptualize the relationship between

social media and organizational processes both within corporate forms and far more generally. Even as communicative and constitutive frameworks in organization studies become more prominent, scholars are still limiting themselves contextually to the comfortable environs of corporate organizing. Too often, scholars exempt themselves from interrogating those questions and contexts they deem transgressive. Too often, scholars find their work rejected or derided for boldly transgressing these norms. But organization, social media, and especially inquiry about the two thrive on transgression and evolution. For researchers and managers, transgressions will take different forms; nonetheless, as the landscape of social media, employment, technology, and organization shifts and changes, those transgressions and that transformation can serve as the foundation for realizing the broken promise spoken of by @sbworkersunited organizers—communication, connection, and partnership.

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29

NAVIGATING EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION DURING TIMES OF BACKLASH

An Affordance Perspective on Online Organizing

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2020 was a perfect storm of disruption, crisis, and protest, compounded by widespread and intersecting organizing both on- and offline. In March 2020, COVID-19 caused widespread disruptions as work-from-home orders became prevalent across the global workforce (Duffy, 2020). In April, as remote work became a topic of pandemic discourse, workers mobilized around the hashtag #OpenAmericaNow to protest work-from-home orders (Jarvis & Eddington, 2021). Additionally, protests occurred around issues of race in the summer of 2020 as a video detailing the murder of George Floyd by members of the Minneapolis Police Department spread across the Internet (Buchanan et al., 2021). The tumultuous U.S. presidential election further exacerbated the ire and simmering frustrations of 2020.

As leaders and workplaces struggled to understand the impact of these sociocultural phenomena, workers adopted various offline and online strategies to make sense of the ongoing cultural tumult. Whereas most seemed to adopt productive means of responding and adapting to the zeitgeist (see Parker et al., 2022), a growing minority enacted more

problematic and reactionary expressions of sensemaking—particularly in and through online spaces like social networking platforms. A *2022 Pew Research Report* found that roughly 6% of Americans retreated from "traditional social media sites" and engaged in alternative social media (alt-tech) sites (e.g., Truth Social, Parler, Telegram, Gab) that were "a refuge for some who feel they do not have a home on the more established sites" (Stocking et al., 2022, p. 11). Moreover, the report highlighted that these alt-tech platforms were predominantly Republican or right-leaning, cultivating a sense of community for those who sought "antidotes to the censorship and 'cancel culture'" that exists on traditional platforms (Stocking et al., 2022, p. 14). Despite the relatively low percentage of Americans that use these spaces, their existence is another example of reactionary politics and backlash. Given the absence of a perceived "safe space" to voice opinions, these 6% of Americans sought solace in a different form of participatory online space. To situate our chapter within the growing trend of online backlash, we draw from Mansbridge and Shames (2008): "The resistance of those in power to attempt to change the status quo is a 'backlash,' a reaction by a group declining in a felt sense of power (Lipset & Raab, 1978) of the broad sort" (p. 645). This definition is aptly helpful, considering the implicit affective sense of loss and the desire to regain this perceived loss through participation in online communities and participatory spaces (Eddington et al., 2023).

As Sobieraj (2020) described, "Participatory online spaces such as comment sections, blogs, Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube now serve as digital public spheres in the sense that they provide a space for and include the practice of open discussion about matters of common concern" (p. 7). To address how organizations and workplaces have leveraged and used participatory online spaces like social media platforms, Leonardi and Vaast (2017) described the impact of social media and its implications for organizing using an affordance-based perspective. We build from Leonardi and Vaast's (2017) call for further examinations of organizing from an affordance lens by highlighting the emotional and affective states fostered vis-a-vis affordances.

Fueled by resentment and backlash, online participatory spaces are organized through various sociocultural, political, and material means (e.g., anti-wokeness movements, anti-critical race theory and parent's rights mobilizing, and anti-trans legislation). In considering these growing affective states, we argue that understanding how resentment and backlash transcend the online to impact the offline workplace is a

necessary and critical endeavor for leaders and employees in today's workplace, as belonging and inclusion are increasingly valued by workers (Minkin, 2023). In doing so, our chapter advances an affordance-based approach to online organizing. It considers the variety of ways that the features of social media sites enable the spread and impact of backlash and resentment in offline workplaces.

With attention to affordances, our chapter examines the various forms of online organizing and organizations that have impacted workplaces in the post-pandemic landscape. We begin by reviewing how backlash vis-a-vis far-right attitudes, values, and whisper networks are organized on social networking platforms and how these can create problems for offline workplaces. We aim to build a conceptual linkage between affordances and backlash communication to understand how far-right socio-political issues are a product of online organizing processes. First, we highlight examples wherein discussions of antifeminism, "anti-wokeness", and anti-diversity, equity, inclusion, and belonging attitudes and values are virally and affectively leveraged in the organizing of a host of spaces on- and offline (e.g., Eddington et al., 2023; see also Ashcraft, 2022). Next, we take a broad view by focusing on three specific affordances that help sustain the ongoing reactionary communication spread throughout social media and impact everyday workplaces and cultures. They are anonymity, community and connection, and the role of emotion.

Our discussion contends that these recurring online issues are a central problem for workplaces and organizations offline, which have increasingly become sites of political and social justice entanglements. We conclude our chapter by discussing implications for employee communication, describing practices and policies that workplaces and leaders adopt to address these controversies and conflicts spurred by backlash organizing.

Toward a Communicative Understanding of (Online) Backlash

While the study of backlash has received recent scholarly attention, scholars (Kimmel, 1987) have traced the roots of backlash in the United States to the 1890s, when an enraged minority sought to undermine the suffrage movement. Further, given the push for civil rights throughout the 20th century, scholars have examined different aspects of backlash to understand better the organizing of reactionary and backlash political

movements around intersections of gender and race. Susan Faludi's (1991/2006) widely cited book, *Backlash*, examined the coordinated media messages that incited movements against women's liberation and feminist progress throughout American society during the Reagan era of the 1980s. Faludi argued that the media and commercial cultures of the 1980s promoted antifeminist arguments concerning the perceived dangers of women's career ambitions and desire for economic independence. Scholars have claimed that these media messages cultivated and contributed to the rise of antifeminism, men's rights movements, and white supremacy movements during the 1990s (Ferber, 2000). Although the previous examples of backlash are more extreme, Gallagher's (1997) research into the identity constructions of whiteness and the white ethnic identity adopted a more moderate frame to explore racial backlash: white college students' understanding of themselves within the shifting socioeconomic demographic landscape of work and political spheres. Gallagher argued that students' understanding of being white triggered a sense of crisis and loss given their perceived struggle for resources (e.g., access to race-based organizations or the impact on hiring practices because of affirmative action policies).

Studies have only recently begun exploring the role of social media and online enactments of backlash. For example, during the late 2000s and 2010s, the global rise of right-wing activism and the increased presence of social media and social networking sites sparked scholarly interest in the role of backlash throughout society (Ashcraft, 2022). Across various platforms, researchers examined the different messages, communities, and modalities that individuals utilized to mobilize and recruit potential members (Eddington, 2020; McNamee et al., 2010). Additionally, recent scholarship into online whisper networks has demonstrated the private network communication backchannel's collective power and possibilities for protection, change, and support (Johnson, 2023). Some scholars have argued that online platforms have made whisper networks easier to navigate for women and other marginalized groups (Brunner & Partlow-Lefevre, 2020). For example, Brunner and Partlow-Lefevre (2020) described the impact of the initial whisper network, #MeToo, in reducing various communication barriers and allowing for widespread consciousness-raising around the prevalence of sexual violence in daily life. In reclaiming a sense of lost agency (real or, in the case of right-wing activists, perceived), scholars have begun to highlight the inherent communicative nature of backlash.

The relative ease combined with the emotional and affective communication shared in messages has prompted new questions about the role of affective communication in the study of backlash. Just's (2019) introduction of "affective intensification", or the organizing process that enables the enactment of digital organizations and organizing, offers a critical way to view online organizing—in highlighting the role of affect,[1] Just argued that online communities and spaces affectively entangled together by human and non-human actors (e.g., affordances). Thus, the intensification of sensate and emotional forms of communication shared online are the driving forces for digital organizing (as a verb/process) and organizations (as an entity). Most recently, Eddington and colleagues (2023) examined the role of affect in constructing online organizational identities within the men's rights group, The Red Pill. Their study advanced an affect-centered approach to understanding how traditional and hegemonic forms of masculinity are enacted through backlash using affective forms of contradictory communication, sensemaking, and identification processes. Both Just (2019) and Eddington et al. (2023) argue that online backlashes have become widespread because of users' identification and (potential) subversion of specific features of social media platforms, known as affordances. In the next section, we describe how backlash is enacted online by describing several key affordances contributing to the reproduction and transmission of messages and ideas.

An Affordance Approach to Online Organizing

In understanding the affective potential of affordances, we move to conceptualize the critical characteristics and components of affordances. To do so, we discuss how backlash logic emerges through social media platforms such as Reddit and Twitter with varying offline implications of these online organizing patterns. Given their unique amalgamation of communicative affordances, Reddit and Twitter, among other social media platforms, have become a tentpole for vitriolic, hateful, and contrarian politics (Eddington, 2020; Fox et al., 2015; Massanari, 2015). Affordances are inherently relational, constructed, and characterized by "the relationship between the materiality of technological artifacts and the lived practices of communication" (McVeigh-Schultz & Baym, 2015, p. 1).

Specifically, affordances refer to a social media platform's various communicative, social, and technical features that simultaneously shape

and facilitate how individuals, groups, and organizational entities interact and communicate within a given platform (Leonardi & Vaast, 2017; Rice et al., 2017). Affordances can also be perceived in that users' perceptions of possibilities within a technological infrastructure can inspire different ways of using and interacting within a technological ecosystem (Rice et al., 2017).

We briefly focus on three key affordances that are critical to organizing and are shared throughout social media platforms: (1) anonymity, (2) community and connection, and (3) the role of emotion. Following our brief overview, we discuss what makes Reddit a unique exemplar of online organizing.

Anonymity

The affordance of anonymity allows individuals within online spaces to cloak their online identities (Fox et al., 2015; Jaidka et al., 2021; Rice et al., 2017). Cloaking is enacted in different ways and across different levels across all social media. From a platform standpoint, social media sites (e.g., Reddit or X–formerly Twitter) have historically provided anonymity as a technical feature and users can share certain identifiable information (e.g., names, photos, geographic location, political affiliation). For example, Scott and Rains' (2020) work on hidden and invisible organizations showcase how users and organizational entities (e.g., online communities) use anonymity to "operate outside public knowledge" (p. 395).

From a communicative and social affordance perspective, scholars disagree about the impact of anonymity online. Some argue that anonymity has increased freedom of expression, democratic engagement and deliberation, and inclusion (e.g., Yeshua-Katz & Hård af Segerstad, 2020). Others have taken a more complex, complicated view. Jaidka and colleagues (2021) evaluated the influence of anonymity on the quality of online discussion. They noted that users navigate the tensions between personal anonymity (e.g., omission of names, phone numbers, and email addresses from user accounts) and social anonymity (e.g., use of hashtags, emojis, images, or references that indicate membership within a social identity category) in their ongoing engagement and deliberation online. Jaidka et al. (2021) found no significant difference between personal anonymity and personal identification; however, when users' social identity was displayed, the quality of discussion was higher, given group-level norms around topics and issues.

A bulk of scholarship has given attention to the adverse outcomes of anonymity online, particularly to civility and the impact of hate and sexist speech (see Fox et al., 2015; Rösner & Krämer, 2016). Users use anonymity to mask their identities while simultaneously sharing harmful content online. Groshek and Cutino (2016) argued the growing ubiquity of mobile technologies and platform-specific technical features, like hashtags, as helpful mechanisms that allow anonymous users to engage with others in a more hostile and uncivil manner. Moreover, Groshek and Cutino warned that online anonymity might have offline implications—most notably furthering polarization issues.

However, as recent research has shown, the trend toward uncivil debate online has caused offline communication repercussions through polarization and silencing. For example, Woods and Ruscher (2021) noted that anonymity allowed users to share hate speech more quickly, often avoiding detection by law enforcement and other authorities. In discussing the unique nature of anonymity and hate speech, they highlighted the emotional responses (e.g., fear and uncertainty) to anonymous hate speech on targeted individuals, citing the challenge of uncertainty and magnitude of harassment (e.g., one harasser or many) (Woods & Ruscher, 2021). Thus, the ubiquity of anonymity online can create technocultures wherein individuals can spread harmful and problematic content more easily.

Community and Connection

The affordance of community and connection is a feature and outcome of the communicative possibilities for creating communities. On various social media platforms, specific features enable community, which is part of the technical infrastructure of the platform. As scholars have identified, technical affordances like hashtags have been vital for organizing groups of people—particularly those from marginalized and minoritized social identities (Eschmann, 2023; Jackson et al., 2020). Linabary et al. (2020) studied #WhyIStayed and uncovered contradictory postfeminist discourses surrounding domestic violence narratives. Despite creating a meaningful and visible communal hashtag space that provided support and solace for victims/survivors of domestic violence, Linabary and colleagues' findings "suggest the long-term impacts of hashtag activism may be limited to the individual-level (e.g., survivors learning about domestic violence survivor communities through the

hashtag) with less visible impacts on structural and cultural change" (p. 1843).

Just as online organizing affords social connection, it also has the potential to afford backlash and reactive politics. Jarvis and Eddington's (2020) study of the Reddit forum r/RedPillWomen (RPW) highlighted the contradictory nature of their organizing as supporters of the antifeminist men's rights subreddit, r/TheRedPill (Eddington, 2020; Eddington et al., 2023). In their study, Jarvis and Eddington describe RPW's use of perceived affordances of visibility and invisibility to act agentically within the men's movement. That is, the "affordances of gendered (in)visibility offer participants the ability to communicate their ideals about womanhood, critique feminists, and talk openly about their experiences and desires in a relatively supportive climate" while navigating "the broader [men's rights] network in which they are embedded" (p. 116). Online spaces and hashtagged backchannels can cultivate various forms of support. Moreover, communication can incite and coordinate mobilization efforts. Jarvis and Eddington's (2021) study of #OpenAmericaNow examined the labor protests that surfaced in response to the COVID-19 work-from-home orders. They found that the hashtag offered a shared communicative space that simultaneously organized various alt-right and conspiracy logics while coordinating and mobilizing nationwide protests and activism.

The Role of Emotion

The third affordance that we adopt to explore the role of backlash online is an emerging area of research around the role of affect and emotion. We argue that affective affordances are rooted in emotionality and central to sustaining online spaces. Sturm Wilkerson et al. (2021) define affective affordances as possibilities for the "expression of feeling in relation to content" (p. 15). Affective affordances contribute to sensory experiences (e.g., a photo of a beloved family member shared on Facebook that prompts feelings of connection or happiness). Moreover, affective affordances can also be leveraged to enact self-presentation strategies, protect one's identity, and regulate emotions (Vidolov, 2022).

Recent scholarship has begun to examine the role of emotional content online through affective affordances, highlighting the intersections of visual, sensory, and affective content that coalesce to create heightened visibility and virality of social media content (Geboers & Van De Wiele, 2020; Sturm Wilkerson et al., 2021). For example,

Sturm Wilkerson et al. studied affective affordances through the lens of Facebook reactions and hyperpartisan political news during the 2016 U.S. Presidential Election. One of their findings noted that antagonistic content shared on conservative pages led to higher engagement through reactions and sharing throughout Facebook networks. Geboers and Van De Wiele's (2020) qualitative visual analysis of refugee photos shared on Twitter highlighted different visual traits and themes that led users to retweet content throughout their networks. Their findings demonstrate the affective nature of images shared, as users retweet images that elicit an emotional response throughout their networks, inadvertently reinforcing problematic depictions of refugee images (GeBoers & Van De Wiele, 2020, p. 759). In a similar vein, Eddington et al. (2023) explored the role of affective content on the Reddit forum, r/TheRedPill, and showcased how the configurations of various affordances (e.g., upvotes, commenting, anonymity) enabled users to simultaneously organize their collectivity while engaging in sensemaking through the visceral and embodied nature of the affective narratives shared on their forum.

Implications for Employee Communication

These three affordances, anonymity, community and connection, and emotionality, reveal a more profound understanding of how backlash discourses have gained public prominence in recent years. As many of the examples highlight, where these discourses may begin online, they are more often and more frequently resulting in real, lived consequences in the offline world. With this acknowledgment, employers must contend with questions of when and how to respond to these events. In the final section, we review some implications for the modern workplace and further practical recommendations for how employers can better respond in times of backlash-originating crisis. As such, we conclude this chapter by offering several practical considerations for workplace and employee communication.

Policies for Harassment and Trolling

For workers, particularly those with public-facing roles in workplaces, the threat of trolling and harassment is ever-present, especially for marginalized and minoritized individuals (Vogels, 2021). Thus, we invite organizations to consider a holistic approach when considering strategies

and policies that might be adopted if/when employees are experiencing online harassment and trolling. We draw from Marwick et al.'s (2016) considerations to outline a multi-faceted plan that leaders and employees can enact collaboratively and preemptively. First, workplaces can host regular seminars and professional development opportunities around privacy issues. Specifically, workplaces can encourage employees to conduct social media audits and privacy checks of accounts regularly (*Crash Override Network // for Employers*, 2023). Second, workplaces can enhance the contact privacy of workers by limiting contact information that could be used to harass workers further. Third, workplaces can consider creating an organizational crisis communication response team including organizational leaders, public relations staff members, and other support staff, to develop a response plan focused on internal and external communication. This team should focus on developing comprehensive response plans for both internal and external communication during crises.

Leadership Considerations

Leaders must understand that backlash in mediated settings is increasingly becoming an everyday feature of life online, and supporting their workers holistically is an ethical obligation of modern leadership. One practice related to backlash is "bombarding a target's work with messages, false complaints, and threats in a coordinated attempt to get them fired" (*Crash Override Network // for Employers*, 2023, para. 4). These coordinated efforts may also show up as organizational boycotts (see the recent example of Bud Light and Target boycotts for their support of LGBTQ activism in Zahn, 2023). Additionally, employers would do well to take an empathic approach toward their employees. In doing so, employers and leaders can "move beyond the modern/Fordist notions of the workplace (e.g., control, efficiency, and exercising power), and adopt postmodern positions of influence and regulation of emotions" (Eddington & Jarvis, 2021, p. 189). Leaders must be situationally aware, empathetic, and supportive of their employees throughout the process and "work with them rather than punish, terminate, or silence their online activities outright" (*Crash Override Network // for Employers*, 2023, para. 6). To that end, leaders would do well to engage in perspective getting to understand the experiences of their employees better.

Managing Difference

Finally, as the online increasingly blends with the offline, we invite employees to consider how they engage with each other. In their 2021 case study examining Google and James Damore, Eddington and Jarvis invited employees to consider the role of bounded emotionality as a pathway for bridging differences. They encouraged employees to consider "the role of relationships, understanding, and community, which seek to transform organizational realities beyond binary ways of thinking, doing, and being" (p. 191). We contend that perspective-getting is an additional component of bounded emotionality. Perspective-getting, or "hearing about the experiences of an outgroup member (from them or others)", has gained both scholarly and media attention as one potential strategy to mitigate differences (Kalla & Broockman, 2023, p. 186). Kalla and Broockman's (2023) field studies around perspective-getting narratives demonstrated their role in reducing exclusionary attitudes. Thus, we argue that these narratives may also be leveraged to address issues of backlash that are organized online. However, given various interpersonal barriers, perspective-getting is not readily used (Damen et al., 2021). As threats to free speech have caused moral panics, which have spurred backlash, we contend that employees would do well to approach others from a place of perspective-getting rather than judgment, outrage, and entitlement. Rather than ignoring, shying away from, or invoking fear-based appeals, a perspective-getting approach demonstrates the malleability of online/offline attitudes and beliefs that can be positively shaped by human connection and relationship-building.

Concluding Remarks

As online backlashes continue to impact offline workplaces, fostering inclusion through policies, leadership, and perspective-taking is key to mitigating harm and divisions among employees. Throughout our chapter, we have highlighted the need to prioritize perspective-getting rather than judgment, outrage, or entitlement in the face of backlash. In doing so, a perspective-getting approach may be a useful way to work through social outrage.

Note

1. We borrow from Stewart's (2007) definition of affect as sensate experiences that exist as "impulses, sensations, expectations, daydreams, encounters, and habits of relating, in strategies and

failures, in forms of persuasion…that catch people up in something that feels like something" (p. 2).

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TRACING THE HISTORY OF ORGANIZATIONAL REPRESENTATIVES' COMMUNICATION COMPETENCE

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Competence in communicating is essential for all aspects of organizational functioning (Shockley-Zalabak, 2015) and organizations have always been dependent on the ability of their individual members to communicate on their behalf (Pels, 2000, p. xiii). Similar to Spitzberg and Cupach (1984), in this chapter, communication competence refers to the overall set of skills, abilities, and knowledge about what, when, and how to communicate in different situations, to diverse stakeholders, and for various purposes.

With the rise of social media, individuals are seen as having amplified opportunities to represent their organizations communicatively and to contribute to organizational goals (Snyder & Honig, 2016; Pekkala, 2020). This has increased the importance of understanding those competences that enable individuals to produce a positive megaphoning effect (Kim & Rhee, 2011) and to communicate on behalf of their collectives. Kim and Rhee (2011) define the megaphoning effect as "the likelihood of employees' voluntary information forwarding or information sharing about organizational strengths (accomplishments) or weaknesses (problems)" (p. 246).

The aim of this chapter is to increase understanding of organizational representatives' communication competence by exploring how it has

been conceptualized and how it has manifested in different eras, from ancient orators to contemporary employee advocates. To this end, a scoping review of previous literature was conducted, focusing on individuals' communicative roles and competences. Theoretically, the review includes literature from multiple disciplines, such as classical rhetoric, media studies, public relations, corporate communication, and organizational communication. It discusses changes in organizational representation by looking at individual members of organizations and their communication competence (e.g., valued competences), as well as the organizational context (e.g., those permitted to act as organizational representatives), and the media landscape (media used). Three organizational representative archetypes and their related competences are identified and discussed, with suggestions for future research avenues.

What Is Communication Competence and Why Does It Matter?

Communication competence has been the subject of many theoretical and empirical approaches. Although the perspectives on communication competence are rich and diverse (Rickheit et al., 2008), they are generally more complementary than contradictory (Shockley-Zalabak, 2015). These various perspectives share the view that communication competences are important in an organizational context, that they can be developed, that they influence organizational and group performance, and that they are subject to different perceptions and evaluations (Shockley-Zalabak, 2015, p. 397). Competence is thus inherently an evaluative judgment of a behavior, rather than a skill or trait possessed by an individual. In other words, an individual becomes a competent communicator only when they have been judged to be so by a perceiver (Roloff & Kellermann, 1984). Communication competence is therefore contextual (Spitzberg, 2000; Spitzberg & Cupach, 2002), varying according to cultural, chronological, relational, environmental, and functional factors (Spitzberg, 2000; Spitzberg & Brunner, 1991), as well as the means by which the communication is carried out (Wilson & Sabee, 2003). As a matter of fact, one of the key contextual factors for communication competence is the medium of communication, which has evolved from oral, direct, vocal media to the digital media of today.

Spitzberg (1988) suggests that contextual factors shape what is considered appropriate or accepted in that given context. Morreale et al.

(2013) describe appropriate and effective communication as occurring "when you act in ways suitable to the norms and expectations of contexts you encounter. Effective communication occurs when you are able to achieve the most desirable objectives or outcomes in contexts" (p. 5).

Over the years, scholars studying communication competence have attempted to identify how competence is constituted, as variations in its performance can affect perceptions of effectiveness and appropriateness (Backlund & Morreale, 2015). Overall, this literature has discussed the topic according to three typologies, based on their studied unit of analysis: (1) individual, (2) group and team, and (3) macro-organizational levels (Shockley-Zalabak, 2015). Acknowledging different specializations in the field of communication and the contextual nature of communication competence, this chapter focuses on the individual level and spotlights the process of an individual communicating on behalf of a collective to the public.

A large body of literature on communication competence exists; many of the conceptual foundations addressing the individual level rely on an interpersonal communication understanding of competence. Studies exploring the specific skills and knowledge that constitute competence in diverse roles, processes, and for specific performance goals are few (Shockley-Zalabak, 2015). Additionally, the rapid evolution of digital communication technologies as an integral medium for communicating has required individuals to acquire new competences as the divisions between interpersonal and mass communication have increasingly dissolved (Spitzberg, 2006). These new forms of mediated and participative communications through social media platforms, for instance, have created new avenues and needs for communication competence research.

The History and Evolution of Organizational Representatives

The tradition of individuals advocating a cause, position, or the wellbeing of a collective dates back to ancient Greek and Roman orators, who are known to have spoken on behalf of their collectives (Elsbach, 2003). Institutional settings and channels of communication have changed since ancient times, but new forms of institutions, including modern organizations, still communicate through individuals (Cooren & Taylor, 1997). In the following sections, we discuss the evolution of communication competences within organizational settings across three

historical eras, characterized by macro-level societal and technological transformations that are closely intertwined with how individuals practiced communication and developed their communication competences.

Ancient Orators: Establishing the Foundation for Communication Competence

The origins of organizational representation are traditionally ascribed to ancient Greece over 2,500 years ago, when so-called "orators" protected and managed the images, identities, and reputations of their collectives (Elsbach, 2003). During antiquity, rhetoric was viewed as the civic art of public speaking and persuasion through words. Public oratory in assemblies or courts of law provided a forum in which individual speakers sought to challenge and persuade a mass audience (Ober, 2007). Interestingly, the historical roots of theoretical traditions and frameworks for organizational and group communication competence also lie in classical rhetorical traditions (Hannawa & Spitzberg, 2015).

Communication competence as a concept has been linked to rhetorical traditions, beginning with the sophists around 467 BC and continuing with the influence of ancient philosophers and rhetoricians, such as Aristotle, Cicero, and Quintilian (Shockley-Zalabak, 2015). Quintilian defined an orator as "a good man speaking well" in his book series *Institutes of Oratory* (95 AD) and created a link between the individual and communication ability. Cicero mentioned in his book series *On the Orator* (55 BC) that the ideal orator is trained in rhetoric, philosophy, law, and all knowledge, is morally upright, and is an active participant in public life (Kennedy, 2011). Isocrates also saw the individual as a source of values influencing society at large, and believed that successful orators embodied and exemplified those values (Marsh, 2013). The orator's power lay in his speaking ability, which was at least partly a product of specialized education (Ober, 2007).

In ancient Greece, rhetoric was considered a craft (*tekhne*) (Habinek, 2005), and its various forms were introduced in several handbooks written by ancient philosophers. One of the best-known books is Aristotle's *Rhetoric* (384–322 BC), in which he introduced three proofs of persuasion: logos (logical arguments), pathos (emotional appeal), and ethos (ethical appeals or a person's character, which strengthens the rhetor's credibility) (Ihlen, 2013). Aristotle argued that ethos, or character, may almost be called the most effective means of persuasion,

and hence ethos is particularly important when discussing an individual's reputation (Ihlen, 2013). Isocrates (436–338 BC) emphasized the importance of the "natural aptitude" of a speaker, by which he meant an innate ability for political discourse. He pointed out that all speakers can be trained through instruction, practice, and performance, but success also requires natural talent (Marsh, 2013).

The literature related to ancient orators, early rhetorical theory and its practical applications leads us to understand that orators in the classical era were valued for their oratory and argumentation skills, empathy, and character, as well as for being morally upright and taking an active role in public life. The assessment of communication competence during the time of orators was made according to effectiveness (how well the orators were able to influence the court) and participation, such as how big a crowd they were able to draw (Habinek, 2005). The legacy of ancient orators laid the groundwork for both practical and theoretical frameworks of communication competence for organizational representatives, which continues to influence contemporary thinking on the topic. With the development of media during the Middle Ages and early modern period, the media landscape underwent significant changes, and communication competence became multimodal, extending beyond mere oral skills.

Organizational Spokespeople: Institutionalizing Communication Competence

The rise of "modern journalism" in the late 19th century, characterized by values such as objectivity, public service and active news-gathering (Krause, 2011), gave rise to new expectations for organizations and required them to establish operative functions for media relations and public information. This development led to the rapid emergence of public relations functions, with the role of organizational spokespersons becoming critical, particularly in the areas of media relations, crisis communication, and issues management (Troester, 1991; Troester & Warburton, 2001).

The rapid growth of industrialization also called for more effective methods of management and communication, and the early 20th century saw the development of management theories such as Taylor's Scientific Management. Taylor's time can be seen as the beginning of the organization of work and its content. Taylor's ideas contributed to the

development of a normative environment supporting efficiency in all organizational functions, including communication.

In organizational settings, this emphasis basically translated into an increased preoccupation with identifying the factors and characteristics of an effective organizational spokesperson (Grunig, 1992, p. 537). This period of time was characterized by a focus on issues close to the speech communication discipline, which traditionally understands competence as either the competence to speak effectively or the competence to speak meaningfully, that is, to be understood as one intends (Sanders, 2015). At that time, many corporations began to organize speech communication training for their executives to enhance their speaking skills.

All in all, the new hierarchical form of organizations, efficiency as a normative ideal, the increased importance of the news media, and the intensified attention to speech communication led to the institutionalization of the role of the organizational spokesperson. The spokesperson was typically a visible leader or a public relations practitioner (Elsbach, 2003; Järventie-Thesleff et al., 2011). The literature particularly emphasized the role of the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) in personifying the organization and acting as the highest-level corporate spokesperson (Park & Berger, 2004; Zerfass et al., 2016).

Organizational spokespeople were expected to deliver consistent messages and to speak with the same voice and tone (Ihlen, 2013), realizing the vision of contemporary corporate communication to manage all communication as one entity (Christensen & Cornelissen, 2011). Spokespeople were regarded as actors, agencies, and instruments representing a company's organized interests to the public (Crable, 1990).

They were expected to follow five principles when communicating for and on behalf of the organization, including (a) understanding the nature of the message recipients, (b) recognizing the respective audience attitudes, (c) accepting emotion as a communication variable, (d) responding to the differences between controlled and uncontrolled media, and (e) handling the dynamic and fluid nature of the public relations process (Troester & Warburton, 2001, p. 243).

Overall, in this historical phase, four main organizational communication competences were considered important: knowledge, sensitivity, skills, and values (Littlejohn & Jabusch, 1982; Shockley-Zalabak, 2012). Knowledge in this context refers to the ability to understand the organizational communication environment and master the related tools, technologies and communication methods. Sensitivity

is the ability to sense meanings and emotions accurately. Skills refer to the capacity to analyze organizational situations accurately and to communicate appropriately. Lastly, values refer to taking responsibility for effective communication (Shockley-Zalabak, 2015, p. 401).

Employee Advocates: Renewing the Importance of Individuals' Communication Competence

During the past decade, the increased use of digital communication technologies, and particularly social media, has brought about significant changes in organizational life. Today, employees can share their work experiences with a wide audience outside the organization by using social media (Miles & Mangold, 2014), increasing the importance of their role as communicators for organizations. This idea of employee advocacy (Men & Stacks, 2013) largely resembles Kim and Rhee's (2011) idea of "positive megaphoning", which refers to employees' external communication behavior about their organizations (p. 246). Employee advocacy can be seen as word-of-mouth behavior, which entails the promotion or defense of a company or brand (Walz & Celuch, 2010).

Organizations view social media as both an opportunity to engage with stakeholders and as a risk to their reputation and business due to the potential loss of control over communication flows (Gruber et al., 2015; Miles & Mangold, 2014; Pekkala, 2021). The competence of employees in using social media judiciously and creating a positive megaphoning effect has become crucial. Inappropriate or incompetent social media use can harm organizational reputation (Ivens & Schaarschmidt, 2015), as there are many instances where employees' social media actions have negatively impacted their employer's image and overall performance (Walsh et al., 2016).

The literature related to competence in using digital media technology has flourished for almost two decades. In 2006, Spitzberg postulated a theory of computer-mediated communication (CMC) competence, which suggests that when CMC competence increases, co-orientation, appropriateness, effectiveness, satisfaction, and preferred relational outcomes are more likely to occur: "Competence, in this sense, is based on some of the same variables or components of competence as in face-to-face interactions, with the addition of media as an intervening factor" (Backlund & Morreale, 2015, p. 27). Subsequently, Alber et al. (2015) introduced the concept of social media competence (SMC), which refers

to an individual's capability of using social media appropriately as a means of sharing information, engaging with others, and encouraging participation in a community. However, Walsh et al. (2016) realized that even with the widespread recognition that employees' social media use can shape a company's reputation, no concept would describe employees' competence to communicate in a way that would positively affect organizational reputation. Therefore, they developed a construct that they termed reputation-related SMC, referring to "an employee's explicit and tacit knowledge, skills, and behavior that give him or her the ability to use social media in ways that do not harm the employer's reputation" (Walsh et al., 2016, p. 46). Reputation-related SMC includes the following five distinguishable dimensions: employees' social media-related technical competence, visibility awareness competence, knowledge competence, impact assessment competence, and social media communication competence (Walsh et al., 2016, p. 49). Hence, the reputation-related SMC construct provides an opportunity to empirically study employee advocates and their competence in the contemporary media landscape.

In summary, the increased importance of employees' communication competence in the digital media environment, and the recognition of its importance in the organization's operations, has led to a growing interest in employee advocacy as a concept and practice. As employees can and will wield their communication power on social media, their communication competence is a critical success factor for today's organizations (Walsh et al., 2016) and one that deserves to be further explored and understood.

To advance understanding of the communication competence of organizational representatives, this chapter has explored how communication competence has been discussed, conceptualized, and embodied in different periods of time from ancient orators to today's employee advocates. When looking at the context of communication, and the available media and attributes that have been associated with organizational representatives in each period, we identified three organizational representative archetypes and their competence attributes at different points of time, which are presented in Table 30.1.

Table 30.1 Organizational representative archetypes by context, media, an

Archetype	*Definitions*	*Context*	*Media*	*Compe attribu*
Orator	"A good man speaking well" Quintilian, c. 95 AD	Public oratory in ancient assemblies or courts of law	Oral	Logica argume skills, for em appeal person charac (Aristc 384–3
Organizational spokesperson	"Organizational spokespersons convey or explain symbolic actions to organizational audiences. Spokespersons include anyone who is perceived by audience members as representing the organization" (Elsbach, 2003)	Organization in industrial era	Oral, written	Knowl sensiti skills, values (Littlej Jabusc

Archetype	*Definitions*	*Context*	*Media*	*Compe attribu*
Employee advocate	A person who enacts advocacy, referring to "a behavioral construct, that is, the voluntary promotion or defense of a company, its products, or brands by an employee externally" (Men, 2014, p. 262)	Organization in information era	Oral, written, visual, on- and offline	Emplo social relate techni compe visibili awarer compe knowl compe impact assessı compe and so media commu compe (Walsh 2016,

Discussion

This chapter has sought to increase understanding of organizational representatives' communication competence, and of how it has been conceptualized and manifested in three different eras, from ancient orators to today's employee advocates. This chapter identifies three organizational representative archetypes and duly demonstrates that competence attributes in different periods of time depend on the context and the normative ideals that vary from one era to another (Deetz, 1992). Furthermore, the archetypes identified show that the way communication and related competence attributes are conceptualized is closely linked to the media landscape in each time period (see also Innis, 1950).

The first ancient-orator archetype embodies competences that relate to public speaking, argumentation, ethics, and planning. The organizational-spokesperson archetype is characterized by public speaking skills and the ability to communicate with an organizational tone, conveying knowledge and values. The most recent employee advocacy archetype consists of technical, conversational, and reputational competences. Each organizational representative archetype includes an interplay between multiple factors, such as media and audience characteristics, which influence the communication behavior of each archetype (Howes & Sallot, 2013). Hence, old and new modes of communication coexist and constantly interact with new modes of organizational representation. In this way, competence attributes have become more complex, particularly due to the increased number of media outlets available. Overall, by looking at past and emerging forms of organizational representation, the chapter demonstrates that the communication competence of individual members continues to be of great importance for organizations.

Development toward employee advocacy via social media has changed corporate communication practices from top-down, managerially controlled communications into a bottom-up responsibility shared by a wide range of organizational actors. This approach de-emphasizes the idea of "one voice" and allows organizations to speak with many different voices simultaneously (Christensen & Cornelissen, 2011). Scholars have suggested that conventional structures that allow only single actors (e.g., the official spokesperson) to communicate on behalf of an organization may not be viable in today's dynamic and complex environment, characterized by polyphony and diversity (Christensen et al., 2008). Consequently, this ongoing change, which enhances participation, requires a better understanding of competences and how they develop among the contemporary workforce. This is important given that many employees lack confidence in their ability to use social media strategically to achieve professional and organizational goals (Pekkala & van Zoonen, 2022). In the age of social media, it is increasingly important for communication practitioners to understand their competence needs and to continuously train and build an organization-wide competence base (Gregory, 2013).

As the chapter shows, the communication roles and competences of organizational representatives have evolved through the different eras, and this evolution is expected to continue, providing fruitful avenues for future research. For example, future research could explore different processes of employee learning and usage of social media and other

digitally mediated technologies to identify and assess the benefits of such engagement at the personal, organizational, and societal levels. In addition, recent advances in AI and its increased adoption by organizational representatives call for empirical research. Today, more than ever, authentic human communication is challenged by artificially generated content, raising questions about the role of human employees as communicators in comparison to machines and their increasingly human-like content creation capabilities. This evolution needs to be considered further in order to develop both theory and praxis to address the changing media, organizational and societal landscapes. Future research could, for instance, investigate the paradoxes, opportunities and pitfalls of machine communications in organizational settings in light of human communication competences. To what extent are AI technologies impacting these competences? Are they constructing new ones or reshaping existing ones? These are just two questions among others that deserve more careful investigation.

Practical Implications

The media ecosystem of organizations is expanding and changing rapidly. While these developments offer greater opportunities for organizations and their members to communicate and interact with diverse stakeholders, such changes also require organizations to be particularly sensitive to issues such as ethical standards and privacy concerns, confidentiality and copyright aspects related to content usage and distribution, as well as the usability of different media tools and technologies. Continuous training and education of employees on these matters are paramount if organizations plan to empower their employees to ethically and responsibly assume roles as organizational representatives. Moreover, managers must recognize that fostering an inclusive and supportive leadership culture is essential for facilitating employee engagement and commitment to communication-related tasks.

Limitations and Future Research

Much like Eisenberg et al. (2007), it is important to acknowledge that all historical writings, including this review, have inherent limitations as they are partial, partisan, and problematic. Firstly, we cannot provide a complete account of the history of communication competence within the scope of a book chapter, so our account is inevitably partial. Secondly, we have written this chapter under the limitation of

partisanship, meaning that the knowledge we present here is shaped by the theories and interpretations we use to make sense of the world. Thirdly, we have written this chapter knowing that the content we present here is problematic: "the answers it does provide are based on what is currently known rather than all that could be known" (Eisenberg et al., 2007, p. 64). We are aware of these limitations, but we have chosen to write this chapter with the aim of stimulating further discussion and suggesting new avenues for expanding communication competence research.

Note

An earlier version of this paper was included in Kaisa Pekkala's doctoral dissertation titled "Social Media and New Forms of Communicative Work".

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31

CHALLENGES FOR GLOBAL AND INTERNATIONAL EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION

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Organizations, Internal Communication, and Culture

The intersection of organizations, international communication, and culture is evident in studies of organizational culture. There is a fundamental connection between societal culture and organizational culture, as employees, who have been acculturated in society through their homes and schools, bring those values into the workplace, shaping organizational culture (Sriramesh, 2019). With the realities of the 21st century, characterized by a highly mobile workforce due to globalization, employees are more likely to be multicultural and even spread across multiple borders than ever before. As a result, it is crucial for organizational managers to be more aware of the interaction between societal and organizational culture. Embracing multicultural narratives that encompass the varied perspectives of all employees will not only bring about a transformation in both public and private economic establishments but will also breathe new life into societal discussions and political systems, thus enhancing collective social, political, and economic welfare.

The concept of a globally connected world, often referred to as a "global village", is reshaping organizations. This evolving paradigm gives rise to an internal communication[1] landscape that crosses national and cultural boundaries, demanding a more nuanced consideration of the

impact of culture on this domain. The integration of new technologies further complicates the environment where interconnected global communication must be maintained internally and externally (Gurau, 2008). The structural decisions taken within organizations significantly influence the management and coordination of internal communication strategies (Neill & Jiang, 2017). Contrary, the fundamental objectives of internal communication departments around the world remain relatively uniform: disseminating organizational culture, vision, and mission while facilitating interaction between management and employees through enhanced communication channels (Apud & Apud-Martinez, 2008).

To successfully navigate internal communication across diverse cultural contexts, it becomes vital to embrace cultural diversity without imposing judgments and to prevent cultural insensitivity that overlooks the nuances among various cultural identities (Adler, 2002). Effectively managing cross-cultural internal communication hinges upon cultivating cross-cultural competence within the internal communication department, heightening awareness of culture's impact on their work, and nurturing specialized knowledge and skills tailored for multicultural communication teams (Apud & Apud-Martinez, 2008). Language, for instance, emerges as a critical factor for organizational functioning and internal communication efficiency (Louhiala-Salminen & Kankaanranta, 2012). That is why internal communication department's efforts should foster a strong connection across transnational settings (Neill & Jiang, 2017).

In 2003, Kinicki & Kreitner highlighted that the progression of globalization fundamentally necessitates employees to cultivate international awareness and cross-cultural proficiency. Twenty years later, managers and staff residing within their native countries still encounter challenges in evading involvement in the global economy. Many inevitably engage with international markets, either through employment in foreign corporations or through interactions with foreign suppliers, clients, and collaborators. The global economy merges diverse cultural elements, contributing to the composition of organizational cultures. As per Robbin's observations in 2002, even in optimal scenarios like interactions among individuals from the same culture within an organization, achieving effective communication remains a complex endeavor. In the context of organizations encompassing diversity or operating on a multinational scale, cross-cultural elements undeniably introduce a heightened potential for communication complications. The procedure of encoding and decoding messages into symbols is heavily

influenced by individual cultural backgrounds, thus producing different outcomes for each person. There are significant disparities between message senders and receivers, encompassing substantial variations in the interpretations assigned to certain words or actions (Mogea, 2023). This is why, as Stohl stated more than two decades ago (2000), there is still an awareness that organizational communication processes cannot be confined to a mono-cultural framework. To foster cross-cultural awareness, there should be a shift from a monocultural team to cross-cultural internal communication, comprising representatives from the organization's key regions. This approach proves particularly effective in multicultural environments, emphasizing the translation of meaning rather than mere language (Apud & Apud-Martinez, 2008).

In understanding internal communication within an organization, accepting its embedded culture is vital (Broom & Sha, 2013). As articulated by Sriramesh, the symbiotic relationship between communication and culture is undeniable (2009). Likewise, internal communication is inherently entwined with culture. As messages grow in volume, internal communication's mandate expands. It becomes the responsibility of internal communication to lead in significance by honing skills that facilitate engagement with top management, ultimately positioning it as a strategic business discipline (Helsby, 2002). However, this journey requires internal communication professionals to deal with the complicated communication demands within increasingly complex organizations and among a diversified employee base (Welch, 2012). Indeed, internal communication departments possess the potential to orchestrate the assimilation of cultural synergy within a global corporate framework (Apud & Apud-Martinez, 2008).

Internal Communication in Multicultural Organizations

Multicultural organizations serve as melting pots for diverse cultures from around the globe. A multicultural workforce implies a staff comprising of individuals from various cultural backgrounds. Each culture contributes its distinct dimensions and viewpoints. Multicultural workforces possess unique traits, stemming from cultural variations among employees, which consequently foster innovation within the organization. A multicultural workforce encompasses employees' diversity in numerous distinct attributes while uniting under the organization's shared goals (Bhardwaj & Sharma, 2017). Navigating communication obstacles in globally varied teams is unquestionably a

difficult task (Hussain, 2018). In a multicultural organization, effective communication serves as the sole means through which information is exchanged, trust is established, and positive connections are fostered. Iedema and Wodak (1999) acknowledged that organizations don't exist independently of their members but are molded and remolded through the acts of communication among members. Organizations typically encompass intricately differentiated social systems (Scott, 1997), featuring formal and informal boundaries, and negotiated distinctions. As multicultural organizations are in a state of constant evolution, communication processes also evolve to both shape and reflect new structures, procedures, and relationships.

The understanding of culture and the multicultural nature of modern organizations can lead to divergence in approaches to internal communication. Zerfass et al. (2022) conducted interviews with communicators who have international responsibilities and found that global chief communication officers tend to keep communication under control in corporate headquarters, where communication is responsible for vision, mission, values, and other essential building blocks of a corporation. They fear losing control over them, as it could jeopardize corporate identity and reputation. In contrast, local communication managers and their teams in European companies enjoy greater flexibility to implement these standards while adapting them to local cultures and circumstances. Numerous other studies focus on identifying fresh obstacles associated with multiculturalism in society and the evolving characteristics of work and the working population (Ravazzani, 2016). These challenges stem from the expansion of activities into the global sphere, the movement of immigrants, and the heightened mobility of employees. Mentioned dynamics contribute to the diversification of the composition and requirements of consumer and labor markets (Mazzei & Ravazzani, 2012). Transforming these broader societal and business-level changes into concrete issues confronted by managers often proves to be a complex task (Williams & O'Reilly, 1998).

Organizations that overlook the challenges of cross-cultural communication encounter many difficulties across various facets of international internal communication. This encompasses aspects like free trade policies, decisions regarding localization and standardization strategies, advertising, brand efficacy, business relationships, international business management, international marketing, negotiations on a global scale, consumer behavior, staffing, industrial relations, interpersonal interactions, negotiation, and team building (Hussain,

2018). The challenging context of communication within multicultural teams prompts inquiries into how managers can effectively surmount the structural and cultural circumstances and limitations that define their functioning. Many individuals with experience in collaborating within multicultural project teams are yet to acquire the skills required to navigate such a demanding communication environment. Given that multicultural teams comprise individuals from diverse cultures, relying solely on professed best practices doesn't guarantee successful outcomes (Ochieng & Price, 2010).

Drawing from intercultural studies, numerous public relations scholars have explored multicultural communication in relation to external audiences, both on an international scale (Zaharna, 2001) and within domestic contexts (Fiske, 2007). Nonetheless, only a limited number of studies have directed their attention toward internal audiences within multicultural environments (Banks, 2000). Across these investigations, a common thread is that they emphasize the impact of culture on communication. They highlight the imperative to adjust communication strategies across various dimensions, including language, content, media consumption habits, technological preferences, visual elements, and strategies for rhetoric and argumentation (Ravazzani, 2016). This implies that alongside linguistic adaptations, there's a call to consider other cultural expressions, as highlighted by the body of literature on managing intercultural rapport (Spencer-Oatey, 2005). The need for such adaptation is rooted in the recognition that cultural disparities can create obstacles to effective communication, leading to misunderstandings and even work-related conflicts within organizations (Guirdham, 2005). In navigating these complex challenges, managers are tasked with fostering an awareness of cultural subtleties, taking an audience-centered stance (Falkheimer & Heide, 2006), and critically examining assumptions inherent within their organizations (Ravazzani, 2016).

Facilitating Technologies for International Internal Communication

Emerging communication technologies (such as Artificial intelligence, Social media and collaboration platforms, Big data analytics, Cybersecurity tools, and Cloud computing) are expediting decision-making processes and altering the dynamics of interactions within organizations. These technologies are also pivotal in modifying

organizational processes, decision-making procedures, and the overall organizational design (Herschel & Andrews, 1997). New technologies provide enhanced access to global events and individuals, removing barriers and promoting transparency. On a global scale, technology encourages cross-cultural interactions, although it can also create barriers, often arising from resistance to technological change or fear of it (Cowan, 2017).

The progress and evolution of technology has greatly enhanced our way of life, touching nearly every aspect, with a significant impact on communication methods. The field of communication has witnessed notable advancements, evolving from symbolic forms of communication to modern digital tools such as mobile devices and computers. While the essence of communication remains constant, the tools we employ to communicate have undergone transformation. The etiquettes and protocols tied to our modes of communication remain essential in facilitating mutual understanding. As emerging technologies continue to shape our communication landscape, new etiquettes and norms accompany these novel methods of interaction (Sheoran, 2012). The integration of digital technology into broader society has reshaped organizations too, leading managers to reconsider how internal communication is conducted and defined, particularly within the realms of public relations and strategic communication (Men, 2021). As Holtz (2006) has highlighted, the internet has provided tools that empower individuals to become content creators and connect all members of an organization. For modern organizations, this means the exchange of messages across temporal and geographical boundaries (García-Morales et al., 2003), underlining the importance of international internal communication.

Change was already in progress before the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic, which highlighted the significance of effective internal communication. However, communication professionals within organizations were ill-prepared to actively engage in the digital transformation of internal communication (Zerfass et al., 2022). More than a decade ago, in the 2011 European Communication Monitor (Zerfass et al., 2021), many public relations experts perceived managing the evolution of digital media and the social web as the foremost strategic concerns within their field. Yet, in the 2021 Monitor (Zerfass et al., 2022), many shifted their attention to other pressing issues. One potential explanation is that they believed they had "mastered" digitalization, but it is more likely that they encountered challenges in

keeping up with the rapid pace of digital transformation. The adoption of digital technologies within organizations for daily communication has not been a straightforward process (Tkalac Verčič & Špoljarić, 2020).

One of the outcomes of the worldwide pandemic, however, is a much faster adoption of digital communication, especially in an international context. It became apparent that a benefit of information and communication technologies is their ability to enable new modes of work within virtual or partially virtual organizations, such as telecommuting, as well as novel and more informal employment arrangements. This is especially important in the international context. These transformations significantly impact the relationships between individual employees and the organizations they work for. Within this context, Gossett (2002) outlined communication strategies that, rather than fostering, obstruct member identification with organizations. Long before the pandemic Jablin and Sias (2001) raised questions regarding the consequences of the increasing presence of contingent workers on what is considered effective communication, suggesting that competent contingent and permanent workers may require distinct skills and knowledge. Hylmö and Buzzanell (2002) employed three cultural perspectives to shed light on the paradoxical functioning of telecommuting within organizations. Other researchers have explored obstacles to communication and identification in this context, such as Chapman et al. (2005). Jones et al. (2004) investigated communication within geographically and professionally diverse networked organizations and found that the most significant challenges and opportunities revolved around the diversity of social identities and how they were managed to either create or not create an overarching organizational identity. It has, therefore, been clear for decades that the changing nature of working conditions affects all aspects of communication, especially in an international context.

Competencies for Multicultural Communication

In the global business environment, there is a growing demand for a profound understanding of cultural diversity, in addition to intercultural communication competence (ICC; Matveev & Nelson, 2004). Global organizations need to recognize the diverse nature of modern workforce and should increasingly shift their focus toward examining work teams composed of members from various cultural backgrounds (Jackson & Ruderman, 1995). Embracing workforce diversity can significantly enhance team performance, thereby advancing organizational efficiency

and effectiveness (Cox, 1993). As contemporary workplaces increasingly rely on multicultural teams, it becomes imperative not only to recognize but also to cultivate the communication processes necessary to develop high-performing teams, all while emphasizing ICC (Prieto et al., 2009). To effectively collaborate with individuals from diverse cultural backgrounds, members of multicultural teams must demonstrate a deep understanding of their team members' personalities, conflict resolution approaches, and life experiences, thereby exemplifying ICC (Triandis & Singelis, 1998).

Organizations are increasingly recognizing the significance of ICC and are investing in education and training to nurture this skill among their workforce. ICC is described as the ability to establish a mutual understanding among individuals with diverse social identities and engage with people while acknowledging their intricate human nature, multiple identities, and individuality (Byram et al., 2002). In literature, the treatment of ICC closely parallels that of general communication competence but distinguishes itself by placing additional emphasis on the cultural context (Chen & Starosta, 1996). Spitzberg (1989) argued that the only aspect that shifts from general interpersonal to intercultural communicative interactions is the contextual parameters (Kim, 2017). Collier (1989) identifies four distinct approaches historically used to study ICC: ethnography of speaking, cross-cultural attitudes, behavioral skills, and cultural identity. Ruben (1989) emphasizes the significance of encompassing the multifaceted aspects of cross-cultural competence when conceptualizing this phenomenon. He underscores the necessity to differentiate between cross-cultural competence and related concepts such as adaptation and adjustment, all of which contribute to the complexity of the internal communication context (Arasaratnam & Doerfel, 2005).

Beyond effective and appropriate communication with others in general, ICC entails effectively and appropriately communicating with individuals who identify with specific physical and symbolic environments due to their cultural background (Chen & Starosta, 1996). The extent to which individuals' cultural backgrounds overlap can vary, with lower degrees of shared cultural context leading to higher levels of intercultural communication complexity (Gullestrup, 2003). The enhancement of intercultural competence is not solely an organizational responsibility; even the European Union is implementing programs aimed at improving the ICC of its citizens (Tkalac Verčič et al., 2021).

Intercultural competence holds great significance for communication practitioners because it aligns with the increasingly globalized and diverse nature of the world market (Commission on Public Relations Education, 2018). Within the realm of intercultural competence, one fundamental aspect is the cultivation of relationships with individuals and groups from various cultures (Deardorff, 2009), a principle that deeply resonates with a fundamental value in public relations: the development and maintenance of relationships (Cutlip et al., 1994). Additional facets of intercultural competence encompass the ability to comprehend the context and interconnectedness of diverse cultures, the capacity to transcend boundaries and bridge differences, and, most significantly, the importance of mutual respect (Deardorff, 2009). In the context of internal communication, ICC emerges as an indispensable asset, enabling organizations to navigate the diverse tapestry of their workforce harmoniously. By fostering an environment where employees can communicate effectively, understand one another's perspectives, and respect cultural differences, ICC cultivates stronger bonds among team members. Ultimately, it serves as a catalyst for enhanced collaboration, increased productivity, and a more inclusive and successful organization.

Suggestions for Global Internal Communication

As contemporary organizations navigate the complexities of globalization, deregulation, and economic crises, it is crucial to adopt a proactive stance to adapt and thrive (Tkalac Verčič, 2020). Here are some suggestions for practitioners and management to address the challenges and leverage the opportunities in global internal communication:

1. Embrace cultural sensitivity: As organizations expand globally, understanding and respecting cultural nuances become paramount. It is advisable to invest in cross-cultural training for employees, especially those in communication roles, to ensure messages are appropriately tailored and conveyed (Deardorff, 2009).
2. Build and maintain trust: Addressing the decline in employee trust requires transparent and consistent communication. Organizations should consider regular, open forums where leadership can communicate directly with employees, address concerns, and showcase transparency (Jiang & Probst, 2015; Grunig & Huang, 2000).

3. Leverage technology wisely: While embracing digital tools, it is important to balance technology use with human interaction. Implement training programs to enhance digital literacy and establish guidelines to prevent information overload. Explore and integrate technology like AI and chatbots judiciously to enhance, not replace, human interaction (Men & Bowen, 2016).
4. Prioritize inclusivity: Actively work toward creating an inclusive environment where diverse perspectives are recognized and valued. Encourage diverse teams to share insights and contribute to communication strategies, ensuring all voices are heard (Pless & Maak, 2004; Tkalac Verčič, 2019).
5. Adapt to new work dynamics: With the rise of remote work and digital collaboration, develop flexible communication policies that accommodate different working styles and locations. Regularly assess and update these policies to reflect the latest trends and employee feedback (Richter, 2020).
6. Manage information flow: To combat information overload, curate content carefully and prioritize clarity and brevity in communications. Implement systems that allow employees to filter and customize the information they receive.
7. Foster work-life balance: Recognize the importance of work–life balance in communication strategies. Respect boundaries and encourage practices that allow employees to disconnect and recharge, leading to more engaged and productive teams.
8. Stay ahead of global trends: Continuously monitor and analyze global trends affecting the workforce. Be prepared to adjust strategies swiftly in response to external factors such as economic shifts, technological advancements, or societal changes (Mishra et al., 2014).
9. Encourage continuous feedback: Establish channels for employees to provide feedback on internal communication efforts. Use this feedback to make iterative improvements and ensure that strategies remain effective and relevant.
10. Invest in ongoing development: Encourage continuous learning and development for communication practitioners. Staying updated with the latest communication trends, technologies, and best practices is essential for navigating the evolving landscape.

By considering these suggestions, organizations can better prepare for the future of global internal communication, ensuring they are equipped to handle the challenges and capitalize on the opportunities of an increasingly interconnected world.

Note

1. In this chapter terms internal communication and employee communication are used interchangeably.

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32

HYBRID WORK CONTEXT AND LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION

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The first studies on the evolution of the concept and practices of leadership according to the emergence of virtual work settings date back to the beginning of the millennium. Drawn by the new economy revolution scholars and practitioners began to reflect about different managerial models under the label of e-leadership. Then, the impact of COVID-19 has brought an extraordinary acceleration with remote working becoming the everyday experience of most employees. For managers being able to do their job of "leading other people" became a huge challenge to ingrained habits, behaviors, and beliefs. With the continuous spread of hybrid work contexts, where presence and distance, as well as the real and virtual, are more and more intertwined, there is a need to relaunch the debate about the concept and function of leadership.

The objective of this chapter is to explore how the concept of leadership is changing in the hybrid working environments, with a focus on the communication behaviors of leaders in their action of people management. Moreover, it proposes practical implications to inspire effective behaviors by managers operating in hybrid settings.

Adopting a multidisciplinary approach, this chapter is based on the analysis of four interrelated areas of managerial studies: e-leadership, virtual team management, communication in virtual settings, and the emerging field of hybrid workplace characteristics and dynamics.

Defining e-Leadership and Hybrid Workplaces

The need to rethink the traditional idea and function of leadership arose across the Millennium when the diffusion of Advanced Information Technologies and the rapid development of the Internet Economy determined the emergence of new ways of working in a context where information was easier to share and store, time and space stopped to represent a barrier, and communication processes were rapidly evolving (Torre & Sarti, 2020).

Researchers understood that the concept and practices of leadership were changing and they introduced the label "e-leadership" (DasGupta, 2011), which highlights the role of new technologies in communication processes (Avolio et al. 2000). They also noted the need for e-leaders to change the way they relate to employees, as they cannot count on physical presence, *de visu* communication, and non-verbal codes (Avolio & Kahai, 2003), as well as the relevance of being technologically savvy and able to effectively blend electronic and traditional methods of communication (Van Wart et al., 2019).

Before the pandemic, the challenges of e-leadership concerned a limited number of managers operating in large multinational companies and responsible for leading virtual teams across the globe (Sampat et al., 2022). Then, with the need to use social distancing as a sanitary prevention method and remote working as a highly diffused standard, many managers were caught unprepared by the new situation (Contreras et al., 2020).

It is possible to affirm that COVID-19 acted as an accelerator of structural changes in organizational and managerial processes that were on the table before its breakout (Hopkins & Figaro, 2021). First, the process of *digital transformation* opening "unprecedented opportunities to develop relationships and networks among people and organizations, questioning the traditional model based on hierarchy, separation from the outside, and physical presence in the office" (Mazzei, Quaratino, et al., 2023, p. 296). Second, the *growing stakeholders' pressure on companies to reduce carbon footprint and reach environmental sustainability* had already started a process of rethinking organizations able to limit traveling and commuting of employees to reduce emissions and to "help people to reach a better work-life balance, promoting a sense of autonomy and empowerment" (p. 296). Finally, hybrid workplaces seem able to address *broader social and cultural changes bringing new work values and identities*, as blurring of spatiotemporal boundaries related to when and where people work (Zapata et al., 2024), offering an attractive

proposal for many people appreciating the opportunity to be partially free to select how and where to work (Peprah, 2024).

So, how is it possible to define a hybrid workplace? Based on the literature (Hopkins & Figaro, 2021; Sampat et al., 2022; Peprah, 2023; Zapata et al., 2024), it is possible to identify the essence of the phenomenon in the following elements: (a) break of traditional time and space boundaries, combining remote working and on-site presence; (b) relevance of technology-mediated communication; (c) emergence of flexible organizational configurations; and (d) need for new managerial modes, beyond hierarchical "command and control" approach and based on promoting employees' autonomy and self-management.

Recently, Mazzei, Quaratino, et al. (2023) referred to hybrid workplaces "as a new place and time of work where presence and remote connection, physical and digital experience virtuously blend with the aim of maximizing the benefits of the two modalities for both the individual and the organization" (p. 297). In-presence working preserves the social and relational domain (e.g., interpersonal interactions, feeling of membership, cohesion), while remote working improves the operative and instrumental domain (e.g., efficiency, focus on tasks) (Mazzei, Quaratino, et al., 2023). To design such a balanced hybrid workplace, they propose an organizational and managerial model based on three key pillars. The first concerns leadership style and organizational culture and requires the development of new competences both for managers and employees; the second regards rethinking of physical spaces and time to optimize the balance between individual performance and motivation, and teamwork effectiveness; the third relates to technology implying investments in infrastructures and personal devices. The following paragraphs focus on the first pillar.

Emerging Challenges for Managers

According to research (Zapata et al., 2024), a wide array of challenges is emerging for leaders operating in a hybrid work context, trying to combine productivity goals with the well-being of their teams. They concern what we defined the social and relational domain on one side, and the operational and instrumental domain on the other.

Challenges regarding the social and relational domain are socialization of new hires; engagement and job embeddedness; cultural alignment and cohesiveness; preventing isolation and psychological safety.

Socialization of new hires. According to literature (Mazzei, Ravazzani, et al., 2023; Peprah, 2024), this process results less efficient and effective in a hybrid setting, where people need more time to be fully oriented into organizational ways and processes compared to when they fully work on-site. This is even more problematic with younger employees who receive less on the job mentoring and coaching from senior colleagues and bosses, and this lack of feedback might negatively impact both their integration and career development over time (Kane et al., 2021). So, it is important to carefully select supervisors for hybrid work settings, where the ability to understand when individuals and the team need to shorten the distance through face-to-face relations and direct interaction is fundamental (Torre & Sarti, 2020).

Engagement and job embeddedness. Within the context of a hybrid workplace, it becomes challenging for leaders to develop social interactions in their teams able to sustain trust and empathy among people. According to literature (Hopkins & Figaro, 2021), the consequence might be a working environment less prone to generate "job embeddedness", defined as a situation where individuals experience an array of ties deeply linking them to the organization and producing higher commitment and engagement. Avolio et al. (2014) suggest that more frequent on-line communication, based on a shared language, and planning emotional work events (e.g., tributes to colleagues, rallies) can highly increase the quality of leader–member relationships.

Cultural alignment and cohesiveness. When work settings become virtual to some extent, one of the implications is the difficulty to maintain alignment with corporate values, as people have fewer opportunities to experience and nurture the organizational culture (Hellwig & Murawsky, 2023). Spending less time together in the same place, the moments to share and celebrate successes decrease, the preservation of common language and habits gets harder, and the influence of some key variables in conveying cultural messages, as the design of physical spaces or the way people dress, turns weaker (Kane et al., 2021). Besides, organizations run the risk of developing two distinct company cultures separating onsite and offsite working employees, with the possibility of losing their sense of community, common identity, and shared purpose (Peprah, 2024).

Preventing isolation and promoting psychological safety. Contreras et al. (2020) stress the crucial role of e-leader's behaviors in relieving the physiological problems related to physical distance and its consequences on social interactions. In hybrid settings it becomes crucial to invest in

humanizing interpersonal dynamics from remote and in developing an inclusive social environment as much as possible. When people do not find a way to replace the "human touch" they experience onsite, they start to feel emotionally isolated and experience feelings of anxiety, despair, and psychological isolation, with an inevitable impact on their motivation and performance (Peprah, 2024). According to literature (Sampat et al., 2022), leaders should ensure employees' physical and mental health in the new hybrid setting through appropriate actions of involvement, care, support in self-management, and protection of their psychological safety, that is, the possibility to speak up and share aspects of their personal situations relevant to their work scheduling/location without risk of punishment or humiliation.

Challenges regarding the operational and instrumental domain include coordination and integration; knowledge sharing; and generating innovation.

Coordination and integration. According to Gratton (2021), one of the key emerging issues in managing a team in a hybrid setting is how to overcome the arising of place and time barriers to cooperation among people, thus preventing a dangerous drop in the quality of interactions and then in productivity. The more coordination with others is required, the more leaders should be able to ensure clear task assignment and effective integration of interdependent activities. Teams must be supported in developing appropriate practical strategies to limit the physiological break of effective communication and connection that a hybrid context implies, sustaining the processes of information sharing between coworkers and teambuilding (Hellwig & Murawsky, 2023). Planning a balanced alternance between remote and in presence activities, adequate online and offline coordination meetings, and shared rules for interacting becomes a crucial step (Zapata et al., 2024).

Knowledge sharing. Recent literature widely recognize knowledge sharing as a major challenge leaders must face when managing people and teams in partially virtual settings, where the habit of continuous daily in-person interactions fails (Hellwig & Murawsky, 2023; Zapata et al., 2024). In hybrid contexts barriers due to distance and asynchronous time tend to emerge causing a break in the organization knowledge transmission (Peprah, 2024). This break has an impact on team learning, that is, the increase in the level of knowledge and skills of a team, generated through collaboration, communication, and exchange of experiences among members. Less effective knowledge sharing can weaken team learning and thus its effectiveness in addressing unforeseen

scenarios, creatively approach complex problems, develop original knowhow, and adapt to new trends.

Generating innovation. The widespread capacity across the organization to produce innovation in business models, products/services, and operational processes is probably one the main asset to develop competitive advantage. According to literature (Zapata et al., 2024), some critical activities as strategic decision-making, complex negotiation, and innovation greatly benefit from being performed in person. When these activities are moved into a hybrid setting, they become more difficult. Concerning innovation processes, the main reason is that even though remote collaboration and social relations among members of a team are fine and smooth, in a hybrid context most serendipitous connections with the others drops off dramatically (Kane et al., 2021). When people meet online, they are much more focused, timely and efficient, but lose the chance to freely digress on different work related or even personal topics. Given that many creative ideas originate from casual and accidental communication between people with weaker ties, researchers (Chamakiotis et al., 2021; Hopkins & Figaro, 2021) suggest that leaders in hybrid settings should favor a network of informal and unstructured relations among team members able to be creative and innovative.

Key Competences for the New Leaders

To effectively address these challenges, leaders should rethink their role and functions inside organizations and groups, developing a new set of knowledge, skills, and attitudes coherent with hybrid workplaces, avoiding the shortcut of merely transposing conventional leadership competencies in the new settings where they risk being unproductive (Pullan, 2016; Contreras et al., 2020; Hopkins & Figaro, 2021). In contexts where time and space are no longer limitations and where new ways of communicating are emerging, leadership is inevitably transforming (Torre & Sarti, 2020).

Drawing upon scientific literature, it was possible to identify three founding functions leaders should preliminarily consider: sense-making, culture building, and mutual trust strengthening.

First, leaders should be fully aware of their role in guiding individuals and teams in the process of appropriation and sense-making of the new working technological and social context. Avolio and colleagues (2014), referring to the “Adaptive Structuration Theory”, affirm that

> people make sense of the social world around them by enacting micro changes that accumulate in major social and structural changes […] leaders are likely to be strong contributors to this sense making and enactment, for instance, providing an organizational vision.

So, leaders' interpretation of the new situation, the cognitive guidelines they provide, and their concrete actions have a powerful influence on employees understanding and future behaviors: "leaders can be role models" and send signals that legitimize followers' participation" (Avolio et al., 2014, p. 107). Similarly, Purvanova and Bono (2009, p. 346) affirm that in settings dominated by a sense of uncertainty and ambiguity, as the hybrid ones, "leaders are in a position to provide a sense of social context, to structure the work, and to create a sense of predictability and certainty".

Second, leaders should actively work on building a culture that is open to embrace new working settings inside their hybrid team; as a matter of fact, positive organizational culture helps reap the long-term benefits of hybrid working mode (Sampat et al., 2022). In this perspective, their ability to reshape the "psychological contract" with team members clarifying a new set of mutual expectations plays a crucial role. Zapata and colleagues (2024) suggest this process being more democratic than in traditional settings, with leaders actively involving employees in continuously revising the physical and virtual workplace design and collaboratively negotiating the organization and personnel needs. Several authors identified the distinguishing cultural traits leaders should focus on, as sharing with followers, stimulating active participation from employees, and promoting individual responsibility (Contreras et al., 2020; Li et al., 2021). It is widely shared that traditional hierarchical forms of leadership are less suitable in remote and hybrid workplaces, and many studies confirm the superiority of transformational over transactional leadership in facing the new challenges (DasGupta, 2011; Chamakiotis et al., 2021; Edelbroek et al., 2023). Recently, Hellwig and Murawsky (2023, p. 605) observed that in the new way of working "the traditional control-based managing structure dissolves and a relation of trust and autonomy arises".

Third, since seminal studies on e-leadership appeared (Cascio & Shurygailo, 2002; Avolio & Kahai, 2003), it was immediately clear that, even though trust is important for any team, in virtual settings it is more critical. At the core of effective leadership lies the capability to build

trusting relationships, and doing it without the help of nonverbal cues, direct supervision, and with less face-to-face interactions as in traditional teams, makes things more complicated. According to Zaccaro and Bader (2003, p. 382), the challenge consists in making people deeply identified with the leader and the other members because they trust that their beliefs and mutual expectations will be matched and "that each member will live up to agreed commitments, that each member is acting with good intentions on behalf of the group, and that each will work hard on behalf of the group". And when people are working in hybrid settings trust should be based more and more on visible and concrete actions than just on goodwill, because "goodwill is hard to observe virtually, expectations about actions and actions themselves need to be made as explicit as possible for all the others to see" (Malhotra et al., 2007, p. 61). Recently, Chamakiotis and colleagues (2021) explained this idea referring to the Chinese concept of "guanxi" that highlights the primacy of trusting interpersonal relations where leaders and team members invest in developing harmony, respect, reciprocity, and sense of shared responsibility for the team's goals and well-being.

Among the specific skills leaders should master in a hybrid working setting (Van Wart et al., 2019; Ahuja et al., 2023), communication competencies become critical as never before, as will be explained in the next section.

Leaders' Communication Competencies in the New Workplaces

Communication is one of the most relevant managerial competencies leaders can rely on to positively affect team members' performance, and its quality is a determinant of a group's success. Nonetheless, communicating in a hybrid working setting differs a lot from traditional in presence situations: when people at least partially operate geographically dispersed and with asynchronous timing, nonverbal communication cues and the chance to use informal communication approaches are limited, accidental conversations no longer exist, and the probability of misunderstandings and delays in information dissemination between leaders and members increases (Newman et al., 2020; Hopkins & Figaro, 2021). Moreover, the quality of communication from leaders is at the basis of building trust (Torre & Sarti, 2020), already identified as one of the three key pillars of leadership in hybrid contexts.

Evolution of Communication in Hybrid Work Context

An extensive literature developed in the last 20 years with the aim of understanding how the communication arena, inside both teams and organizations, is evolving with the emerging of new remote and hybrid working settings. Some interesting lessons can be derived from research on communication among fully virtual teams, a sort of "extreme version" of the today hybrid workplaces (Suchan & Hayzak, 2001; Hambley et al., 2007; Malhotra et al., 2007; Marlow et al., 2017).

The first peculiarity concerns the *limited feeling of the leader's presence*, which affects the "reach, speed, permanence, and perception of the leader's communication" (Avolio & Kahai, 2003, p. 327). In such a context, leaders lack some powers proper of physical observation and their listening becomes more complex, for example, interpreting the meaning of "electronic silence" as acquiescence or inattention (Malhotra et al., 2007).

The second specificity relates to *less face-to-face communication and a prevalence of computer mediated communication* whose impact has been carefully analyzed in literature (Purvanova & Bono, 2009; Marlow et al., 2017; Newman et al., 2020): a poorer communication in terms of nonverbal and paraverbal cues; increase of information loss due to simultaneous usage of multiple channels/devices; reduced feelings of social presence and conversational involvement; increase of cognitive and physical burden; loss of communication quality in terms of timeliness; more space for subjective interpretation of communication content in the case of written texts; higher possibilities for conflicts to rapidly escalate. According to Van Wart et colleagues (2019), insufficient and poor communication, miscommunication, and communication chaos potentially arising in this new communication arena are among the major challenges for leaders. They should adapt and change their way of communicating, aware that being successful in traditional face-to-face communication does not automatically transfer to the digital setting (Liu et al., 2018).

Finally, a digital workplace potentially promotes *employee voice and horizontal communication*, thanks to software for digital collaboration, inter-functional online communities, open debate on the intranet, or even quick and agile solutions as WhatsApp group and instant polls (Mazzei, Quaratino, et al., 2023). To take advantage of this situation, leaders should be able to sustain participation going beyond traditional top-down approaches and be competent in using cutting-edge technology.

Guidelines for Communication in Hybrid Work Context

So, what should communication competencies in hybrid workplaces look like? A comprehensive conceptual framework is proposed by Marlow and colleagues (2017) who identify the following variables of communication: frequency, quality (clarity, effectiveness, accuracy, and completeness), timeliness, close-loop (follow-up to ensure a message was received and understood), and content (either task-oriented or relational-oriented). Building on this framework and based on recent literature (Liu et al., 2018; Van Wart et al., 2019; Contreras et al., 2020; Newman et al., 2020; Li et al., 2021), it is possible to draw potential guidelines for the communication of leaders operating in partially or fully virtual settings.

First, ensuring *frequent individual and group communication* to positively affect team members working experience in terms of the quality of information exchange with the leader and among teammates. Second, *making communication the more predictable as possible*, providing accurate feedback whenever appropriate. Third, being *responsive and timely* in addressing questions, inquiries, and doubts from the team, avoiding relational silence. Fourth, taking care of *communication clarity*, establishing clear goals, tasks and roles, and promoting this way self-regulations and better accountability concerning member's performance. Fifth, *addressing not only the cognitive (information) but also the affective (emotion) dimension of communication*, choosing the appropriate strategy to satisfy recipients' desire in terms of customization, timing, and tone of voice. Sixth, building a communication setting where team members feel free and *psychologically safe* to participate, present their ideas, make their "voice" heard. Finally, ensuring a communication that is *authentic and transparent*, providing both positive and negative news, seeking team members' continuous feedback, and taking care of information truthfulness and its substantial value. Overall, following these guidelines leaders should be able to positively affect both people performance and engagement though their communication.

Communication Channels Choice

From an operational perspective, one key point regards the choice of the most suitable channels, tools, and technologies to communicate in a hybrid workplace. First, leaders should be aware that what they do before and after a meeting (online or offline) is particularly relevant for making

their communicative action continuous over time and keeping a sound relationship with team members once back in a remote setting (Cascio & Shurygailo, 2002). Second, leaders should be prompted to understand when a shift to a face-to-face dynamic is needed, privileging direct contact even though more expensive (Torre & Sarti, 2020), typically in the initial stages of the group lifecycle when it is crucial to develop trust among participants (Marlow et al., 2017).

Early studies on communication dynamics in virtualized workplaces (Suchan & Hayzak, 2001) underlined the importance of making a media choice coherent with tasks to be completed and typology of cooperation needed, even daily. According to Malhotra and colleagues (2007), defining clear communication norms and repeatedly revisiting them, as well as involving team members in decision, is equally important not only for ensuring coordination and task reporting, but especially renewing sense of purpose, shared identity, and motivating and inspiring people. Recent research (Contreras et al., 2020) stressed that, in selecting the best method to communicate in hybrid settings, leaders should consider at the same time the perceived quality of the tool and the receivers' preferences.

Literature (Hambley et al., 2007; Newman et al., 2020) identifies two key dimensions for guiding the operational choice of the communication medium coherently with the above-mentioned issues. On the one hand, according to "media synchronicity", it is possible to distinguish synchronous interaction when people communicate at the same time and in real time, as for example with videoconferencing and chat sessions; and asynchronous interaction with team members communicating at different times, such as in e-mail or threaded discussions. On the other hand, "media richness" refers to how different communication media affect task performance, with a rich medium allowing transmission of multiple verbal, nonverbal, and paraverbal cues; use of a natural language; immediate mutual feedback; conveying personal feeling and emotions.

In the new working setting, it is crucial for leaders to develop specific knowledge and competences about a conscious use of communication technologies (Liu et al., 2018), that is, smoothly switching across different tools and platforms, knowing how social media work, and exploiting the opportunity coming from the most recent digital suites for virtual cooperation.

Theoretical and Practical Implications

Based on literature a definition of hybrid workplace and its characteristics is proposed emphasizing the break of traditional time and space boundaries, the relevance of technology-mediated communication, the emergence flexible organizational configurations and the need for new managerial and communication competencies. In these new settings leadership function evolves, focusing on "appropriation and sense-making", on developing trust and promoting autonomy and responsibility among coworkers. Besides, the communication arena in which leaders operate profoundly change due to distance, asynchronous timing, loss of nonverbal communication cues, and fewer accidental and informal conversations. This increases the probability of insufficient and poor communication and miscommunication with an impact on managerial effectiveness.

From a managerial perspective, the implications are relevant. The need to take care of specific challenges concerning both the operative-instrumental and the social-relational domain of leader's action. They concern key organizational processes as coordination, knowledge sharing and innovation on the one side, and socialization of new hires, people engagement, cultural alignment, and promotion of psychological safety, on the other. The main concern for leaders should consist in avoiding the risk of disruption with people drifting apart in the hybrid workplace. To compensate this centrifugal thrust due to distance in space and time, leaders must intentionally and proactively plan their behaviors and create daily routines to stay in touch with people, listen to their needs, inspire their actions, and develop their engagement.

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EMPLOYEE ACTIVISM FOR SOCIAL IMPACTS

The Strategic Management and Relational Approach

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In recent years, we have seen how activism has raised awareness on certain social issues and brought impact across societies such as the Black Lives Matter movement (Marshall et al., 2024). From an organizational communication standpoint, organizational leaders can no longer ignore the role of activist groups in shaping and re-shaping organizational priorities. The 2020s could become the age of employee activism (Peachey, n.d.). Just before it began, a series of events have showed the signs. For example, the employee protests at Wayfair, an online furniture retailer, in 2019 illustrated the ability of employees to put pressure on their employers in taking a stance on controversial social issues (Hames, 2019). Wayfair employees walked-out of their offices as an expression of protest to the company when they learned that the latter sold furniture to migrant detention facilities. Also in 2018, Google fired three senior executives over sexual misconduct with one of them receiving a severance package of US$90 million. As a result, 20,000 Google employees in 50 global offices walked out protesting their company sexual harassment cases and the company's approach in handling these cases (Ghosh, 2018). Following these initial events of employee activism, it has become more common that employees actively voice out their concerns and disagreement on their employers' behaviors

against their values. Employee activisim has led to employees empowering themselves to mobilize and express their opposition to organizational policies and stance on broader social issues.

An activist public is "a group of two or more individuals who organize in order to influence another public or group of publics through action that may include education, compromise, persuasion, pressure tactics, or force" (Grunig et al., 2002). The current literature on activism has shown that most of the strategies in communicating and dealing with activists are mostly aimed at external activists in the society. For example, Weaver (2013) took the critical approach, articulated the organizing strategies and tactics for women activists in addressing gender issues. Research has also acknowledged the impact of activism that can bring positive changes to organizations (Villagra et al., 2021). There are different types of activists based on their relationship with the targeted organizations. For example, insider activists are the employees of the target organizations and outsider activists are those independent social movement publics or organizations (Briscoe & Gupta, 2016). Nevertheless, as much as research acknowledged the positive impact of external activism may have toward favorable organizational behavioral changes (Veil et al., 2015), there is a paucity of research that has looked into the impact of internal activists' behaviors on an organization and on society (Krishna, 2021).

Due to the rapid changes and development in the society, societal issues and problems have caused employees to shift their expectations toward their employers. Millennials and Gen Z, when compared to Baby Boomers and Generation-Xers, are more outspoken in spotting or criticizing their employers' behaviors over controversial issues affecting the society (Tyson et al., 2021). In specific, employees wish to see their employers' behaviors to match their values and expectations, and they expect their jobs to make contributions to the society (Krishna, 2021). We consider it is important to explore the impact of employee activism for the following reasons:

First, with increasing expectations for organizations to contribute to society, organizations realize the potential when employees are encouraged to demonstrate good corporate citizenship. From a social legitimacy theory perspective, organizations are considered as social entities with obligations to contribute to the welfare of the wider society (Mahmood & Humphrey, 2013; Margolis & Walsh, 2003). Organizations, in order to survive and maintain as legitimate operators, should not only be guided by organizational interests alone that

characterize corporate bourgeoisie (Aßländer & Curbach, 2014). Instead, organizations should act as corporate citizens that share responsibility with other civil society institutions in promoting well-being and societal welfare. Employee activism connotes employee expectation that their employers will align organizational priorities and objectives with societal expectations. It is important for these types of employees to see that their employers take a stand on societal issues as a means to demonstrate corporate citizenship.

Secondly, strategic management scholars (e.g., Leitner, 2014; Mintzberg & Waters, 1985; Mintzberg, 2008; Perot, 2023), in discussing the complex context of strategy formation processes, contended that organizations should adapt and revise corporate strategies in engaging with employees (Lee et al., 2022; Tolici, 2021). Employee activism demonstrates challenges for an organization's internal and external communication strategies because the senior management must consider how to address employees' demands before and after challenging organization's values is made public (Krishna, 2021).

Moreover, organizations, realizing the social expectations toward organizations, need to develop effective communication strategies to engage with the employees (Lee et al., 2022; Briscoe & Gupta, 2016) to enhance job performance (Jalalkamali et al., 2016), to ensure employees' well-being during a changing and difficult environment, and to motivate employees' organizational citizenship behavior (Santhosh & Baral, 2015). For example, Mazzei et al. (2019) described that an organization's communication engagement with employees lead to employees' prosocial communication behaviors such as corporate social advocacy, which meets employees' expectations of their organization's role in the society.

Therefore, the purpose of this conceptual paper is threefold: first, to discuss the rise of employee activism and its effect for enhancing organizations to bring social impact; second, to suggest the importance of incorporating employee activism in an organization's strategic planning; and third, to identify communication strategies for an organization to respond to employee activism for better employee engagement and organizations' address to social issues. Future research directions are also proposed at the end of this chapter.

The Rise of Employee Activism

Employee activism is defined as the "goal-oriented efforts organized and negotiated by individual and/or groups of employees to internally and/or externally advocate for or against organizational policy and/or decision making to generate social change" (Krishna, 2021). Rheinhardt et al. (2023) discussed the forms of activism such as citizen activism, organizational-change activism, and platform activism. Citizen activism, as what Briscoe and Gupta (2016) described "outsider" activism, refers to individuals participating in a social movement with the aim to make social changes (van Stekelenburg et al., 2019). The commonly used tactics involve street protests, demonstrations, and letter-writing campaigns.

From an organizational communication perspective, organization-change activism and organization-as-platform activism are related to employee activism. Organizational-change activism is about employees' participation in a social movement with the purpose to make changes in the workplace (Briscoe & Gupta, 2016). Employees involved in organizational-change activism also usually target issues relevant to organizational management and policies on wedges, benefits, and working conditions of employees, among others. The purpose for this form of activism is to make organizational changes (Rheinhardt et al., 2023), such as protests made by labor unions to advocate for employee welfare and benefits. Organization-as-platform activism refers to how employees use an organization's physical or symbolic features to communicate their messages about a social issue and to make changes. An example of this form of activism was the 2016–2017 NFL's "Take a Knee" movement. The protests were considered organization-as-platform activism because they took place during the pre-game national anthem ceremony of a football game for the players to show solidarity with the Black Lives Matter movement.

Summarizing the discussions on the forms of activism, employee activism involves the intention to bring organizational change (Krishna, 2021; Scully & Seagal, 2002) and to make social impact (Rouse, 2020). In reviewing the employee activism cases in recent years, we agree with Briscoe and Gupta (2021) that the focus of employee activism has been related to social and CSR issues and are deviated from labor union demands. As a result, we focus our discussions of employee activism on social issues.

With employee activism and employees' expectations on corporate responses on issues relevant to the society, it is risky for organizations to ignore such expectations because employees are prepared to leave the

company if they see no response from their organizations (Reitz & Higgins, 2022). Inaction is also considered an action when it comes to societal and employee expectations. Organizations should also recognize that it is the society that gives corporations the social license to operate (Demuijnck & Fasterling, 2016). To this end, it is essential for corporations to include the expectations from the stakeholders in an organization's strategic management process so as to develop business strategies and policies conducive to the organizations and the society. Business in this aspect should serve as "the activist company" (Eilert & Cherup, 2020, p. 46) to work with employees with expectations to be responsible corporate citizens for making changes in the society.

Strategies for Engaging Employee Activism

Lebas and Euske (2007) contended that there are dynamic and interacting factors that affect to what extent an organization can achieve its goals. Tolici (2021) outlined several factors driving an organization's performance that includes organizational culture, leadership, employee performance, stakeholder engagement, and relationship management, among others. Management scholars (see, e.g., Abdulkadir et al., 2012) advocate that an organization's strategic management processes informs an organization's ability to adapt to the changes brought by internal and external environmental forces. Mintzberg (2007) considered deliberate strategy (i.e., intended and is about control) and emergent strategy (i.e., unintended and learning from the process) to be organizations' strategic processes to adopt and respond to challenges in the business environment.

Taking from Mintzberg's (2007) thoughts, organizations may have developed intended strategies (deliberate) to interact and engage with the employees. Moreover, employees' values and expectations toward an organization's performance and operations can bring pressure to organizations to develop unintended (emergent) response strategies. As a result, for an organization's strategic management process, employees' perspectives, concerns, values, and voices should be heard and integrated when formulating organization's strategies (Tolici, 2021).

From an organizational perspective, employee activism can bring positive impact to organizations in terms of its ethical practices and contributing to corporate citizenship. Therefore, it is essential for organizations to take employees' expectations and voice into account in an organization's strategic management and develop appropriate

strategies. In this section, we will start with the discussion on strategic management of public relations and communication management and illustrate its relations to employee activism, followed by linking the selection of organizational strategies and strategic management in engaging with employees.

The Model of Strategic Management of Public Relations in Identifying Employee Issues

Kim et al. (2013), in applying Grunig et al.'s (2002) model of strategic management of public relations, discussed how an organization should address behavioral consequences from publics and from the organization itself, and how communication executives should participate in an organization's overall process of strategic management. This model depicted that, before an important decision is made, communication executives should consult with stakeholders to ensure responsible decisions that incorporate stakeholders' concerns and expectations can be attained. Public relations and communication executives therefore should engage with internal and external stakeholders because organizations' decisions will bring consequences to stakeholders, and/or organizations need the support from stakeholders in making decisions to ensure organizational goals could be achieved. The role of communication in this context is to continuously engage with stakeholders and to help identify issues and concerns from stakeholders in the business environment, including employees.

We consider employees as stakeholders that are critical to the success or failure of organizations. This perspective can also be applied to the employee activism context. Using this model to analyze the Wayfair case, the consequences were a two-way street. Before Wayfair decided whether the company would sell furniture to migrant facilities, the management could gauge views from different stakeholders, including the employees, and review the corporate values and culture on the legitimacy of such actions. Yet, the management's decision was against employees' values and triggered the walked out. From the rationale of the model, employees were dissatisfied with management's decision and, from the logic of the situational theory of publics (Grunig, 1992), these employees became active publics and decided to take actions to show their dissatisfaction. Hence, the behaviors of the employees brought consequences to the company and the management, and the walkout also

created an issue that got attention from the media and the politicians, such as Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez (Shankar & Roeder, 2019).

Two-way communication and relationship cultivation strategies are essential elements in the model of strategic management of public relations (Grunig et al., 2002; Kim et al., 2013; Yue, 2022). Whether it is at the stage when management is making decisions, when stakeholders are affected by those decisions, or when affected stakeholders are making an issue out of it, public relations and communication executives should keep two-way communication going and strive to cultivate collaborative relationships with the (affected) stakeholders.

The use of communication and relationship cultivation strategies in the model can be reflected in Mintzberg's (2007) deliberate and emergent strategies and van den Bosch and van Riel's (1998) bridging strategies. Mintzberg (2007) posited that deliberate and emergent strategies are at the two ends of a continuum of the real-world strategies. Organizations may plan a communication strategy that mainly focuses on one-way communication. However, this communication approach does not lead to positive and inclusive outcomes. Existing literature has suggested different relationship cultivation strategies (see Hung, 2004; Ki & Hon, 2009) in the context of organization–public relationships.

Organizations can adjust the dynamics in the interactions and the relationships with the stakeholders by utilizing different cultivation strategies to meet organizational goals. Organizations apply buffering strategies to prevent instabilities in the business environment; bridging strategies are used by organizations to adapt to the environment and to ensure organizations' behaviors conform to societal norms and expectations (Kim & Kim, 2016; Yue, 2022). Buffering strategies aim to keep stakeholders and publics at a distance, which is not conducive for relationship building. Conversely, bridging strategies help organizations to build relationships with the stakeholders and encourage collaboration. Yue (2022) contended that buffering strategies are organization-centric and designed with the intent to control and manipulate, while bridging strategies are symmetrical, relationship-based, and can be more effective than buffering strategies in communicating with employees.

Having discussed strategic management of public relations, we are focusing on how an organization can engage with employees via relationship cultivation as bridging strategies in the following section.

Communicating and Engaging with Employees

In any situation, whether it is daily organizational operation or when an organization is in a dire situation, communicating and engaging with employees is significant (Lee, 2021). From a strategic management of public relations viewpoint, communication and relationship cultivation allow organizations to collaborate with employees in addressing societal issues, which empowers employees in the process (Chen & Lee, 2022). Empowering employees is in synch with the rationale of bridging strategies. We are now exploring the strategies for working with employees in the context of responding to organizational behaviors and social expectations.

Relationship Cultivation. Employees are part of an organization and in the context of dealing with social movements, organizations should consider employees as partners and collaborators. We first discuss the construct of relationship cultivation, followed by cultivation strategies. Hung (2002, 2004) took Dindia and Canary's (1993) discussion on relationship maintenance and Baxter and Montgomery's (1996) dialectical perspective on the nature of relationship and coined the term, relationship cultivation in discussing the context of organization–public relationships. The dialectical perspective in relationship posits that there always are continuous contradictions and tensions (Montgomery, 1993) in the organizational context (Hung, 2004; Mitra & Fyke, 2017). Therefore, in the context of employee activism, which can cause tension and conflicts between an organization and its employees, the nature of the organization–employee relationship is changed. To keep organizational relationships healthy and positive, organizations should maintain open-mindedness in when responding to employee activism demands and behaviors.

The cultivation strategies with employees are those from Hon and Grunig (1999):

- positivity: organizational efforts to ensure employees enjoying and feeling content in their relationships with the organization,
- access: communication channels offered by organizations to employees,
- openness: being open and honest in sharing information and thoughts,
- sharing of tasks: organizations collaborate and work with employees in resolving problems,

- networking: organizations make effort to establish the same networks with the employees, such as environmental groups, and
- assurance of legitimacy: organizations acknowledge the existence of the employees and express commitment to maintaining the relationship.

These strategies have been commonly used in explicating different relational contexts between an organization and publics (e.g., Dong & Morehouse, 2022; Zeqiri, 2021). Additional strategies found from literature include keeping promises (organizations ensuring to deliver what they promise their employees) (Hung, 2002), vision/value communication (communicating organizational mission and value to boost publics' confidence), authentic communication (being true and honest in communicating with publics), empowerment (encouraging employees in different occasions of communication, e.g., conversations, decision-making process), and proactive reporting (keeping employees in the loop) (Chen & Lee, 2022; Men et al., 2017).

These cultivation strategies can serve as effective bridging strategies in the employee activism context. We agree that organizations should strive to bring positive impact to the society, and work to resolve societal issues. These cultivation strategies provide opportunities for organizations to partner and engage with employees in advocating societal issues, and this process can also strengthen relationships with employees. For example, in joining employees' actions for taking a stance on societal issues, organizations can utilize networking strategies to collaborate with employees in establishing partnerships with activist groups. In the strategy of access, organizations can ensure proper communication channels for employees to raise their concerns on organizational behavioral consequences affecting stakeholders and the society. In terms of positivity, organizations can encourage employees to speak up and make them feel that their concerns are heard and acknowledged.

These cultivation strategies provide the normal approach to how an organization should engage and communicate with the employees on societal issues. As we employed the dialectical approach in discussing these strategies, which shows the possible tensions and dynamics that may arise due to different values organizational management and employees hold, it could happen that either side refuses to cooperate and communicate. The strategic management model of public relations proposed by Kim et al. (2013) and Grunig et al. (2002) can provide a

possible solution in examining whether the engagement of employee activism is unable to achieve positive social impact. This model allows organizations to constantly conduct environmental scanning to understand stakeholder responses and reactions so that organizations are able to adjust their communication strategies to achieve their purposes of communication.

Future Research Directions and Conclusion

Having discussed employee activism and how it can affect organizations' role in the society and an organization's strategic management, strategies, and relationship cultivation with employees, we are suggesting the followings for possible future research directions.

Firstly, interested scholars may explore in-depth the dynamics of employee activism in relation to making impacts to the society, using a case study method that requires multiple sources of data. From the walkouts of Google and Wayfair employees, we have seen employee activism focusing on organizations' decisions opposing employees' values. However, the impact of their walkouts may not be extended to the societal level. Social impact is about "the consequence, real or perceived, on a social setting, that results from an organizational decision or action" (Hurst & Johnston, 2021, p. 2). It will be interesting to explore how employee activism results in organizations to be aware of their behavioral consequences to the society, and what actions organizations can take to address these impacts.

Secondly, the topic of corporate social advocacy has become more important nowadays. However, most of the research was done from the audience or consumer perspective (e.g., Song & Lan, 2022; Tsai et al., 2023). Another possible research direction is to take the context of organization-platform activism (Rheinhardt et al., 2023) to explore an organization's strategic management and position in partnering with their employees on issues of racial and gender equality, environment, poverty, social polarization, climate change, etc., and how organizations communicate such issues in the society.

Thus far, the strategic management model of public relations (Grunig et al., 2002) has been a conceptual model in literature. We encourage interested scholars to take this model for empirical research in combining strategic management, identifying the dynamic nature of the interdependent relations with employees, communicating views of values and expectations and cultivating relationships with them, and whether

such actions can lead to satisfying organization–employee relationships, favorable organizational reputation, and positive social impacts.

So far, as we agree with Krishna (2021), little communication research focuses on employee activism. In this chapter, in addition to discussing the nature of employee activism, we also linked this concept with how it can contribute to an organization's role in fulfilling corporate citizenship, and how an organization should consider employee activism in its strategy development and public relations' strategic management. We believe that employee activism can have positive organizational and societal influence. We also welcome more scholarly works taking sociopolitical approach to further examine the context of employee activism.

Finally, we consider it worth exploring the possible adverse effects when organizational management denies or ignores the pressure and demands from employees on social issues. The trends on employee activism have shown the issues employees care about most are relevant to CSR (Briscoe & Gupta, 2021). As we mentioned earlier, inaction to employee activism is also a kind of response. It is worthwhile to explore further possible negative consequences brought to an organization and its relationships to employees and the society when organizations dismiss and discourage employees' voices in expressing their views on social issues.

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FROM EMPLOYEE ENGAGEMENT TO WORKER VOICE

Communicative Dilemmas in Labor and Supply Chains in the Global South

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Worker voice has been a vital element of critical organizational communication inquiry over the last 40 years, and a crucial vector around which critical inquiry on employee engagement and participation has taken place. Scholars have examined not only what counts as workplace participation, who gets to participate, and what they get to participate about, but they have also emphasized the disciplinary and potentially disempowering aspects of such communication itself (e.g., Papa et al., 1997) and the importance of foregrounding the critical content of employee voice over employee engagement per se. Our goal is to engage anew with issues of worker participation and voice by broadening the terrain of inquiry to consider how workers and labor are communicatively embedded in global supply chains. This wider perspective helps reframe how we apprehend worker voice beyond single organizational containers. In turn this enables more complex views of how worker voices are systematically placed, offering more thorough analyses of worker exploitation systems *and* the potentially countervailing force of worker voice. Additionally, considering the place of worker voice in terms of supply chains helps dislodge theoretically hegemonic and problematically parochial examinations of both voice and

engagement, embedded as they are in US-centric organizational communication discourse.

We achieve this in two parts. We first build a framework appropriate for understanding communicative issues relating to employment and work in the Global South. We critically assess organizational communication research on participation and voice in the context of employee engagement, arguing for the need to employ terminology more conducive to critical analyses that center workers and labor. We then consider issues of voice in global labor hierarchies, focusing upon global commodity and supply chains. We consider worker voice as a simultaneously necessary and deeply problematic representational practice, arguing that we need to hold the communicative issue of voice in the midst of tensions between incorporation and disarticulation.

In the second half, we illustrate this framework through two cases. Our first case study animates how we deploy the concept of disarticulation and incorporation by focusing upon onion supply chains in India. Our second case employs the supply chain metaphor to critically review the place of labor in artificial intelligence (AI) technologies, treating AI itself as a supply chain. Here, we explore AI as emblematic of a central contradiction in efforts to incorporate employee voice in supply chains: the ultimate dispossession of workers from their data as voice is aggregated and centralized. In concluding, we address whether and how issues of voice might be placed as central in contemporary discussions about circularity and sustainability, and vexed questions about scale, vulnerability, and risk that inevitably accompany discussions about solutions and remedies to the ravages of global capitalism on work, life, and the planet.

From Employees and Engagement to Labor and Disarticulation

The term “engagement” is often foregrounded in studies of employee communication and can be considered one of the central backdrops of mainstream organizational communication research. Engagement is a polysemous term. A central preoccupation has been the connection between employee engagement and productivity, where engagement is seen to foster cooperation, collaboration, and innovation, and is often associated with such constructs as workplace commitment (Welch, 2011). Another central concern has been the place of engagement in organizational governance. Jiang and Shen (2023), for instance, showed

that increased organizational transparency leads to better employee and stakeholder engagement.

Critical work on employee engagement, however, often foregrounds the term participation over productivity or governance, and studies of worker voice are often explicitly situated vis-à-vis this concept. The literature on participation and communication at work is now legion (e.g. Cheney et al., 1998; Stohl & Cheney, 2001), and encompasses several different perspectives including postpositivist, critical, feminist, and postcolonial views of organizing. Most of these perspectives, like much scholarship in organizational communication studies, rely on insights generated from the Global North despite ongoing critiques of the Northern tilt of organizational communication research (Ganesh et al., 2024). Centers of intellectual imperialism tend to have tight citational networks, be based in particular universities, have discipline-like identities, and secure an identifiable canon and vocabularies that peripheries must adopt. So, while there are several studies of participation that are not based on insights drawn from empirical work in North America in particular, they tend to echo and extend dominant trends in research on participation (Stohl, 1993). Perhaps the earliest studies conducted outside the United States were those in the 1980s based on employee voice and participation in quality circles in Aotearoa New Zealand (Stohl, 1993).

The scope of participation research expanded greatly in the 1990s as scholars began to study nontraditional organizing situations, bringing voluntary and community participation and cooperative forms of organizing into its ambit, and taking a more explicitly critical turn. Here, such research began to take a prominent place in conversations about extant organizational communication constructs such as concertive control or cooperative organizing, while continuing inquiry on participation in industrial workplaces (e.g., Marshall & Stohl, 1993). The highly cited Grameen Bank studies of community participation in microfinancing underscored the extent to which forces of concertive control generate participation itself (Papa et al., 1997). Cheney's (1999) now-iconic work on the Mondragon cooperatives highlighted how participatory practices could be commodified and coopted into capitalism. These studies helped to also shape research on participation as being paradoxical and power-laden (Cheney & Stohl, 1999).

Work on participation stretching beyond US boundaries came into its own after the millennium (Stohl & Ganesh, 2014) and began to center issues of voice more as it developed a transnational and often Global

South-oriented imaginary. Consequently, such research began to develop and problematize theories and methods developed in largely US contexts. We trace at least four consequences of such expansion. First, a greater focus on the global organization of capitalism has led scholarship to emphasize the importance of workplace democracy and labor. Cheney and Cloud (2006), for example, argue that under conditions of global capitalism, worker participation research needs to explicitly account for conditions and possibilities for workplace democracy, especially given the tendency for capital itself to be seen as global while workers are seen as local and ultimately disposable (Cloud, 2001).

Second, the transnationalization of organizational communication studies of participation and voice has been greatly enhanced in the last two decades by studies done under the rubric of the culture-centered approach (Dutta, 2012), where a major concern has been to examine the communicative conditions and infrastructures that might facilitate the expression of subaltern voice and to treat as central the need for researchers to develop relationships in solidarity with marginalized communities under study (Ganesh et al., 2021), and knowledge and voice itself as dialogically co-constructed (Dutta, 2012). In the process, issues of participation and voice have been seen as intrinsically related to processes of resistance and change.

Third, and inevitably, transnational work has begun to foreground issues of colonialism and empire in the transnational organization of work. Broadfoot and Munshi (2007) center voice as a precondition for participation, arguing for researchers' need for a postcolonial reflexivity to create an epistemic foundation upon which listening is the first activity or basis for postcolonial organizing praxis. Cruz and Sodeke (2021) likewise "advocate for intersectional thinking that considers the interlocking of Eurocentrism with other systems of oppression" (p. 15) to center disenfranchised voices.

Fourth, as organizational communication scholars have centered voice more and more in their examination of participation and labor under global capitalism, they have moved far beyond single-site and container-based models of organizing in their work. While some scholars have examined social justice and labor organizing in such contexts as global food insecurity (Scharaedly et al., 2020), others have begun to focus upon cross-border and transnational supply and commodity chains in which worker voice is dis/embedded (Zoller et al., 2020).

Disarticulation, Incorporation, and Global Supply Chains

Supply and commodity chain analysis is particularly important in Global South contexts because the impact of the global economy is visibly instantiated through these chains. Through the colonial state's emphasis upon building capacities, entire countries have been arranged at the manufacturing peripheries of global capitalism. How can one conceive of participation and voice in such vast contexts? Two concepts from supply and commodity chain analysis are particularly helpful in thinking through the im/possibilities of voice and participation: incorporation and disarticulation.

Scholars of transnationalism have spent considerable energy unpacking the historical dynamics of national and subnational incorporation into the world capitalist system, focusing upon issues ranging from livelihoods and migration on one hand, to military conquest and trade treaties on the other (Chin, 2017). Incorporation is more than an economic attachment between fully formed subjects and capitalism; it is the construction of diverse populations into particular subject positions and identities such as workers, laborers, or peasants, and their subsequent domestication and marginalization. In the context of indigenous studies and politics, scholars have commented on the role that the developmental state plays in rearranging formerly nomadic tribes from "people in place into nodes in networks" creating systems of dependence (Ganesh, 2018).

Incorporation, however, is always ongoing. Michael Dove illustrates how the erosion of indigenous community autonomy is never complete. While on one hand, the granting of "rights" to indigenous communities is in many ways their subservience to a larger system (Agarwal, 2005), on the other, indigenous ways of life, modes of being, and worldviews are remarkably resilient and difficult to stamp out. Considering issues of voice and participation in the context of global capitalism can be productively problematized in Global South contexts by the notion of partial incorporation, a construct that draws attention to the simultaneous structural subservience to and disinvestment from the global economy, of subaltern subjects.

The concept of disarticulation is closely linked to issues of incorporation. Amin (1976) posits that disarticulation refers to the process whereby systems of production are detached from their local economic connections and networks and reattached and readjusted to meet the needs of global systems of production, distribution, and consumption. Disarticulation prevents "the transmission of the benefits

of economic progress from the poles of development to the economy as a whole" (p. x). Bair and Werner (2011) have usefully placed the concept of disarticulation in tension with the logic of conventional supply chain analysis.

When placed next to the notion of incorporation, a duality emerges in the concept of disarticulation: through supply chains, labor is disarticulated from local economies and incorporated into global production processes; yet, problematizing how subjects are incorporated as labor involves actively incorporating and subjugating prior identities into employees, participants, supplicants, or laborers. Hence the question: What does employee voice look like in global supply chains when we see it both in terms of incorporation as well as disarticulation?

We address this question through two case studies, both originating in the Global South. The first case, focusing on onion supply chains, helps animate and illustrate the concept of disarticulation and its relationship with incorporation. As such, onions as a product represent an archetypal supply chain with a tangible material product, identifiable labor and relations of production and consumption. In contradistinction, our second case focuses on AI, and takes the unusual step of seeing AI itself as a supply chain to discuss the potential countervailing communicative force of worker voice to resist disarticulation.

Tears of Onion Labor: Disarticulations in Onion Supply Chains

Supply chains are interconnected networks stretched across the world, linking raw materials, manufacturers, distributors, and consumers that allow businesses across all sectors to procure various kinds of goods and services. More specifically, agricultural supply chains involve a set of activities in the "farm-to-fork" sequence such as farming (cultivation of land and crops), processing, testing, packaging, warehousing, transportation, distribution, and marketing (Tsolakis et al., 2014). The commodity chain and supply chain scholarship grapples with "inclusionary bias" that is inclined to prioritize tactics for incorporating and implicating more people, places, and commodities in the call for development while disregarding concurrent exclusionary practices (Bair & Werner, 2011, p. 989). In this section, we investigate the interplay between inclusion through incorporation and disarticulation of labor voices in the larger agricultural economy through an ethnographic case study of an onion supply chain.

The onion, a seemingly mundane item on grocery lists, has gained a contentious reputation in India due to its vulnerability to intense price fluctuations and sensitivity to the whims of the market. On average, India produces 24 million metric tons of onions annually, which has significant impacts on market economies both nationally and globally. The onion supply chain in the state of Maharashtra, which accounts for 30% of the onion production of the country, is particularly unique, especially the chain that travels through the Nashik district, which itself accounts for 21% of the onion production of the country (APEDA.gov, 2022). Onion production and supply issues are known to consistently instigate political hostilities and public outcry over rising prices.

One example of incorporation in tension with disarticulation is that of the linking and delinking of women workers in the onion supply chain. Supply chains and commodity chains are not "black boxes"; rather they constitute complex social relations that intersect with local norms of gender and labor. Studies adopting a feminist frame of analysis seek to demystify the movement of commodities in supply chains by making visible the social reproduction of labor and unveiling the unpaid, unmeasured work that goes into keeping communities and households afloat (Dunaway, 2014). In the onion chain, women workers participate in diverse production, harvesting, and post-harvesting activities such as planting, tilling, cleaning, sorting, packing, and even sewing gunny sacks used for packaging onions all while managing their households, balancing multiple identities as homemakers, farmers, and laborers. While women have multiple entry points for participating in the chain, due to the gendered nature of division of labor, there is not much scope for upward mobility or upgrading their value. Field observations and conversations indicate that women's participation in the chain is fluid and marked by the dialectic of (de)attachment. Some women stay home to take care of young kids but remain linked to the chain by participating in the sewing economy and earn piece rate wages for stitching gunny bags. Other women participate more directly by working at a godown/warehouse, sorting and packing onions, which is physically more demanding.

Additionally, some women engage in farm work mostly on other farmers' land where they work as laborers. As seasons alter, so does the nature of the work which can temporarily sever their connection with the chain as explained by a worker, "for four months (or during the planting season) we replant the saplings, and for the rest of the year we find other jobs on the farm, and if we get nothing, there is no other option but to

stay at home". Women's participation in the chain is precarious and dependent on multiple externalities:

> see that woman over there, her leg is cramped and swollen and despite that she is here to do this work. After all this work, if the crop rots away [damaged due to hail or excess rain], then it's a disaster for the farmer, and we won't get more jobs if the production is low, but if the farmer gets a good price, they are able to help us out too.

One of the critical components of the onion supply chain is jute gunny bags/sacks, which are used to pack and secure the produce before it goes for local and global distribution. This work is a production of articulations that forges links of participation across various forms of labor (e.g., household, waged, volunteer). Upon being asked why they participate in this production practice, the elderly woman said:

> to run the household, we use the money to buy groceries, and other essentials. It's not much (the earnings from sewing the bags), we can hardly get enough vegetables to sustain two people. But it's better than doing nothing all day as I cannot work in the warehouse, it's physically hard, so this is a better alternative.

Women usually sew about 200–300 bags in a day. Despite the advent of machinery that stitches and assembles these bags faster and cheaper, the bags sewn by hand are more durable, sturdy, and less likely to tear during handling, making them preferable over machine made. Currently women are paid a meager 70 paise per bag (or 70 cents), 70 rupees for 100 bags sewn. Usually, the traders play a big role in deciding the prices and it is an uphill battle for women to negotiate an increase in the wages to keep up the increasing inflation. Thus, participation of women in supply chains is partial at best and is often fraught with exploitative relations of production and consumption. Having highlighted how incorporation and disarticulation work to produce worker incorporation and participation as a deeply problematic practice, we turn now more directly to the question of worker voice, examining AI using a supply chain metaphor.

AI as a Supply Chain

The term "Artificial Intelligence" often brings to mind disembodied and digital computer programs that perform activities automatically and

seamlessly, independent from human intervention. Yet, in reality, AI is deeply reliant on human labor—performed by workers often located in the Global South, where data are produced, extracted, and refined. As Adam Zewe (2023) explains, when people talk about AI, they are typically referring to machine-learning models that "learn to make predictions based on data" (Zewe, 2023). For example, AI that performs object recognition or facial recognition does so through likeness: something or someone is similar to closely related others of that type. Generative AI—the class of AI technologies that includes ChatGPT and Dall.E—uses more advanced models to produce new[1] text or images, but this has only deepened their indebtedness to data that inform their outputs.[2]

AI that is capable of automatically recognizing content has to be trained on thousands of examples, which have been categorized and labeled by people. In *Inside the AI Factory*, journalist Josh Dzieza (2023) details his experience as a professional "data annotator" for a platform that enables English-speaking people throughout the world to do data annotation work remotely. Their combined labor produces enormous labeled datasets for their parent company, the data vendor ScaleAI, which are sold to clients (including OpenAI) that produce AI. In *Data Feminism*, Catherine D'ignazio and Lauren Klein (2023) refer to relationships like these as part of a "data supply chain". Data must be created, collected, and processed before they can become an AI product. These labor efforts rarely occur in-house at a single organization; instead, they are distributed through the various working arrangements and hand-offs that characterize other types of supply chains.

Dzieza (2023) observes that data are mostly digital supply chains that can be "endlessly and instantly reconfigured, moving to wherever there is the right combination of skills, bandwidth, and wages". This malleability means the chain is often linked through the impermanence of contracts (Posada et al., 2023). AI technology companies based in Silicon Valley give short-term contracts to employers in places like Nairobi, which themselves employ workers in Kenya through project-specific contracts. For on-demand data workers, the availability of tasks is unsteady and unpredictable (Ingram, 2023). The instability is exacerbated by the culture of the technology industry more broadly—where risks and rewards (once shouldered by corporations) are individualized in the name of entrepreneurship (Neff, 2012). Yet, the labor conditions of data workers stand in stark contrast to the high-status,

high-perk, and high-pay on the other end of the supply chain where employees design, program, and engineer AI (Irani, 2021).

It is not accidental that data annotation tasks are typically out-sourced to locations in the Global South. Critical technology studies scholars Chaar López and Sánchez (2024) observe in their case study of Sama that the company was explicitly founded to incorporate marginalized workers into the technology industry—an ethics-driven employment strategy called "impact sourcing". Yet, Chaar López and Sánchez argue that this strategy brings primarily Black and non-white workers into the lowest tiers of the technology labor hierarchy, where they are conscripted to care for the digital infrastructure that the rest of the world relies upon. This is just one instantiation of the extractive economy of AI. It withdraws resources—both raw materials and labor—from places and people in the majority world[3] to enrich the lives of people elsewhere (Amrute et al., 2022).

The task of data annotation is described by workers as ranging from "very boring" (Dzieza, 2023) to "tortuous" (Perrigo, 2023a, 2023b). Yet, the series of hand-offs that characterize AI production processes diminish the sense of agency—and responsibility—felt by AI engineers for what happens across the supply chain (Widder). Miriam Posner (2021) argues that this unknowability is a functional feature, not a failure, within supply chains. Gaps in understanding provide "critical cover" so corporations can distance themselves from ethical issues that emerge in production. For data annotation workers, information about how their work connects to the AI supply chain is deliberately withheld. They work on projects with nonsensical codenames distributed by subcontractors who do not disclose their payers. Workers state that this secrecy inhibits their ability to build their skills and establish an occupational identity (Dzieza, 2023).

What Does Worker Voice Offer as a Countervailing Force in the AI Supply Chain?

In a front-cover feature story in *Time* magazine, Manu Chopra recalls his reaction visiting a cramped data-annotation center in India, full of workers paid under 40 cents an hour: "I thought, this cannot be the only way this work can happen" (Perrigo, 2023a, 2023b). Chopra subsequently co-founded the start-up Karya, which is dedicated to producing linguistic data in languages, like Kannada, that are spoken by millions of people worldwide but are disproportionately absent from the

web. Karya pays workers well above the prevailing minimum wage and distributes royalties every time the datasets they contributed to are sold. Beyond better working conditions, Chopra argues that this approach produces a better product—reporting a less than 1% error rate.

Technology companies that make a sustainable level of profit *and* offer fair compensation for workers reflect a business philosophy known as "the double bottom line" (Gray & Suri, 2019). Although it is "perfectly legal and understandable" for companies to maximize profits through employment terms that position workers as no different than customers in a labor marketplace, it is also entirely possible to treat them as an essential aspect of business success (p. 143). Karya offers an example of an organization where the voices of workers—both literally and figuratively—are valued in their contributions. However, as voice is incorporated into the supply chain, it is ultimately aggregated into a data-product that is centralized and distanced from the decision-making power of any one contributing individual or collective. Yet, the *Time* profile also acknowledges that the workers for Karya have limited understandings of the AI technologies to which they are contributing. Critical computing scholars Miceli and Posada (2022) argue that the atomized organization of data work produces not only data but also a type of worker. Data annotators are alienated from the products of their labor and are made immobile within the technology industry. "Kept apart from the rest of the Machine Learning production chain…they are given no opportunity to rise socially or professionally in terms of salary or education" (p. 30). Though documentation of working conditions is often treated as the solution to ethical supply chain production, the very organization of a supply chain protects the routinization of work and deskilling of labor, which produces alienated workers (Ganesh, 2024).

Employee voice in AI supply chains requires not just recording or even remunerating worker's inputs, but supporting what Ramasubramanian and Dutta (2024) refer to as "purposiveness"—the ability to determine how and where one's data is shared. Data workers need informed understanding of the projects they are contributing to and the ability to decline inclusion when datasets are sold. Employees across the technology industry are struggling to realize similar types of creative determination. In campaigns such as #techwontbuildit and #notechforICE, thousands of tech workers have organized in an attempt to cancel corporate contracts with organizations they view as abusing human rights (Costanza-Chock, 2020). As Miceli (2023) observed in commentary on *Time's* Karya story, "AI is always by the people. Before

saying it's for the people, we need to question the technologies in which it is put to work".

Conclusion

In this essay we have situated the importance of worker voice in the context of supply chains to juxtapose it with conceptions of employee engagement and resituate voice from the confines of particular organizational settings to broader production and consumption circuits in capitalism (i.e., commodity and supply chains). We have shown that worker voice as a communicative construct represents a potentially deeper level of empowerment and agency for workers in supply chains. In the process, we have highlighted how the concepts of incorporation and disarticulation are key analytical tools in radicalizing how we conceive of voice and lift the concept beyond the confines of particular organizational boundaries. By examining how systems of production and labor are attached and detached to supply chains, we can derive a nuanced understanding of the countervailing potential of worker voice to contend with contemporary capitalist inequities.

In closing, we offer two suggestions for further inquiry. For one, we suggest that worker voice be considered explicitly in terms of current debates about sustainability and circularity in the global economy. Current conceptions of circularity in sustainability tend to privilege environmental regeneration as the main goal of sustainability, over economic and social inequalities. Focusing on how worker voice can be communicatively amplified and circulated throughout supply chains has considerable potential not only in addressing issues of economic and social unsustainability but also in broadening the concept of circularity itself to include redistribution as well as regeneration (Palakshappa et al., 2023). Second, and relatedly, reconsidering worker voice at the level of supply chain analysis helps us explicitly tackle issues of scale, vulnerability, and risk in addressing issues of environmental and social change. It is well known that upstream actors in global supply chains, including miners, farmers, garment workers, and data laborers experience considerably more precarious and vulnerable work conditions than downstream actors located in the Global North. Focusing on how worker voice can be heard across the chain will go a long way in beginning to address fairly intractable problems related to extraction, financialization, exploitation, and environmental degradation.

Notes

1. The newness of generative AI outputs is a topic of debate, as outputs closely resemble the existing images and text in their datasets (Marcus & Southern, 2024).
2. Much of the data that was used to train ChatGPT had been scraped from public websites, as freely-available examples of sentence structure. It is worth noting this content is also the product of someone's labor and the authors were neither compensated for, nor consented to, inclusion in ChatGPT's dataset (see Li et al., 2023).
3. This descriptor represents a shift in standpoint, recognizing that "the majority of the world's human's population lives in geographic regions–variously addressed as 'the Developing World,' the 'Third World,' or the 'Global South'" (Amrute et al., 2022, p. 2).

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35

BELONGING AT WORK

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Belongingness, deeply rooted in psychological scholarship, plays a pivotal role in human motivation. A sense of belonging occurs when people feel like they are an integral part of a system or environment (e.g., Hagerty et al., 1992). Abraham Maslow (1943) included "love and belongingness" in his renowned hierarchy of needs. Psychologists Baumeister and Leary (1995) describe the need to belong as a pervasive drive for positive interpersonal relationships. Beyond social affiliation, belongingness shapes well-being, behavior, and interactions. Recognizing the power of belonging is crucial for fostering inclusive environments where everyone feels valued and connected.

Traditionally studied in social settings, the concept of belonging has gained attention within the workplace as a key factor in employee satisfaction and retention. This is particularly timely in the wake of the global pandemic, social unrest, economic disruption, and subsequent workplace shifts. As organizations navigate these challenges, cultivating belongingness among employees is essential. This chapter delves into the why and how of cultivating workplaces where every employee experiences a strong sense of belonging.[1]

Review of Literature

Factors of Belonging at Work

Research consistently reports factors associated with a sense of belonging in the workplace. These include being recognized for unique contributions, feeling connected to coworkers, receiving support for

daily work and career development, and feeling proud of the organization's values and purpose (Argo & Sheikh, 2023; Bordeaux et al., 2021; Chung et al., 2020; Coqual, 2020). Additional factors include open and honest communication, valuing every team member, authenticity at work, and the belief that everyone can succeed—regardless of their identity (BetterUp, 2020; Coqual, 2020).

Psychological safety, where organizational members feel safe to express their perspectives without fear of humiliation or punishment, is essential for fostering belonging (Edmondson, 2018). In this environment, employees feel empowered to share ideas, ask questions, and admit mistakes, which facilitate creating a more inclusive workplace. While important for all employees, psychological safety is particularly valuable in diverse workplaces where individuals may hesitate to speak up due to societal norms and assumptions. Without it, underrepresented groups may refrain from sharing dissenting views or innovative ideas, hindering collaboration and innovation. Prioritizing psychological safety enables everyone to contribute meaningfully and to benefit from diverse perspectives (McCausland, 2023).

A study in the pharmaceutical industry examined how psychological safety impacts performance in diverse teams (Bresman & Edmondson, 2022). Findings showed a negative association between diversity and performance on average. However, psychological safety moderated this effect. Teams with high psychological safety exhibited a positive association between diversity and performance, while teams with low psychological safety showed a stronger negative association between diversity and performance. These findings support the potential for psychological safety to unlock the potential benefits of diverse teams, although a need exists for further research across industries.

Feeling like an insider or an outsider is another crucial aspect of workplace belonging (Bond, 2022). Everyday communication helps to shape this perception. Exclusive language—such as inside jokes, references to events that only select members attended, or jargon understood only by specific groups—subtly signals who belongs and who does not. Exclusive cliques create social divisions and isolate those left out. Consistently interrupting, dismissing, or ignoring certain individuals signals that their ideas do not matter. Limited cultural awareness, like assuming everyone celebrates the same holidays, makes people feel unseen and excluded. These behaviors can create an outsider feeling, reinforce harmful stereotypes, and make employees question their place within the organization.

In the quest for workplace belonging, underrepresented employees can face barriers driven by unequal access to information and opportunities. When colleagues or leaders gate keep knowledge, even unconsciously, they erode underrepresented employees' sense of belonging. For example, withholding information about available mentorship opportunities limits their access to guidance and support. Biased task assignments reinforce power structures, excluding these employees from full team integration. These types of exclusion fuel a cycle of negative consequences: underrepresented employees may withdraw from professional development opportunities out of a confirmed fear of not belonging, which may hinder their career advancement. Conversely, members of dominant groups often experience effortless insider status, connecting easily with colleagues who share their background (Bond, 2022). This effortless inclusion further reinforces their sense of belonging and potential for advancement, widening the gap between "insider-outsider" groups.

Othering, the process of defining individuals or groups as different and therefore excluded from the dominant "norm", significantly undermines workplace belonging (Anjorin & Busari, 2024; Gallegos & Surasky, 2023). An "us" vs. "them" mentality fueled by judgments of superiority and inferiority (Dervin, 2016) leads to labeling and potential stigmatization of those perceived as "other".

Othering can manifest in numerous ways, stemming from differences in race, ethnicity, gender, sexual orientation, religion, job function, or even personality (Carter et al., 2024). It serves as a way for individuals to reinforce their own sense of belonging by defining who does not fit in (Anjorin & Busari, 2024). For example, in male-dominated tech companies, female engineers often find themselves subtly othered (Alfrey & Twine, 2017; Wilson & VanAntwerp, 2021). Colleagues may dismiss their ideas in meetings and overlook their contributions, leading to feelings of doubt and a diminished sense of professional belonging. This continuous exclusion reinforces the sense of being "different", eroding trust and hindering collaboration and job satisfaction.

Research consistently shows that members of underrepresented groups are at higher risk of feeling a lack of belonging in the workplace (Alfrey & Twine, 2017; Carter et al., 2024; Wilson & VanAntwerp, 2021). This manifests as exclusion from both professional and social opportunities. Members of these groups may engage in "covering" behaviors to "downplay known disfavored identities to blend into the mainstream" (Stephane et al., 2023, p. 1). They might change their

appearance, avoid members of their group, minimize certain behaviors to negate stereotypes, or refrain from advocating for their group (Yoshino, 2006). This coping strategy has significant drawbacks. It reinforces inequality and places the burden of belonging on the individual rather than creating a truly welcoming workplace. Moreover, the constant emotional labor of covering one's identity can take its toll, leading to negative consequences for both the individual and the organization. Although research persistently shows that members of dominant and non-dominant groups engage in covering, non-dominant groups report higher rates (Stephane et al., 2023).

A study examined how various identities affected feelings of belonging at work (Coqual, 2020). Employees of color, particularly Black and Asian women, reported feeling more like outsiders than white counterparts. Parents reported a stronger sense of belonging than those who did not have children. Another study confirmed these trends, finding higher belonging scores among older, higher-socioeconomic status employees, parents, and heterosexual individuals compared to those identifying with other genders or sexualities (BetterUp, 2020).

A research project examined disclosure behaviors among members of minority religious groups in the workplace (Charoensap-Kelly et al., 2020). Participants included U.S. adult workers from diverse religious backgrounds, age groups, and geographic locations. The findings revealed a strong positive association between **s**ense of belonging and the anticipation of benefits related to disclosing one's religious identity. Participants who felt a stronger connection to their workplace were also less concerned about the risks associated with self-disclosure. Consequently, they were more likely to share their religious affiliations openly.

This research sheds light on the intricate relationship between belonging and the often-invisible aspects of employees' identities. The anxiety surrounding whether to reveal stigmatized identities at work significantly impacts communication dynamics. Self-disclosure, a powerful tool for self-affirmation and social bonding, plays a pivotal role in this context (Charoensap-Kelly et al., 2020). Thus, these findings have broader relevance for any marginalized groups in the workplace whose identities may not be immediately apparent.

Responding to work-related changes that occurred during the pandemic, a study examined how the shift towards remote, hybrid, and onsite work models impacts employee belongingness (Dalessandro & Lovell, 2024). Surprisingly, the workspace itself (remote vs. in-person)

had no significant effect. However, the study revealed that age, pay structure (hourly vs. salaried), and "minority" status impact feelings of belonging. Notably, minority employees (e.g., people of color and LGBTQ individuals) who were working remotely before the pandemic felt a greater sense of belonging. The findings imply that workplace flexibility, particularly the option for established remote work, might enhance feelings of belonging in groups.

Benefits and Costs of Belonging

Fostering a culture of belonging benefits both employees and organizations (BetterUp, 2020; Coqual, 2020; Komisarof, 2021). Employees who feel valued demonstrate higher job satisfaction, engagement, productivity, innovation, collaboration, and loyalty. Belonging creates psychological safety, reducing conflict and exclusion. Conversely, low belonging harms employees, leading to disengagement, isolation, career stagnation, decreased performance, increased stress, lowered morale, and a higher likelihood of seeking employment elsewhere. As discussed earlier, these effects are often amplified for members of non-dominant groups.

Organizations with strong belonging cultures see greater efficiency, productivity, and improved employee retention, resulting in lower absenteeism and turnover costs. They also attract top talent and enjoy increased customer satisfaction due to engaged employees. They are more likely to attract and retain diverse talent who offer invaluable perspectives related to the organization's mission. A strong sense of belonging also helps to remove barriers that hinder underrepresented individuals from advancing (e.g., by validating their identities and valuing and respecting their unique perspectives and experiences). Overall, these organizations foster higher performance, greater innovation, and a more positive culture.

Neglecting belonging can be costly to organizations (Bordeaux et al., 2021). They may experience high turnover, absenteeism, decreased productivity, and increased recruitment costs. These issues damage overall culture, lower morale, and reduce team cohesion. Such organizations may struggle to attract talent and face legal costs from discrimination or harassment claims. Neglecting to foster belonging hinders overall success, affecting both financial and non-financial metrics. From revenue and profit margins to reputation and community engagement, organizations suffer when they do not prioritize belonging.

A final area of benefits and costs of belonging for organizations is their commitment to diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI; Coqual, 2020). DEI are essential components for promoting a sense of belonging. Numerous resources provide compelling justification for prioritizing belongingness along with DEI efforts (Carr et al., 2019). They cite belongingness as a bridge that connects DEI efforts to the benefits of fostering a sense of belonging. For dominant group members, DEI and belonging (DEIB) initiatives foster self-awareness and cultural competence. This leads to greater empathy, improved collaboration, and expanded networks. For non-dominant group members, belonging creates psychological safety, allowing them to contribute unique viewpoints and perspectives.

When organizations fail to prioritize DEI and belonging, everyone suffers. Dominant group members may remain unaware of their biases, limiting their ability to communicate effectively and adapt in a diverse workplace. For non-dominant group members, a lack of belonging can signal an unwelcoming environment, hindering their participation and the organization's potential to benefit from their unique perspectives. Without a strong culture of belonging, organizations struggle to attract and retain diverse talent, negatively affecting overall success.

In summary, an expanding body of research underscores the pivotal role of cultivating workplace belonging. A strong sense of belonging is demonstrably linked to employee well-being, engagement, retention, and organizational success. These studies also reveal a reciprocal link between belonging and DEI. By fostering a sense of belonging, organizations unlock a host of benefits. Therefore, organizations should proactively invest in initiatives that prioritize belonging as a fundamental part of their success strategy.

Promising Practices

To fully realize the benefits of a workplace where everyone feels valued and has a strong sense of belonging, organizations must implement strategic, systemic, and sustainable practices that directly address the root causes of employee disenfranchisement. They also should incorporate insights about known factors associated with belonging. Strategic practices emphasize long-term goals and alignment with the organization's mission; systemic practices focus on reforming underlying processes and structures; and sustainable practices stress lasting impact and adaptability within the workplace. Systemic issues and biases deeply

ingrained in society inevitably impact the workplace. Therefore, it is essential to acknowledge the broader social context within which organizations operate.

The Othering & Belonging Institute (OBI) has developed a powerful framework known as Belonging Design Principles (Gallegos & Surasky, 2023). These principles offer a roadmap for fostering a sense of belonging and inclusivity within institutions and communities. They promote cooperation and recognizing interconnectedness among humans. Thus, this framework goes beyond superficial changes and aims to address the root causes of exclusion and inequality.

The Belonging Design Principles counter othering by affirming the fundamental worth and agency of every individual. They advocate moving beyond simply including people within existing structures to create new structures designed to serve everyone. This involves dismantling systems of oppression and inequality rather than merely applying surface-level fixes. For example, by actively addressing salary disparities or ensuring diverse representation in leadership positions. These principles advocate understanding and addressing existing power dynamics to achieve structural change.

As organizations refer to these principles to cultivate belonging, it is important to be aware of well-intentioned efforts that may inadvertently hinder progress (Nwoga, 2023). Here are some common approaches to avoid:

Focus on Actions instead of Outcomes: Many organizations jump-start their DEI efforts with visible actions like DEI training, employee resource groups, and public statements. These positive steps can achieve greater impact with a well-defined roadmap for success that aligns with the organization's mission, vision, and values (Ballard et al., 2020; Crabb, 2020; Nwoga, 2023).

Superficial Fixes: Mandatory social events, one-off diversity training sessions, and surface-level holiday celebrations do not address the root causes of exclusion. They focus on appearances rather than fostering the deep changes needed for genuine belonging.

Tokenism: Hiring solely for diversity quotas or taking a "colorblind" approach can backfire. A prevalent example is performative allyship such as leaders making grand statements about inclusion without backing them up with actions or accountability (Ballard et al., 2020). These practices often prioritize optics over actual inclusion.

Placing the Burden on Individuals: Organizations often expect marginalized employees to "educate" others about their experiences, forcing them to become DEI experts on top of their regular workload, or to assimilate to dominant norms, such as changing their hairstyle or speech patterns to "fit in" (Allen, 2023). Dominant group members may downplay perceptions of discrimination by citing similar experiences or demanding definitive proof, thereby dismissing the unique challenges faced by underrepresented individuals. These approaches create obstacles rather than dismantle systemic barriers to belonging.

Effective belonging initiatives avoid these practices. They focus on systemic, strategic approaches to dismantling exclusionary practices, creating new and inclusive structures, and empowering everyone to contribute to building a welcoming workplace. They also infuse accountability at the organizational and individual level (Crabb, 2020). In addition, effective belonging efforts focus on three aspects of the workplace that influence an organization's ability to activate belonging and enhance employees' experience: organizational culture, personal relationships, and leadership attitudes and behaviors (Bordeaux et al., 2021).

Strategic Design for Belonging

To achieve lasting results, belonging initiatives must be intentional, measurable, and integrated into the core of an organization's strategy (Wise, 2022). Here are ideas for how to make this vision a reality:

Set Measurable Goals: Align belonging objectives with the organization's overall mission. Define clear targets (e.g., increased employee engagement scores, reduced turnover among underrepresented groups).

Data-Driven Insights: Regularly collect and analyze both qualitative and quantitative data to assess progress. Track demographics and retention rates and conduct surveys and focus groups to understand experiences and identify areas for improvement.

Consider Multiple Differences: Avoid one-size-fits-all DEIB approaches. Design initiatives that acknowledge and address the wide variety of ways that humans differ as well as the unique experiences of individuals with multiple non-dominant identities (Carter et al., 2024; Tulshyan, 2022).

Metrics That Matter: Include indicators of belonging (e.g., promotion rates by diverse groups, participation in leadership programs)

in performance evaluations to underscore accountability.

Holistic Talent Management: Review the entire employee lifecycle—from recruitment to promotion—to identify where biases or systemic barriers may be excluding diverse talent.

Transparent Policies and Processes: Ensure clarity and fairness in policies related to compensation, performance reviews, and workplace flexibility. This fosters trust and signals that opportunities are equitable.

Address Power Dynamics: Provide training on how power and privilege can manifest in workplace interactions. Equip employees with tools to respectfully challenge exclusive dynamics and create space for marginalized voices.

Design for Inclusion: Create workspaces with flexible layouts, inclusive seating, natural light, personalization opportunities, and accessible amenities. Consider remote and hybrid work options as well. These elements signal a commitment to respect and support for a diverse workforce (Dalessandro & Lovell, 2024).

Designing policies and practices for belonging that hold everyone accountable is only one side of the coin. To drive change, organizations must equip and empower employees with the knowledge and skills to communicate in ways that foster a sense of belonging.

Continuous Improvement in Employee Communication

To foster a culture of belonging, organizations can implement a continuous improvement approach to employee communication, providing everyone the knowledge, skills, and spaces to communicate effectively with one another. Continuous improvement means regularly evaluating the effectiveness of these practices and adapting them as needed. This ongoing commitment fosters an environment where everyone feels empowered to communicate respectfully, thereby promoting belongingness.

Here are key building blocks that organizations can implement in stages, tailoring them to their unique needs and resources.[2] While this overview presents these building blocks in sequence**,** organizations can adapt and implement the recommendations to suit their current needs and resources, focusing on areas that will have the most significant impact initially.

Empower Everyone to Communicate Effectively

- **Develop Essential Skills**: Offer training programs on topics such as respectful communication, active listening, and giving and receiving feedback.
- **Navigate Difficult Conversations**: Include workshops on courageous conversations and fostering psychological safety.
- **Build Cultural Awareness**: Integrate DEI topics into communication training, covering topics such as implicit bias, covering, microaggressions, and privilege.

Create Open and Inclusive Communication Channels

- **Multiple Feedback Avenues**: Provide surveys, focus groups, and anonymous suggestion boxes for employees to share feedback.
- **Accessibility Matters**: Choose communication platforms with features such as captions, screen readers, and translation options to ensure everyone can access information.
- **Inclusive Language and Representation**: Promote conscious word choice and diverse visuals in all company communications. In workplaces with multilingual employees, examples of inclusive actions include translating documents in multiple languages, displaying multilingual signage and announcements, and providing interpretation services for meetings or training sessions.

Build Trust and Foster Connection

- **Positive Feedback Culture**: Normalize giving regular praise alongside constructive criticism. Recognize effort and progress, not just end results.
- **Safe Spaces for Dialogue**: Create regular facilitated discussions where diverse employees can share experiences, learn from each other, and develop action plans.
- **Empathetic Storytelling**: Organize company-wide forums for employees to share their stories and perspectives. This builds understanding and bridges cultural gaps.
- **Celebrate Diverse Achievements**: Implement recognition programs that highlight the contributions of employees from all backgrounds.

Cultivate a Communication Culture of Belonging

Ideas for additional initiatives include:

- **Mentorship and Sponsorship Programs**: Connect employees with mentors or sponsors who can advocate for their advancement and career development.
- **Employee Resource Groups (ERGs)**: Encourage the formation of ERGs to amplify the voices and needs of diverse employees.
- **Ally Training**: Educate employees on how to be effective allies for underrepresented groups.
- **Conflict Management and Resolution**: Implement clear processes for addressing conflicts and reporting potential bias incidents.
- **Community Engagement**: Encourage employee participation in volunteer or mentorship programs within the local community.

Building a culture of belonging is an ongoing process. By focusing on these steps and making continuous improvements, organizations can create a more inclusive and respectful work environment for everyone.

The Essential Role of Inclusive Leadership in Fostering Belonging

Leaders set the tone for a workplace culture. To create an environment where everyone feels valued and respected, leaders must actively champion inclusion, confront biases, and cultivate open and honest communication (Kennedy, 2021). Key actions for inclusive leaders include the following.

1. **Champion Belonging with Visibility and Consistency:**
    - **Set the Standard**: Inclusive leaders publicly endorse inclusion initiatives, allocate resources, and hold themselves and others accountable for progress.
    - **Keep Belonging Top-of-Mind**: Regularly reinforce belonging as a core value through various communication channels. This ensures everyone stays engaged in creating an inclusive workplace.
2. **Foster Psychological Safety and Empower Employees:**

- **Lead by Example**: Actively participate in and provide training on psychological safety. This creates a space where people feel comfortable sharing diverse perspectives and learning from mistakes.
- **Empower and Delegate**: Delegate challenging tasks and offer opportunities for professional development to foster a sense of ownership and belonging within the organization.

3. **Build Diverse Teams and Embrace Continuous Learning:**
    - **Seek Out Different Voices**: Actively seek out and build diverse teams. Foster an environment that solicits, values, and respects everyone's voice.
    - **Embrace Learning and Self-Awareness**: Provide tools for self-reflection on leadership styles and potential biases. Understanding one's own biases facilitates leading inclusively and promoting belonging.
4. **Make Belonging Measurable and Rewarding:**
    - **Accountability for Inclusivity**: Integrate belonging metrics like promotion rates for diverse groups into leader performance evaluations. This reinforces the importance of creating a culture of belonging.
    - **Recognize Contributions**: Publicly acknowledge and reward employee contributions across all backgrounds. This reinforces a sense of belonging.
5. **Promote Transparency and Address Difficult Topics:**
    - **Explain Decisions Clearly**: Regularly communicate the reasoning behind choices to build trust and transparency.
    - **Proactive Approach to Inclusion**: Do not shy away from difficult conversations. Address incidents that undermine belonging and foster a safe space for everyone to raise concerns.

By implementing these five key actions and leading by example, leaders can create a workplace where everyone feels valued, respected, and empowered to contribute their best work.

Fostering belonging is an ongoing process. By prioritizing these recommendations and continuously seeking feedback, leaders and organizations can create a more inclusive and welcoming workplace for everyone.

These promising practices provide a roadmap to creating a workplace where everyone thrives. Imagine an environment where inclusion is more than a buzzword, where open communication fosters trust, and leaders actively champion belonging. In this context, every employee feels valued, respected, and empowered to contribute their unique talents and perspectives. Continuous education and opportunity creation can propel this journey.

Conclusion

This chapter has focused on the importance of belonging in the workplace, particularly for members of non-dominant groups. In closing, it is crucial to remember that:

1. **Belonging Matters Universally**: The desire to feel valued, respected, and part of a community is a fundamental human need. Everyone, regardless of background or identity, thrives in an environment where they feel they belong.
2. **Belonging Is a Personal Journey**: What makes someone feel like they belong can vary greatly. It is a complex tapestry woven from factors such as shared values, professional development opportunities, sense of purpose, and genuine connection with colleagues.

Therefore, to create an inclusive and thriving workplace, organizations must move beyond a one-size-fits-all approach:

3. **Strategic and Systemic Solutions**: By acknowledging the diverse needs and experiences of their workforce, organizations can develop strategic and systemic belonging initiatives. These initiatives go beyond superficial gestures and focus on creating a culture where everyone feels empowered to contribute their best selves and reach their full potential.

This requires ongoing evaluation and adaptation. A sustainable approach to belonging ensures that organizations remain welcoming and inclusive for everyone. The bottom line? Building belonging is an ongoing process that never concludes. By dedicating themselves to persistent efforts and drawing upon proven practices, organizations can cultivate thriving workplaces where every employee feels a genuine sense of belonging.

Notes

1. Throughout the chapter, I alternate "belongingness", "sense of belonging", and "belonging", usually based on how sources refer to the concept.
2. These recommendations are based on a review of documented best practices (BetterUp, 2020; Bond, 2022; Bordeaux et al., 2021; Cenkci et al., 2019; Coqual, 2020; Gallegos & Surasky, 2023; Kennedy, 2021; Stamps & Foley, 2023) and the author's experience as a DEIB consultant.

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A MULTINATIONAL COMPANY WITH FOREIGN EMPLOYEES

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The history of international trade dates back to approximately 1,000 BC, evident in mythological narratives like that of Hermes, the protector of merchants (Briquel, 1985), and the worship of sea deities in ancient Asia (Andaya, 2016). During this era, trade flourished among cultural communities due to resource disparities and the appeal of exotic goods, exemplified by the discovery of Chinese silk in an Egyptian mummy (Hancock, 2021), motivating traders to undertake risky journeys for profit (Rice, 2007). Early trading methods, such as the "silent trade", highlighted the challenges of cross-cultural transactions (Brown, 1969). However, as time passed, global solutions began to emerge to regulate commerce, as evidenced by ancient Roman commercial law (Sirks, 2017). Moreover, the rise of companies as business entities further streamlined international trade. Consequently, regulatory solutions and the incorporation of businesses facilitated the rapid expansion of multinational companies (MNCs) in global trade (Jones, 2005).

The success of MNCs is often attributed to factors like subsidiary size, entry strategy, national systems, and organizational principles (Hansen & Gwozdz, 2015). However, the significant role of communication strategies must also be acknowledged (Chapel, 1995). This chapter primarily focuses on these communication strategies. It begins by defining MNCs and then explains the challenges they encounter, particularly regarding integration and differentiation. The chapter further explores how communication strategies (two-way,

symmetrical, and cross-cultural communication) can effectively address these challenges and yield meaningful outcomes in a global context.

The Definition of Multinational Corporations

Over the years, numerous proposals and standards have emerged to define MNCs, yet precision remains elusive. Economically, MNCs are seen as businesses operating across multiple countries, owned by foreign entities, or structured globally with distinct product divisions. Its definitions often consider factors like the proportion of foreign revenue, assets, or workforce (Ajami & Goddard, 2014), or link them with foreign direct investments and control over value-added activities in multiple countries (Mayrhofer & Prange, 2015). However, arguments against capital flow as the sole defining factor exist (Hymer, 1976). Alternatively, sociological definitions of MNCs emphasize organizational practices such as management structures, decision-making processes, HR policies, and cultural dimensions (Heidenreich, 2012). MNCs serve as conduits for disseminating management techniques, workplace norms, and corporate values globally (Lazarus, 2001). This perspective emphasizes the impact of cultural and institutional factors, including negotiation, adaptation, and occasional resistance across diverse national contexts.

Despite the evolving economic landscapes impacting organizational structures, MNCs fundamentally manage operations across borders (economic perspective) while navigating global complexities and engaging with cultural diversity and institutional differences (sociological perspective). Thus, this chapter defines MNCs as *dynamic entities integrating global economic activities while navigating diverse cultural and institutional landscapes across national borders*.

Challenges of Multinational Corporations

Studies extensively explored the challenges faced by MNCs (Bartlett & Ghoshal, 1989; Hofstede, 1997; Taylor, 2007), with most agreeing that MNC management faces a dual challenge: integration and differentiation. *Integration* entails transferring decision-making powers and activities from a headquarter to regional subsidiaries (Feld, 1974), while *differentiation* acknowledges the unique cognitive and emotional orientations, needs, and characteristics of each culture across various subsidiaries (Lawrence & Lorsch, 1967).

Integration

MNCs are in a situation where a headquarter and subsidiaries must share their knowledge (Riege, 2007). Therefore, effectively disseminating information across distant units is crucial for seamless global knowledge sharing, given geographical dispersion, time zone differences, and limited face-to-face interaction. This integration aligns operational structures and employment systems, allocating resources from a central authority to subsidiaries across different countries or regions, addressing global competitive pressures (Doz et al., 1981) by centralizing decision-making and standardizing procedures (Caligiuri & Paul, 2010).

There are two types of integration: formal and informal (López-Sáez et al., 2021). *Formal integration* entails structured inter-unit communication, bringing employees together from different units through established mechanisms and interfaces like weekly meetings, official shared digital platforms, and structured reporting systems. These practices foster collaborative projects and joint research endeavors. In contrast, *informal integration* emphasizes social connectedness and value sharing among employees across MNC units through voluntary interactions or shared commonalities like language, religion, or interests. This occurs through activities such as regular coffee breaks, participation in company-sponsored sports teams, networking events, or online forums where employees share knowledge and experiences spontaneously.

Differentiation

The headquarters and subsidiaries share a dyadic exchange relationship, with both interdependent and independent interests (Ghoshal & Nohria, 1989), as subsidiaries have unique operational contexts and local market dynamics, leading to independent goals. This independence is attributed to two factors. The first factor is *external*. Each MNC subsidiary operates in heterogeneous environments, facing unique conditions, complexities, and resource availability (Ghoshal & Nohria, 1989). Those factors result in varying strengths among subsidiaries, such as low-cost labor or specialized technologies (Ivarsson & Alvstam, 2005). Consequently, MNCs adopt differentiated structures and systems (Pfeffer & Salancik, 1978), which research suggests are more effective than uniform global practices (Edwards & Zhang, 2008).

Besides, there are also *internal factors* that lead MNCs to pursue their independent interest. MNCs often recruit talent globally, resulting in a

workforce with diverse professional experiences, skills, and expertise. Thus, the workforce of MNCs composed of individuals from various cultural backgrounds, ethnicities, and nationalities brings different languages, perspectives, values, and communication styles to the workplace. Due to cultural differences, varying workplace norms, and different occupational profiles (Ivarsson & Alvstam, 2005), employees in MNCs may have different work styles, practices, and approaches to tasks (Boonsathorn, 2007).

In short, MNCs strive for uniformity in implementing strategies across their international business units amid the cross-national distance (e.g., cultural, economic, geographic, knowledge), notwithstanding the variations in management accounting practices prevalent across countries. Previous studies have delineated these two challenges—integration and differentiation—as *harmonizing global operations*, which underscores the imperative for MNCs to synchronize their varied operations across disparate countries and regions (Baumgartner & Tippmann, 2019); *achieving consistency amidst diversity*, which highlights the task of maintaining cohesive standards while operating in diverse global markets (Rosenzweig, 1998); or *balancing globalization and localization*, which underscores the tension between standardizing operations for efficiency and tailoring them to local preferences and regulations (Lane, 1998). Whatever they are termed, these challenges extend beyond the corporate level and also pose challenges to employees. Next, we will look at the impact these two challenges can have on MNC's employees, especially from a communication perspective.

Communication Challenges of MNC Employees

The challenges faced by MNCs can lead to communication issues for employees from distinct perspectives. Regarding integration between headquarters and subsidiaries, limited face-to-face interaction poses significant challenges to effective communication, hindering rapport and trust establishment (Nilsson & Mattes, 2015). Time zone differences exacerbate these challenges, making it difficult to schedule meetings and coordinate communication. The absence of interactions also obstructs relationship-building, particularly when local work practices involve different languages (Jaehne et al., 2009).

In terms of differentiation, communication with employees from diverse cultural backgrounds can indeed be demanding. Language

differences can exacerbate potential misunderstandings, especially in conflict situations (Sanden, 2015). Moreover, research indicates that employees in certain countries, such as Spain and Austria, adhere to process-oriented practices, while those in others, like Poland, the United States, and China, prioritize outcomes (Festing et al., 2012; Stor & Kupczyk, 2015). Additionally, some employees are accustomed to reporting financial figures, functional processes, and tangible assets exclusively, whereas others have experience in environments where nonfinancial metrics, cross-functional processes, and both tangible and intangible assets are reported (Xi, 2011). These differences can cause confusion, require more translation efforts, and result in communication delays and inefficiencies.

Communicative Solutions for MNCs to Overcome Challenges

The outlined challenges stem from a communication culture within MNCs that is closed, asymmetrical, and ethnocentric. Closed communication restricts information flow, leading employees to adhere to a prescribed role, which can breed resentment and hinder collaboration (Kim, 2007). Asymmetrical communication occurs when one party, often MNCs, possesses more power or knowledge, resulting in unequal access to information and feelings of undervaluation among employees (Hung, 2007). Ethnocentric communication revolves around the home culture of the MNC, often sidelining other cultural perspectives and causing misunderstandings and reduced inclusivity (Malik & Sanders, 2021). These communication cultures impede integration and differentiation efforts within MNCs, affecting team dynamics and morale. To foster a positive work environment and enhance effectiveness, MNCs should cultivate a communication culture that prioritizes openness, symmetry, and multiculturalism.

Two-Way Communication

Two-way communication in MNCs signifies an open approach characterized not only by the willingness to transmit information to employees but also by the openness to receive information from them. It is distinguished by transparency, honesty, accessibility, and a willingness to freely share and receive information (Grunig et al., 1995).

Effective communication behavior is crucial for both integration and differentiation within MNCs. In terms of integration, two-way

communication facilitates knowledge flow among headquarters, subsidiaries, and within subsidiaries themselves (Michailova & Bernhard, 2006), ensuring alignment of goals and actions through regular updates on company-wide developments. It also empowers employees to share feedback (Aylott, 2022), fostering an open environment where information is shared efficiently. Regarding differentiation, two-way communication values employee input, allowing MNCs to learn country-specific perspectives (Kim & Mauborgne, 1993) and aiding foreign employees in seeking clarification for unexpected changes (Janssens, 2001). This reduces uncertainty and enables employees to articulate concerns stemming from differences in economic conditions or cultural backgrounds (Hofman et al., 2014).

Symmetrical Communication

Symmetrical communication aims to cultivate mutually beneficial relationships and equalize power dynamics between headquarters and subsidiary employees (Grunig, 1992). It emphasizes reciprocity, horizontal communication, and tolerance for disagreement. This approach adopts an employee-centered style, prioritizing employees' welfare by demonstrating a willingness to adjust MNCs' positions, plans, or policies for employees' benefit (Huang, 2004).

In terms of integrity, symmetrical communication promotes organizational cohesion and inclusivity by fostering an environment where employees are actively invited to participate in the management process and advocate for their interests (Grunig & White, 1992). This approach transforms authority-driven organizations into more subordinate-driven entities, meaning that not only do authorities at headquarters influence subsidiaries' employees but they are also influenced by them (Gulev, 2006). Such communication ensures that management and employees value each other's perspectives (Grunig, 1992), with consensus and shared values serving as the cornerstone for decision-making (Ghoshal & Nohria, 1989). By prioritizing symmetrical communication, MNCs can cultivate a work culture of mutual understanding and control mutuality (Chen, 2004). In terms of diversity, symmetrical communication enables MNCs to address the interests of both MNCs and their employees (Sha, 2004). Employee interests are shaped by both external and internal factors. Externally, employees are influenced by the specific laws and compliance standards of the region in which they work, which can impact their labor certificates, working

visas, or resident permits, causing considerable concern and stress for foreign employees (Radović-Marković et al., 2019). Internally, their interests are affected by the programs provided by MNCs such as organized language courses (Charles & Marschan-Piekkari, 2002) or talent management programs (Napathorn, 2020). Especially, well-being initiatives are becoming increasingly important for MNC employees, though differences exist between Western and Eastern countries in practices (e.g., work hours, parental leave policies) (Chandra, 2012). While initially, embracing symmetrical communication may lead MNCs to perceive an over-prioritization of employee interests, ultimately, this approach contributes to the organization's overall success.

Cross-Cultural Communication

To serve customers effectively across different regions and build strong relationships among employees from diverse backgrounds, MNCS must understand how cultural similarities and differences shape communication within various contexts (Banks, 1995). Hence, this chapter also addresses cross-cultural communication, which is an interaction among individuals from diverse cultural backgrounds, varying in crucial aspects like preferred communication codes, role expectations, and perceived social relationship norms (Lustig & Koester, 1998). It involves the exchange of verbal and non-verbal messages, aiming to convey meanings, ideas, and emotions effectively across cultural boundaries (Harris & Moran, 2000).

When cultures differ, it hinders integration and increases conflict. However, cross-cultural communication enables MNCs to enhance trust, respect, and understanding among foreign employees, facilitating smoother collaboration (Progoulaki & Theotokas, 2016). MNCs can also create a hybrid project team culture that blends the diverse cultural backgrounds of team members into a cohesive and functional dynamic (Henrie, 2014), which sparks original thought and innovative problem-solving (Putri, 2024). Furthermore, cross-cultural communication addresses differentiation challenges by increasing MNCs' intercultural competency. It promotes an inclusive workplace culture that embraces and respects diversity, enabling employees to adopt cross-cultural code-switching behavior, where they modify their behavior in foreign settings to accommodate different cultural norms, thereby contributing to more effective cross-cultural performance (Molinsky, 2007). By fostering such an environment, MNCs can create a space where employees feel valued

and appreciated for their unique perspectives, encouraging increased cultural sensitivity and reducing cultural barriers such as stereotypes, unconscious biases, and premature judgments (Norales, 2006).

Practical Solutions for MNC

Implementing two-way, symmetrical, and cross-cultural communication together can indeed be a complex endeavor for MNCs. However, they can strive to adopt several practical solutions. Specific details are provided for each communication type.

Two-Way Communication

To enhance two-way communication, MNCs can implement direct and indirect channels for addressing workplace issues (Tüselmann et al., 2015). Direct channels ensure regular updates and official knowledge sharing (Rosenzweig & Singh, 1991), while indirect channels reduce misunderstandings, promote fairness, and empower idea contribution (Grunig et al., 2002). Both approaches improve team dynamics and highlight operational differences among subsidiaries, impacting the MNC's survival. Additionally, MNCs can foster an environment that values new input and feedback, nurturing employee ownership and addressing subsidiary needs (Ahlvik et al., 2016). Although these solutions may increase overhead, they reduce turnover (Bailey, 2009) and promote organizational growth by balancing global efficiency with local responsiveness (Kim & Mauborgne, 1993).

Symmetrical Communication

To establish a culture of symmetrical communication, MNCs can promote horizontal communication, encourage tolerance for disagreement (Grunig, 1992), and use cross-functional interfaces (Jansen et al., 2009). In detail, both liaison personnel and ombudsman services can serve as intermediaries between management and employees, addressing concerns, promoting transparency, or seeking impartial guidance on workplace issues (López-Sáez et al., 2021; Subedi, 2003). Establishing employee resource groups also provides employees with opportunities to connect with peers who share similar perspectives on various issues (Greige & Khayr, 2019). These solutions will lead MNCs to achieve equilibrium, equality, autonomy, and effective conflict resolution (Grunig & White, 1992).

Cross-Cultural Communication

To address cross-cultural communication challenges effectively, MNCs can first emphasize the use of a clear common business language, often English (Neeley, 2013), to enhance communication effectiveness and reduce misinterpretation. If this presents difficulties resulting in mistrust, avoidance, and exclusion, MNCs should ensure the availability of translation services to facilitate seamless communication across borders (Tomi, 2019). Secondly, MNCs should frequently arrange team-building activities to increase interactivity and creative problem-solving (Dyer et al., 2013). Thirdly, MNCs should provide sensitivity training to help employees learn unique cross-cultural components, fostering a respectful work environment through cross-cultural communication (Zakaria, 2000). These proactive measures can enhance intercultural understanding and collaboration, ultimately contributing to the success of MNCs operating in diverse global contexts.

The Outcomes of Two-way, Symmetrical, and Cross-Cultural Communication

The integration of the three communication strategies not only fulfills the prerequisites of responsiveness (two-way communication), efficiency (symmetrical communication), and learning (cross-cultural communication) highlighted by Bartlett and Ghoshal (1989) for MNCs, but also fosters outcomes vital for organizational success. These outcomes include ethical communication, inclusivity, leadership endorsement, and proficient conflict resolution.

Ethical Communication

As Grunig and Grunig (1996) noted, adhering to the principles of two-way and symmetrical communication inherently fosters ethical communication, which refers to communicating with moral intention (teleology), disclosure, and social responsibility (Huang, 2004). Similarly, cross-cultural communication can nurture ethical sensitivity by clarifying a new premise of fairness or accountability and generating more ethical communication (Foeman & Pressley, 1987). Integrating all three communication strategies will have a positive impact on humanitarian development by enhancing overall ethical communication within MNCs, fostering greater respect, tolerance, accountability, and fairness across diverse cultural contexts.

Inclusion

Two-way communication entails actively involving employees from diverse cultural backgrounds to construct shared meanings and collective knowledge (Maimone, 2017). Symmetrical communication dismantles barriers between headquarters and employees, enabling them to voice their interests (Grunig, 1992), fostering a sense of belonging and unity. Cross-cultural communication facilitates the bridging of diverse cultural experiences, values, and beliefs, aiding foreign employees in establishing common ground (Jackson, 2019). The integration of these communication strategies can have a positive impact on social development by promoting inclusion, which is about unity, association, and close connections with other parties (Grunig, 2023).

Conflict Resolution

Two-way communication encourages sharing best practices, prevents problems before they occur, and minimizes the expansion of issues into risks (Roberts-Lombard, 2011). Both symmetrical communication and cross-cultural communication reduce conflicts; the former creates mutually acceptable solutions in conflict situations (Huang, 2001), while the latter helps employees become more cognizant of attitudes and feelings toward people of other countries or communities (Oetzel, 2001). This approach not only enhances the economic development of MNCs but also contributes to the economic development of society.

The implementation of two-way, symmetrical, and cross-cultural communication strategies may pose challenges, but it also yields various outcomes crucial for the success and innovation of MNCs in a global context.

Conclusion

Despite the challenges inherent in defining MNCs, the complexity of MNCs navigating the interplay of integration and differentiation is evident across various facets of their operations. Integration within MNCs involves aligning diverse units across different geographical locations to ensure cohesive decision-making, resource allocation, and knowledge sharing. However, this integration must also contend with the need for differentiation, as subsidiaries often operate in distinct cultural, regulatory, and market environments, necessitating tailored approaches to suit local conditions. Moreover, the diverse workforce composition of

MNCs, comprising individuals from various cultural backgrounds and professional experiences, adds another layer of complexity to the integration-differentiation dynamic.

This chapter introduces two-way, symmetrical, and cross-cultural communication as vital communication strategies that could help MNCs not only better navigate the complexities of integration and differentiation inherent in their global operations but also effectively achieve those solutions. They could bridge the gap between headquarters and subsidiaries, facilitate collaboration among diverse teams, and navigate the various cultural nuances present in each subsidiary. It also explains that the combination of these communication strategies empowers MNCs to drive meaningful outcomes in terms of facilitating ethical practices, promoting inclusion, garnering leadership support, and enabling effective conflict resolution.

Future studies could explore how the three communication strategies can enhance the efficiency and effectiveness of MNC operations through the integration of emerging technologies (e.g., AI, machine learning).

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INTERNAL CORPORATE SOCIAL RESPONSIBILITY

A Communication Perspective on CSR for Employees

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It truly is an exciting time to be studying and discussing corporate social responsibility (CSR), specifically in communication. We must continue to think about the role of business in society and, more specifically, focus our attention on the continually evolving and changing relationship between corporations and stakeholders (Buckley et al., 2023). As Carroll states, stakeholder expectations are changing (Carroll, 2021), so we can question how are corporations responding to these demands? How are corporations balancing demands and responsibilities, for which audiences? The particular audiences focused on this chapter are those deemed internal stakeholders—namely, employees.

Overall, there is an increasing call for a change in workplace environments (Gerdeman, 2018; Kantor, 2018; McPherson, 2018; Temin, 2018). Thus, key CSR issues should be focused internally—including the end of workplace harassment and inequality, expanding diversity initiatives, and getting CSR more involved at the C-suite level (Garcia, 2018; McPherson, 2018). As times and the issues we as a society care about change, so must corporate approaches and CSR foci. Therefore, it is important to understand how more companies are adopting and aligning CSR into their core business strategies, and how these initiatives are communicated to and among employees. Additionally, scholars can

further investigate for what or whom companies believe they are responsible.

A Brief Review of Corporate Social Responsibility

As Gond and Moser (2021) described, CSR is viewed as a managerial and strategic process and the "field of scholarship that explores how businesses and societies interact" (p. 6) (see Crane et al., 2008). The concept of CSR is largely attributed to Bowen in 1953, putting forth the initial argument for the responsibilities of businessmen as the obligation "to pursue those policies, to make those decisions, or to follow those lines of action which are desirable in terms of the objectives and values of our society" (p. 6). Bowen (1953) extended the belief that corporations were centers of power, and thus impacted the lives of societal groups. As Carroll (1999) predicted, CSR continues to evolve particularly in response to growing social issues, as reactive to corporate crises and scandals, and in fulfilling continuous calls for organizations to simply *do the right thing*. While now a widely studied phenomenon in the communication discipline—namely public relations and organizational communication—it is also conceptually housed across other fields. Organizational communication scholars are particularly appropriate to study CSR due to the discipline's long-standing history of examining organizational phenomena, organizing processes, and stakeholder interactions—often via a cross-sectional or multi-level approach. This discipline positions scholars to examine both internal and external practices and discourse.

The question then becomes: how can we continue to reconsider the role of business in society—and whom, or what, is CSR truly for? This debate came from a rather informal conversation I had with Jeremy Moon—a prolific scholar and educator of CSR and corporate governance—at the Copenhagen Business School. I left that meeting with an impressionable question Jeremy posed, one that would find itself at the center of my dissertation and ultimately ground my research agenda: "Don't you believe that CSR, at its core, is *for* employees", he asked. I began to explore this further through thinking about internal-based CSR in two ways: an agenda for employees to enact, or one to benefit from. On either side, it is important to recognize the role of communication for sustaining employee engagement around CSR.

The Internal Side of CSR

CSR as Contextual and Socially Constructed

Important to the study of internal CSR is the view of corporate responsibility as a social, communicative, and discursive construction. As Ihlen et al. (2011a) pointed out, the notion of social constructionism, particularly in the context of organizations, is largely unchallenged today. From this perspective, internal stakeholders, in particular, are key in the co-creation, dissemination, and execution of CSR practices. Thus, approaching CSR through a communicative lens is important to understanding "how the meaning of CSR is constructed, how it is implemented in organizations, and used to achieve organizational goals" (p. 11). It is accepted that communication is simply inescapable on the matter of CSR—and that communication is what helps "constitute stakeholder participation and ethical business practices" (p. 11). Thus, viewing CSR as a set of communicative and co-created processes, rather than just outcomes, continues to grow in organizational studies. Recently, scholars have called for an increase in theorizing CSR through context (Brown et al., 2022), which would allow for an important understanding of localized meanings and practices with a priority placed on stakeholder expectations, such as employees. There is a growing need for the contextualization of CSR, rather than generalizing a one-size-fits-all approach to these practices, and the employee perception as a data source may serve as an in for achieving this goal.

Micro-CSR and the Consideration of Employees in CSR Research: Employee Communication, Sensemaking, and CSR as an Employee Organizing Process

Approached from a very interdisciplinary standpoint, CSR has been explored at various ranks—with a common interest having been at the macro, organizational, and societal levels (Matten & Moon, 2008). Until somewhat recently, research has largely neglected the micro or individual level when analyzing CSR processes, specifically when it comes to employees, and has been increasingly called for throughout the past decade (Aguinis & Glavas, 2012). More recently, Aguinis and Glavas (2019) contend that it is important to understand how and why individuals, such as employees, make sense of CSR in different ways. From a social constructionist standpoint, these individuals are "agentic

actors who are actively interpreting and shaping the world around them and are not just passive recipients of organizational policies and actions" (p. 1076; see Weiss & Rupp, 2011). Research has proven that CSR is greatly beneficial to for-profit organizations, specifically when we think about the employee implications. To start, CSR contributes to positive employee attitudes, identification, and productivity in the workplace, ultimately benefiting a company's financial performance (Tziner, 2013). But, we don't seem to know enough about the psychological experiences when it comes to employees in the CSR context.

The consideration of employees in the CSR discussion, particularly in understanding their perspective on such efforts, has been commonly called for across varying bodies of literature (see May & Roper, 2014; Crane & Glozer, 2016; Edinger-Schons et al., 2019). There are still areas where CSR research is lacking, particularly in considering internal organizational processes around CSR. Existing work, specifically in a Western context, has examined the explicit and often external-focused efforts labeled "CSR" (Matten & Moon, 2008) and has been largely macro in analysis. As Dhanesh (2023) notes, we know employees to be an important stakeholder group "in the enactment and communication of CSR", but we are still lacking scholarship from this standpoint when comparing to the body of research on the external side (p. 240). And while socially responsible companies do tend to take care of their employees, and research has shown that these individuals tend to be more satisfied with their jobs at organizations that institutionalize ethics (see Singhapakdi et al., 2015), Dhanesh (2023) presents the dark side of CSR from the employee perspective whereby too much CSR may lead to employee burnout, work addiction and meaningfulness, and an increased level of workplace control.

This is not to say that employees have been entirely absent from organizational scholarship as we are seeing an increase of studies dedicated to this topic. Among the first of these studies explored the impact of CSR on prospective and current employees from a recruitment standpoint (Backhaus et al., 2002; Turban & Greening, 1997). Other employee-focused research has examined topics such as: the relationship between CSR and organizational identification (Bartel, 2001; Carmeli et al., 2007; Kim et al., 2010), job satisfaction (De Roeck et al., 2014; Dhanesh, 2014), management attitudes (Muller & Kolk, 2010), organizational commitment (Brammer et al., 2007), and organizational pride (Jones, 2010). Largely, research in this area has "examined individual-level variables that may serve as mediators or moderators of

the effects of CSR on outcomes" (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019, p. 1061). More recently, Rupp et al. (2018) explored employee autonomy and engagement when participating in their company's CSR activities—focused on the micro-level of analysis.

Employee participation in CSR from a communicative standpoint continues to be a focus in the internal research space. Morsing and Schultz (2006) coined three strategies for companies communicating with stakeholders regarding CSR—stakeholder information strategy, stakeholder response strategy, and stakeholder involvement strategy—emphasizing the need for two-way communication to successfully engage these groups. Employees are arguably the most important group for buying into the responsible and ethical practices a company claims to enact. Are these initiatives fully integrated into workplace culture? Employees can speak to this reality or potential disconnect, and this support is essential (Brunton et al., 2015). Internal, strategic communication regarding to CSR to employees is imperative for gaining loyalty, support, legitimacy, creating awareness, and building a sense of identification. From this perspective, employees are not seen as passive recipients of CSR information, but rather play an essential role in advocating, enacting, and monitoring an organization's responsible business practices (Jiang & Luo, 2024). Additionally, as will be explicated further in this chapter, CSR has important impacts on the employee's quality of life at work. In other words, CSR includes how an organization takes care of its employees—concerned with working conditions and climate, diversity and inclusion, individual physical and mental well-being, and additional benefits (Singhapakdi et al., 2015). Therefore, how employees are communicated, and therefore perceive and make sense of their employers' CSR activities, matters.

First put forth by Weick (1995), sensemaking "is the process through which individuals give meaning to ongoing experiences such as work" (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019, p. 1058). Thus, sensemaking, understood both at the individual and collective level, aids actors in understanding the complex phenomenon of CSR and related problems—such as the disconnect between CSR words and actions or failing to include multiple stakeholders in such efforts (Golob et al., 2013, p. 368; see also Calton & Payne, 2003; Pater & van Lierop, 2006). CSR is known to be ambiguous and complex, making a sensemaking approach fitting, and not novel, for studying the phenomenon. And as Aguinis and Glavas (2019) argue,

> because CSR expands the nature of work to include making a broader impact (e.g., on community members and other intended beneficiaries of CSR initiatives who are not members of the organization), through sensemaking individuals may have new experiences at work in terms of their place in the world.
>
> *(p. 1064)*

Sensemaking, in short, allows us to explore the underlying processes that ground the development of CSR in organizational contexts—further examining behavior, communication, and motivation (Nijhof & Jeurissen, 2006). Basu and Palazzo (2008) first proposed an organizational sensemaking model in exploring how managers intrinsically think and act with stakeholders in a CSR capacity, and Angus-Leppan et al. (2010) provide an examination of leadership styles in driving CSR activities.

Only recently have studies been pushing a deep-dive into CSR sensemaking from the employee *perspective* as this stakeholder group has been somewhat challenging to reach. Thus, how employees experience CSR is an important area of study that is still largely untapped (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019). Miller (2022) interviewed over 40 employees from varying organizations and industries to understand first how they generally view and define CSR at a conceptual level, and then how these stakeholders engaged in sensemaking processes to understand CSR practices in and by their workplace. Findings revealed how CSR activities impact employees' view on their personal and professional life, as well as their (dis)identification with their employer, and how this stakeholder group comes to learn about and rationalize CSR at their organization through formal and informal communication channels. Studies have also considered how employees find meaningful work through CSR sensemaking (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019), as well as how CSR transparency can emerge as an outcome through internal employee sensemaking (Sendlhofer & Tolstoy, 2022).

Employee-Directed CSR: Employees as Actors/Benefactors versus Beneficiaries

Indeed, the social aspect of CSR has been somewhat of a hot topic in recent years and is increasingly becoming an expectation of corporate activity. And with an increased focus on Environment, Social, and Governance investing, we are seeing even more of a commitment and

conversation surrounding responsible business practices—and those that seem to blur the lines between internal organizational practices and external-based initiatives. However, both research and practice have long divided CSR practices between external and internal dimensions. Hameed et al. (2016), echoing conceptualizations from other scholars (see Shen & Zhang, 2019), explicitly distinguished and defined each side based on targeted stakeholder groups. Specifically, "internal CSR denotes the policy and practices of an organization that are related to the psychological and physiological well-being of its employees (Verdeyen et al., 2004; Brammer et al., 2007; Turker, 2009; Shen & Jiuhua Zhu, 2011)" (p. 2). Whereas, "external CSR relates to environmental and social practices that help to strengthen the firm's legitimacy and reputation among its external stakeholders (Carroll, 1979; Brammer et al., 2007)" (p. 2). When questioned on how CSR could possibly be considered internal, when so much of its conceptual and operational history has been external in nature, and easily seen as synonymous with conventional HR functions, I argue that we can view the initiative of CSR as not just one that is practiced externally. In fact, many of the internal initiatives reflect external societal discourse and priorities, and targeting those within the organization can be an avenue for social change.

Research has largely focused on employees as actors of CSR—that is, individuals conducting or "doing" the CSR work, or serving as ambassadors (Edinger-Schons et al., 2019)—and internal perceptions of activities (Lee & Chen, 2018). However, we know the relationship between the employee and organization to be incredibly crucial, even a precondition for CSR (Tziner, 2013). If CSR, as a strategic activity, is one meant to create value for stakeholders, this surely goes beyond the financial benefits, and can be seen as a source of value-creation for employees in terms of productivity, satisfaction, well-being, and identification. Miller's (2022) work on employee sensemaking touched on an idea of employee-directed CSR—a concept more commonly studied in management and the business-society literature—but broken down into two avenues of practice: employees as [benef]actors of CSR versus employees as beneficiaries. In other words, employees are either the ones enacting CSR (i.e., doing the "work" of these practices) or are the end recipient group benefitting from these initiatives.

As an employee organizing process, CSR puts this stakeholder at the center in often leading, advocating for, or rallying around such practices. CSR has been proven to enhance feelings of meaningful work and

organizational identification by employees. These individuals feel they contribute to greater social issues and find meaning beyond their day-to-day responsibilities through activities such as volunteerism or social advocacy (see Miller, 2022). CSR programs also have important recruitment and retention implications as an employee-organization management strategy (Dhanesh, 2014).

As Morsing et al. (2008) argued, the treatment of employees is a necessary element of any corporations' CSR agenda. Classically, Cloud (2007) points our attention to the treatment and well-being of labor as a CSR consideration. Here we see the explicit argument that, "an organization's treatment of workers may be the most concrete and, perhaps, the most telling measure of its commitment to social responsibility" (p. 228). A dedication to the inward turning of CSR to not only include external actions, but in truly creating an ethical, safe workplace culture is imperative. While largely operationalized as "other-focused", we can continue to see discussions and scholarship of CSR focused on the self, and more employee-oriented (see Hameed et al., 2016; Schaefer et al., 2020).

Current Trends and Future Considerations

The continually evolving nature of CSR, as well as its conceptual *and* operational ambiguity, results in shifting trends in what is deemed "socially responsible" behavior by corporations. Top trends forecasted for 2023 alone included a greater emphasis on DEI, job purposing, and harnessing internal corporate cooperation for social change (Hessekiel, 2023).

From an internal perspective, we must continue to consider how employees receive and benefit from CSR-related activities beyond traditional benefits or HR policies. As Johnston (2001) discussed over two decades ago, "If a company does not assume a high level of responsibility toward its own staff, it is unlikely to do so toward its customers or the social and natural environment in which it operates" (Tziner, 2013, p. 92). My hope is that scholarship extends organizational ethics further into the CSR realm by considering how corporations are acting responsibly toward their employees in terms of their psychological and physiological well-being and as a way to empower this important stakeholder group in the workplace. Much of these actions stem from grander societal issues, and are reflected in how companies choose their CSR platforms. For example, companies like Netflix and Spotify are

redefining employee rights, such as longer paid parental leave, as a social responsibility effort; Ford Motor Company is dedicated to pay equity, and Starbucks is committed to diversifying its workforce and tackling social and racial equity company-wide.

From a generational perspective, understanding employees' perception of work and organizational life is extremely salient for how businesses will attract talent and clientele—and how they perceive corporations to be socially (ir)responsible is no exception. The newest and youngest workforce generation, Generation Z, is entering the working world with high expectations of corporate responsible behavior. As Millennials and Gen Z are quickly becoming the majority of the workforce and will soon hold the largest buying power, it is important to understand their take on CSR. In fact, 64% of Millennials will refuse a job if the employer does not demonstrate a strong commitment to CSR. Additionally, the alignment in values will be the number one career-driving decision for Gen Z (Davidson, 2024). These groups will strive to challenge and create the (socially responsible) organizations they will work for and live among.

Aside from practical considerations, there is still much to discover in the wide-ranging territory of CSR scholarship. Echoing Dhanesh (2023) and Aguinis and Glavas (2019), we may turn to further understanding the negative and harmful experiences of CSR that lead to burnout, work addiction, and ill-being. While grassroot and bottom-up CSR initiatives are on the rise, top-down communication and management in this area continue to dominate—leading to stress and a lack of true, meaningful sensemaking (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019; Maitlis & Christianson, 2014). And, if CSR is not truly embedded in core business operations and, perhaps more importantly, throughout corporate culture, will it continue to be seen as a PR ploy or inauthentic (Aguinis & Glavas, 2019)? Few studies in this space have relied on qualitative methods at the micro-level—primarily ethnographic and narrative—to understand the individual CSR experience. In fact, only 169 articles between 1994 and 2014 employed some form of qualitative methodology (Bass & Milosevec, 2018). Future work should continue to address this gap. As scholars, we must continue on in the quest to understand employee perception and sensemaking of CSR particularly as these individuals reconsider the role of work in their lives, as well as how companies are responding to changes in employee value priorities (Dhanesh, 2023). Finally, we must consider the outcome and experience of disidentification if

organizational values and commitment to particular social issues misalign with those of the employee (Miller, 2022).

The goal of this chapter was to highlight internal CSR and CSR employee communication as an important area of study, and practice, at the cross-section of organizational communication, PR, and management/HR. My hope is to challenge scholars to further explore this still rather understudied concept, particularly in the communication discipline. Organizations and leaders, particularly in the PR space, need to take on a new view of what Mundy (2022) describes as empowerment —empowering our internal members, and important practices and efforts such as DEI, social justice, safe and equitable workplace cultures, and so on. What is considered "socially responsible" and the corporation's proper role in society are both continually debated and continue to evolve. Future scholarship, as called for in this chapter, should further interrogate the employee-directed notion of CSR, and how the lines between internal and external socially responsible practices are not separate, but rather connected.

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38

THE ROLE OF INTERNAL COMMUNICATION IN PREDICTING REMOTE EMPLOYEE ENGAGEMENT IN A CRISIS

An Expanded Framework of Remote Internal Crisis Communication (RICC)

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The hurried adoption of remote work when the COVID-19 pandemic disrupted everyday work posed challenges for organizations to keep employees engaged. Although studies had underscored the role of internal communication[1] as a driver of employee engagement (EE) in face-to-face (e.g., Duthler & Dhanesh, 2018; Kang & Sung, 2017; Ruck et al., 2017; Shen & Jiang, 2019; Vercic & Vokic, 2017) and virtual settings (Gerards et al., 2018; Makarius & Larson, 2017; Shaik & Makhecha, 2019), and had examined internal crisis communication (ICC) as a driver of employee relational outcomes (Heide & Simonsson, 2015; Mazzei & Ravazzani, 2015; Ravazzani, 2016), the interplay among EE, remote work, and ICC remains underexplored. How can organizations leverage internal communication to keep employees engaged during remote work in a crisis?

This question is important given that remote work continues to prevail in a world navigating *permacrisis*, a portmanteau word combining *permanent* and *crisis*, which describes living through continuing wars and conflicts, geopolitical uncertainties, and social and environmental movements. Although Dhanesh and Duthler (2021) offered a conceptual framework of remote internal crisis communication (RICC) to examine communicative drivers of remote EE during a crisis, after its publication, much work has been produced

on communicative drivers of EE during the pandemic. Accordingly, this chapter reviews recent research on ICC and remote EE from public relations, business, and human resources management and offers an expanded RICC framework incorporating additional variables, to provide a comprehensive framework to understand drivers of EE in remote work during crises.

Literature Review

Employee Engagement

In a foundational definition, personal engagement is described as "the harnessing of organization members' selves to their work roles; in engagement, people employ and express themselves physically, cognitively, and emotionally during role performances" (Kahn, 1990, p. 694). Similarly, to Shuck and Wollard (2010) EE is "an individual employee's cognitive, emotional, and behavioral state directed toward desired organizational outcomes" (p. 103). To Schaufeli et al. (2002) EE is "a positive and fulfilling work-related mindset characterized by vigor, dedication, and absorption" (p. 74). Another definition addressed psychological state engagement including an individual's feelings of energy and absorption; behavioral engagement including extra-role behavior; and trait engagement including positive views of life and work (Macey & Schneider, 2008). These definitions suggest engaged employees exhibit commitment to their diverse role performances, encompassing cognitive, emotional, and behavioral dimensions.

Within public relations research too, EE has been conceptualized with cognitive, affective, and behavioral dimensions (Karanges et al., 2015; Welch, 2011). Welch (2011) defined organization engagement as, "a dynamic, changeable psychological state, which links employees to their organizations, manifest in organization member role performances expressed physically, cognitively and emotionally, and influenced by organization-level internal communication" (p. 337). Soane et al. (2012) identified three dimensions of EE: cognitive, emotional, and social. The cognitive dimension or intellectual engagement is "the extent to which one is intellectually absorbed" (Soane et al., 2012, p. 532). The emotional dimension or affective engagement is "the extent to which one experiences a state of positive affect relating to one's work role" (Soane et al., 2012, p. 532), and finally, the social dimension is "the extent to which one is socially connected with the working environment and shares common values with colleagues" (Soane et al., 2012, p. 532). We adopted Soane et al.'s (2012) definition of EE as it addresses work and organizational levels of engagement, which can be affected during remote work in a crisis, and because it included the social dimension of engagement, which could become crucial during remote work.

Drivers of Employee Engagement

A review of antecedents of organization engagement found organization-related resources such as perceived organizational support, justice perceptions, corporate social responsibility, and HR practices such as training and development, and career management were most often studied and consistently related (Saks et al., 2022). Most relevant to public relations research was the focus on internal communication as an enabler of EE.

According to Ruck and Welch (2012), EE is an outcome of internal communication, and employee voice is a critical driver of engagement along with performance feedback, clarity on employee's role, identification with the organization, organizational support, and information provision on corporate goals and strategy. Their model includes aspects of work and organizational EE, which are influenced by internal corporate communication. Similarly, engagement strategies of openness (feedback, listening and sharing information), assurances of legitimacy (upward voice and senior management's receptiveness to such voice) and networking (rewarding interactions at work, employee access to resources and information) contribute to EE, which can produce contextual performance, and employee communication behaviors (ECBs), which include positive and negative messaging (Shen & Jiang, 2019).

Scholars have mostly theorized employee voice, or employees' tendency to speak out in order to improve organizations and the work environment, as an antecedent of EE (Ruck & Welch, 2012; Shen & Jiang, 2019). When employees feel psychologically safe to speak up and they are offered assurances of legitimacy through senior management's receptiveness to employee voice, they feel more engaged. Meanwhile, research in public relations has found that ECBs, including megaphoning and scouting that refer to employees' voluntary efforts to collect and circulate strategic organizational information within personal networks and to colleagues and leaders can be outcomes of EE (Kang & Sung, 2017). Further, Lee (2017, 2020) conceptualized ECBs in a crisis by distinguishing two types of behaviors—seeking crisis information and voicing and found ECBs an outcome of employee–organizational relationships.

Although employee voice has been found to be a driver of EE and an outcome as part of ECB during a crisis, we reconcile these perspectives by viewing voice and EE, not as linear but as dynamically interrelated. When organizations actively listen to and act on the voices of their employees, it gives them a sense of ownership which then makes them feel they have a say in their organization. In this chapter, we consider employee voice as an antecedent of EE, while acknowledging that it is an important concept of ECB as an outcome of EE.

Research on internal communication as a key driver of EE within public relations research has examined the following predictors—satisfaction with internal communication (Vercic & Vokic, 2017; Verčič et al., 2023), employee voice (Ruck et al., 2017), symmetrical internal communication (Duthler & Dhanesh, 2018; Kang & Sung, 2017; Krishna, 2022), transparent organizational communication (Jiang & Shen, 2023), information flow, information adequacy and interaction supportiveness of employee communication (Walden et al., 2017), and organizational and supervisor communication (Karanges et al., 2015).

While internal communication satisfaction has been found to predict EE (Verčič et al., 2023), Vercic and Vokic (2017) found that satisfaction with feedback, informal communication, and communication during meetings are the strongest dimensions for EE. Lee (2023) also found support for the effects of the use of formal and informal information and communication technologies on employee job and organizational engagement.

Ruck et al. (2017) found that upward employee voice and senior manager receptiveness to employee voice predicted emotional organizational EE. Similarly, Karanges et al. (2015) found that internal organizational communication and internal supervisor communication contributed to developing and maintaining EE. Kang and Sung (2017), Duthler and Dhanesh (2018), and Krishna (2022) found a positive relationship between symmetrical internal communication and EE. Jiang and Shen (2023) found that transparent organizational communication could positively affect EE. Walden et al. (2017) examined information flow (the open exchange of ideas, issues, and opinions via vertical and horizontal channels of an organization), interaction supportiveness (employees' perceptions of the climate of communication within organizations) and information adequacy (employee views of the content of communication about personal and organizational issues) as factors that could predict job engagement.

To summarize, body of work on drivers of EE has highlighted the rising importance of employee voice, organizational listening, and two-way flows of communication, and the role of formal and informal use of communication technologies, all of which take on added relevance during remote work during a crisis.

Drivers of EE during Crises

Although scholars have examined the influence of various aspects of internal communication on EE, scarce work has examined drivers of EE during a crisis. However, some scholars have examined ICC strategies that could drive EE during a crisis. This work is mostly conceptual (Frandsen & Johansen, 2011), with a few qualitative (Heide & Simonsson, 2015; Ravazzani, 2016) and quantitative empirical studies (Mazzei & Ravazzani, 2015).

Frandsen and Johansen (2011) offered a framework to examine ICC that focuses on (1) employees as receivers, (2) employees as senders, and (3) horizontal communication among managers and employees. The framework offers a set of factors that could have an influence on ICC such as crisis type, cognitive, affective, and behavioral reactions to a crisis; crisis culture; communication culture/climate; and communication strategy. Building on this framework, Mazzei et al. (2012) considered the effect of internal communication on organization–public relationships and ECBs. Mazzei and Ravazzani (2015) offered ICC strategies (transparency, cohesion, evasion, activation of behavior, under-utilization) based on the contents (informative, identification, factual) and objectives of ICC (security, belonging, activating behavior). During the COVID-19 pandemic, accommodative communicative strategies of creating a sense of security, sustaining a sense of belonging, and activating employees as allies of the organization were critical for EE (Mazzei et al., 2022).

Dhanesh and Duthler (2021) found that ICC content was a strong predictor of EE during the pandemic, specifically identification. Other studies also highlighted the importance of informational and relational communication content during the pandemic. For instance, Lee (2023) found that the formal and informal use of ICTs influenced informational and relational communication, which in turn affected employee job and organizational engagement. Similarly, while satisfaction with informational communication influenced employees' acceptance of managerial decisions, satisfaction with relational communication exerted the most influence on affective commitment, the strongest predictor of job engagement (Einwiller et al., 2021).

Further, transformational leadership and leader motivating language, specifically the use of direction-giving and empathetic language (Tao et al., 2022) met employees' autonomy, relatedness, and competence needs satisfaction, which in turn influenced employee organizational engagement during the pandemic, supporting research on the role of authentic leadership as a driver of EE (Krishna, 2022; Jiang & Shen, 2023).

To summarize, research on internal communication factors that influence EE during a crisis has foregrounded the importance of communication content, objectives, and transformational leadership communication that expresses empathy.

Drivers of Virtual/Tele/Digital EE

Larson et al.'s (2020) recommendations to improve engagement and productivity during sudden remote work included establishing daily structured check-ins; providing an array of communication technologies; establishing rules for the frequency, means and timing of communication; providing opportunities for remote social interaction; and offering encouragement and

emotional support by listening to employees' anxieties and concerns and empathizing with their struggles. Among these recommendations, the importance of communication factors such as enabling employee voice, managers' receptivity to employee voice, offering reassurances, and provision of appropriate communication technologies is prominent along with the need for social interaction and connection.

We next discuss broad theoretical conceptualizations and reviews of research on remote work including employees working remotely/virtually, teleworking and utilizing flexi-work programs (Gilson et al., 2015; Makarius & Larson, 2017) and then focus on research on engaging employees remotely.

Makarius and Larson (2017), who reviewed research on virtual work, telecommuting, and computer mediated communication from 1984 to 2015 identified behavioral skills, situational/structural factors, and individual differences that could determine the success of virtual work. Behavioral skills included the individual setting norms for frequency and channel of communication; engendering others' trust in their ability and generating relational trust from others; coordinating information, including information seeking and sharing; the ability to manage a range of technologies, and determine communication media based on media richness and task-tech fit. Situational/structural factors included organizational support through offering appropriate technologies and creating formalized policies for virtual work; managerial processes that included creating patterns of social interaction; and job characteristics such as autonomy, interdependence, and empowerment. Individual factors that determined who might be successful at remote work include personality traits such as agreeableness, openness to experience, extroversion, and conscientiousness; motivational dispositions such as need for affiliation and power; and cultural background, particularly individualism and uncertainty avoidance. In this comprehensive model, internal communication plays a key role across behavioral skills and organizational support, particularly access to information, control over communication technologies, and creating opportunities for social interaction.

The need for social interaction and employee well-being during remote work was also highlighted in another review of work on virtual teams over a ten-year period (Gilson et al., 2015). They noted the scarce literature on well-being and affective states, which could be operationalized as work engagement, and called for more research on whether well-being is positively or negatively affected by working virtually.

Finally, Marlow et al. (2017) reviewed literature on the role of communication in virtual teams and offered a framework linking communication factors that affect outcomes in virtual teams. They identified three variables—communication content, frequency, and quality—that could affect trust and cognition, which can affect outcomes such as satisfaction and performance. McGloin et al. (2022) found a link between frequency of text

messaging and good rapport between employees and supervisors, highlighting the importance of less formal and more personal forms of communication for effective work relationships.

Reviews of literature across virtual teams, remote work, and telecommuting have highlighted the role of communication variables, particularly access to information, control over communication technologies, communication content, communication frequency and creating opportunities for social interaction. In addition, we reviewed empirical work that examined the antecedents, mediators, and moderators of EE.

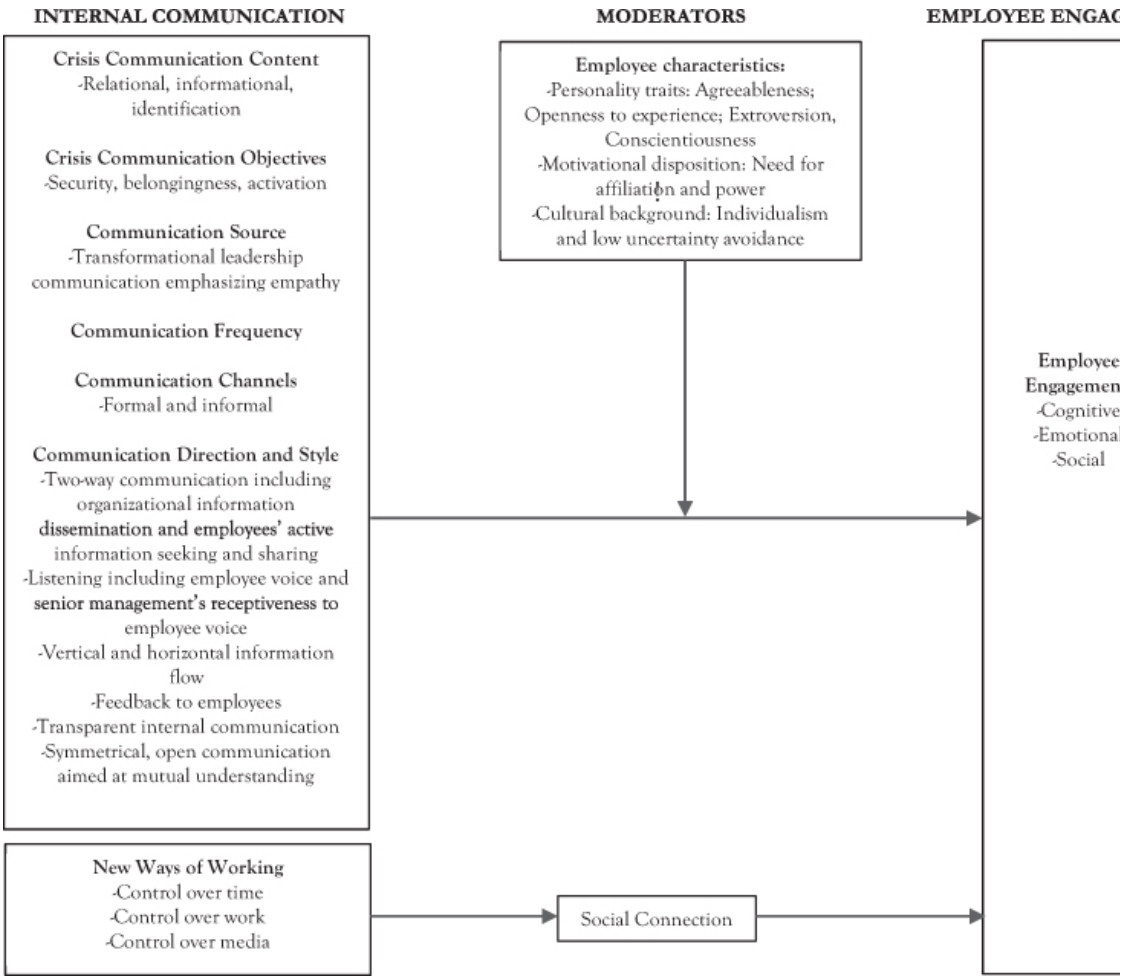
Most of the quantitative studies focused on the effects of new ways of working (NWW) on EE. NWW have typically been operationalized as temporal and spatial flexibility, and control over communication media (ten Brummelhuis et al., 2012; ter Hoeven & van Zoonen, 2023; ter Hoeven et al., 2016). Most importantly, most studies have employed some form of social aspect as a mediator that could explain the effect of NWW on EE. For instance, studies have employed social support (Sardeshmukh et al., 2012), social interaction (Gerards et al., 2018), helping behavior (ter Hoeven & van Zoonen, 2023), and communication quality including connectivity (ten Brummelhuis et al., 2012) and accessibility (ter Hoeven et al., 2016) as mediators in the relationship between workplace flexibility/NWW and employee work engagement.

Other studies have considered the effect of extent of telework on EE mediated by autonomy, feedback, and social support, and on exhaustion, mediated by time pressure, role ambiguity and role conflict (Sardeshmukh et al., 2012), comparable to the behavioral skills of media competence in the Makarius and Larson (2017) model.

As predicted by Makarius and Larson (2017), Shaik and Makhecha (2019) found that technology appropriateness impacts EE in global virtual teams. Instead of being a moderating factor as per the model, formal and informal communication was a predictor of EE. Similarly, Jacobs (2006) found that managers taking special efforts at offering individual and personal attention through communication systems, employees having a voice through participation and two-way communication and permeable social/task communication parameters, could lead to EE.

To summarize, the variables found to influence remote EE include use of appropriate communication technologies, and to a lesser extent communication frequency, in addition to drivers found in general studies of EE such as two-way communication, communication content and social connection.

Based on the above extensive and thorough reviews of literature on communicative drivers of EE, remote EE, and engagement during a crisis, we have put together an expanded RICC framework (see Figure 38.1).



▶ Long Description for Figure 38.1

Figure 38.1 Expanded Remote Internal Crisis Communication (RICC) framework for employee engagement.

The Expanded RICC Conceptual Framework

Within the expanded RICC framework, we have included factors that were most common across the three bodies of literature, particularly communication content, communication objectives, communication source, communication frequency, communication channels, communication direction and style, NWW, and social connection.

What to Communicate and Why: Communication Content and Objectives

Employees valued communication content across all three bodies of work, particularly informational and relational content (e.g., Einwiller et al., 2021; Lee, 2023; Marlow et al., 2017; Ruck & Welch, 2012; Walden et al., 2017), and objectives of creating a sense of security, belonging, and activating employees (Mazzei & Ravazzani, 2015; Mazzei et al., 2022). When a crisis

places inordinate demands on employees to manage their regular work while coping with the crisis, organizations can provide ICC, leveraging which employees are able to stay cognitively, emotionally, and socially engaged. ICC could include various types of ICC content, such as informative, relational, and identification; and ICC objectives that could offer a sense of security and belongingness and activate employees. Empirical research during the COVID-19 pandemic has offered strong support for foregrounding informational and relational communication to bolster EE.

Who Should Communicate: Communication Source

Although Saks et al. (2022) had noted the lack of focus on leadership communication as a driver of organizational engagement, research on internal communication during the COVID-19 pandemic highlighted the increasing importance accorded to transformational leadership communication that emphasized emotion-focused empathetic language (Tao et al., 2022). Leadership communication that employs direction giving language and empathetic language met employees' autonomy, relatedness, and competence needs satisfaction, which in turn helped them to employ coping strategies of control and stay engaged with the organization (Tao et al., 2022).

When and Where to Communicate: Communication Frequency and Channels

To a lesser extent, communication frequency and channels could affect EE (Makarius & Larson, 2017; Marlow et al., 2017, McGloin et al., 2022), specifically the use of formal and informal communication (Lee, 2023; Vercic & Vokic, 2017). When employees are abruptly thrust into a remote working situation and face demands due to a sudden loss of face-to-face communication, organizations can provide them with adequate frequency of communication through channels that allow for less formal communication, helping to build and maintain interpersonal relationships.

How to Communicate: Communication Direction and Style

One of the strongest factors in the framework, communication direction and style includes related concepts such as two-way symmetrical communication (Duthler & Dhanesh, 2018; Kang & Sung, 2017; Krishna, 2022), listening, employee voice and senior management's receptiveness to employee voice (Ruck & Welch, 2012; Ruck et al., 2017; Shen & Jiang, 2019; Jacobs, 2006; Larson et al., 2020), vertical and horizontal information flow (Walden et al., 2017), feedback to employees (Ruck & Welch, 2012; Vercic & Vokic, 2017), and transparent organizational communication (Jiang & Shen, 2023). When faced with uncertainty and anxiety in a crisis, the appropriate communication

direction and style could help to manage EE. Specifically, stronger EE outcomes can be expected when organizations offer opportunities for voicing employee concerns, being receptive to employee voice, fostering two-way symmetrical communication, offering vertical and horizontal lines of communication and performance feedback to employees.

How to Communicate Using ICT: New Ways of Working and Social Connection

Research from remote EE provided the variables of NWW including control over time, work, and media (ten Brummelhuis et al., 2012; ter Hoeven & van Zoonen, 2023; ter Hoeven et al., 2016). Further, the role of social connection in mediating the relationship between NWW and EE has been highlighted by multiple studies (e.g., Gerards et al., 2018; Sardeshmukh et al., 2012). The demands of being suddenly thrown into remote work due to a crisis can be managed if the organization offers resources related to these NWW such as media-rich communication technologies that could offer employees control over their time, content of work and use of task-specific appropriate communication technologies. These resources that strengthen NWW, in addition to the use of relational communication and empathetic leadership communication could address issues of social connection that some employees might crave during isolating remote work in a crisis.

Moderators of Communication Effectiveness: Employee Characteristics

Finally, characteristics of individual employees such as personality traits, motivational disposition, and cultural background (Makarius & Larson, 2017) could moderate the relationships between the independent variables and EE. Although not many studies tested these moderating variables during the COVID-19 pandemic, Lee (2023) found that employees' affiliative tendency could moderate the relationship between the use of formal and informal communication technologies and employee perceptions of information substantiality and relational satisfaction.

Conclusion

According to the expanded RICC Framework, eight aspects of communication can impact remote EE during a crisis—(1) content, (2) objectives, and (3) source (4) direction and style, (5) NWW, and (6) social connection. In addition, although to a lesser extent, (7) communication frequency and (8) channels can also influence EE during remote work in a state of crisis. The

framework offered in this chapter has important implications for theory and practice.

Theoretical Implications and Future Research

This chapter connects literature from internal communication, remote work, and ICC, and offers a conceptual framework for public relations scholarship focused on the role of internal communication in engendering EE while working remotely during a crisis. This expanded, comprehensive RICC framework can aid internal communication researchers to focus on critical communication variables during crises when employees have to work remotely.

Although the COVID-19 pandemic provided near-ideal conditions to test many of the independent variables proposed in the expanded RICC framework, future research could test possible moderators such as open-mindedness, conscientiousness, and cultural background, particularly individualism and uncertainty avoidance. It could also examine the moderating role of organizational cultures. How did remote work impact EE in organizations with toxic cultures versus supportive cultures, and most importantly what role could internal communication play in maintaining EE in organizations with diverse cultures?

Practical Suggestions

Practitioners could provide opportunities for two-way, symmetrical communication that allows employees to share their concerns, particularly when they are away from their physical workplaces during crises. Practitioners could also focus on sharing both informational and relational content, aimed at nurturing a sense of security and belongingness, as well as activating employees as allies of the organization. Leaders could adopt transformational communicative styles that emphasize not just direction giving, but also empathy, which can in turn strengthen relatedness and affiliative needs of employees. Practitioners could ensure that NWW include technological affordances that can bolster social connection. This is particularly important when employees are suddenly torn away from the informal communication and hallway conversations that physical workspaces offer. Finally, they can also pay attention to adequate frequency of communication and the formal and informal use of channels.

Note

1. We use the terms internal communication and employee communication interchangeably in this chapter.

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WHEN EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION BEHAVIOR TRIGGERS ORGANIZATIONAL CRISIS

Strategic Thinking about Internal Crisis Communication (ICC) in Public Relations

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Traditionally, public relations (hereafter, PR) researchers have concentrated on how internal communication can foster employee empowerment and engagement, which can subsequently yield favorable organizational outcomes (Shen & Jiang, 2019). More recently, the focus of research has shifted towards the examination of employee communication during crisis or disaster situations (Kim, 2018; Mazzei et al., 2012). Internal crisis communication (hereafter, ICC), defined as "the communicative interaction among managers and employees in a private or public organization, before, during, and after a crisis occurs in an organization or society" (Johansen et al., 2012), has emerged as a significant theme within the field of PR (Adamu et al., 2023; Coombs, 2014). ICC research, with its emphasis on employees as key stakeholders, offers a valuable framework and concepts for research related to employee communication behavior (hereafter ECB).

However, in ICC research, the primary focus has been on how organizations communicate internally toward employees. Essentially, employees have been primarily viewed as message recipients during and after a crisis who "respond" to organizational messages. Furthermore, what is surprisingly absent is the discussion of organizational-level crises triggered by the ECB itself. In this chapter, we begin with a review of the overall development of ICC research. Subsequently, we categorize ICC research according to variable types: ICC strategies, antecedents, and outcomes. We then assess the status of the ECB concept within the existing ICC literature and argue for a more proactive inclusion of ECB in ICC research, with a specific focus on the analysis of employees' anonymous online communication behavior. Building upon the review, we explore potential directions for future ICC–ECB research and conclude the chapter by discussing practical applications of relevant concepts and frameworks for communication professionals.

Overview of ICC Research

Heide and Simonsson (2020) noted a growing body of research on ICC following Taylor's (2010) call for more studies in the Handbook of Crisis Communication (Coombs & Holladay, 2010). In their review of ICC literature, ICC research was divided into two main perspectives. Process-oriented ICC research is conducted from a social constructivist perspective, while managerialistic ICC research belongs to the instrumental/functionalist perspective. In the former, communication is not considered merely as a variable but rather as a precondition that enables the existence of the organization. Employees are seen as entities that enact the organization through interaction and communication. In the latter perspective, employees are regarded as one of the important stakeholder groups, and the organization is seen as a concrete structure in which various factors of communication interplay (Putnam, 1983). Heide and Simonsson (2020) examined process-oriented ICC research, while in this chapter, we shift to a managerialistic perspective and explore key ICC variables.

Similar to Heide and Simonsson (2020), we searched for peer-reviewed journal articles from 2018 to 2023 (January–July) using Google Scholar and EBSCO. We found 20 papers (see References for the full list). On average, about four papers were published annually during this period, indicating a growing trend, but ICC research is still relatively nascent. Next, we delve into ICC research by key variables.

Key Variables in ICC

The literature on ICC can be categorized into ICC strategies, their antecedents, and outcomes.

ICC Strategies

Studies have developed the ICC framework that outlines communication strategies and assesses the perceived quality of ICC. For instance, Mazzei and Ravazzani (2015) combined objectives and contents and suggested five possible ICC strategies: Transparency strategy uses informative messages to reduce crisis-induced uncertainty. Cohesion strategy aims to improve a sense of belonging by highlighting the organization's unique values and culture. Activation of behavior strategy encourages proactive behaviors through factual messages about the organization's actions. The evasion strategy is employed by organizations that try to activate certain behaviors without taking responsibility or corrective actions. Underutilization strategy involves accepting responsibility and acting but not actively involving employees. Meanwhile, Adamu and Mohamad (2019) developed an ICC scale and proposed 11 ICC items reflecting employees' overall perceptions of their companies' ICC. These items include statements like "I have been clearly informed by management internally about external responses to be used during a crisis" and "I feel like my management is prepared for how to communicate with employees in times of crisis" (for the full list of items, see Adamu & Mohamad, 2019).

PR scholars taking a strategic management approach emphasize transparent and symmetrical internal communication during crises. Transparent internal communication involves making all legally releasable information, whether positive or negative, available to employees, encompassing accountable (i.e., providing complete and inclusive information), participative (i.e., encouraging employees to actively seek, acquire, and transmit useful and relevant information), and substantial (i.e., offering valuable, credible, truthful, and substantial information) principles (Men & Stacks, 2014). During a crisis marked by ambiguity and uncertainty, transparent and symmetrical internal communication aids in minimizing misunderstandings, prompting employees to share pertinent crisis information and alleviate confusion or anxiety (Kim, 2018; Lee et al., 2021).

Empirical research has demonstrated that transparent or symmetrical internal communication is an effective ICC strategy. Kim (2018) found that symmetrical and transparent internal communication improved active positive ECB for sense-making (i.e., information seeking) and sense-giving (i.e., information forwarding). Lee et al. (2021) found that employees who perceived transparent internal communication were more likely to engage in knowledge sharing during the COVID-19 outbreak.

Another group of researchers focuses on crisis response strategies outlined by Coombs' Situational Crisis Communication Theory and timing strategies. Ndone (2023) examined the effects of crisis response strategies (defensive strategy vs. rebuilding strategy) and timing strategies (stealing thunder vs. thunder). He found that in a hypothetical crisis caused by a technological error, the CEO's rebuilding message prevented employees from engaging in unsupportive behaviors, whereas the timing strategy was not a significant influential factor in crisis outcomes. Kim and Lim (2022) focused on a company's crisis strategy to deal with crisis misinformation, which is conceptualized as "false information about a crisis" (Van der Meer & Jin, 2020, p. 561). Misinformation corrective messages include simple rebuttal and factual elaboration. They found that in a crisis related to racial discrimination, the factual elaboration message improved post-crisis internal reputation, and the stealing thunder strategy directly led to employees' positive megaphoning.

Antecedents of ICC Strategies

The ICC research we found has a limited exploration of antecedents, with a primary focus on organizational culture and leadership. Adamu et al. (2016) suggested that organizational culture shapes how an organization perceives, interprets, and responds to a crisis by affecting ICC. When an organization adheres to the principles of a participatory culture during a crisis, employees can engage in productive and meaningful conversations (Kim, 2018). Leadership that values relationships, empathy, and mutual understanding can help an organization navigate a crisis effectively (Adamu et al., 2016). Lee et al. (2021) explored the role of diversity-oriented leadership during the COVID-19 pandemic. Diversity-oriented leadership involves actively engaging employees from diverse backgrounds and appreciating different perspectives (Nembhard & Edmondson, 2006). They found that employees perceived internal communication as participative and

accountable when their leaders were committed to a diverse workforce, collaborated effectively with employees from diverse backgrounds, and sought input from employees.

Outcomes of ICC Strategies

ICC strategies can affect employees' cognitive, affective, and behavioral responses. For cognitive outcomes, studies have explored job engagement and internal reputation. Job engagement denotes "a positive, fulfilling, work-related state of mind characterized by vigor, dedication, and absorption" (Schaufeli et al., 2002, p. 74). Lee et al. (2021) argued that engaged employees can help their organization not only survive during a crisis but also thrive afterward. Their research showed that transparent internal communication enhanced job engagement during the COVID-19 outbreak as it fulfilled employees' needs for autonomy, competence, and relatedness. Dhanesh and Picherit-Duthler (2021) surveyed employees who worked remotely during the COVID-19 pandemic and found that employee engagement was significantly influenced by the content of ICC and the extent of two-way communication. Internal reputation reflects employees' overall perception of their organization. Liu-Lastres et al. (2024) found that employees' perceived internal reputation was enhanced when they recognized transparent communication efforts during a crisis. However, Ndone (2023) noted that internal reputation could be negatively affected when employees perceive negative employee-organization relationships during a crisis.

Regarding emotional outcomes, researchers have explored how ICC can alleviate negative emotional reactions. Liu-Lastres et al. (2024) conducted interviews with tourism employees during the COVID-19 crisis and found that ICC influenced employees' emotional responses differently. Some interviewees who received layoff notices without any communication experienced frustration and upset, while others who perceived ICC as caring and supportive displayed empathy. Psychological safety, "a shared belief amongst individuals as to whether it is safe to engage in interpersonal risk-taking in the workplace" (Newman et al., 2017, p. 521), can be another emotional outcome. Liu-Lastres et al. (2023) stated that psychological safety can be influenced by how employees communicate with co-workers, the organization's crisis-related messages from leaders, and information provided by leaders about arrangements, consequences, and supportive programs. The

authors found that factual and empathetic communication helped employees feel safe at their workplace during the COVID-19 crisis.

Behavioral outcomes encompass ECB and turnover intention. ECB becomes particularly powerful during a crisis, as employees' actions in seeking and transmitting crisis information can foster meaning construction and facilitate others' better understanding of the situation and the organization's efforts to address it (Kim, 2018). Kim (2018, 2020) proposed two types of ECB: sense-making involves searching for and obtaining valuable and positive organization-related information from internal and external stakeholders. Sense-giving involves forwarding valuable and positive organization-related information to internal and external constituencies. Kim (2018) found that employees' sense-making and sense-giving were improved by transparent communication and symmetrical communication. According to Kim (2020), organizational resilience, which reflects employees' beliefs about their capabilities to perform actions and control crises and their ECB to seek and transmit valuable and positive information, can be improved by strong organization-employee relationships during crises.

Researchers have also focused on specific aspects of ECB. For example, Lee et al. (2021) explored knowledge-sharing as an outcome of diversity-oriented leadership and ICC. Knowledge-sharing indicates employees' communication activities aimed at transferring or disseminating knowledge from one person or group to another. They found that employees' knowledge sharing during the COVID-19 pandemic was enhanced when employees perceived diversity-oriented leadership from their managers and transparent internal communication.

It is also important to assess whether ICC can reduce turnover intention among employees. When employees tend to leave their companies after a crisis, the organization may face significant challenges in recovering its damaged reputation and rebuilding mutually beneficial relationships, which can hamper organizational resilience and morale. Relatedly, Liu-Lastres et al. (2024) surveyed employees working in the tourism industry during the COVID-19 pandemic and found that transparent internal communication reduced turnover intention by enhancing the quality of employee-organization relationships.

The Bleeding Edge[1] in ICC Research

PR scholars have primarily focused on ECB as an outcome variable in ICC research. Consequently, research examining crises initiated by ECB is limited. The typical emphasis has been on studying how internal communication, following a crisis triggered by external factors, affects employee behavior or perception. However, in today's context, many organizational crises originate from employees' communication behaviors, often occurring in public spaces like privately operated anonymous social community apps outside the organization's network. Real-world organizations increasingly grapple with this unique communication phenomenon. Given this, it's essential to re-evaluate the current ICC research agenda. Here's an illustrative case to emphasize this point:

> In 2014, the "Nut Rage" crisis at Korean Air began when employees reported an incident on the anonymous community app "Blind," popular among office workers in Korea. VP Hyun Ah Cho ordered a plane to return at JFK Airport in NYC due to dissatisfaction with first-class nut service. She berated the crew captain, humiliated him in front of passengers, and had him removed from the flight, causing a significant delay. Initially, employees used "Blind" for anonymous complaints due to the company's discouragement of open communication. Later, management directed them to leave the platform and sent emails implying collective responsibility for the incident. This led to employees' offline actions, resulting in Cho's resignation and prosecution.
>
> *(Park, 2014)*

As this case shows, in organizational crises related to internal whistleblowing regarding workplace harassment or executive misconduct, there is often a greater need for authentic and sensitive communication with internal stakeholders, namely the employees. Especially in the social media era, where crises triggered by ECBs, like anonymous online posts, are becoming more common, it is necessary to adopt a different approach from traditional crisis response strategies tailored to the external publics. However, existing ICC research has fallen short in addressing crises originating from ECBs. Out of the 20 ICC articles we have identified, 11 dealt with crises originating from external factors and 9 focused on the COVID-19 pandemic as the crisis, researching how organizations communicated with their employees during this pandemic. Among the remaining nine papers, two do not deal

with crises per se; instead, they conducted in-depth interviews and survey research to develop measurement tools for ICC strategies. Consequently, only seven papers dealt with crises caused by internal factors, which encompassed internal crises such as gender discrimination, racial discrimination, technical errors, product recalls, etc. Even within this limited subset, research addressing ECB triggering the onset of crises is exceptionally rare. While many studies provide hypothetical crisis scenarios in the form of news articles and conduct experimental research, it is challenging to find cases where employees' communicative actions, such as whistleblowing or negative megaphoning, are cited as the primary cause of the organizational crisis. Next, we go beyond the ICC literature and explore further employees' anonymous online communication behavior.

Anonymous Online Megaphoning and ICC

As the prevalence of the social media environment continues to grow, the number of employees who share their opinions about organizations externally, without relying on traditional media or the organization's channels, is expected to increase further. Early on, Kim and Rhee (2011) conceptualized megaphoning as employees' positive or negative external communication behaviors about their organization, operationalized as the likelihood of employees' voluntary information forwarding or information sharing about organizational strengths (accomplishments) or weaknesses (problems). Their research laid the foundation for examining in detail whether employees engage in positive or negative megaphoning during crises in PR research. The megaphoning scale has been applied in numerous PR research (see lists of references in Kim, 2020; Lee, 2022; Lee & Kim, 2020) and is also used in ICC research (Kim, 2018, 2020; Kim et al., 2019; Kim & Lim, 2022; Lee, 2021; Lee et al., 2021). However, megaphoning was primarily examined as a communicative action in a public setting with real names among people close to employees, such as co-workers, friends, and family members. Nowadays, employees are not limited to communicating only with people they know but are engaging in broader communication with the public, including strangers. This calls for an expansion in the direction of megaphoning research.

Closely linked to megaphoning and reflecting the dynamic employee communication landscape is the concept of Employee Anonymous Online Dissent (EAOD) discussed by Ravazzani and Mazzei (2018).

They pointed out that existing research has overlooked employees' expressing dissent outside the organization. According to them, the phenomenon of "EAOD" has become a subject of debate in various studies concerning the modern digital environment. Similar to the case of Korean Air mentioned above, the anonymous disclosure incident by former employees about Amazon's labor exploitation in 2015 spread widely on community-based social media services like Reddit and Glassdoor. Ravazzani and Mazzei (2018) highlighted the scarcity of research on employees expressing opinions anonymously in public forums (e.g., Balnave et al., 2014). They explain that because there is a tendency for the public to trust anonymous disclosures more or perceive them as highly important (Callison, 2001; Rains & Scott, 2007), organizations need to address this issue promptly.

Anonymity is not a concept that has frequently been addressed in PR research. However, it is likely to become a crucial research topic, as seen in various corporate crisis cases triggered by anonymous disclosures by employees. Ravazzani and Mazzei (2018) are one of the few scholars who have addressed and explored anonymity in employee communication. Anonymity serves to safeguard minority opinions in democratic societies (Scott, 2004), prioritizes message content over the sender (Marx, 2001), and fosters social participation by marginalized groups (Scott et al., 2011). However, anonymous communication often lacks credibility and accountability, as the originator need not provide evidence or defend their message (Klaas et al., 2012; Scott, 2004). In PR, the understanding of anonymity's multifaceted attributes and its link to ECB is currently quite limited. Similarly, there is a complete absence of research on how ICC should be conducted in crises triggered by anonymous online communication by employees. Therefore, finding recommendations for how to examine and address crisis-inducing anonymous communication from an organizational management perspective is even more challenging. Based on the literature review, we propose Anonymous Online Megaphoning (AOM) as an important and long overdue research agenda in PR research on ICC and ECB. We define AOM as "positive or negative online anonymous external communication behavior of employees about one's organization". Future research agenda could be structured around the AOM concept.

First, research needs to uncover the motivations behind why employees use anonymous channels. In a survey of users of the Blind social app among Korean employees, it was found that employees primarily use the app to access company and industry information, with

the next most common use being to raise issues about organizational misconduct and problems (Noh & Lee, 2021). Particularly, it was observed that dependence on anonymous apps increases when employees feel they are not receiving the necessary support in their work or perceive their affiliated organization as unethical. Considering the findings from the PR research discussed previously, which indicate that positive ECB intentions are higher when organizational communication is transparent and two-way symmetrical, it can be expected that dependence on anonymous apps is closely related to the quality of internal communication. Along with AOM motivation research, there is a need for a detailed exploration of the various antecedents of positive and negative AOM and the situations that trigger them. Additionally, the organizational culture, considered a critical ICC factor by Heide and Simonsson (2020), should be addressed as a variable that can influence AOM. They predicted that a democratic and participatory culture would have a more positive impact on ICC, and it would be worthwhile to verify if similar results are obtained regarding AOM.

Second, the collection and analysis of crisis cases triggered by negative AOM in real-world situations are needed. By designing scenarios based on such case analyses and exploring the relationships among various ICC variables, more insightful findings can be expected. Third, exploration is required on how the perceptions of the public exposed to AOM are linked to organizational reputation, the organization–public relationship, and crisis message acceptance. Investigating whether the public utilizes AOM as a guideline for assessing and trusting an organization can help organizations gauge how they should conduct their external and ICC in tandem. Fourth, research should be conducted on how internal organizational communication in AOM-triggered crises affects employee-public relationships, employees' behavioral intentions, such as turnover intentions, and other related outcome factors. Such research can provide strategic insights to human resources (HR) and communication professionals tasked with employee retention. Fifth, exploring the relationship between generational differences in work ethics and the manifestation of AOM-triggered crises can also provide valuable insights to HR and internal communication professionals. In addition, conducting a cross-cultural study to see if AOM patterns differ depending on cultural, political, and technological developments in various countries could help explore the possibility of constructing a generalizable scale.

Practical Applications for Strategic Management of AOM and ICC

Research on AOM and ICC is still in its early stages of development. Developing more refined diagnostic tools and conceptual frameworks for ICC and AOM is a pressing task for PR scholars. However, the contents discussed in this chapter can undoubtedly offer practical assistance to professionals in managing ICC in the field and understanding employees' external anonymous communication behavior.

Firstly, the list of ICC strategies can be readily used when practitioners investigate employees' perceptions of ICC. The five strategies proposed by Mazzei and Ravazzani (2015), the 11 auditing items suggested by Adamu et al. (2016, 2019), and concepts like transparent communication, two-way symmetrical communication, crisis corrective response strategies, and timing strategies (e.g., stealing thunder) applied by Lee et al. (2021) and Kim et al. (2022) can be employed to construct employee perception survey questions or auditing tools for assessing organizational ICC readiness and post-crisis evaluations.

Moreover, practitioners can utilize the AOM concept presented in this chapter to understand and respond to employees' use of anonymous communication channels they encounter in their daily work. Existing megaphoning measurement tools (Kim & Rhee, 2011) can be easily revised and adapted to assess AOM intentions. Organizational culture and leadership communication as antecedents to AOM can be evaluated by drawing items from the research findings (e.g., Adamu et al., 2016; Lee et al., 2021) discussed in this chapter. Practitioners can explore cognitive (Dhanesh & Picherit-Duthler, 2021), emotional (e.g., Liu-Lastres et al., 2024), and behavioral (e.g., Kim, 2018) consequences of ICC by adopting respective concepts and measurements reviewed in this chapter.

Introducing specific conceptual frameworks and measurement tools for ICC and AOM will empower practitioners to proactively diagnose and plan for crises stemming from AOM. This endeavor can not only highlight the direct link between AOM and organizational-level crises in the social media era but also help persuade decision-makers of the vital importance of strategic ECB and ICC management.

Note

1. This term describes the most advanced or experimental technology, ideas, or practices in their early stages of development and often involves uncertainty. It contrasts with the "cutting edge", representing established and widely adopted technology or practices (https://dictionary.cambridge.org/ko/%EC%82%AC%EC%A0%84/%EC%98%81%EC%96%B4/bleeding-edge). Coombs (2014), a renowned crisis management scholar, referred to the so-called "social media crisis" as a bleeding edge crisis type in his Institute for PR (IPR) article. Inspired by his use of the term, this chapter proposes AOM, a more specific social media communication phenomenon, as a bleeding-edge research topic.

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PANDEMIC AND EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION

Unprecedented Changes in Employee Communication and Organizational Processes

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Employee communication during crises or internal crisis communication is a dynamic and continuous communication process that involves all organizational members as communicators in the roles of receivers, senders, sensegivers and sensemakers, as well as contributors to crisis management and outcome (Mazzei & Ravazzani, 2022). Regardless of crisis type and origin, poorly managed internal communication can create a dual crisis with a decline in employee trust in the organization (Frandsen & Johansen, 2017). Pandemics represent a special type of crisis (Diers-Lawson et al., 2021): they involve multiple crisis events and cycles over an extended period, collective responsibility, rapid deployment of communication, and a high degree of interagency collaboration. Consequently, pandemic communication differs from traditional health and crisis communication and presents unique challenges to organizations and their employee communication in managing pandemic-induced changes.

This chapter aims to delve into pandemic and employee communication, focusing on the unprecedented changes brought about by COVID-19, which represents the most impactful pandemic of our

times. The COVID-19 pandemic differed from previous pandemics (e.g., the Zika virus, Ebola, H1N1, MERS) in the magnitude of its impact on all people and social institutions on a global scale (Diers-Lawson et al., 2021). In this sense, it could be conceptualized as a "high-magnitude crisis" (Moskowitz et al., 2011), similar to global financial or climate crises, that is, a crisis that expands over time, affects many people and societies, and requires dynamic modeling for an effective response given the incomplete and often contradictory understanding of the situation, the spread of misinformation and the lack of visibility of the measures taken and their effectiveness. For organizations, the pandemic also represented a chronic (Chon et al., 2021), sticky crisis (Coombs et al., 2020) because it affected so many organizations simultaneously and its ripple effects were recurring, persisting, or even worsening over time. Moreover, this pandemic embodied a "wicked problem" that exhibited an extremely high degree of complexity and ambiguity (Heide & Simonsson, 2021), which further challenged organizations' communication efforts to make sense of pervasive confusion and uncertainty.

While the COVID-19 pandemic represented an exogenous, uncontrollable crisis for organizations, its severe consequences were an internal problem, and indeed, employees were among the most affected stakeholders (Chon et al., 2021). From one day to the next, employees were asked to adhere to new routines and strict health regulations, work from home, and deliver new products or services. In some cases, employees suffered pay cuts due to reduced working hours or were even laid off. These severe crisis effects had a strong impact on employees' sense of belonging, engagement, socialization, collaboration, and prioritization of work and life. Faced with this crisis, for which there were no comparable precedents, companies were forced to rethink their established methods of work, leadership, and communication.

To help make sense of such changes in employee communication, this chapter first provides an integrative review of the key themes and findings gleaned from a selection of studies on employee communication in this pandemic context. Second, this chapter builds on these findings to develop theoretical and practical implications. It concludes with an outlook on the future of pandemic and employee communication.

Employee Communication in the Face of COVID-19: Core Themes and Learnings

This section draws on cross-national evidence from studies conducted around the world following the outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic to identify, relate, and understand the profound changes and challenges this crisis brought to employee communication.

Cross-Situational Factors: Crisis History and Relationship Quality

The literature on employee communication variously points to the existence of cross-situational factors that form the basis of employee trust, satisfaction, and commitment in both normal and critical times, and thus impact the approach and effectiveness of internal crisis communication. Cross-situational factors (e.g., employees' evaluation of the workplace or the company's prior crisis history) differ from situational factors in that they concern the overall perception of organizational factors and are not exclusively related to a specific crisis. An analysis of studies of employee communication during the COVID-19 pandemic highlights the cross-situational factors of organizational conflict history and existing relationship quality between employees and the organization.

Chon, Tam, and Kim (2021) examined the interaction effects of organizational conflict history, that is, employees' memories of past conflicts in the organization, and situational perceptions of COVID-19 on employees' positive or negative behavioral intentions. They started from the premise that "organizations exist over time, and their pasts create either doubt or/and trust for their current actions. When a crisis occurs, there are accentuated impacts from how communication managers have dealt with the problems in and around organizations" (p. 310). They identified organizational conflict history as a key factor that influenced employees' perceptions of and reactions to the pandemic, with employees in highly conflict-prone workplaces reporting higher negative megaphoning and turnover intentions compared to employees in less conflict-prone workplaces. In addition, employees' situational perceptions of a crisis would exacerbate the effects. Their findings underscore the need for proactive and symmetrical internal crisis communication to facilitate employees' coping process and preserve employee-organization relationships.

Several studies emphasize the critical role of employee-organization relationships in explaining communication approaches, employees' crisis perceptions and their communication behaviors. For example, Neill and

Bowen (2021) highlighted how cultivating an open communication climate provides the foundation for a quality employee-organization relationship that supports effective communication and positive employee outcomes during a crisis. They focused on the listening challenges posed by the COVID-19 pandemic, when a large portion of the workforce transitioned to telecommuting. Their study shows that organizational listening is important not only for identifying employee communication needs and making room for employee voice, but also because it has the potential to activate the moral sensitivity and empathy of organizational decision makers. Yet while listening was valued during the pandemic, it was often not prioritized. This lack of priority is explained by management's lack of desire to truly listen to employees, as well as lack of time, lack of employee trust, and unfavorable remote working conditions. Despite these challenges to listening in organizations, the authors emphasized that moral sensitivity, empathy, openness, and ethical decision-making in organizations are important lessons learned from the COVID-19 pandemic.

Employee Communication Approach and Situational Antecedents of Its Quality

Organizations face the challenge of developing effective communicative responses in times of crisis. Research points to accommodative approaches to internal crisis communication (Mazzei & Ravazzani, 2015; Mazzei et al., 2022) as best suited to address the unique bond between employees and the organization and the intense psychological reactions employees typically experience during organizational crises. Research on employee communication in the context of the COVID-19 pandemic reveals the predominant approaches and core characteristics that affected the quality of that communication as perceived by employees and their reactions.

Ecklebe and Löffler (2021) examined predictors and outcomes of high-quality employee communication. Their study identified the following key factors: frequency of communication with employees, dissemination of substantial information based on informative and factual content, participatory communication style to address employee communication needs, and firm rejection of secrecy to ensure openness in communication. They found that high-quality communication had a positive impact on the overall employee-organization relationship, on the sub-dimensions of trustworthiness, commitment, and job satisfaction.

Einwiller, Ruppel, and Stranzl (2021) showed that, on the one hand, informational communication, which conveys both instructive information and transparent information about the crisis impact on the organization and employees, promoted employees' acceptance of managers' decisions; on the other hand, relational communication, which includes participatory and appreciative forms, influenced employees' affective commitment and, consequently, their engagement during the protracted COVID-19 pandemic.

Transparent communication consisting of accountability, substantiality and participation was found to promote employees' problem-oriented control coping, reduce uncertainty, improve the quality of employee-organization relationships (Li et al., 2021), and support employees' efforts to re-evaluate change and engage in change-promoting behaviors, which in turn reduced their willingness to leave the organization (Yue & Walden, 2023). Stranzl, Ruppel, and Einwiller (2021) demonstrated the importance of transparent communication and in particular substantial information to improve engagement. They also found that the relationship between transparency and engagement was mediated by trust in the organization, while job-specific anxiety mediated the relationship between transparency and disengagement. Interestingly, disengagement was higher among workers who worked in remote locations. In this regard, Dhanesh and Picherit-Duthler (2021) added that relational communication, which includes two-way interactions and content aimed at enhancing trust and identification among employees, was particularly important in promoting engagement among employees working at remote sites during this pandemic.

Other studies analyzed the quality of employee communication as symmetrical communication, that is, communication that incorporates employee input into the organization's decision-making, in fostering employee perceptions of the quality of internal crisis communication, perceptions of organizational support, and positive emotions (e.g., relief and hope), which in turn led to stronger identification with the organization (Sun et al., 2021). Symmetric communication was also found to be effective in nurturing employees' trust in the organization, which in turn positively affected employees' psychological well-being (Qin & Men, 2022), and in inducing positive external communication behaviors (Perdana et al., 2021). Similarly, dialogic communication was found to influence employee efficacy and perceived threat of COVID-19 through the collaborative relationship with the organization, which in turn led employees to engage in safety behaviors at work (Lee, 2022).

While frequent, transparent, relational, symmetrical, and dialogical communication is in some ways a common thread for quality employee communication during the COVID-19 pandemic, some scholars cautioned against viewing employees as a homogeneous group and suggested adapting the communication approach to their different roles, needs, and crisis-related circumstances. Horlait and Lambotte (2021) showed that segmentation based on employees' work realities (e.g., telecommuting, or temporary unemployment) and exposure to different risks specific to their work situation provided fine-tuning of communication to the different communication needs. Similarly, other studies detailed the differential impact of internal crisis communication on full-time versus part-time and salaried versus hourly employees (Liu-Lastres et al., 2023), and on management and administrative staff versus core professional employees (Falkheimer et al., 2022).

Finally, research showed that employee communication during COVID-19 had to simultaneously address communication needs related to creating a sense of security, maintaining a sense of belonging, and activating employees as allies of the organization (Mazzei et al., 2022). The findings also show that employee engagement and protection were important contingency factors that led to the adoption of an accommodative approach to internal crisis communication that was best suited to manage the intense emotional reactions of employees.

Leadership Communicative Role and Sensegiving

Organizational leaders are expected to engage in employee communication during a crisis to provide clear direction, reduce ambiguity, and support sensemaking, while ensuring that statements made are consistent with actions taken (Frandsen & Johansen, 2017; Mazzei & Ravazzani, 2015). The COVID-19 crisis presented heightened challenges to organizational leaders, to the point that some even argue that this crisis was also a leadership crisis (Tourish, 2020).

Yeomans and Bowman (2021) highlighted the critical role that employee-focused sensegiving played during this pandemic. They identified three core sensegiving narratives requiring sense to be reframed as events unfolded: organizational competence and resilience; empathy, reassurance, and recognition; and community and location. Their findings show how leaders in the highly uncertain and stressful pandemic context were able to construct emotions in relating with employees, help them understand the changing realities, and mitigate

perceived dissonance. Men, Qin, and Jin (2021) focused on leaders' use of meaning-making, empathetic, and direction-giving language during the pandemic, which had a positive effect on employees' trust in both leadership and the organization. Again, sensegiving by leaders appeared to be essential in aligning employees' personal goals and concerns with a higher purpose for the organization and in building trust in the leadership's and organization's ability to manage the crisis.

Heide and Simonsson (2021) suggested that effective crisis leadership in a complex crisis such as the COVID-19 pandemic must focus on improvisation, collective sensemaking, and listening to employees. This is especially important when employees are expected to act as ambassadors to support the organization in its crisis management efforts. However, their study shows that while leaders displayed knowledge and rhetoric about the role of employees as active crisis sensemakers and communicators, top-down information dissemination prevailed. Santoso, Sulistyaningtyas, and Pratama (2022) described the characteristics of transformational leaders during the COVID-19 pandemic: encouraging employees to take active communicative actions, using empathy to generate gratitude, presenting the actual situation of the organization, listening to employees' voices, and framing the crisis as an opportunity. Such a style influenced acceptance of management decisions and engagement among employees.

The need for more transparent and participatory communication is also highlighted by Haavisto and Linge (2022). Their case studies show that leadership transparency and presence facilitated employees' sensemaking and helped build trust relationships during the pandemic, with a special role assigned to listening for encouraging employees to share suggestions on how to deal with the crisis internally.

Effective crisis sensegiving, therefore, requires that the organization listens to employees during a pandemic in a way that is both ethical and strategic. As the previously cited work of Neill and Bowen (2021) emphasizes, "listening efforts need to be authentic, morally autonomous or open-minded, and empathetic to respect the genuine concerns of employees and how organizational decisions will affect them" (p. 276). It is suggested that leaders and communication professionals should cultivate and enhance moral sensitivity even after the pandemic to build on the lessons learnt from the COVID-19 crisis.

Employee Crisis Sensemaking and Communication Behaviors

One of the growing perspectives on internal crisis communication emphasizes that employees can assume the communicative roles of crisis sensegivers and sensemakers (e.g., Frandsen & Johansen, 2017; Mazzei et al., 2012; Mazzei & Ravazzani, 2022). Such active roles imply that employees can reject or reinterpret the intended meaning of the company's official crisis communication and positively or negatively influence external stakeholders' perceptions.

Looking at research on employee communication during COVID-19, Heide and Simonsson (2021) underscored the value of employees and communicative coworkership. They also highlighted a critical tension in internal crisis communication: while employees were treated *de facto* as passive recipients of information, they were expected to act as active communicators to the outside world. Their findings suggest that employees' roles as active crisis sensemakers and communicators are best achieved through open dialog, collaboration, and listening for collective sensemaking, rather than through orders and directives for unilateral crisis management.

Chon, Tam and Kim's (2021) study added that adversarial external communication behaviors can be a negative outcome among situationally motivated employees in conflict-prone organizations. Therefore, symmetrical communication is essential for creating shared crisis awareness and aligning employee and organizational crisis perceptions, which in turn results in positive employee communicative behaviors both internally and externally. Indeed, Perdana, Latifunnur, and Hendriana (2021) examined how good employee-organization relations leading to symmetrical internal crisis communication encouraged employees to engage in positive external communication behaviors, that is, advocating for the organization, recognizing the crisis as a serious problem, feeling more involved and less constrained in problem solving, and less likely to share negative messages. Similarly, other studies (Mazzei et al., 2021; Mazzei et al., 2022) showed the prevalence of positive outward-facing employee communication behaviors, namely withstanding pressure to protect confidential company information and acting as brand ambassadors.

In summary, these studies detail how the COVID-19 pandemic stimulated a greater focus on the idea of communicative organizations, in which employees play the role of active communicators and advocates who support their organizations and contribute to building organizational resilience through their internal and external communication behaviors.

Tensions in Pandemic Communication Management

Crisis researchers adhering to a social constructivist perspective (e.g., Heide & Simonsson, 2015) emphasize how paradoxical tensions are embedded in crisis understanding and crisis communication for which no simplistic either/or thinking can provide a solution.

From this perspective, a study by Ravazzani, Mazzei, and Butera (2024) addressed the conflicting demands that the complexity of the COVID-19 pandemic placed on employee communication. In the acute phase, they identified the following key tensions: "planning-improvisation", where planned and structured communication was needed to respond quickly and reduce uncertainty, but also improvisation through experimentation with new tools and continuous review of priorities; "formalization-spontaneity", where employee communication relied on institutionalized top-down communication from managers to provide constant and transparent information, but also on bottom-up communication generated by employees themselves to facilitate their crisis sensemaking and address their communication needs; "internal-external", where employee communication focused on internal stakeholders to inform and reassure them, but also extended to external stakeholders by repurposing internal crisis narratives. In the subsequent normalization phase, the evolution of the pandemic created additional tensions: "emergency-resilience", in which employee communication continued to function in an emergency-crisis logic, but also gradually acquired a resilience logic, in which change became normal and the innovations, initially introduced through improvisation and experimentation, became established; "preservation—revitalization", where the organization's history and core values served as a compass in employee communication to help employees cope with the crisis, but evolving cultural and management models also became part of the narrative to sustain changing conditions and shared sentiments; "work engagement-sociality", where employee communication struggled to maintain high levels of engagement in work tasks and duties, but also addressed increased sensitivity to relationship and socialization issues.

Other research revealed tensions related to, for example, the difficulty of using employees as crisis communicators while prioritizing instructional communication (Heide & Simonsson, 2021), or using listening while failing to incorporate employee voices in decision-making (Haavisto & Linge, 2022).

All in all, these tensions embody the complexity and rapidly changing conditions that challenged established employee communication practices. In many cases, this created space for approaches based on "emergent learning" and creative improvisation (Fischbacher-Smith & Adekola, 2022).

Building on the COVID-19 Experience: Theoretical and Practical Implications

Overall, the unprecedented challenges posed by the COVID-19 pandemic and the lessons learnt for employee communication can inform future theory and practice.

Theoretical Implications

This chapter contributes to the growing body of research on pandemic and employee communication in several ways.

First, the studies reviewed collectively contribute to describing the core elements of high-quality employee communication during a complex and prolonged crisis such as a pandemic. While the various studies contribute to a specific conceptualization of key constructs such as relational or dialogical employee communication, it remains that this crisis threatened the entire value system of the organization, resulting in changes that are likely to persist. This pandemic placed new demands on employee communication and leadership to become less top-down, more participatory, focused on genuine listening, transparent in admitting that organizations may have only provisional answers, and has gradually institutionalized them. The integrative review also shows the various positive effects of such high-quality employee communication on employee-related outcomes such as trust, identification, acceptance of management decisions, engagement, and safety behaviors, while reducing disengagement, perceived threat, anxiety, and turnover intentions. This encourages researchers to further investigate the multiple antecedents, moderated and mediated effects, as well as the cognitive, affective, and behavioral outcomes beyond the singularity of this pandemic and at the intersection of employee, risk, crisis, and change communication.

Second, this chapter emphasizes the importance of preemptively managing organizational conflict and cultivating an open communication climate to preserve the quality of employee-organization relations in both

normal and crisis times. The evidence gathered shows that employees in workplaces that have experienced more conflict in the past are more likely to doubt their organization and engage in negative communication behaviors that discredit management's problem-solving efforts. In contrast, when quality relationships and ethical and strategic listening are established, employees feel they are treated fairly and have more confidence in their leaders' ability to meet any challenge.

Third, to attract employees' supportive emotions, cognitions, and behaviors, organizations must provide adequate resources in return for their employees' resources, which take the form of trust, identification, engagement, and so on. This is not just about providing material resources such as money and equipment, but more importantly socio-emotional resources, such as "love" through the communication of appreciation in relational employee communication (e.g., Einwiller et al., 2021). While providing timely and reliable information is important in crisis situations, relational and appreciative communication makes all the difference in strengthening emotional attachment and commitment. Additional studies are needed to clarify how organizations and their leaders can provide employees with adequate socio-emotional resources and thus uphold the principles of communicative organizations in which employees act as key actors in crisis management. Furthermore, as suggested at the beginning of this chapter, pandemics can be considered "high-magnitude crises" as they are characterized by multiple cycles, extremely high levels of information ambiguity and uncertainty, and the need for collective responsibility and interagency collaboration. Therefore, further research is needed to understand how employees' resources (e.g., engagement) can be sustained over time during such protracted and severe crises.

Practical Implications

This chapter also offers implications for pandemic and employee communication practices, given the unique impact of the COVID-19 pandemic and the new communication practices it brought.

First, the studies reviewed outlined in different ways how employees perceived and responded to the pandemic differently. Communication professionals should proactively use strategic and ethical listening (Neill & Bowen, 2021) to better understand the communication needs of employees, identify the specific concerns of the most active employees who might turn their activity into adversarial behavior, and avoid

misalignment and disconnection among employee groups that differ in occupation, work reality, and risk exposure. Such a listening practice should lead to a more refined approach to segmenting internal publics and tailoring messages, facilitating the strategic allocation of resources to maintain positive organizational-employee relationships.

Second, employee engagement strategies should be rethought in light of the evolving psychological contracts and the different communication needs of employees in hybrid workplaces that persisted after the COVID-19 pandemic. For example, relational communication takes on a new importance for the population that works partially or entirely from home. In addition, engagement strategies should proactively recognize the ultimate disruption of internal-external communications and the growing role of employees as active communicators, who may influence colleagues as well as external stakeholders to become advocates or opponents of their employer.

Finally, the renewal of organizations and employee communication triggered by this pandemic disruption requires the development of new competencies among leaders through training and communication initiatives. Employees expect leadership to be performed through empathy, participatory decision-making, and emotion-based language to establish a human connection in employee-organization relationships. Such individual leadership competencies appear to be essential for effective sensegiving intended as future-orientated sensemaking during transformational changes, as well as for implementing employee-centered leadership in regular times.

Future Outlook: A Processual, Paradoxical Perspective

Although the COVID-19 crisis obviously taught many lessons that organizations, leaders, and employees alike can build upon to create better workplaces for today and prepare for future crises, this pandemic was such an unprecedented event that it is reasonable to assume that other unique and unimaginable scenarios may occur in the future. Managing the "unimaginable" (Zerfaß et al., 2023) might therefore be best accomplished by adopting a paradoxical perspective on crises and internal (crisis) communication.

According to this perspective, crises should be viewed as perceptual, processual, and integrated phenomena that are accompanied by ambiguity, disorientation, and lack of control, yet are part of "normal" organizational life (Heide & Simonsson, 2015, 2021; Ravazzani et al.,

2024). Internal crisis communication should be understood as a complex process that is meaning-driven and based on a holistic understanding of the organization as an ensemble of cultural and psychological elements and multiple and often divergent voices. Only by recognizing messiness and paradoxical tensions as fundamental features of crisis and employee communication can both-and or more-than thinking as well as improvisation become the resources needed to manage both imaginable and unimaginable events.

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AI, CHATBOTS, AND EMPLOYEE COMMUNICATION

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On November 30, 2022, the company, OpenAI, introduced ChatGPT, a chatbot driven by Generative Pre-Trained Transformer (GPT) models, hence the name ChatGPT (Marr, 2023). Within five days, more than 1 million users signed up. Following this, OpenAI, the company that owns ChatGPT, received approximately 1.7 billion visits per month. Meanwhile, as of November 2023, 16,200 keywords were used for accessing ChatGPT on the web, with the most frequently searched keyword being "chatgpt", which received 25.8 million searches each month. By May 2024, ChatGPT achieved 180 million users, with the largest segment of users coming from the United States, but it only contributed to about 12.04% of ChatGPT's total accounts (Duarte, 2024). Given this, one can regard the adoption of ChatGPT as a global phenomenon. Following this, Microsoft invested in ChatGPT for the third time with $10 billion in 2023 in order to integrate it into its search engine, Bing (Q.ai, 2023). The first two investments took place in 2019 and 2021, respectively.

On March 21, 2023, Google introduced Bard, in response to Microsoft's integration of ChatGPT (Alba & Love, 2023). The name Bard means exceptional ability in storytelling and creativity, often given to a poet or storyteller (Wankhede, 2023). Shortly after Google's release of Bard, ChatGPT and other chatbots were hailed by many as the solutions for query-answering, language translation, and text summarization, possibly replacing personal assistants, researchers, editors, as well as some of the earlier usage in customer service, therapy,

and entertainment. ChatGPT is capable of learning language structure, syntax, semantics, and even context. Overnight, ChatGPT made artificial intelligence (AI) chatbots "hot and trendy".

However, chatbots are not new technology. Several chatbots have been utilized by companies to help with their organizational communication needs prior to ChatGPT. In this chapter, we discuss the general topics of AI, chatbots, and employee communication by looking at a few main points. First, we discuss AI applications at the workplace, such as internal communication and external communication. Second, we explore AI's affordances at the workplace, including automation, personalization, and self-learning. Third, we examine two challenges of AI in the workplace, which include the ethical considerations of biases in AI systems, the threats of AI at the workplace, as well as fairness, transparency, and privacy. Fourth, we provide a brief overview of three theoretical frameworks for understanding AI adoption and implementation in organizations. Finally, we conclude with some thoughts and future directions. While there are many other topics to include, we believe this brief overview provides a good starting point for interested readers before they explore this body of literature further. This chapter continues in the next paragraph on AI's organizational applications.

AI's Applications at the Workplace

Internal Communication

AI and chatbots have been used for internal communication purposes within organizations. For example, AI can facilitate the onboarding process of new employees (Singh et al., 2021) such as task assignments, coworkers' introductions, and company policy overview. Furthermore, AI can be used to assess employees' performance, identify limitations, and recommend training programs to improve performance (Sima et al., 2020). In a study by Kowalski et al. (2013), they tested the use of a chatbot (Sally) in training professionals about information security. They reported that 70% of the participants who did the training with the Sally chatbot found Sally to be useful, and over 70% of the participants also reported that Sally had a positive effect on their training and learning about information security, and that they would use the chatbot again if presented with another opportunity in the future. AI chatbots are capable

of various organizational tasks because of several affordances, which we discuss later in this chapter.

Another AI's application for internal communication is the use of algorithms to screen a large amount of information, such as job applications. For example, Xerox, an IT company, uses algorithms to screen job applicants (Peck, 2013). The software generates an index score which represents an applicant's fit with the advertised job. This index score is operationalized to include several dimensions, such as qualifications provided on the resumes, assessment of the applicants' likelihood of handling specific job-related challenges appropriately, and a comparison between characteristics of new applicants against past and current employees who are high performers. Although AI screening software has its own limitations, such as biases potentially built into the codes, algorithms, and/or datasets with certain assumptions (see the section 'Ethical Challenges of AI at Work' in this chapter), Buckley and Eder (1988) argue that human screening is based on 'snap decisions'. Furthermore, Edgar and Geare (2004) suggest that demographic information, such as gender, age, ethnicity, and so on, can consciously and unconsciously slip into decision maker's judgments, even though doing so is technically illegal under U.S. federal law. Given these biases, proponents of AI screening argue that algorithms can be more comprehensive, systematic, and fair (Deshpande et al., 2020).

A third organizational application of AI is text summarization of complex business reports. According to Allahyari et al. (2017), automated text summarization software programs often follow the three main steps of analyzing the text in the input sources, determining the salient points in the information, and synthesizing an appropriate summary as an output. Besides ChatGPT and Bard already discussed in the introduction, other Pre-Trained Language Models that can perform text summarization include PEGASUS (Zhang et al., 2020), T5 (Raffel et al., 2020), and Switch (Fedus et al., 2022). Although the potential of these applications is exciting, Naidoo and Dulek (2022) concluded in their study that the effectiveness of AI summarization software of complex business reports is about 22% to 26%. In other words, there is still room for improvement in the application of AI for automated text summarization in organizations.

External Communication

As mentioned earlier, AI chatbots are not new to organizations. An example of organizational use of AI for external communication is in the area of customer service. For example, Ava (Autodesk Virtual Agent) is a chatbot used by Autodesk, a 3D design software company. Ava is available 24/7, capable of addressing customer questions and issues in about five minutes on average (Prakash, 2019). Ava was designed to have a persona, which includes a female face and a female voice (Shumanov & Johnson, 2021). Shortly after implementation, Ava was able to address about 15,000,000 calls from customers per month, increasing the company's ability to address customer service queries by 100% (Schneider, 2017). Chatbots such as Ava can be effective for customer service because they do not get tired or need a break, they do not react to angry and rude customers, and they are not face-threatening to customers who are unsure if their questions may sound silly to a human agent (Calvert, 2017).

Another example of organizational use of AI chatbot is Luvo, which was first tested by Royal Bank of Scotland in a limited trial in 2016 (Mazumdar & Jyoti, 2019) and then early 2018 (Lui & Lamb, 2018) with internal employees who manage accounts with small and midsize enterprises. In the early days, Luvo was mainly capable of answering queries such as "I've lost my bank card" and "I've bolted my PIN" (Mehra & Singh, 2021, p. 10). Over time, it became capable of handling more complex inquiries, incorporating more personalization, separating multiple questions and issues for customers, and recommending appropriate actions successfully. Luvo can now free up human support teams to handle more complex questions from customers. In contrast to Ava, Luvo's example demonstrates both internal communication (i.e., supporting employees) and external communication (i.e., customer service) of AI chatbots. This highlights the different affordances of AI at the workplace.

AI's Affordances at the Workplace

Automation

Automation speaks to the system's adeptness to execute tasks efficiently and precisely by itself, and without feeling tired (Li et al., 2023). In many work-related tasks, especially those involving repetitive processes, AI has the potential to outperform human efforts (Brougham & Haar, 2018). Taking ChatGPT as an example, it provides non-stop availability,

immediate support, and a performance standard that remains consistent, uninfluenced by human factors such as mood swings or fatigue. AI's proficiency to process growing data volumes, its ability to communicate in multiple languages, and the scope for international service outreach further highlight its competency. By integrating generative AI into organizational functions such as customer support through chatbots, automated email replies, and content monitoring, businesses can achieve faster, more precise, and relentless task completion compared to relying solely on human labor. This AI intervention paves the way for employees to concentrate on tasks that demand nuanced decision-making or innovative thinking.

Personalization

In the evolving landscape of organizational operations, AI-driven personalization signifies the system's ability to tailor its functionalities to meet the unique needs of a particular enterprise or its workforce (Bubeck et al., 2023). Contemporary studies highlight the escalating significance of personalization in elevating employee satisfaction and enhancing human capabilities within the workplace (Kumar et al., 2019; Schork, 2019). Generative AI tools can dynamically adjust their outputs based on evolving employee feedback and preferences. To achieve a high degree of customization, AI algorithms continuously collect and interpret data related to employee demographics, behaviors, and preferences, forming a comprehensive user profile. This profile then serves as a blueprint for AI-driven customizations. Additionally, AI solutions can be refined to meet individual employee requirements, from adapting visual displays to benefit those with visual impairments to simplifying interfaces for employees less acquainted with advanced technological solutions. This vision of personalization stands as a cornerstone for the future of work, ensuring that technology aligns seamlessly with human needs.

Self-Learning

AI's intrinsic capacity for continuous learning, evolution, and enhanced performance plays a pivotal role in the future of work (Ponnusamy et al., 2022). Modern AI solutions, especially in natural language processing, are equipped with introspective mechanisms that capitalize on user interactions to foster adaptive learning, ensuring they remain attuned to ever-shifting organizational dynamics (Radanliev & De Roure, 2023; Shin, 2023; Whitten, 2023). A notable example in the broader AI

landscape is DeepMind's AlphaGo (Silver et al., 2018). It iteratively honed its gameplay by self-play, learning, and iterating upon its strategies. Moreover, certain advanced AI tools in the organizational context can autonomously identify inaccuracies or inefficiencies and deploy corrective measures, paving the way for more streamlined operational workflows (Ponnusamy et al., 2022).

This self-enhancing nature of AI holds the potential to significantly bolster human efficiency within enterprises. Nevertheless, as we transition towards this AI-augmented workplace, it is imperative to address and assuage concerns regarding the implications of highly autonomous AI systems on job prospects and the broader employment landscape (Brougham & Haar, 2018). The next section discusses some related challenges.

Ethical Challenges of AI at Work

Biases in AI Systems

While much of this chapter focuses on the positive aspects of AI and chatbots for employee communication, we acknowledge a few ethical considerations. Among them, biases in AI systems have received much attention, as hinted at in the example of AI screening of job applications discussed earlier. Srinivasan and Chander (2021) wrote a comprehensive summary of the possible AI-related biases, organized based on the four steps of what they called the AI Pipeline: (1) data creation, (2) problem formulation, (3) data analysis, and (4) validation and testing.

First, during data creation, the key problem is sampling biases. Sampling biases can stem from measurement biases (e.g., consistently capturing data from a limited angle), label biases (e.g., due to annotator's unconscious beliefs), and negative set biases (e.g., due to non-representative samples that over-include data points of a particular subgroup(s)). Second, during problem formulation, framing effect biases can occur. How a problem is defined will narrow the AI systems to focus on certain types of information. This can lead to a higher false positive rate of some factors or groups that received more attention. Third, during data analysis, sample selection biases such as confounding biases (e.g., when an algorithm accidentally includes findings from a spurious relationship) and design biases (e.g., software that depends on randomness is not truly random, but skewed towards data points at the start of a list or distribution) can occur. Finally, during validation and

testing, sample treatment biases can happen. This problem associated with sample treatments includes human evaluation biases (e.g., confirmation biases) and test dataset bias (e.g., inappropriate datasets for testing).

Threats of AI for Job Security

In organizational communication, the potential of AI technologies to displace human jobs has garnered significant attention (Xu et al., 2023). Numerous studies, including one revealing that 81% of Americans express their concerns about AI-related layoffs (Rainie et al., 2022), underscore this apprehension. Such fears can make employees feel undervalued, heightening their insecurities about potential unemployment due to AI integration (Brougham & Haar, 2018). Recent reviews indicate that the perceived threat to job security may play a crucial role in the acceptance of AI in the workplace (Kelly et al., 2023).

Fairness, Transparency, and Privacy

As the future of work unfolds, the emphasis on ethical AI systems, anchored in principles like human rights and fairness, has become paramount. However, inherent AI characteristics may challenge the realization of these ethical ideals. Transparency is universally recognized as vital for ethical AI. This sentiment is echoed in various guidelines, including those from the European Commission's Expert Group on AI (Larsson & Heintz, 2020). Yet, there are challenges. The pursuit of AI personalization, which relies on user data, can risk privacy breaches. Additionally, AI's propensity to narrow content based on user biases can inadvertently create echo chambers, limiting diverse information access (Cinelli et al., 2021). Moreover, generative AI models, like ChatGPT, might produce misinformation, adding to the ethical quandary (Bubeck et al., 2023). For organizations navigating the evolving work landscape, it is crucial to champion AI tools that prioritize human agency and uphold ethical considerations, especially privacy (e.g., Laitinen & Sahlgren, 2021). As AI integration accelerates, organizations must ensure their strategies remain ethically grounded, protecting both business integrity and employee interests. This raises the question of the theoretical frameworks of AI adoption and implementation, which we will discuss next.

Theoretical Frameworks of AI Adoption and Implementation

Diffusion of Innovations

Multiple theoretical frameworks can be used to understand AI adoption in the workplace. One of the most widely cited frameworks of technology adoption is Rogers' (2003) Diffusion of Innovations (DOI) framework. DOI is a general theory about technology persuasion, adoption, implementation, and the ultimate spread (including reinvention and/or discontinuation) of an innovation in a social system (including a workplace). Key concepts in this theory include: adopter categories (i.e., innovators, early adopters, early majority, late majority, and laggards), innovations attributes (i.e., relative advantage, perceived compatibility, perceived complexity/simplicity, trialability, and observability), the innovation-decision process (i.e., knowledge, persuasion, decision, implementation, and confirmation), and how opinion leaders and change agents are critical in promoting the adoption of an innovation within the target community, and a few other concepts.

In the case of AI and chatbot, the general DOI framework can be used to study adoption and implementation within the workplace. A possible theoretical extension may follow the example of Moore and Benbasat (1991), in their classic study of desktop computers within the late 1980s workplace, they expanded Rogers' original five innovation attributes to eight factors, which are voluntariness, relative advantage, compatibility, image, ease of use, result demonstrability, visibility, and trialability. They found empirical evidence to support that observability of a computer manifests in practice as visibility and result demonstrability. They also reported that voluntariness and image are key to adoption because knowledge workers cannot be forced to do their work in a strictly controlled way, and the use of a new technology can be symbolic to them at work. Furthermore, a recent longitudinal study extends the DOI theory by considering the threat of technology and examining the adoption of AI in the workplace over time from a dynamic, differential-effects perspective (Xu et al., 2023). The study reported that trialability positively influenced attitudes only among employees who held a positive attitude previously. Observability and the threat of AI, however, were more influential among employees who held a negative attitude previously. AI adoption thus presents an opportunity for new theoretical extensions.

Technology Acceptance Model

Another theory is Davis and colleagues' (1993, 2023) technology acceptance model (TAM). TAM is a simpler framework than DOI in that it only includes two predictors of adoption – perceived usefulness and ease of use. TAM's basic assumption is that if a new technology is useful for an employee (in that it helps improve job performance), and the technology is easy to use (free of effort), then it will receive wide acceptance at work. These two factors overlap with DOI's factors of relative advantage (similar to TAM's usefulness) and perceived complexity/simplicity (similar to TAM's ease of use), so some researchers consider TAM as an alternative to DOI when a less complex framework is necessary for a study. For example, a survey questionnaire based on TAM would be shorter compared to one that is grounded in DOI. Both frameworks have been commonly used in technology adoption research over the past few decades.

Another comparative note between TAM and DOI is that studies using both frameworks have tended to point out that relative advantage/usefulness is the primary driver of adoption. In the case of AI, an example of relative advantage/usefulness can be seen in an example of KPMG LLP, a global tax network of professional firms providing audit, tax, and advisory services, which piloted the use of AI for audit and advisory risk assessment for mortgages and loans. According to Ng and Alarcon (2020), this pilot was a significant success, in that what usually takes a human loan professional about two weeks to process was completed by AI in about two hours. Although AI presents significant relative advantage/usefulness, there are other factors that influence its future adoption. This is an example of how AI can be studied using TAM and DOI theoretical frameworks.

Computers as Social Actor

A third theoretical framework is Nass and colleagues' (1997) computers as social actor (CASA). The general basis of CASA is that humans unconsciously employ the same social rules and heuristics they commonly used with each other in human interactions to their interactions with computers. In other words, humans mindlessly treat computers as humans. CASA explains that humans unconsciously and mindlessly fall into this tendency because computers can mechanically demonstrate several human-like actions, such as generating words as output (written and spoken), interacting with humans (responding to

human input), and performing some traditional human tasks (e.g., calculations).

This theoretical framework can be used to study AI and chatbots in exploring how humans respond to AI and chatbots with some mindless social heuristics, and how these observations have theoretical and practical implications. For example, Nass et al. (1997) reported that participants in their study rated computers used as female-voiced tutors as more informative about topics related to interpersonal relationships and love, whereas computers with a male-voiced are rated as more proficient in topics related to technical subjects. This finding can be applied to designing AI chatbots with a gender persona in mind, such as the Ava chatbot by Autodesk discussed earlier in this chapter. However, it is important to note the ethical considerations of maintaining gender stereotypes that diminish women's technical capabilities. This example on gender can be extended to other demographic variables, such as race/ethnicity, sexual orientation, religions, physical ability, as well as personality, such as submissive, dominant, supportive, and unhelpful. In the meantime, these extensions into other demographic variables are even more troublesome. Such practices might make business sense, but the tool could also be used for social change.

Conclusion and Future Directions

In general, we remain enthusiastic about the future of AI and chatbots for employee communication. We believe that AI and chatbots are gaining ground, including in their applications, affordances, and integrations within the workplace. The examples discussed in this chapter support this general sentiment. With increasing employee literacy and self-efficacy, we believe that the trajectory of AI and chatbots for employee communication will continue to be upward and forward.

Although the bulk of this chapter focuses on AI and chatbots for employee communication, we would like to clarify that the broad spectrum of what AI can do and has done deserves more and future research attention. Here we highlight additional functionalities summarized by Davenport (2018). For example, statistical machine learning, which computerizes training and model fitting to data, can be used for marketing analyses on big data. Moreover, neural networks, which weigh data input and correlate them with information output, can be used for credit fraud identification. Furthermore, deep learning, which uses techniques of artificial neural networks with multiple layers of

variables, can be used for image and voice recognition, as well as meaning extraction from textual data. Additionally, rule-based expert systems, which are a set of expert-defined logical rules, can be used for credit approval and insurance underwriting. The example goes on and on, and can include AI-powered physical robots to help with warehouse and factory tasks—or even in medical fields, and many others.

In the future workplace, human agency, highlighted by AI designs empowering employees' control over AI systems, is a key facet of human-AI collaboration (Candrian & Scherer, 2022; Sundar, 2020). This emphasis arises from the balance between human choices and the advanced autonomy of modern AI systems (Kang & Lou, 2022; Sundar, 2020). While professionals value AI's efficiency, concerns about AI overriding human decisions persist (Kang & Lou, 2022). Therefore, AI systems that enhance human agency shape positive workplace perceptions. Generative AI platforms, for example, can be tailored to let users influence outputs, pause operations, or provide feedback. Emphasizing AI solutions that uphold human agency addresses concerns of AI overreach and marks a commitment to ethical AI adoption in organizations (Laitinen & Sahlgren, 2021).

Although the ethical concerns and biases of AI remain today, we believe that with the increasing awareness of these concerns among AI developers, governmental regulations of AI's negative consequences, and potentially the emergence of a new profession or network of professionals whose job is to ensure the ethical implementation of AI, the potential of AI's could be responsibly harnessed in organizations.

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CONCLUSION

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Our handbook sought to make sense of and draw out the tensions between and within scholarship and practice from public relations (PR) and organizational communication perspectives. At the conclusion of this handbook, we reflect upon what chapter authors collectively have given to researchers, engaged or applied scholars, practitioners, and students. Although both PR and organizational communication share different means of conceptualizing and operationalizing communication to assist workers, organizing processes, and organizations, they differ in their metatheoretical groundings as indicated by what disciplinary members study and how they advocate for change. Rather than attempting to bring all of the chapters into conversation with each other in terms of similarity and difference, we take this opportunity to center on some key questions that can prompt future research and practical applications. In our closing we describe what we regret is missing in our handbook and hope that these topics form the bases for a second handbook of this nature.

To begin, our questions center on four areas that constitute the difficulties and opportunities of bringing PR and organizational communication together around issues of employee communication. These four areas are (a) who employees are and what emphases these workers place on the meanings and meaningfulness of their labor, (b) how certain aspects of employee communication and organizing become more or less visible and to what ends, (c) when and where tensions emerge during organizing employee communication, and (d) why employee communication needs to be challenged at this point in time for ethical and responsible futures. We imagine that the ways in which

chapters address these four issues offer both a state-of-the-art and a range of possibilities for development of new theory, research, and practice about employee communication. As noted above, rather than discussing all chapters within each of these four themes, we highlight only certain chapters in each and hope that these sections spur further conversations.

Who Employees Are

This theme examines who employees are and what emphases these workers place on the meanings and meaningfulness of their labor. In describing these tensions, this theme problematizes employee and organization, often reverting to worker or other descriptors and a range of organizations, organizing, and environmental or ecological possibilities. This topic is pivotal to our entire handbook and forms the crux of what is similar and dissimilar in employee communication from organizational communication and PR approaches.

Providing an overview of these issues, Patrice Buzzanell, Willow Craine, Sidney Murray, and Maggie Vail (Chapter 3) discuss the origins of organizational communication research as a focus on employee and managerial communication to improve productivity in bricks-and-mortar settings that had hierarchical structures and demarcated roles. Over 40 years ago, these emphases shifted to incorporate both these mainstream business concerns but also to challenge whose voice, knowledge, organizational form and processes, and organization-society linkages were represented and promoted. These moves ushered in scholarship today that aims to de-colonize Western priorities and reinvigorate the discipline from fluid, entangled processes and human/non-human agents with diverse agendas, situated knowledge and communities, and identities/identifications.

These directions in the identity and identifications in organizational communication are amplified in chapters that bridge organizational, strategic, risk, crisis, and managerial communication as well as PR. Similarly, Lisa Tam and Jeong-Nam Kim (Chapter 2) also trace the development of PR from Impression Management Strategies to Employee–Organizational Relationships. Tam and Kim propose that employees have become “strategic brand ambassadors who are not just recipients of messages but active communicators of information related to the organizations with external publics” via social media (p. 3). Thus, employees link internal communication, roles and practices, and corporate branding with external stakeholders and outcomes.

In cases of organizational communication and PR, engagement with the disciplinary identities and identifications add complexity to notions of "employee" and "organizational process" shifting variously from internal business connections and workers at large (and vice versa) and within a range of organizations and institutions. For example, Kirstie McAllum, Laura Ginoux, and Félix Bourget-Careau (Chapter 18) argue that employee communication must study volunteers and other workers in not-for-profit organizing world-wide. In this way, they contend that scholars can better understand how ideals and/or economic sustainability and competing pulls toward consensus and/or conflict drive organizing and members' everyday actions. Unlike McAllum et al., instead of advocating for inclusion and significance of a particular group like nonprofit members into the framework of employee communication, Rickard Andersson, Mats Heide, and Charlotte Simonsson (Chapter 20) recommend that "coworker" be used rather than "employee" to signify that organizational members are active agents in constituting their organizational lives.

Rather than agency, Shiv Ganesh, Bhoopali Nandurkar, and Samantha Rae Shorey (Chapter 34) provide insight into how people are systematically distanced from their labor and its distribution world-wide. They are neither employees nor volunteers and nonprofit members in the traditional senses of these terms, but they are laborers in global commodity and supply chains in the Global South. In illuminating these workers' vulnerabilities, Ganesh, Nandurkar and Shorey describe disarticulation (i.e., processes of detaching production systems from local economic networks and to global supply chains) via onion supply chains in India but then expands the ideas by focusing on the disposition of employees from their data and voice in artificial intelligence (AI) technologies when AI is treated as a supply chain.

Each of these cases of those engaged in nonprofits, of co-workers, and of workers disenfranchised via global supply chains from their labor and voice, reframes notions of "employee". Other chapters examine roles within and beyond organizational boundaries to consider who "employees" are in organizational worldmaking. For example, Sean M. Eddington, Caitlyn M. Jarvis, Cale Morrow, Mara McGee & Chase R. Jordan (Chapter 29) examine divisive climates but within ways leaders and members engage in workplace communication. They address contexts in which online organizing, social media, contentious values, and technological affordances interact to produce variations in organizational membership and broader constituencies. Although not

framed in terms of Eddington et al.'s boundaries/boundarylessness, Loarre Andrew Perez and Kyougmin Lee's (Chapter 5) engagement with who and what boundary-spanning and boundary-spanners are serves to challenge traditional container notions that position people's boundary spanning at the borders within and outside organizations. They center on the digital interactions that fluidly engage in internal-external exchanges and expertise constitution to navigate complexities of today's employee communication and organizational ecosystems. Kerk Kee, Shan Xu, and Kulsawasd Jitkajornwanich (Chapter 41) also focus on technologically afforded interactions when they expand notions of employee communication and membership to describe the role of AI and chatbots in ordinary organizational functions and outcomes such as training and productivity.

Finally, Jennifer Mease (Chapter 22) moves beyond questions of who employees by intra-connecting organizing and membership with environment, meaning that these constructs fluidly merge to constitute new knowledge and opportunities. To present these possibilities, she centers indigenous ontologies and epistemologies or ways of being and knowing through interconnected views of human and non-human agencies. These agencies are materialized through decisions and interaction patterns as embedded in and mutually constitutive of environments through which work and membership have meaning. In all, this final chapter and other chapters in this first theme challenge researchers, practitioners, and students to reconsider who and what employees and organizations are to navigate shifting membership, technological, and environmental interactions and meaningfulness of work locally and globally.

How Employee Communication and Organizing Become (In)Visible

Second, our chapters examine how certain aspects of employee communication and organizing become more or less (in)visible and to what ends. In this section, we move from broad considerations and questions of membership and organizing to specific constructs that have garnered attention in recent years. Pathways toward (in)visibility are not always explicated explicitly but underlie chapters on varied constructs and topics. These constructs include: media literacy (Young Kim, Chapter 5), network perspectives (Seungyoon Lee and Ajay Shah, Chapter 7), listening (Jim Macnamara, Chapter 26), communication

competence (Kaisa Pekkala, Chiara Valentini, & Vilma Luoma-Aho, Chapter 30), and a cluster of positive communication interests such as well-being (Enzhu Dong and Yeonjae Lee, Chapter 25), belongingness (Brenda J. Allen, Chapter 35), and resilience that incorporates advantages of dissent communication (Ziyu Long & Lauren Buisker, Chapter 24). Of interest in these chapters is not the topics per se but how the authors reframe and enrich these concepts for employee communication in today's political-economic-cultural setting. Moreover, they provide jumping off points for further exploration as noted especially in the discussion of well-being and resilience that follows.

For instance, Young Kim describes how processes of employee communication behaviors for sensemaking and sensegiving can impact social media literacy and enable employees to discern, or make visible and useful, accurate and helpful information helpful during times of organizational crises. Seungyoon Lee and Ajay Shah advocate network perspectives as means of fostering creativity, including unconventional organizational forms. Jim Macnamara upends the typical reliance on speaking by encouraging listening as key to constituting organizations in ways that they deem successful. Similarly, Kaisa Pekkala, Chiara Valentini, and Vilma Luoma-Aho urge additional scholarship on communication competence as integral to success by enlarging the concept to competencies and noting how these competencies have changed and adapted from ancient oratorical endeavors to contemporary social media needs. In each of these chapters, authors spotlight how and why certain constructs that perhaps have been given short shrift in the past are needed to enable more effective employee communication and diverse organizational outcomes.

Adding to this need to make visible or increase the prominence of alternative insights and ways of accomplishing organizing are emphases on employee and organizational well-being through communication. In this section on how employee communication and organizing become (in)visible, chapters take up the necessity of advocating for inclusion of processes and outcomes needed for a good life and sustainable organizing. Researchers consider well-being, belongingness, and resilience as critical organizational factors and positive communication interests regardless of whether or how they contribute to the bottom line or corporate reputation. Enzhu Dong and Yeonjae Lee add the crucial element of well-being, particularly affective well-being or positive energy, to employee communication. They contend that well-being functions within managerial responsibilities for employee health but also

for productivity and other outcomes such as coping given rapid organizational and societal changes. They describe these responsibilities as needed during the abrupt move to remote work and organizational lockdowns during the COVID-19 pandemic. Although not focused on extraordinary stressors on people and systems such as the pandemic, Brenda J. Allen also deals with well-being on multiple levels in more ordinary circumstances. She explicates what belonging and belongingness mean for workplaces and other communities thus expanding diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) initiatives into DEIB.

Finally, Ziyu Long and Lauren Buisker question what care and justice look like and how they can be actualized in today's organizing contexts. They include cultivating a dissent-welcoming culture and building mentoring relationships, among other practices. Their invocation of dissent-welcoming cultures encourages attention to more in-depth chapters on dissent. Cary Greenwood (Chapter 14) theorizes from an evolutionary lens about why people in PR positions might be reluctant to engage in employee whistleblowing (termed "Golden Handcuffs"). Ryan Bisel and Egbe Okpaireh (Chapter 9) add complexity to discussions by maintaining that employee silence cannot be reduced to dualities of employee voice and dissent but must include strategies to encourage employee contributions for their own and organizational well-being. Johny Garner (Chapter 6) overviews employee voice and contested sites in which voice and participation are silenced, including technology, definitions of employee, and work-family considerations, from behavioral, political, and structural lenses.

Furthermore, Myoung-Gi Chon and Soo Hyun Park (Chapter 8) grapple with how quiet quitting, or work and dissent via organizational disengagement, and scouting, or voluntary efforts to acquire information useful to tasks and other organizational functions, can be merged productively. Minjeong Kang (Chapter 10) advocates that employee dissent be reframed positively for organizational democracy, efficiency, listening, and dialogic organizational communication. Although not focused on dissent per se, Julia Stranzl, Christopher Ruppel, and Sabine Einwiller (Chapter 23) themselves dissent in terms of current research trends. They do so by tracing the puzzling lack of research on employee appreciation which can assist dialogic communication and the cluster of scholarship we describe in this part on well-being, belonging, and resilience of our overall discussion on how employee communication and organizing become (in)visible. Stranzl et al. provide empirically-driven insights into how managers and other organizational members can

cultivate an appreciative working climate. Thus, they add depth to related chapters by addressing what an appreciative climate would entail as well as ways to develop and sustain this climate.

When and Where Tensions Emerge

Third, chapters in our handbook explore when and where tensions emerge during the organizing and organization of employee communication. Although tensions emerge within and across our handbook chapters, in this section, we discuss only those tensions surrounding secrecy and silence, employee activism and internal corporate social responsibility or advocacy (CSR or CSA), and crises and needed leadership communication changes.

To begin, secrecy and silence are explored on micro/relational, meso/organizational, and macro/societal levels. Rather than seeing this process as the opposite of dissent, chapter authors frame secrecy and silence in terms of managing what is known and unknown to present a more creative more-than (rather than either-or or both-and) approach. In this respect, chapters overlap with the previous section on (in)visibility but differ insofar as paradox, or the "family of concepts, such as tensions, contradictions, and dialectics as variations of bipolar opposites" (Fairhurst & Putnam, 2024, p. 1) become prominent. The more-than approach achieves creative non-obvious ways of handling problems and issues of curiosity by eschewing either-or strategies that veer into one or the other pole and both-and practices that seek to bridge and integrate opposing elements and processes. Neither either-or nor both-and solutions are sustainable since they seek to resolve concerns whereas both-and practices offer temporarily satisfying, innovative, and creative processes for navigating contradictions.

For instance, Sean Horan and Rebecca Chory (Chapter 11) provide an overview of workplace romance and gossip to sort out how employee communication might be optimally constituted for this frequent but challenging phenomenon. Whereas Horan and Chory orient the discussion of secrecy and silence toward disclosure and its implications, Eric Karikari (Chapter 13) centers on control—control of information, organizational knowledge, and employee communication—noting that security leakages and censorship can act as double-edged swords that invite complicated organizational and societal or global policy discussions. Anna Wolfe (Chapter 12) critiques the transparency bias in organizational research from organizational, organizational

communication, PR, and related perspectives. However, she focuses on formal–informal, internal–external, and ethical–unethical communication dilemmas given power issues and changes in the technological landscape.

Additionally, tensions emerge in organizing employee communication around processes related to employee activism and CSR or CSA. Chun-Ju Flora Hung-Baesecke and Kate Delmo (Chapter 33) encourage employee activism for sustainable change by taking strategic management and relational cultivation approaches to develop partnerships for effective corporate citizenship. Katharine Miller (Chapter 37) encourages localized sensemaking of what internal responsibilities are, how they are integrated into organizational cultures, and what environmental and social practices are perceived as legitimate by internal stakeholders like employees themselves. Miller encourages further attention on external constituencies with generational perspective differences as one of many issues warranting additional research. On the flip side, Yunna Rhee and Bitt Moon (Chapter 39) provides findings of and their applications for communicating with internal stakeholders during crises, particularly how online Employee Communication Behavior can trigger organizational crises.

Lastly, crises and other disruptions have prompted greater attention to employee communication given the confluence of changes and the need to address what has been happening from many different disciplinary vantage points and for varied reasons. This attention also has reinvigorated leadership studies to better handle the chaos of pandemics and other organizational uncertainties. Silvia Ravazzani (Chapter 40) directly addresses the changes in and international research on employee communication resulting from the COVID-19 pandemic. She advocates for more relational, ethical, empathic, and paradoxical communication by employees and leadership to foster well-being. Ganga Dhanesh and Gaelle Duthler (Chapter 38) offer insights into ways of promoting employee engagement during internal crises in remote work settings. Luca Quaratino (Chapter 32) presents the pandemic as an accelerant for increasing the trends toward remote work, rethinking management and leadership, and delving more deeply into virtual leadership, team dynamics, communication, and hybrid workplaces.

As a whole, then, employee communication and organizational processes writ large are rife with contradiction with regard to when and where tensions emerge.

Why Employee Communication Is Needed for Ethical and Responsible Futures

Fourth, this section poses questions about why employee communication and organizational processes need to be challenged at this point in time for ethical and responsible futures. The chapters in this section are broad visions for the present and the future involving local concerns and global possibilities.

Overlapping with the prior section on tensions, as Timothy Betts and Logan Gibbs (Chapter 28) suggest about the utility of contradictions evidenced in social media, organizational representatives and researchers often view social media sites with stories on advocacy and r/ antiwork as threatening but "do so in ways that disconnect those stories from the economic and political contexts through which employers justify the practices the r/antiwork community derogates" (p. 6). Yet such criticisms and collective sensemaking make "radical reimagining…possible". Such reimaginings foster possibilities for "communication, connection, partnership" (p. 6).

Other chapter authors offer their own visions and criteria for ethical and responsible futures. Shannon Bowen (Chapter 16) takes a strategic and intentional ethical stance for creating internal ethical cultures. She focuses on ethics in and for employee engagement with ethics defined as "how, or if, an organization's culture inspires ethical thought and action throughout the organization among leaders and followers" (p. 2). Her framework brings together internal communication practices, enhanced employee engagements, as well as servant and authentic leadership to unify employees and leadership around common goals of responsible and sustainable futures. Her framework is devised in ways to encourage ethical organizational cultures and institutionalized values. Her model encourages internal communication centered on rationality, respect and dignity, idealism or principled behavior, and moral courage. These add up to her ENACTED Ethics model in which Enacted is an acronym for key concepts of Engaged, Narrative, Authentic, Conscience, Theoretical, Empowered, and Decisive.

Alessandra Mazzei (Chapter 19) argues that the term "internal communication" is inadequate for encapsulating what employee communication actually is and how it functions. Instead, she reframes "internal" as creative, collaborative, or organizational and "employee" as workforce, co-workers, and organizational members. She seeks a "new vision of employee communication" which, she contends, focuses on

interactive processes generating engagement and knowledge creation as well as resource perspectives. Called "Engaging Model of Employee Communication", this model aims to "promote effective and positive employee communication behavior" (italics in original, p. 6). Ana Tkalac Verčič (Chapter 31) explores the concepts of culture, globalization, technology, and intercultural or multicultural communication in PR and employee communication.

The final chapter in this section looks to the past to create viable futures. Valentina Martino and Alessandro Lovari (Chapter 17) take readers into the rich and illuminating study of corporate heritage by providing extended case studies about how corporate culture and identity can be cultivated for quality employee-organizational-societal linkages. They show how investing in histories create the legacies that propel future employee communication and organizing. Thus, these and other chapters throughout our handbook engage with ethical and responsible futures in distinctive ways that promote visions for the future that are situated in PR and organizational communication and PR-Org Com intersections.

Closing

As stated at the start of this chapter, our intent was not to summarize and thematize all the chapters in our handbook. Instead, we selected those that challenged what employees and the identities and identifications within organizational communication and PR mean. Second, we sought to capture concepts and processes that have been invisible, that address invisibility and secrecy, and that have been heretofore marginalized in our efforts to bring them to the forefront of employee communication and organizational processes scholarship and practice. Third, we advocate tensions as sites in which innovative insights can be studied and advanced in organizational worldmaking while also offering some visions for responsible and ethical futures in our fourth section.

Although we have chapters on a number of different topics from varied approaches, there still are many areas that we regret not covering. As we reflect on what we have accomplished and what we would like to have included, we recognize that we do not have chapters on: different generations co-existing in the workplace, contingent workers, needs for slack resources (time for socialization, onboarding; funds for innovation); further and evolving changes spurred by AI; constantly changing careers and their members like social influencers; and the

positive communication movement that currently is reinvigorating all communication contexts. We also have not incorporated employee and organizational communication issues regarding unions and labor negotiations, pay equity and promotion schemes, and internal organizational concerns. More broadly, we have not accounted fully for external political and religious influences on organizing processes nor have we interrogated Whiteness and needs to delve into the United Nations Strategic Development Goals (SDGs) in all aspects of employee communication and organizational processes. In examining Whiteness and the UN SDGs, amongst other areas, we can pursue more in-depth conversations about power, control, and resistance in employee communication and organizing.

Furthermore, we decided not to include chapters on method. To that end, we encourage readers to turn to the many excellent handbooks on methods, including *The SAGE handbook of qualitative research in organizational communication* (2024) that recently won the book award from the Organizational Communication Division of the National Communication Association.

We are grateful to our authors for contributing to our handbook. We admit that there is much more that we could have covered even though we ended up with 42 chapters. We preserve our list of excluded topics for our next handbook….

It is our sincere hope that our handbook becomes a springboard for future activity in employee communication and organizational processes in ways we cannot even imagine.

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